

What is Curse of Strahd about?

The *Curse of Strahd* module is a gothic horror adventure for *Dungeons & Dragons* 5th Edition. The campaign provides a similar atmosphere to *Castlevania*, *Dracula*, or (if you've played *Magic: the Gathering*) the plane of Innistrad. Here, classic horror monsters of every type haunt the woods, mountains, and villages of the dreary and terror-haunted land of Barovia.

As PCs, your players take on the role of adventurers who are new to Barovia - either because they have been invited there, or because they have been lured and trapped there. Through the course of the campaign, they will have an opportunity to help the native Barovians fight back against predatory monsters, overthrow monstrous tyrants, and gather artifacts to help kill Strahd forever.

The *Curse of Strahd* module is the latest in a long line of D&D campaigns that take place in the Ravenloft setting. The first adventure including Strahd von Zarovich was created for *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons*, and each edition since has included a campaign, book, and/or other product exploring Strahd's realm.

Please note that *Curse of Strahd* is a highly roleplay-oriented module. Unlike many other published adventures, the average *Curse of Strahd* is roughly 60% roleplay, 20% combat, and 20% exploration. However, it's not a traditional social intrigue adventure - instead, a large part of the module's content comes from investigating mysteries, exploring character backstories, building relationships with helpful NPCs, and dealing with Strahd as a social antagonist, rather than an enemy combatant. Make sure that all of your players are on-board with this before beginning a campaign.

What's the basic storyline of the module?

Curse of Strahd, focuses heavily on themes of corruption, innocence, and abuse. As PCs, your players will have an opportunity to be heroes of the Barovians - or corrupt servants (or victims) of Strahd.

Nearly all campaigns will begin in the same place: With the PCs finding themselves magically spirited away to Barovia, or by the PCs accepting an invitation to travel there. Upon arriving in the land of Barovia, the PCs may encounter Death House, a haunted house-style prologue that aims to take a 1st-level party to 3rd-level while setting the stage for Barovia's lore and atmosphere.

After escaping Death House, most groups will explore the village of Barovia (which shares a name with the kingdom), meeting Ismark Kolyanavich and Ireena Kolyana. Ireena is a target of Strahd von Zarovich, who secretly views her as the reincarnation of his long-lost bride. Ismark will ask the PCs to escort Ireena to Vallaki, the town next door, to keep her safe from Strahd. Ireena will agree to accompany the PCs only if they bury her father, the burgomaster (mayor) of Barovia Village, at the town church. If the PCs accept this mission, they will meet Father Donavich, the local priest, and encounter his son Doru, a vampire spawn and victim of Strahd.

After leaving Barovia and departing for Vallaki, the PCs are heavily encouraged by assorted NPCs to visit Madam Eva at Tser Pool Encampment. There, the PCs can receive a Tarokka card reading that foretells the location of three artifacts that can help defeat Strahd, as well as the identity of an ally in their fight.

After departing Tser Pool, the PCs have the choice of several stops along the way to Vallaki. They can visit the Old Bonegrinder windmill and encounter the coven of hags that inhabit it; they can (if they're feeling suicidal) venture down the old road toward Strahd's home, Castle Ravenloft; or they

can interact with a number of random encounters that you, the DM, may choose to place in their path.

Once the party reaches Vallaki, the module opens up considerably into a full sandbox. The PCs can stay in Vallaki and interact with its tense political situation. They can undertake a quest to sanctify the local church (and create a haven for Ireena from Strahd). They can accept a mission to recover wine from a nearby winery, or they can depart Vallaki entirely for the quiet mountain village of Krezk. They can also begin searching for the artifacts and ally predicted by their Tarokka reading, which, depending on what you chose, can take them - quite literally - anywhere on the map.

As the PCs visit additional locations and obtain allies, artifacts, and information, Strahd begins to grow interested in them. He may make occasional appearances to lure Ireena away from the party, or he may attack the PCs to test their abilities. Most often - though not always - once the PCs have gathered all three artifacts and their ally, they will choose to assault Castle Ravenloft for a final showdown with Strahd, killing him for good - or dying in the process.

Additional community-created content (e.g., the Fanes of Barovia, the Orphanage of Saint Andreol, the sealing of Vampyr, etc.) can add further depth, length, and complexity to the narrative. However, none of these elements are necessary for a satisfying, full-length campaign.

What's the backstory of Barovia? Who is Strahd, and where did he come from?

Barovia is one of the Demiplanes of Dread - a territory of the Shadowfell that lies beyond the Raven Queen's control. Instead, it is ruled by the Dark Powers: amorphous, anonymous beings that capture "Darklords" - powerful villains from the Material Plane - and imprison them in shadowy, mist-filled realms to torment them for eternity.

Strahd is one of these "Darklords." In life, he was a general and a prince, conquering lands for his parents, King Barov and Queen Ravenovia. Upon arriving in Barovia, he conquered its lands for his family, slaughtering the Order of the Silver Dragon - an ancient order of knights and paladins - and renamed the valley "Barovia," after his father. He then built Castle Ravenloft and invited his family - the King and Queen, and his younger brother Sergei, to join him.

Barov and Ravenovia died before they could make the journey, leaving Sergei alone with Strahd in their new castle. Strahd soon grew jealous of Sergei, who had romanced a beautiful Barovian maid - Tatyana Federovna. Strahd desired Tatyana for himself, but grew bitter as she spurned his advances. He became convinced that his old age and impending death were the cause of her scorn, and sought out a means of immortality to restore his youth.

After researching dark magic for a time, Strahd journeyed to the Amber Temple - an ancient prison for dark and dead gods in southern Barovia - and struck a deal with Vampyr, one of the divine vestiges locked away within. Vampyr taught Strahd the secret to vampirism, and on the day of Sergei's wedding, Strahd slayed his brother and drank his blood. When his castle's guards killed him, Strahd arose as a vampire, slaughtered the guards, and pursued Tatyana until she jumped to her death in the ravine beside Castle Ravenloft. The Dark Powers took note of Strahd's monstrous acts, and sealed him - and all of Barovia - inside of a Demiplane of Dread, closed off from the outside world.

Now, Strahd amuses himself by taking consorts, eliminating vampire hunters, and tormenting adventurers who arrive in his lands. Barovia's closed-off nature has caused souls to be reincarnated, instead of moving to the afterlife - which has driven Strahd to search out Tatyana's reincarnation in

each new generation. Today, he has found it in Ireena Kolyana, a resident of Barovia, and a major focus of the campaign.

Which NPCs are most important?

- **Ireena Kolyana**: The most recent reincarnation of Strahd's long-dead love, Tatyana Federovna.
- **Ismark Kolyanavich**: Ireena's brother and the new burgomaster of Barovia Village.
- **Urwin & Danika Martikov**: The owners of the Blue Water Inn and secret members of the Keepers of the Feather, an order of **wereravens** that opposes Strahd.
- **Baron Vargas Vallakovich**: The cruel ruler of Vallaki.
- **Lady Fiona Wachter**: Baron Vallakovich's main political opponent and a loyalist to Strahd.
- **Dr. Rudolph van Richten / Rictavio**: A disguised vampire hunter who has come to Barovia to kill Strahd.
- **Ezmerelda d'Avenir**: A Vistani monster hunter who has come to Barovia to kill Strahd and find her mentor, Dr. Rudolph van Richten.
- **Rahadin**: Strahd's dusk elf chamberlain and enforcer.
- **The Abbot**: A **deva** sent to save Barovia who has been corrupted and driven mad by the land's darkness.

Which areas should I prepare first?

If you're just starting out the module, read the book cover-to-cover before your first session. You don't need to memorize everything, but you should have a general appreciation of what the campaign contains and how the different areas and NPCs connect to each other.

Before running your first session, prepare (1) your campaign hook, (2) Death House (if you're running it), and (3) the entirety of the village of Barovia. Barovia is fairly small, so it shouldn't take too long. You should also secretly pre-determine which Tarokka cards Madam Eva will use in her reading, and decide which, if any random encounters you'll place on the Svalich Road around Barovia. If you choose to run Death House, that'll also give you an extra 2-3 weeks to prep Vallaki while you run through it.

Once your PCs reach Vallaki, prepping any individual session becomes far more difficult. I highly recommend using [the Lazy DM session preparation method](#), in which you prepare materials based on the locations and NPCs your PCs are likely to encounter based on their current quests and interests, rather than worrying about predicting exactly what your party will decide to do. You should also re-read any individual chapters (e.g., the Werewolf Den, the Village of Krezk) immediately before any session in which you expect your PCs to travel to that specific location.

How can I avoid common pitfalls for Curse of Strahd DMs?

- Don't do a random Tarokka reading. Pre-select cards for maximum dramatic impact and to direct your PCs to interesting and isolated locations. There's nothing worse than a campaign with Clovin Belview as an ally, the Tome and Holy Symbol in Castle Ravenloft, and the Sunsword three feet away in Madam Eva's wagon.
- Don't let your PCs persuade Ismark Kolyanavich to come with them to Vallaki. There's a common problem where parties assemble too many allies, making combat clunky

and detracting from the PCs' accomplishments. Let Ismark stay in Barovia to tend to his father's estate and to assume the position of burgomaster, and make the PCs escort Ireena themselves.

- Don't run Morgantha and the night hags at Old Bonegrinder as an immediate combat encounter. They're incredibly deadly to a low-levelled party, and they're much more interesting as a roleplay encounter.
- Don't treat Ireena as a bland quest item. Give her a personality, her own motivations, and her own active goals. Give her a resourceful and helpful attitude and do your best to make her useful and likable to the PCs.
- Don't run Vallaki as one massive political sinkhole. You should feel free to space out the periods of time between events like the Feast of Saint Andral and Fiona Wachter's rebellion. It's pretty common for players to get super fatigued and frustrated after five or six straight sessions dealing with Vallakian intrigue.
- Don't let Strahd, Rahadin, or any other notable NPCs face your PCs in combat alone. 5e's action economy will allow your PCs to lock down and destroy any solo enemy. Use encounter building tools like [Kobold Fight Club](#) to make sure that no "boss" battle is anything less than a Deadly encounter.
- Don't roll for random encounters while your PCs are travelling or resting. Instead, choose random encounters that complement the atmosphere of Barovia and foreshadow future plot elements (e.g., the werewolf encounter, the bundle of clothes, etc.)
- Make sure you hold a session zero with your players to clarify what Curse of Strahd is and is not about. Don't allow Evil-aligned PCs unless you're comfortable with entirely rewriting large sections of the campaign from scratch (as the campaign lays plot hooks that are only attractive to Good-aligned PCs), and don't allow lone wolves or antisocial PCs (as the module is heavily dependent on teamwork and roleplaying).
- Don't radically increase Strahd's CR to compensate for perceived "weakness." Strahd's RAW statblock has its issues - most notably including a massive gap between playing him optimally (near-unbeatable) and playing him suboptimally (weak PC punching bag). But while there's an argument to be made for bumping Strahd's difficulty up to CR16 or CR17, try to avoid the CR27 stat block and similar "upgrades" that are floating around. At the end of the day, Strahd is a four-centuries old vampire who rules over a backwater duchy with three towns in it; he isn't (and should not be) a match for the eons-old demon prince *Orcus*.
- Don't give your PCs maps from the module itself; those outright reveal the locations of the Werewolf Den and Amber Temple. There are several better community-created maps throughout the subreddit that can give your players a sense of Barovia's geography without spoiling the location of major hidden areas.

What are some tips and tricks for running Curse of Strahd?

- Don't be afraid to TPK! A total-party wipeout doesn't have to mean your PCs' deaths - instead, perhaps they're captured by a powerful enemy, rescued by unlikely allies, or spirited away to Strahd's dungeons. Curse of Strahd is a perfect place to let your PCs fail forward, rather than ending their stories immediately because they misjudged the difficulty of a single combat encounter. Rather than making them bitter and harming their attachment to their characters, a few "nonlethal" TPKs can give your players a healthy sense of respect and caution.
- Before you start running the campaign, choose what kind of relationship you want Strahd to have with your PCs in the early stages of the campaign. Should he be a shadowy, distant tyrant? A cruel and ever-lurking monster? A suave and cordial

patron? There are many ways to develop Strahd's relationship with the party, and you should ensure upfront that you have a good idea of where you'd like it to start.

- Encourage your PCs to develop flawed or tragic characters, and use your plot hook and/or Madam Eva's Tarokka reading to link the PCs' goals and backstories to questlines in Barovia.
- During Session Zero, make sure to check with your players whether they're okay with certain traumatic or uncomfortable content that *Curse of Strahd* includes. If they're not, see what you can to tweak the module to remove problematic elements, or (if they can't be easily worked around) suggest a different module altogether. A brief (though not comprehensive) list of potential triggers include: child abuse, murder, kidnapping, gaslighting, racism, sexism, torture, mind control, cannibalism, sexual assault, mental illness, animal cruelty, body horror, incest, suicide, drug addiction, and alcoholism.



Curse of Strahd: Reloaded

A Campaign Guide by /u/DragnaCarta

Chapter 0: Adventure Hooks

Chapter 0: Adventure Hooks

An Analysis of *Curse of Strahd* Hooks

While perfectly serviceable as generic openings to the *Curse of Strahd* campaign, each of the four adventure hooks presented in the original module leave much to be desired ***if the DM and players are looking for a more narrative- and character-driven experience.***

- *Plea For Help* serves only as a trap to lure the PCs into Barovia, leaving the thrust of the campaign feeling hollow, as if their very presence in Barovia is a foolish accident - an adventure to be regretted, rather than relish.
- *Mysterious Visitors* is perhaps the most useful of the hooks, drawing the PCs into the grander narrative of Strahd's corruption and the curse upon Barovia, and presenting them with the campaign-long task of defeating Strahd and laying his troubled soul to rest. However, it is neither personalized nor grounded, leaving the PCs as generic participants in a cookie-cutter campaign and introducing the players to the adventure while within a wholly irrelevant setting (Daggerford).
- *Werewolves in the Mist* fails as a hook for two reasons. First, it fails to tie the PCs into any meaningful grand narrative (as the Werewolf Den is the location in Barovia most divorced from Strahd's curse and storyline). Second, while it is not a bad idea to involve some element from a PC's backstory in the hook (the factions), the fact that the factions will never come up again (and that the werewolves have very likely never heard of the Harpers or Zhentarim) can leave the entire experience feeling hollow.
- *Creeping Fog*, while admirable in its simplicity, utterly fails to invest the PCs in the adventure they are about to undertake.

Of these, *Plea For Help*, *Werewolves in the Mist*, and *Creeping Fog* are clearly intended to serve as traps for the PCs - once the PCs willingly (or unwillingly) enter Barovia, they will soon find that there is no way out without slaying Strahd. As a result, each of these three hooks sets "survival horror" as the tone of *Curse of Strahd*, whether or not you meant to run it that way.

Moreover, *Plea for Help*, *Mysterious Visitors*, and *Werewolves in the Mist* seem to assume that the PCs have already been travelling together for some time - and in the case of *Mysterious Visitors*, already accomplished some notable task for the Duchess of Daggerford. A long-term campaign can easily begin with a three-session attack on a horde of goblin bandits outside of

Daggerford, and cleanly segue into a short “arc” thereafter. However, the *Curse of Strahd* module is far too long to serve as a brief “arc” in a broader adventure, leaving any earlier adventures (like one in Daggerford) dangling off into irrelevance like a vestigial limb.

Designing a New Adventure Hook

Given all this, it is our goal to design an adventure hook that meets the following criteria:

1. Solidifies *Curse of Strahd* as a self-contained campaign from level 1 (or 3) to 10, without any need to refer back to previous adventures;
2. Gives the PCs a “true” reason to enter Barovia, in order to preserve their agency and make them feel that they chose to begin this campaign of their own volition and with full knowledge of the potential consequences;
3. Invokes the backstories and desires of the PCs in order to allow the players to drive the campaign by developing their characters and accomplishing long-term goals;
4. Promotes the “gothic opera” tone of *Curse of Strahd*, encouraging the PCs to emotionally invest in the narrative and questlines of the campaign; and
5. Creates a beginning-to-end throughline across the entire module to give the players a sense of accomplishment and fulfillment upon completing the finale of the campaign.

Adventure Hook: Secrets of the Tarokka

This scenario works to incorporate each of the above design goals by giving each PC a personal goal that they can achieve while in Barovia, shaped and foretold by Madam Eva’s predictions and promises. Over the course of their adventure, the PCs grow to rely on one another, helping each other in their individual quests and, ultimately, accepting their destinies to defeat Strahd and lift the curse upon Barovia.

Crafting a Backstory

As you work independently with your players to create their characters, encourage them to develop hidden tragedies, impossible goals, and regrets into their characters’ pasts. Your PCs don’t need to be “dark and edgy,” but they should have some great desire informed by past mistakes, losses, or failures. These will likely fall into one or more of three broad categories:

- This PC is a broken creature searching for healing or redemption.
- This PC is a lost soul searching for kinship or purpose.
- This PC has lost or been abandoned by someone or something important to them, and are attempting to regain it.

Your players may be tempted to create traditional Dungeons & Dragons PCs - a bard whose ultimate goal is the seduction of every creature he meets; a wizard whose only goal is the acquisition of power for power’s sake; or a rogue who steals from others in order to become wealthy. While these are perfectly fine for low-investment parties, they will actively detract from any group that aims to create a high-investment, narrative-driven experience. Barovia, at its core, is a dark and broken land that attracts dark and broken people.

Some of the traditional character archetypes can be tweaked to better fit this mold (e.g., Caleb Widogast of *Critical Role*), but your overall goal should be to help your player craft a backstory whose driving goal *can only be fulfilled within the borders of Barovia*. See below for some sample PC goals:

- A draconic sorcerer has forsaken his home and his people, and is searching for a means of understanding his ancestry and finding a new land to settle in.
- A dragonborn cleric was abandoned by his tribe at birth, and hopes to one day find them and rejoin his people.
- An aasimar paladin destroyed her church in a fit of zealous rage and hubris and Fell from grace; now, she searches for a way to redeem herself in the eyes of her god and sire.
- A tiefling rogue was orphaned as a child, and desperately longs to find a family that they can love and trust.
- An elven ranger watched her forest suffer and die to a dark, creeping corruption, and longs to gain revenge against the evil that created it.
- A human monk was forced to abandon his adventuring party when a great injury waylaid him for a year and a day; now, he longs to rejoin his friends and ensure their safety.
- A halfling wizard was abandoned by his mentor many years ago, and hopes to find them and prove his worth.

Notably, while the player will not know this explicitly until informed by Madam Eva, each of these goals can be tied to a specific location, quest, or character within Barovia:

- The draconic sorcerer is a descendant of Argynvost, and is tasked by the dragon's spirit with sanctifying the memory of the Order of the Silver Dragon before founding the Order anew.
- The dragonborn cleric finds a small collection of other dragonborn amongst the berserker tribes on Mount Ghakis - the first of his kind that he has ever seen - and is welcomed into their tents with open arms.
- The aasimar paladin learns that she must recover the holy symbol of Tasha Petrovna as an exercise of penance; upon completion of this task, her wings will be restored to her.
- The tiefling rogue was whisked away at birth by a caravan of Vistani after the death of their parents; in truth, their trueborn sibling still lives in Vallaki - Izek Strazni.
- The corruption that destroyed the elven ranger's forest blossomed from a seed of the Gulthias Tree, empowered by the blood of Strahd von Zarovich before it was carried into the world beyond the mists by the werewolf pack.
- The human monk learns that his adventuring party was swallowed up by Barovia's mists soon after his injury; by following their trail through Barovia, he can discover their fate and rescue his sole living companion.
- The halfling wizard's mentor is Dr. Rudolph van Richten, famed vampire hunter, who abandoned the halfling for fear that his curse would strike his pupil down, and so fled to hunt Strahd von Zarovich instead.

Some other potential hooks might involve the werewolf pack, the Abbot at the Abbey of St. Markovia, the Ladies of the Fanes, or Strahd himself. As with the dragonborn barbarian and the human monk, don't be afraid of adding in small elements of your PCs' backstories into the RAW setting. Modules are built to be personalized, and your players will be thrilled to see their backstories transform the world that you run.

Madam Eva's Promise

As the campaign begins, the PCs are wholly ignorant of one another - or, if their personal quests overlap, they may be already travelling together in pairs. Two weeks before your adventure begins, each PC receives a mysterious dream sent by a strange crone clad in red robes: Madam Eva. Eva invites each PC to visit her in order to have their fortune read, promising to each PC in turn that she alone can show them how to achieve their goal. For each of our sample PCs, Eva promises the following:

- Draconic Sorcerer: *"Find me at the crossroads of Tser Pool, and I will share with you path to uncovering the power of your bloodline - and the true nature of your heritage."*
- Dragonborn Cleric: *"Come to my tent, and I will guide you to the hearth of your people."*
- Aasimar Paladin: *"Journey through the mists of Barovia, and I will whisper to you the key to regaining your honor - and the favor of your god."*
- Tiefling Rogue: *"You are not alone in this world. I can tell you the name of the one that shares your blood - but only if you travel to my fire and speak my name."*
- Elven Ranger: *"You hunger for vengeance, but your eyes are blind. Journey past the mists, and I will help your eyes to see your enemy."*
- Human Monk: *"The ones that you love have wandered astray, and their lives may hang in the balance. Find me, and I will show you to them."*
- Halfling Wizard: *"The teacher you love is not as far as you fear - travel to the encampment at Tser Pool, and I will show you the place where he hides."*

In each of these instances, Madam Eva speaks the truth. She does so, however, for ulterior motives - through her Inner Eye, she has looked out into the world to find individuals whose potential for power and goodness is great, and who may be easily lured to Barovia of their own will. She sees through her foresight that they may accomplish their goals if brought into Strahd's realm - and, if guided properly, may accomplish her own goals as well.

For more ideas on potential quests your PCs can have, see the **Personal Readings & Quests** section [here](#).

Getting the Group Together

It would be easy for any person to dismiss such a vision as a hollow dream. However, the experience is vivid enough to leave the PC shaken, and each PC should be desperate or lost enough to grab for Madam Eva's promises with gusto. To solidify her promise, and to make it clear that these dreams were true dreams, each PC then awakes with a single Tarokka card in their lap.

Each Tarokka card should be personalized to each PC, and is preferably different from the cards that you plan to use for the Tarokka reading proper. This card can reflect the PCs' background, stature, weaknesses, or abilities. Madam Eva then describes to each PC that cards that the others hold, as well as their "signs" - one or two identifying features that help each character stand out in a crowd.

In these dreams, Madam Eva directs the PCs to travel to an inn in Daggerford called the Nightmare's Stable; there, she promises, they will meet their companions and find directions to Stanimir, a "man of many colors" who can guide them to her. A PC's full dream may look like this:

For the past moon, you have suffered strange dreams of a woman, her voice rasping behind a darkened veil. In each dream, she speaks of secrets of your past - knowledge buried so deep that not a single other soul could know. She speaks of answers to your questions, and the fulfillment of your fate. She speaks of inheritance and magic, and promises both - and more. She speaks in riddles, and whispers in tongues.

In the final dream, she spoke thusly:

"Seek the Thief, the Soldier, and the Monk," she told you. "You will know them by their signs - the Devil's horns; the blinded eyes; and the setting sun's scales. You will find them in the home of night's steed, behind the walls of the dagger's ford.

"Once you have found these companions, seek out the travelling man of many colors. His song will guide you to me."

When you awoke, the moon still high in the night's sky, you waited for the dream to fade from your mind. Instead, you felt the visions solidify, clarify - and felt a weight in your lap. When you looked down, you saw a single playing card resting there: the Beggar.

The next morning, you packed your possessions and prepared for the journey. After consulting a map, you decided your destination: the Nightmare's Stable, in the town called Daggerford.

The road lay before you, and your past lay behind. As the sun rose above your head, you steeled your will, cleared your mind, and let fate guide your step.

In this particular example, the **Thief** is the tiefling rogue, the **Soldier** the aasimar paladin, and the **Monk** the dragonborn cleric. This dream is relayed to the dragonborn sorcerer, the **Beggar**, whose sign is "the dragon's mark."

Upon arriving in Daggerford, the PCs soon find each other to be the only other inhabitants of the Nightmare's Stable, and can easily detect their companions by their signs. The barkeep, a sour man named Kelrick, can inform them that a troupe of Vistani recently arrived in town to perform and share stories in their encampment, a fact that is advertised on a flyer just beside the bar.

Inform your players ahead of time that you encourage them to keep their personal quests and backstories **private** until such a time as they become directly relevant to the story. It is a common temptation for many new players to introduce their characters by revealing their true appearance (“My arms are secretly covered in dragon scales”), their hidden motives (“I’m the lost heir of a great kingdom, and I want to reclaim my throne”), and their personal tragedies (“I got my entire platoon killed in battle. I regret it every day”). **Do your best to keep your players from doing this.** Their personal quests are much more enriching and interesting to the other players and NPCs if they are revealed piecemeal, with each delicious hint and secret dropped bit-by-bit over the course of the first two-thirds of the campaign, rather than dumped on the table all at once.

The Road to Barovia

Upon arrival at Stanimir’s camp, the PCs are greeted warmly by Stanimir’s children, as if the party’s arrival has been expected. After introducing himself, Stanimir invites the PCs to sit by his fire and share a story or experience “that can make a man laugh, or make a man weep.” Vistani trade in stories, not money, and this is an ages-old custom for guests invited to sit around a Vistani fire. As a roleplaying exercise, each PC may then relay a personal tale of joy or sorrow, keeping it as brief and vague as desired.

When each PC has delivered their tale, Stanimir then relays his own story of Barovia’s “dark prince,” as depicted in the *Mysterious Visitors* hook of the original module. Notably, however, he does not ask the PCs to defeat Strahd or break his curse; rather, he changes the story to subtly draw comparisons to the PCs’ own hidden backstories, and concludes by informing the PCs that Madam Eva has seen their destinies intertwined with Strahd’s own.

The PCs are welcome to sleep overnight at the Vistani camp. The following morning, the Vistani pack up and guide the party to Barovia through the misty woods beyond Daggerford. After a full day of travel, it becomes evident to the party that they have “shifted” en route to a different forest entirely, slipping into the space between planes. Stanimir leaves the PCs at Barovia’s gates, confessing that Madam Eva has banished his caravan from Barovia for some offense many years ago, and that his service in transporting the PCs is part of the payment for his transgression. He bids them luck, and tells them to stay on the path, and to beware of dangers that may far overpower them.

Tarokka Readings & Beyond

When the PCs arrive at Madam Eva’s tent, they are presented with two readings: their individual readings (as described [here](#)), and the standard reading involving the three artifacts and ally. After completing the personal readings, Madam Eva informs the PCs: “Your fates are intertwined, and your hands will be those that free this land from darkness,” and proceeds directly to the standard reading.

As your PCs make their way throughout Barovia, accomplishing each task in turn (e.g., restoring Argynvost’s skull, reclaiming Petrovna’s holy symbol, or bringing down the Gulthias Tree), consider bestowing them some boon or charm as a reward for achieving this milestone. For

example, the draconic sorcerer may receive a gift of flight from Argynvost's spirit; the aasimar paladin may be allowed to shift her subrace from fallen to protector; or the elven ranger may receive limited power over plantlife from a thankful Lady of the Fanes. While you should take care to keep these boons from being overpowered, you should also enjoy the experience of tailoring them to your players and their sense of fun. *Curse of Strahd* has few true moments of accomplishment, and this is a rare opportunity to truly reward your PCs for their deeds.

Chapter 1: Death House

Unlike most other locations in Barovia, which, while optional for the players, serve as concrete areas within the Ravenloft setting, Death House is an entirely optional prequel module that serves as an introduction to *Curse of Strahd*'s setting, tone, and themes.

The choice to run Death House or not is entirely at the DM's discretion. While surveys of [/r/CurseOfStrahd](#) show that a large majority of DMs tend to run this dungeon, it is perfectly permissible to run your PCs through another adventure that will take them from levels 1 to 3, or to simply start them off in Barovia at level 3.

A few points to consider when choosing to run Death House or not:

Pros

- Simply starting the PCs in the village of Barovia as-written can serve as an anti-hook. Unless you employ the Plea for Help or Mysterious Visitors hooks exactly as the book describes them, the PCs will have no pressing action or intrigue to engage them until they receive Madame Eva's reading, encounter Morgantha peddling her wares, or become embroiled in the politics of Vallaki.
- The malevolence and alien nature of Death House can serve as a marked contrast to Ismark and Ireena's warmth and humanity, driving the players to view them more positively.
- Should you choose to run *Curse of Strahd* as-written, without any modifications regarding lethality, Death House serves as an excellent introduction to the danger and deadliness of Barovia.
- Several items within Death House, including Strahd's note and the deed to Old Bonegrinder, can foreshadow future locations and characters while planting the seeds for future plot hooks.
- Throwing a group of level-one PCs into a dark and dangerous haunted house builds both the suspense and fear that make *Curse of Strahd*'s creeping horror so effective.

Cons

- The mechanical tone of Death House can differ greatly from the rest of *Curse of Strahd*, building player familiarity with a linear dungeon crawl that contrasts with the open sandbox nature of the rest of Barovia.

- Many experienced players prefer starting at a level when their characters become more complex and their archetypes accessible. Level one characters can occasionally bore veterans who may be more interested in mechanical aspects of D&D.
- Death House can easily be removed from a campaign without impacting the rest of the adventure, which speaks to its uselessness in service to the overall plot.

Once you have chosen to run Death House, you must be prepared to structure the earliest sessions of the campaign around it.

When the PCs arrive in the land of Barovia, Death House will be the first sign they see of proper, established civilization. However, placing it within the borders of Barovia Village can make it clear to your players that they are being railroaded inside, and possibly lead them to mistrust Rose and Thorn from the get-go.

To play Death House as a more insular and immersive location, place it within a small hamlet on the side of the road to the Village of Barovia. It is flanked by two abandoned structures on either side: a dilapidated servants' house; and a ruined stable. Both are largely empty, and contain only a single room.¹

If you would like to encourage the PCs to view Death House more favorably upon their initial arrival, allow a thunderstorm to erupt as the characters are making their way down the Svalich Road. While seeking shelter amidst the storm, they see a light in the distance - a lantern held by the illusory Rose, who is standing beneath the awning of the house, sheltering her "brother" from the rain and signalling for help to any victims nearby.

Once Death House has been completed, and the PCs have escaped its dungeon, the fog recedes, allowing the characters to see the village in the distance.

¹ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

? For Your Consideration - Low-Gear Beginnings

If you chose to use the **Penniless and Weaponless** story hook modification, Death House is an excellent opportunity to make your players feel powerless while also providing them an opportunity to improvise their self-defense and acquire low-level gear that they can build up over time.

Survival horror is a genre that shines when characters are incentivized to run and hide, rather than standing and fighting. This kind of theme is an excellent tone to strike in Death House, both for the dungeon's own atmosphere, and for the lesson it teaches players regarding the rest of the sandbox-style module to come.

At this point, your PCs should retain, at most, their clothes, and a few choice items that they have slept with, including a coin pouch, single dagger, or arcane focus. A player that has lost their backpack, their heavy armor, or even their boots will feel much more vulnerable to the horrors that Death House holds. As a result, they will become anxious enough to scavenge - and more resourceful as a result.

While within Death House, your players will need to get creative with the weapons that they can use. Fireplace pokers can serve as spears, and barrel covers can act as makeshift shields. A bottle of wine, a tinderbox, and an old rag can easily create a Molotov cocktail. If you keep track of the mundane and weaponized item within Death House, and add in a few that your PCs might be able to use, your players will have a good array of options to choose from.

Do note that this can be regarded as a hardcore mode of gameplay, afforded only to veteran roleplayers or experienced survivors of horror games. Encourage your players outside of game to treat Death House as a kind of *Amnesia*-like survival horror game, and allow them the freedom to create their own solutions to monstrous, overwhelming problems.²

History

As-written, the legacy of the Durst family and its cult is a perfectly acceptable piece of Barovian history for your PCs to confront. However, while the official version of the Dursts' story can provide a comfortably evil equivalent to Acerak, the Black Spider, or similarly evil D&D villains, they can feel largely one-dimensional while compared to the emotional and mental depth of Strahd himself.

Much of the modifications that this guide makes to the Death House appendix encourage players to seek out more depth and characterization of potentially-rich characters such as Rose, Walter, and the Durst family's nursemaid. However, if you wish to go even deeper into humanizing the struggles and darkness of the Durst household, you may consider using the following family history, on which many of the following modifications are based:

When Strahd von Zarovich conquered Barovia, the Durst family was an upper-class household of minor noble descent that managed to retain power under the new regime by cozying up to the

2 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

new lord in Castle Ravenloft. As time went on, however, Mr. and Mrs. Durst were affected by the darkness that swept over Barovia. Mr. Durst became solemn and depressed, while Mrs. Durst felt herself grow older and uglier.

In search of the brightness that had escaped his life, Mr. Durst turned to his children's nursemaid, a young and single woman by the name of Margaret. Flattered by the older and wealthier man's charms, Margaret enjoyed a brief affair with him that accidentally ended with her pregnancy.

As she watched Margaret's belly swell with her husband's bastard child, Mrs. Durst lost herself to jealousy and hatred, convinced that her increasing age was responsible for her husband's adultery. Drawing on tales of Count Strahd von Zarovich's eldritch power, Mrs. Durst founded a cult dedicated to the secrets of immortality and youth. Mr. Durst soon found himself involved - and complicit as well.

The cult would lure travelers, neighbors, and servants alike into the Durst household, murdering them in ritual sacrifice on the altar in the basement in an effort to draw forth their life force. However, nothing ever worked.

Each time Mr. and Mrs. Durst performed these sacrifices, they locked their children in their rooms in a sincere attempt to protect them. However, soon after Margaret's bastard son, Walter was born, Mrs. Durst lost her patience completely.

One stormy night, Mrs. Durst murdered Margaret in her sleep, and took Walter down into the basement. Standing alone before the altar, she chanted an unholy prayer and sacrificed the infant upon its stone surface. This act of infanticide attracted the notice of a Dark Power - Norganus, the Finger of Oblivion. Amused by the depravity and desperation of the Dursts, Norganus granted the Dursts and their cultists the immortality they so craved - by turning them into ghouls and ghosts.

Mr. Durst, upon seeing what his wife had done, was overcome with guilt, and hanged himself in the basement. Mrs. Durst soon lost herself to madness, and lost herself in the catacombs of the dungeon beneath. With no adults left to remember them, Rose and Thorne starved to death in their room.

Mrs. Durst's final sacrifice, so perverted and malignant in its nature, transformed Walter himself. This act of betrayal twisted and broke the infant's soul and body, morphing Walter's spirit and flesh into an enormous, horrible monster that anchored Norganus' curse to the very foundations of Death House.³

If made in aggregate, these changes have several notable effects:

- Though Mr. Durst retains his culpability for his involvement with the cult, the horrors that he produced are the indirect result of the wickedness of Mrs. Durst. Even if the PCs

3 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

recognize Mr. Durst's own evil, they may yet feel a certain level of pity and sympathy for the creature that he became.

- The twisted, two-dimensional depravity of the cult, including its cannibalism and orgies, is no longer necessary.

Rose and Thorn

If you wish your PCs to trust these children, avoid showing your players the illustration of Rose and Thorn at all costs. The creepy imagery will immediately put the players on guard, and they make ignore or attack the illusions instead of entering the house.⁴

While illusions, Rose and Thorn are sophisticated simulacra created by the house. They are solid to the touch, and are indistinguishable from ordinary children.⁵

The children ask the PCs to check on their baby brother, Walter, who they say was left upstairs when they fled the monster in the basement. They inform the party that their parents went down to stop the monster some time ago, but have not returned since. Both children are too frightened to enter the house, and Rose refuses to leave Thorn's side, who fled in tears when the monster began to roar.

The children refuse to venture into the fog in search of help because they know that "bad things" lurk there. They inform the PCs that the fog appeared soon before the beast, and suggest that the mists may clear up when the monster is killed. A PC with a sufficiently high passive perception can hear a baby faintly crying from the upper levels of the house.⁶

Areas of the House

As your PCs explore the main floors of Death House, keep in mind that many of the rooms may be empty, and that the story of the Durst family is told through forgotten trinkets, hidden secrets, and personal affects. While this campaign guide has updated the first half of this dungeon to create a more atmospheric and engaging tone, do make sure that you are keeping your players engaged in the environment around them. The intensity of *Curse of Strahd* ramps slowly, beginning mild, and spiking toward the end.⁷ Make sure you're doing your part to build the slow, creeping horror that is meant to define this module's danger and darkness.

☐ Extra Credit - Death House Soundscape

When running your PCs through the interior of Death House, consider using [this](#) soundscape created on AmbientMixer to enhance their immersion.

4 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

5 ElvenTower, [Curse of Strahd intro – Running the Death House](#)

6 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

7 Power Score, [Curse of Strahd - Death House](#)

To this end, several of the rooms in this campaign guide have been updated to contain For Your Consideration information boxes that build toward a creepier, more traditional haunted-house feel. While these modifications can, individually, make Death House a more interesting experience for your players, in aggregate they can downplay the mystery and ultimate reveal of the house's fate. This has the potential to transform a mystery-solving adventure into a more straightforward dungeon escape, which may harm the narrative urgency that drives your players to uncover the remnants of the Durst family's legacy. Therefore, be cautious when considering which, when, how, and how many of these spookier encounters you employ.

If you ultimately choose to leave one or several of the rooms empty, you run the risk of boring your players. For this reason, be mindful of the pacing of your session, and do your best to keep things moving if the story begins to drag. Don't be afraid to tell your players that a room contains nothing else to find, and ask them what they would like to do next.

Due to the small size of most rooms in Death House, there is very little room for tactical combat. You may find it easier and more immersive to run combat scenarios using "theater of the mind," rather than an illustrated battlemat. As the floorplan of the house can be confusing, however, it can't hurt to encourage your players to sketch out a rough map of the rooms they've already visited. Spend your time worrying about where your PCs are and what they can interact with, rather than calculating the exact bounds of a Ray of Sickness.⁸

1. Entrance

If your PCs return to the front door after entering the house, they find it to be stuck in the doorframe, unable to be opened.

2. Main Hall

If you wish to instill a sense of urgency in your players, allow them to hear a muffled scream from the floor beneath, and the soft sobbing of an infant coming from an upper level. Keep in mind that this may cause your PCs to skip many rooms as they race toward their ultimate goal.

? For Your Consideration - Main Hall Haunting

When a PC listens at the dining room doors, the sound of clinking glass, laughter, and muffled conversation can be heard from beyond. When the door is opened, the PCs find the room to be empty.

3. Den of Wolves

? For Your Consideration - Den of Wolves Haunting

The stuffed wolves move when not directly observed.⁹

5. Dining Room

? For Your Consideration - Dining Room Haunting

The dining table is laid with a magnificent feast. A PC that eats from it must succeed on a DC 15 Wisdom save, or else be compelled to stuff themselves with food. After the PC has filled their gullet for a full minute, the glamor upon the banquet vanishes, revealing it to be rotted, foul meats infested with maggots and stale breads stuffed with weevils. At this point, the compulsion upon any affected PCs falls, leaving them poisoned for 1 hour.

6. Upper Hall

? For Your Consideration - Upper Hall Haunting

A character that listens at the door of the Servants' Room can smell blood, and hear the sobs and muffled gasps of a woman in pain.¹⁰

7. Servants' Room

If your PCs decide to take a long or short rest while in Death House, the Servants' Room is the most likely location for them to do so. If they choose to hole up in this small chamber, you may consider upping the difficulty of the House by giving the characters terrible nightmares, removing any benefits they may gain by taking a long rest.

If the PCs take a long rest in this or any other room of Death House, use one or all of the following haunts while the characters sleep:

- A PC hears rats scrabbling up and down the spaces between the walls.¹¹
- A PC hears footsteps descending from the attic and stopping outside of their door before moving away to the library. Soon after, a grinding noise can be heard coming from the library (the sound of the secret door).
- A PC hears maniacal laughter echoing from far below the House.
- A PC experiences a false awakening, wherein they wake to see that one of their friends has been replaced by a ghast, which is slowly creeping toward another PC. If the PC

9 Los Vaqueros Press, [Death House: Reworked Regions #1](#)

10 Los Vaqueros Press, [Death House: Reworked Regions #1](#)

11 Power Score, [Curse of Strahd - Death House](#)

stays still, the ghast slices open its victim's throat, and the PC watches their friend bleed out before waking up.¹²

- A PC overhears a whispered argument about parentage. A pleading female voice in the PC's right ear swears that "it isn't his." A cold female voice in the PC's left ear scoffs, and says that it doesn't care.¹³

If the PCs damage anything on the first or second floor in their search for traps or treasure and return to any such chambers after a long rest, let them know that the rooms have been restored to pristine condition.

8. Library

A tattered piece of sheet music lies on the desk. It is titled "Song for Elizabeth." A handwritten, partially burnt note sits beside it; it reads "Bulwarton's words can open the way." The red-covered fake book that opens the secret door is titled "An Architect's Art," and is written by Archibald Bulwarton.

A small rock collection sits upon one of the shelves; each of the stones are labelled with its scientific name. This collection once belonged to Mr. Durst. Additionally, the top drawer of the desk contains a number of receipts for candles, daggers, and incense.¹⁴

? For Your Consideration - Library Haunting

One of the books on the shelves is titled "The History of (PC's Name)." If read, it provides a narration of the PC's entire life. The final page reads: "[He/She] pulled the book down off the shelf and began to read, unaware of the creature that watched [him/her] from the shadows. Slowly, the beast began to creep forward." The next page is blank, save for a bloodstain two-thirds down. A search of the room evidences no indication of any other creature.¹⁵

A PC that searches the room and passes a DC 15 Investigation check can see flickering candlelight beneath the secret door.¹⁶

9. Secret Room

Change the text of Strahd's letter in the secret room to refer to a "bastard" instead of a "stillborn."¹⁷

If you are using Uncle Dimov as discussed in the For Your Consideration box of Area 20, you may choose to include the following letter tucked away in the alcove alongside the deed to Old Bonegrinder:

¹² /u/ajcperei, [Long Rests in the Death House](#)

¹³ Los Vaqueros Press, [Death House: Reworked Regions #1](#)

¹⁴ /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

¹⁵ /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

¹⁶ Los Vaqueros Press, [Death House: Reworked Regions #1](#)

¹⁷ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

My dear Dimov,

I must confess, my nights as of late have been sleepless. The child's wails these past several evenings have kept me awake, haunting these halls like a ghost. Margaret does her best, but other clouds yet trouble my dreams.

My beloved Elisabeth, I am sure, feels it too, for she tosses and turns in our bed and awakes with her forehead slick with sweat. O'er the past several congregations, I have become suspicious of the ambitions of the others. Their dark murmurs worry me, and though I know that a shadow ought not fear a blacker night, I cannot but fear for the extent of their plotting.

If anything happens, you are to be steward of our parents' house, and caretaker of my children. Keep Rose and Thorn safe, and dear Walter close to your breast. Should the worst come to pass, you shall be all they have left.

Your loving brother,
Gustav

The key to Rose and Thorn's room is folded inside of this letter.¹⁸

10. Conservatory

If a PC plays the "Song of Elizabeth" found on the desk in the library on the harpsichord in this chamber, the conservatory fills with ghosts that dance about the room to the tune of the melody. The ghosts take no notice of the characters, save for two: Gustav and Elizabeth Durst, who stand beside the fireplace, staring at the PCs. When noticed, the harpsichord's strings are cut, the ghosts vanish, and a grinding sound can be heard from above, signalling the opening of the secret passage in the attic.¹⁹

If the PCs exit the room without playing the harpsichord, the sound of "Song of Elizabeth" can be heard faintly through the doors until the room is re-entered.²⁰

A PC that searches this room can find a small dog hiding under an armchair. A tag on his leash identifies him as Lancelot, owned by Gertruda. As Mad Mary lost herself to grief, Lancelot left his house in order to search for Gertruda. He wandered into Death House, and was trapped in the conservatory when the house shut the door behind him. He is rail-thin and starving, and terrified of any character that approaches him. He can be coaxed out from his hiding spot, however, with a DC 10 Animal Handling check, with advantage if offered food.

The cult of Death House considers Lancelot an acceptable sacrifice if killed on the altar.

18 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

19 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

20 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

11. Balcony

As the characters ascend the spiral stairs, remind them that they can see down the center of the staircase all the way to the bottom floor.²¹ If the Animated Armor is thrown down to the first floor and the PCs do not reveal their presence atop the balcony, it is unable to observe them with its sixty feet of blindsight, and is too stupid to think to climb back up.

A creature that is pushed over the edge of the balcony falls two stories, or twenty feet, and takes 2d6 bludgeoning damage. That creature must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check or land prone.

Remember that there are two secret doors that can lead to the attic staircase. The first lies in the upper left corner of the Nursemaid's Suite. The second is directly opposite the first, at the southern corner of the Balcony.

☐ Know the Monsters: Animated Armor

The Armor will attempt to push PCs over the railing itself using a shove attack,²² or attempt to grapple its nearest target before shoving them prone. Remember that, as the Armor has two attacks per round, it is able to make two shove or grapple attempts each turn, or any mixture of the two.²³

12. Master Suite

Mrs. Durst's jewelry box contains an unsent letter from Mrs. Durst to a fellow cult member. It reads:

My Dear Mrs. Petrovna,

Your advice on dealing with the unwanted fiend in my home is quite good advice indeed. Tonight's ceremony will proceed as planned when the moon is at its highest peak - without, of course, the attendance of Mr. Durst. I must agree with you that, with the assistance of such a remarkably innocent subject, the results of our proceedings may be far improved. "Innocent," of course, is not quite the term I would use.

If nothing else, I am relieved that I shall soon no longer have to suffer the harlot's insufferable presence each time we must pass through her quarters to our meeting-space. We shall be well rid of her indeed.

My Thanks,
Mrs. Elisabeth Durst²⁴

21 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

22 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

23 The Monsters Know What They're Doing, [Animated Object Tactics](#)

24 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

When the PCs enter this room, they find a male **ghast** dressed in fine clothes hanging from a noose tied beside the bed. This body is Mr. Durst. He is dead, and does not attack the PCs when disturbed.

A small piece of parchment is clutched in Mr. Durst's right hand, held tight by rigor mortis.²⁵ If removed, it reads:

My Beloved Children,

I wish I could do what all fathers do and tell you that monsters aren't real. But it wouldn't be true.

Life can create things of exquisite beauty. But it can also twist them into hideous beings. Selfish. Violent. Grotesque. Monstrous. It hurts me to say that your mother has turned into one such monster, inside and out. And I'm afraid the disease that afflicted her mind has taken hold of me as well.

It sickens me to think what we've put you through. There is no excuse. I only ask you, though I know I have not the right to do so, to try and forgive us. I despise what your mother has become, but I love and pity her all the same.

Rose, I wish I could see you blossom into a strong, beautiful woman. Thorn and Walter, I wish I could be there for you. But I can't. This is the only way.

Goodbye.

A DC 13 Wisdom (Medicine) check reveals that Mr. Durst has been dead for no more than a few hours. This is another manifestation of the house's curse, and not actually correct.

15. Nursemaid's Suite

A small table beside the bed holds a cobwebbed copy of a raunchy romance novel on its surface, hidden clumsily beneath a mildew-covered towel. The novel is titled "Blue-Blooded Lips," and tells the story of a wealthy duke who enjoys an affair with his female cupbearer.²⁶

When any character inspects the mirror, they find the secret door automatically without any checks required. It makes little sense for such a mundane door to be concealed so expertly, and

²⁵ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

²⁶ /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

a DC 15 Perception barrier can create undue frustration in your players, given that finding this door is necessary to continue forward.

There are three ways to run the encounter with the nursemaid, each varying with her emotional and spiritual state: Hostile, Alien, and Friendly.

A **hostile** encounter maintains the antagonism of the nursemaid's specter. While it is ill-advised to run this encounter as an immediate combat, due to the severe mismatch between a specter's CR and your PCs' expected level, a lack of care by your players can lead to a dangerous situation. When the PCs open the door to the nursery, they see the back of a young woman wearing a homely dress and a bonnet. If disturbed, the specter slowly turns toward the PCs, revealing the face of a terrified, skeletal young woman whose flesh falls off in chunks to reveal the specter beneath.²⁷ If the PCs approach, she warns in a whisper: "Don't wake the baby. The baby is sleeping." If a PC threatens or approaches the bundle containing the "baby," the specter attacks, relenting only when all PCs have fled her chambers, or when the character that disturbed her "baby" has been killed or knocked unconscious.

An **alien** encounter preserves the emotional distance between the PCs and the nursemaid's ghost. While the spirit is not actively antagonistic, she cannot be communicated with directly. When the door is opened, she holds a finger to her lips and whispers, "Hush. The baby is sleeping."²⁸ If a PC approaches the crib in the nursery and opens the bundle inside, the nursemaid's specter vanishes. A PC that then views the mirror sees the image of the nursemaid looking back at them.²⁹ The reflection perfectly follows the PC's movements; however, the nursemaid's eyes can still blink on their own. If a PC asks her for help in locating Walter or the basement, she smiles and steps aside, leaving the mirror blank. Alternatively, when the crib is approached, the nursemaid scoops up the bundle in the crib and exits the nursery, passing through the mirror and the closed secret door there.

A **friendly** encounter allows the PCs to communicate directly with the spirit of the nursemaid. If approached with hostility, the specter vanishes in fright. If approached with kindness or respect, however, the nursemaid's specter introduces herself as Margaret. She is withdrawn and shy, and does not fully understand how or why she died. She is confused, and frequently jumps between awareness and ignorance of her own state of undeath, sometimes in the same sentence.

She speaks fondly of Mr. Durst, but avoids mentioning their affair out of a sense of propriety. If a PC asks her about her relationship with Mr. Durst or her parentage of Walter, she smiles sadly and informs the party that it is "not her place to speak of such things." She adores Rose, Thorn, and Walter. While she does not speak ill of Mrs. Durst if asked, she is clearly uncomfortable and fearful of the lady of the house.³⁰ When the PCs finish their conversation, she scoops up the

27 /u/I_BLADE_YOUR_MOTHER, [What I have learned from running Curse of Strahd twice Death House to Vallaki](#)

28 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

29 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

30 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

“baby” in her arms and informs the PCs that she’s taking him to play with his older brother and sister. Margaret then walks through the mirror into the attic; a moment later, the secret door clicks open, revealing the hidden passageway.³¹ Margaret does not appear again.

18. Storage Room

If the players find the nursemaid’s body, and you chose to run her specter as an **alien** or **friendly** encounter, her ghost does not reappear.

The nursemaid’s corpse appears curled up in the trunk. If the PCs investigate, they see that the front of Margaret’s dress has multiple stab holes, indicating her murder.³²

20. Children’s Room

Take care to play the encounter with Rose and Thorn’s ghosts as humanizing and sympathetic, rather than alien and frightening. Despite their nature as centuries-old spirits, Rose and Thorn are fundamentally children - lost, scared, yet innocent children. As such, when Rose or Thorn attempt to possess a PC, attempt to present it in such a manner that the character willingly allows the spirit to enter their body. If you describe it as “a child’s tiny hand, desperately seeking the warm embrace of another soul,” your players may even decline to roll a saving throw against possession.³³ A PC that is possessed by Rose or Thorn can continue to communicate with the child’s spirit as a voice in their head.

If you would like to deepen Rose’s characterization, you may make her a child prodigy who is quite aware of the dynamics in her house (though not the specific details). She is also a budding wizard who discovered a small spellbook in her father’s library, and took great care in copying the Mending, Light, and Shocking Grasp cantrips into her diary. To demonstrate this, you may choose to have the ghostly Thorn accidentally break one of his toys, which Rose swiftly Mends. Should she possess a PC, she is able to cast those cantrips through her host’s body.

Rose shyly shares her diary with the party if her use of magic is remarked upon. Rose’s diary contains entries regarding her studies, her friends, her younger brother (who she is fiercely protective of), and elementary (yet insightful) observations on the nature of magic.³⁴

31 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

32 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

33 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

34 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

? For Your Consideration - Uncle Dimov

If you wish to include a darker undercurrent to Rose's wizardry, you may choose to include the following entry in Rose's diary, just below her notes on Shocking Grasp:

It worked! Uncle Dimov snuck into our room again, but this time I was ready. I hope he never comes back!

If the PCs attempt to discuss this incident or an Uncle Dimov with Rose, she instantly clams up. If Thorn is asked about his uncle, he shrinks in on himself and falls silent, Rose hugging him while glaring daggers at the PC responsible.³⁵

If you would prefer to avoid the implication of child abuse, you may have Rose instead explain that Uncle Dimov would break Thorn's toys and taunt him for his timid nature and weak constitution.

Once the PCs have made friends or allies of Rose and Thorn, if the PCs appear wounded or tired, the ghostly children offer the use of their room as a sanctuary for a rest, and promise to stand guard against the "monsters" that they've heard below.³⁶

While ignorant to the true nature of the cult, Rose remembers hearing her mother bringing Walter to the basement before she died. She asks the PCs to save their baby brother and parents, and defeat the monster below once and for all.

Rose knows the way down to the basement, but "isn't supposed to go down there" and "doesn't want to get in trouble."³⁷ If the party convinces her to show them the way, she points them toward the dollhouse, revealing the secret entry. In exchange, she asks the PCs to deliver her and Thorn's bones to their resting places in the crypts below.³⁸

The dollhouse contains small dolls that depict tiny, twisted molds of any characters and creatures currently visible in the house. The dolls are made of painted resin. Any character looking inside the dollhouse while in Rose and Thorn's room can see the appropriately-placed dolls of all living creatures within the manor.³⁹

21. Secret Stairs

Make sure to remind your players to prepare to reach level two before the session that you expect them to find this area.

35 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

36 SlyFlourish, [Running Death House](#)

37 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

38 ElvenTower, [Curse of Strahd intro – Running the Death House](#)

39 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

25. Well & Cultist Quarters

The footlocker containing the eyepatch contains a cultist's logbook, bound in grimy black leather. This journal maintains a list of names, physical descriptions, and details of some sort of event. One of the head cultists maintained this logbook as a record of the cult's victims. The second column maintains the physical description of each victim named in the first column, while the third column bears gruesome details describing the sacrifice, such as "Struggled profusely" and "No sedative given."⁴⁰

28. Larder

The grick in this alcove is coiled on the ceiling, and drops onto its victim when they enter. A DC 17 Wisdom (Perception) check allows a PC to determine its presence before entering.⁴¹ Rather than reptilian, the grick's skin has been flayed away, rendering its species unrecognizable and its body a pink, fleshy substrate with tendon-like tentacles.

29. Ghoulish Encounter

As-written, this encounter can be far beyond Deadly. To give your PCs a better chance of survival, you may choose to tailor the number of ghouls to the size and level of your party using a tool like [Kobold Fight Club](#).⁴² You may also choose to make the ghouls spend their first turn digging their way out from their shallow graves, removing the element of surprise.

While the narrow corridors of this basement should allow your PCs to bottleneck these ghouls quite easily, you may also wish to encourage your party to avoid this hallway entirely by describing it as holding "an overpowering stench of death and decay." If nothing else, this alerts your players that something dangerous lies down this hall, and potentially prepares them for battle.

As the ghouls are the undead forms of the former cultists, they retain some vestige of their former selves. They mindlessly repeat any or all of the following phrases as they attack the PCs: "Beautiful. We're so beautiful"; "Nothing can hurt us"; "We are perfect. We are immortal"; and "Help us live forever."

30. Stairs Down

Similar to the house above, it is quite possible for your PCs to beeline a path directly to the ritual chamber, thus skipping many of the other rooms and encounters. If you want to ensure that the PCs get to see most of the dungeon, you may place a locked door at the bottom of these stairs. If you choose to do so, you should move the corpse of Mr. Durst from Area 12 (The Master Suite) to Area 34. The key to unlock this door can be found hanging from Mr. Durst's neck.⁴³

40 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

41 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

42 StarwalkerStudios, [How to Run Death House Without Killing All the PCs](#)

43 SlyFlourish, [Running Death House](#)

31. Darklord's Shrine

This is an incredibly lethal encounter, especially given the Strength Drain ability each shadow has, which can easily snowball into a TPK. You can ease the difficulty by allowing the shadows to emerge in waves, with two new shadows attacking each round.⁴⁴

You can also foreshadow the danger in this room by telling the PCs that they can see five ashen shadows burned into the walls, with soot marks stretching across the floor toward the Darklord's statue. If the orb is disturbed, the shadows begin swooping across the walls, and attack the party a round later. While the shadows prepare to attack, the PCs can hear their murmured moans, including phrases such as "Begone from this place!"; and "Look not upon us."

A character that approaches the orb can hear many voices whispering: "His gaze burns upon us"; "the Darklord's eyes are always watching"; and "He is the Ancient; He is the Land."

If you wish to remove the combat aspect of this area altogether, you can remove the shadows from this chamber, and simply inform any PC that touches the orb that they suddenly feel "a dark, ancient evil turning its eye upon them." Strahd then becomes aware of the PCs' presence in Death House.⁴⁵

33. Cult Leaders' Den

If the **mimic** is attacked at range by a wary or alerted PC, it flees, vanishing around the corner and reappearing as a door, chest, or longsword elsewhere in the dungeon.

34. Cult Leaders' Quarters

Don't forget that the lockbox in this room contains a *cloak of protection* and several *potions of healing*. These will be invaluable in keeping your PCs alive as they progress deeper into the dungeon. There's also a spellbook containing a number of staple spells that any wizard would be grateful for.

When a character removes the items from the chest or inspects either of the portraits. Mrs. Durst, a ghost, bursts from behind her portrait and attacks.⁴⁶

Unlike the ghouls, Mrs. Durst retains the ability of speech. She has retained her memory, but has completely succumbed to her own dark whims. She wears a tattered, once-beautiful red dress, and she wears gold earrings and a golden necklace around her neck. Her lips and gums have gone black with rot, and her smile shines with madness. At this point, she bears only a vague resemblance to her own portrait.

Mrs. Durst has gone completely insane. She is arrogant to an extreme, and shuns her dead husband, calling him a lecherous traitor who deserved his death. She speaks unkindly of Walter

44 ElvenTower, [Curse of Strahd intro – Running the Death House](#)

45 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

46 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

and the nursemaid, and writes off Rose and Thorn as “bothersome nuisances.” She is vulgar to a fault, and speaks in a hissing, gurgling voice.

Should the players ask her what she did to Walter, she invites them to descend further into the basement and “see for themselves.”

If reduced to half hitpoints, Mrs. Durst commands the PCs to leave, and defensively backs herself into the corner.

35. Reliquary

To foreshadow some of the future locations and characters, you may replace some of the items in this chamber with trinkets or omens reflecting other events in Barovia.⁴⁷ They include:

- an angelic feather
- a wooden figurine of a black knight bearing the emblem of a rose
- severed raven talons
- a small chunk of amber resin that exudes an evil aura
- a cracked egg containing the remains of a skeletal infant dragon

37. Portcullis

The wooden wheel that opens the portcullis is located on the eastern side of the gate, rather than the western side. When the Mound is summoned, the portcullis crashes to the ground, sealing shut.

38. Ritual Chamber

When the PCs enter this chamber, you can inform them that they can see a blanket of mist rolling off of the top of the dais beneath the altar, and specifically draw their attention to its resemblance to the fog outside. This will suggest to them that something about the altar is causing the fog outside. When the ritual is completed, the fog disappears, signalling that the PCs can now escape.

A small, white bundle is visible atop the altar. When approached, it resembles the size and shape of an infant wrapped in swaddling clothes. It instead contains a rusted, serrated dagger painted red with dried blood.

When the Mound is summoned, the cultists chant instead: “Come, demon! We awaken thee!”⁴⁸ A small earthquake shakes the foundations of the house above, sifting dirt and dust from the ceiling above.⁴⁹

To better situate the Mound (a plant creature) within Death House’s dungeon, use the following reflavored description as it emerges:

47 /u/endangerous, [DM Tips Curse of Strahd - Part 1 - Intro & Death House](#)

48 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

49 /u/NobbynobLittlun, [Notes from running Death House](#)

Before you, coming out of the westernmost alcove is a rolling mass of decay and rot. Thick tendrils of waste wriggle from it, reaching for nearby surfaces. You can see the tendrils' grip on the walls tighten with crushing force. As the enormous thing crawls towards you, you see bodily remains of humans buried in its putrid body.⁵⁰

When Lorgoth begins to move, the ghosts of Rose and Thorn (if on friendly terms with the PCs) appear, interposing their spirits between the Mound and the characters, and shout for the party to flee.

? For Your Consideration - Walter, the Flesh Mound

For a darker, more personal, and more grotesque take on this encounter, consider replacing the Shambling Mound with a Flesh Mound, as described below.

When the Dark Power accepted Mrs. Durst's final sacrifice, Walter was transformed into a terrible monster: a vessel for the cult's hatred, arrogance, and depravity bound within an innocent babe. If the PCs refuse to make the requested sacrifice, the cult is angered, and summons Walter. If the PCs make the requested sacrifice, the cult chants victoriously, and summons Walter anyway. Either way, your players should feel as though they have just made a grave error.

When the Flesh Mound is summoned, the dirty water filling the chamber ripples as something moves beneath the surface. A host of bones, flesh, and disparate body parts come together from the water, collecting into a massive, shifting heap of gore.

During this battle, you may use the modified stat block for the Flesh Mound, which can be found below.⁵¹

WALTER, THE FLESH MOUND

Large undead, unaligned

Armor Class 15 (Natural Armor)
Hit Points 119 (14d10 + 42)
Speed 20ft., swim 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	8 (-1)	16 (+3)	3 (-4)	10 (+0)	5 (-3)

Condition Immunities Blinded, Deafened, Exhaustion
Senses blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 10
Languages None
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Innocent Heart. Walter's infant corpse lies at the heart of the Flesh Mound, crying and afraid. So long as a creature remains engulfed within the Flesh Mound, they are entrapped within the central cavity where Walter's corpse dwells.

This "Heart" is encased by a thick shell of white bone and pulsating veins that extend throughout the mound. The Heart has an AC of 10 and 5 HP; if the Heart's hit points are reduced to 0, the Flesh Mound is reduced to 0 hit points and dissolves into a pile of liquid gore.

Actions

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5ft., one target. *Hit:* 13 (2d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a creature, the Flesh Mound can grapple it (escape DC 14) instead of dealing the bludgeoning damage.

Engulf *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5ft., one target. *Hit:* The Flesh Mound engulfs a Medium or smaller creature grappled by it. The engulfed target is restrained, and must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw at the start of each of its turns, taking 3 (1d4) bludgeoning damage on a failure. If the mound moves, the engulfed target moves with it. The mound can have only one creature engulfed at a time.

If you wish to force the PCs to engage with the Mound, consider allowing the cult to shut and lock the portcullis that serves as the room's main entryway.

Once a PC has seen or learned of Walter's existence, if that PC is aware of the circumstances of Walter's birth and death, that PC may make a DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) or DC 15 Intelligence (Religion) check to learn the source of the curse upon Death House. A PC that

⁵¹ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd, Part 2: Entering Barovia and Streamlining Death House](#)

succeeds on this check learns that the spirit of a murdered infant, unwanted by a parent, can incite a powerful curse upon its household, tormenting its killers and chaining their souls to the place of its death. The only way to remove the curse upon Death House, this PC learns, is to bury Walter's corpse at sunrise beneath the threshold of the dwelling.

Endings

Flight from Death House

When the PCs defeat or flee from the Shambling Mound, the house responds in kind. The floor begins to quake, and the ceiling shudders and cracks as debris and dust begin to sift into the air. As the structure groans above the PCs' heads, make it clear that they must flee - before Death House collapses atop them.

To successfully escape from Death House, the PCs must succeed on a skill challenge.⁵² A holdover from 4th edition, a skill challenge requires the PCs to face a number of obstacles that cannot be solved solely by combat.

Note that the following section is largely copied wholesale from Wyatt Trull's [Curse of Strahd: Escaping Death House Skill Challenge](#). If you find it interesting or helpful, we heavily recommend donating a small amount using the Dungeon Masters Guild link above to support their work.

For more information on how to run a skill challenge, see [Appendix F: How to Run Skill Challenges](#).

Running the Skill Challenge

The PCs must accrue 4 successes before 3 failures to escape Death House successfully.

Once the challenge begins, swarms of maggots begin to bleed from the walls, floor, and ceiling of any room that the PCs take refuge in, filling the room completely within 3d4 rounds. Note that only the doorways to Areas 12 and 15 have the scythes mentioned in the module.

Roll initiative upon beginning the skill challenge; on 3 failures, the slowest adventurer is left behind. On 5 failures, the slowest two adventurers are trapped while their companions make it to safety. If the characters achieved 4 successes before 3 failures, all make it out—worse for wear, and forced to carry in their hearts this hellish night forevermore.

The skill challenge begins as soon as the party defeats or decides to flee the Mound in the basement. The rooms of the house are modified in the following ways:

38. Ritual Chamber

As the PCs move to flee, the portcullis slams shut. On a failure, the adventurers wallow in indecision or struggle to force it open, eventually escaping at the cost of 1 failed check.

⁵² Wyatt Trull, [Curse of Strahd: Escaping Death House Skill Challenge](#)

The following skills are suggested for surmounting this obstacle:

- **Athletics** can be used to force open the portcullis or unjam the wheel. (Moderate DC)
- **Thieves'-, or Tinker's tools** can be used to assess the damage to the wheel and manipulate its gears to unjam the portcullis. (Moderate DC)
- **Insight** or **Investigation** can be used to recall or rationalize that the nearby corridor to Area 36, the Prison, might have a secret door. (Hard DC)
- **Perception** can be used to spot the hidden door to Area 36, the prison, providing another means of escape from the chamber. (Moderate DC)

26. Hidden Spiked Pit

There is no mandatory obstacle here, but a trap that might not have been previously encountered by the adventurers. Run it as-is in the Death House module: a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check is necessary to notice the trap. The first character to step on the trapped section falls prone and takes 1d6 bludgeoning damage, plus 2d10 piercing damage from the spikes. The pit is 10-feet deep.

At your discretion, this can serve as an obstacle. A player might request—scream out, even—for the chance to stop a character from falling into the pit. If so, it counts as a success or failure for the skill challenge; otherwise, treat this area as a non-obstacle. Some skill checks suggested by the players might include:

- **Carpenter's- or Woodcarver's tools** can be used to notice how rotted the planks are and understand it to be unsafe before all is lost. (Moderate DC)
- **Sleight of Hand** can be used to snatch at the falling character's belt, or snatch at the edge, preventing their own fall. (Easy DC)
- **Acrobatics** may allow a character to divert their momentum into a leap, landing safely on the opposite side. (Moderate DC)

25. Well & Cultist Quarters

The room has become heavily obscured by an unnatural black fog. In the well, a skeleton has been roused from its slumber, and grapples the last character that moves through this chamber.

- **Acrobatics** or **Athletics** can be used to break the grapple. (Easy DC)
- **Insight** can be used to recall one's steps, if the characters explored this room beforehand. (Easy DC)
- **Perception** can be used to navigate the darkness, hear the skeleton before it strikes, or find its victim. (Moderate DC)

On a failure, the adventurer is nearly pulled into the well where they struggle against the skeleton that seeks to drown them; ultimately, the victim escapes, but not worse for wear.

27. Dining Hall

<i>Screams rend the darkened depths. Screams for mercy, for help, for a quick end. You come</i>

across a man chained to the wooden table, thrashing, screaming. A gash runs the length of his belly, from which blood pulses out to the beat of his heart! How or where he came from doesn't matter, but in the distance, you hear them: the cultists, chanting, hungering! Can you silence him before those ravenous cannibals come upon you?

A ghost of Death House's red past has been made flesh once again, and mad babbling threatens to draw the ghostly cultists upon the adventurers. He has the statistics of a restrained **commoner** with 1 hit point remaining and is bound by chains.

If the characters linger here, five cultists (**shadows**) arrive in 2 rounds and descend upon the man if he yet remains. If freed, he stumbles down the darkened corridors, babbling madly before fading from being. If slain, he does not die quietly.

- **Athletics** can be used with a weapon to break the man's chains, while **thieves' tools** can unlock them. (Hard/Moderate DC)
- **Deception** or **Persuasion** can be used to deceive the man into calm. (Moderate DC)
- **Medicine** can be used to dress his wounds, if the character has a healing kit with 1 action. (Moderate DC)
- **Spells** that restore hit points (healing word, cure wounds) can be used to heal the screaming man. (Automatic Success)

A success here means that this lone spirit, weak as he may be, devotes all his unearthly power to aiding the adventurers.

3. Den of Wolves

Death House has animated the stuffed wolves in the den and flooded the room with blinding smoke. The wolves have the statistics of a **wolf** but with vulnerability to slashing, piercing, and fire damage; their Bite attack deals 1 piercing damage; and they do not need to breathe.

- **Animal Handling** can be used to subdue the wolves; the long-lost spirits of the beasts still obey such primal laws of nature. (Moderate DC)
- **Stealth** can be used to slip past the wolves undetected. (Easy DC)
- **Levelled Spells** (Automatic Success) or **cantrips** (DC 13 - Moderate) such as *minor illusion* or *animal friendship* can be used to distract or subdue the wolves .

21. Secret Staircase

The mortared walls of this staircase have been covered with swarms of infant spiders. As the PCs flee up the steps, an enormous **giant spider** climbs up from the depths, seeking to drag them below. A PC that fails here loses time struggling against the spider.

- **Animal Handling** or **Intimidation** can be used to scare off the spider, especially if fire is used or an attack is made. (Moderate DC)
- **Athletics** can be used to wrench the character out of the web or to keep the spider from dragging the character away. (Moderate DC)

- **Levelled Spells** (Automatic Success) or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) can be cast to subdue the spider or burn the web (e.g., *animal friendship*, *produce flame*, and *firebolt*).

15. Nursemaid's Suite

When the PCs enter this room while fleeing the house, read the following:

As you rush towards the door, you hear woman shout out, "Tell me to push, one more time, Inala! One more time, I swear to the Morninglord!" but her curses are quickly consumed by cries of pain.

You perk into the room: women crowd around a young girl laying in the bed, her feet up. Her face twists with pain while a midwife says, "The baby's coming, but - Gods, it's ankles first!"

The balcony—the only way out of this accursed manor—lies nearby, and with frustrated horror, you see that the door has been replaced with bloodied scythe blades that seem to spin even quicker whenever the girl's contractions rage.

The memories of the past have come alive: while Elisabeth fumes with mute disdain in the Master Suite, the nursemaid is giving birth to the bastard Walter. Several assistants crowd the room while the baby is crowning—but he's coming out ankles-first. The scythe-blades spin so long as the nursemaid is in labor, spinning faster and faster during her contractions. To escape the manor, the adventurers must make it through that doorway.

If the party does not make an ability check for this obstacle, they accrue a failure, and each creature that passes through the doorway must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 2d10 slashing damage. Regardless, they pass through the doorway and onto Area 15C, the Nursemaid's Balcony.

If the party attempts an ability check but fails, no Dexterity saving throws are necessary.

- **Acrobatics** or **Investigation** can be used to make it through the doorway unscathed; the adventurer making the check takes a leadership role in guiding his or her companions through the blades. This check is made only once for all characters present. (Moderate DC)
- **Insight** can be used to gauge when the nursemaid's contractions are about to begin or end. (Moderate DC)
- **Medicine** can be used to assist in the birth: Walter is coming out ankles-first, posing significant risk to the him and the mother. The scythe-blades stop spinning altogether if this ability check succeeds. (Hard DC)

15C. Nursemaid's Balcony

Death House has put all its remaining energy to afflict its prey with a powerful phantasmal force spell (no saving throws required). The balcony has grown into a cliff that drops to a thousand feet below (an eerily accurate representation of the Tser Falls of Barovia). Only with courage,

skill, or acuity can the adventurers conquer the illusory cliff without destroying their minds in the process.

If no skills or spells are applied, the characters accrue a failure and each creature that simply leaped must make a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or take 2d6 psychic damage and wakes to find itself mewling at the foot of the Durst Manor an unknown amount of time later. On a success, a creature takes half damage. No matter the check made, scaling the cliffs takes less than a minute, but feels as if it took an hour.

- **Acrobatics, Athletics or Survival** can be combined with tools such as rope or a climbing kit to scale the cliff, leading others down. (Moderate DC)
- **Arcana** can be used to understand the powerful phantasmal force spell at work, that their psyches stand to be torn apart if caution is thrown to the wind; that perhaps the best way to survive is to play along. (Moderate DC)
- **Investigation** can be used to shatter the illusion by harnessing the strength of the mind. (Hard DC)
- **Spells** that slow or affect flying, such as feather fall; or that would imbue creatures with courage, such as heroism can be used to conquer the illusion; both put the characters' psyches at rest, tricking their subconsciousness believing all will be well. (Automatic Success)

12. Master Suite

The memories of the past have come alive; on the eve of Walter's birth, the Dursts are engaged in a cold war. The suite is as cold and unforgiving as their marriage; while Gustav paces the room, Elisabeth fumes in mute disdain at her vanity. Every so often the two burst into a new round of arguments—and the scythes spin ever faster.

Not quite ghosts, yet not quite illusions, the Dursts are representative of the emotional carnage of the manor. The scythes on the doorway are connected to the two's temperament. And to escape, the party must make it through those scythes.

Read the following:

The master suite has grown deadly cold: a well-dressed man paces the room while a woman stares at herself in the vanity, her eyes scornful as if to wonder why she wasn't enough for her husband. You recognize the Dursts alive and in the flesh—how or why doesn't matter. The two fall between bouts of silence and explosive rage, arguing over Gustav's infidelity.

You look to the corner of the room, to the balcony, that sweet, sweet balcony, the gate to getting the hell out of this accursed manor—and in the doorway spin rusted scythe-blades. You look back: Elisabeth is glaring at you, and she snarls, "Servant! Get out! Get out! Come back only when the bastard's been born!"

You notice with mounting frustration that while Elisabeth snarls at you, the scythe-blades spin pick up speed, spinning ever quicker.

If the party does not make an ability check for this obstacle, they accrue a failure, and each creature that passes through the doorway must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 2d10 slashing damage. Regardless, they pass through the doorway and onto Area 12C, the Master Balcony.

If the party attempts an ability check but fails, no Dexterity saving throws are necessary.

- **Acrobatics** or **Investigation** can be used to make it through the doorway unscathed; the adventurer making the check takes a leadership role in guiding his or her companions through the blades. This check is made only once for all characters present. (Moderate DC)
- **Insight** can be used to gauge Elisabeth or Gustav's emotions, finding the best possible moment to make the leap. (Easy DC)
- **Persuasion** can be used to calm the Dursts, even if for a moment. (Moderate DC)

12C. Master Balcony

Death House has put all its remaining energy to afflict its prey with a powerful phantasmal force spell (no saving throws required). The balcony has grown into a cliff that drops to a thousand feet below (an eerily accurate representation of the Tser Falls of Barovia). Only with courage, skill, or acuity can the adventurers conquer the illusory cliff without destroying their minds in the process.

If no skills or spells are applied, the characters accrue a failure and each creature that simply leaped must make a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or take 2d6 psychic damage and wakes to find itself mewling at the foot of the Durst Manor an unknown amount of time later. On a success, a creature takes half damage. No matter the check made, scaling the cliffs takes less than a minute, but feels as if it took an hour.

- **Acrobatics**, **Athletics** or **Survival** can be combined with tools such as rope or a climbing kit to scale the cliff, leading others down. (Moderate DC)
- **Arcana** can be used to understand the powerful phantasmal force spell at work, that their psyches stand to be torn apart if caution is thrown to the wind; that perhaps the best way to survive is to play along. (Moderate DC)
- **Investigation** can be used to shatter the illusion by harnessing the strength of the mind. (Hard DC)
- **Spells** that slow or affect flying, such as feather fall; or that would imbue creatures with courage, such as heroism can be used to conquer the illusion; both put the characters' psyches at rest, tricking their subconsciousness believing all will be well. (Automatic Success)

11. Balcony

The door to the bathroom bulges outward, and then explodes into splinters. A flood of filthy water crashes out, threatening to push the PCs away from the stairs.

- **Athletics** can be used to stand one's ground and resist the flood; other adventurers can brace themselves against the character or angle themselves so that he or she takes the brunt of the flood. (Moderate DC)
- **Nature** or **Survival** can be used to call on past experiences or knowledge of flash floods, allowing a character in that split second to take necessary precautions (hang on the other side of the balcony, leap for a nearby door, et cetera). Characters with the Outlander background have advantage on such a check. (Moderate DC)
- **Sleight of Hand** can be used to snatch at the balcony or the oil lamps mounted on the wall before being swept away. (Easy DC)

6. Upper Hall

The suits of armor have been animated by Death House but are not true suits of animated armor. For the purposes of potential combat, they have an AC of 12, 5 hit points each, immunity to poison and psychic damage, and -1 to Strength. Each suit can make a spear attack (+2 to hit, 1 piercing damage) against targets within 5 feet; these attacks might be made with advantage (and melee attacks made against with disadvantage) depending on if any attackers are below them on the staircase.

- **Athletics** can be used by a character wielding a shield or similar protection to charge the ranks, hoping to topple the statues. On a failure, they may be speared up to four times. (Moderate DC)
- **Acrobatics** can be used to leap to the other end of the spiraling staircase. (Moderate DC)
- **Blacksmith's tools** or **Investigation** can be used to ascertain the formation's weaknesses, for without men behind the armor, they have significantly less strength. Characters with the Soldier background have advantage on such a check. (Moderate DC)

4. Kitchen & Pantry

As a character makes their way in or out of the dumbwaiter, the oven spits a column of fire. Any characters in the room must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw to clamber into the dumbwaiter, working the rope-and-pulley before being scorched. On a failure, a creature takes 1d6 fire damage, but continues upward. The explosion shakes the entirety of the manor.

1B. Entrance Foyer

To their horror, the characters discover that the front doors are slowly becoming bricked up—and behind them, the doors to the Main Hall begin to swing shut. Characters can make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw to hurl themselves into the Main Hall before the doors swing shut. Otherwise, read the following:

The mahogany hall doors behind you slam shut with ominous thunder. You look about the room, desperate to escape—and when you look toward the exit, you see the bottom third of the front door has been replaced by brick. Defying all logic, the wood has melded into the

rows of moldy brick. You blink—and to your mounting horror, in that span of a second, more of the door has been converted. You keep your eyes wide open so as not cast away your chance at breaking down the door... That's when a fetid cloud of filth rolls in, stinging your eyes and drawing tears. The walls are brittle now, rotten. The wallpaper hangs in slivers, and from behind the plaster, a flood of rats bursts onto the floor, crawling across your feet and scratching at your flesh.

A PC that attempts a skill check in this room must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw, or the rats' stench causes them to falter, giving them disadvantage on their check.

- **Athletics** or combat **spells** can be used to break through the rotten, brittle walls (Easy DC); the bricked-up front door (Hard DC); or the stuck hallway doors. (Moderate DC)
- **Nature, Intimidation, or Animal Handling** can be used to keep the rats away. (Moderate DC)
- **Perception** or **Investigation** can allow a PC to see a weak point where the bricks have become weak and crumbling. (Moderate DC)

1A. Entrance Gate

This challenge takes place only if one or more of the PCs are still possessed by the spirits of Rose and Thorn. As the PCs approach the iron gate, the ghosts struggle with the PCs for control of their bodies, and beg and plead for the PCs to stay behind.

- **Athletics** can be used by an unpossessed character to force a possessed PC over the threshold. The possessed PC must succeed on a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw or take 1d4 psychic damage as the spirit is violently torn from their body. (Hard DC)
- **Persuasion** or **Intimidation** can be used to coax the spirits from their unwilling hosts. (Easy DC)
- **Arcana** or **Religion** may allow a character to draw on their reserves of magic or faith, respectively, forcefully dispelling the intrusive soul. (Moderate DC)

Aftermath of Escape

If any PCs were trapped inside Death House, Norganus, the Finger of Oblivion appears to them as if in a dream. The trapped PCs find themselves dragged through the front doors of Death House, their legs and ankles seized by shrieking spirits and hissing ghouls. Just before they cross the threshold, Norganus appears to them: a tall, dark shadow with indistinguishable features. In a soft, hissing voice, he asks them to take his hand - an inky black void dripping a foul, ichorous ooze from its fingertips. He mourns their wasted potential, and promises to free them from these "unquiet dead."

If the PCs take his hand and accept Norganus' dark gift, they awaken in the tall grass in front of the house. PCs that have been resurrected this way gain the Touched By the Mists Trait, which leaves them tainted by Norganus' evil touch.⁵³ Cats hiss and milk sours at their approach, and they detect as evil-aligned undead to divination magic. These traits remain until the character

⁵³ [Adventurer's League: Curse of Strahd Edition: March 4, 2016, to August 25, 2016](#)

receives a *remove curse* spell. Moreover, any such PCs marked by Norganus specifically gain one of the following Dark Gifts:

- The character's eyes melt away, leaving empty sockets. He or she has disadvantage on Charisma (Persuasion) checks, but gains blindsight out to a range of 60 feet. The character is blind beyond this distance.
- The character's skin is cold and clammy to the touch. The character gains resistance to cold damage and vulnerability to fire damage.
- At night, the character can spend 1 hit die to move through solid objects as though they were difficult terrain. A character who ends his or her turn inside an object takes 5 (1d10) force damage. The character counts as an undead creature for the purpose of spells and effects such as turn undead.

Regardless of the ultimate outcome of the ritual, Strahd is aware of the events beneath Death House, and may taunt the PCs for their decisions in the dungeon below.⁵⁴

If you choose to use the **Walter, the Flesh Mound** encounter discussed above, Death House will reset (and, if destroyed, reform) soon after the PCs leave it, once more awaiting new travellers that it can ensnare. The only way to remove its curse permanently is to remove Walter's body from the remnants of the Mound below, and to bury it at the threshold of the House outside.

? For Your Consideration - The Death of Death House

When all PCs have escaped the house, you may play out any, all, or none of the following scenes:

- Death House swallows itself up, vanishing into the ground below.
- The PCs notice a sign pointing in the wrong direction that reads: "Death House - Don't Talk to the Children!"
- The spirit of the nursemaid lifts a hand in thanks from atop the ruins of the accursed house.⁵⁵

54 ElvenTower, [Curse of Strahd intro – Running the Death House](#)

55 SlyFlourish, [Running Death House](#)

? For Your Consideration - Welcome to Barovia

When the PCs escape Death House, you may believe that a congratulations or welcome from Strahd is in order. Feel free to use one of the following scenes:

- A coffin is left on the road outside of Death House. When opened, the corpse inside matches one of the PCs. The PC then reveals themselves to be Strahd von Zarovich, or else vanishes into a cloud of bats or mist.
- Count Strahd von Zarovich verbally congratulates the party, either after emerging from his black carriage or from the roof of a nearby house.
- As the PCs leave Death House, they find a note of congratulations enchanted to provide a “slow clap” sound effect when opened, courtesy of Strahd.⁵⁶
- When the PCs escape Death House, they find a small wooden box at the entrance containing a number of healing potions equal to the number of surviving party members. The box also contains a message written by Strahd, reading: “Thank you for cleaning this vermin off of my domain. Your efforts are appreciated, even if for just one night. Please accept this small gift to help your recovery. Welcome to Barovia. -S”⁵⁷
- The party finds a small gift basket in the street outside of Death House. Inside is a note bearing the words “Welcome to Barovia,” signed with a cursive letter S; a bottle of Purple Dragon Crush; and a taunting letter bearing the words: “Deliver To: Master Ismark Kolyanovich.” It reads as follows:

Master Kolyanovich,

I regret your loss, I truly do. But surely now you must see the futility of your efforts. I offer you a simple trade:

Release Tatyana to me, and I will see that you are left in peace.

Your dread lord and master,
Strahd von Zarovich

Chapter 2: The Village of Barovia

The Raven on the Rooftop

When the PCs first arrive in Barovia, or exit Death House, if you kept it in Barovia, they encounter a raven with blue-tipped wings perched atop one of the houses flanking the street. This is Muriel, the wereraven, in animal form. She attempts to lead them to the Blood of the Vine tavern.⁵⁸

⁵⁶ Morallygreypirate, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 6/24](#)

⁵⁷

⁵⁸ Power Score, [Dungeons & Dragons - How to Run Curse of Strahd](#)

□ Getting to Know You - Muriel, the Wereraven

Muriel is perhaps the most active of the non-Martikov members of the Order of the Feather, and a frequent character in your campaign's story. Naturally shy, but curious, she maintains her raven form while monitoring the characters throughout Barovia, appearing from time to time and assisting them if she believes them to be good-aligned. In the original module, she appears as a guide to the characters in the swamps of Berez.

Muriel dyes the tips of her wings blue each month, a vain practice that Urwin has warned her could endanger her ability to remain undercover. While other wereravens have monitored adventuring parties in the past and grown cynical in the process, Muriel is a newly-accepted member of the Order of the Feather, and still believes that a group of heroes may one day arrive and overthrow Strahd von Zarovich.

While she does not reveal her true form unless strictly necessary, she does keep Urwin Martikov informed of the PCs' locations. She may occasionally contribute in combat using the Help action if she is nearby and believes the party to be in imminent danger, but only if the danger in question poses no great threat to her. If you choose, you may use her as a replacement for the ordinary wereraven outside of Old Bonegrinder, providing a call-back and a recurring character.

Angry Mobs of Barovia

The village of Barovia, as destitute as it is, is frequently a launching point for angry mobs driven toward Castle Ravenloft. 10 to 20 villagers come out of the woodwork once every year or so to "save Barovia," and are never heard from again. Upon reaching the castle proper, half of their numbers evaporate, with the rest swiftly dying or fleeing upon entry. They act together on initiative, and charge blindly ahead, a liability to themselves and others.⁵⁹

Consider using any of the following rumors to incite a mob while your PCs are within the village, approaching or within the castle, or on the road between the two:

- A vampire killed Mad Mary, but townsfolk overheard it gloating about her daughter, all snug in the castle. The townsfolk have realized that Mary wasn't crazy after all, and some brave "heroes" are ready to rescue her daughter or (more inevitably) die trying.
- The ghosts have been hinting all along! A random rabble-rouser believes that the ghostly procession is actually a subtle hint from the netherworld. The mob believes that any person who follows the ghosts' path and leaps from the tower alongside them will escape Barovia forever.
- Some villagers have gotten it in their heads that Ismark is dead and Irenea has been taken to the castle. They believe that an end to the burgomaster's line will mean the death of all Barovian "vassals," and are determined to rescue Irenea from the Devil's clutches.

Areas of the Village

E1. Bildrath's Mercantile

Due to the layout of the village, it is entirely possible for Bildrath and Parriwimple to be the first living Barovian NPCs that your PCs encounter. Remember that Bildrath has seen many adventurers come and go, and views your PCs as a simple cash injection from the world beyond the mists. While he does not mention this outright, it is clear from his demeanor that he does not expect the PCs to hold onto their purchases for long.

Parriwimple, meanwhile, adores meeting newcomers, and in fact holds adventurers second only to Uncle Bildrath in his heart. If given the opportunity, he will ask the PCs how many “big dummies” they’ve killed, and will remark on how “amazing” they must be to have come all of the way to Barovia. If directed by Bildrath to remove unruly customers from the shop, Parriwimple bears them no ill will, and attempts to grapple them with his +10 Athletics in order to physically remove them from the premises.

□ Plot Hook - Last Week's Meat

Bildrath Cantemir keeps his inventory stocked by recycling the items he sells to doomed adventurers. If the PCs complain about his prices, he asks the party to retrieve a large, leather-bound bundle that he believes to be downstream of the Ivlis River Bridge, south of the village. If the bundle is returned to him, undamaged and still tied in its original string, he offers the PCs a 20 gold discount on any one purchase.

This bundle contains four *explorer's packs*, unopened by the adventuring party that purchased them two months prior. Bildrath does not tell the PCs the history of their target, though he does inform the party that danger should be expected. The previous party, a group containing a low-level wizard, cleric, rogue, and fighter, perished soon after entry into Barovia, dying at the hands of a marauding tribe of scarecrows. The scarecrows were aggravated by the wizard's raven familiar, a Fey spirit that found refuge with the Order of the Raven.

The bundle is guarded by a mated pair of **ankhegs**, which have incorporated the bundle into their nest. This nest is marked by a number of tall mounds of soil adjacent to the riverbank. The ankhegs have burrowed underground, and attack any PCs that approach within 15 feet of their nest. The nest also contains a purse holding 3 gp, 6 sp, and 21 cp; as well as a rusted greatsword, a pair of rusted daggers, and a muddy wizard's spellbook. Most of the spellbook's pages have been rendered unreadable, but the spells *Find Familiar*, *Alarm*, and *Detect Magic* are still legible. Enough bones to comprise four adult humans can be found woven into the wood and clay of the nest.

E2. Blood of the Vine Tavern

? For Your Consideration - The Devil's Name

All native-born Barovians fear to utter the name of Strahd von Zarovich. They believe that merely speaking his name gives him power, and draws his attention upon one's self. This is a myth. However, it is a part of Barovian culture to refer to Strahd as "the Devil" (in Barovia and Vallaki), "the Beast" (in Krezk), and "the Count" (for those that serve him). The Vistani name him freely, calling him "Lord Strahd" or "Count Zarovich"; for this, Barovians fear - in some cases, quite accurately - that the Vistani serve him. After all, who else could speak the name of a devil with such impunity?

□ Strands of Fate - New PC Introductions

Should you need to replace any deceased characters after Death House, or if you have any new players joining your campaign, the Blood of the Vine tavern is a good place to encounter any new PCs. These PCs may have newly arrived in Barovia using any one of the module's adventure hooks, or they may be the survivors of a previous adventuring party, such as the party referenced in the **Last Week's Meat** plot hook in area E1.⁶⁰ They may also be natives of the village of Barovia, such as:

- the child of a Barovian hunter or trapper whose parent went missing in the woods
- a budding mage who seeks to gain the power to escape Barovia
- an acolyte of the local church who is seeking an end to Donavich's misery
- the elder sibling of a child sold to Morgantha for dream pastries, seeking revenge on the hag and the safety of their brother or sister
- Ireena or Ismark Kolyana (see **For Your Consideration** later in the chapter)

The Owners of the Tavern

Arik, the barkeep, is an excellent opportunity to introduce the Soulless to your PCs. Take care to emphasize the emotionless, robotic nature of his words and actions, as well as the drab nature of his clothes. Your players will be both uncomfortable and curious to know what, exactly, has robbed Arik of his spark of life. If a PC asks the colorful and animated Vistani owners what ails Arik, Mirabel informs them that "the poor man is addled like all Barovians," laughing jovially.⁶¹

? For Your Consideration - The Nature of the Soulless

The nature of the Soulless can provide a source of intrigue to your players as they explore the settlements and NPCs of Barovia. Residents of Barovia, Vallaki, and Krezk call them "mist-touched," believing their spirits to be choked by the dark fog that surrounds Barovia. Those Barovians with a more animated spirit name themselves "sun-touched," but mentioning either of these names around a Soulless is an incredibly rude taboo. Only Strahd, Madam Eva, the Abbot, the hags of Old Bonegrinder, Baba Lysaga, and a select few others know that the mist-touched lack a soul entirely.

Alenka, Mirabel, and Sorvia are the Vistani owners of the Blood of the Vine Tavern. As-written, they are ordinary Vistani who happen to own land in Barovia. You may also run them as *mortu*, or Vistani outcasts, as described below. If you do, change the source of Radu Radovich's connection to Strahd from Soriva to Arrigal, and apply the following points:

- These three women are no longer welcome at Vistani camps. As *mortu*, they have no friends or family among their own culture. They have been stripped of their Evil Eye, and lack the minor precognition common to other Vistani. The sisters are cruel and shallow individuals, and were exiled from their encampment as younger women. They mocked their people's beliefs in favor of the trappings of civilization, and were cast out as *mortu* for crimes against other Vistani.⁶²

60 /u/paintraina, [What I have learned from running Curse of Strahd twice - Barovia and the road to Vallaki edition](#)

61 /u/praetorrent, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Barovia Village](#)

62 [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: The Village of Barovia](#)

- As a Lawful individual with respect for the Vistani, Strahd refuses to associate with them, and so avoids using them as spies, instead using the soulless Arik as a focal point for his *Scrying* spell.

Should the PCs ask the Vistani about Ismark, the trio speak of him with disdain, calling him “Ismark the Lesser,” and placing him thoroughly in the shadow of his late father.⁶³ The Vistani, if asked, are happy to provide directions to Madam Eva - provided the PCs shake down the drunken Radu Radovich for the money he owes them, a sum total of 5gp.

63 Power Score, [Dungeons & Dragons - How to Run Curse of Strahd](#)

□ Getting to Know You - Radu Radovich

Radu Radovich is a member of Arrigal's camp, and a frequent visitor of the Blood of the Vine tavern. In the past, he fancied Elladore, a young woman living in the village. The relationship was little more than a passing fling, but the deeply possessive Radu was enraged and offended when Elladore's father, a soulless fletcher named Tural, discovered them and forbade Radu from darkening their doorstep. In his bitterness, a drunken Radu raved to Soriva, one of the three Vistani owners of the Blood of the Vine. Soriva, one of Strahd's Vistani spies, told Radu that Count Zarovich was known to reward his Vistani servants, and told him how to offer his services to Rahadin, the Master's right hand.

Currently, Radu is in Barovia on a mission from Arrigal. Commanded to search for the missing Arabelle, Radu is instead slacking and drinking, convinced that the girl is long since dead. He arrived yesterday morning, and has yet to pay his tab, aggravating the bar's three owners. If he overhears the PCs agree to escort Ireena to Vallaki, he shadows the party while they linger in Barovia, eager to earn Strahd's favor by providing information on their histories, personalities, names, or abilities.⁶⁴ Should Strahd become interested in the PCs, Radu follows them on the road, gathering more information to deliver to his master.

If the PCs shake him down for the money owed to Alenka, Mirabel, and Soriva, the drunken and cocky Radu obeys only if a character succeeds on a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidate) check. Otherwise, a DC 8 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check is sufficient to steal the purse from his belt. If attacked, Radu throws the 10 gold at the PCs and attempts to place the following Vistani's Curse upon them before fleeing: "If it be gold you prize, then let it dance from your fingers!" The PC that attacked him must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw; on a failure, that PC is cursed to have all gold coinage or items that they pick up vanish within thirty seconds. This includes any gold thrown by Radu.

Radu's purse contains 13 gp, 16 sp, and 28 cp. If the PCs offer to pay his debt, he thanks them, and offers to lead them to Madam Eva's tent at Tser Pool for a reading. Secretly, he seeks to gain more information about them to report to Strahd, and will attempt to eavesdrop on their Tarokka reading if possible.

Meeting Ismark, the Lesser

As a citizen of Barovia, Ismark has seen many adventurers come and go. Still, that does not reduce his desperate need to ensure Ireena's safety, nor does it reduce his faith in the potential goodness of each newcomer that arrives in his village. Not only has he heard that Vallaki is well-defended, but his father, Burgomaster Kolyan Indirovich, used to tell Ismark that the Burgomaster of Vallaki owed him a favor, a debt made in their youth. Between his father's death, and Strahd's second visitation, Ismark is ready to leap at the first party that may help him escort Ireena safely.

While socializing with the PCs, Ismark attempts to discover what they aim to achieve while in Barovia. When he describes Ireena's predicament, the PCs can clearly see the desperation on

⁶⁴ Power Score, [Dungeons & Dragons - How to Run Curse of Strahd](#)

his face. The other villagers are too smart or fearful to oppose the Devil's will, but Ismark sadly and bitterly admits his hope that outsiders might be easier to convince - or buy.⁶⁵ He offers fifty gold pieces and his own companionship as payment if they escort his sister to Vallaki. He also offers to call in his father's favor with the Baron in order to assist their efforts. He has little else to offer.

In order to emphasize the reveal when the PCs discover Izek's relationship with Ireena, remember that Ismark does not know that his sister is adopted, and believes her to be his trueborn sibling.⁶⁶

If asked about the Vistani, Ismark responds with quiet suspicion, noting that he has heard that some serve as spies to Strahd.

□ The Butterfly Effect - Ireena Alone

Should your PCs choose to disregard Ismark's request, or fail to encounter him at all, he and Ireena set off to bury their father two nights afterward. Ismark is fatally injured by wolves on the road to Vallaki, and Ireena buries him by the Barovian Gates near Castle Ravenloft. She later arrives at Vallaki, and soon finds lodging with the Baron. Izek's interest frightens her, however, and an attack by Strahd on the burgomaster's mansion soon drives Ireena out of Vallaki altogether. She makes her way to Krezk, seeking refuge at the Abbey. Disheartened by the Abbot's madness and bereft of companionship in the world, Ireena returns to Barovia and is spirited away by Strahd on the road. While waiting for her wedding ceremony soon after being turned into vampire spawn, Ireena is killed by Rudolph van Richten or Ezmerelda, which drives Strahd into a maddened rage. Ireena's killer is found and slain soon after, their tortured corpse displayed gruesomely before the castle drawbridge.

The Dream Pastry Patrons

As your party approaches or departs the Blood of the Vine Tavern, you may describe a trio of drunken locals staggering away from the door. One of them splits off toward a peddler's cart, complaining of an empty stomach.⁶⁷ If they are followed, the Dream Pastries special event is triggered.

E3. Mad Mary's Townhouse

The first floor of this old, dirty dwelling comprises a one-room divided living space. To the north lies a small kitchen, its countertops dirty and covered with dust. There is a broken glass on the floor and a rotted meal for two set on a table covered with a dirty blue tablecloth. Mary poured herself a glass of wine to steady her nerves after realizing Gertruda's disappearance, and dropped it on the floor in anguish. A small sitting area to the south contains a fireplace, two comfortable armchairs, and a dirty rug. Stairs lead up from here to the second floor.

The second floor corridor contains three wooden doors. One leads to a bathroom with an unemptied chamber pot and a bowl of dirty bathwater. Mary is sobbing in her own bedroom, which holds a writing desk and a bed. Gertruda's bedroom door is slightly ajar, and a tray

⁶⁵ [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: The Village of Barovia](#)

⁶⁶ ElvenTower, [Chapter 3 – Village of Barovia](#)

⁶⁷ /u/ReadingIs4Communists, [How do I introduce dream pastries without tipping off the players?](#)

holding a broken tea kettle and cup has shattered on the floor before it. Mary was bringing Gertruda tea when she found her daughter missing, and dropped it in her horror.

Gertruda's room holds a clumsily handwoven dress, a shelf holding fairytales and a hairbrush, a rug with a chewed-up bone, and an open window. Strahd stole Gertruda through the window one week ago.

□ Strands of Fate - Gertruda's Dog

When the party enters Gertruda's room, if they are accompanied by Lancelot, the dog from Death House, he jumps up onto the bed and curls up beside the pillow, whining. He was raised by Gertruda as a puppy, and fled through a hole in the walls after Gertruda's disappearance because Mary neglected to feed him. He eventually wandered into Death House when tempted by the scent of food. Mary recognizes him, but Lancelot keeps away from her, saddened by the scent of madness on her person.

E4. Burgomaster's Mansion

? For Your Consideration - Ireena and Ismark as Player Characters

There are multiple pros and cons to turning Ireena Kolyana into an ordinary PC. While her story and relationship with Strahd may ultimately remain the same, there are a number of things to consider when making such a decision:

Pros	Cons
• The DM does not have to provide both sides of a conversation between Ireena and an NPC. • The DM does not need to maintain Ireena's combat statistics. • Plot twists (e.g., Izek, Sergei, etc.) have a much larger impact.⁶⁸ • It is easier for a PC to mislead or direct the party than an NPC	• Ireena can play too specific a role to be left to the mercy of a player's understanding and whims.⁶⁹ • Strahd's obsession with Ireena can make her player uncomfortable.⁷⁰ • Ireena is notably vulnerable to kidnapping, corruption, or death.⁷¹

Ismark may also provide a suitable candidate for a Barovian PC. He is directly tied to the party's quest, and is honorable enough to fight alongside the party even once Ireena is dead or saved.⁷²

Meeting Ireena Kolyana

To conceal the marks of Strahd's teeth on her neck, Ireena wears a thick red scarf. It was knitted for her by her mother, Indira.

Ismark is an excellent chef, despite his meager larder, and Ireena is happy to answer any questions the PCs may have about Barovia. She is, however, eager for information about the PCs and the world outside of Barovia, and has a thirst for tales of heroism, adventure, and valor.

68 /u/paintraina, [What I have learned from running Curse of Strahd twice - Barovia and the road to Vallaki edition](#)

69 /u/AmorphousGamer, [Curse of Strahd: Ireena as a Player Character?](#)

70 /u/Gyromitre, [Curse of Strahd: Ireena as a Player Character?](#)

71 /u/DG86, [Curse of Strahd: Ireena as a Player Character?](#)

72 /u/DG86, [Curse of Strahd: Ireena as a Player Character?](#)

If you wish to reduce the number of NPCs your party is likely to travel with, Ismark gently turns down any offer to travel alongside the PCs to Vallaki. His new duties as Burgomaster limit him to the village of Barovia.

In order to assure Ireena's safety, Ismark tells her to stay at home while their father is buried. Ireena fights stubbornly to come, but to no avail. She's already getting the assurance that her father will rest peacefully, so staying safely behind the walls of their home for another day isn't too much to ask.⁷³

□ Strands of Fate - Purchased Dream Pastries

If Ireena or Ismark are offered a dream pastry, they politely decline. They are unaware of the pies' true ingredients, but have lost friends to their addictive properties. They see no harm in trying a single pastry, however.

□ Getting to Know You - Ireena Kolyana

There are several archetypes that you can employ when playing Ireena. Choose one of the following when planning her mechanical and character role in your party's story:

swordswoman, **novice**, or **noble**.

The **Swordswoman** is a skilled warrior. While less adept than Ismark with the blade, she is sharp-eyed and quick on her feet. She begins the campaign with the **Spy** statblock, and improves to the **Veteran** statblock with sufficient motivation. She is fearless in battle, and despises Strahd with a passion. She is fiery-tempered, stubborn, and impatient, but absolutely loyal to her friends and family.

In social situations, the **Swordswoman** is quick to be bored, and eager to act. She may insult the Baron inadvertently, or betray an ally's secrets by accident. She believes that Strahd can be overthrown with sufficient manpower and will, and dreams of helping Ismark restore the village of Barovia to its historical glory.

The **Novice** has been forced to toughen up by the everyday challenges that face a Barovian citizen. She begins the campaign with the **Scout** statblock, and may improve to the **Bandit Captain** statblock if given training and practice. She is stubborn, but wise for her age, and is adept with a **Healer's Kit** and **Herbalist's Kit**. She has a crude sense of humor, and is intensely curious about the world around her - sometimes to a fault.

In social situations, the **Novice** does her best to be helpful. She is proficient in Persuasion, as well as Nature, Religion, and History checks. She seeks shelter from Strahd's lusts, and believes that someone in Barovia must be able to provide her sanctuary from his creatures.

The **Noble** retains the **Noble** statblock as defined by the module. While passable with the sword, she has been trained by Ismark to use the Noble's **Parry** feature, and aims to keep herself alive until her brother or an ally can arrive at her side. She is occasionally frustrated by Ismark's safety measures, and views his worst defensive impulses as stifling. With sufficient training, practice, and motivation, she can increase her to-hit bonus from +3 to +4, and eventually gain a multiattack for her rapier.

The **Noble** possesses significant social skills. As the Burgomaster's only daughter, she gains the Position of Privilege feature from the Noble background. If she has built a relationship with any NPC that the PCs are attempting to deal with, her presence gives the PCs advantage on any social checks they may attempt in the course of the conversation. She has both proficiency and expertise on History and Religion checks to recall information, and has extensive knowledge of Barovia's geography, notable residents, and history.

Due to her education in politics, the **Noble** understands how to manipulate an ally, turn a political foe into a turncoat, and execute a political scandal. She enjoys embroidery as a hobby, and can gain the Healer feat given time, practice, and motivation. She has a stubborn streak, and can be a cunning cynic. She believes that Strahd cannot be killed, and intends to vanish into the streets of Barovia, keeping her head down until the vampire loses interest. She is unused to the rigors of life on the move, and her early travels with the PCs will leave her exhausted and sore. She will never complain, but may allow signs of her own fatigue to slip into view when with people she trusts.

No matter which archetype you choose, each of the **Swordswoman, Novice, and Noble** are kind, courageous, and quick to comfort children and those in need. Should Ireena realize she cannot keep up in a fight, she will work to help in other ways, such as gathering expended ammunition, learning first aid, searching bodies for useful things, and training her own physical and martial aptitude. She is terrified by Strahd, but is motivated by fear, rather than incapacitated by it. She has a sense of humor, and an affinity for bad puns and dark jokes.

Her natural hair color is a brownish-red auburn - identical to Tatyana's - which is uncommon enough in Barovia that she regularly dyes it black. If questioned, she claims that "red hair is unlucky," and cites tales of other red-haired maids (all other reincarnations of Tatyana) who died in gruesome ways in Barovian history. She must re-dye her hair on a regular basis, or it will wash out, letting her easily stand out in a crowd.

If informed of the true reason for Strahd's interest in her - namely, her status as Tatyana's reincarnation - Ireena recoils, at first denying the relation, and then becoming bitter if the evidence becomes incontrovertible. She may only come to accept her soul's history following an encounter with Sergei's spirit at the blessed pool in Krezk.

Romantically, Ireena is naturally drawn to strong warriors with a civilized streak. She can be moved to fall in love with Vasili von Holtz, Strahd's alter-ego. Strahd has issued a standing order to all creatures of Barovia to avoid harming Ireena at all costs, and she thus has a near-immunity to danger in most combat situations.⁷⁴

You may also choose to have Ireena played as a PC. For more information on that, see the infobox above.

Spending the Night

The Burgomaster's Mansion has a similar layout to the Baron's mansion in Vallaki, except for the attic, which has a ladder leading up to a trapdoor in the roof.

If the PCs arrive at the mansion exhausted from Death House, or toward the evening, Ismark offers them the opportunity to rest in the relative safety of his home. The PCs are offered beds in the mansion's equivalent of Vallaki's room N3F, the Servants' Quarters. If they sleep here, one of the PCs finds beneath their pillow a child's drawing depicting a bald-headed, scowling man, his left arm a twisted, demonic limb coated with jagged scales. Ireena unknowingly drew this picture of the "monster man" (Izek) as a child, but forgot it here years ago, and doesn't recall what drew her to make it.

74 /u/guildsbounty, [My Notes on running Ireena without making her a badass](#)

□ Strands of Fate - Madam Eva's Invitation

If the PCs spend the night in Barovia, each of them experiences an identical dream. In that dream, the PC finds themselves standing at the River Ivlis crossroads, where a raven beckons them toward Tser Pool. Their surroundings blur, delivering them to Tser Pool, where the PC finds the Vistani encampment empty. The dreamer is then psychically drawn to the interior of Madam Eva's tent, where the seer sits, her face and form concealed by a dark purple cloak. Eva draws a card from the Tarokka deck atop the table - the Mists card. She informs the PC that the distance between them renders her Sight blurred and obscured, and invites the PC to join her at Tser Pool to learn what the future holds. The dream's Madam Eva addresses each character by name, and each one recalls the experience vividly. When the party arrives at Tser Pool, Madam Eva does not acknowledge the dream, but does coyly suggest that she can see the strings of Fate that have born them to her door.

? For Your Consideration - The Siege of the Burgomaster's Manor

As-written, Strahd chooses to hold his siege of Ireena's home to provide her time to bury her father in the cemetery. However, if you would prefer to play up Strahd's antagonism before the burial, or else punish your PCs from spending time in Barovia after they have buried the burgomaster's body, you may run the following siege encounter, as Strahd's forces return in their efforts to open the mansion to Strahd's unholy clutches.

Warning: Do not run this encounter unless you plan to make Strahd an obvious villain from the get-go. Likely consequences of this encounter include:

- Your PCs will not trust Strahd or his servants at any point, including the promise of safe passage written into his dinner invitation
- Strahd's rationale for approaching the party with a cordial, if not friendly guise, is heavily damaged
- Your PCs will be confused or irritated if Strahd does not continue assaulting them with similar villainous attacks at a regular interval while in Barovia.

Keep in mind that the goal of this siege is to provide an opening for Strahd to meet and charm Ireena - not to kidnap her. Strahd's forces have the following goals:

- destroy the wood and nails that are boarding up the mansion's windows, doors, and walls
- seek out and destroy any traps or rooms that may provide Ireena haven from Strahd's next visitation
- incapacitate or remove any non-Ireena characters that may prevent Strahd from gaining access to the mansion

Depending on when the PCs arrive at the manor, if Ismark expects the oncoming siege, your players may have time to prepare for the night's attack. Allow them to set up traps, chokepoints, barricades, and other combat assets as they dig into the trenches. See the following table for some sample preparations your PCs might make from the resources Ismark has available:

Preparation	Effect	Time to Prepare (per person)
Barricade (Large)	Obstructs line of sight and movement; takes 2 rounds to destroy/remove	2 hours
Barricade (Small)	Provides three-quarters cover and difficult terrain	1 hour
Nail Trap	Creatures that cross must make DC 12 DEX save or take 1d4 piercing damage	30 minutes

	and half their speed	
Grease Trap	Creatures that cross must make DC 12 DEX save or fall prone	30 minutes
Tar Trap	Creatures that cross must make DC 12 STR save or become grappled	30 minutes

Strahd's forces arrive in waves, beginning at midnight.⁷⁵ See the following table for which creatures arrive and when:

Round	Creatures	Location	Goal
1	4 Wolves	Front Door (N3A)	Break down front door
2	4 Zombies	Kitchen Door (N3G)	Break down kitchen door
3	1 Ogre Zombie ⁷⁶	Front Door (N3A)	Break through 2nd-floor window (N3I) Break through front door
4	2 Swarms of Bats	2nd-Floor Window (N3I) [If Open]	Harass characters inside the mansion
5	1 Ogre Zombie	Outside-Facing Room Containing 1+ PCs	Tear down any structural walls that PCs are using for cover
6	2 Zombies	Chimney	Ascend to roof and gain access to mansion interior
7	2 Dire Wolves	Front Door (N3A) or Kitchen Door (N3G)	Injure and/or drag away any PCs within the mansion

At the back of the horde, a PC that passes a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check can see a large wolf with a pitch-black coat watching intently.⁷⁷

When the siege is defeated, Ismark offers the PCs all he has as a reward, and tells them that the Baron of Vallaki owes his father a debt. He can call on that debt - if only the party helps escort Ireena to Vallaki.

⁷⁵ /u/Stepchildofthesun, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Barovia Village](#)

⁷⁶ /u/TheGentlemanDM, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Barovia Village](#)

⁷⁷ /u/Stepchildofthesun, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Barovia Village](#)

□ Strands of Fate - Leaving Barovia Behind

If your PCs encountered and kept the dog Lancelot from Death House, Ismark is likely to note that the road is no place for a house-raised animal. He can offer to care for Lancelot while he stays to rule as Burgomaster of Barovia.

Mad Mary's Visit

If your PCs are too spooked or distracted to investigate Mad Mary's crying, Mary herself knocks at the mansion's front door soon after the party has met Ireena and gotten comfortable. Ismark asks the PCs to stay with Ireena upstairs while he answers the door; upon opening it, however, Mad Mary pushes her way into the house. The players can easily overhear Mary's frantic rambling as she begs Ismark to help her daughter.

If the PCs intervene, Mary latches onto the first PC to speak to her warmly. Despite Gertruda's age, Mary speaks of her like a girl of seven or eight years. Once the PCs have comforted and reassured Mary, Ismark walks her back to her home, leaving the party alone with Ireena. Ireena tells the party that Gertruda vanished from her home little more than a week ago, and is most likely dead.⁷⁸

E5. Church

The Vampire in the Cellar

If you would like to give your PCs the opportunity to learn more about the Mad Mage and his rebellion against Strahd, or if you would like to avoid the possibility of an encounter with a CR 5 vampire spawn, you can make Doru more sympathetic and less monstrous by playing up his desperation. Rather than attacking or hissing at the PCs, he shies away from them, and pleads for "just a little blood." If provided blood, he sates his thirst with a single **Bite** attack, which restores him to a more reasonable state of mind. You may also have Doru's thirst overtake his sanity, which leads him to attempt to drain his victim dry. In his starvation, Doru has been reduced to 40 hitpoints, and regenerates only 5 hitpoints at the start of each of his turns. If Doru escapes, he flees toward Castle Ravenloft.

If Doru is killed, Donavich becomes withdrawn and inconsolable. When the PCs leave the church, they can hear the church bell ring a single time. If the party returns to the church, they find that Donavich has hanged himself from the bell's rope.

The Burgomaster's Burial

As Donavich recites the final rites and prayers during the burgomaster's burial, a heavy fog rolls in. A PC with a passive perception of 13 or higher can see a figure standing behind the cemetery fence, his features shrouded in mist. He appears to be a tall man clad in black, and is bowing his head as if in prayer.⁷⁹

⁷⁸ [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: The Village of Barovia](#)

⁷⁹ [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: The Village of Barovia](#)

After the burgomaster's burial. Father Donavich suggests that Ireena be moved as far away from Castle Ravenloft as possible. He suggests the Church of Saint Andral in Vallaki and the Abbey of Saint Markovia in Krezk.

E6. Cemetery

You may choose to run the burgomaster's burial as a **diplomatic** or **combative** event.

In a **diplomatic** encounter, Rahadin arrives at the burial shortly before the burgomaster is interred. He extends his Master's greetings (though does not speak Strahd's name), and offers his own sympathies for Ireena and Ismark's loss. He then hand-delivers the following letter to a PC, Ismark, or Ireena before departing⁸⁰, allowing any characters within 10 feet to experience his Deathly Choir feature.

Dearest Ireena,

It is with the deepest grief that I learn of the death of your kind and noble Father; and, especially, that it is affecting your young heart beyond all sensation. In this sad world of ours, sorrow eventually comes to all; and, to the young, it comes with the bitterest agony, because it so often takes them unaware. Your elders, no doubt, have learned to ever expect it.

I am anxious to afford some alleviation of your present distress. Perfect relief is not possible, except with time. You surely realize now that you will never smile again, is not this so? And yet it is a mistake. You are sure to be happy again. To know this, which is certainly true, will make you some less miserable now. I have had experience enough to know what I say; and you need only believe it to feel your heart warm once again. The memory of your dear Father, instead of an agony, will yet be a sad sweet feeling in your heart, of a purer and holier sort than you have ever known before.

Please present my kind regards to your afflicted brother.

Your lord, master, and love,
Strahd von Zarovich

In a **combative** encounter, Strahd appears personally in an effort to seize Ireena for himself, or to test those PCs that seek to protect her. Shortly before dawn, fog falls over the graveyard, and an enormous swarm of bats bursts from the mists, filling the skies and obscuring the PCs' vision. Soon after, snarling **wolves** creep from the mist and attack the PCs. They may be accompanied or replaced by **zombies** that clamber from the graveyard around them.

As the battle commences, Strahd appears in the mist. He holds a hand out toward Ireena, attempts to **charm** her, commands her to approach. If successfully charmed, Ireena begins to

⁸⁰ /u/red_mosquito76, [Strahd Pays His Respects](#)

approach him, a mix of fear and yearning etched on her face. If none of the heroes try to stop her, Ismark will hold her back.

After a few rounds of fighting, the wolves back off. If a hero did particularly well in the combat, Strahd compliments them. He says to Ireena in a pained voice, "They can't keep us apart for long." Then he turns to mist and vanishes.⁸¹

Warning: Do not run this combative encounter unless you plan to make Strahd an obvious villain from the get-go. Likely consequences of this encounter include:

- Your PCs will not trust Strahd or his servants at any point, including the promise of safe passage written into his dinner invitation
- Strahd's rationale for approaching Ireena with a cordial, if not friendly guise, is heavily damaged
- Your PCs will be confused or irritated if Strahd does not continue assaulting Ireena with similar villainous attacks at a regular interval while in Barovia.

☐ Worth a Thousand Words

If you choose to run a combative encounter, you may find helpful this [map of the Barovian graveyard](#),⁸² or [this map of an autumn graveyard](#).⁸³

☐ Module Milestone - The Burgomaster's Burial

If the PCs successfully bury the Burgomaster, you may choose to reward them with a milestone.

Special Events

March of the Dead

☐ Strands of Fate - Ireena's Fascination

To drive the PCs toward this unique event, Ireena coyly advises the party to visit the graveyard toward midnight, noting only that something "interesting" happens.⁸⁴ She is fascinated by all adventurers that come to the valley, and is awed and intrigued by the many ethnicities, professions, and personalities represented in the ghostly march.

If Donavich is present during this event, he explains its source to the PCs, illustrating the Sisyphian task that has lured and destroyed so many adventurers within Barovia.

81 Power Score, [Dungeons & Dragons - How to Run Curse of Strahd](#)

82

83

84

? For Your Consideration - A Lonelier Barovia

If you wish to make your PCs feel more isolated, and remove the “casual” presence of adventurers within Barovia, you may remove the March of the Dead event entirely. Moreover, you may find the frequency of previous adventuring parties to be damaging to the verisimilitude and magnitude of your campaign. You may feel that a history of adventurer incursions can damage the Barovians’ rationale for xenophobia, and reduce the impact of Strahd’s interest in them as rare playthings. A more isolated Barovia is a potentially more horrific and alien Barovia, so consider before you begin this campaign how frequently adventurers have visited this setting in the past.

Dream Pastries

The Dream Pastries event is likely to occur at one of the following times:

1. upon first entering the village
2. while travelling from the tavern to the mansion
3. while escorting the coffin from the mansion to the church
4. while exploring the village
5. while departing the village

In case 1, 4, or 5, Morgantha does not go out of her way to draw the attention of the PCs. She goes about her business, cautiously ensuring that no one is following her, and slips suspiciously away into an alleyway if approached.⁸⁵ In case 2 or 3, she accosts the party and attempts to sell them one or more dream pastries.

If you choose to use case 1, your PCs are almost certain to take interest in her as the first living person they have met in Barovia. Your PCs are likely to ignore Morgantha in case 5, and may take an interest in her in case 4.

If engaged in conversation, Morgantha presents herself as a defenseless and grandmotherly peddler who only wishes to sell delicious pies and bring cheer and warmth to a village bereft of either. If asked for her name, Morgantha replies honestly, but calls it “too formal” and asks the PCs to call her “Granny” instead.⁸⁶

If a PC uses Divine Sense or a similar ability to sense her Fiendish nature, Morgantha notices the PC’s discomfort and asks for its cause. If prodded, she spins a tragic tale of a nasty encounter with a witch that left a dark stain on her mother’s side of the family. If asked about the contents of the pies, Morgantha describes a recipe that includes maple syrup, toasted pecans, grandmotherly love, and “a bit of protein.” If asked about the protein, she avoids the topic, and instead discusses the many kinds of meat used in Barovian cooking.⁸⁷ She provides the party with a single pie to share as a free sample for “new customers and tired travelers.”

85

86

87

When Morgantha describes the dream pies, she informs the characters that the pastries are infused with a piece of magic taught to her mother before she was killed by the witch. The pies bring the eaters only the sweetest dreams, she tells the PCs, which are poorly lacking in dreary Barovia.

If challenged about a child she has taken, she tells the PCs that she is the matron of a local orphanage, and makes it clear that she believes the child's parents to be unfit to care for their progeny. If the child is returned to its parents, both adults are visibly drugged by the pastries they've consumed.⁸⁸ You may wish to avoid the child-collecting portion of this encounter entirely if you wish to build to a later betrayal of your players' trust in Morgantha and her pastries. Unless you wish to encourage your players to view Morgantha unfavorably from the start, it is recommended that you avoid sharing her official illustration from the *Curse of Strahd* book.

! Expanded Event - Dream Pastry High

The players who indulge in the pie are delighted by the taste. It's quite flavorful, which is unexpected for food from this dreary world. When they sleep that night, they have bright, beautiful dreams full of color. In the dreamworld, they feel hopelessly safe and loved, and cannot be woken until sunrise. In the morning, they awake feeling empty, hollow, and desperate to return.⁸⁹

More Barovian Encounters

The Dead Pet

If your party contains a wizard, cleric, or paladin, a child with a dead pet runs up to them. Unlike many other Barovians, this child has a soul, and is dressed in bright red clothes. They ask this PC to heal their pet, believing them to only be sleeping.

Barovian Addicts

Two men are fighting in the street over a small paper bag. The bag contains a pair of dream pastries that one of them, Braden, just purchased from Morgantha that morning. The other man, Javaris, is going through a horrific withdrawal from a lack of the pastries, and will kill Braden if it means getting his hands on another fix. Both men are heavily addicted to the pastries, and will only relent if forcibly separated.⁹⁰

Chapter 3: Tser Pool Encampment

□ Strands of Fate - The Railroad to Tser Pool

The Tarokka Reading is one of the most important components of the Curse of Strahd module. It drives the plot forward, invests the PCs in the lore and land of Barovia, and forms the backbone of a natural narrative between Strahd and the adventurers. It is critically important that your PCs are incentivized to receive a reading from Madam Eva soon after departing Barovia.

You can do so in one of the following ways:

- Ismark or Ireena hint that Madam Eva is a skilled diviner, and suggest stopping by her camp to receive insight into their future, or advice on how the PCs may depart Barovia.⁹¹
- Madam Eva appears to the PCs in dreams, either before or during the campaign, and invites them to learn their fates face-to-face by Tser Pool, “where the mists do not cloud the Inner Eye.”
- One or more of the Vistani sisters at the Blood of the Vine tavern advise the PCs to visit Madam Eva to learn their fate in Barovia.
- The Vistani caravan in the *Mysterious Visitors* adventure hook guide the PCs directly to the encampment. *Warning: This will likely cause your PCs to skip over the Ismark & Ireena plotline, unless Madam Eva advises them to return to Barovia following their reading.*
- As dusk begins to fall over the Svalich Road,⁹² Ismark suggests making camp at Tser Pool, where he knows an encampment of Vistani keeps wild beasts at bay.⁹³

Arrival at the Encampment

The Sound of Music - Vistani Camps

Feel free to use any, all, or none of the following tracks when your PCs are within or nearby a Vistani encampment:

- [Vistani Camps](#)

When the PCs approach the Vistani encampment, those with high passive perception can hear happy, festive music echoing from the trees toward Tser Pool.⁹⁴

91 /u/paintraina, [What I have learned from running Curse of Strahd twice - Barovia and the road to Vallaki edition](#)

92 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarokka Reading](#)

93 /u/cudder23, [DM question: Railroaded to Madame Eva?](#)

94 /u/cudder23, [DM question: Railroaded to Madame Eva?](#)

As soon as a Vistana catches sight of the approaching PCs, they call out to the party as though greeting a host of long-lost friends. The PCs are ushered into the camp and seated by the campfire where the Vistani provide them food and wine. The PCs find themselves thrust into a world of color, music, and laughter far removed from the bleakness and darkness of Barovia and Death House, respectively.

Two Vistani serve as the PCs' "handlers" while the party is at Tser Pool. The first is Arahja, a larger-than-life boisterous man whose laughter booms across the clearing. The second, Rina, is a quiet woman who speaks little; what she does say, however, is either profound or full of mischief. While other Vistani may greet and interrogate the PCs, Arahja and Rina will ask most of the questions, and provide most of the exposition.

The Vistani may ask the PCs any of the following questions:

- Where are you coming from?
- From where do you hail?
- Where are you headed?

The Vistani are happy to speak of their arrangement with Strahd. They have no opinion of Strahd's dominion over Barovia, and tend to keep out of his way. They do not warn the PCs about Old Bonegrinder, and if asked, refer to it as "the windmill-upon-the-hill."

At some point, Arahja should make a passive joke about the PCs' entrapment in Barovia. "Look at this one, Rina!" Arahja might say. "His skin is so tan! Almost like Vistani, himself, eh?"

Rina might reply: "Yes; show it off while you can, *giorgio*. The coming years without sunlight are sure to steal it from you."

If asked, the Vistani somberly inform the PCs that no one leaves Barovia, and welcome them to their new home. The Vistani don't know how one might pass through the mists, but invite the PCs to ask Madam Eva for insight.⁹⁵

Vistani of the Encampment

The Vistani are a joyful, cheerful people. They enjoy mischief, but honor hospitality above all else.

Their culture is bound up in an oral tradition - to a Vistani, a story is inseparable from the person who tells it. Because of this, Vistani culture is an ageless one; there is no separation between a youthful storyteller and a centuries-old story. Conversely, the stories of the present meld with the legends of the past in Vistani society. The Vistani at Tser Pool have seen dozens if not hundreds of adventurers find their deaths in Barovia, and expect the same to occur to the PCs. They are not, however, a morbid bunch (though dark humor is not uncommon), and are eager to add the tales of the PCs' past and future adventures to their oral mythologies.

⁹⁵ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

The Vistani that tells the tale of the Wizard's Rebellion does so with an edge of mirth mixed with a tone of genuine awe. The PCs may find themselves unnerved by the fact that the Vistani view them not as heroes, but as doomed gladiators whose stories will spin the tales of a thousand entertainments.

Three families dominate the Tser Pool Encampment: the Funars; the Vasilles; and the Ig'ars.

1. The Funars

The Funars dwell in a large wagon painted in stripes of dark pink and bright yellow.⁹⁶

The mother, Bela, is 26 years old. She is fat and loves jewelry, specializing in trading rare and exotic adornments at markets beyond Barovia. She married her husband, Lee, at age 16, and still adores him. They quickly - some say too quickly - had a baby, who they named Tara.

Lee is a 28 year old man. He is very skinny, hates exercise, and finds wine disgusting. He is very kind, and adores his children. Other Vistani secretly refer to him and his wife as "the Prats," but neither Lee nor Bela knows this.

Tara is a 10 year old girl. She doesn't show much interest in her mother's jewelry-making, and instead enjoys playing the flute. She is quite good for her age, and often warms up crowds with her music. Her brother, Baby Karol, is a 6-month-old boy who constantly drools.

2. The Vasilles

The Vasiles live in a bright orange wagon with blue doors and shutters.⁹⁷

Grigori Vasilie is a 40-year-old strapping man with a plethora of tattoos. He has had many relationships, but has never been married. Some say that no woman's cooking has ever lived up to his mother's, but in truth, he fears commitment, and so continues to live with his mother and brother. He and his brother are excellent actors, with Grigori often playing the villain.

Stefan is Grigori's 35-year-old younger brother. His first lover cheated on him, and he never quite got over it. He loves apples, and can often be found munching on one as a snack. He serves Strahd as a spy. As a younger man, he was cast in plays as the handsome prince, but has grown too old to serve in that role.

Ursula is the 60-year-old mother of Grigori and Stefan. Her husband, Varus, died many years ago, but she was secretly glad because he became cruel in his later years. She doesn't mind her boys living with her because otherwise she would be lonely, but she does wish that they would grow up a bit. She enjoys reading romantic tales, but finds them difficult to come by.

3. The Ig'ars

⁹⁶ /u/Blasted_Skies, [Random Vistanis](#)

⁹⁷ /u/Blasted_Skies, [Random Vistanis](#)

The wagon of the Ig'ars is painted with children's drawings.⁹⁸

Eliza Ig'ar is a 40-year-old woman with dark hair and green eyes. She feels uncomfortable without her “face” of makeup, and spends at least an hour preparing it each morning. She loves children, and especially enjoys bossing them around. She is a renowned storyteller at the encampment, and is the Vistana that tells the story of the Mage’s Rebellion around the campfire.

□ Plot Hook - Picking Up a Present

As the party is preparing for bed, Eliza approaches one of the PCs. She carries a large magpie on her shoulder, and a bright red sash. She greets the PCs warmly, and notes that few non-Vistani outsiders come to Barovia - after all, only one group has ventured into Barovia since the Mage. She asks the PCs whether they are powerful mages come to tear down the stones of Ravenloft, like the last notable visitor.

Eliza does not suspect Ireena's true identity, but is a spy for Strahd. She seeks to uncover the nature of the PCs' abilities and backgrounds, and intends to report their goals and current destination. To conceal this, however, she uses a cover story: Eliza's niece's nameday is approaching, and she is unable to purchase the girl's gift herself, both due to her own familial commitments and the ban of Vistani from Vallaki. She asks the PCs if they are heading toward Vallaki, and offers a payment of 25 gold pieces if they purchase a toy for the girl - Arabelle - from Blinsky's Toys in Vallaki and deliver it to Luvash in the Vistani encampment outside town. She offers a brief note addressed to Luvash as a token to gain entry into the camp.

After speaking with the PCs, Eliza retires to her wagon. Her magpie, an intelligent, but cruel bird named Gurgeh, whose name means "Darkwing," is sent off into the night soon after midnight, a message tied to its leg addressed to Rahadin. That message contains all of the knowledge she has gained regarding the PCs' capabilities, backstories, intentions, and destinations. This message may serve to set up a Strahd-directed encounter on the road to Vallaki (e.g., a meeting with Vasili von Holtz).

A DC14 Wisdom (Insight) check can reveal that Eliza is not being completely forthright with the PCs. The “Arabelle’s nameday” trick is one that she has practiced with Luvash and Arrigal several times; most times, the Vistani brothers are able to steal away the 25 gold pieces from Blinsky’s shop and eventually return them to her. However, both brothers play along with the charade while with the PCs, and Blinsky is happily ignorant of his role in the ruse. If challenged by the PCs, Eliza “reveals” that she is estranged from her brother, and has been barred from visiting Arabelle in person, which is why she requires adventurers to do it for her. She refuses to divulge any more information on their “argument.”

Iosif, Eliza’s husband, is a 43-year-old man with golden hair. He plays the lute and usually plays the trickster in plays. He also loves children and loves taking them on adventures.

Sofya is 15-year-old sullen teen girl with golden hair and green eyes. She spends most of her time in the family’s wagon, writing poetry. She dreams of becoming a published poet. Despite

repeated requests to attempt “spoken word poetry” at shows, her parents have thus far refused each time. She is considering spying for Strahd, and views him as a grand romantic.

Nicu is a 13-year-old boy with dark hair. He follows his father everywhere and is currently learning the lute from him. He dreams to one day play the part of the trickster like his father.

Simione is an 8-year-old boy with red hair. He loves dancing and will rush out of the family’s wagon no matter the hour if he hears people playing music outside.

Lil' Rosie is a 5-year-old girl. She is always excited and adores listening to Sofya’s poetry. Eliza and Iosif have a hard time getting her to sit still to learn her letters and numbers.

Madam Eva’s Tent

The Sound of Music - Madam Eva’s Tent

Feel free to use any, all, or none of the following tracks when your PCs are within Madam Eva’s tent:

- [Madam Eva’s Tent](#)

When the PCs approach Madam Eva's tent, she calls for them to enter before they even announce themselves. She addresses each of the PCs by name without needing an introduction, and uses their full birth name instead of nicknames.

When the party has been ushered inside and is sitting around her table, she proclaims, "It took you all long enough! I have been expecting you. Are you ready to learn your fate?"

If the PCs ask how she knows them, Madam Eva tells them that her cards grant her sight into the Threads of Fate that bind all things. Her Inner Eye, she tells them, told her that champions were coming to the land and that she would guide them on their path.

After the Tarokka reading, Madam Eva shoos the party from her tent and tells them to go and have fun. The night proceeds festively, with more wine and laughter. The Vistani happily provide their guests with some bedrolls and a spare tent.

The Tarokka Reading

To combat memory issues and solidify the story’s narrative arc, you may want to allow the players to keep their cards after they have drawn them. You may also choose to provide the players with written notes containing the exact wording for each one of Madam Eva’s predictions.

It is recommended whether you stack the deck or not that you practice the Tarokka reading in order to hone your acting, sleight-of-hand, and reading of the results. You may also choose to

prepare additional reactions for Madam Eva depending on the cards drawn. A nearby treasure may be accompanied by an encouraging hint; a distance, challenging treasure may be paired with a despondent sigh and a suggestion to pursue it last. You may also choose to add additional information that strongly hints to the location of more ambiguous hiding places. For example, a treasure hidden in Sergei's crypt may be paired with a warning that it rests beneath "the Devil's tower itself.

Feel free to use additional props, such as dimmed lights, a crystal ball, or a black velvet cloth. To heighten apprehension, Madam Eva waits for absolute silence before revealing each card. Above all else, your goal is to make this Tarokka reading feel special, atmospheric, and memorable.

Chapter 4: Old Bonegrinder

Old Bonegrinder is perhaps the grimmest section of the *Curse of Strahd* setting. Delving into the darkest aspects of Brothers Grimm-style horror, it deals with human trafficking, child abuse and murder, and drug addiction. Before you begin your campaign, it is highly advised that you confirm that all players are comfortable with the darker topics that Old Bonegrinder and similar areas of Barovia are likely to touch upon.⁹⁹

Worth a Thousand Words - Old Bonegrinder's Exterior

You can use either one of [these two](#) pictures when describing or presenting Old Bonegrinder's appearance to your players.

The Sound of Music - Old Bonegrinder Ambience

This [ambient sound board](#) may help you set the scene when your PCs enter Old Bonegrinder's structure.

Morgantha's Coven

The most important thing to remember about Morgantha and her daughters, Bella and Offalia, is that they are saleswomen first, corrupters second, and monsters last.¹⁰⁰ If presented incorrectly, this encounter can easily lead to an unfair TPK for a low-levelled party. The purpose of this area is not to present an immediate combat scenario. Instead, your goal should be to either:

- 1) present a sympathetic group of NPCs whose ethically questionable sales practices lead to the discovery of great evil later on
- 2) shock your players with a thinly-concealed monstrous den whose inhabitants intimidate or weakly imprison the PCs, setting up a long-term enemy that can be conquered later

⁹⁹ ElvenTower, [Chapter 6 – Old Bonegrinder](#)

¹⁰⁰ /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Old Bonegrinder](#)

- 3) create an opportunity for your PCs to give into the corruption of Barovia, either by incriminating themselves through association or inaction, or by cutting dark deals with the coven

The first priority of the hags is self-preservation. If attacked outside of the coven, Morgantha or her daughters will beg the aggressors to stop, claiming to be innocent bakers who wish only to feed the people of Barovia and care for its children, while portraying their attackers as unruly, rude, and violent barbarians.¹⁰¹ The hags portray themselves as weak, and only use magic if absolutely necessary.

If pleading does not seem sufficient to stop their attackers, the hags offer knowledge in exchange for their life. As in the village of Barovia, the hags can offer the following information:

- Strahd has mastery over the land and the weather, and his spies include the Vistani
- Strahd has undead enemies in Barovia - the fallen knights of the Order and the Silver Dragon. The revenants can be found in a ruined mansion west of Vallaki.
- Strahd's most carefully guarded secret is a temple of forbidden lore hidden in the mountains. The temple can be reached by following the long and winding Tsolenka Pass.

The hags can also provide basic information and insight regarding the Tarokka readings given by Madam Eva. However, they pass on the content of these readings to Strahd shortly afterward.

If no amount of pleading or negotiation is sufficient to deter their attackers, the hags vanish into the Ethereal Plane. If the PCs are still present at the windmill shortly afterwards - for example, if they busy themselves with the task of freeing the children upstairs - the hags are waiting downstairs for the PCs when they return, alongside the third member of their coven.

Once the hags have assembled their coven, Morgantha has one of three goals:

- 1) turn the PCs over to Strahd, if she knows that he has an interest in them
- 2) cripple the PCs by striking a deal that forces them to sacrifice some part of their power or moral character
- 3) force or convince the PCs to act in a way that draws them down a path of fear or corruption¹⁰²

As per their entry in the *Monster Manual*, night hags find the souls of evildoers to be the greatest delicacy. Morgantha knows that strangers in Strahd's domain are prime targets for temptation and corruption. She may promise an ambitious young wizard power, obtained by sacrificing one of the children upstairs. She may even promise to set both children free - if only the paladin leaves his squire behind.

¹⁰¹ /u/Hoaxness, [How I Managed: Old Bonegrinder](#)

¹⁰² /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Old Bonegrinder](#)

□ Know the Monsters - Morgantha & Her Coven

An encounter with Morgantha and her daughters will come to blows only if the coven feels genuinely offended or threatened by the PCs - and even then, only if all members of the coven are present. In combat, the hags' primary aims are to (1) incapacitate; (2) intimidate; and (3) cripple their enemies, in that order.

If only one or two hostile PCs are present, or if the hags believe the PCs to be low-levelled, the coven will use *Polymorph* to turn one of the PCs into a toad (L4; Wisdom DC 15) as an intimidation tactic. If that fails, they will attempt to target that PC with *Eyebite's* unconscious condition (L6; Wisdom DC 15). The goal: to render that PC harmless, and to toss them into a cage with a cackle.

Whenever possible, the hags will cast *Bestow Curse* using a level 5 spell slot, and *Hold Person* using a level 4 spell slot. If facing a magic user, all three will attempt to preserve their level-3 spell slots to cast *Counterspell* when necessary. See the table below for a list of all spells that the hags will use in combat. Bolded spells are preferred at that spell slot; italicized spells are cast at a higher spell slot than their own.

Make sure to remember that the hags share their coven spell slots. If Morgantha casts *Counterspell* at 3rd-level, Bella and Offalia only have two 3rd-level spell slots remaining.

Level	Slots	Spells
1st Level	4	Identify; Ray of Sickness
2nd Level	3	Hold Person ; Locate Object
3rd Level	3	Bestow Curse; Counterspell ; Lightning Bolt
4th Level	3	Phantasmal Killer; Polymorph ; <i>Hold Person</i>
5th Level	2	<i>Lightning Bolt</i> ; Bestow Curse ; Contact Other Plane; Scrying
6th Level	1	Eyebite

When facing a larger group of enemies, two hags will open with *Bestow Curse* at 5th-level, if feasible, to curse one PC's Wisdom score. The third will follow up with an *Eyebite* attack at 6th-level, aiming to infect the most threatening PC with the Sickened condition. They will then use *Polymorph* together at 4th-level, attempting to turn all hostile PCs into toads. If that fails, two Hags will cast *Hold Person* at 2nd-level, while the third casts *Ray of Sickness* at 1st-level or uses her action to Change Shape, dealing critical-hit claw attacks on paralyzed PCs. A 3rd-level *Lightning Bolt* is a panic button - if a dying hag sees an opportunity to kill multiple PCs at once with it, she'll cast it from pure spite.

Once the hags begin to run low on resources, they turn to their innate spellcasting abilities. Two hags will focus-fire a PC with their at-will *Magic Missile*, after which the third will cast one

of her two daily *Sleep* spells in an effort to render that PC unconscious.

If any hag dips below 30 HP, she uses her action to slip into the Ethereal Plane. Note that this doesn't break the coven - due to the Material and Ethereal Planes' proximity, ethereal hags still count as present for the purposes of maintaining the coven. If two hags go below 30 HP, any member of the coven dies, or the coven runs out of spell slots and daily innate spells, however, the remaining members use their action to flee into the Ethereal Plane.

The PCs can learn more about the hags in Vallaki. Rictavio, Ezmerelda, Urwin Martikov, or a book in Baron Vallakovich's library (DC 15 Investigation check) can give the party information on the history and interests of night hags (should the coven reveal their true forms, or hint at their true nature); their damage resistances; their haunting ability; and the heartstone and soul bag.¹⁰³

An Intelligence (Arcana) check can allow any PC to attempt to recall information about night hags. This information is gained at the following DCs:

DC 15: Night hags are demonic creatures of nightmares. Like other hags, they can form covens with exactly two other hags, which vastly increases their power.

DC 20: Night hags thrive on corruption and fear. They are tempters and dealmakers, and consume the souls of evildoers for pleasure and nourishment. Their skin is hardened against elemental forces, and they fear no mortal metal save silver. So long as the members of a hag coven remain nearby to one another, their arcane power is greatly increased.

DC 25: A night hag is said to have passage through the Ethereal Plane, slipping away into the realm of spirits to better haunt her prey. It is said that the touch of a night hag from the Border Ethereal can torment her victim with terrible nightmares and exhaustion. Night hags are fond of devouring children, and must do so to produce their foul offspring.

DC 30: A night hag keeps two artifacts that are precious to her. One is a heartstone - a lustrous black gem allows a night hag to become ethereal while it is in her possession. The touch of a heartstone also cures any disease. The second is a soul bag. When an evil humanoid dies as a result of a night hag's haunting, the hag catches the soul in a black sack made of stitched flesh. A soul bag can hold only one evil soul at a time, and only the night hag who crafted the bag can catch a soul with it.

The PCs can also learn more about the hags in Vallaki. Rudolph van Richten knows all the information in the above table, while Ezmerelda knows all of the information up to DC 25. A book in Baron Vallakovich's library (**Intelligence (Investigation)** DC 15) can be found that contains all information up to DC 20 of the table, while Urwin Martikov knows the information at DC 15.

A Hag's Bargain

If the PCs come to the hags seeking information, or otherwise seek a deal to free children or themselves from imprisonment, the hags are happy to offer it - at a price. The hags are dealmakers, and they are happy to trade away things of value at an accompanying price. A hag does not volunteer the description or mechanical impact of a deal - only its name.¹⁰⁴ See the table below for some example deals that the hags might offer.

Deal	Value	Description
Your Final Breath	Medium	A PC that accepts this deal dies after two failed death saving throws, rather than three.
Your Victories	High	A PC that accepts this deal can no longer make the final blow on a weakened enemy; even if their attack hits, the enemy is able to miraculously avoid taking any damage.
Your Luck	Medium	Three times per day, the DM can impose disadvantage on a roll made by a PC that accepts this deal.
Your Memory	Low	A PC that accepts this deal has disadvantage on any History, Arcana, Religion, or Nature checks made to recall information.
Your Body	Low	A PC that accepts this deal must provide the hags with a vial of blood or a lock of hair.
Your Courage	Low	A PC that accepts this deal gains disadvantage on saving throws against any fear-related effects.
Your Hope	Medium	A PC that accepts this deal gains the flaw: " <i>The world is a dark, terrible place, and no man's fight can ever push back the darkness.</i> "
Your Swiftess	High	A PC that accepts this deal gains disadvantage on initiative rolls.
Your Voice	High	A PC that accepts this deal becomes mute and cannot cast spells that require verbal components.
Your Tongue	Medium	A PC that accepts this deal gains disadvantage on all social Charisma-based checks.

Your Breath	High	A PC that accepts this deal heals only half hitpoints from hit dice and magical healing, and regains only one-fourth of their total hit dice upon completing a long rest.
Your Heart	Low	A PC that accepts this deal gains the flaw: “ <i>The suffering of others does little to stir me.</i> ”

The hags store their gains from these deals in small glass vials stored near the childrens’ cage on the third floor. Any ephemeral profits (e.g., “Luck”) are stored as brightly colored essences that slosh, bubble, and swirl within the glass like liquid or gas. If one of those vials are shattered, the essence within escapes back to its owner, and the deal is broken.

Ownership of the Mill

If the PCs find the deed to the windmill in Death House, they may infer that they are now the owners of the property.¹⁰⁵ However, if confronted with the deed, the hags are able to provide paperwork sealed and signed by Strahd that legitimizes their business practices and the storage of Barovian children for use thereof.¹⁰⁶

Dream Pastries

To create their magical power, dream pastries must be baked from the flesh of children with souls. When the hags first bring a child to the windmill, they prick the child’s finger with a needle. If the child howls in pain, the hags take this as evidence that the child has a soul, and harvest their victim to cook the pastry filling. If the child suffers the pain silently, the hags view the child as soulless, and use their bones to grind the pastry flour.¹⁰⁷

When a PC eats their first dream pastry, they feel a bit drowsy and pleasant. When they next take a long rest, that PC has wonderful, happy, vivid dreams. Any PC sleeping under the influence of a dream pastry sleeps a full eight hours and cannot be woken. When the PC awakes the next morning, they feel hollow and somewhat depressed.¹⁰⁸

Each day a PC awakes after sleeping under the influence of a dream pastry, they must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or consume an additional pastry. If the PC fails this saving throw and has no dream pastries easily accessible, they feel a strong craving for more and have disadvantage on all skill checks until they consume another pastry. An addicted PC that is unable to consume dream pastries has terrible nightmares when they attempt to sleep, and cannot gain the benefits of a long rest.

The DC of this Constitution saving throw increases by 2 for each additional day that the PC consumes at least one dream pastry, up to a maximum DC of 26. The DC also decreases by 2

¹⁰⁵ ElvenTower, [Chapter 6 – Old Bonegrinder](#)

¹⁰⁶ /u/cheatisnotdead, [What I have learned from running Curse of Strahd twice - Barovia and the road to Vallaki edition](#)

¹⁰⁷ Ultanya, [Curse of Strahd: Old Bone Grinder](#)

¹⁰⁸ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing out Curse of Strahd: The Mechanics of Dream Pastries](#)

for each day that the PC goes without consuming any dream pastries, down to a minimum of 4. The only exception is the day after the PC consumes their first dream pastry; at noon, the PC may roll an additional DC 4 Constitution saving throw. On any day, if the PC succeeds when the DC for the saving throw is 4, the PC is no longer addicted to dream pastries.

The first day an addicted PC fails to consume a dream pastry, they gain disadvantage on all saving throws. On the second day, the PC gains disadvantage on all skill checks and saving throws. On the third day and beyond, the PC has disadvantage on all skill checks, saving throws, and attack rolls until they consume a pastry or are no longer addicted.

If a PC goes seven consecutive in-game days without eating dream pastries, they are no longer addicted. This happens regardless of their save DC and immediately alleviates any and all disadvantages they might have gained as a result of their addiction. Should a former addict ever eat a Dream Pastry again, their starting Constitution saving throw DC will be 15 instead of 10.

Approaching the Windmill

As the PCs approach the windmill, they notice an abundance of rodents, snakes, and spiders in the grass nearby. Characters that stray into the tall grass are attacked by a poisonous snake or swarm of spiders the following turn. Beasts with an intelligence of 2 or lower are aggressive, due to their proximity to the corrupted Fane marked nearby.

At the intersection where the windmill's path meets the road, the PCs can find a small twig figurine discarded upon the ground. It was left here by Offalia, who enjoys crafting them and has a small collection in the attic.¹⁰⁹

A soft, curling stream of smoke from a crooked pipe chimney gives the windmill a homely, comfortable appearance. The smoke comes from the oven on the first floor.

☐ Worth a Thousand Words - Windmill Exterior & Battlemap

Should a fight break out on or outside the first floor of the windmill, consider using [this map](#)¹¹⁰ to depict the location.

Areas of the Windmill

When the PCs arrive at Old Bonegrinder, Morgantha is away, returning from a successful business venture in Vallaki. Bella instead greets the PCs at the door cheerfully inviting them inside. If asked, or if she is in the process of showing the PCs around the first floor, she informs the PCs that "Mother" should return within the hour.¹¹¹ Bella refuses to lead the PCs to the second floor or above, and informs them that her sister is working up there, and hates to be disturbed.

109 /u/Hoaxness, [How I Managed: Old Bonegrinder](#)

110 /u/Havelok, [Old Bonegrinder Exterior Map](#)

111 /u/Hoaxness, [How I Managed: Old Bonegrinder](#)

Should the PCs attack Bella, she and Offalia vanish into the Ethereal Plane. Morgantha returns home shortly thereafter.

□ Strands of Fate - The Treasure of Old Bonegrinder

If one of the three treasures is located here, only the hags, Baba Lysaga, and the Keepers of the Feather know of its presence. The wereravens spotted it while scoping out the windmill before a failed rescue attempt. Even Strahd is ignorant to its location.

O1. Ground Floor

Just behind the door, the hags keep a small umbrella stand that contains an ugly green parasol with rotted fabric and a rusted longsword. If asked about the sword, Bella claims that it belonged to an old lover of hers who left it to her as a memento. In truth, the sword belongs to a former adventuring party that stormed the hags' windmill and were swiftly and brutally destroyed. Bella herself fondly remembers using the swordsman's bones as toothpicks after consuming him and his friends.

The acrid smell coming from the barrel of demonic ichor isn't potent. Rather than mixing with the smell of the pastries, the ichor's scent is only detectable if the PCs place themselves directly beside the barrel.

The windmill isn't filthy. It's certainly not clean, however, and has a musty, lived-in air about it. There are no bones littering the floor; instead, the children's bones are kept in a burlap sack beside the oven. You can describe the chamber thusly:

A large brick oven takes up most of one side of the room. The oven emits warmth and you can smell something sweet baking inside. Surrounding the oven on some shelves are several jars of condiments and ingredients. You can also see a few bins filled with animal bones and bits of discarded dough.

Because of their size, the bones could be easily mistaken for animal bones. A PC can make a DC 15 Wisdom (Medicine) or Intelligence (Nature) check to correctly identify the bones as belonging to human children.

Conversations with Bella

There isn't much room inside the windmill's first floor for everyone to be comfortable, but Bella makes a show of trying to be hospitable. There is a single unused chair in a corner, piled high with Offalia's twig dolls, that Bella clears off to provide one of the PCs a place to sit.

Bella informs the PCs that she, her sister, and her mother don't often have guests, and apologizes for not making things nicer. Bella freely says that her sister is hard at work upstairs, calling her "Sister" rather than "Offalia." When the PCs enter the windmill, Bella calls up to invite

Offalia downstairs; Offalia quickly calls down that she's hard at work, and reminds Bella that "Mother" will be home soon.¹¹²

Bella and Offalia can inform the PCs that their mother, Morgantha, often goes into town for a few days at a time to peddle their wares. They have a little place in Barovia to stay, but much prefer to live in their cozy windmill. Bella and her sister are the primary bakers of their business.

If the PCs have previously met Morgantha, Bella is delighted. Bella is further pleased if one of the PCs has sampled one of her dream pastries, and asks for the PC's critiques on the taste, texture, and consistency of the pastries. She doesn't discuss the content of the pies unless specifically asked, and even then admits that it's a family secret passed down from her mother's mother, and asks the PCs not to inquire further.

Bella is aware of Morgantha's usual excuse for her fiendish aura (that Morgantha's mother had a bad encounter with a wicked witch), and appears sad when she tells the PCs that Morgantha doesn't often talk about her grandmother's misfortune.

If the PCs bring up the deed to the windmill obtained from Death House, Bella looks devastated. She tells the PCs that the windmill was abandoned for centuries before their grandmother came to live there, and asks the PCs if they plan to shamefully evict "three old women" from their home.

Otherwise, Bella does her best to keep the conversation about the PCs. She asks them where they're headed, where they're from, and how they're handling Barovia.

If Bella offers the PCs a dream pastry as a sale or free sample, the wereraven outside hops onto the windowsill and caws loudly in warning. Bella quickly closes the shutters and asks the PCs to shut the other windows. If the PCs do not obey, the raven hops into the window closest to one of the PCs and attempts to get their attention. An instant later, Bella throws a kitchen knife at the raven's chest, and attempts to use an **Intelligence (Sleight of Hand)** check to conceal the *Magic Missile* spell she is casting around the knife. Whether the knife hits or misses, the wereraven is wounded in the side by *Magic Missile* and flies off soon after.

Bella attempts to play down the incident by claiming that the ravens have been terrible bothers to her and her sister ever since a falling tree destroyed their only scarecrow. She informs the PCs that the ravens frequently fly inside to eat their pies, defecate on their floor, or attack their mothers' hairpiece. If the PCs notice and point out her use of magic, Bella claims to be a simple woodswitch who has grown used to using her small arcane talent to keep her home clean and safe.

O3. Bedroom

□ The Butterfly Effect - Freek and Myrtle

If the PCs are able to rescue Freek and Myrtle, the children can be taken in by Father Lucian Patrovich in Vallaki,¹¹³ or Burgomaster Dmitri Krezkov in Krezk.

If the PCs attempt to rescue Freek and Myrtle and fail, or fail to find the children while visiting, only Freek is still alive when they return.

If the PCs burn down or otherwise destroy the windmill without rescuing the children inside, they can later find a pair of child-sized corpses charred or otherwise killed in cages within the wreckage. The cages have been ravaged by fingernails, and the PCs can clearly hear Freek and Myrtles' screams as the windmill is destroyed.¹¹⁴

□ Module Milestone - Rescue the Children

If the PCs rescue Freek and Myrtle from the windmill, you may choose to award a milestone and allow the characters to level up.

O4. Domed Attic

A small collection of twig dolls and fetishes is kept here on a shelf by Offalia, who fashions them in the shape of the children she devours.

If one of the three treasures of Madam Eva's reading is present here, it is displayed reverently atop a small shrine dedicated to Strahd. When Saint Markovia marched upon Castle Ravenloft, only one of her followers - a coward of little faith - survived. He filled his bag with treasures and fled the fortress - only to be taken in the night by the hags of Old Bonegrinder as he camped by the road. The hags believe that the treasure's presence is a sign of Strahd's favor in them.

The Megaliths

The megaliths of Old Bonegrinder are home to the Forest Fane, the shrine of the Huntress. The Huntress, a member of the *Rozana*, or the Ladies Three, lost much of her power when Strahd perverted the rituals of the druids of old Cerunnos to claim the seat of her power for himself.

The Forest Fane is one of three Fanes throughout Barovia that have been claimed by Strahd to provide him power over the land, weather, and beasts of Barovia. The Fane of the Huntress is the source of Strahd's dominion over the feral wolves and other beasts of the Barovian woodland. It also provides him the continuous protection of a *nondetection* spell, which protects him from the detection of all divination magic. If cleansed and reconsecrated, the fane's boon fades from Strahd's grasp.¹¹⁵

113 ElvenTower, [Chapter 6 – Old Bonegrinder](#)

114 /u/paintraina, [What I've learned from running Curse of Strahd twice: Old Bonegrinder Edition](#)

115 /u/DragnaCarta, [Revisions for Running Curse of Strahd: The Fanes of Barovia](#)

The Fane itself is a small stone shrine that stands in a small underground cavern beneath the megaliths. It is flanked by a pair of stone etchings that depict the Huntress: a tall, long-haired, well-muscled maiden wielding a spear and a bow-and-arrows. The left etching shows the Huntress chasing a deer through a forest alongside a trio of friendly wolves; the right carving depicts the Huntress devouring the freshly-carved heart from a boar's fresh corpse, a bloodstained stone dagger in her other hand.

The wall behind the altar is covered by a half-rotted tapestry depicting a trio of old crones, one of whom resembles the Huntress. The second woman, the Weaver, bears short, ravenlike hair; the third, the Seeker, has sharp-angled cheeks and long, flowing black hair. All three women wear ragged tunics of leathers and rough cloth.

The front of the altar itself bears the following words in Druidic script:

*Mistress of the green,
Lady of the forest,
I offer you my sacrifice.
I ask you for your blessing.
You are the eye in the trees,
the hunter of the woods,
who brings life to the dawning spring.
You are the deer in rut,
mighty Horned One,
who roams the autumn woods,
the hunter circling round the oak,
the antlers of the wild stag,
and the lifeblood that spills upon
the ground each season.
Mistress of the green,
Lady of the forest,
I offer you my sacrifice.
I ask you for your blessing.*

The cavern is accessible through a small hollow at the center of the circle, which has been covered up by a large boulder. A DC 12 **Intelligence (Nature)** or **Wisdom (Perception)** check can inform the PCs that the boulder is made of a different type of rock than the standing stones around it. It can only be moved with a successful DC 20 **Athletics (Strength)** check. The hags moved it here to bury the Fane's entrance tunnel after moving into the windmill beside it.

To keep the Fane freshly desecrated, the hags scatter children's teeth in small mounds across the grass in front of the megaliths. This is done as an offering to the entity they worship, the wicked archfey Ceithleann of the Crooked Teeth.

If any of the hags observe the PCs attempting to move the boulder sealing off the cavern, they exit the windmill and attempt to persuade the PCs to leave the Fane alone. Morgantha tells the PCs that the Fane is the place of power of a barbaric and cruel Fae spirit who demanded human sacrifices from the people of Barovia, and tormented her subjects through torture and disfigurement. Though the hags may be evil, they at least only commit evil acts with the consent of their victims.

If the PCs make any further attempts to unseal or sanctify the Forest Fane, Morgantha and her daughters attack, fleeing only under the conditions listed above. Morgantha believes that a return of the Huntress will invite the Lady's retribution down upon the coven's heads for their sustained desecration of the megaliths above. If the Fane is successfully restored, the night hags do not return to Old Bonegrinder until Strahd has slain the PCs and reconquered the Huntress' shrine.

Purifying the Forest Fane

After the PCs learn the history and rituals of the Fanes from the Tome of Strahd, the berserker spirit Kavan, or the berserker tribes, they may return to the megaliths of Old Bonegrinder in an attempt to restore the Huntress' place of power. The Forest Fane can be reconsecrated by carving the heart from a hunted beast and placing the organ into a stone bowl resting atop the shrine's surface. The Huntress' stone dagger must be used to accomplish this act; it lies atop the shrine beside the bowl.

When the offering is completed, the eyes of the Huntress in the tapestry and stone etchings glow, and a wolf's howl can be heard in the distance. If all three Fanes have been reconsecrated, the tapestry is restored to pristine condition, and its depiction of the Ladies shifts from old crones to beautiful maidens. After the Forest Fane has been restored, Strahd loses the benefits of its *nondetection* spell and can no longer command the feral wolves of Barovia. Moreover, any PCs that participated in the ritual gain the benefit of its *nondetection* spell for as long as they stay in Barovia.

☐ Module Milestone - Cleansing the Forest Fane

If the PCs cleanse the Forest Fane, and have previously reconsecrated the Mountain and Swamp Fanes, you may choose to award them a milestone and allow them to level up.

After the Battle

Fights with Morgantha and her daughters are more often the beginning of a story than the end of one. If the PCs drive the hags away from Old Bonegrinder, any survivors of the coven will haunt the party from the Ethereal Plane, pushing them toward the brink of corruption so that the PCs will be driven to commit evil, and so become a tasty meal for the hag's soul bag.

If one or more hags were killed in the fight, the survivors instead focus on achieving vengeance against the PCs. They pursue the PCs at any cost, haunting them with nightmares. and step in to finish the job whenever the party appears weak or outnumbered.

If the PCs are able to flee from battle, the hags let them go. However, if any one of the PCs appeared to have a Neutral or Evil alignment, Bella or Offalia attempts to scry them one or several nights thereafter, and focuses that PC with her Nightmare Haunting ability in an effort to corrupt that PC's soul. Under no circumstances does a single hag reveal herself from the Ethereal Plane, save for an opportune moment when she believes she may be able to obtain a lock of hair or personal possession to strengthen Morgantha's *Scrying* spell.

Any haunted PCs should be unaware of the source of their nightmares. Only Rudolph van Richten and Ezmerelda recognize the symptoms of a potential night hag haunting. Van Richten, Ezmerelda, and the Abbot are the only creatures able to drive off the hags through the benefits of a *Magic Circle* spell. The hags are also unable to enter the Church of St. Andral.

If one or more of the PCs are knocked unconscious or taken prisoner by the coven, the hags keep them tied up alongside the children on the third floor. Bella and Offalia torment their prisoners by murdering and devouring Freek in plain view, and promise the PCs that they plan to fatten the characters up until they can serve as supper themselves.¹¹⁶ Morgantha will make a deal to allow any one of the PCs to go free - but only at the cost of one high-value or multiple low-value deals as described in the section above.

A captured PC that accepts a deal in this way is made into a "volunteer" that Morgantha swiftly puts to work. The PC's gear, arcane focus, and any weapons are taken and locked away in a safe whose key hangs around Morgantha's neck. The "volunteer" is then tasked with selling pies or retrieving children from impoverished parents.¹¹⁷

So long as any of the PCs remain as prisoners or "volunteers" at Old Bonegrinder, the hags torment them nightly using their Nightmare Haunting ability.

116 /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Old Bonegrinder](#)

117 /u/Nalgrim, [Old Bonegrinder Brainstorm help needed.](#)

□ The Butterfly Effect - Ireena and the Hags

If Ireena is with the PCs, the hags place her unconscious using a *Sleep* spell, and proceed to abandon her unconscious at the bridge to Castle Ravenloft. Ireena is narrowly saved from Rahadin's notice by a pair of helpful wereravens, who escort her to Vallaki. If the PCs are still imprisoned in the windmill the following day, Ireena persuades Urwin Martikov to allow her to lead Muriel and Guswin, two members of the Order of the Feather, to the PCs' rescue.¹¹⁸ The wereravens wait until Morgantha has taken her cart down the road to Barovia, and attempt to chew through the ropes keeping the PCs tied up. Bella and Offalia target Guswin first in their efforts to recapture the PCs. If Guswin is killed, this sours the relationship between the PCs and the Keepers of the Feather.¹¹⁹

If any of the PCs die in battle with the hags, Morgantha leaves their bodies between the megaliths behind the mill to be eaten by crows. Any PCs killed this way before level 5 should have an opportunity to be resurrected through a Dark Gift.

If the PCs have piqued Strahd's interest to the point where he views one or more of their party has a potential successor, the hags put the party to sleep and proceed to load them onto Strahd's black carriage, which carries the PCs to Castle Ravenloft before dumping them in the courtyard. The PCs must then succeed on a skill challenge to evade a pair of hungry vampire spawn crawling from the upper towers and cross to the other side of the chasm before the drawbridge is completely raised.

CHAPTER 5: THE TOWN OF VALLAKI

WELCOME TO VALLAKI

OVERVIEW OF VALLAKI

At more than seventy-five pages, this guide is easily the longest chapter in the *Curse of Strahd: Reloaded* compendium. It's not hard to see why. Vallaki is a centerpiece of plot hooks, significant NPCs, and interlocking politics.

However, don't be too intimidated by this chapter's extreme length. Rather than a mire of criss-crossing hooks and political snares, you can view Vallaki as a "home base" for your players to return to while completing the campaign. Many of the events discussed in the *Plot Hooks & Special Events* section should be taken as special occasions that can only happen when

118 ElvenTower, [Chapter 6 – Old Bonegrinder](#)

119 /u/Expers, [Ending up making a mess at the Old Bonegrinder, ack](#)

specific conditions occur, and most of these events can be comfortably spread out across the length of your campaign.

VALLAKIAN GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

Like Krezk and Barovia, Vallaki is ruled by a burgomaster: Baron Vargas Vallakovich. A cruel yet cowardly man, Baron Vallakovich believes that Vallaki can be kept safe from Strahd's predations if its citizens retain an eternal state of happiness and mirth. To foster this goal, Vallakovich holds weekly festivals, for which attendance and smiles are mandatory. As your PCs arrive in town, the previous festival - the Wolf Head Jamboree - has recently finished, and the Baron's servants are preparing for the next event: the Festival of the Blazing Sun.¹²⁰

Few residents of Vallaki are happy with their lives. Baron Vallakovich rules sternly, though not wisely, and his weekly festivals have long since lost their charm. The citizens of Vallaki dare not speak against the Baron's "happy" world for fear that his guards will throw them in the stocks or exile them from Vallaki, forsaking them to die.

Unlike Barovia, the streets of Vallaki are teeming with people and obvious signs of life. In contrast to the dreary emptiness of Barovia village and the lively wilderness of the Tser Pool Encampment, Vallaki should feel like a familiar, near-normal location for the PCs.

At first glance, the tyranny of the Baron's rule is not immediately visible. The people here, though oppressed, do their best to live their lives as well as possible. Vallakovich actively encourages his citizens to smile, so a passive, jovial countenance is not uncommon amongst Vallakians, however clearly fake it may be.¹²¹

Fear of the burgomaster's justice is matched only by the residents' fear of Strahd. Long ago, this fear drove a powerful paranoia that fueled the Vallakovichs' rise to power. The Vallakovich family is an old noble house, and has always believed that strict laws are required to keep Vallaki safe from the Devil of Castle Ravenloft. The severity and nature of these rules have varied from Baron to Baron, but they are built into the very foundation of Vallakian society.

THE DEVIL'S SHADOW

Strahd has not openly visited Vallaki in the last century. Though he has entered the town in disguise as Lord Vasili von Holtz, he has had no reason to take a direct hand in the town's affairs. For the past one hundred years, he has waited patiently for Tatyana to be reincarnated, and so allowed the Vallakians to live their lives free of his personal influence.

Because of Strahd's absence, the people of Vallaki have come to believe that their methods - guards, curfews, laws, and festivals - are effective in keeping the vampire at bay. None suspect

120 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

121 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse Of Strahd: Vallaki II](#)

that Strahd's absence is caused by simple apathy. As a result, the Vallakovich family has effectively consolidated its power within the town's walls, turning the elected position of burgomaster to the hereditary title of Baron.¹²²

VALLAKIAN LAW

CRIMES & PUNISHMENTS

MALICIOUS UNHAPPINESS

Under Baron Vargas Vallakovich, Vallaki has the following laws:

- None shall speak Strahd's name aloud or carry written documents bearing his name. Vallakovich believes that to speak his name is to summon his attention or presence. When they must, Vallakians refer to Strahd simply as "the Devil."
- None may speak ill of the Baron or his festivals, nor hold any documents that present either in an ill light. The Baron believes that happiness is the key to the town's safety, and severely punishes any resident that threatens to harm "morale."
- All visitors and residents shall assist with the festivals. This includes both preparations and clean-up. These duties rotate through the general public on a random basis, in a manner similar to jury duty.
- All visitors and residents shall attend the festival. Guards routinely go door-to-door in the time before and during a festival, and patrol the streets to ensure that no attendee has been left out.

Any Vallakian charged with breaking these laws is charged with "malicious unhappiness," and sentenced to 2d6 days of public humiliation in the stocks. The length of the criminal's stay in the stocks depends on the severity of the crime and the intent of the offender.

GREATER CRIMES

Theft and "public brawling" are punished with 4d6 days of public humiliation in the stocks, with the length of the criminal's stay depending on the severity and intent. Theft from the Baron's estate, repeated minor offenses, or major injury to another civilian are punishable by exile from Vallaki to the wilderness of the Svalich Woods.

Murder is rare to nonexistent in Vallaki. However, on the rare occasion that a Vallakian kills another - intentionally or not - the perpetrator is sentenced to a public hanging from the gallows in the Town Square. While awaiting their sentence, the perpetrator is imprisoned in the stocks alongside other criminals, and is executed at the next sunset following their arrest.

122 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

BREAKING THE LAW

As-written, if the PCs get on the Baron's bad side by breaking one or more laws, he accuses them of being "spies of the devil Strahd" and sends twelve **guards** to arrest them, seize their weapons, and run them out of town.

☐ **KNOW THE MONSTERS - VALLAKIAN TOWN GUARD**

The guards (and Izek, if present) make every effort to subdue the PCs, only moving to attack the PCs if one of their own has been slain. Under no circumstances do the low-level guards outright attack a party of high-level PCs, instead preferring to incapacitate their enemies one at a time through ambush, overwhelming force, and the use of rope ties to render their opponents incapable of fighting back.

The guards first attempt to grapple the PCs. Once a PC has been grappled, any guard will try to shove them prone. Once a PC is prone and grappled, any of the guards can attempt to tie the PC's hands behind their back, making a Strength (Athletics) check contested by the PC's choice of Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) to do so. A prone PC's contested check is made with disadvantage.

The rope can be snapped with a DC 15 Strength check, and has AC 12 and 2 Hit Points. Any creature bound by the guards' rope gains the *restrained* condition, but can still move at half speed. A second length of rope can also be tied around the ankles, capping any creature's movement speed at 5 feet per round (barring the use of the Dash action).

If it becomes clear to the guards that they face an overwhelmingly powerful force, they take the Disengage action and swiftly flee.

If the guards fail in their duty, the baron sends Izek to rally a mob of thirty **commoners** to lynch the party. These commoners attempt to grapple and drag the party to the stocks, at which point a makeshift gallows is erected. Any PC lynched by the commoners has a single round to act before the impact snaps their neck.

If the commoners also fail, the baron summons the twelve remaining guards to defend his mansion, giving the characters the run of the town.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

d6	Encounter
1	While walking through the streets, the PCs pass a puppet show run by a brightly-dressed man - Rictavio. His small stage is surrounded by a half-dozen drab Barovians watching from the muddy cobblestones. ¹²³

¹²³ /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Vallaki](#)

2	While walking through the streets, the PCs pass a Dominionist follower of Lady Wachter preaching of “the coming of the Sun” to a paltry audience of three Barovians. One Loyalist jeers at the preacher, and a passing guard quells any dispute.
3	The PCs are watched by a raven with blue-tipped wings. This raven is secretly Muriel Vinshaw of the Keepers of the Feather in raven form.
4	The PCs notice two children pointing at Ireena and whispering. If approached, the children mention that Ireena looks exactly like Blinsky’s dolls. ¹²⁴
5	An wild-eyed old man grabs the PCs and yells about dark magic and purple flashes of light from the attic of the Burgomaster’s Manor in the night. Two guards rapidly approach and drag him away. ¹²⁵
6	Two orphans stand on a street corner, singing a hymn to the Morninglord in off-key voices. The poorly-spelled sign on their bucket invites donations to St. Andral’s Orphanage. On closer inspection, one of the children has a dark bruise on their arm.

Plot Hooks & Special Events

	The Missing Vistana	Lady Wachter’s Wish	Tea with the Baron	Izek’s Request	Tyger, Tyger	Festival of the Blazing Sun	Vasil’s Ledger	Feast of Saint Andral
TRIGGERS	• Talk to Arigal and Luvash at the Vistani camp near Vallaki • Encounter Bluto the fisherman at Lake Zarovich • Meet travelling Vistani on the Svalich Road	• Deliver wine to the Blue Water Inn • Successfully resist arrest by the Vallakian guard • Recover the Bones of Saint Andral and defeat the vampires	• Publicly identify Ireena Kolyana to the Vallakian guard while on neutral or friendly terms with Baron Vallakovich	• Linger in Vallaki alongside Izek Strazni’s long-lost sibling (Ireena or a PC, depending on the party) for two or more days	• Participate in the Festival of the Blazing Sun	• Be present in Vallaki on the third day after entry	• Find sanctuary for Ireena Kolyana in Vallaki	• Find sanctuary for Ireena at the Church of Saint Andral for three days or more.
EVENT	The PCs must find and rescue the young Vistana Arabelle before she is killed by Bluto the fisherman at Lake Zarovich.	Lady Wachter invites the PCs for dinner and asks them to assassinate Izek Strazni to assist her takeover of Vallaki	Baron Vallakovich invites Ireena and her companions to tea at his manor to learn more about their presence in Vallaki	Izek greets his sibling with joy and asks them to investigate Wachterhaus for signs of treasonous activity	Rictavio’s saber-toothed tiger escapes his wagon and wreaks havoc across Vallaki.	The PCs are required to attend the Festival by the Vallakian guard, and can step in to defend one of the Baron’s men after he laughs at the Baron’s attempts to light the wicker sun in the rain.	Vasil von Holtz befriends Ireena while she is away from the Church of Saint Andral and asks the PCs to investigate a trade wagon that has gone missing.	Ludmilla Vilisevic steals the bones of St. Andral from the church and attacks with a vampire raid to demolish and demoralize the parish.
OUTCOME	+ The PCs rescue Arabelle and gain an ally in Luvash, who offers a reward from the Vistani treasure wagon - Arabelle drowns	+ The PCs assassinate Izek and Lady Wachter has the Baron quietly exiled from Vallaki - The Baron’s guards throw the PCs out of town without weapons	+ The PCs gain an ally in Baron Vallakovich, who takes a favorable eye of their exploits - The Baron’s guards throw the PCs out of town without weapons	+ The PCs gain an ally in Izek, who defends their actions before the Baron - The PCs are captured by Lady Wachter, who delivers them to Strahd	+ The PCs gain an ally in Rictavio, and learn of Van Richten’s Tower - Rictavio flees Vallaki alone	+ The PCs rescue Lars Kjurlis, intimidate the Baron, and gain free reign of Vallaki - The Baron’s guards throw the PCs out of town without weapons	+ The PCs receive a reward of 100gp and unknowingly obtain Strahd’s animated armor - The PCs uncover Vasil’s true identity	+ The PCs restore the bones of Saint Andral and defeat the vampire attack - The church is destroyed and Father Lucian killed

Key: (+) = Positive Outcome / (-) = Negative Outcome

[Link to Full Image](#)

124 Ziopliukas, /r/CurseOfStrahd Discord Server

125 Matt88, /r/CurseOfStrahd Discord Server

THE MISSING VISTANA

Bluto Krogarov, a Vallakian fisherman without a soul, has been unable to catch any fish at Lake Zarovich for the past several weeks. In a fit of maddened desperation, he recently kidnapped the Vistani child Arabelle while she played in Vallaki with her friends at the Orphanage of Saint Andral. Using Blinsky toys to keep her quiet, Bluto is currently preparing to drown Arabelle in Lake Zarovich as a sacrifice to the lake with the hopes of filling his nets with fish once more.

BEGINNING THE QUEST

The PCs can learn of this quest at any one of the following locations:

- If the PCs talk to **Arrigal** and **Luvash** at the Vistani camp near Vallaki and view them punishing Alexei, the characters may offer to rescue Arabelle in exchange for goodwill, a monetary reward, or a treasure placed in the Vistani treasure wagon by Madam Eva's Tarokka reading.
- If the PCs encounter **Bluto** at Lake Zarovich as he prepares to sacrifice Arabelle, the characters may decide to row out to meet him and rescue Arabelle from her sack before she sinks beneath the waves.
- If the PCs encounter a group of travelling **Vistani** on the Old Svalich Road, or if they meet **Savid** in Argynvostholt, the characters may offer to journey to the Vistani camp in order to learn more about Arabelle's disappearance and her abilities as a seer.

DEVELOPMENTS

Neither Luvash nor Arrigal has been able to search for Arabelle within Vallaki, due to the laws barring Vistani from entry. However, Arrigal knows that Arabelle has been known to sneak into town to play with the children of St. Andral's Orphanage, and that she is especially fascinated by the festivals that take place within Vallaki.¹²⁶

If the PCs agree to find her, Luvash gives them a small necklace bearing a bronze tab decorated with a trio of twinkling stars - Arabelle's favorite. He tells them that she will trust them if that necklace is presented to her. A transformed druid or ranger's companion with the Keen Senses feature can use Arabelle's necklace to track her to the Orphanage of Saint Andral, Blinsky Toys, Bluto's home, and Lake Zarovich (in that order) with a successful DC 15 Perception (Wisdom) check.

Otherwise, the orphans of St. Andral's Orphanage can inform the PCs that they recently saw a grimy-looking man wearing a straw hat and carrying a bottle of wine watching them play when Arabelle was last in Vallaki. Danika Martikov or Headmistress Claudia Belasco of the Orphanage can quickly identify that as Bluto, the town drunk and local fisherman, and point the PCs toward his home.

Bluto's neighbor Camilla Veredov, a gossipy dowager arranging pots of sickly-looking flowers, can inform the PCs that Bluto has not been seen in more than a day, having vanished after boasting of a new "good-luck" charm that he hoped would solve his fishing woes. Danika Martikov can share the same information.

COMPLETING THE QUEST

When the PCs arrive at Lake Zarovich, they will have to pass the following skill challenge to save Arabelle, the Vistana child that Bluto Krogarov has kidnapped. See [here](#) for more information on how to run skill challenges.

In this skill challenge, the PCs must accrue three successes before three failures. If the PCs pass this challenge, they are able to rescue Arabelle before she drowns. If the challenge is failed with at least one success, the PCs are able to recover Arabelle's corpse from the lake. If the challenge is failed with zero successes, Arabelle's corpse falls into the depths of Lake Zarovich, lost among the dark silt and cold currents.

This skill challenge is divided into three separate stages: **Sprint**, **Recovery**, and **Revival**.

During the **Sprint**, your PCs must reach Bluto's boat before Arabelle's sack sinks too deep in the water. One success is required to progress from this stage to the Recovery stage. Your PCs may use several skills or abilities to pass this section of the skill challenge, including any of the following features:

- **Athletics** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to swim from shore to rescue Arabelle.
- **Athletics** (DC 8 - Easy) can be used to swim to Arabelle's rescue if the PCs previously took a rowboat out onto the lake.
- **Nature** (DC 18 - Hard) can be used to spot currents in the water's surface that can speed one's progress.
- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) such as *Enlarge*, *Gust of Wind*, *Alter Self*, or *Misty Step*; or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) such as *Shape Water* can be used to speed a PC's attempts to swim toward Arabelle.

In the second part, the **Recovery** stage, your PCs must swim deep enough to retrieve Arabelle's sack before it sinks into the murky depths. One success is required to progress from this stage to the Revival stage.

- **Athletics** (DC 8 - Easy) can be used to carry Arabelle's sack back to the surface.
- **Perception** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to peer through the silt-choked water to track the movement of Arabelle's sack.
- **Investigation** (DC 18 - Hard) can be used to feel the motion of the water currents to track the displacement of the sinking Arabelle.
- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) such as *Enlarge*, *Gust of Wind*, *Alter Self*, or *Misty Step*; or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) such as *Shape Water* can be used to speed a PC's attempts to dive down to Arabelle.

- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) such as *Levitate*, *Tenser's Floating Disk*, or *Feather Fall*; or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) such as *Gust* or *Shape Water* can be used to raise Arabelle through the water toward her rescuer.

With Arabelle saved from a watery fate, the PCs find the girl unconscious, unmoving, and unresponsive. In the **Revival** stage, she must be saved from the liquid in her lungs before it suffocates her. If the PCs achieve their third success in this stage before failing, they complete the skill challenge successfully.

- **Medicine** (DC 8 - Easy) or **Survival** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to pump the water from Arabelle's lungs.
- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) such as *Healing Word*; or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) such as *Shape Water* can be used to remove the water suffocating the girl.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the PCs succeed in rescuing Arabelle, the precocious young Vistana thanks them for their aid, and asks them to deliver her to the Vistani encampment near Vallaki. Upon arrival, Luvash greets Arabelle joyously, and showers the PCs with praise, offering the party the choice of an artifact or treasure from the Vistani treasure wagon. As the party prepares to leave, Arabelle's gifts as a seer overtake her, and she delivers a foreboding prophecy that foreshadows a great danger or reward in the trials to come. From this point forward, the PCs are always welcome at the Vistani encampment here, and Arrigal refuses any assignments Strahd may make to hunt or steal from the PCs.

If the PCs fail to rescue Arabelle before she drowns, or if they ignore this quest entirely for seven days or more, Arabelle is drowned beneath the waters of Lake Zarovich. With her dying breath, Arabelle curses Bluto with the power within her Vistana blood. Her malediction, strengthened by the trauma of her death and her relation to Madam Eva, disfigures Bluto's face into a wolf's muzzle, so that he may resemble in body the predator he has become in spirit.

Bluto flees for Vallaki and hides himself away in his home, ashamed and terrified of discovery. Two days after drowning Arabelle, Bluto emerges into Vallaki's market to purchase basic foodstuffs and supplies, and is discovered by the town guard when the rag he has wrapped around his face falls loose. He is captured and imprisoned in the stocks. Baron Vallakovich proceeds to parade Bluto about the town in chains during the next festival, releasing him shortly before the burning of the wicker sun for the townsfolk to stone him to death.¹²⁷

LADY WACHTER'S WISH

Lady Fiona Wachter has become embittered by the inept and malicious rule of Baron Vargas Vallakovich and his line, and wishes to destroy his family for the harm that Victor inflicted on her

daughter, Stella. To this end, she seeks a worthy accomplice or mercenary to dispose of the Baron's greatest asset and protector - his enforcer and Captain of the Guard, Izek Strazni, who has terrified Vallaki with his barbarity and supernatural power.

BEGINNING THE QUEST

Lady Wachter has seen many adventurers come and go, and knows only that a special group of newcomers will be useful to her plans. Fiona's interest is roused if the PCs do anything that makes them stand out as potential defenders of the citizens of Vallaki or enemies of Baron Vallakovich, including (but not limited to) the following:

- Deliver barrels of wine from the Wizard of Wines to the Blue Water Inn
- Defy Baron Vallakovich and rescue Lars Kjurl at the Festival of the Blazing Sun
- Successfully resist arrest by the Vallakian guard

Once Fiona has identified the PCs as an asset to her plans, she sends Ernst Larnak or her sons to deliver a standing invitation to dinner at Wachterhaus.

DEVELOPMENTS

Upon meeting the party, Wachter will inspect and politely interrogate each of her guests. She favors tieflings for their "beautiful" Abyssal nature.¹²⁸

During this meeting, Wachter is quite open, if politely so, about her distaste for the Baron. She makes the following points in their conversation in an attempt to sway the PCs to her side:

- Vargas is not the first terrible burgomaster of the Vallakovich line. Each Baron has been just as terrible as the last, if not worse. His father, Vargon, was a mad tyrant who ruled Vallaki with an iron fist and cruel, inhumane punishments.
- Vargas and his captain, Izek Strazni, are brutes. It is common knowledge that Izek relishes the torture of prisoners, but Fiona believes that Vargas has his own mean streak. The Baron's wife, Lydia, is a fragile, delicate woman - she likely fears her husband's wrath.
- Fiona attempted to create an understanding between their two families by arranging the marriage between their children. However, she was unaware of Victor Vallakovich's cruelty, and the apathy Vargas had toward her daughter's wellbeing. Though Wachter does not know what Victor did to Stella to destroy her mind, she knows it must have been horrific. It clearly pains her to share this story with the party, but she does so to convey the hereditary corruption of the Baron's family line.

If the flow of conversation allows, Fiona may relate the story of her meeting with Strahd as a young woman. As-written, she shares her belief that Strahd is, at worst, a negligent landlord, and points out Zarovich's calm and diplomatic nature, as well as her belief that Vallaki would remain safe under the vampire's rule if guided by the correct leader. She uses the Devil's name freely, and claims that "a servant of the light has no fear of the dark."

128 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

Toward the end of the meeting, Fiona makes an effort to feel out the party's sympathy toward herself and her cause. If the atmosphere is hostile or suspicious, she thanks the PCs for their time and sends them on their way. She then assigns Ernst Larnak to tail the party, who reports back to Fiona immediately if he witnesses the PCs conspiring against her.

If Fiona feels she has earned the party's trust, she informs them that, as a young woman, she received a prophecy from a seer that told of their coming. Wachter believes that the party's arrival in Vallaki foretells the beginning of a new age, and she wants dearly to bring this to fruition. Under no circumstances does she reveal the true nature of her "book club," though she may make reference to her "friends" amongst the Vallakian populace.

If the PCs seem willing, Fiona asks them to assassinate Izek Strazni, the Baron's top enforcer and main protector. If the PCs appear reluctant to do so because they have begun the **IZEK'S OBSESSION** quest, Lady Wachter asks them instead to persuade Izek to turn on the Baron himself - or, if he cannot be persuaded to kill the Baron by his own hand, to step away and allow Fiona's agents to remove him from Vallaki themselves. Fiona is not interested in the prospect of killing or exiling the Baron while Izek remains present to retrieve and/or avenge him.

COMPLETING THE QUEST

The PCs can find by visiting or with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check that Izek can often be found patrolling Vallaki's Town Square during the day, and sleeping in his quarters at the Baron's manor by night. Alternatively, if the characters have met the necessary conditions for triggering the **IZEK'S OBSESSION** quest, Izek seeks out his sibling at the Blue Water Inn or other place of residence to introduce himself and show them around Vallaki.

If he is neutral or hostile to the PCs, Izek is a dangerous opponent. At no time does he leave the side of his trusty greataxe, and he is always hungry for a fight. He may mock his assailants for failing to face him in a fair two-man fight, but will happily employ any dirty tricks (e.g., attacking bystanding PCs with surprise) as necessary. In combat, Izek uses his Hurl Flame multiattack as he closes the distance to his enemies, and switches to his greataxe once entering melee. In a melee fight, Izek attempts to corner the most vulnerable of his opponents before attacking them with his greataxe, focusing fire on one weakened PC at a time. His childhood tragedy and blossoming sociopathy have left Izek without fear, and he does not flee battle once engaged.

If the PCs attempt to convince Izek to assassinate or allow them to assassinate the Baron, only his sibling is able to do so. Even then, a successful DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check on the part of his sibling is required, and the party must provide direct evidence that the Baron's removal from power will have positive consequences for Izek or his sibling (given that Izek is, above all else, a creature of selfish desires). Izek cannot be convinced by arguments for the greater good of Vallaki, and believes that he alone knows what is best for himself and his sibling.

If the party is in need of a place to stay, Fiona offers her own home to them. She makes her sons' rooms fit for guests, informing the PCs that Nikolai and Karl stay out most nights anyway. She notes, however, that Stella's room, the basement, and the master bedroom are strictly off limits.

DEVELOPMENTS

It is likely that the PCs may remain skeptical of Lady Wachter's intentions, especially given her lack of antagonism toward Strahd. Sufficiently paranoid parties may even discover the true nature of her inner circle. If Fiona suspects that the PCs may betray her, she hands Ernst a bag of 100 gp (taken from area N4q) and instructs him to deliver it to the Vistani camp outside town, along with a letter from her that asks Arrigal to dispose of the characters once they have left town. The Vistani burn the letter after reading it, as per Lady Wachter's request. If the characters have rescued Arabelle (see THE MISSING VISTANA above), the Vistani return Lady Wachter's gold to Ernst and do nothing. Otherwise, a Vistana bandit watches the road east of Vallaki and reports back to camp if the characters are sighted leaving. Arrigal pursues the PCs thereafter, attacking from the shadows during their next short or long rest outside of civilization if he feels confident that he can take them on.

Otherwise, once Izek is assassinated or otherwise removed, Lady Wachter directs her three **cult fanatics**, guided by her **imp**, Majesto, to sneak into the Baron's manor by night and take him and his family captive. Following an arcane duel that leaves Lydia and two of Fiona's cult fanatics dead, Victor Vallakovich flees his father's manor for an abandoned cottage just beyond Vallaki's western gates. The surviving fanatic and two of Lady Wachter's **cultists** take the unconscious Vargas and Vallakovich servants to Lake Zarovich, where Ernst Larnak slits their throats and drowns the corpses beneath the waves.

The following morning, Lady Wachter publicly drafts a search party to search for the Baron and his family, ensuring behind the scenes that their mission is a farce. Meanwhile, she claims the title of "acting Baroness," which is indisputed without Izek to challenge her power.

Once her power is consolidated, Lady Wachter implements the following reforms:

- Abolishment of all town festivals, excepting those held as part of a normal seasonal celebration
- Immediate release of all prisoners kept in the stocks due to "malicious unhappiness"
- Prohibition of the word "Devil" to describe Strahd von Zarovich. "Lord Zarovich" or "Count Zarovich" will suffice instead.

- Regular meetings with Rahadin and Anastraya Karelova at Wachterhaus, transported by Strahd's black carriage after sundown in full sight of Vallaki's citizenry and guards. (Fiona claims that the meetings are "diplomatic summits" in order to "keep the peace.")
- (Eventual) reinstatement of the centuries-old practice of paying Strahd's twice-annual taxes via the provision a young (and preferably attractive) Vallakian citizen, delivered willingly or by force in Strahd's black carriage. Twelve potential sacrifices are chosen by lots, and the final sacrifice is selected by Anastraya (who specifically chooses a sacrifice with a soul).

Lady Wachter is driven by four things: Her loathing for the Vallakoviches, her love for her children, her loyalty to Strahd, and her belief in a better Valalki. Once Vargas' legacy has been thoroughly stomped out, she will implement reforms that she believes will drive Strahd to look upon Vallaki more favorably. If Ireena is present in Vallaki, Strahd may reach out to her in an effort to drive her into his arms. Fiona will also receive orders to begin hunting for Rudolph van Richten, and will actively forbid entry to Vallaki for the PCs if they are enemies of Strahd.

BARON VALLAKOVICH'S INVITATION

Baron Vallakovich is ever-fearful for the stability of his position, and fears especially the machinations of Strahd's agents within the walls of Vallaki. The Vallakovich line has long maintained an enmity for the house of Wachter, and that rivalry has only deepened between Vargas and Fiona.

Vargas believes strongly that Fiona Wachter has designs on his position, and suspects Fiona to be an active conspirator and servant of the Devil. He knows also that two of his servants have vanished in recent weeks, and believes - incorrectly - that Lady Wachter abducted them to steal information regarding his habits and defenses.¹²⁹

However, he has been unable to act on his suspicions, as the ancient house of Wachter is well-established in town and has both wealth, property, and friends in many places, including a number of vassals that work the land Fiona owns. If Vallakovich were to move openly against Lady Wachter, Vallaki would erupt into riots, and his life's work would be lost. As such, he has faced difficulty in recruiting guards to investigate Lady Wachter's secrets. Izek, of course, is far from a subtle inquisitor.

BEGINNING THE EVENT

If the Baron learns that the daughter of Barovia's burgomaster is in Vallaki, or if the actions of the PCs lead him to believe that they may be potential allies, he swiftly sends Izek to personally invite the party over for tea. The PCs might also request an audience with the Baron in an effort to find sanctuary for Ireena, or to gain access to his library or a treasure hidden in his attic.

Should he find them trustworthy and firmly opposed to the Devil's servants, he asks them to investigate Lady Wachter's home for signs of conspiracy or heresy. As a reward, he offers to assign a pair of guards to watch over Irenea Kolyana for as long as she remains in Vallaki, as well as the substantial sum of 200 gp for their services.

He invites the PCs to begin their investigation in his mansion, and suggests they interview his wife and son. Lydia is able to provide no useful information, but the PCs are likely to uncover the servants' fate upon recovering Victor Vallakovich's journal from his study in the attic.

DEVELOPMENTS

Should the PCs accept the invitation (which Irenea strongly urges for the sake of diplomacy), they are welcomed by Vargas' wife, Lydia, and guided into the Den (area N3E), where the Baron meets them after a few minutes of waiting. In the meantime, Lydia does her best to entertain the PCs, though she is so lost to Vargas' beliefs that it is clear that she is barely able to process any other information. If the PCs make any questionable remarks or questions, Lydia only laughs fearfully and ignores their words entirely.

While enjoying a bitter-tasting tea brewed by the cook, the Baron asks the PCs their opinions of his "magnificent society." He waxes at length regarding the work he has done to keep Strahd's influence out of the valley, and brags about the "perfect happiness" enjoyed by his subjects. His speech patterns are streaked with nervous tics and repeated phrases (e.g., "All will be well!"), and his face never loses its constant, gritted smile. During this time, Lydia falls entirely silent, speaking only when spoken to and making clearly scripted responses.

Should the PCs degrade or question Vallaki's laws or culture in any way, the Baron's attitude toward them quickly chills; if the PCs insult any tenet of Vallakian society, the Baron orders them to leave. Should the PCs directly challenge the Baron's authority, or if the situation otherwise goes rapidly downhill, he waits for the PCs to leave before sending twelve **guards** to arrest them, seize their weapons, and run them out of town. For more information on running the Baron's animosity, see **BREAKING THE LAW** above.

Should tea-time go well, the Baron asks the PCs to investigate the indiscretions of Lady Wachter or the disappearances of his servants. Additionally, should Irenea's appearance and personality charm him, he is likely to begin making preparations for an engagement between her and his son, Victor. After the "travesty" of a mate that Stella Wachter proved to be, it's important the the Baron find a properly blue-blooded and demure woman for his son to marry. If the PCs or Irenea mention her need for a place to stay, the Baron instantly offers his own home - after all, there can be no greater sanctuary from the Devil than the domicile of his greatest enemy.

If the PCs reject the Baron's invitation to tea, he is grossly offended, and orders Izek to punish them severely if caught making the slightest infraction.

COMPLETING THE EVENT

In the course of carrying out the Baron's wishes, the PCs may choose to investigate Lady Wachter further, either by infiltrating her estate or through subterfuge.

If she catches PCs snooping around her home - especially after breaking and entering - Lady Wachter first attempts to persuade them to leave peacefully, claiming full innocence of any crime or ill behavior. If the PCs claim to be convinced of her guilt, Lady Wachter leads them to the room of her daughter, Stella, and describes the terrible crimes that Victor Vallakovich has brought upon her family. If the PCs appear sympathetic, Fiona may then attempt to assign them the quest **LADY WACHTER'S WISH**, as described above.

If the PCs approach Lady Wachter and attempt to engage her socially, with the goal of gaining access to her secrets or tricking her into revealing incriminating information, she is more than happy to invite a party of newcomers to dine with her at Wachterhaus. If the PCs appear sympathetic, Fiona may then attempt to assign them the quest **LADY WACHTER'S WISH**, as described above.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the Baron is informed of Lady Wachter's treasonous plans, he instantly asks the PCs to seek out incriminating evidence that will sway the town to his side. If the PCs have any information regarding incriminating objects within Wachterhaus, the Baron writes a warrant of investigation and assigns Izek and a platoon of six **guards** to ransack Fiona's manor. Once any evidence is found - including the corpse of Nikolai Wachter or the animated skeletons in the basement - the Baron orders the immediate arrest of Lady Wachter and her children. Fiona and her sons are swiftly imprisoned in the stocks following a mockery of a trial, and Stella is locked away in St. Andral's Orphanage for the rest of her maddened life. Fiona is able to escape arrest through the use of her arcane powers, and flees alongside Majesto and her three **cult fanatics** to seek refuge at Castle Ravenloft. Nikolai II and Karl are later tied to stakes above the wicker sun at the Festival of the Blazing Sun and burned alive as an example.

If Ernst or another of Fiona's spies are alerted to the Baron's intentions, Lady Wachter quickly moves to cleanse her home of all incriminating evidence, relocating any questionable items or texts to the secret chamber in her basement. If she is prepared for her own imminent arrest, she takes shelter in the cellar of one of her followers' homes, and from there directs a guerilla rebellion that begins with the arson of the Burgomaster's Manor.

TYGER, TYGER

Karl and Nikolai Wachter are young, foolish men from a proud noble family. The drunken brothers sneak into Arasek's Stockyard while everyone else is attending the festival in the town square. On a dare, one of them rocks the wagon. The saber-toothed tiger locked inside becomes enraged and smashes through the wagon door. The characters and everyone else in

town hear the screams of the young men as the tiger escapes. The tiger flees the stockyard without harming the Wachters and begins to prowl the streets, looking for an escape. Reports of a tiger running loose in the streets ruin the festival and send townsfolk scurrying for their homes.

BEGINNING THE EVENT

If the PCs are in Vallaki on the day of the Festival of the Blazing Sun, they are alerted to the tiger's escape by the sound of Nikolai and Karl's screams nearby. Alternatively, if the PCs encounter and befriend Nikolai II or Karl in the days before the Festival (e.g., sharing drinks at the Blue Water Inn), either of the siblings may invite the PCs to ditch the "boring" Festival and share in some mischief instead.

DEVELOPMENTS

The saber-toothed tiger doesn't harm anyone until it takes damage, whereupon it attacks the perceived source of the damage. If he is still alive, **Izek Strazni** gathers six town **guards** and hunts down the beast with the intention of killing it. Meanwhile, Rictavio does his best to lure the beast back to his wagon while assuring townsfolk that it won't harm them.

COMPLETING THE EVENT

The tiger, which Rictavio has named Rameses, makes its way to Blinsky Toys, following the scent of the monkey Piccolo in an effort to rejoin its master. The PCs can track it using a skill challenge (see [here](#) for more information on running skill challenges), employing the following skills in an effort to gain three successes before three failures:

- **Stealth** (DC 18/20 - Hard) may be used to avoid disturbing the tiger or drawing attention to the party's investigation.
- **Animal Handling** (DC 13/15 - Moderate) may be used to coax the tiger out of the store.
- **Nature** (DC 13/15 - Moderate) may be used to calculate the tiger's likely path or identify its species, thereby predicting its behavior.
- **Perception** or **Survival** (DC 13/15 - Moderate) may be used to find and follow the tiger's tracks.
- **Investigation** may be used to infer the tiger's trail from the site of its escape (Moderate - DC 13/15).
- **Persuasion**, **Deception**, or **Intimidate** (DC 8/10 - Easy) may be used to draw clues from startled eyewitnesses.
- **Athletics** or **Acrobatics** (DC 13/15 - Moderate) may be used to take shortcuts through twisting Vallaki alleyways or across nearby roofs.
- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) or **cantrips** (DC 13/15 - Moderate) may be used at the DM's discretion to achieve any of the goals listed above.

The different DCs (e.g., 13/15) reflect the increase in difficulty that skill challenges undergo when the PCs reach level 5. If the PCs are below level 5 during this challenge, use the first given number; if they are at or above level 5 (and below level 10) during this challenge, use the second number.

If the PCs pass the skill challenge, they arrive at Blinsky Toys to find Piccolo perched on Rameses' shoulder as the tiger prowls the length of the store, and Gadof Blinsky cowering on an upper shelf. If the PCs fail the challenge, they arrive to find that a platoon of four **guards** has arrived before they, and are currently aggravating Rameses with their pikes while preparing to attack. It is instantly clear to any PCs that Rameses has no intention of fighting, and is only hostile if cornered.

A DC 15 Animal Handling (Wisdom) check will allow any PC to calm Rameses. If the PCs fail both the skill challenge and this check, Rameses lashes out at the guards nearby, which provokes a full-on brawl. Rictavio arrives as soon Rameses is calmed, or at the beginning of the third round of combat. If the guards are present, he calms Rameses and attempts to gain the PCs' support in persuading the guards to allow him to leave with the tiger. If the PCs refuse, or fail to persuade the guards, Rictavio nonlethally dispatches the guards and flees with Rameses in tow.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the PCs provide any aid to Rictavio during this encounter, or if they succeed in finding and peacefully securing Rameses before he arrives, Rictavio thanks them for their assistance and invites them to join him at the tower at Lake Baratok should they need a safe haven. He then vanishes with Rameses into the alleys of Vallaki, gathering his possessions from the hidden compartment of his wagon and fleeing for refuge at Van Richten's Tower.

If he's still in power, the burgomaster conducts an investigation to find out where the tiger came from. Guards and local witnesses are questioned. The Wachter boys feign innocence, insisting that they were at the festival, but Gunther and Yelena Arasek admit to hearing "evil growls" and scratching sounds coming from inside the carnival wagon parked in their stockyard. When pressed, the Araseks admit to seeing the wagon's "weird owner" routinely drop food into the wagon through a hatch in the roof. They also confess that the half-elf paid them for their silence.

After the burgomaster learns that the tiger belongs to Rictavio, he commands his guards to arrest the mysterious bard. If Rictavio thinks the characters can help him, he asks them to distract the burgomaster and the guards while he gathers his horse, wagon, and tiger (in that order). If the characters ask Rictavio where he plans to go, he tells them about an old tower to the west where he can lie low.

FESTIVAL OF THE BLAZING SUN

BEGINNING THE EVENT

The Festival of the Blazing Sun begins at sunrise on the third day after the PCs enter Vallaki, exactly one week after the Wolf's Head Jamboree. That morning, all the townsfolk are

shepherded (though few need to be led) by the town guards into the Town Square for a day of “light and liveliness.” This Festival has been prepared specifically by Baron Vallakovich as a political countermeasure to Lady Wachter’s growing popularity and the expanding membership of the Dominionists within the town.

Throughout the morning, the townsfolk are made to endure a program of poorly-prepared musical numbers, enforced “decoration appreciation,” a lengthy session of prayer and off-key song, and a two-hour speech on security and obedience by Baron Vallakovich. Several shopkeepers set up stands in the square during this time, including Gadof Blinsky, who displays his best work of the month,¹³⁰ and Rictavio, who puts on a small puppet show for the local children.

DEVELOPMENTS

Shortly before noon, Baron Vallakovich directs his guards to assemble the Parade of the Blazing Sun, during which the wicker sun is brought out of the Burgomaster’s Mansion and placed in the center of the street behind a parade of children wearing poorly made flower costumes. When noon arrives, Vargas rides his horse through the streets, leading the parade back into the Town Square. The wicker sun, carried by a quartet of guards, is set upon a platform constructed beside the stocks and gallows, and is set alight following a speech by Vargas that ends with his traditional phrase, “All will be well!”

It is at this point that the storm clouds that have gathered over Vallaki erupt, dousing the wicker sun.

COMPLETING THE EVENT

See *FESTIVAL OF THE BLAZING SUN* in the original module for a complete discussion of how this event unfolds.

FEAST OF SAINT ANDRAL

Nearly five weeks before the PCs arrived in Barovia, Ludmilla Vilisevic - Strahd’s most loyal and highest-ranking bride - visits Vallaki to gather intelligence on the town’s sociopolitical situation. After learning of Tatyana’s most recent incarnation, and without prompting by Strahd, she makes the calculation that Ireena will need to be guided to Castle Ravenloft through the absence of any other safe haven that the girl might use to escape her fate. Ludmilla then takes it upon herself to monitor the hallowed ground of the Church of Saint Andral, in case that it might provide sanctuary to the embattled Ireena.

BEGINNING THE QUEST

If Ireena remains within the Church of Saint Andral for at least three days, Ludmilla concocts a plan to both deconsecrate the Church and destabilize Vallaki's social situation, leaving the town completely unfit for Ireena's habitation. She visits Henrik van der Voort, finding him a suitable proxy for her plan due to his cowardly personality and social isolation. Through a combination of thinly-veiled threats and the promise of a substantial reward, she tasks him with uncovering the secret to the Church's holy ground.

The next day, a cloaked and hooded Henrik recruits Milivoj to his cause, providing the gravedigger with fifty gold pieces and a cursed locket that Ludmilla promises will seal him to secrecy. This same locket later finds its way into the hands of the orphan, Felix, sending St. Andral's Orphanage spiraling into tragedy. See **THE CURSED ORPHANAGE** quest below for more information on the fate of this transaction.

That night, Ludmilla employs Castle Ravenloft's Teleportation Room to deliver six **vampire spawn** to Henrik's shop, both in preparation for their assault, and as incentive for the coffin maker to expedite his work. The next evening, Milivoj - grown sick and pale from the passive influence of the demonic locket - meets with an anxious Henrik in the Town Square to report his findings. Milivoj receives instructions to steal the bones and deliver them to a cart near Wachterhaus, outside the home of Bluto Krogarov, the town drunk. Milivoj steals the bones from Saint Andral's crypt at midnight, and receives his sack of gold upon their delivery.

The following morning, Milivoj makes his way to the Blue Water Inn, where he hires the wolf hunters, Szoldar Szoldarovich and Yevgeni Krushkin, to find three orphans that have gone missing from St. Andral's Orphanage. Upon his return to the Orphanage, he collapses into unconsciousness, falling fully under the spell of the demon imprisoned in the locket he had brought home.

On the seventh day of Ireena's presence within the Church - the dawn immediately following the bones' disappearance - Father Lucian discovers the theft. The bones serve as his holy symbol while he is within the church; without them, he bears none of his priestly abilities and is reduced to the statblock of a **commoner**. If the party includes a cleric or paladin known to him, Father Lucian immediately seeks them out and relates the church's plight to that PC before begging for their help. Otherwise, he informs Ireena of the church's dilemma, and she seeks the PCs out to ask their aid as quickly as possible. If she is friendly with the Martikovs at Blue Water Inn, Urwin notices her distress and offers to dispatch a messenger raven to the PCs, which arrives no more than two hours later bearing a note requesting their urgent help.

DEVELOPMENTS

When the PCs arrive, Father Lucian clears out the Church, and proceeds to lead the PCs down into the hidden crypt beneath the stone altar at the head of the sanctuary. There, he reveals the

stone slab where St. Andral's bones once lay, and informs the PCs that the remains must be restored to their previous resting place to re-consecrate the once-hallowed ground.¹³¹

Unlike the module, Father Lucian does not suspect Milivoj to be the culprit. He views the boy as something close to a son, and would never break that trust. However, he and Yeska were out of the Church during the night that he suspects the bones were stolen, and Milivoj was assigned to dig a trio of fresh graves that evening. Lucian hopes that Milivoj may have seen any strangers entering or exiting the Church. Lucian provides the PCs with basic directions to St. Andral's Orphanage, where Milivoj lives, and wishes them luck.

COMPLETING THE QUEST

In order to complete this portion of the quest, the PCs will likely need to complete the **CURSED ORPHANAGE** storyline first. See below for more details on running this subquest. Otherwise, a PC may employ the *Locate Object* spell in order to detect the bones directly.

Once they have uncovered the truth of his crime, the PCs may pursue Milivoj's leads at any one of several locations. Do remember that all clues involving Bluto, Baron Vallakovich, or Lady Wachter are red herrings, and should be presented to force the PCs to either critically examine their clues or waste precious time.

Blue Water Inn: Danika Martikov can inform the PCs that Bluto has not been seen in more than a day, having vanished after boasting of a new "good-luck" charm that he hoped would solve his fishing woes.¹³² She can also relate the recent death of Bluto's wife, a sickly woman named Vanessa. If provided the description of Milivoj's employer, Danika is able to quickly match it to descriptions of Bluto, Henrik van der Voort, and Ernst Larnak (who served as a laborer before his employment to Lady Wachter). Szoldar and Yevgeni can inform the PCs that, after tracking the boys that fled from the Orphanage, they lost the trail close to a favored haunt of the werewolf pack. They believe the boys to be dead, or else taken to the pack's den and turned. Both advise the PCs not to investigate further.

Bluto Krogarov's House: Bluto's neighbor Camilla Veredov, a gossiping dowager arranging pots of sickly-looking flowers, can inform the PCs that Bluto has not been seen in more than a day, having vanished after boasting of a new "good-luck" charm that he hoped would solve his fishing woes. She can also relate the recent death of Bluto's wife, a sickly woman named Vanessa, and believes that the cart left outside his house that night belonged to the local coffin maker, who had delivered the coffin in which Vanessa was buried. Any PC that visits Bluto's house immediately notices that it sits across the street from Wachterhaus, caught in the shadow of the grim, larger structure.

¹³¹ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki IV - The Feast of St. Andral and Tyger](#), Tyger

¹³² butlerlog, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 6/24](#)

Arasek Stockyard: Any exploration of Rictavio's carnival wagon risks setting free the saber-toothed tiger within. The owners of the nearby general store have no knowledge of Milivoj's nighttime meetings, but can pass on their observations of multiple shadows moving behind the upper-floor curtains of Henrik van der Voort's shop - a man who lives quite alone.

Eventually, all clues should point the PCs toward the shop of Henrik van der Voort, Vallaki's sole coffin maker. As written in the module, Henrik refuses to allow the PCs entry to his shop, but quickly cracks if the party forces their way in. He is able to provide the PCs with the following information:

- A dark-skinned woman named Ludmilla approached him several weeks ago, and forced him to discover the source of the church's hallowed ground.
- After Milivoj obtained the secret of the bones of St. Andral, Henrik directed him to steal the bones using funds Ludmilla had provided.
- Ludmilla forced Henrik to house crates containing multiple vampire spawn in his home, both as an incentive to expedite his work and for some dark plot that Henrik doesn't fully understand.
- Two vampire spawn currently rest in a straw-stuffed crate on the upper floor; four others have been relocated to the Town Square.
- The bones of St. Andral are tucked away in a wardrobe on the upper floor, in the room that serves as Henrik's bedchamber. Ludmilla has warned him not to disturb them, threatening grievous harm if he does.

Henrik has not dared to look at the bones since receiving them, and is unaware that Ludmilla has added additional magical protections since their delivery. He does not know Ludmilla's true identity or intentions, and is unsure whether she is a vampire or a mortal servant of Strahd. He does his best to conceal his original willingness to participate in Ludmilla's plots, and portrays himself entirely as a victim, rather than a well-paid (albeit intimidated) proxy.

Should the PCs investigate the vampire spawn, they can evade their notice by succeeding on a DC 14 Stealth (Dexterity) check while approaching the crates. The spawn attack if disturbed or attacked, and can be easily dispatched while asleep using a wooden stake carved from the lumber within Henrik's workshop.

Should the PCs disturb the bones, they trigger a pair of *Glyphs of Warding* placed by Ludmilla as additional insurance. One of the Glyphs casts *Clairvoyance*, which alerts Ludmilla to the PCs' interference. She immediately uses one of her third-level spell slots to cast *Sending*, directing the vampire spawn in the adjacent room to confront those that removed the bones. Both spawn fight to the death, too terrified of Ludmilla's wrath to flee if outmatched.

If the PCs return to the Church of St. Andral in an attempt to restore the bones and after triggering the *Clairvoyance Glyph of Warding* in Henrik's shop, Ludmilla Vilisevic is waiting for them in the pews, disguised as a worshipper. Upon the PCs' arrival, she swiftly takes Father

Lucian hostage - with the aid of a subordinate vampire spawn if the PCs failed to prevent the vampiric rampage before sundown. She attempts to bargain with the PCs for Father Lucian's life, demanding the bones in exchange for his release. If the PCs refuse, she attempts to kill Father Lucian, but diverts her offensive efforts to the PCs once attacked.

Ludmilla's primary goal is the death of the PCs and the recovery of the Bones of Saint Andral. She flees only if reduced to one-half of her maximum hitpoints, or if all of her spell slots are expended. She retains a single level-one spell slot to cast *Disguise Self*, and vanishes into the crowd of Vallakians outside the church. Upon fleeing Vallaki, she returns to Castle Ravenloft in disgrace, where she is scorned by Strahd and sealed within his crypt for her "sloppy, incompetent efforts."

DEVELOPMENTS

If the PCs bring their findings to Baron Vallakovich before confronting Henrik, the Baron assigns four **guards** to independently investigate the shop and recover the bones. Henrik immediately confesses his crimes to the guards, and two guards return to recruit Izek for assistance in destroying the vampire spawn upstairs. The remaining two guards disregard Henrik's warnings and attempt to retrieve the bones themselves, alerting Ludmilla and triggering the events described above. When Izek or the PCs return to the shop, they find both guards and Henrik slaughtered and drained of blood, with the lone vampire nowhere to be found.

If the PCs bring their findings to Baron Vallakovich after confronting Henrik, but before removing the bones, the Baron assigns six **guards** to accompany Izek Strazni on a mission to apprehend Henrik and destroy the vampires within. The cowardly Henrik flees Vallaki for Krezk, and is killed just outside Vallaki's walls by Ludmilla if the bones are disturbed soon after. If one of the PCs has remained at the shop to ensure Henrik's compliance, Izek immediately melts the man's head into slag using his *Hurl Flame* ability as punishment for "high treason."¹³³ Izek is able to dispatch two vampire spawn, though not without the death of all of his men. The remaining vampires remain within the coffin shop, awaiting an opportunity to attack the church at dusk.

If the PCs arrive at Henrik's shop after dusk on the day immediately after the bones are stolen, they are too late to stop the slaughter from beginning. The six vampire spawn have already awoken, attacking the Church of St. Andral, where they slaughter any worshippers present and are soon joined by Ludmilla herself.

If the PCs fail to arrive in time to prevent the rampage of the vampire spawn through Vallaki and two or more locations are destroyed in the ensuing spree, or if the party fails to restore the bones within three days of their arrival, public unrest boils into revolutionary fervor. With Vallaki's rules and customs proven useless against the vampiric menace, the terrified citizens of Vallaki erupt into a riot during a mass burial at the town's cemetery the next day.

Baron Vallakovich and his wife are lynched in the town square and their mansion is burned to the ground. Vallaki's southeastern sector (including Blinsky Toys, the Town Square, and Arasek Stockyard) is scarred horrifically by fire, and the central market district is raided by a plague of panicked looters.

When the dust settles the following morning, following a moot of minor nobles, Lady Fiona Wachter takes over as Baroness - if she is still alive. If not, the town remains a place of lawlessness and quiet terror for the foreseeable future. Many Vallakian citizens rendered homeless by the fires establish refugee tents in and around the Blue Water Inn, avoiding the burnt husk of the Church of Saint Andral. The remaining members of the town guard seize control of the streets and demand exorbitant payments as "tribute" while ruling the ruined settlement like a gang of common thugs.¹³⁴

THE CURSED ORPHANAGE

An orphan raised at St. Andral's Orphanage, Milivoj now lives there as a caretaker, contributing whatever meager earnings he makes from his gravedigging career to provide for the structure's upkeep and the childrens' care. The children love him, and revere him as an elder brother. Milivoj is a jaded, sullen nineteen-year-old, but holds an enormous soft spot for the other residents of the Orphanage.¹³⁵

The Orphanage is home to Milivoj, Headmistress Claudia Belasco and nearly two-dozen orphans. Two months ago, the Orphanage's most recent addition arrived: an eight-year-old boy named Felix. Socially withdrawn and suffering from nightmares of his parents' demise at the claws of a pack of werewolves, Felix drew the sympathy of Milivoj, who took the younger boy under his wing. After receiving his first payment from Henrik van der Voort for investigating the Church of St. Andral, Milivoj provided Felix with a gift included in that reward: a rusted tin locket engraved with an inscription written in Celestial. The inside of the locket is engraved with an inscription in Celestial that means "Let darkness hide from the gaze of the light."

Unbeknownst to Milivoj, Felix, and Henrik, the locket is the prison of a **maurezhi**, a demon summoned and bound long ago by Strahd. Ludmilla Vilisevic provided Henrik with the locket as a means of destroying any evidence of Milivoj's crimes - but did not expect him to give it away. Instead, Felix is the locket's wearer, and his body now serves as a flesh disguise for the cruel fiend within.

From its place within Felix's skin, this demon has been secretly tormenting the other children of the Orphanage, giving them night terrors and feeding off of their vitality, leaving terrible bruising and wounds behind. It is also responsible for the disappearance of another orphan.

134 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#).

135 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki - St. Andral's Orphanage](#).

An atmosphere of fear has shrouded the Orphanage in recent days. Three boys, terrified of their nightmares and fearful of the Headmistress' motivations, recently fled Vallaki for the woods, and are currently captives at the Werewolf Den. Drained and tormented by the demon's hauntings, Milivoj has fallen gravely ill as well. Cedrik possessed no soul, much to the demon's disappointment. However, Milivoj does - and once the demon is strong enough to devour him, it will be freed from its locket prison forever.

More information on the areas of the Orphanage can be found in *N10. St. Andral's Orphanage* below.

Credit for the creation of this section is attributed to /u/MandyMod and her original [guide to the location](#).

BEGINNING THE QUEST

Should the PCs accept the Bones of Saint Andral quest from Father Lucian at the Church of Saint Andral, he will naturally direct them toward Milivoj, the gravedigger, who has not come into work in a few days. The PCs can find Milivoj sick and unconscious in bed in his room at the Orphanage.

If the PCs had an encounter with the hags at Old Bonegrinder, they may leave the windmill with 2-3 new children in tow, including Myrtle, Freek, and Lucian. These children, effectively orphaned, can find a loving, if crowded home at St. Andral's Orphanage.

Finally, if the PCs accepted the Misting Vistana quest from Luvash at the Vistani Encampment, they can learn from Arrigal that Arabelle often snuck into Vallaki to play with the children of the Orphanage during festivals. The orphans can tell the PCs that Arabelle departed after the Wolf's Head Jamboree in the company of a man fitting the description of Bluto Krogarov, the town drunk and local fisherman.

DEVELOPMENTS

When the PCs arrive at the Orphanage, they are greeted in the yard by Headmistress Belasco, who has just finished a solemn discussion with Henrik van der Voort, the coffin maker. Two somber-looking children are also playing in the yard, but their hearts clearly aren't in it. Henrik has just delivered a child-sized coffin for Cedrik, who died two nights ago. As Henrik packs his cart and leaves, Belasco sadly informs the PCs that Milivoj has fallen gravely ill, and is confined to his room. If the PCs push to speak with him, or if one among their number is a healer, Belasco leads them to his room.

Upon arrival in Milivoj's room, the PCs are greeted by Keller and Ema, two of the older children within the Orphanage. Ema sadly informs Belasco that Milivoj has yet to wake after fainting the previous night, and Keller asks the PCs if they have come to cure him. A DC 14 Arcana or Medicine check will reveal that Milivoj's condition is magical in nature, and not contagious. Use of the spell *Detect Magic* reveals an aura of necromancy magic shrouding Milivoj's unconscious

form, while the Divine Sense feature will reveal traces of demonic energies feeding from Milivoj's spirit.

Healing magic and potions have no effect on Milivoj. His illness can only be cured by a Greater Restoration spell or the elimination of the demon.

COMPLETING THE QUEST

If the PCs have impressed Headmistress Belasco with their sympathy, compassion, or intelligence, she takes them into her office and presents what little information she has. Following her discovery of a strange array of runes carved into Cedrik's bedpost, she fears the presence of a spirit or curse within the Orphanage's walls. She believes that the children may know more, but despite her good intentions, fears that her strict and authoritative nature has aroused the orphans' mistrust. Belasco invites the PCs to investigate the Orphanage and inquire with - though not interrogate - the children regarding the recent strange phenomena. Perhaps the orphans will be more likely to trust a friendly stranger than "Belasco the Bully."

Belasco does not suspect Felix to be the culprit, but if asked about him following the PCs' investigation, does reveal her suspicions that the boy may have been driven somewhat mad by his parents' gruesome deaths.

A cursory investigation of the Orphanage will soon direct the PCs' suspicions toward the evidently sociopathic Felix. Upon confronting Felix in his attic hideaway, the PCs must defeat the maurezhi that has devoured him. If the demon successfully destroyed, Milivoj awakes soon thereafter.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the PCs do not cure Milivoj's illness before sundown, the maurezhi devours his body and soul entirely, using its power to break free of the locket forever. The entire population of the orphanage is slaughtered and devoured that same evening. Should the PCs later visit the Amber Temple, they find that the demon has taken up residence in one of the chambers within.

RESIDENTS OF VALLAKI

THE RICH & POWERFUL

THE HOUSE OF VALLAKOVICH

BARON VARGAS VALLAKOVICH

AN UNHAPPY FAMILY

Baron Vargas Vallakovich is the product of his father, a dour, cruel man named Vargon Vallakovich. Vargon ruled Vallaki with an iron fist, and believed that Strahd's presence was punishment for the moral failings of his sinful subjects.

Under Vargon, Vallaki enforced a strict curfew from dusk till dawn. Public torture was commonplace for criminal activity, including public beatings and whippings. Children showing signs of ill temper were taken from their families and re-educated at Vargon's training camp, where they were raised to be cold-hearted, broken members of the town guard.

Vargon Vallakovich died young, at age forty-six. His son, Vargas, took his position as Baron at the young age of twenty-one. Though Vargon's official cause of death was illness, several suspicious circumstances surrounded Vargon's death. However, the young and idealistic Vargas was quick to rescind his father's cruelest laws, and few Vallakians cared to investigate the old tyrant's premature death.

In contrast to his father, Vargas Vallakovich is a man motivated and controlled by fear, absent of any semblance of wisdom or reason. His father, Vargon, took his cruelty home regularly, and often took out his frustrations on his family. Vargas' mother, Lavinia, bore the brunt of her husband's anger, leaving Vargas to watch helplessly as his sense of weakness and self-loathing grew. He watched his mother suffer a string of miscarriages due to Vargon's beatings, leaving Vargas an only child.

Because of his father's abuse, Vargas was raised in an environment of constant fear. As a child, he became extraordinarily careful about his actions and words, perpetually afraid of angering his father unintentionally. Vargon justified his cruelty and abuses to himself and his family with a single scapegoat: the Devil, Strahd von Zarovich. To rid Vallaki of the Devil Strahd, Vargon told his son, strict laws and severe punishments are necessary. No conspiracy or ill behavior was too light to be ignored. Vargas soon came to believe that his father's cruelty was not his own fault, but that of Strahd.

As he grew, Vargas came to believe that all evil in this world could be traced back to Strahd - all sadness, all anger, and all tragedies and hatred. As his delusions grew, he began to see the evil in his own father. As he saw Vargon descend further into cruelty and abuse, Vargas came to believe that his father had become possessed by the Devil, and decided to take action.

On a night when the Baroness' pained whimpers were near drowned out by the noise of the storm outside, Vargas decided to take action. He placed a sleeping draught in his father's drink and smothered the man in his sleep. Strahd, Vargas believed, had been excised from his household forever.

THE MADNESS OF VARGAS VALLAKOVICH

Today, Vargas does not physically abuse his family. However, his harsh childhood instilled him with severe problems with anger and control. He wants Vallaki run in a very specific way; when his designs are ignored or fail, he tends to panic and lash out.

Vargas refuses to lay a hand on his own wife or child. Instead, he limits his outbursts toward those who "deserve it," believing his rage to be a holy implement wielded against the influence of the Devil. Each week, as mentioned above, he selects randomly a dissenter from the stocks and imprisons them at his house. In that time, he takes out all his frustrations on this lone individual, inflicting his father's abuses tenfold.

According to Vargas' delusions, feelings of panic and anger are signs of the Devil. He does his best to conceal those feelings when they stir within him, and roams Vallaki with a constant, strained smile. "All will be well!" has become his catchphrase, bordering on a nervous tic. It is his constant assurance that he is right, that he is succeeding, and that Strahd holds no sway over his heart.

The few happy memories of Vargas' childhood are the festivals held in town, including Yuletide and Spring Coming. He believes that those feelings can be replicated eternally, and so holds his weekly festivals in an effort to stave off the Devil's darkness forever.

BARONESS LYDIA PETROVNA

Lydia Petrovna and Vargas Vallakovich came together under an arranged nature. Lydia's complacent nature appealed to Vargon's controlling tendencies, and his son and new daughter-in-law were married soon thereafter, little more than a year before Vargon's murder.

Lydia is a Morninglord-fearing woman. She is gentle and reserved, and does her utmost to keep "bad thoughts" from her mind. If she observes something violent, disturbing, or painful, she actively suppresses her knowledge of it and enters a state of complete denial.

She has only the most superficial likes and dislikes. She avoids involvement in more complicated matters, and leaves political matters to her husband. She is aware that Vargas makes use of Vallakian prisoners as outlets for his own rage and frustrations, but denies that his

beatings take place - even to herself. Beneath her shell of denial, Lydia fears her husband greatly, and is grateful that he has yet to turn his anger toward her.¹³⁶

BARONET VICTOR VALLAKOVICH

Victor Vallakovich is the eighteen-year-old son of Vargas Vallakovich and Lydia Petrovna, only months younger than the gravedigger, Milivoj. He is a disobedient, irreverent, and irritable young man, and loathes both of his parents. He is also a precociously powerful mage, an eagerly amoral experimenter, and the source of Stella Wachter's insanity.

Due to Vargas' terror at the possibility of repeating his father's mistakes and Lydia's inability to convey any semblance of genuine emotion, Victor has grown up entirely within a cold, neglectful household. He considers his mother a horrid simpleton and his father an ignorant and coldhearted buffoon. As a boy, Victor was isolated from his peers due to his father's status and his own attention-seeking behaviors. As youth became adolescence, that loneliness solidified into resentment and selfishness toward both his family and the rest of Vallaki.¹³⁷

It was an afternoon of utter boredom and self-loathing that drove Victor to explore his father's study for the first time in a lifetime. That day, he made the discovery of a lifetime: an ancient, dog-eared book containing the incantations and instructions for three spells: *Friends*, *Minor Illusion*, and *Charm Person*. He mastered *Minor Illusion* easily, and turned then to the fascinating concept of mental enchantment.

His first use of the *Friends* cantrip was magical - and terrifying. An older, prim-and-proper guard was turned into Victor's personal toy and amusement-maker - for a single minute. If the guard's family hadn't already suspected his wits to be failing, Victor would have been found out and punished for sure. Instead, the older guard soon retired from service for the sake of his mental health, and Victor grew wiser and more cautious in the exercise of his burgeoning arcane power.

It was through independent study that Victor further developed his magic. Gifted with a near-eidetic memory, Victor began to advance his prowess as an enchanter further than he had ever believed possible.

Still, Victor began to question his ambitions. What use were hypnosis and suggestion in a town of fools and thugs? He began to fantasize of achieving what no other wizard had ever achieved: escape from Barovia itself. Beyond its misty walls, surely, he reasoned, there must be some gleaming city worthy of his gifts and control. And so, Victor began to develop his preliminary designs for the *Teleportation Circle* spell.

136 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs I - Establishing Politics, The Baron and Lady Wachter](#)

137 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs I - Establishing Politics, The Baron and Lady Wachter](#)

At the time of the PCs' arrival in Vallaki, Victor Vallakovich is a **mage** with the following spells prepared and recorded in his spellbook:

Cantrips: Friends, Minor Illusion, Frostbite

1st Level (4 slots): Charm Person, Shield, Tasha's Hideous Laughter, Ray of Sickness

2nd Level (3 slots): Suggestion, Misty Step

3rd Level (3 slots): Hypnotic Pattern, Fear, Animate Dead

4th Level (3 slots): Blight, Confusion, Greater Invisibility

5th Level (1 slot): Modify Memory, Dominate Person¹³⁸

Victor also has the **Enchanter's Instinctive Charm** feature:

Instinctive Charm (Recharges after the Enchanter Casts an Enchantment Spell of 1st level or Higher). The enchanter tries to magically divert an attack made against it, provided that the attacker is within 30 feet of it and visible to it. The enchanter must decide to do so before the attack hits or misses.

The attacker must make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. On a failed save, the attacker targets the creature closest to it, other than the enchanter or itself. If multiple creatures are closest, the attacker chooses which one to target.

Additionally, he is responsible for the mysterious disappearance of two of his family's servants in the pursuit of testing his faulty *Teleportation Circle*. He is also the cruel and intentional instigator of Stella's madness, having used her as a test-subject for mind-altering magic repeatedly until she finally broke.

VICTOR AND STELLA

As an early scheme to seize the reins of power in Vallaki without endangering her own position through open revolt, Lady Fiona Wachter employed old favors and newer allies to manufacture an engagement between her daughter, Stella, and the Baron's only son, Victor. The Baron was reluctant to trust Lady Wachter's offer, but ultimately accepted in the hopes that Lady Wachter might be brought to heel if her daughter's livelihood lay beneath his thumb.

Though Stella was an innocent and kind-hearted girl, Fiona pushed her to ingratiate herself into Victor's life. Longing to teach her daughter the ways of manipulating a husband, Lady Wachter forced Stella to return again and again to the Burgomaster's Mansion in the hopes of winning Victor's trust. However, Victor had no plans to allow her to do so.

Resentful toward his parents for pushing Stella into his life, and resentful of Stella for disturbing his concealed research and experimentation, Victor did his best to push Stella away. Stella proved unwilling to disappoint her mother, and remained a constant thorn in Victor's side for the first three days of their engagement. Finally, infuriated with the world and maddened at Stella's

¹³⁸ Matt88, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 7/22 \(](#)

incessant attempts to start a conversation, Victor snapped and cast *Fear* upon her - the first spell since *Friends* that he had cast upon another human being.¹³⁹

As Stella cowered and sobbed in the corner of the attic, Victor panicked at the thought of destroying his cover, alienating a powerful noble, and angering his father. He swiftly cast *Modify Memory*, doing his best to purge her memory of her fear. Stella fled immediately afterward, leaving Victor with a cold, terrified lump in his stomach.

The following morning, an abashed Stella returned to the mansion - and apologized profusely for her outburst the day before. Victor realized that, in his panic, he had only edited the memory of the spell he had cast, leaving behind the memories of Stella's terror. However, without any recollection of the fear's cause, Stella's tale led her mother to dismiss the experience as a silly girl's fit of pique. Stella did her best to accept this explanation, and was quickly horrified at the way she had fled Victor's room the previous night.

Another mage would have taken this stroke of luck as an indication to exercise caution and humility. Instead, Victor was satisfied with the evident success of his spellwork in Stella's mind, and hungry to put the rest of his theoretical magic into practice. Emboldened by his narrow escape and arcane skill, Victor welcomed Stella into his laboratory - and locked the door behind her.

The next several days were a whirlwind of cruel experimentation with Stella's mind, driving Victor's maddened sense of curiosity wild with the endless possibilities that seemed to lie before him. He repeated several tests of the *Fear* spell, erasing the trigger each time using *Modify Memory* while leaving her experience of terror intact. He cast *Phantasmal Force* upon Stella in secret, haunting her with visions and sounds that only she could perceive. *Suggestion* allowed him to exult in the finesse of his control over her mind, and planted the subconscious seed that convinced her to return to him each morning, no matter how barbaric and cruel the previous night had been.¹⁴⁰

Victor's first use of *Dominate Person* was a rush of adrenaline and pride. With a spoken word and a twitch of his hand, Stella was his to control, little more than a puppet dancing from strings upon his fingers. However, cognizant of his inability to cast *Modify Memory* using the mana he had spent on *Dominate Person*, Victor was careful to only push her toward shameful actions that *Suggestion* would easily bury. Uninterested in sex to the point of asexuality, Victor thankfully never abused Stella in that way, but did force her to humiliate herself in painful, terrifying ways. He enjoyed the way she meowed and purred when he commanded her to walk on all fours like one of his skeletal cats, and continued to return to that instruction time and time again.

As Stella slipped slowly into madness, her mother, Lady Wachter, remained fixated on the foothold she seemed to have created in Baron Vallakovich's home. Obsessed with Stella's

139 /u/guildsbounty, [Alternate \(very negative\) take on Victor Vallakovich](#)

140 [Ibed](#).

obvious “success” in gaining Victor’s attention and preoccupied with the machinations of her most trusted cultists, Fiona was simply too distracted to notice or care that her daughter was rapidly growing erratic, confused, and terrified of anything that moved.

Within several weeks of their first meeting, Victor came to the realization that Stella was more of a distraction than a boon to his research. His *magnum opus* - a full-fledged *Teleportation Circle* that should allow egress from Barovia - lay unfinished and underdeveloped. However, a part of Victor could not divorce itself from the cruel joy it gained from touching Stella’s mind with his magic. At the end of the day, she was an excellent means of relieving his stress.

To keep her new strange behavior from distracting him from his studies, Victor employed a number of minor spells to keep her in the company of his skeletal cats. Soon, he decided that her irritating behavior might be reduced if she acted like a cat as well. Victor noted that Stella was growing increasingly receptive to his *Suggestion* spells, her degrading mental state making even more of his requests appear “reasonable.” Before long, Stella found herself slipping into her “role” as “Little Kitty” without any spellwork at all.

One day, Stella didn’t come “out of character” when Victor grew tired of her. Victor was forced to use magic to make her “normal” enough to return home. The next morning, Stella woke up “in character” once more - and didn’t come out.

The widespread belief that Stella’s madness was caused by “cruel words” was an invention of Victor’s, who used magic to persuade his father’s guards that he and Stella had shared a contentious relationship. Soon, the story grew to include several words that Victor said “he regretted,” an argument that swelled into a raging conflict, and Stella’s irrational breakdown flight back to Wachterhaus.

THE JOURNAL OF VICTOR VALLAKOVICH

If the PCs explore Victor’s hidden laboratory in the attic of the Baron’s mansion, they find a tome containing Victor’s experiences, research notes, and spellbook. Several of its entries are as follows:¹⁴¹

Journal Entry #1

My miserable parents have found yet another way to drive me mad. It’s not enough that they drag me down to their meals and force me to sit in on their meetings. No - now they’re finding new ways to ruin my work by shoving this vapid little girl into my life. Her voice, her face, and her very being are pure frustration to me. Surely if I keep trying to work in front of her, she’ll be frightened and tell my parents of my work. How can I remove her?

Journal Entry #2

I might be in trouble. That irritating little girl was sent up into my workroom with me. “Spend

some time with her," Father said; "You need to get to know each other!" I don't want to get to know this stupid girl; I want to be left alone!

She kept trying to talk to me, interrupting what little bits of work I could do in front of her. I finally cast a Fear spell on her to shut her up and drive her away from me. She spent the next minute cowering in the furthest corner of the room. It was only by the time the spell ended that I realized what I had done. She'll tell someone what happened!

I used one of my more difficult spells on her. I MADE her forget her fear. I hope it was enough.

I've never used magic like that on a person before.

Journal Entry #3

I'm not in trouble! I've never been happier to see that round little face at my door. The magic worked! She doesn't know what happened! She actually apologized for her panic attack and for embarrassing herself in front of me and assured me that it "wasn't a regular occurrence."

On the other hand. I'm stuck with her again. But perhaps that's a good thing. I have a lot to learn about magic, after all.

Journal Entry #4

Somehow, I forgot how ignorant this imbecilic town is. I don't know why I worried so much. The stupid girl doesn't know anything about magic. I tried a few more spells on her today, and even before I erased it from her mind, she had no idea what was happening. Still, it's best to be careful.

I couldn't resist pulling a little prank on her, though. As she was leaving the house today, I gave her a little illusion that only she could see. It was pathetic how many people came running to see her scream.

Journal Entry #5

This is incredible! Magic is incredible! I'm like a god! I command her and she obeys; I wish her to be frightened and she is. And all the while, she doesn't even know what is happening!

Today, I finally used a spell on her that I have never been able to actually cast before. It seized control and bent her to my will - she could do nothing that I did not let her, yet she was aware the whole time!

But I've found that that spell uses too much mana to allow me to alter her memory until tomorrow. I decided to kill two birds with one stone: I both got to see the extent to which I

could control her, and embarrassed her enough that it was simplicity itself to plant the idea that she shouldn't keep this incident a secret. It's become so laughably easy to Suggest that she come back in the morning.

Journal Entry #6

As I expected, the stupid Wachter girl crawled back to me this morning, red-faced and quiet. I tidied up her memories, then sent her on her way. I couldn't do anything too blatant to her today, given that I'd already changed her memories once. I decided to have a little fun instead. After a few illusions that no one else could see and a spell to scramble her stupid brain, she caused quite the hilarious scene.

Journal Entry #7

The stupid girl didn't show up today, I guess she's playing sick after her little episode yesterday. That won't do; I have more things I want to test. There's another spell I haven't tried yet. It's supposed to let me enter someone's dreams and control what they see.

Journal Entry #8

Well, it worked. The stupid girl is back. But now that she is, I realize how much of my time she has been taking up. Even under my control, she's still a nuisance. A distraction.

Still, I've learned much about magic because of her. I think I'll just have her play with the cats while I work.

Journal Entry #9

The girl is getting annoying again. She's acting strange and can't seem to keep a straight thought in her head until I pound her stupid brain into shape with a spell. Still, at least she's becoming more responsive to my Suggestion spells; I don't have to work twice as hard to twist her mind as I did a week ago.

Playtime with the cats isn't enough to keep her out of my hair. Maybe I can get her to pretend she is a cat. Meowing doesn't distract me.

Journal Entry #10

This is excellent. The girl stays out of my way, a quick spell shoves her into her role as a cat, and from there she obeys without a single other spell. I can finally focus on what's important -

and she's still handy if I become frustrated. Even when my work is at its hardest, it's always satisfying to see my power in action.

Journal Entry #11

Father says the stupid girl isn't coming back. Apparently, she woke up stuck in her role, still acting like a cat. I suppose this was bound to happen eventually. Her stupid little brain just couldn't handle magic like mine can. Some of Father's guards wanted to ask me what happened. It was easy to convince them that I'd had some arguments with the stupid girl, said some things I regret, and that her own delicate constitution had done the rest.

Ignorant, weak-willed idiots.

It's a shame, too. I'd finally gotten used to her. I guess I can admit that when she wasn't annoying me, she was a nice piece of scenery to have around. Maybe once I finish my work, I'll take her with me. She's already shown herself a good test subject, and it would be a nuisance to have to break another one in.

Journal Entry #12

I think it's ready. Maybe now I can finally get out of this place. It's a shame that girl isn't here. I could have her try it out for me. I'm certainly not testing it first. Perhaps one of the servants might prove useful.

Journal Entry #13

Evidently, it's not ready. Will keep trying.

Journal Entry #14

What am I doing wrong?

IZEK STRAZNI

Izek is Baron Vallakovich's Captain of the Guard, and is quite dedicated to his job. He is quick to act against threats to the Baron, and happy to shut down any public displays of malcontent. Most Vallakians fear him, including his own subordinates. His mere presence brims with authority, in sharp contrast to the Baron's snobbish, cowardly personality.¹⁴²

Soon after his father's death, Baron Vargas Vallakovich found Izek Strazni lost and orphaned in the woods near Vallaki. He saw Izek's arm as a physical version of his own anger: a sin of their parents that both must bear. Unable to give the boy up to the orphanage, Vargas brought Izek into his own household, and raised him as his own.¹⁴³

¹⁴² /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

¹⁴³ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs II - The Blue Water Inn and Izek Strazni](#)

Izek holds the Baron in the highest regard. While Izek doesn't hold all of Vallakovich's beliefs regarding Strahd and the festivals, he considers himself duty-bound to carry out the Baron's will upon the town. He is loyal to a fault - save where his true sibling is concerned.

Since Izek entered manhood, Baron Vallakovich has grown to rely heavily on his service, both militarily and emotionally. Vargas views Izek as his right-hand, as his confidante, and as his personal protector. If Izek is slain, Vallakovich dresses one of his bulkier guards in Izek's clothing and places red-painted padding around the guard's arm in an effort to fool his citizens into believing that Izek is still alive.¹⁴⁴

A DARK POWER'S BLESSING

Izek's arm was at once a gift and temptation from the Dark Powers, who saw the vast potential for cruelty present in the boy and restored his missing limb with the arm of a barbed devil when he reached adolescence. Over time, Izek has honed his sadism to a fine point, allowing him finer control over the powers granted by his demonic arm.

Should Izek live long enough, he will soon begin to descend into acts of increasing barbarity. If Izek harms his sibling in any way, he gains the Barbed Devil's *Barbed Hide* feature, and an appearance to match it. If the PCs push Izek to commit other atrocities, especially crimes against innocents, he gains the Devil's *Devil's Sight* and *Magic Resistance* abilities. Once both abilities are obtained, if he still lives, the Dark Powers invite Izek to travel to the Amber Temple. Upon his arrival, Izek communes with the Powers in the dark chambers of the Temple, emerging with the appearance of a full Barbed Devil, an additional 50 hit points, and the ability to make three Battleaxe attacks or two Hurl Flame attacks when he takes his Multiattack action.¹⁴⁵

THE SIBLINGS STRAZNI

From the time of the tragedy that killed his parents, Izek has been haunted by dreams of his lost sibling. The dreams resemble a dark void containing a blurry figure; as Izek approaches the figure, it slowly becomes more resolved until its details are crystal-clear - but vanishes when he reaches out to touch it. As the years have rolled by, the figure has aged accordingly, allowing Izek to watch his lost sibling grow up day-by-day.¹⁴⁶

His sibling was never found by the residents of Vallaki. Though he has been told otherwise by the Baron and the older generation of Vallaki, Izek adamantly believes that his dreams mean that his lost sibling still lives.

As-written, Izek's sibling is in truth the adopted daughter of Burgomaster Kolyan Indirovich of Barovia, known to the PCs as Ireena Kolyana. However, if you chose to make one of your PCs

144 /u/cudder23, [Party may leave Vallaki before anything has really happened...](#)

145 /u/guildsbounty, [Useful/Optional Fluff \(collated by me\)](#)

146 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs II - The Blue Water Inn and Izek Strazni](#)

an orphan or former resident of Barovia, you may wish to make that PC Izek's sibling instead, especially if that PC is human or a tiefling.

Since adolescence, Izek has used the income from his work with the Baron's guard to commission dolls of his sibling from Gadof Blinsky, the toymaker. Izek keeps hundreds of these dolls mounted on shelves in his room at the Burgomaster's Mansion, and has grown to obsess with the idea of his lost sibling to a point bordering on worship.

If presented with his sibling - even if that sibling has dyed their hair or made other superficial changes to their appearance - Izek recognizes them immediately. From that point on, Izek begins plotting to recover the relationship that he has been denied for the past two decades.

There are two potential ways that you can run Izek's actions from this point onward. He can be an antagonist to the PCs, committing horrific acts in his pursuit to take his sibling for himself. Alternatively, he can serve as a strange ally to the party, defending his sibling from the Baron's wrath while doing his best to continue his responsibilities as usual.

Your mileage may vary in either case, depending on the kind of game you want to run and the kind of Vallakian environment you choose to manufacture. However, generally speaking, Izek is preferred as an ally if one of the PCs is his sibling (in order to preserve player agency); and excels as an antagonist if Irenea Kolyana remains his sister (in order to maximize tension and conflict). Additionally, if you choose to make Izek the party's foretold ally in Madam Eva's Tarokka reading, it becomes almost necessary to play him in a friendlier, more diplomatic way.

Antagonist. If you choose to play Izek as an antagonist, from the moment he lays eyes on his sibling, his only desire is to see them by his side - even if by force - and to eliminate all others that may come in his way. In this state, Izek is fiercely territorial of this sibling's interest and affections, and may believe that the only way to truly rebuild his relationship is the death of all others who may compete for his sibling's love. Due to his obsession, Izek covets his sibling in an unwholesome - though non-sexual - way, and won't allow anyone or anything to come between them.

The next time his sibling is alone, asleep, or otherwise vulnerable (whether in the Blue Water Inn or Saint Andral's Church), Izek attempts to take them by force to the Burgomaster's Mansion, where he plans to hold them captive in his bedroom. If the PCs are outside of Vallaki at this time, Izek orders the guards to bar the gates to them, forcing the party to assault or sneak past the town's walls to enter.¹⁴⁷ If the PCs are in Vallaki when his sibling is kidnapped, Izek doubles the guards outside the Burgomaster's Mansion and soon tries to arrest the PCs on trumped-up charges once it becomes clear that his sibling won't give up their loyalties easily.

Ally. When Izek finds his long-lost sibling, he recognizes them immediately and greets them with an unnerving level of elation and interest. Any nearby guards and commoners are disturbed by his obvious joy, and quickly make themselves scarce.

147 /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Vallaki](#)

The PCs will probably meet Izek during a scuffle with some of the Baron's guards after breaking one of Vallaki's many laws. If swords are drawn in Vallaki's walls, Izek will arrive fairly quickly. If the party is accused of a minor offense, he will use his authority to excuse the party's wrongdoings and do his best to bring them to the Burgomaster's Mansion, where he promises they will be safe while he catches up with his sibling. After all, any friend of theirs is a friend of his, and the Baron is happy to entertain guests if Izek approves of them.

If the PCs break a major law, Izek will do his best to follow the law and keep his sibling safe. If a PC commits a notable crime - such as killing or grievously wounding a guard in a scuffle - Izek still happily invites the party to the Burgomaster's Mansion. He then quietly locks the criminal PC in the secret closet containing Udo Lukovich, the shoemaker, where they are to await the arrival of the guards for exile from Vallaki. Izek does his best to keep his sibling ignorant of the criminal's fate, claiming that they left the mansion to explore Vallaki, or that they have departed the town entirely.

If, by chance, the worst criminal of the party is Izek's sibling, he will actively betray Vallaki for their sake. He will not use lethal force when dealing with the Baron's guards, but will happily cut through scores of enemies to keep his sibling safe.¹⁴⁸ If all else seems lost, he offers to escort his sibling and their companions to Krezk himself.

If Izek is the party's foretold ally, or if the party offers him the choice to journey with them alongside his sibling and succeeds on a DC 15 Persuasion (Charisma) check, Izek throws away his loyalty to the Baron in an instant and follows his sibling wherever they may travel.¹⁴⁹ If this occurs, Izek is likely to struggle with his darker nature and violent impulses, and may be further corrupted by the Dark Powers should the party fail to prevent his fall.¹⁵⁰

THE HOUSE OF WACHTER

LADY FIONA WACHTER

DISENCHANTMENT AND DEVILS

The bright and charming scion of the ancient house of Wachter, Lady Fiona grew up in a politically tumultuous Vallaki. Vargas' father, Baron Vargon Vallakovich, ruled Vallaki as a police state, setting early curfews and strict, barbaric punishments. Fiona was privately optimistic when the young Vargas Vallakovich succeeded his father, but quickly disappointed when his idealism proved a mask for his more secretive, chaotic rule.

As a young woman, Fiona grew to despise the rulers of Vallaki, unable to comprehend the sway that their atrocities could hold over the town. Compared to the violence and fear of her

148 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

149 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs II - The Blue Water Inn and Izek Strazni](#)

150 /u/guildsbounty, [Useful/Optional Fluff \(collated by me\)](#)

childhood, a distant vampire lord hardly seemed a threat. At age fifteen, she persuaded her parents to sanction a trip to the village of Barovia - a political pilgrimage, she assured them, to strengthen the family's ties to their southern neighbor.

Unbeknownst to her parents, Fiona was determined to meet the "Devil" whose horror had driven her home to madness. She attempted to persuade her escort to allow a brief detour to Castle Ravenloft, and when that failed, slipped away in the night and vanished across the drawbridge.

Strahd had little interest in the young Fiona, but served as a gentlemanly host throughout her brief visit. Her intellect and natural charm intrigued him, and while he found her natural beauty lacking, he offered her a place among his consorts - as a vampire.

Fiona politely - and carefully - declined. However, she was impressed by Strahd's reserved nature, and quickly decided that this "monster" was far less monstrous than the man that ruled her home. She countered with an offer: She would depart Castle Ravenloft as a mortal, and instead serve his interests from within Vallaki's walls. Strahd agreed to this tentative alliance, and provided her with two gifts: a tome on diabolic magic; and an imp bonded as her familiar.

It was hours later that an innocent Fiona rejoined her escort, and resumed her journey to Barovia. Her time in the village was brief, though she befriended the young burgomaster, a handsome man named Kolyan Indirovich.

FIONA'S PROPHECY

On the road back to Vallaki, Fiona bullied her guards into a final detour: Tser Pool Encampment. Driven by a passing whim to meet the famous Madam Eva, Fiona was impressed by the warm welcome she received from the Vistani, and soon found herself within Eva's tent.

From her Tarokka deck, Madam Eva drew three cards: the Hooded One; the Executioner; and the Healer. Thus she spoke:

"I see an outsider - a foreigner to this land. They are the Hooded One, the stranger whose arrival will mark a new age within Vallaki's walls"

"The Executioner marks the coming of a great ruin. The coming of this outsider will bring a purge upon this land like no other."

"In the hands of the Healer, there is a purifying flame. When the ruin has finished, and the land has been torn asunder, the sword of the outsider will shed sunlight on Vallaki yet again."

Like most fortunes, this reading was vague and far-reaching. Yet in that instant, Fiona felt her eyes open like never before. She latched onto Madam Eva's fortune and it became her obsession.

LADY WACHTER'S FOLLOWING

Today, Lady Fiona Wachter commands the respect of her “book club” with her wit, her charm, and her natural charisma. The Wachters have long maintained a base of support within the walls due to their philanthropic efforts, and Fiona has made a point of continuing them. From her charitable work for the poor and sick of Vallaki, she has created a faction all her own, and through them spread the word of her prophecy.

Though the bulk of her followers believe that the Outsider will destroy Strahd and so free Vallaki, Lady Wachter's visit to Ravenloft has persuaded her that Strahd is not the evil that the Outsider must destroy. Instead, she - and a small group of Vallakians that have become her inner circle - believes that the Outsider will kill the Vallakovich line, root and branch. Once Vallaki has been purged of the Baron's poison, she will bring peace to Vallaki beneath the “sunlight” of her own rule.

RUNNING FIONA WACHTER

Lady Fiona Wachter is quite the opposite of the arrogant, neurotic Baron Vallakovich. Her manner is both comforting and commanding, and she never raises her voice. She prefers to listen, rather than speak, and speaks only in a calm, unhurried manner. The only hint to her hidden, darker nature is the near-religious fervor to her words and her obsession with a “purge” of blood and the unclean.

Wachter is the only person in Vallaki who will call Strahd by name, even in defiance of the Baron's laws. She has no fear of the Devil, and privately sees no monster in the land but Vargas himself. She believes that Vargas' fear of Strahd is merely an excuse to bolster his own power, and that Vargas actively sows that fear to sway the citizens of Vallaki away from thoughts of rebellion. At worst, Fiona believes Strahd to be a “negligent landlord,” but shares this only with her most trusted associates.¹⁵¹

Fiona Wachter is cool, calculating, and knows how to manipulate others. However, she is no sociopath. Her late husband, Nikolai, was her world. They met when she was sixteen, and he nineteen. Nikolai was a banker's apprentice, but his interest in and support for Fiona's goals and beliefs easily won her heart.

The two fell madly in love, much to the chagrin of Fiona's parents. Fiona threatened to elope if they weren't allowed to marry. Rather than suffer such a scandal, her parents allowed it - under one condition: that Nikolai adopt Fiona's surname, and so join her household. Weeks later, the two were married.

Lady Wachter's three children - Nikolai II, Karl, and Stella - are her life's great loves. She has done her best to nurture them, and has watched as the three have grown into largely capable young adults. Fiona loathes herself for allowing Victor Vallakovich to destroy Stella's sanity, and holds a personal grudge against the Baron's house.

151 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki III - Running the Mansion and Wachterhaus](#)

All the same, Fiona is, at her core, a woman of strong beliefs and stronger ambitions. While it would tear her apart to do so, if the only way to destroy the Vallakovich regime was the murder of her own child, she would seize the knife herself and see the task through.¹⁵²

STELLA WACHTER

Before her mental breakdown at the hands of Victor Vallakovich, Stella Wachter was a sweet, kindly girl. She was patient, well-mannered, and eager to please those around her. These attributes, of course, made her easy prey for Victor's manipulations. Nikolai and Karl could only occasionally persuade Stella to join them on their nightly revelries, but Stella never truly enjoyed them. Though she is the youngest of the three Wachter children, Stella often found herself chastising and looking out for her older brothers.

NIKOLAI II & KARL WACHTER

Karl and Nikolai (II) Wachter are the heirs to the ancient line of the house of Wachter. As such, they spend their time doing everything in their power to avoid that responsibility. Over the past several years, Nikolai and Karl have acquired a reputation as drunkards, revelers, pranksters, and generally promiscuous. However, while they may be irresponsible and crude, neither brother would ever intentionally hurt an innocent, either physically or emotionally. Both brothers despise Victor Vallakovich for his crimes against their younger sister, though, and would happily cause him harm if they thought they could get away with it.

The two brothers prefer to avoid the politics of Vallaki. While they maintain a respected position among the Dominionists due to their familial ties, both Karl and Nikolai are uncomfortable with their mother's followers and do their best to keep away from any sociopolitical events. Were they to discover Fiona's sacrificial rites or the depth of her loyalty to Strahd - or even the fact that she has preserved their father's corpse in the master bedroom - both would be horrified.¹⁵³

ERNST LARNAK

Ernst Larnak is a callous, cruel man motivated primarily by gold and his own dark amusements. While Lady Wachter finds his lecherous and irreverent personality unpleasant and unbecoming, she nonetheless tolerates him due to his many connections throughout Vallaki's underbelly, as well as his own unmatched skill as a forger and informant. He is well-paid by Lady Wachter's house - a rate of one hundred gold pieces a year - and fears her enough that he will only consider betraying her for a sum three times that amount.

152 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs I - Establishing Politics, The Baron and Lady Wachter](#)

153 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs I - Establishing Politics, The Baron and Lady Wachter](#)

THE KNOWLEDGEABLE & WELL-CONNECTED

THE CHURCH OF SAINT ANDRAL

FATHER LUCIAN PETROVICH

In contrast to Father Donavich of Barovia, Father Lucian is a warm and welcoming man who has dedicated his entire life to the service of the Morninglord. However, any PC that spends time with him will soon discover a strong fanatical streak to the man's faith, which often culminates in the attribution of the PCs' hard work and efforts to the favor of the Morninglord, or the well-intended critique of others who seem to lack sufficient faith. Father Lucian's religiosity is so forceful as to border on irritating, but is so obviously old and broken that the party can clearly tell that his faith is all he has left.

Lucian's fanatical personality stems from his experiences with the darker natures of Vallaki's residents. As head of the local church, he provides private confessional services twice monthly, receiving and sealing to silence the most monstrous secrets of his neighbors. Bound by faith never to divulge the knowledge confessed in this way, he has been driven close to madness after decades of fruitless preaching.

Lucian knows the following pieces of information, and can only be persuaded to share them with a DC 25 Persuasion (Charisma) check. A Deception or Intimidation check will always fail to evince the desired information.

- Vargon Vallakovich abused his family before his death (Source: Vargon Vallakovich)
- Baron Vargas Vallakovich murdered his father (Source: Vargas Vallakovich)
- Fiona Wachter's cult practices ritual sacrifice in the basement of Wachterhaus (Source: Ivana Mironova)
- Fiona Wachter keeps the corpse of her late husband in her bedchamber (Source: Ernst Larnak)

MILIVOJ

The nineteen-year-old Milivoj is a moody, jaded young man. A former orphan at St. Andral's Orphanage, Milivoj contributes the bulk of his earnings as the town's gravedigger toward the care of the other children remaining there. His foster siblings adore him, a relationship that he secretly treasures despite his own misgivings about his self-worth.

As an orphan with no family, no inheritance, and no education. Milivoj has few prospects. Though Father Lucian has done his best to teach the young man to read and write, Milivoj has stubbornly stuck to his gravedigging job, an occupation that few other Vallakians wish to do. Milivoj bears no fondness for his work, but values the higher wage he earns from the public coffers compared to similar menial labor.¹⁵⁴

154 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: The Church of St. Andral's NPCs and the Mechanics of Hallowed Ground](#)

YESKA

Yeska is the altar boy at St. Andral's, and the product of a tragic history. When Yeska was four years old, his mother brought him to confession on the night of the full moon. Yeska's mother - unstable and maddened with sorrow and self-loathing - confessed how she had abandoned the boy's father after he was bitten by a werewolf in the woods outside Vallaki. She then slit her throat and bled out on the altar, still cradling the bawling Yeska in her other arm.

Father Lucian took Yeska in from a sense of misplaced guilt. Unable to save the boy's mother, he reasoned that he might be able to save the boy in her place. As a result, he raised the boy as his own, and was delighted to find him an intelligent, dutiful child.

Now approaching ten years of age, Yeska is a wide-eyed, fearful, and scrawny little boy. He completes each of his chores with a constant nervous energy, and is easily intimidated or frightened.¹⁵⁵

THE KEEPERS OF THE FEATHER

The Keepers of the Feather are the sole organization actively working against Strahd in Barovia, and the Martikov family sits at the core of the operation. As the largest single family in Barovia, as well as the sole purveyors of the Wizard of Wines winery, members of the Martikov family can find a welcome place near everywhere they go.¹⁵⁶ As a secret society, the Keepers of the Feather are largely unknown by the average Barovian and Vistani. Strahd is aware of them, but allows their work to continue for his own amusement.

While wereravens are immune to direct weapon damage, they can be overwhelmed and killed in other ways. In Barovia, the Keepers of the Feather are heavily outnumbered by creatures that would kill them if given the chance. As such, they prefer to avoid direct combat wherever possible.

A NETWORK OF RAVENS

Functionally, the Keepers of the Feather operate as a decentralized spy network that employs the local raven population within the valley as spies and messengers. Because a wereraven can speak with natural ravens while transformed, the birds themselves can carry simple verbal messages to other agents throughout Barovia.

All natural ravens in Barovia reflexively defer to the Keepers of the Feather, but not all ravens are actively employed as spies or messengers. The Keepers do, however, maintain several hosts of ravens throughout the region assigned to warn travelers of danger; monitor specific enemies (including Baba Lysaga, the werewolves, and the hags of Old Bonegrinder); and inform the Keepers of the entry of any outsiders into Barovia. The reports provided by the natural

¹⁵⁵ [Ibed.](#)

¹⁵⁶ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki NPCs II - The Blue Water Inn and Izek Strazni](#)

ravens tend to be simplistic, and require confirmation by a Keeper agent if further investigation is merited.

Barovia is host to a scattering of Nests, which house a group of wereravens who “command” a resident flock of ravens. The Blue Water Inn is one such Nest, as is the Wizard of Wines (though not all Nests lie in civilized areas, or even human-built structures). The leader of an individual Nest has a large amount of autonomy, but ultimately reports any notable information to Urwin Martikov, the spymaster of the Keepers and the owner of the Blue Water Inn in Vallaki.

There are limits to the knowledge of the Keepers of the Feather. Ravens tend to avoid entering homes or similar structures, both for reasons of subtlety and instinct. The Keepers are aware of any movement between towns, and are generally kept informed of notable events in the wilderness of Barovia.¹⁵⁷

RUNNING THE KEEPERS

The Keepers of the Feather were formed two centuries past to support one of the earliest rebellions against Strahd von Zarovich. While that revolt failed, the Keepers were able to fade quietly into the background, and have worked subtly against the Devil’s machinations ever since.

Any non-evil party interested in bringing about Strahd’s downfall will have the wereravens’ support. This support, however, will not always be obvious. Earlier on, the Keepers will do their best to aid the PCs without revealing their true nature. Members of the Keepers of the Feather may act as “quest givers,” pointing the party toward hidden secrets, potential allies, or notable dangers. Danika and Urwin Martikov especially can provide intelligence to the party in the form of rumors. If the party is stripped of gear, the Keepers will personally see that their belongings are restored.

Once the PCs have proved their worth - likely through the destruction of Old Bonegrinder or the restoration of the Wizard of Wines winery - the Keepers may reveal themselves, though they will maintain the secret of their lycanthropy. They will present themselves as a secret society that opposes Strahd, training ravens as messengers and spies. At this stage, the PCs will be able to use the Keepers to send messages around the region, scout out dangerous locations, and receive occasional updates of current events elsewhere in Barovia.

The Keepers of the Feather are hesitant to reveal their lycanthropic nature, or to commit to physically fighting alongside the party. The PCs are not the first adventurers that the Keepers have assisted, and the Keepers would rather they not be the last. The Keepers’ central goal is the maintenance and expansion of their intelligence network; should the PCs fail, the Martikovs and their allies will do their best to retrieve their gear, consolidate their findings, and prepare for the next group of adventurers.

Only in the most critical of situations will the Keepers voluntarily reveal their lycanthropy to the PCs. Even then, any physical aid they provide will be limited to tactics and mobility alone. A pair of wereravens in hybrid form can provide an emergency airborne evacuation to any single PC.¹⁵⁸

Under no circumstances will the Keepers of the Feather offer to spread their lycanthropy to a PC. Unlike the werewolves, the control they exercise over their lycanthropic nature is a gift from the Ladies of the Fanes, Stribog, obtained through intimate rituals and months of transformation and meditation. A Keeper of the Feather would sooner die than allow their gift to be stolen and misused by a PC with no appreciation for the care and control it requires.

What the Wereravens Know

Old Bonegrinder. The Keepers of the Feather know that Morgantha and her children are, in truth, a coven of hags that abduct children and bake addictive pastries from their bones. They are fully aware that open combat against the hags is suicide, and instead do their best to rescue any children when the coven is absent or distracted. A raven is permanently stationed near the windmill, and makes an effort to warn away any travelers who approach the structure. As the Keepers are careful to always operate in raven form around Old Bonegrinder, the hags have not yet been able to ID them, though the coven harbors a deep mistrust of the ravens of Barovia.

The Werewolf Den. The Keepers are peripherally aware of the recent schism in the werewolf pack, and that Kiril's leadership has led to a surge in new captives for the werewolves to turn. The wereravens have thus far been unable to intervene - while neither lycanthrope can truly harm the other, the werewolves are stronger, and could easily grapple and bind any wereraven that openly attacked.

Currently, the Keepers are focused on observation, gathering all of the intelligence they can in the hopes that a group of skilled individuals can be directed toward the Den.

Lady Wachter. The Keepers of the Feather are as well-informed of Lady Fiona Wachter's beliefs and aspirations as any other member of the town, but are ignorant to any of her true secrets. They are horrified at Stella's current mental state, as the girl used to watch Brom and Bray while Danika and Urwin were minding the taproom.

Baron Vallakovich. The Keepers are well aware of the excesses of Vargas Vallakovich. The Martikovs take it upon themselves to smuggle food and drink to those people locked up in the stocks, and do their best to defuse or conceal any situations that may invoke his wrath. Despite Lady Wachter's position as the likeliest person to take control of the town, the Martikovs mistrust her judgment and motivations. The order has historically remained neutral in political matters for fear that intervention will destroy the integrity and secrecy of their organization, and will not take action against either faction's leader without good reason.

The Abbey of St. Markovia. The Keepers are vaguely aware of the twisted nature of the Abbey's current inhabitants. Several flocks of ravens have previously observed the mongrelfolk,

and the Abbot has been a subject of personal interest to a scattering of wereravens over the past century since he arrived in Barovia. However, both mongrelfolk and Abbot appear relatively benign, and so the Abbey is subject to only the occasional observation.

Argynvostholt. The Keepers know of the revenants of Argynvostholt, and know a small amount of the place's history. They know that several revenants haunt the dark paths of the Svalich Wood in search of Strahd's servants, but are wary of Vladimir Horngard, whose opposition to Strahd's enemies resulted in the failure of an attempted alliance decades previously. Both the revenants and phantom warriors that fight under Horngard's command are lethal even to lycanthropes, so the Keepers tend to keep their distance.

Tsolenka Pass & the Amber Temple. The slopes of Mount Ghakis are far too cold for ravens to visit. All the Keepers have are rumors of an ancient treasure said to be lost amidst the mountain's peak. They will warn any travelers of the Roc of Mount Ghakis, and advise the PCs to purchase warm clothing before climbing the winding mountain pass.

Van Richten's Tower. The wereravens are aware of Rictavio's residence within the tower at Lake Baratok prior to his arrival in Vallaki. While they are suspicious of his motivations, and know that his appearance is a magical disguise, the Martikovs have thus far allowed him to remain as a guest at the Blue Water Inn, though he remains under close surveillance. They have largely avoided the tower, however, wary of the arcane traps and dangers that may lie within.

The Wizard of Wines. The Martikovs are aware of the blight infestation at the winery, but are powerless to clear it out. The druids of Yester Hill have never controlled an army of this size, and the blights within and without easily outnumber those wereravens capable of combat. Due to Urwin's feud with his father Davian, Danika and Urwin Martikov have been kept in the dark regarding the winery's current situation, and are currently hoping to steer a group of adventurers toward the winery to investigate the reason for the delayed shipment

URWIN MARTIKOV

Urwin Martikov is Davian Martikov's second-born son; the current spymaster of the Keepers of the Feather; and the owner of the Blue Water Inn. He is well-known and well-respected in Vallaki, and maintains the current intelligence of the wereravens of Barovia.¹⁵⁹

Because of his skill as a cook and his place at the Inn, Urwin has friends throughout the town of Vallaki. He can easily gather - or spread - rumors without arousing suspicion from the Loyalists or Dominionists.

As a person, Urwin Martikov is one of the few genuinely nice residents of Barovia. He is kind-hearted, selfless, and willing to forgive nearly any transgression. He is able to see the best in the worst of people, and maintains a personal code of strict nonviolence. If Vargas Vallakovich, Fiona Wachter, or even Strahd himself required a kind word in their defense, Urwin would be

among the first to speak. He is quick to give aid to those in need, freely providing room and board at the Inn for those with nowhere else to go. Without Danika's business-savvy mind, Urwin's generosity may have driven the Blue Water Inn into bankruptcy long ago.

DANIKA MARTIKOV

Danika Martikov is the Blue Water Inn's bartender, waitress, and accountant. As the face of the Inn's taproom, she has gained an expertise with gossip and rumors like no other in Barovia. She collects information like a collector might gather stamps - and is exceptionally skilled at doing so.¹⁶⁰

Unlike her kind-hearted husband, Danika sees herself as a realist. She is slower to trust strangers, but is always willing to give a newcomer a chance if she believes their heart to be in the right place. Regardless, Danika is always happy to chat with any who enter her bar, from the dour fisherman Bluto to Izek Strazni himself. Any PC should find her both relatable and easy to talk to, two traits that are strengthened by Danika's uncanny ability to read others' emotions.

Danika's love for her husband and children outweighs all else in her life. She would let the world burn before allowing any harm to come to Brom or Bray, and adores Urwin with all her heart. She admires her husband's kindness, and often defers to him in charitable matters.

BROM & BRAY MARTIKOV

Brom and Bray are eleven and seven years old, respectively. Patrons of the Blue Water Inn know them as harmless pranksters and generally adorable children. As such, the tavern's customers tend to ignore their presence, which allows both boys to easily eavesdrop on conversations while "playing" with a favorite Blinsky toy. Even if they're caught hiding beneath a table, most patrons won't suspect anything beyond a youthful proclivity for mischief.¹⁶¹

Brom and Bray have turned their spying into a brotherly game and competition. They make constant efforts to push the limits of their sneakiness, with each attempting to one-up the other on information they overhear, places they slip into, or items they are able to snatch. At the end of each week, Urwin and Danika declare one of the boys their most useful informant, a contest that entertains and motivates the two to no end.

At times when the boys have pushed their boundaries too far - for instance, playing near the stocks or irritating a drunk Izek Strazni - Urwin and Danika have done their best to rescue their children and chide them appropriately. The boys have learned that spying can be a wonderful game, but have also learned that they are to scam at the first sign of trouble, or else be grounded for a month.

Both Brom and Bray are resourceful children, having learned a number of tricks from their many "Aunties" and "Uncles" among the Keepers of the Feather. They are able to use their youth to

160 [Ibed.](#)

161 [Ibed.](#)

manipulate many adults with ease, though Danika and Urwin are able to see through their wiles without a moment of hesitation.

THE OUTSIDERS & OUTCASTS

THE ORPHANAGE OF SAINT ANDRAL

HEADMISTRESS CLAUDIA BELASCO

A shrewd woman in her early fifties, Ms. Belasco loves propriety and order. She wears her grey-streaked brown hair up in a tight bun, and has developed fine wrinkles around her mouth from years of disapproving frowns.

The previous headmistress of the Orphanage was an older woman named Victoria Moldovar, who passed away six months ago. Belasco was previously a caretaker for the children before Ms. Moldovar passed away, but has struggled to control the children as Victoria did, and has resorted to stricter rules and punishments. As such, the orphans have grown particularly resentful of Ms. Belasco, the primary source of discipline in the house. They've taken to calling her "Belasco the Bully" behind her back, and swapping stories of Ms. Belasco eating naughty children for her meals.

Despite her harshness and abrasive nature, Ms. Belasco cares for her children very much. She is still struggling with the idea of being liked in return. Still, so long as the children are safe and healthy, she will dish out as many lectures and confiscations as she sees fit.

If the players get on her good side, possibly by showing their similar and heartfelt concern for the orphans, she'll share what little information she's gathered.

FELIX

Felix has only lived at the orphanage for little more than six months. Prior to his arrival, Felix was the son of a pair of gardeners who tended a grove of apple trees just outside of Vallaki. However, on one fateful full moon, his parents were slaughtered by wolves, leaving the sobbing Felix to flee for the town as his parents bled out onto the forest floor.

For months, Milivoj noticed that Felix was withdrawn, shy, and isolated. In an attempt to bond with him, the ever-awkward Milivoj provided him a gift: a rusted tin locket engraved with an inscription written in Celestial. However, that same locket was the prison for a shadow demon native to the Shadowfell, and that demon's dark consciousness soon dominated Felix's own.

Felix's demon was sealed within the locket by a cleric who was unable to conquer it. While the demon has great power now that it has a humanoid vessel, it is still not technically free of the locket. Only by devouring an exceptionally strong soul can it finally find release. The illness that

is slowly killing Milivoj is actually the draining of his soul. When Milivoj dies, the ritual will be complete and the demon will slaughter the residents of the orphanage.

Currently, Felix isn't Felix - he's the demon. He acts like a young sociopath with a talent for lying and falsehoods. His emotional range is quite shallow and he shows almost no sympathy for the plights of others, even smiling if Cedrik's death is mentioned. If approached, he speaks monotonously, and with great disinterest, but quickly descends into a volatile emotional state if questioned or challenged.

CEDRIK

Now deceased, Cedrik was a mischievous troublemaker while alive. An orphan from birth, Cedrik soon learned that his attention-seeking activities were the easiest and fastest way to receiving attention from the adults around, even if that attention was more negative than positive. As a result, he became a bully toward some of the other children at the Orphanage. While he never injured another child, it was common for Cedrik to be punished for the theft of another child's toy or cruel, taunting words said toward a fellow orphan.

On the day before the PCs' arrival in Vallaki, Cedrik stole Felix's locket from around his neck while he was sleeping. The shadow demon possessing Felix was enraged by the theft, and pushed Felix to steal the locket back before pushing Cedrik out of a second-story window. Cedrik died upon impact. Currently his body is kept in storage in the basement of the Orphanage, awaiting the arrival of an appropriately sized coffin from Henrik van der Voort, the local coffin-maker.

Before his death, Cedrik nursed a hidden crush for Tessa, another member of the Orphanage. The two were close friends, with Tessa the only resident who could persuade Cedrik to return a stolen doll or apologize for a crude comment.

THE MISSING BOYS

Six days prior to the PCs' arrival in Vallaki, three of the younger boys of the Orphanage fled in the night, driven to a maddened terror from their dark dreams, bruises, and fear of Headmistress Belasco. By some stroke of terrible luck, they managed to slip past the guards at the gate and into the western woods around Vallaki. It was only three days later that Milivoj managed to uncover the details of their disappearance. The morning after, he hired the wolf hunters, Szoldar and Yevgeni, to follow the boys' trail into the forest and bring them home, if possible.

The boys' names are Marek, Stefan, and Anton. They are currently being held at the Werewolf Den, and Kiril plans to bite and turn them on the next full moon. Szoldar and Yevgeni managed to track them as far as [the Wolfrun region](#) before confirming that the boys had been taken by a pack of werewolves. They report back to Vallaki shortly after the PCs' arrival, and sadly inform Milivoj of the boys' fate.

THE OTHER ORPHANS

Many of the orphans sport various bruises and mild injuries. These come from Felix's demon feeding on their life force in the night. None of the children have any idea how they received their injuries.

All the children have been suffering from horrific night terrors. Most nights are interrupted by more than one terrified scream.

RICTAVIO

Rictavio is a colorful, flamboyant, and entertaining half-elf bard staying at the Blue Water Inn. He rolls his r's, speaks with constant delight, and has a never-ending stream of amusing and lighthearted anecdotes.¹⁶² However, his bright personality is a mask that conceals the true identity beneath: the renowned vampire-hunter, Dr. Rudolph van Richten.

Van Richten is a veteran hunter of undead and monsters, and uses his Rictavio persona as a means of avoiding suspicion by Strahd's servants. Under no circumstances does he reveal his true identity to the party while within Vallaki's walls, instead saving a proper introduction for Van Richten's Tower.

It is possible that the party may uncover hidden depths to Rictavio's public persona while still in Vallaki. If this occurs, Van Richten claims to be a spy for an anti-Strahd faction scattered across Barovia. He refuses to reveal any additional details, such as the name of the faction or the identities of any other members. He informs the PCs that he is currently monitoring the political climate of Vallaki while keeping an eye out for any activity by the vampire's servants. He has suspicions regarding the motivations of Lady Fiona Wachter, but no clear proof.

MEETING RICTAVIO

If the PCs rent rooms at the Blue Water Inn, Rictavio approaches them on the second or third night of their stay to warn them about the strange customs and citizens of Vallaki. He specifically advises them against any courses of action that may get them into trouble, depending on their current goals and prior experiences. If the PCs have been planning a break-out from the stocks, Rictavio relates an anecdote regarding a criminal's torment within Baron Vallakovich's mansion. If the PCs have recently met with Lady Wachter, Rictavio tells them that she is a dangerous woman, and warns them to be wary of her motivations and followers.

If the PCs push for further information; accuse Rictavio of "knowing too much"; or single him out due to a related Tarokka reading, he leads them to his room for a more private conversation. There, he reveals that his role as a carnival ringmaster is only a front for his spying ventures. As the PCs are outsiders, Rictavio notes that he feels morally obligated to warn them that Vallaki is neither a safe nor a welcoming place.

¹⁶² /u/guildsbounty, [Rictavio Name Change?](#)

He tells them to leave town as quickly as they can, and advises them to keep their heads down in the meantime. He will then proceed to ask the PCs their goals in Vallaki and prior experience in Barovia. Rictavio also provides basic directions to his tower on Lake Baratok in case of trouble, but neglects to provide them instructions for opening the door in order to force them to figure it out for themselves as a test of skill.

WHAT RICTAVIO KNOWS

If the PCs mention Madam Eva's Tarokka reading, Rictavio is intrigued, and offers to interpret her card reading as best he can. While he knows little more than the locals regarding the geography and history of Barovia, he can direct the PCs toward specific locations including Argynvostholt, the Dusk Elf slums, or the Abbey of St. Markovia in Krezk.

If he believes himself to be the prophesied ally, he keeps that information to himself until he believes the party to be strong enough to overcome Strahd. If the PCs ask him outright to join their party, he offers to serve as their spymaster and informant until such a time that they feel prepared to investigate Strahd's secrets directly.¹⁶³ He also confirms the rumored existence of the legendary Sunsword, and promises to join the party's side once they have obtained it.

If the PCs ask after a Treasure that's in his possession, Rictavio either guides them to his carnival wagon in Arasek Stockyard, or gives them directions to his tower at Lake Baratok.

If the PCs mention the Keepers of the Feather, Rictavio notes that he is watching them, and advises the PCs to be wary before alerting them. He believes them to be enemies of Strahd, but does not wish to disturb them before he is fully aware of their members and motivation. If the PCs mention the Vistani, Rictavio warns the party to avoid them entirely. Despite his affinity for Ezmerelda, he has nursed a deep prejudice against the Vistani in the decades since his son's death, and believes that nearly all of the Vistani in Barovia are willing servants of Strahd.

If asked about the Mad Mage of Mount Baratok, Rictavio shares his belief that the Mad Mage and the wizard that stormed Castle Ravenloft the preceding year are one and the same. He suggests that the PCs find him and restore his madness; if the PCs lack any means to do so, Rictavio mentions that he has his own ways of curing insanity.¹⁶⁴ Should the PCs apprehend the Mage and send for Rictavio, he prepares the Greater Restoration spell the following day and uses it to remove the Mage's madness.

RECENT EVENTS

Rudolph van Richten first came to Barovia four months ago with the intention of destroying Strahd von Zarovich, whose name was legendary even among elder vampires. Employing dark secrets and the blood of a Vistana, he slipped through the mists of Ravenloft in the guise of an archaeologist named Relyon, bringing with him a wagon holding a "guard-dog" saber-toothed tiger named Ramses that he had trained from birth.

¹⁶³ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse Of Strahd: Vallaki II](#)

¹⁶⁴ butlerlog, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 7/29](#)

As Relyon, van Richten steadily plotted his invasion of Castle Ravenloft while investigating Strahd's abilities, allies, and enemies. Through observation of a meeting between Muriel Vinshaw and Adrian Martikov, he is peripherally aware of the Keepers of the Feather and their antipathy toward Strahd, but is wary to approach the lycanthropes due to his own ill fortune with a tribe of werewolves and a gang of wererats. He believes that Urwin and Danika Martikov may somehow be connected, but is unaware of their lycanthropic nature.

According to legend spread by Vistani storytellers, the vampyr Strahd von Zarovich is known to slumber for years or decades at a time, only to awake when a great disturbance has shaken his lands. When Relyon arrived in Barovia, Strahd was still hibernating in his coffin. Relyon quickly seized the opportunity to explore Castle Ravenloft in disguise, and therefore has a basic knowledge of the layout of the first floor, as well as the Larders of Ill Omen. However, Rahadin discovered him before he was able to enter the Crypts, and Rudolph barely escaped with his life.

As he dueled a trio of ghaists, Relyon's *Hat of Disguise* slipped, allowing Rahadin a brief glimpse of the true form underneath. Rahadin later learned from the Vistani at the Tser Pool Encampment that his description of the invader's appearance perfectly matched that of Rudolph van Richten, famed vampire hunter. He would relay this information to Strahd as soon as the vampire awoke.

KASIMIR VELIKOV

A mutilated and grief-stricken dusk elf, Kasimir has been trapped in Barovia since the elves' surrender to Strahd's conquering army. Should the PCs seek out knowledge of the history of the land before Strahd's ascension, or if they learn that one of the three treasures is in Kasimir's possession (or if Kasimir himself is their prophesied ally), they will be able to find him at the small circle of dusk elf shacks located by the Vistani Encampment near Vallaki. Additionally, either Ezmerelda d'Avenir or Rudolph van Richten can inform the PCs that the leaders of the Dusk Elves are among the few peoples left in Barovia who may be able to recall the location of the legendary Amber Temple.

As a dusk elf, Kasimir Velikov is one of the eldest living residents of Barovia - likely even older than Strahd himself. His memory runs long, and if prompted, he can share stories of Strahd's original military campaign to conquer Barovia. He regrets Sergei's death, and wishes that the younger prince could have eventually ascended the throne, rather than Strahd's own undead hand.¹⁶⁵

THE SERVANTS OF THE DEVIL

VASILI VON HOLTZ

Vasili von Holtz is the alter ego of Strahd von Zarovich. From time to time over the passing centuries, Strahd has disguised himself as Vasili in an effort to explore his domain without triggering an inevitable reaction of fear. In the past, he's used the Vasili persona to amuse himself by stirring up petty politics, toying with foreign adventurers, and romancing Tatyana's reincarnations without revealing his true nature.

Publicly, Vasili claims to be an accountant in Vallaki who assists several shops and the Baron with their finances and tax payments. If the PCs ask around, they can find that no shopkeeper remembers ever working with him, but all agree that it's common knowledge that he works with everyone else. The Baron barely recognizes the name, but doesn't ever work with the taxes himself, leaving the job for his more qualified servants.

At all times, Strahd's true appearance is carefully hidden using a *Disguise Self* spell. This illusion lasts for only one hour, and he must take periodic breaks to renew it (e.g., stepping into an outhouse to "freshen up," or "losing" the party temporarily while they're exploring). A suspicious PC can make a DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation) check to see through his illusion. However, the illusion spell that hides his appearance is concealed from *Detect Magic* and *Identify* through the use of *Nystul's Magic Aura*, which also hides his vampiric nature from the Paladin's Divine Sense feature.

Due to his natural Charisma score of 18 (+4), as well as the charming and aristocratic appearance of Vasili von Holtz, Strahd has no need for the Charm feature of his original stat block, and actively avoids the use of any magic that might reveal his true identity. However, due to his vampiric nature, he avoids entering any household without invitation. (The Blue Water Inn and unconsecrated Saint Andral's Church don't count, because the constant influx of visitors has worn their spiritual thresholds down to nothing.)

Vasili uses the stat block of a **noble** with 16 hitpoints and a Dexterity of 18 (+4), and uses the **multiattack** feature of his original stat block to make two **rapier** attacks every turn.

GETTING THE JOB DONE

Vasili's primary goal while the PCs are in Vallaki is to woo Irenea Kolyana. He believes that, if he gains her favor while in disguise as Vasili, he can reveal his true identity as Strahd and persuade her that he is neither a monster nor her enemy.

His secondary goal is the investigation of the adventurers (the PCs) that have recently entered his territory. While he bears no real interest for them until they achieve some notable act (e.g., overthrowing the Baron, retrieving the Bones of St. Andral, or cleansing the Winery), he still

does his best to briefly greet each new party in disguise to gain their measure and a peripheral awareness of their background and purpose.

If you chose to run an encounter with Vasili while on the road to Vallaki, your PCs should already be aware of him. If not, Vasili introduces himself to the PCs while they're dining or drinking at the Blue Water Inn on their first day in-town and shares a few pieces of advice regarding Vallaki's laws and society. He then offers to show them around town. He makes a point of stepping inside the (unconsecrated) Church of Saint Andral, as if to subtly prove that he's no undead.

He has a basic knowledge of the culture and layout of Vallaki, and makes every effort to assist the PCs if requested. While he does not directly intervene in the politics of Vallaki, he will join the PCs against the vampire spawn during the Feast of Saint Andral event if the party appears likely to win regardless.

At any time when the PCs encounter Vasili in a peaceful setting, he makes an earnest effort to strike up a conversation with them. An inquisitive or philosophical PC will soon find that Vasili has a wide variety of interests, including ethics, metaphysics, history, and the nature of magic and immortality.

ENCOUNTERS WITH VASILII

At any point while the PCs are out and about in Vallaki, if Ireena has been left behind at the Church or the Inn, Vasili approaches her and invites her to dinner. The two meet that evening in the taproom of the Blue Water Inn, with Vasili bringing a bottle of Champagne du Stompe wine from his "private collection." Should the PCs return to the Inn that evening, they find Vasili and Ireena enjoying each other's company, both seemingly half-drunk on wine and merrily swapping stories. The following morning, the PCs can find Ireena eagerly reading a book of fiction left by Vasili that details the tragedy of Marina of Berez, and the wrath visited upon the town for the incestual lusts and jealousy of her father (without mentioning Strahd at all, and never disclosing the identity of Marina's suitor).

Once the PCs have proven comfortable with Vasili, he approaches them with a request and one of the following plot hooks:

□ PLOT HOOK - THE RANSACKED CARAVAN

If the party includes a fighter or paladin, Vasili approaches the PCs one morning and informs them that one of his clients, a Vallakian merchant named Zhenya Romanov, recently vanished along the Old Svalich Road on her way toward Krezk. This merchant, Vasili claims, possessed a ledger detailing her transactions and accounts that Vasili badly needs for his records. Should they accept, the PCs are tasked with confirming the destruction of the caravan, rescuing Romanov (if alive), and retrieving the ledger from the rusted tin lockbox in which it is kept.

Vasili adds that Romanov also carried a purse containing money for making purchases and change, and that one of her guards, a man named Elya, wore an enchanted suit of armor that is said to be able to fire bolts of arcane energy. Should the caravan have been destroyed, Vasili invites the party to recover both items for their own use.

If the PCs ask around and succeed on a DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check, they can learn that Romanov is a moderately well-known merchant who set off for Krezk three days prior. If the PCs pass a DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation) check, they can learn from one of the nearby guards or shopkeepers that Romanov set off late in the afternoon - a foolish decision, given that night would surely fall before her arrival in Krezk. This is because Vasili enchanted her with a *Suggestion* spell, speeding her planned departure by a day in order to get her killed by the werewolf pack while planting a set of magical plate armor on one of her guards.

Romanov's caravan can be found two hours' travel west on the Old Svalich Road. Romanov, Elya, and two other guards can be found slain, savaged, and dismembered. A DC 12 Wisdom (Medicine) or Wisdom (Nature) check can make it clear that they have been partially consumed, as if by a large wild animal. A DC 15 Wisdom (Nature) check can confirm a large wolf as the culprit.

Elya can be found wearing the plate armor described by Vasili, which is itself miraculously unharmed (though the helm has been lifted and Elya's face torn off, rendering him unrecognizable). The purse can be found attached to a finely-dressed dismembered lower torso and pair of legs that once belonged to Romanov; it contains 22 gp, 29 sp, and 78 cp. The lockbox containing the ledger can be easily found on the wagon beneath sacks of grain, textiles, hide, and dried fruit and fish. It can be opened with a successful DC 13 Dexterity (Thieves' Tools) check, and contains the ledger that Vasili described.

If worn, Elya's suit of armor gives a PC who wears it the same benefits to Armor Class as does an ordinary suit of plate armor. However, it is in truth **Strahd's Animated Armor**. If examined with *Detect Magic* when first found, it reveals an expected aura of *Evocation* magic. However, after 24 hours of discovery, it instead reveals an aura of *Conjuration* magic as Strahd's *Nystul's Magic Aura* spell expires. However, Strahd believes that the PCs will be too

greedy to be suspicious. He has planted it here as a cruel joke and a means of testing the PCs' trust in his alter ego.

Any PC that wears the armor and is proficient with it gains the ability to wield the Animated Armor's **Shocking Bolt** attack (though without the Armor's **Multiattack** feature). At any later point, Strahd or one of his servants can speak the command word: "Mordent." Upon hearing this command word, the Animated Armor immediately moves to restrict and control its wearer's movement. At the beginning of each of its wearer's turns, the Armor and its wearer must make a contested Strength (Athletics) check. If the wearer wins, they can move at half speed and make attacks with disadvantage. If the Armor wins, it can force its wearer to move at half speed, and can force its wearer to make attacks (also with disadvantage). The Armor's helmet also rotates 180 degrees to blind its wearer.

Three successful Strength (Athletics) checks are required to remove the Armor from its wearer completely - one each for the helmet, chestplate, and legs. If the helmet is removed, the wearer's sight is restored. If the chestplate is removed, the wearer can no longer be prevented from making attacks, or forced to make attacks against its own volition. If the legs are removed, the wearer can no longer be prevented from moving or forced to move.

Vasili will also make regular appearances around town. You may consider having him greet the PCs after he has finished doing business with Lady Wachter at Wachterhaus, or sadly eye the prisoners in the stocks in Vallaki's town square. The PCs should receive the overall impression that Vasili is:

1. an ordinary part of Vallakian society
2. an exceptionally curious and/or friendly Vallakian resident
3. an independent-minded man who is troubled by Vallaki's harsh system of justice

Should the PCs ever become suspicious of Vasili's nature or intentions, he "admits" that he has become concerned by the cruel and unusual society that Baron Vallakovich has created. He informs the PCs that he has been searching for a group of outsiders who may be more able and willing to investigate means of changing the regime, but hasn't had the courage or connections to do so himself. He has kept his intentions to himself for fear of being reported to the Baron's guards, or losing the business of his several clients.

As the party grows more used to Vasili, he eventually confesses his interest in Irenea to one of the PCs, and asks for guidance in courting her. From this point, he begins to bring Irenea a number of gifts, including a rose, a bottle of wine, or a collection of Barovian folktales.

HENRIK VAN DER VOORT

Henrik van der Voort is a mediocre carpenter and a troubled, lonely man. He was visited six weeks ago by a well-dressed, dark-skinned woman who named herself "Ludmilla Vilisevic"

(rather than Vasili von Holtz, as in the book). Ludmilla promised van der Voort “good business” in exchange for his help.

Henrik was tasked with securing intelligence on the Church of St. Andral, in preparation for an attack by the vampire spawn Ludmilla had left in his shop. While Henrik knew of this dark plot by eavesdropping on the vampires, his cowardly nature has kept him from reporting it to the Baron. Upon his discovery of the bones beneath the Church, Ludmilla ordered him to steal them - which he did by proxy soon thereafter, paying the gravedigger, Milivoj, to snatch and deliver the bones under cover of night.

Should the PCs discover his possession of the bones, Henrik does not allow them to enter the store, claiming that his shop is “closed.” If the party attempts to gain entry by posing as customers, Henrik tells them (through the door) to slip a piece of parchment containing their desired coffin’s dimensions and the address of delivery beneath the door. He delivers the coffin using his cart and mule two days later.

If the party breaks in, Henrik offers no resistance, clearly intimidated. He can provide a clear description of Ludmilla’s appearance, persona, and name, but does not know her vampiric nature. He pretends to be ignorant of Ludmilla’s plans for an attack on the Church of St. Andral, and takes care to paint himself as an innocent and waylaid bystander. He immediately throws himself on the mercy of the PCs, asking for aid in avoiding the wrath of the vampire upstairs.¹⁶⁶ He can also inform the PCs of the location of the other four vampires, having stored their coffins beneath the hangman’s stage in the Town Square while making repairs to the structure.

LUDMILLA VILISEVIC

At nearly 200 years old, Ludmilla Vilisevic is Strahd’s oldest bride. Where other consorts have been cast aside as Strahd grew tired of them, Ludmilla has survived by keeping to herself while tending to matters he deems important. She serves as the unofficial leader of his harem, and reins the others in when necessary.

Ludmilla first came to Barovia as a little girl, stowing away in a Vistani caravan that passed through her homeland of Amn. When she arrived in Barovia, she made a living by stealing and hiding in the shadows. It was only as a young woman that a kindly family in Vallaki found and adopted her.

Life with a family was better than life on the streets, but the dark color of Ludmilla’s skin marked her as an outsider - and, in some ways, an outcast - to the other citizens of Vallaki. At the age of eighteen, Ludmilla fled Vallaki, following an ancient map that provided directions to the Amber Temple. There, she believed, she would find the answers and belonging she sought.

It was on the snow-covered slopes of Mount Ghakis that Ludmilla met the dusk elf, Rahadin, for the first time. Ludmilla was entranced by him; Rahadin saw her as a pleasurable and intriguing

distraction for his master. He offered to guide her to Castle Ravenloft, where he promised her a partner, a teacher, and a home.

For the next three years, Strahd taught her the secrets of the arcane arts alongside the minutiae of courtly etiquette. He fed upon her regularly, and was impressed by her stoic, yet thoughtful response to his hunger. Her intelligence and charisma were apparent, and Strahd soon offered her a position as his bride. She gladly accepted.

As a vampire, Ludmilla soon learned from Rahadin that Strahd would inevitably tire of her - unless, that is, she proved herself useful. She set about serving him in the advancement of his arcane studies, and personally took on the task of recruiting and training his next bride, Anastraya. She now carefully stays out of Strahd's way unless he requests her presence directly, and has formed close ties to Rahadin.¹⁶⁷

Ludmilla is cautious, reserved, and cunning. She has the stat block of a **vampire spawn**, but with 100 hit points, a Charisma score of 15, and an Intelligence score of 17. Ludmilla is also a deadly spellcaster, having learned the arcane arts from her master, Strahd. Her spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks) and she has the following Wizard spells at her disposal:

- Cantrips (at-will): *Message*; *Mage Hand*; *Produce Flame*
- 1st level (4 slots): *Fog Cloud*; *Disguise Self*; *Magic Missile*
- 2nd level (3 slots): *Blindness/Deafness*; *Invisibility*; *Levitate*; *Misty Step*
- 3rd level (2 slots): *Counterspell*; *Sending*; *Clairvoyance*

In combat, Ludmilla never resorts to traditional vampiric attacks unless she is truly desperate. Instead, she begins by casting *Levitate* with **concentration** on the most threatening melee combatant, followed by the use of a *Blindness/Deafness* spell on any identifiable spellcasters. If she has any level-three spell slots available, she reserves her reaction to cast *Counterspell*. Once her enemies have been incapacitated, she uses *Magic Missile* to whittle down their health. She always reserves a single 2nd-level slot for escape using *Misty Step*, *Fog Cloud*, or *Invisibility*. If she runs out of levelled spell slots, if her enemy reveals the *Sunsword* or the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind* and she does not have melee-capable allies nearby, or if she is reduced to one-third of her hitpoints, Ludmilla immediately flees from combat. If the *Sunsword* or *Holy Symbol* are used in combat against her, she casts *Fog Cloud* to conceal herself while allowing her allies to do her dirty work.

As is her wont, Ludmilla is doing Strahd's work before he has realized it himself. Knowing that her master is hunting the maiden Ireena, Ludmilla soon takes note should Ireena find sanctuary in the Church of St. Andral. She is the mastermind of the plot to steal St. Andral's bones, rather than Vasili von Holtz, and intends to destroy the church permanently soon after the Festival of the Blazing Sun. Once her plan is set into motion, Ludmilla stores her coffin in Arrigal's wagon, and staying with the Vistani as his "special guest." For more information on Ludmilla's plots, see the *Feast of Saint Andral* section above.

167 /u/JonathanWriting, [The Brides of Strahd](#)

AREAS OF VALLAKI

APPROACHING THE TOWN

When the party arrives at the border of Vallaki, the guards will halt them from behind the closed iron gates. They will hold the following interrogation with the gates remaining locked, only allowing the PCs through when they have answered all questions to the guards' satisfaction.

The guards will ask the PCs for the following information:

- Names, occupations, and business in town. The guards will latch onto any hesitation or suspicious answers, and will grill the PCs on all potentially relevant information. If a PC fails a DC 12 Deception (Charisma) check in a lie to this question, the guards will be annoyed, and will request the truth. On the second lie, the guards will shutter the doors to the PCs, leaving the situation salvageable only by Ireena's best efforts.
- Opinions of Strahd. The guards will do their best to ensure that the PCs have no sympathy or even apathy toward the Devil.

Should the PCs appear to be struggling with the guards' questions; if the guards appear liable to forbid entry into the town; or if the guards have refused to allow visitors to pass through the gate due to nightfall, Ireena will intervene. As a burgomaster's daughter, she has the social skills and niceties to grant the PCs advantage on all of their interactions with the guards. Should the guards remain skeptical, Ireena will warmly and proudly present herself as the daughter of the Barovian Burgomaster's daughter, drawing on the respect her father's name commands and her own diplomatic expertise to convince the guards to allow entry. Should Ireena reveal herself in this way, one of the guards will inform Izek and Baron Vallakovich of her arrival soon after.

Once the PCs' have passed the guards' interrogation, they will be allowed to enter through the gates for a briefing on Vallaki law. The guards will review the following rules with the party:

- The mention of the name "Strahd" is strictly illegal, even in written form. If he must be referred to, "the Devil" is the commonly accepted term.
- The town holds weekly festivals in to promote merriment and honor the Burgomaster, Baron Vargas Vallakovich. As guests, the PCs will not be required to assist in the preparation of these festivals, but their attendance and participation in each festival is mandatory for the length of their stay.
- The next Vallakian festival is the Festival of the Blazing Sun, to be held in five days' time in the Town Square.
- Failure to comply with any Vallakian laws will brand the PCs as criminals, and will lead to punishments in accordance with the local justice system, including imprisonment in the stocks and, in extreme cases, exile.

The guards will begrudgingly answer any questions the PCs may have, but will make sure to reinforce any and all of these laws with the party as many times as necessary. The guards will

refer to the festivals and the Baron in only the most positive light. The guards will not discuss the stocks or the Burgomaster's private torture of prisoners.¹⁶⁸

SNEAKING INTO VALLAKI

If the PCs have been exiled or otherwise barred from entry into Vallaki, they can successfully make their way into Vallaki undetected by sneaking over the walls. To do so, they will need some means of ascent (e.g., a rope, ladder, or *Levitate/Fly* spells), and to pass the following skill challenge.

In this skill challenge, the PCs must accrue three successes before three failures. If the PCs pass this challenge, they make it over the wall and into town undetected. If the challenge is failed, the PCs are discovered just after cresting the wall, and the guards successfully raise the alarm, summoning 2d4 additional **guards** in three rounds.

The PCs may use several skills or abilities to pass this skill challenge, including any of the following features:

- **Athletics** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to ascend a rope quickly.
- **Sleight of Hand** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to lasso the rope to a secure and concealed portion of the palisade.
- **Perception** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to locate a portion of the palisade wall that provides the greatest cover from the patrolling guards' prying eyes.
- **Levelled spells** (Automatic Success) such as *Invisibility* or Charm Person; or **cantrips** (DC 8 - Easy) such as *Minor Illusion* or Friends can be used to disguise the PCs' ascent from view or dissuade the nearest guard from raising the alarm.
- **Nature** (DC 18 - Hard) can be used to detect when the wind is blowing in such a way to cover the scent and sound of the PCs.
- **Stealth** (DC 13 - Moderate) can be used to conceal the sound and sight of the climbing PCs.
- **Investigation** (DC 8 - Easy) can be used to observe the pattern of the guards' patrol schedule, and so calculate the best time to climb the wall without drawing their notice.

168 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki I - Setting Up the Big Picture and Getting Through the Town Gates](#)

N1. ST. ANDRAL'S CHURCH

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF ST. ANDRAL'S CHURCH

When the PCs first arrive in Vallaki, the party's cleric or paladin may wish to visit the church and meet the local priest, Father Lucian. Father Donavich of the village of Barovia may also suggest that the PCs deliver Ireena to the safe haven of St. Andral's Church. Finally, Danika Martikov is happy to inform the PCs that the church is commonly rumored to be consecrated ground, protected from the influence of vampires or dark magic.

At the church, the PCs can learn from Father Lucian that the bones of St. Andral have been stolen, rendering its hallowed ground impotent. Father Lucian can also inform the PCs that the local gravedigger, Milivoj, is the most likely person to have witnessed the theft, and can point them toward St. Andral's Orphanage, where a sickly Milivoj is currently resting. Finally, if the Feast of Saint Andral event is allowed to proceed, the church is specifically targeted by Ludmilla Vilisevic, Strahd's most senior bride and the organizer of the attack, along with one of her subordinate vampire spawn during the rampage.

□ WORTH A THOUSAND WORDS - CHURCH OF ST. ANDRAL BATTLEMAP

If your PCs face an encounter within the Church - likely with Ludmilla Vilisevic after recovering the saint's bones, or with Izek Strazni as he pursues Ireena - you can use [this battlemap](#).¹⁶⁹

When the PCs first arrive at the Church of St. Andral, no matter the hour, they can find Willemina Rikalova in the pews, praying. If it is day, Father Lucian is beside her, comforting her. She has not left the chapel since her son, Udo Lukovich, was taken by Baron Vallakovich's men.

On any given evening, Father Lucian can be found delivering a sermon to 3d6+2 Vallakian worshippers. Otherwise, he can be found tending to the grounds, cleaning the pews or altar, reading to Yeska from a book of holy stories, eating a meal, or praying before the altar. Only on rare occasions does Father Lucian venture forth from the Church.

Unlike in the module, the bones of St. Andral were previously stored on a large stone slab at the center of a ten-by-ten foot crypt concealed beneath the chapel of the church. This crypt is accessible by means of a hidden shaft built into the stone altar of the Morninglord, whose secret door opens when the trigger, disguised as the westernmost line of the carved sun's rays, is firmly pressed down.

¹⁶⁹ /u/CS12, [Our group took the time to restore the Church of the Morning Lord in Barovia Village, so I decided to restore the map as well!](#)

N2. BLUE WATER INN

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF THE BLUE WATER INN

Should the PCs request assistance finding lodging for the night, any guard or Vallakian resident will point them toward the Blue Water Inn for room and board. The PCs may also visit the Inn to obtain information or rumors from Danika, especially regarding the disappearance of the bones of St. Andral. The PCs may also go into hiding at the Inn in the event of political turmoil, and can find refuge in the secret loft on the Inn's highest floor.

At the Inn, the PCs can obtain information regarding the disappearance of Bluto Krogarov and the delayed shipment of wine from the Wizard of Wines winery. They can make friends with Nikolai and Karl Wachter; obtain the services of Szoldar Szoldarovich and Yevgeni Krushkin; and interrogate the half-elf Rictavio regarding a Tarokka reading that describes him or the saber-toothed tiger within the carnival wagon in Arasek Stockyard. If the PCs are collaborators with the Keepers of the Feather, they can also send and receive messages through Danika and Urwin Martikov to other members of the order.

If a new PC is planning to join the campaign, the Blue Water Inn is a good place to introduce them. This PC might be an associate of Rictavio or the wolf hunters; a wounded adventurer nursed back to health by the Keepers of the Feather; or a local resident of Vallaki.¹⁷⁰

ROOM & BOARD

Should the PCs request a room at the Inn, Danika will have her boys, Brom and Bray, lead the way to their lodging. Brom and Bray are liable to prank one of the PCs with one of their Blinsky toys, but will happily shower the PCs with innocent questions regarding their race, equipment, and experiences in and outside of Barovia.

Danika will charge the PCs 5 sp per person for each night they stay at the inn, though Urwin will offer the room free of charge if he gets to the party first. The menu here is roasted wolfmeat, aged venison, dried apples, crusty bread, goat's cheese (imported from Krezk), and wine - specifically, Purple Grapemash No. 3. A mug of wine normally costs 4cp, but has been raised to 8cp due to the currently limited supply. A loaf of bread costs 2 cp, a hunk of cheese 1 sp, and a cut of wolfmeat or venison 3 sp. A modestly portioned meal of meat, potatoes, cheese, and dried carrots costs 1 sp.¹⁷¹ Should all of the PCs partake of the wine, Danika's supply runs out that evening; otherwise, it runs out the following day.

PLOT HOOKS & RUMORS

Should the PCs ask about the wine shortage, Danika informs the PCs that a shipment of wine is usually delivered from the nearby Wizard of Wines winery once per season. However, the latest shipment is more than a week late, and the inn's supplies are running dry. She shares that her husband, Urwin, has family at the winery, but adds sadly that Urwin and his father, a gruff man

170 /u/GTSimo [Introducing a New Character Late in the Game](#)

171 MandyMod, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 7/29](#)

named Davian Martikov, had a falling-out years ago. As a result, Urwin hasn't yet sent a message to his father regarding the winery's fate, and has not received any information from the winery in turn. If the PCs appear amenable to further investigation, Danika asks them to investigate, and provides directions to the Wizard of Wines from Vallaki's western gate.

Danika Martikov is a talkative barkeep, and can provide the PCs with any or all of the following rumors, often without any prompting:

- One of the Inn's best patrons and the town drunk, Bluto, hasn't been seen for a couple days. He's often found uselessly fishing on Lake Zarovich, north of town. At his last appearance in the tavern, he boasted of a special "good-luck" charm he had found that would ensure the success of his next fishing expedition. Bluto's wife, Vanessa, recently passed away due to illness.
- There have been no recent sightings of the Mad Mage of Mount Baratok. Folks used to see him skulking along the north shore of Lake Zarovich, shooting lightning bolts into the water to kill fish. His first sightings began around eleven months ago.
- The Baron's henchman, a brute with a demonic arm named Izek Strazni, recently arrested the local shoemaker, a man named Udo Lukovich, for "malicious unhappiness." Using some kind of dark magic, Izek burned his house to the ground as punishment for resisting arrest. Udo's family fled the burning house, and are currently staying with his mother, Willemina Rikalova, who spends much of her time at the church.
- The Vistani at the nearby western encampment have been restless over the past day or so. Rumors abound that they're searching for something, but no Vallakian has been brave enough to ask what.

□ **THE BUTTERFLY EFFECT - A SAFE PLACE**

Should the PCs run afoul of Vallakian law, the Martikovs will do their best to provide the party with sanctuary. The wereravens will put the party in the secret attic (area N2Q) to hide them from the Baron's men, allowing them entry and egress through the secret passage in area N2I. If any of the party's belongings are stolen or confiscated by the Vallakian guard, the Martikovs will steal and return them soon thereafter.¹⁷² Once the PCs' trail has cooled, the Martikovs help them escape over the walls in the night and provide them with directions to the Wizard of Wines (if it still stands) or Krezk.

The wolf hunters Szoldar and Yevgeni can provide the PCs a crude map of the area immediately surrounding Vallaki, bounded by Krezk to the west, the Winery/Argynvostholt to the south, Lake Zarovich to the north, and Old Bonegrinder to the east, providing it to the party for the cost of a night's worth of drinks. They can also provide information to the PCs regarding their pursuit of the missing boys of St. Andral's Orphanage, and explain their belief that the boys were taken by the werewolf pack of the Wolfrun region - alive or dead, neither hunter can say. The hunters can provide the PCs direction to Milivoj if they wish to take up the quest, but do not know the location of the den, and view the mission as hopeless.

N3. BURGOMASTER'S MANSION

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF THE BURGOMASTER'S MANSION

If the PCs are searching for a safe place for Ireena to stay, they may visit the Burgomaster's Mansion in order to obtain an audience with the Baron; after all, as effective Barovian nobility, it's not unlikely that the Baron would be willing to host her indefinitely. The Baron happily grants Ireena an audience and a spare bed in N3F, the Servants' Quarters.

The PCs may enter the mansion on a wild goose chase in search of St. Andral's bones, or to investigate the strange purple lights that have been seen in the attic. If Izek has kidnapped Ireena, the PCs will be able to find her kept captive in his room on the second floor. In either case, the Baron will bar them entry, forcing the PCs to sneak in.

If the players meet Lady Fiona Wachter and earn her trust, she might ask them to investigate the mansion for signs of the Burgomaster's corruption. Fiona also desperately wants to know what Victor did to her daughter to cause the girl's madness.¹⁷³ Baron Vallakovich, of course, will not willingly allow the PCs to investigate his own domicile, requiring the party to break in and snoop around unless they bring an excellent cover story and succeed on a DC 20 Deception check.

If one or more of the PCs have been imprisoned in the stocks, the party may seek mercy or information from the Baron in order to set their friends free. If the PCs succeed on a DC 20 Persuasion or Intimidation check, the Baron agrees to release the PC in exchange for a fine commensurate with the crime committed, with a minimum fee of 50 gp.

Finally, the PCs may also visit the Burgomaster's Manor in order to obtain information from his library. Alternatively, if the party's Tarokka reading directed them to the Burgomaster's Mansion, they can find a treasure in the N3S, the Attic Storage, forgotten amongst piles of junk. If the PCs are upfront regarding these requests, the Baron allows them inside only with a successful DC 15 Persuasion or Deception check - but only after summoning Izek Strazni, who accompanies the PCs inside to ensure that they don't steal anything.

INFILTRATING THE BARON'S MANOR

If the PCs attempt to enter during the day, the front door and rear door are unlocked. However, the family's cook can always be found working in Area N3G (Kitchen), and there is a 40% chance that the family's maid is cleaning in one of the rooms adjoining Area N3a (Entrance Hall and Vestibule). Additionally, if PCs sneak in before the Festival of the Blazing Sun, Lydia Petrovna and eight peasant **commoners** can be found preparing decorations in Area N3c (Dining Room). The PCs must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity (Stealth) check to sneak past any occupied room; a PC that fails this skill check must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity (Stealth) check to duck into one of the adjoining rooms and hide.

If the party infiltrates the Baron's mansion during the night, the PCs must evade the attention of the Baron's two slumbering mastiffs, who sleep in N3i., the Upstairs Gallery. While asleep, their

¹⁷³ [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Vallaki III - Running the Mansion and Wachterhaus](#)

collars are chained to a ring set into the wall. The dogs awake if the PCs pass by and no attempts are made at stealth.

- **Nature** (DC 20 - Hard) can provide information regarding the best way to avoid awakening a slumbering canine.
- **Animal Handling** (DC 15 - Moderate) can allow a PC to calm the dogs if awoken. This check is made with advantage if the PCs provide some kind of food.
- **Stealth** (DC 15 - Moderate) can allow the PCs to sneak past, letting the sleeping dogs lie.
- **Levelled Spells** (Automatic Success) such as Animal Friendship; or features like a Firbolg's *Speech of Beast and Leaf* (Persuasion DC 10 - Easy) can allow a PC to keep the dogs quiet.

If the PCs fail their check, the dogs awaken, requiring an **Animal Handling** check (DC 15 - Moderate) to quell their barks, or a **Stealth** check (DC 15 - Moderate) to hide elsewhere in the mansion before the Baron arrives.

If the PCs enter the mansion during the day, the Baron and his dogs can be found in Area N3L (library), with the door closed. Additionally, if the family's maid is not cleaning downstairs, there is a 60% chance that she is cleaning one of the rooms on the second floor. (Otherwise, she is out running errands about town.)

Should the PCs be discovered inside of the manor by Lydia, the maid, the cook, or Lydia's female peasant helpers, they can successfully persuade their discoverer that the Baron has requested their presence with a DC 12 Charisma (Deception) check (made with advantage if the PCs are disguised as ordinary Vallakians, or if the PCs have been discovered by one of Lydia's helpers). If a PC fails this Deception check, their discoverer prepares to call for Baron Vallakovich in his study on the second floor, and can only be dissuaded from doing so if the party promises to leave immediately and succeeds on a DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check.

Should the PCs be discovered inside of the manor by Baron Vallakovich, only a DC 20 Charisma (Deception) check can convince him that the PCs have a legitimate reason for being there (made with disadvantage if the PCs have broken in at night, and with advantage if the PCs were allowed in by Lydia or one of the servants and mention that fact). If the PCs succeed on this check and were not discovered in a compromising position, the Baron leads them to Area N3I (library) and commands them to explain themselves. If this check is failed, or if the PCs were discovered in an obviously criminal position (e.g., searching the Baron's bedroom or freeing Udo Lukovich from his restraints), he swiftly calls for **Izek** to arrest the PCs on the spot (if it is night) or sends Lydia to alert the guards on duty that his home has been invaded by servants of Strahd (if it is day).

Under no circumstances does Izek use his *Hurl Flame* ability if fighting within the mansion's walls.

N3T. VICTOR'S WORKROOM

The *Glyph of Warding* set into the door of this room casts the *Suggestion* spell, rather than triggering lightning damage, when opened. Any creature that opens the door must succeed on a DC14 Wisdom saving throw or else be Suggested to proceed downstairs and ignore whatever reason they may have had for entering.

If the PCs enter this room at night, Victor has fallen asleep at this desk.

N4. WACHTERHAUS

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF WACHTERHAUS

The PCs may snoop around Wachterhaus under the direction of Baron Vallakovich, who wants the PCs to obtain evidence of Wachter's treachery. They might also join Lady Wachter for dinner on the invitation of Ernst Larnak, or request access to the Wachters' library to search for information. If the party's Tarokka reading directed them to Wachterhaus, they can find a treasure in the closet of N4O, the Master Bedroom, in the iron chest containing Leo Dilisnya's bones.

N4S. CELLAR

If a snooping PC encounters the skeletons in Lady Wachter's basement and confronts her about it, she claims that she had them raised to serve as builders for her unfinished wine cellar, but found them to be far too unintelligent to properly construct anything, and is in the process of having them repurposed as guards.¹⁷⁴ She justifies her use of necromantic magic by claiming that "so long as any action is taken beneath the Morninglord's sight, it is good and proper and just."

174 Franky, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 7/22](#)

N5. ARASEK STOCKYARD

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS TO ARASEK STOCKYARD

If the PCs are searching for a general store where they can purchase basic adventuring gear, nearly any Vallakian citizen can point them toward Arasek Goods, located at the southwestern end of Arasek Stockyard. The PCs might also choose to investigate the Stockyard after awakening Milivoj at St. Andral's Orphanage to search for clues left from the meetings between him and his mysterious employer.

It is also possible that the PCs (correctly) deduce from clues elsewhere that Henrik van der Voort, the coffin maker, is the man who persuaded Milivoj to steal the Bones of St. Andral. If so, they can locate his shop on the southeastern side of the Stockyard.

Finally, if the PCs become suspicious of Rictavio, or believe that his wagon may contain one of the treasures referenced in their Tarokka reading, they can easily discover that his wagon is hitched at the center of the Stockyard. If the PCs first confront Rictavio in person and mention their Tarokka reading, he asks them to meet him in his room at the Blue Water Inn within the hour and slips away to retrieve the lead-lined box containing the treasure from his wagon.

When the PCs enter Arasek Stockyard, they can see two signs at the southern end: "Arasek Goods," and a coffin-shaped sign bearing no words that marks the entrance of the coffin-maker's shop (N6).

□ THE BUTTERFLY EFFECT - SETTING RAMESES FREE

If the PCs open the back door of Rictavio's carnival wagon without Rictavio present, they must succeed on a DC12 Dexterity saving throw and a contested Strength (Athletics) roll to slam the door shut on the **saber-toothed tiger** before it can escape. Otherwise, the tiger (whom Van Richten has named Rameses) breaks from his rickety prison and bounds away into the alleys of Vallaki in an effort to locate Rictavio or Piccolo. For more information on running this encounter, see the *Tyger*, *Tyger* special event.

N6. COFFIN MAKER'S SHOP

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS TO THE COFFIN MAKER'S SHOP

If the PCs interpret Milivoj's clues correctly, they may deduce that Henrik van der Voort, the coffin maker, is the man who persuaded Milivoj to steal the Bones of St. Andral. Once the party learns that Milivoj met with his mysterious employer at Arasek Stockyard, they might attempt to ask Henrik if he saw those meetings from his shop window (and, of course, be turned away).

Instead of barred from the inside, the side door to the Coffin Maker's shop is locked, and may be unlocked with a successful DC 15 Dexterity (Thieves' Tools) check. Henrik keeps the only key upon his person.

N6E. HENRIK'S BEDROOM

Soon after Henrik takes the Bones of St. Andral from Milivoj, he stores them here, in the secret compartment of the wardrobe in this room. The night after he informs Ludmilla of his success, she enters the bedroom in secret and places two *Glyphs of Warding* beneath the sack containing the bones. These glyphs are triggered when the sack containing the bones is removed. Both glyphs are nearly invisible; only a successful DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) check can allow a character to detect the thin lines of arcane energy poking past the edge of the sack.

The first *Glyph* is a *Spell Glyph*; once triggered, it casts a *Clairvoyance* spell that provides Ludmilla with a direct line of sight to this chamber and any characters within it (assuming that Ludmilla is present in the Vistani Encampment, Vallaki itself, or any of the surrounding area).

The second *Glyph* is a set of *Explosive Runes* that erupt with magical energy in a sphere of 20-foot-radius when triggered. Each creature in the affected area (even if around a corner) must make a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw. A creature takes 5d8 cold damage on a failed saving throw, or half as much damage on a successful one. Ludmilla chose the *cold* damage type to prevent anyone outside the shop from hearing the explosion of the runes.

□ **THE BUTTERFLY EFFECT - TRIGGERING THE RUNES**

If the glyphs are triggered, the two **vampire spawn** in the Vampire Nest (N6F) instantly awaken and attack any characters on the second floor before searching for survivors lurking on the main floor.

If the PCs or the Baron's **guards** forced Henrik to retrieve the bones himself, he is killed in the ensuing explosion, leaving the location of the five hidden vampire spawn a mystery. Only through asking the right questions and a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check can the PCs learn that Henrik was recently commissioned to make heavy repairs to the gallows' platform in the Town Square.

If Ludmilla sees only Henrik when her *Clairvoyance* spell is triggered, she casts *Clairvoyance* a second time to confirm that the bottom of the shop is empty as well. If she detects the presence of the PCs in the shop, she quickly presumes the worst and casts *Sending* to direct the six **vampire spawn** to eliminate all intruders in all rooms of the coffin shop. She then makes her way to the Church of Saint Andral to await any characters that may return with the bones.

N7. BLINSKY TOYS

❑ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS TO BLINSKY TOYS

Picking Up a Present: The PCs may make their way to Blinsky Toys to purchase a toy for Arabelle after accepting Eliza's *Picking Up a Present* sidequest in [Tser Pool Encampment](#). If they do, Blinsky recognizes Arabelle's physical description and is happy to do business with them.

The Man with the Monkey: The PCs may make their way to Blinsky Toys after learning from Danika Martikov of an "entertaining man with a monkey" that fits the relevant Tarokka reading for Strahd's Enemy. Blinsky protests any idea that he might be suitable for opposing the Devil of Castle Ravenloft, but can inform the PCs that he purchased the monkey from a man named Rictavio, who is currently staying at the Blue Water Inn.

The Missing Vistana: If the PCs accept the [Missing Vistana quest](#) from Luvash and Arrigal at the Vistani Camp outside Vallaki (area N9), the residents of St. Andral's Orphanage can inform them that a grubby-looking man offered to purchase Arabelle some toys at Blinsky Toys. Blinsky can inform them that the man was Bluto Korgarov, one of the local fishermen. Bluto came by the previous day accompanying a girl fitting Arabelle's description and bought her a pair of zombie dolls before leaving. Bluto told Blinsky that he was "taking Arabelle fishing." Blinsky found the entire affair strange, as he did not know Bluto to have any children of his own.

Tyger, Tyger: If the PCs chase after the escaped Rameses, the saber-toothed tiger, either during the [Tyger, Tyger special event](#) or accidentally freeing him themselves, they can find him here, having broken through the window of the shop in an attempt to reunite with Piccolo, the monkey. The PCs find Piccolo happily perched on Rameses' shoulder while Blinsky hides and whimpers from a top shelf of his shop.

N8. TOWN SQUARE

❑ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF THE TOWN SQUARE

Due to its nature as a nexus of transportation rather than a destination, it is rare that your PCs will head toward the Town Square specifically. Instead, they are likely to pass through it while traveling between Arasek Stockyard and the Burgomaster's Mansion. Any PC that takes the time to explore Vallaki will also naturally find themselves passing through the Town Square, a central point of commerce and travel in Vallaki.

Additionally, several shops are located in the Town Square. Any PC searching for some kind of commerce will be able to find their way to the appropriate shop within 30 minutes after succeeding on a DC 5 Intelligence (Investigation check), or within 15 minutes by passing a DC 10 check. Before ascending Mount Ghakis toward the Amber Temple, it may behoove the PCs to commission sets of warm winter clothing from Endless Delight Clothiers, located on the southeastern side of the square.

If the PCs decide to attend the [Festival of the Blazing Sun](#), they will be able to enjoy the climax of the Festival at the center of the Square.

The Town Square is the heart of Vallaki. Between the posters advertising the Festival of the Blazing Sun, the watchful eye of Izek Strazni, and the spectacle of the stocks, any party visiting the Square will quickly gain an appreciation for the culture and current state of Vallaki.

Because Izek can often be found lurking within or nearby the area, no Vallakian will freely speak with the PCs while in or around the Town Square. These citizens may glare and snarl at the PCs when approached; happily bubble with Baron-approved propaganda; or entirely ignore the party if approached.

Though a stone fountain lies at the geographic center of the Town Square, the stocks are the clear centerpiece. **Unlike in the module, Izek cannot be found here when your PCs first arrive.** Instead, the townsfolk speak of his name in terrified whispers if the PCs suggest any hint of disloyalty or conspiracy.

☐ **WORTH A THOUSAND WORDS - POSTERS FOR THE FESTIVAL OF THE BLAZING SUN**

While exploring the Town Square, the PCs can find many copies of [this poster](#) advertising the Festival of the Blazing Sun.¹⁷⁵

Should a tense situation descend into combat, feel free to use this [Town Square battlemap](#).¹⁷⁶

DONKEY-HEADED CRIMINALS

If the PCs approach the men and women in the stocks, a terrified Vallakian peasant approaches to warn the party that providing comfort or aid to criminals is punishable by ten days in the stocks, while attempting to free those in the stocks is also punishable by a public flogging. If any PCs try to free the prisoners anyway, or are caught doing so, the peasant swiftly vanishes into the crowd, but swiftly reports their crime to Izek when he next returns to make his rounds.

SHOPS OF VALLAKI

There are several shops in Vallaki's Town Square where your PCs can purchase basic goods and supplies.

THE CRACKED ANVIL

Owned by blacksmith Dragomir Ulbrek, The Cracked Anvil is the proud purveyor of functional pieces including horseshoes, nails, hinges, spearheads, arrowheads, and daggers. Dragomir can also sell shortswords and longswords at twice the listed price in the Player's Handbook, and can repair any nonmagical weapon or piece of armor for half of its normal price. He can also silver weapons for the PCs, but at the exorbitant price of 200 gp per weapon, and only has enough materials to silver two weapons without the PCs purchasing more from the Vistani.

¹⁷⁵ /u/doubleg316, [My players just reached Vallaki in Curse of Strahd, and I made this poster to inform them of the next event: The Festival of the Blazing Sun!](#)

¹⁷⁶ /u/centumviri, [Curse of Strahd: Vallaki Town Square](#)

As raw materials for new equipment are so hard to come by in Barovia, he will also pay the listed price in the Player's Handbook for any weapons offered for sale. Because of this, he often has a small and eclectic collection of weapons and armors for sale obtained from the remains of dead adventurers.

Magda Ulbrek, Vallaki's only fletcher and Dragomir's wife, also works out of this shop. She can make bows and arrows for sale at twice the normal price, and will take a period of two days to create a new bow from scratch.

LUKRESH TANNERY

Lukresh Tannery is owned by the dark-humored and abrasive Fatima Lukresh. She is most experienced in the production of straps, harnesses, and belts, but can craft normal and studded leather armor on commission if asked. Her work is crude, but functional.

ENDLESS DELIGHT CLOTHIERS

The three Alastroi siblings, Alek, Andrej, and Alana own and operate Endless Delight Clothiers (formerly named Alastroi Clothiers, until the Baron pressured them into renaming it). They are a weaver, cobbler, and tailor, respectively. The Baron frequently commissions their shop to produce the outfits and decorations for his festivals, leaving them highly skilled at their trade in a constant effort to please him. They are experienced crafters of warm clothing.

VALLAKI WAGON REPAIR

Vallaki's most experienced wainwright is a gruff, unpleasant man named Tural. He occasionally exits Vallaki to do business with the Vistani, which leaves him a social pariah amongst some of the more mistrustful townsfolk. However, if the PCs need an introduction to the Vistani near town, Tural is happy to provide it.

THE APOTHECARY

The Apothecary is owned by a soft-spoken, but nonetheless eccentric man named Harkus Stefanovich. Possessed with an unnerving bedside manner and a lack of appreciation for personal space, Harkus is nonetheless a simple apothecary, rather than a potion-maker or alchemist.¹⁷⁷ He is perfectly qualified to produce simple remedies, poultices, and tinctures, but quite ignorant of the materials or skills needed to produce Potions of Healing or similar items. He can sell the PCs a Healer's Kit at twice the normal price.

177 /u/guildsbounty, [Questions about Shopping in Vallaki](#)

N9. VISTANI CAMP

□ STRANDS OF FATE - HOOKS OF THE VISTANI CAMP

The Missing Vistana: Upon rescuing Arabelle from Bluto at Lake Zarovich, the PCs will be directed to return her to her father, Luvash, at this encampment. Should they recover her drowned body, she is recognizable as a Vistana from her clothes and complexion.

Tarokka Treasures: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading informs the PCs that a treasure can be found here, it is located within the Vistani Treasure Wagon (area N9I).

If the PCs successfully rescue Arabelle, Luvash tells them that some members of their camp routinely make trips to the world outside Barovia. Should the PCs pay half of the price upfront, the caravan would be happy to pick up some minor mundane or magical items on their behalf, deliverable in four days. The Vistani refuse to purchase holy water or any items hazardous to the undead, however, due to their stance of neutrality toward Strahd.¹⁷⁸

N10. ST. ANDRAL'S ORPHANAGE

[Click here for N10. St. Andral's Orphanage.](#)

N11. VASILI VON HOLTZ'S HOUSE

Few Vallakians know where to find the home of Vasili von Holtz, Strahd's secret alter-ego. A DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check can allow the PCs to find someone who can point them there. Urwin and Danika Martikov can also provide the PCs with directions, having observed Vasili leaving his home on at least one occasion through the eyes of their ravens.

Vasili's home is located in an old two-story townhouse in a somewhat wealthier part of town. The front door is locked, and the first floor shutters have been bolted closed. A DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check can break the door down, while a DC 15 Dexterity (Thieves' Tools) check can unlock it. Given the wealthy nature of the neighborhood, breaking and entering Vasili's home is swiftly reported by a neighbor, which may lead Izek or another local constabulary to track down the one responsible.

The first floor of Vasili's home is divided into a front and back area. The front of the house contains a simple, well-kept living space, which includes a stove, a pile of neatly-stacked firewood, two comfortable-looking armchairs, and an old sofa adjacent to a brick fireplace. A PC with a passive Perception of 16 or higher notices a faint layer of dust on the floor and furniture. Inspection of the firewood reveals it to be quite old and nearly rotten. A doorway at the rear of the space leads to the back of the first floor.

¹⁷⁸ /u/cryid, [Questions about Shopping in Vallaki](#)

The back area contains a small washroom, an empty pantry, and a set of wooden steps leading to the second floor. The washroom's corners are full of dirt and grime, and a thick layer of dust covers the shelves of the pantry.

The second floor contains a single large room largely bereft of any furniture or decoration. The only exception is a large, king-sized bed whose bed frame has long since rotted. The mattress is moldy and infested with a colony of cockroaches. Many of the floorboards are clearly aged and creaky, and the room is coated with dust, cobwebs, and patches of mold and soil.

Chapter 6: The Wizard of Wines

Ch. 12: The Wizard of Wines

□ **Strands of Fate: Hooks to the Winery**

A Martikov's Plea: Urwin or Danika Martikov at the Blue Water Inn in Vallaki may invite the PCs to investigate the mysterious delay of shipments from the winery.

Vistani Vittles: Arrigal and Luvash of the Vistani Encampment outside of Vallaki may agree to part with the Sunsword, Tome of Strahd, or Holy Symbol of Ravenkind if the PCs retrieve a fresh shipment of wine for their camp.

Gates of Krezk: Burgomaster Dmitri Krezkov of Krezk is naturally suspicious of outsiders, but will allow the PCs entry if they retrieve a shipment of wine from the Winery.

All Will Be Well: Baron Vargas Vallakovich of Vallaki may ask the PCs to restore the shipments of wine from the winery in order to ensure the success of the Festival of the Blazing Sun.

Mission For the Devil: Strahd may ask the PCs to rescue the winery from the "creatures" that have infested it, both to test their mettle and to ensure that his own stores of wine do not run dry.¹⁷⁹

History of the Winery

The Martikov family line has been the keeper of the Wizard of Wines winery for the past two hundred years, after marrying into and subsuming the branch house of the Krezkov line that had originally owned it. The winery itself, however, predates even Strahd's invasion of Barovia.

The Wizard of the Wines

It is common legend - purposefully spread, in fact, by the Martikovs themselves - that the three magical gems that produce the grapes of the winery were created by a powerful wizard, hence its name. Only the Martikovs, however, know in truth that the gems were not a creation of the wizard, but a gift bestowed upon her by the ancient spirits of the valley.

After falling in love with the green, sweeping landscapes of this land, the mage forged a bond with the druids of the old country, whose ancestral homes and ancient ways had been swept aside by the cold steel of their invaders. As a reward for her friendship, the druids drew upon the ailing strength of the *Rozana*, the Ladies of the Fanes, and gifted her with three enchanted gemstones that would allow the mage - a connoisseur of wines - to produce hearty, delicious grapes in the wilderness of the woods.

What the Martikovs Know

The Krezkovs, gifted the winery for their loyalty to Strahd, soon fell in love with the land in much the same way as the wizard had more than a century before. Soon after the end of the war, however, a rebellious faction of druids approached them and begged for shelter against the purges that Strahd's servants had wrought upon their people. The Krezkovs accepted, and so entered a year-long guerilla war that allowed these druids to evade Strahd's eye and gather resources while building new, hidden encampments on Mount Ghakis.

With their last breath of defiance, these rebellious druids offered the Krezkovs of the Winery a gift: the curse of lycanthropy. Once, all druids had enjoyed the power of *wildshape*, but as their power had waned, the totems that allowed these transformations had cracked and decayed, leaving only the Raven's totem behind. As a token of gratitude, the rebellious druid spirited the Raven's totem away from the camp of Strahd's servant-druids and delivered it to the Krezkovs. This item would bestow upon them the gift of a wereraven's lycanthropy, providing them the ability to defend their land from Zarovich's forces should he discover their treachery from his castle.

These friendly druids also gave the Krezkovs instructions for the *Hatching*, a year-long ritual by which the Krezkovs and their mates could share and master the wereraven's transformation - without this ritual, any lycanthrope would soon lose their minds to the animal's instincts. The Krezkovs accepted, and became wereravens themselves.

When Strahd von Zarovich accepted the curse of vampirism, the Krezkovs were alarmed at the shroud of darkness that fell over their new home. They joined together, recruiting extended friends and family, and formed the Order of the Feather - a secret society that aimed to protect Barovia's citizens from the monsters that now surrounded them. Years later, when the Martikovs married into their line, the Krezkovs shared the secret of lycanthropy with them, and so passed on the wereravens' order to a new generation.

Anger of the Druids

For three hundred years, the betrayer druids that served Strahd searched in vain for the Raven's totem that the Gatekeepers had stolen. Finally, after beseeching the aid of Baba Lysaga in the ruins of Berez, the druids learned by her scrying that the Martikov family were the inheritors of the wereraven's lycanthropy, and resolved to attack.

However, even with the use of the *Moonbeam* spell known only to the most practiced of the druidic naturalists, the Keepers of the Feather were too wary, too quick, and too well-defended

for the druids to attack directly. The enemy druids retreated to their gathering place upon Yester Hill, and glared from the shadows of the Svalich Wood.

Decades later, the soul of Tatyana Federovna was reincarnated in the body of Ireena Kolyana, a young woman from the town of Barovia. Strahd's newest wife, an ornery, psychopathic vampire by the name of Volenta Popofsky, felt threatened by the emergence of this threat to her stature as her husband's favored bride. In a visit to the crone Baba Lysaga, she learned of the feud between the druids and the Keepers of the Feather, and resolved to orchestrate the destruction of the winery in a self-aggrandizing display of cunning and power.

Through the use of Volenta's shard of the Heart of Sorrow, the druids separated a branch from the Gulthias Tree and infused it with the essence of the tree's power. The Gulthias Tree had always ambiently produced blights of varying shapes and sizes as a defense mechanism, but this staff would allow the druids to control them, directing an army of blights against the wereravens' winery. With this horde, the druids soon invaded the winery, driving the Martikovs from their ancestral home and spiriting away the final gem for their own purposes.

Approaching the Vineyard

As the PCs make their way to the Wizard of Wines, you can use the Random Encounters table (pg. 29) to establish the themes and creatures that they can expect to encounter. If you want to set up the enemies they're likely to run into, run the Druid and Twig Blights encounter.¹⁸⁰ If you'd rather focus on the Martikovs or the raven motif, use the Hidden Bundle and Swarms of Ravens/Wereraven encounters instead.

Any ravens that the PCs encounter en route can serve as guides that lead them to the grove where Davian Martikov is hiding. You may also want to use the Druid and Twig Blights encounter earlier in the module in order to foreshadow their appearance later.

The Martikov Family

The Martikovs' grove is filled with three **swarms of ravens**, which Davian Martikov treats as pets. From this, your PCs know that the ravens within the Winery are allies, rather than enemies.

To prevent the PCs from fighting through the horde of **needle blights** concealed within the vineyard, Davian warns the party that they will need to sneak past the horde to deal with the druids inside. He believes that one or more of the druids may have some knowledge of how to dismiss or destroy the blights, and advises the PCs to flee or sneak through the lines of blights. He advises them to inspect the vineyard thoroughly before entering, and to make their way cautiously toward the winery to avoid disturbing the blights. If the PCs take Davian's advice and make their way toward the winery, run the **Skill Challenge: Escaping the Horde** below, starting at Stage 1: Investigation.

¹⁸⁰ /u/paintrana, [What I have Learned from Running Curse of Strahd Twice: Wizard of the Wines Edition](#)

Once the Winery has been freed, Davian begs the PCs to retrieve the stolen wine gems from Yester Hill, noting that without it, the Winery will have to close its doors forever. The location of the third gem is unknown to both Davian and Urwin Martikov, and is not described in the module. If this retrieval is successful, Davian then asks the PCs to retrieve the gem from Berez, noting that Baba Lysaga likely has further plans for an attack on the winery.

The Keepers of the Feather

Once the PCs have proved their worth through the restoration of the Wizard of Wines winery and the retrieval of the gems from Yester Hill and/or Berez, the Keepers of the Feather may choose to reveal themselves, though they will maintain the secret of their lycanthropy. They will present themselves as a secret society that opposes Strahd, training ravens as messengers and spies. At this stage, the PCs will be able to use the Keepers to send messages around the region, scout out dangerous locations, and receive occasional updates of current events elsewhere in Barovia.

The Keepers of the Feather are hesitant to reveal their lycanthropic nature, or to commit to physically fighting alongside the party. The PCs are not the first adventurers that the Keepers have assisted, and the Keepers would rather they not be the last. The Keepers' central goal is the maintenance and expansion of their intelligence network; should the PCs fail, the Martikovs and their allies will do their best to retrieve their gear, consolidate their findings, and prepare for the next group of adventurers.

Only in the most critical of situations will the Keepers voluntarily reveal their lycanthropy to the PCs. Even then, any physical aid they provide will be limited to tactics and mobility alone. A pair of wereravens in hybrid form can provide an emergency airborne evacuation to any single PC.¹⁸¹

Under no circumstances will the Keepers of the Feather offer to spread their lycanthropy to a PC. Unlike the werewolves, the control they exercise over their lycanthropic nature is a gift from the wind spirit, Stribog, obtained through intimate rituals and months of transformation and meditation. A Keeper of the Feather would sooner die than allow their gift to be stolen and misused by a PC with no appreciation for the care and control it requires.

For more information on the Keepers of the Feather, see their description in [Residents of Vallaki](#).

❑ **Strands of Fate: The Travellers Four**

If you are using the “Travellers Four” campaign hook from the beginning of this guide, Davian Martikov remembers that, after hosting them at the winery in exchange for labor, the three travelers ran afoul of Baba Lysaga, with one captured by the hag while the two survivors fled into the mountains.¹⁸²

Approaching the Winery

If the PCs choose to inspect the vineyard from the outside before entering, run the *Escaping the Horde* skill challenge described below, starting from Stage 1: Investigation.

Alternatively, if the PCs pass through its front gate without investigating, or if they do so after achieving only one or no successes in Stage 1 of the skill challenge, read:

As your boots break the boundary of this crumbling vineyard, you hear the rustle of dead vines all around you. Inhuman shapes emerge from the vineyard, their limbs crackling as they trudge forth through the mist and rain. One dozen - two dozen - there are too many to count! Fighting clearly isn't an option. You can either flee from the scene - or you can make a mad dash for the winery.

If the PCs choose to continue toward the winery, run the *Escaping the Horde* skill challenge described below, starting from Stage 2: Evasion.

Skill Challenge: Escaping the Horde

This skill challenge has four stages. Each time the PCs complete two skill checks, succeed or fail, they proceed to the next stage of the challenge. By the end of this challenge, the PCs should have attempted eight skill checks in total (or six, if they skipped the first stage).

For every two failures that the party accrues, each PC must make a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw, taking 2d6 damage from the advancing needle blights on a failed save, or half damage on a successful one.

Throughout the entire challenge, the PCs are followed by a pair of **ravens** that squawk for the PCs' attention. The PCs can gain the guidance of these ravens, as detailed in the skill checks below.

Stage 1: Investigation

In the first stage, **Investigation**, the PCs have the opportunity to scope out the winery before actually passing through its outermost fencing - and, therefore, before the blights have even emerged. Unlike the other stages, the party may skip this one entirely or choose to complete only a single check. If the PCs choose to skip this stage completely, they automatically accrue

two failures for their skill challenge, and are attacked by the needle blights as soon as they enter the vineyard.

The PCs can make as many skill checks as they like during this stage of the skill challenge; however, only the first two checks matter for the purpose of counting successes or failures.

Some of the skill checks that the PCs might make include the following:

- **History (DC 20 - Hard)** can allow a PC to recall common layouts of vineyard construction, directing them toward safer and speedier routes.
- **Animal Handling (DC 15 - Moderate)** or **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Beast Bond*, *Speak with Animals*, or *Beast Sense* can allow the PCs to interpret the intentions of the ravens and follow their birds' eye vision to a safer route.
- **Perception (DC 15 - Moderate)** will reveal the shadows of several needle blights lurking nearby.
- **Survival (DC 15 - Moderate)** can let a character use the tracks left by the many needle blights to infer their likely hiding places.

Stage 2: Evasion

When the PCs reach the second stage, **Evasion**, they must escape the notice of the needle blights and make their way toward the winery. The first time the PCs fail a skill check in this or a subsequent stage, or if they enter the vineyard and made one or no successful checks in the **Investigation** stage, the army of needle blights begins to emerge, approaching the PCs with an air of clear hostility. When this happens, read:

You hear the rustle of dead vines all around you. Inhuman shapes emerge from the vineyard, their thorn-covered limbs crackling as they trudge forth through the mist and rain. One dozen - two dozen - there are too many to count! Fighting clearly isn't an option. You can either flee from the scene - or you can make a mad dash for the winery.

Before the first skill check the PCs attempt to advance in this stage, read:

You tear your way through the vines, making a beeline for the building at the center of the yard. Above you, a pair of ravens squawk and caw as they circle in the air. All around you, you can see dark shapes rising between the vines and fence posts, their needle-covered forms lurching toward you. What do you do?

Before the second skill check the PCs attempt in this stage, read:

The vines swallow you up, shriveled grapes and yellowed leaves forming a dense forest around you. You dash toward the winery, but as you pass through an intersection of weaving ditches and fences, you see two groups of blights advancing on your position from either side. What do you do?

Potential skills that may be used to pass either skill check include:

- **Acrobatics (DC 10 - Easy)** or **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Jump*, *Longstrider*, or *Expeditious Retreat* allow the PCs to nimbly make their way past long stretches and small obstacles, such as a ditch, fencing, or overgrown plantlife.
- **Stealth (DC 10 - Easy)** or **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Pass Without Trace* can allow the party to escape notice by ducking through one of the many rows of grapevines.
- **Arcana (DC 20 - Hard)** and **Nature (DC 15 - Moderate)**, if the blights are visible, can let a PC recall information about their nature and abilities, including the details of their blindsight and the range of their attacks.
- **Animal Handling (DC 15 - Moderate)** or **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** can allow the PCs to interpret the intentions of the ravens, and follow their birds' eye vision to a safer route, if they have not already been used in this way.
- **Perception (DC 10 - Easy)** can allow the PCs to detect and avoid blights moving toward them through the vineyard.
- **Intimidation (DC 20 - Hard)** or **Arcana (DC 20 - Hard)** can force the blights to hesitate in their pursuit, if used in conjunction with some form of fire magic (e.g., *Create Bonfire*, *Aganazzar's Scorching Ray*).
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to give the PCs cover from the blights' ranged attacks. Spells that interact with vision such as *Fog Cloud*, *Minor Illusion*, *Silent Image*, or *Darkness* automatically fail due to the blights' blindsight.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

Stage 3: Flight

In the third stage, **Flight**, the PCs have passed through the vineyard and must make their way safely into the winery. They have four doors to choose from: the padlocked double doors in area W5; the locked door at area W3; the half-open door at the rear of area W2; or the closed stable doors of area W1. The players may also suggest choosing to make their way around the house to area W10 or W8, or attempt to climb the thick ivy covering the walls in order to make their way into area W16. Depending on the route that they choose, their options during the skill challenge vary as follows:

W1. Stables

The doors to the stables are unlocked. However, if the PCs attempt to take shelter here, they must succeed on a DC 15 **Dexterity (Stealth)** check to hide from the blights outside (who soon force the door open) and a DC 15 **Dexterity (Acrobatics)** check to evade the blights waiting at the door. If they fail either of these checks, or if they choose not to hide after entering the stables, the party automatically gains two failures, inciting another attack by the needle blights as described above. Regardless of the outcomes of these rolls, the PCs must then choose another entrance into the winery.

W2. Loading Dock

The south door that opens into the main floor of the winery has been forced open and hangs ajar. Due to the open space of this area, the PCs must take additional evasive action to avoid the routine volleys of needle blight thorns now falling like rain around them.

Before the PCs make their first skill check in their dash for the Loading Dock, read:

You run for the loading dock, taking evasive action around a pile of barrels and crates as the main horde of blights marches forth from the vines. A shower of thorns is about to rain down upon you. What do you do?

Before the PCs make their second skill check in their escape to the Loading Dock, read:

You dash inside the loading dock, the roof covering your escape from the main horde. However, as you run along the wooden platforms on either side of the docked, barrel-laden wagon within, you see a second group of blights lurch into view, their forms darkening the entryway. The hook of a crane up above trembles with a metallic jingle, the earth shaking from the weight of the oncoming horde. What do you do?

- **Athletics (DC 20 - Hard)** can allow one or more PCs to collapse the pile of barrels or pull the Martikovs' wagon in front of the door, preventing the blights from getting too close and blocking their line-of-sight.
- **Athletics (DC 15 - Moderate)** can allow the PCs to swiftly scale the crane's rope to the Area W16 on the second floor.
- **Acrobatics (DC 15 - Moderate)** can allow the PCs to nimbly jump or sway as they ascend the crane's rope, avoiding the blights' volleys of thorns.
- **Acrobatics (DC 15 - Medium)** or **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Jump*, *Longstrider*, or *Expeditious Retreat* allow the PCs to nimbly make their way along the top of the wagon, obstructing the blights' view and redirecting their thorns into the barrels and wood paneling of the cart.
- **Intimidation (DC 20 - Hard)** or **Arcana (DC 20 - Hard)** can force the blights to hesitate in their pursuit, if used in conjunction with some form of fire magic (e.g., *Create Bonfire*, *Aganazzar's Scorchers*, *Scorching Ray*).
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to give the PCs cover from the blights' ranged attacks. Spells that interact with vision such as *Fog Cloud*, *Minor Illusion*, *Silent Image*, or *Darkness* automatically fail due to the blights' blindsight.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

W3. Barrel Maker's Workshop

The north door to this room is barred from the inside. The PCs will need to break in before the needle blights fall upon them. After two checks, the PCs automatically break in, but risk taking another volley from the blights if they reach another two failures in the process.

When the PCs first attempt to open the door, before making their first skill check of this phase, read:

You make a break for the front door of the winery - and the handle rattles in your palm as you struggle to push against whatever obstruction is barring the other side. The horde is advancing, and you've only seconds before the blights send forth another volley. What do you do?

When the PCs succeed their first skill check, if that skill check was made in effort to break down the door, read:

The door crunches and cracks beneath the weight of your efforts. You're so close now - but so is the horde, whose shadowed figures are steadily advancing. Every second you have is precious. What do you do?

- **Athletics (DC 20 - Hard); Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Scorching Ray*, *Thunderwave*, or *Knock*; or **cantrips (DC 20 - Hard)** such as *Firebolt* or *Eldritch Blast* can allow the PCs to break through the door.
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to give the PCs cover from the blights' ranged attacks. Spells that interact with vision such as *Fog Cloud*, *Minor Illusion*, *Silent Image*, or *Darkness* automatically fail due to the blights' blindsight.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

W5. Veranda

These two sliding wooden doors are chained shut from the outside, and the smaller door is barred shut from the inside. After two checks, the PCs automatically break in through the smaller door, but risk taking another volley from the blights if they reach another two failures in the process.

When the PCs first arrive at the veranda before attempting their first skill check of this phase, read:

You climb the steps to the winery's veranda - only to find that the three tall barrels had obstructed your view of an iron chain and lock wrapped around the handles of the larger wooden doors. To their side, a smaller door promises entry inside.

You run for the small door, eager for an escape - but the handle rattles in your palm, and you struggle to push against whatever obstruction is barring the other side. The horde is advancing, and you've only seconds before the blights send forth another volley. What do you do?

When the PCs succeed their first skill check, if that skill check was made in effort to break down either door or unchain the larger, read:

Sweat beads on your foreheads as your efforts mount to a climax. You're so close now - but so is the horde, whose shadowed figures are steadily advancing. Every second you have is precious. What do you do?

- **Athletics (DC 20 - Hard); Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Scorching Ray*, *Thunderwave*, or *Knock*; or **cantrips (DC 20 - Hard)** such as *Firebolt* or *Eldritch Blast* can allow the PCs to break through either door.
- **Thieves' Tools (DC 15 - Moderate) or Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Knock* can allow a PC to unchain the large sliding doors.
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to give the PCs cover from the blights' ranged attacks. Spells that interact with vision such as *Fog Cloud*, *Minor Illusion*, *Silent Image*, or *Darkness* automatically fail due to the blights' blindsight.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

W8 & W10. Storage and Glassblower's Workshop

The PCs can attempt to make their way around the eastern or western sides of the winery to gain access to these unlocked entrances. No skill checks are required to do so. However, if they take either of these longer routes, each PC must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw, taking 1d6 piercing damage from the blights on a failure.

W16. Loading Winch

To gain access to the second-floor windows or loading dock of this chamber, the PCs must either attempt to scale the ivy on the outer walls of the winery, or they must try to scale the crane hanging down into area W2.

Before the PCs make their first skill check of this phase, read:

Your feet pound on the dry, dusty dirt of the winery's yard, and you come to a stop beside the forest of ivy covering the building's stone exterior. You try to find purchase, scrambling for grip on the vines, and begin your ascent to the second-story windows. The blights continue to advance, however, and you realize that they'll soon have a clear line of sight. What do you do?

Before the PCs make their second skill check of this phase, read:

You're so close now - three feet to go; two feet; one foot left! As you glance down at your allies, you see that the blights have formed a crescent around the building's base, their shoulders bristling with fresh thorns. Your fingers are so close to the windowsill now, but it's clear that the hordes' next volley is closer. What do you do?

- **Athletics (DC 15 - Moderate)** allows the PCs to swiftly scale the vines or rope to a higher level.
- **Acrobatics (DC 15 - Moderate)** can allow the PCs to nimbly jump or sway as they ascend, avoiding the blights' volleys of thorns.
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to give the PCs cover from the blights' ranged attacks. Spells that interact with vision such as *Fog Cloud*, *Minor Illusion*, *Silent Image*, or *Darkness* automatically fail due to the blights' blindsight.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

Stage 4: Barricade

In the final stage, **Barricade**, the PCs must lock themselves inside the winery, and keep the horde of encroaching blights from coming in after them. Due to the blights' low intelligence, they will not attempt to chase the PCs by taking alternate routes. If the party has not yet failed a skill check upon reaching this stage, they have successfully avoided disturbing the needle blights and automatically pass this stage of the skill challenge.

- **Investigation (DC 15 - Moderate)** or **Perception (DC 15 - Moderate)** allow a character to locate a suitable item for use in barricading the door. (e.g., a barrel or chair)
- **Athletics (DC 15 - Moderate)** can allow a character to jam the door by damaging its frame or warping its planks.
- **Athletics (DC 15 - Moderate)** can allow a character to barricade the door using a number of large, heavy objects (e.g., barrels or crates).
- **Sleight of Hand (DC 10 - Easy)** can allow a character to reset any lock or chain that had previously been used to keep a door shut.
- **Levelled spells (Automatic Success)** such as *Gust of Wind*, *Web*, or *Wind Wall*; or **cantrips (DC 15 - Moderate)** such as *Mold Earth* can be used to obstruct the advancing blights long enough for the PCs to find a means of keeping it shut.
- **Levelled Spells (Automatic Success)** with large areas of effect such as *Tidal Wave*, *Fireball*, or *Call Lightning* can halt the blights' advance long enough to allow the PCs a few additional seconds of time.

Once the PCs have completed all eight (or six) skill checks, they are able to successfully barricade themselves inside the winery. Depending on their success, they may be hale and

hearty, or exhausted and wounded. If they find themselves in area W9, they may find themselves with little opportunity to recover before they are suddenly thrust into a fight.

□ **Worth a Thousand Words: Winery's Exterior Battlemap**

If you are interested in running this encounter on a printed or projected battlemap, consider using /u/x_calderhead_x's [Wizard of Wines Approach Battlemap](#).

□ **Extra Credit: Unearthed Arcana's Mass Combat Rules**

If you choose to run the battle as-written, given that this combat includes up to 64 creatures, you may find this to be a good opportunity to apply the Mass Combat rules released by WoTC in this Unearthed Arcana update. The free playtesting PDF can be found [here](#).¹⁸³

Areas of the Winery

Should your PCs choose to take a short rest within the walls of the winery before the druids have been defeated, they may take refuge in areas W3, W17, W18, W19, or W20. If they do so, they can attempt a **DC 20 Strength (Athletics)** check to barricade the entrance against any intruding druids or blights (with advantage if two or more PCs are working together to do so).

If this or similar defensive measures are not taken, the druids rally together to hunt down the PCs, and force their way into the party's resting place after 3d6 minutes have passed. Each of the druids and blights within the winery's walls join together to attack, with the three **swarms of twig blights** leading the way, followed by two **druid assailants** and five **needle blights**, who are then joined by two **vine blights** and two **druid naturalists**.

If the PCs successfully defend their resting place, the party can hear a suspicious banging coming from the entrance to their sanctuary, though the sound soon subsides. The **druid naturalists** spend the next hour preparing a trap for the PCs. The five **needle blights** and two **vine blights** are lined up on opposite sides of the room's exit.

One druid naturalist casts *Fog Cloud*, shrouding the corridor in heavily-obscuring mist (which doesn't affect the blights due to their blindsight), while another casts *Spike Growth* just before the PCs exit the room. The transformation of the ground by *Spike Growth* is camouflaged to look natural. Each PC that exits the party's resting place must make a DC 12 **Wisdom (Perception)** check to recognize the terrain as hazardous before entering it.

Any druids or blights that the PCs manage to slay or drive off before beginning their rest should be subtracted from the group that attacks the PCs during or following their short rest.

W9. Fermentation Vats

For the sake of simplicity, you may employ the following stat block for a **swarm of twig blights**,¹⁸⁴ with each swarm containing approximately 8 twig blights (thereby replacing 24 blights with 3 swarms).

SWARM OF TWIG BLIGHTS

Medium swarm of small creatures, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 14 (natural armor)
Hit Points 22 (4d6+8)
Speed 20ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	4 (-3)	8 (-1)	3 (-4)

Damage Vulnerabilities fire
Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, paralyzed, prone, petrified, restrained, stunned
Senses passive Perception 9
Languages -
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

False Appearance. While the swarm remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a mound of dead shrubbery.

Swarm. The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice-versa, and the swarm can move through any opening large enough for a small twig blight. The swarm cannot regain hit points or temporary hit points.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5ft., one creature. *Hit* 16 (4d6 + 2) piercing damage. The attack instead deals 2d6+1 piercing damage if the swarm has half of its hit points or fewer.

Rather than utilizing the usual stat block, the druid in this room is a **druid assailant**. The druid assailant has exactly the same statistics of an ordinary druid, but has the following spells prepared:

- Cantrips: *Druidcraft, Thorn Whip, Shillelagh*
- 1st Level: *Earth Tremor, Longstrider, Healing Word, Thunderwave*

- 2nd Level: *Darkvision*, *Barkskin*

□ Know the Monsters - Druid Assailant

The **druid assailant**, if given time to prepare before combat, always begins by casting *Barkskin* and *Longstrider* on herself. It can also always be assumed that she will cast *Darkvision* immediately upon entering any dark- or dimly-lit area, due to its long duration and lack of concentration. Finally, the druid assailant will cast and continually refresh a *Shillelagh* spell in order to maximize the damage dealt by her quarterstaff.

Once combat is entered, the druid assailant will prioritize weaker, squishier targets over harder, well-armored ones. She will use *Thorn Whip* to force her prey closer, and cast *Thunderwave* to maneuver to a better position if cornered. *Thunderwave* is also used if the druid assailant is given the opportunity to push the PCs over an elevated edge, potentially rendering them prone and dealing fall damage as well.

Once bloodied, she will cast *Healing Word* as a bonus action to restore her hit points, and cast *Shillelagh* as needed to refresh her staff's enchantment. Otherwise, she will prioritize the use of her quarterstaff as a weapon, employing *Earth Tremor* only when accompanied by **berserkers** or melee-oriented **blights** able to take advantage of prone PCs. In general, a druid assailant will never flee from combat, preferring instead to die a glorious death in battle.

W14. Wine Cellar

The druid in this chamber is a **druid assailant**, and has been alerted to the PCs' presence if the PCs failed the skill challenge while evading the needle blights outside, or if combat has occurred elsewhere in the winery, and has prepared accordingly. She begins combat with a *Thunderwave* spell as mentioned in the module, and proceeds to hand-to-hand combat while the needle blights assault the PCs from a distance.

W15. Brown Mold

As described above, the source of the Order of the Feather's lycanthropy is the three Ladies of old Cerunnos, ancient fey creatures who created the Fanes of Barovia. This cold, secret chamber serves as a hiding spot for a raven-shaped totem that was used to extend the Ladies' gift to each new generation of wereravens.

The druids attacked the winery in order to steal back this totem, which they believe belongs to their tribe as the land's original inhabitants. The totem cannot be used to turn a PC into a lycanthrope, as the process of becoming a wereraven involves a year-long procedure of meditation and primal ritual.

W16. Loading Winch

Rather than utilizing the usual stat block, the druid in this room is a **druid naturalist**. The druid naturalist has exactly the same statistics of an ordinary druid, but has the following spells prepared:

- Cantrips: *Druidcraft, Produce Flame, Infestation*
- 1st Level: *Faerie Fire, Entangle, Speak With Animals, Fog Cloud*
- 2nd Level: *Spike Growth, Moonbeam*

Additionally, rather than using its as-written statistics, the *Gulthias staff* that he holds has the following properties:

Gulthias Staff

Staff, rare (requires attunement)

Made from the branch of a Gulthias tree, a Gulthias staff is a spongy, black length of wood from which ashen smoke wisps at a constant rate. It has a strangely spongy texture, and leaves behind a bloody residue on one's hand when touched. If squeezed, blood oozes from its pores. If the staff is broken or burned to ashes, its wood releases a terrible, inhuman scream that can be heard out to a range of 300 feet. All blights that can hear the screams immediately wither and die.

Blight Bane. A character that has attuned to the staff has the ability to command blights around them of CR 2 or below using simple, one-word commands. While you are attuned to the staff, blights and other evil plant creatures don't regard you as hostile unless you harm them.

Sower of Corruption. The Gulthias staff has 5 charges. As an action, its wielder can expend charges to create any of the following creatures:

- 1 charge: 1x Twig Blight
- 2 charges: 1x Needle Blight
- 4 charges: 1x Vine Blight

When all charges are expended, roll a d20. On a 1, the staff crumbles to dust without releasing its blight-killing shriek. Otherwise, it regains 1d4 charges each dawn.

Vampiric Hunger. The Gulthias staff draws its power from the blood of its wielder, extending tiny black roots into the veins beneath the owner's skin. For each day that a character is attuned to it, that character must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw, taking 2d6 necrotic damage on a failure. The target's hit point maximum is reduced by an amount equal to the necrotic damage taken. The reduction lasts until the target destroys or unattunes from the Gulthias staff and finishes a long rest. The target dies if this effect reduces its hit point maximum to 0.

When the PCs first arrive in this room, if any combat has taken place elsewhere in the winery, or if the needle blights outside were disturbed, they find that the druid has already used the staff to

create one **needle blight**, and is currently in the process of creating a **twig blight**, which is grown from a knot toward the end of the staff.

Given the size of the horde outside, it is likely that this druid's *Gulthias Staff* will prove a vital resource in destroying or redirecting the needle blights populating the vineyard. However, this **druid naturalist** is skittish, and immediately attempts to flee upon being encountered. As he leaps from the winch into the room below, he points the staff toward the PCs and commands the blights in Sylvan to attack them. As he delivers his orders, the ash around the staff thickens noticeably, and it weeps crimson blood from its pores.

□ **Know the Monsters - Druid Naturalist**

The **druid naturalist** never fights alone, and immediately flees if isolated. If provided with the opportunity to affect nearly all of the enemy's forces, he casts *Faerie Fire* to make it easier for his druidic, **berserker**, or **blight** allies to hit with their attacks. Otherwise, he casts *Entangle* in an effort to restrain the most dangerous melee combatants in their place.

If any PCs are looking wounded, he releases his concentration on his *Entangle* or *Faerie Fire* spell and instead casts *Moonbeam* in an effort to finish them off, shifting the beam on each turn to deal additional damage. If not casting a higher-levelled spell, the druid naturalist attacks with *Infestation* or *Produce Flame*, depending on whether his target has some cover or no cover, respectively, and actively focuses down any enemy spellcasters. If cornered or reduced to zero allies, the druid naturalist casts *Fog Cloud* and vanishes into the mists.

W20. Printing Press

The druid in this room is a **druid naturalist**, preferring to fight from behind while his **vine blights** keep any intruders from entering the room.

□ **Know The Monsters: Vine Blights**

The two **vine blights** within the winery can use their *Entangling Plants* ability to restrain any members of the party that get too close. This ability will not affect their fellow blights. Because this ability also has reach, a blight can restrain a creature ten feet away, preventing a melee victim from moving any closer to attack.

☐ **Worth a Thousand Words: Wine Labels**

If you wish to provide printed wine labels for your players' aesthetic enjoyment, consider using /u/thewarehouse's [Wizard of Wines Wine Labels image](#).

Special Events

Wine Delivery

Once the PCs have restored the Martikovs to the winery, the characters will likely look to deliver a shipment of wine to one or more locations throughout Barovia. There are three barrels available for immediate delivery (located in the cellar), and twenty poisoned barrels' worth of wine available in the fermentation vats. Note that the barrels that the PCs can immediately deliver are not tainted by poison.

It is your choice whether Davian Martikov recognizes the spoiled nature of the vats' wine. If he does not, any further attempts by the PCs to deliver their shipment result in a plague of poisoned customers across the location of delivery. Assume that these characters will link their illness to the PCs' "gift," and react accordingly.

☐ **Strands of Fate: Purifying Food and Drink**

It is a rare adventure that involves the use of poison or disease as a notable plot point. As such, it is unlikely that any of your PCs will have voluntarily chosen or prepared *Purify Food and Drink*. If your party lacks a cleric or druid capable of preparing this spell, consider placing a *Spell Scroll of Purify Food and Drink* or similar wondrous item as a reward for a previous encounter within Barovia. This scroll may be a relic of a previous adventuring party, loot from Death House or Old Bonegrinder, or a special on-sale item from Jenny Greenteeth.

Wintersplinter Attacks

If your PCs are uninterested in pursuing leads at Yester Hill or Berez, be prepared for Wintersplinter's attack to take place in the background while the party travels elsewhere in Barovia. This event is a key opportunity to show your players that Ravenloft is an active, changing setting, and that their choices and priorities can have a major impact on the way the story unfolds.

Keep in mind that the event as-written specifies that the PCs return to the Wizard of Wines almost immediately following Wintersplinter's attack. Given the distance between the winery and Yester Hill, the tree blight is perhaps no more than a half-hour's travel southward. If you wish, you may run a scene in which the Martikovs mourn the loss of the winery and their newfound status as refugees. In that case, if your PCs pursue Wintersplinter down the road, use the tips found in the *Wintersplinter Marching* box below.

! Expanded Event: Wintersplinter Marching

Wintersplinter's goal in this encounter is to return to its masters, the druids of Yester Hill. You may choose to employ the details of the Missing Martikovs quest hook below, in which case one of Wintersplinter's limbs has been transformed into a cage holding Adrian and Elvir Martikov in raven's form. This cage has AC 12, 20 hitpoints, and regenerates 10 hitpoints at the beginning of Wintersplinter's turn.

As Wintersplinter is likely unable to outrace your PCs, it will engage the PCs in combat if they attack it first. Once combat begins, Wintersplinter grapples up to two PCs on each of its turns, focusing its attention on the last creature to deal notable damage to it. It instantly focuses its attention on any creature(s) that hit it with fire damage. Once a creature has been grappled, Wintersplinter holds that creature fifteen feet away to prevent melee attacks, and attacks them with its two branch attacks and bonus bite attack, tossing them aside once they fall unconscious.

Alternatively, you may choose to have the PCs return to the winery hours or even days following Wintersplinter's attack. In that case, consider having a single NPC, such as a mournful Urwin Martikov or Muriel fill the characters in.

When the PCs arrive at the destroyed winery, read:

In the distance, thunder rumbles as a light drizzle begins to fall. You follow the muddy trail southward, descending through the woods until the trees part on either side. You turn westward toward the mist-shrouded meadow that lies in the valley below—and beyond it, the Wizard of Wines winery.

But the winery is no longer there.

In its place, a great, misshapen pile of stone, wood, and smoke sits at the center of the vineyard. The entire front facade of the winery has been torn away, the stones and wood planks cast aside like refuse. Beyond it, the stone pavilion and flagstone floors have been cracked and crunched, as if pressured beneath an enormous weight, while the walls and roof have been torn away as if by a wrathful deity. A single stone staircase, miraculously still standing, leads silently to a landing that no longer exists.

Not a single wall stands to its full height—most have been reduced to lumpy, contorted piles of rock no more than five or six feet tall. The second floor is simply gone—its pulverized remains lying in tiny, debris-ridden piles across the earth of the vineyard. The stable has been stomped flat, the tiles of its roof cracked and mixing with piles of mud-stained hay. Smashed stone blocks mingle with the splinters of finely-made barrels; the twisted wreckage of the loading winch and crane lies on its side, the rigging torn to bits. Chips and shards of furniture—beds, dressers, tables, chairs—have been thrown across the meadow, trampled and broken.

The vineyard beyond has fared no better. The fences have been smashed into kindling, the earth gouged with deep muddy ditches and piled high with mounds of soil mixed with plant matter. Not a single whole grapevine remains, the pale green of life soiled by the dark brown

of earth and spreading purplish puddles that resemble gaping wounds. Through it all, a keen eye can follow lines of massive, inhuman tracks that lurch through the destruction.

The mist swirls silently across the wreckage as droplets of rain run like tears across the mud. The meadow around it is as silent as the grave.

□ **The Butterfly Effect: The Winery's Destruction**

Other NPCs throughout Barovia are likely to comment on or react to Wintersplinter's siege. If this event occurs concurrently with the Dinner with Strahd special event, consider having Strahd arriving late to the castle, and making reference to an "event" on Yester Hill. Baron Vallakovich is likely to take drastic action upon hearing of the destruction of the winery, and the Blue Water Inn will find itself in dire financial straits following the addition of several new permanent residents of the Martikov family. Krezk Burgomaster Dmitri Krezkov may offer the PCs an alternative means of entry into Krezk, should the PCs offer proof of the winery's destruction. It is likely that the Order of the Feather, save for any specific allies that the PCs make, will blame the party for its failure to stop the druids from executing their plans.

Once Wintersplinter has returned to Yester Hill, it will likely remain there, either rooted within the center of the Druids' Circle, or lurking within the woods nearby. Should any nearby settlement, such as Krezk, Vallaki, or Argynvostholt, anger Strahd due to the provision of sanctuary or aid to Ireena or the PCs, he may order the druids to direct Wintersplinter to siege that settlement's walls alongside a small army of blights as punishment.

The destruction of the Winery will likely serve as a low point in the PCs' friendship with the Martikovs, and may create a dangling sense of a job unfinished. If you wish to provide the PCs with a further reason to explore Yester Hill and Berez, consider employing the following plot hook:

□ **Plot Hook: The Missing Martikovs**

When Wintersplinter attacked the Wizard of Wines winery, most of the wereravens fled, save for Stefania Martikov, Davian's daughter. Stefania fought back against the tree blight, assuming raven's form as she flew between Wintersplinter's brambles - only to be ensnared in a cage of brambles and branches grown from the great tree's claws. When Stefania's young son, Martin, broke from Davian's grasp and pursued his mother, he too was captured, and both were spirited away to Yester Hill.

If the PCs are friendly with Muriel Vinshaw, the wereraven approaches them and begs their help in rescuing Stefania. Many years ago, before Stefania married her husband, Dag, she and Muriel shared a long, deep romance that Muriel still treasures to this day. If the PCs do not know Muriel, another member of the Keepers of the Feather may arrive to give them the quest instead.

When the PCs arrive at Yester Hill, they find Stefania Martikov bound and unconscious in a cocoon of sap and branches bound to the trunk of the Gulthias Tree. The druids have been preparing her body as a sacrifice to the vampiric tree, leaving her body scarred with ritualistic cuts, poisoned with strange fungi and roots, and smeared with soil, feces, and rotted honey.

If Stefania is rescued, she informs the PCs that her son, Martin, was traded to a group of animated scarecrows in exchange for a delivery of foul-smelling honey. If the PCs make their way to Berez to rescue Martin, they find him trapped in raven's form in one of Baba Lysaga's bird-cages. The hag has threatened to eat him, and plans on baking him into a pie once he's fattened up.

Any surviving Martikov or member of the Order of the Feather may assign this quest to the PCs. If the PCs ignore this quest for two days or more, Stefania dies of her wounds soon after being rescued, and the original quest-giver can be found dead in Berez, having attempted to rescue Martin themselves and failed. Martin himself survives, having been forgotten in the cages by Baba Lysaga.

Chapter 7: Yester Hill

Ch. 7: Yester Hill

□ Strands of Fate: Hooks to Yester Hill

A Martikov's Plea: If the PCs previously cleared the Wizard of Wines winery of blights and druids, Davian Martikov asks them to retrieve the stolen wine gem taken by the druids to Yester Hill, making it clear that Barovia's wine trade and the family's livelihood will die if the gem is lost.

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies beneath the roots of the Gulthias Tree, the PCs can find it here, following the directions of the Martikovs or one of Vallaki's wolf hunters, Szoldar and Yevgeni.

Cleansing the Fanes: If the PCs have discovered the ancient druidic runes in the Swamp Fane (Berez), or Forest Fane (Old Bonegrinder), or if they've learned of the nature of the Fanes from Elder Ormir in Yaedrag (near Tsolenka Pass), they may decide to journey to Yester Hill in order to reconsecrate the Mountain Fane there.

Areas of the Hill

Y1. Trail

The Seeker's Shrine

This small stone shrine was constructed centuries ago just beside the path that winds up Yester Hill, built as a monument to a great chief of the druidic society now known as the Forest People. That chief's spirit, a ghost named Kavan the Bloodsinger, still lingers within the stones erected to his memory, his soul tormented by the fate that has befallen his people.

At the base of the terraced hill sits a [small](#)

[ring of standing slabs of stone](#), each slab no taller than three feet in height. A thick carpet of moss rolls over the earth here, clinging to the sides of a trio of carved obelisk-like slabs before bubbling over the sides of a terraced cobblestone shrine three layers tall. At the center of the shrine stands a single stone slab, its smooth face washed clean by millenia of wind and water, save for a myriad of carved symbols and runes. A single raven rests upon the slab, and caws mockingly as you approach.

Each of the "obelisk" slabs bears one of three carvings honoring the *Rozana*, the Ladies of the Fanes: the Eye of the Seeker; the Tree of the Weaver; or the Wolf of the Huntress. The central slab contains the following passage, written in druidic runes: *"Here lies Kavan the Bloodsinger. May his spirit guide us through the trials of the Ladies Three."* It stands above the engraved image of a long spear whose carved tip drips with blood.

If the PCs move to pass the shrine by, and have previously rescued the Wizard of Wines from its blight infestation, read the following:

You hear a whisper, a deep voice carried on the wind.

"Long have I waited," it says, "for ones who are worthy. Approach my monument, such that I may look upon you."

The Chieftain's Spirit

The raven atop the monument is a spy for the Keepers of the Feather, but also a servant of the Ladies of the Fanes. Its feathers are tipped with tufts of white, and it can also be found at the Swamp and Forest Fanes and Jeny Greenteeth's hut off the

western Svalich Road. If the PCs have previously saved the Wizard of Wines from the druids' invasion, this messenger, called Stribog by those that know it, has already impressed Kavan with stories of their bravery and prowess.

Should the PCs approach the monument after hearing Kavan's message, the **ghost** of the chieftain's spirit appears to them: a tall, broad-shouldered, well-muscled man with long, dark hair, and a pair of bloody handprints upon his chest. One of his eyes is missing, and he bears a gaping, ragged socket in the place where it once rested. He carries the ghostly image of his spear, *Bloodsinger*, and has a proud, solemn countenance.

Kavan greets the PCs warmly, and thanks them for their service to the disciples of the *Rozana*, which he soon clarifies to be the Martikov clan. He does not reveal their nature as wereravens, but does reveal that Davian Martikov and his kin serve the legacy of the Ladies Three, a trio of archfey-like entities that once ruled the land of Barovia. He can also share with the PCs the following information:

- The nation of Barovia was once called "Cerunnos" by the druids, but was renamed "Delmor" when invaded by a race of Men called Delmoreans ruled by a cruel tyrant named King Dostron the Hellborn, and again renamed as "Barovia" when Strahd's forces invaded.
- A great schism split the Forest People in the wake of Strahd's invasion, in which a group of druids, bitter from centuries of oppression and isolation by the Delmoreans, guided Strahd to their most holy

places in the hopes that his patronage would replace the power that they had lost.

- Both sides of the druidic tribes claim the title of Forest People. Those that oppose Strahd name his servants "the Faithless."
- The Faithless have stolen an artifact of great power from the Martikov clan - a large green gem imbued with the power of the Ladies Three.

If Wintersplinter has not yet attacked, Kavan warns the PCs that the Faithless have designs to invoke a ritual of foul blood magic atop the hill that night, likely to strike back against the Martikov clan in retribution for their failed invasion. He informs them that the ritual will begin at Moonrise, and adds that the "whisperings of ravens" have told him that an emissary of the Dark One will be present for this event. If the PCs appear interested in preventing this ritual and night has not yet fallen, Kavan presents them with a choice: Strike in the day, before the ritual has begun; or attack at nightfall, when the shadows can cloak their approach.

The way up the hill is long and taxing, and its trails are patrolled by many warriors of the Faithless. If the PCs are discovered, Kavan warns, the enemy will rouse many to combat, and may slay the PCs or drive them away. If the PCs attack under cover of night, however, they have a better opportunity of making it to the top, especially as many of the tribe's berserkers will be drawn to the crest of the hill as guardians of the ritual. However, if the PCs wait until nightfall, they risk the ritual's completion.

Kavan does not share any further information until the PCs have disrupted the ritual upon Yester Hill or destroyed Wintersplinter in its approach upon the Wizard of Wines. If Wintersplinter has already destroyed the winery, Kavan solemnly asks the PCs to destroy the Gulthias Tree atop the hill as retribution for the sins of his people.

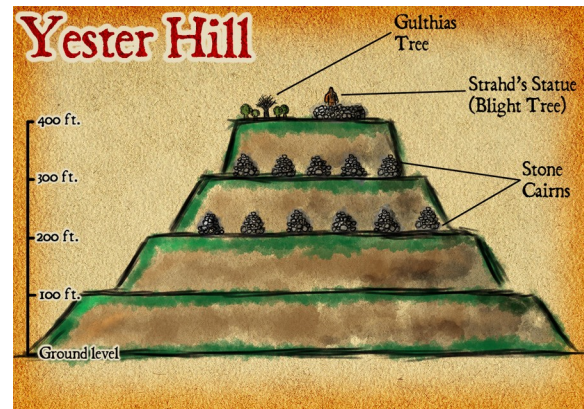
A creature that excavates the area around Kavan's grave finds his bones buried ten feet beneath the central slab. His spear, *Bloodsinger*, however, cannot be found here. It was stolen from his corpse by the future leader of the Faithless when Kavan was buried, and is buried beneath that leader's cairn on the third terrace.

Geography of the Hill

Yester Hill is a terraced hill of four distinct levels. The trail to the top spirals around the hillside, and is lined by the ring of stone cairns. Each spiral of the trail climbs 100 feet up the hill, and the entire path (1.2 miles) can be traversed at a normal pace in roughly 30 minutes. Additionally, a long and jagged slope of rocky, crumbling stone cuts up the front of the hill at a steep incline (0.1 miles), which can be climbed in just over 5 minutes.¹⁸⁵ Each creature that attempts to ascend the incline must make a DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check for each of the four terraces that they climb, taking 1d6 bludgeoning damage on a failure and drawing the attention of any nearby berserker patrols.

The trail is the safer, slower approach, while a creature climbing the rocky slope can be more easily seen by an onlooker peering over the ledge at the top.

¹⁸⁵ Matt88, [Yester Hill](#)



Source: [ElvenTower, Chapter 14 - Yester Hill](#)

Berserker Patrols

The path up Yester Hill is regularly patrolled by a number of druidic guards, which travel in groups of 1d4+1 **berserkers** alongside a single **druid assailant**.

The first terrace is always patrolled by a lone pair of watchful **berserkers**. For each of the three terraces that the PCs ascend beyond that, roll 1d20. On a roll of 10 or above (if made during the day) or 17 or above (if made during the night), the party encounters a berserker patrol that must be hidden from or fought.

If the PCs are attempting to make their way up the hill with stealth, they notice the sound of an oncoming patrol if any member of the party has a passive Perception of 13 or higher. The PCs may then attempt to conceal themselves among the many stone cairns that ring the ascending trail (if climbing the main path), or by pressing themselves between the stone crags of the rocky scree (if ascending by the steeper slope). They succeed in doing so without rousing suspicion if at least half of the party succeeds at a DC 14 Dexterity (Stealth) check, made with advantage if the check is made at night. Otherwise, the patrol moves to investigate further, and can only be

distracted through some manner of spellcraft or other trickery with a successful DC 14 Charisma (Performance) check.

One berserker in each patrol carries with them a large warhorn carved from the antler of an ancient dire elk.¹⁸⁶ When that berserker is reduced to half or fewer hitpoints, they use their action to disengage from battle, retreating 30 feet beyond the front line and raising the horn to their lips. On their next turn, they blow the horn, alerting all other creatures on or near the hill of the party's presence. Once alerted in this way, any other berserker patrols rapidly converge on the party's location, and the DC of any future Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide from these patrols is increased to 17.

The patrols attack all intruders without mercy, and fight to the death. Yester Hill is a sacred place to them, and they do not fear defeat.

Y2. Berserker Cairns

Buried three feet beneath the soft earth to the north of an indistinct cairn on the third terrace of Yester Hill is Kavan's Blood Spear, *Bloodsinger*.

Y3. Druids' Circle

☐ **Worth a Thousand Words - Map of Druids' Circle**

The /r/CurseOfStrahd subreddit joined together to commission a high-resolution battle-ready map of Area Y3, given that no such map is provided in the module. You can find a ZIP file containing day and night versions of this map [here](#). Those who helped fund this project include @InvaderZim#5121, @BigPapaTn#3201, @Sainon#7087, @Chris#0768 on Discord and /u/SlightestSmile on Reddit. Credit for the map goes to [NeutralParty](#).¹⁸⁷

The rocks that comprise the druids' circle range from 10 to 15 feet in height, and require a DC 14 Strength (Athletics) check to climb. Do note that the lightning from the eternal storm above Yester Hill strikes the tops of these black, slippery boulders, and **not** the stone cairns that ring the path ascending the hill.

Once the winding path around Yester Hill reaches the top, the trail continues for an additional 200 feet before reaching the stone circle. The entrance to the druids' circle is guarded at all times by 5 **berserkers** and 2 **druid assailants**. If the alarm is raised by a berserker patrol lower down the hill, 2 **berserkers** and a single **druid assailant** peel off to investigate the disturbance.

When the PCs enter the circle, read the following:

Atop the hill is a wide ring of black boulders and smaller rocks that collectively form a makeshift wall

186 Matt88, [Yester Hill](#)

187 [Yester Hill Map Commission & A Subreddit Update](#)

enclosing a field of dead grass. Lightning strikes the edge of the ring from time to time, illuminating a ghastly, fifty-foot-tall statue made of tightly woven twigs and packed with black earth. The packed earth of the ground rises five feet above either side of the winding trail, forming a natural ditch that snakes toward a wide break in the stone ring on the opposite side.

To the east side of the ring, rough-cut earthen steps lead up to an array of several large boulders that stand among a patch of bare, muddy earth. To the west side of the ring, a set of dirt stairs halfway down the path ascends to a semicircle of tall standing stones arranged in simple geometric patterns around the enormous wooden statue. To the south, beyond the edge of the ring, a massive dead tree rises above a small thicket of gnarled, grey foliage.

If the PCs arrive the day of the ritual, six **druid naturalists** and **Svarog, Druid Elder** are meditating in a semicircle around the statue within the array of standing stones to the west. An additional four **druid assailants** are slumbering beneath the loose earth of several shallow graves scattered amongst the muddy boulders to the east.

If the PCs arrive during the ritual, six **druid naturalists** are performing an arcane chant around the statue while **Svarog, Druid Elder** looks on. Four **druid assailants** are gathered in defensive formation around the semicircle of standing stones. **Strahd von Zarovich**, mounted on the **nightmare** Bucephalus, looks on from the southern side of the standing stones, while **Anastraya Karelava** stands just beside

him. For more information on this ritual, see the *Druids' Ritual* special event below.

If the PCs arrive after the ritual has been completed, day or night, the front of the statue has been torn open, leaving only a hollow shell of thick twigs and brambles behind. If Wintersplinter has not yet been defeated, an enormous dead tree also sits rooted to the ground toward the very center of the ring. This tree is in truth the **tree blight**, Wintersplinter, which animates and attacks any creature that attempts to remove the glowing green gem from its trunk. Three **druid assailants** and three **druid naturalists** can also be found slumbering beneath the loose earth of the shallow graves between the muddy boulders to the east. The druids arise from their sleep and attack any PCs that disturb Wintersplinter, or who pass through the semicircle of standing stones to the western side of the ring.

Assailants & Naturalists

The **druid assailant** has exactly the same statistics of an ordinary druid, but has the following spells prepared:

- Cantrips: *Druidcraft, Thorn Whip, Shillelagh*
- 1st Level: *Earth Tremor, Longstrider, Healing Word, Thunderwave*
- 2nd Level: *Darkvision, Barkskin*

The **druid naturalist** has exactly the same statistics of an ordinary druid, but has the following spells prepared:

- Cantrips: *Druidcraft, Produce Flame, Infestation*
- 1st Level: *Faerie Fire, Entangle, Speak With Animals, Fog Cloud*
- 2nd Level: *Spike Growth, Moonbeam*

See [here](#) for more information on running the druid assailant or naturalist in combat.

The Wooden Statue

A creature that approaches the wooden statue of Strahd can clearly see an array of thick, black roots woven around and into its lower half. The roots continue above ground toward the south side of the ring, a tight “wire” of bundled roots five feet across that winds through the southern exit, passes through the grove of dead foliage to the south, and ends at the trunk of the Gulthias tree.

Y4. Gulthias Tree

If he is not overseeing the ritual in Area Y3 (Druids’ Circle), **Svarog, Druid Elder** can be found within a “cocoon” of interlocking roots and branches approximately halfway (15 feet) up the central trunk of the **Gulthias Tree**. A creature that inspects Svarog’s body finds that the roots of the tree have protruded thousands of tiny black tendrils penetrating Svarog’s skin, drawing sustenance from his blood.

Should the Gulthias Tree be reduced to less than one-third of its hitpoints, it immediately uses its *Blood Drain* legendary action on Svarog, which drains Svarog of his remaining HP and reduces him to a shrivelled corpse.

While he is awake, only Svarog’s torso and lower body are contained within the cocoon, which provides him with an AC of 16. While asleep, his body is withdrawn completely

into the cocoon’s interior. He is usually asleep, and awakens on the first round of combat after a creature attacks the Gulthias Tree.

As in the module, the grove of dead foliage is infested with 3 **vine blights**, 6 **needle blights**, and 12 **twig blights**. These blights are replenished by the Gulthias Tree each day at dusk. The dense thicket of gnarled trees and brushwood rises to a height of 20 feet around the Gulthias Tree, obstructing any view of Svarog’s cocoon from the outside of the grove. The vine and twig blights use their False Appearance to blend perfectly with the surrounding foliage, while the needle blights are hidden among the thicket and require a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect.

If the Gulthias Tree is reduced to 0 hit points, it seems to be destroyed but isn’t truly dead; it regains 1 hit point every month until it is fully healed. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check, a character can determine that the entire stump must be uprooted for the tree to truly die. The Gulthias Tree withers and dies in 3d10 days if a *hallow* spell is cast in its area, and does so immediately if the Mountain Fane below is reconsecrated.

Six feet above the earth on the north side of the Gulthias Tree’s trunk lies a knot of black bark (AC 12, HP 20) that resembles a weeping face. This knot contains the *dagger of the Seeker* (see Area Y6 below).

GULTHIAS TREE

Gargantuan plant, neutral evil

Armor Class 16 (natural armor)

Hit Points 149 (13d12+65)

Speed 0ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	6 (-2)	19 (+4)	6 (-2)	11 (+0)	3 (-4)

Damage Resistances bludgeoning and piercing from nonmagical weapons

Damage Immunities necrotic, psychic

Condition Immunities blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified

Senses blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 10

Languages Understands Common and Druidic but doesn't speak

Challenge 7 (2,900 XP)

False Appearance. While the Gulthias Tree remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a dead tree.

Summon Blights (Lair Action). On initiative count 20 (losing initiative ties), the Gulthias tree uses a lair action to spawn 1d4 Twig Blights among its roots.

Actions

Multiattack. The Gulthias Tree makes 2 attacks with its branches.

Branch. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (2d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Grasping Root. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 15 ft., one creature not grappled by the tree. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage and the target is grappled (escape DC 15). The root has AC 16 and can be severed by dealing 6 slashing damage or more to it at once. Cutting the root doesn't hurt the Gulthias Tree, but ends the grapple.

Frightful Presence (Recharge 5-6). Red blood oozes from the pores of the Gulthias tree as it releases a low, keening moan. Each creature that is within 30 feet of the Gulthias Tree must succeed on a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or become Frightened for 1 minute. A creature can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success. If a creature's saving throw is successful or the effect ends for it, the creature is immune to the Gulthias Tree's Frightful Presence for the next 24 hours.

Legendary Actions

The Gulthias Tree can take 2 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one legendary action can be used at a time, and only at the end of another creature's turn. The Gulthias Tree regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Root. The Gulthias Tree makes one Grasping Root attack.

Lift. The Gulthias Tree can use its roots to lift a creature that is currently grappled by it up to 20 ft. into the air.

Blood Drain. Black tendrils extend from the roots of the Gulthias Tree and penetrate the skin of a single creature that is currently grappled by it. That creature must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, that creature takes 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage plus 10 (3d6) necrotic damage. The target's hit point maximum is reduced by an amount equal to the necrotic damage taken, and the Gulthias tree regains Hit Points equal to that amount. The reduction lasts until the target finishes a Long Rest. The target dies if this effect reduces its hit point maximum to 0. A humanoid slain in this way and then buried in the ground rises the following night as a mindless Vampire Spawn under the control of Strahd von Zarovich.

SVAROG, DRUID ELDER

Medium human, neutral evil

Armor Class 11 (16 while in his cocoon)

Hit Points 39 (7d8 + 7)

Speed 30ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)	17 (+3)	12 (+1)

Skills Medicine +6, Nature +4, Perception +6

Senses passive Perception 16

Languages Common, Druidic

Challenge 5 (1,800 XP)

Spellcasting. Svarog is a 7th-level spellcaster. His spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks). He has the following druid spells prepared:

- Cantrips (at will): Mold Earth, Infestation, Shillelagh
- 1st Level (4 Slots): Thunderwave, Ice Knife, Entangle, Fog Cloud
- 2nd Level (3 Slots): Moonbeam, Gust of Wind
- 3rd Level (3 Slots): Call Lightning, Plant Growth, Erupting Earth
- 4th Level (1 Slot): Wall of Fire

Actions

Quarterstaff. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5ft., one target. *Hit* 3 (1d6 - 1) bludgeoning damage, or 8 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage with shillelagh or if wielded with two hands.

□ Know the Monsters: Grove of the Gulthias Tree

Neither the blights, Svarog, nor the Gulthias Tree attack intruders that enter the grove without hostile intent. Initiative is only rolled when one or more PCs declare attacks against the tree or any of the lurking blights.

When combat begins, the **twig blights** and **needle blights** attack whichever character is nearest, but have a preference for unarmored and/or ranged combatants. Any blight within the dense thicket surrounding the Gulthias Tree has half cover and a +2 bonus to AC.

Meanwhile, the **vine blights** attempt to entrap any ranged enemies using their *Entangling Plants* action, after which they focus on keeping melee enemies away from the Gulthias Tree by grappling them with the *Constrict* action and dragging them away.

The **Gulthias Tree** prioritizes its own defense over all else. It makes a *Branches* multiattack on each turn, and uses its *Root* and *Lift* legendary actions to seize any melee attacker and haul them high into the air, away from its vulnerable trunk. If injured, the Tree uses its *Blood Drain* legendary action to restore its lost health from any grappled enemy. Once reduced to fewer than one-third of its maximum hit points, if Svarog, Druid Elder is within his cocoon on its trunk and it has no other targets to drain, the Gulthias Tree uses its *Blood Drain* on him, draining all of his hitpoints and rejuvenate its own.

Svarog, Druid Elder begins combat by casting *Plant Growth* centered on the trunk of the Gulthias Tree, reducing mobility for any creature that wishes to approach. He then alternates between an offensive and defensive strategy, depending on whether an enemy is currently attacking the trunk of the

Gulthias Tree. If playing defensively, Svarog uses *Gust of Wind* to push any attackers away from the tree's vulnerable trunk, and then casts *Ice Knife* and *Infestation* to whittle down their health. If playing offensively, Svarog casts *Call Lightning*, whose damage is improved to 4d10 on a failed save due to the stormy conditions of Yester Hill, and uses his action on each subsequent turn to call down a new bolt of lightning.

If his concentration on *Call Lightning* is broken, Svarog casts *Moonbeam*, using his action on each subsequent turn to move it to a new enemy's space. If reduced below one-half health, Svarog casts *Fog Cloud*, which removes visibility for any PCs, but allows the Gulthias Tree and its blindsight-endowed blights to continue attacking. While *Fog Cloud* is active, Svarog continues to attack enemies using *Ice Knife* and *Infestation*. If a PC climbs the trunk or otherwise approaches his cocoon, Svarog attempts to push them away by casting *Thunderwave*.

Y5. Wall of Fog

Strahd takes Bucephalus to journey toward the Wall of Fog once every two weeks, when a Blood Moon rises over Barovia. As mentioned in the module, he spends the night from dusk till dawn staring into the mists, tantalizing himself with visions of his homeland. If the PCs are looking to infiltrate Castle Ravenloft before their final confrontation with Strahd (e.g., to retrieve a Tarokka item or Argynvost's skull), a number of NPCs can inform them of this event, including: Ezmerelda, Davian Martikov, Rudolph van Richten, Kasimir, Jeny Greenteeth, and Madam Eva.¹⁸⁸

Y6. Mountain Fane

[Click here](#) for more information about the Mountain Fane.

Special Events

Druids' Ritual

If the PCs assault Yester Hill at night and before Wintersplinter's creation, they arrive at the summit of the Hill just in time to view the druids' ritual in process. No matter the time the PCs arrive at the entrance to the stone circle, the druids are always exactly 10 turns away from completing the ritual and summoning Wintersplinter.

During the ritual, five **druid naturalists** surround the statue of Strahd within the semicircle of standing stones within the stone circle, chanting in the druidic tongue. Any creature can see a stream of sickly green magic flowing from each chanting druid's staff toward the statue at the center of their circle. Two of these druid naturalists must use their action to continue chanting each round while within the semicircle of standing stones; if, at the end of the druid naturalists' turn, there are fewer than two druids casting the ritual, it is disrupted, Wintersplinter's nascent form crumbles within the statue, and the magic must be begun anew.

Three **druid assailants** flank the standing stones, guarding the naturalists while the ritual is completed. They are joined by **Svarog, Druid Elder**, who is present to oversee the ritual and defend his druids from any interruptions. Watching the ritual from the southern side of the standing stones are **Strahd von Zarovich**, astride his **nightmare** Bucephalus; and his bride **Anastraya Karelava**. Strahd and Anastraya

are present as guests, having been invited due to Anastraya's brokerage of the alliance between Svarog and Baba Lysaga. However, Strahd makes no effort to interfere with the PCs' efforts to stop the ritual, and halts Anastraya if she moves to defend the druids, curious to see how events unfold.

Casting the Ritual

A dim, green glow can be seen surrounding the wooden statue, fueled by the sickly green mana flowing from the druids' staffs around it. With each passing round, this aura grows brighter, as the flow of energy can be seen to empower the statue further.¹⁸⁹ The stakes and countdown are made clear to the PCs each round as follows:

Round	Description
1	Svarog, Druid Elder taunts the PCs, declaring that the Chosen (Anastraya) of the Great Shadow (Strahd) has brought his people the power they need to destroy the Betrayers (the Keepers of the Feather).
2	A heavy mist swirls around the chanting druids and the statue, lightly obscuring everything in a 30-foot radius around the statue.
3	The gem within the statue's chest begins to glow a bright green. Svarog declares that the Scion of Gulthias (Wintersplinter) will soon reduce the Winged Betrayers (the Martikovs) to splinters.

4	The sky grows dark as the clouds swell and blacken overhead. A heavy wind begins to blow across the hill as the magic flowing from the druids to the statue redoubles in intensity.
5	The twigs comprising the wooden statue begin to swell, twist, and groan. Svarog laughs, commanding Wintersplinter to Grow! Drink! Consume!
6	If he has not already done so, Strahd commands Bucephalus to fly above the battlefield in order to look down upon the statue. Anastraya transforms into a bat and follows him.
7	A massive, dark shape forms within the statue. "Wintersplinter comes!" Svarog roars.
8	The lightning around Yester Hill increases in intensity, striking the stone circle more regularly. Any creature that begins its turn or atop the stone circle, a boulder, a standing stone, or a tree has a 50% chance of being struck by a bolt of lightning. A bolt of lightning lances down toward Strahd, and he deflects it with a lazy wave of his hand.
9	A low cracking and resonant, monstrous roar is audible from the statue as the shape within solidifies. "Wintersplinter is born!" Svarog laughs.
10	Wintersplinter uses its action to burst from the interior of the statue on its turn.

¹⁸⁹ Matt88, [Yester Hill](#)

□ Know the Monsters - Svarog, Druid Elder

Should the PCs attack while he is overseeing the ritual, Svarog begins combat by casting *Wall of Fire* to block their approach, followed by *Plant Growth* and *Erupting Earth* to slow them down. Once all PCs have made it through the Wall, Svarog drops concentration on it and casts *Call Lightning*, whose damage is improved to 4d10 on a failed save due to the stormy conditions of Yester Hill, and uses his action on each subsequent turn to call down a new bolt of lightning. He prioritizes attacking any enemy magic-users, but will redirect his attention if any PC begins attacking or ascending the statue of Strahd.

If his concentration on *Call Lightning* is broken, Svarog casts *Moonbeam*, using his action on each subsequent turn to move it to a new enemy's space. If the druids casting the ritual are reduced to below one-half their numbers, Svarog casts *Fog Cloud*, which removes visibility for the PCs and allows the druids to refocus their efforts on the ritual. While *Fog Cloud* is active, Svarog continues to attack enemies using *Ice Knife* and *Infestation*. If reduced to less than one-half of his maximum hit points, and the ritual is in danger of being disrupted, Svarog casts *Gust of Wind* in effort to keep any melee combatants from reaching the druids.

The druids continue to attack the PCs for as long as they remain at Yester Hill, but make no effort to pursue if the party chases after Wintersplinter.

If the ritual is disrupted, Strahd descends from Bucephalus and congratulates the PCs on their victory. If they have already dined with him at Castle Ravenloft, he makes some reference to his faith in their abilities and his interest in their future; if they have not already done so, he informs them to expect an invitation from him shortly.

Whether the ritual is disrupted or successfully completed, Strahd then dismisses Anastraya and makes his way atop Bucephalus toward the Wall of Fog, where he proceeds to stare into the mists until dawn. If the PCs approach, Strahd greets them mournfully, and ponders aloud the cruelties of Fate. He then dismisses them, transforming into his mist form if attacked, with Bucephalus departing for the Border Ethereal shortly thereafter.

After the Ritual

When the ritual has concluded, and Wintersplinter is born, the tree blight immediately begins marching toward the Wizard of Wines winery at Svarog's direction. Using its Huge size, it is able to easily step down one terraced level of Yester Hill on each of its turns before continuing on the northern path.

□ Know the Monsters -
Wintersplinter

Due to Wintersplinter's blindsight, the **tree blight** will not pursue any PCs or other hostile creatures that flee its 60 ft. radius. On each of its turns while marching toward the Wizard of Wines, it will move its full 30 ft. up the path and use its Multiattack on any nearby hostile creatures. Due to its low intelligence and



effort to target any ranged attackers while melee opponents are nearby; however, if no melee enemies are nearby and it sustains at least 25 damage in a single turn or becomes bloodied, it becomes

distracted from its northward path and will pursue any ranged enemies using the Dash action.

Chapter 8: Argynvostholt

Chapter 8: Argynvostholt

☐ Strands of Fate - Hooks to Argynvostholt

Search for the Searcher: If the PCs have previously been tasked by Arrigal and Luvash of the Vallakian Vistani encampment with meeting up with Savid in his search for Arabelle, his tracks will lead them to the scene of his skirmish with the needle blights, and, eventually, to Argynvostholt.

Following the Tarokka: If one of the three foretold artifacts is present in Argynvostholt, it can be found in the possession of Vladimir Horngaard in his throne room on the third floor.

A Dragon's Destiny: If you have, through backstory or the Tarokka reading, given one of your PCs the personal quest of laying Argynvost's spirit to rest, they may be directed through Tarokka prophecy or by dreams toward Argynvostholt in order to uncover the riddle within.

The Wandering Revenant: If the party has encountered the wandering revenant random encounter, they will likely investigate Argynvostholt in order to find potential allies in the fight against Strahd. This revenant should be encountered in the Ravenloft Moors, the Vallaki Valley, the Bogs of Berez, or the trail up Mount Ghakis, as described [here](#).

Areas of Argynvostholt

Q3. Dragon's Foyer

When the PCs first encounter the draconic shadow here, they should feel obliged to follow it, almost as though it is summoning them to the upper floors by its presence.

Q4. Spiders' Ballroom

The original Order of the Silver Dragon was thoroughly looted when Strahd's forces attacked. However, in the centuries that have passed since, more adventurers have found their way into Barovia - such as a three-person party including a half-elf ranger, a tiefling wizard, and an elven rogue. These adventurers were slain by the spiders here a century ago, and their remains have long since dessicated to web-clad bone. If their skeletons are searched, the PCs can find a Wand of Magic Detection, a silver dagger, and an Everburning Torch here. These remains are not instantly visible to any creature, but should be described to any PC with a passive perception of 16 or greater, or to any character that enters the spiders' nest.

Q13. Chapel of Mourning

To alleviate the difficulty of this encounter, if the PCs have already befriended the wandering revenant found in the random encounter described in the module, you can have that friendly revenant make a surprise reappearance in defense of the heroes should they look to be close to defeat.

Q14. Chapel Staircases

From the bottom of the staircase, the PCs can hear the sound of retreating boots, as well as an echo of polished steel. Upon reaching the top however, no person is visible.

Q17. West Staircase

Unintelligible whispers from two distinct voices can be heard at the top of this staircase.

Q19. Ruined Bedchambers

Any PC that steps onto the floor of these rooms must make a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw or fall into Q4 (Spiders' Ballroom) below. To tempt them into doing so, a small unlocked chest sits on the wooden floor toward the edge. The chest is empty, save for a rusted breastplate, a rotted pair of common clothes, and a moth-eaten child's stuffed silver dragon.

Q22. Bathroom

This room contains a snuffling undead silver guard drake. The drake attempts to take shiny valuables from the PCs for use in a nest it's built in the bathtub from torn curtains, rusted swords, and furniture debris. This guard drake belonged to Sir Godfrey in life, though neither now recognizes the other.

Q24. Chapel Balcony

A solitary revenant can be found here, inwardly searching for a prayer it no longer remembers. If you have already used the wandering revenant random encounter on the roads of Barovia, this is the same revenant, awaiting the PCs' approach.

Q25. Trapped Hallway

To make this encounter more fair, a corpse lies at the center of the hall, warning the PCs that something is afoot. When the Phantom Warriors attack, they give battle cries of the Order of the Silver Dragon - "To arms, silver knights!", "Hold the line against the devil's men!", and "In the name of Argynvost!" - to make it clear to the PCs that these ghosts are re-living Strahd's siege.

□ Know the Monsters - Phantom Warrior

Due to their single-minded nature, the Phantom Warriors do not fear death; due to their damage resistances and immunities, they do not mind triggering attacks of opportunity or placing themselves in harm's way. Using their incorporeal movement, these warriors weave in and out of the walls of Argynvostholt and any nearby objects or creatures in order to maximize their mobility. Because they lack a fly speed, the spirits are unable to pass to upper floors; however, they are able to "fall" through the ground to a lower floor if desired.

You may also choose to have the phantom warriors begin combat in the Border Ethereal - visible to the PCs, but impossible to interact with. In this case, the spirits ignore the PCs' attacks as they move into position, preventing any attacks of opportunity and lulling the PCs into a false sense of security. Once positioned, the phantom warriors exit the Border Ethereal and attack one round later.

Q34. Ruined Bathroom

A splatter of blood and the moldy ruins of a child's stuffed bat are all that betray the tragedy that took place here.

Q35. Upstairs Gallery

Upon inspection, the symbols of the Morninglord change to those of the three most powerful vestiges for a split second. The three stained-glass figures resemble the Vampyr (a slender, fanged crimson shadow), Tenebrous (a skull with an intricate pentagram imprinted upon its forehead), and Zhudun (a dark star with many tendrils extending from its form) before flickering back to their original forms.

A book containing an assortment of prayers to the Morninglord prayers written in Celestial and Common can be found discarded on the floor here.

Q36. Dragon's Audience Hall

This room is filled with bones - the remains of fallen adventurers and Barovians alike who came to request the Order's aid in defeating Strahd von Zarovich after its fall. Rusty weapons and other armaments litter the floor bearing a variety of insignias and marks.

Due to the potential lethality of this encounter (Deadly for five 10th-level PCs), Vladimir does not attack the PCs unless the PCs display hostile intent or directly insult the integrity of the Order of the Silver Dragon.

If the PCs ask for assistance in killing Strahd's minions (e.g., Baba Lysaga), Vladimir refuses them outright if they have already revealed their hostility to Strahd, and refuses them more gently if they have not, instead informing the PCs that the Devil's Prison is already perfect, and that upending the status quo by killing a notable minion may damage the delicate balance of hope and despair - power and powerlessness - that torments Strahd so beautifully.

If the PCs imply their intention to kill Strahd, Vladimir scoffs at their intent, refusing to believe it possible and condemning their efforts to free Strahd of his prison. He also points out the remains of those that have asked his aid in the past - and the fate that their rudeness and folly led them to at his hands. He promises the PCs a chance to leave and escape their inevitable deaths if they forswear their misguided quest and depart his chambers immediately.

If challenged, his +2 greatsword blazes with a black-streaked silver light, and he summons the six **phantom warriors** to his side in a clear display of force. It is only if the PCs remain after this point that Vladimir attacks of his own volition, promising that “a quick death will be easier than the tortures that Zarovich will inflict upon you - and more merciful than the pain I would deliver if you succeeded.”

If Ireena is present, Vladimir will instantly note her resemblance to Tatyana, and briefly discuss her tragic cycle of reincarnation. Vladimir will advise Ireena to kill herself, and so continue Strahd’s torment, but will make no move to do so himself, confident that the Dark Powers that keep Strahd entrapped will prevent him from obtaining her.

☐ Know the Monsters - Vladimir Horngard

Due to his **Regeneration** and **Rejuvenation** abilities, Vladimir is aggressive in combat to the point of appearing suicidal - he does not fear taking damage, as he knows that those Hit Points will soon be regained, either through his natural recovery or through eventual resurrection. His immunity to Turn Undead grants him a foolhardy confidence in his own righteousness and abilities, and he does not hesitate to slay even the most pious of the Morninglord’s servants.

He opens combat with a pair of attacks with his +2 *greatsword*, making clear to the PCs the power of the enemy they face. After this point, Vladimir uses his Fist attack in order to grapple the PC that appears most hostile to Strahd or the Order, focusing all his attentions on them while his Phantom Warriors defend him. Through his taunts and insults, it should become clear to the PCs that his primary intent is to prevent them from ever departing Argynvostholt, with the meta-goal of pushing them to flee this battle entirely.

If the PCs flee this area, the Phantom Warriors pursue the party only to the ends of the corridor immediately outside, retreating to Vladimir’s side soon thereafter. Vladimir does not leave these chambers under any circumstances.

Q39. Vladimir’s Bedroom

A ghostly rainstorm drenches the interior of this misty chamber. The storm reflects the absence of Sir Godfrey within Vladimir Horngard’s heart.

Q40. Argynvost’s Study

Rather than landing at a PC’s feet, the journal page is blown by the wind through the air until it snags against the frame of the picture of Argynvostholt.

🎵 The Sound of Music - Argynvost's Journal

To lend additional gravitas to this moment, consider employing [this audio reading of Argynvost's journal](#) while the PCs peruse its page.

The top of the chapel tower in the picture can actually be seen to glow with a faint silvery light, casting faint glimmers upon the floor around it, though clearly weakened by the enormous tear that has ripped the tower and manor asunder. If a PC inspects the picture, read:

You reach forward, your fingers pushing the aged canvas back into place within its frame. The faded edges mesh together, highlighting an enormous scar that runs down the length of the portrait.

The picture shows the mansion in better days, under clear winter skies with snow-capped mountains in the background. The top of the chapel tower glows like a silver beacon, but is marred by the great tear that runs through its stone walls.

As your palm pushes the torn edges closer together, the beacon in the picture begins to flicker with a brilliant silver light. A luminescent shape appears at the beacon's center - a dark, winged form that slowly grows until it fills the frame. Then - it vanishes, and the room is plunged into darkness.

With a great roar appears the spectral form of a huge silver dragon, its great size filling the room. "My skull lies in the fortress of my enemy," it says, "displayed in a place of ill omen. Return my skull to its rightful crypt, and my spirit will shine here forever, bringing hope to this dark land." With that, the dragon's apparition fades away, and the light returns to the chamber.

Q53. Beacon of Argynvostholt

A dark cloud is present around this tower, visible to any character on the ground nearby or on the roof. A character that enters the beacon's chamber can see a column of black fog swirling in the room's center - the embodiment of Vladimir's hatred for Strahd. When Argynvost's bones are restored, the fog dissipates, and the dragon's spirit lights the beacon once more.

Lighting the Beacon

Precisely three hints direct the PCs to the proper location of Argynvost's remains: the journal page and slashed picture in area Q40; and the knowledge of Sir Godfrey Gwilym. Due to their vagueness, it is entirely possible for the PCs to mistake the location of Argynvost's remains for the Amber Temple or a similarly foreboding location. If the PCs come into contact with Ezmerelda or Van Richten, either can tell the PCs that they have previously observed a great dragon's skull placed in a hall of bones within Castle Ravenloft.

□ Strands of Fate - The Dragon's Blessing

If, through backstory and/or a Tarokka reading (e.g., a draconic sorcerer descended from Argynvost), you have assigned a specific PC the quest of restoring Argynvostholt and restoring Argynvost's remains, when this quest is completed, the spirit of the silver dragon appears before that PC. Argynvost thanks the PC for their piety and courage, and blesses them with a *Charm of the Dragon*, which takes the form of a small silver tattoo wrought in the shape of a pair of dragon's wings.

Charm of the Dragon

You gain the ability to sprout a pair of dragon wings from your back, gaining a flying speed equal to your current speed. You can create these wings as a bonus action on your turn. This ability lasts for 10 minutes, and can be used only once per day.

You can't manifest your wings while wearing armor unless the armor is made to accommodate them, and clothing not made to accommodate your wings might be destroyed when you manifest them.

Special Events

Special Delivery

Due to its campy nature and irrelevance to the plot, it is highly advised that you do not run this special event.

Arrigal's Hunt

If Ezmerelda is not your PCs' destined ally, and they have not previously encountered her at Van Richten's Tower, Castle Ravenloft, or the Abbey of St. Markovia, it is highly recommended that you run this event in order to introduce her for the first time, building familiarity with her character and increasing the verisimilitude of the world.

In order to encourage your PCs to explore Argynvostholt more thoroughly, Ezmerelda encounters the PCs while they are still in the midst of investigating the first floor. In addition to looking for allies, Ezmerelda believes that the Order of the Silver Dragon once possessed or guarded some kind of powerful magic, holy or otherwise, and seeks to find its source. Unbeknownst to Ezmerelda and the PCs, the Amber Temple is nowhere near Argynvostholt, and there is, of course, no vault of magical artifacts in the mansion - Strahd's forces looted the place centuries ago.¹⁹⁰ However, she will encourage the PCs to investigate every nook and cranny of the mansion, and will irritably flounce from Vladimir Horngaard's chambers once his unwillingness to help becomes clear, determined to search elsewhere in the mansion for some other form of aid.

Chapter 9: Van Richten's Tower

¹⁹⁰ /u/DragnaCarta, [Lessons from Running Curse of Strahd: Argynvostholt](#)

□ **Strands of Fate - Van Richten's Tower**

Fleeing Vallaki: Should Vallaki become inhospitable to your PCs due to revolution, the Baron's wrath, or Strahd's intervention, Van Richten's Tower can serve as a new base of operations, especially if Rictavio has previously provided directions.

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies in Van Richten's possession at the Tower, it can be found here.

Ezmerelda's Request: If the PCs meet with Ezmerelda in Castle Ravenloft, Argynvostholt, or the Abbey of St. Markovia, she invites them to journey with her to the tower at Lake Baratok to reclaim her cart and belongings, and to investigate the path taken by her mentor, Dr. Rudolph van Richten.

□ **Worth a Thousand Words - Van Richten's Tower Art & Battlemap**

If your party encounters trouble near to Van Richten's Tower, consider using [this battlemap](#) to portray the environment. Otherwise, consider using [this picture](#) or this [animated background](#) by James Webster¹⁹¹ to depict the structure's appearance when outside of combat.

As your PCs will likely not know the primary inhabitant of this tower for some time, it is recommended that you call it "the tower at Lake Baratok" or "the old mage's tower" when referring to it in-game, rather than "Van Richten's Tower," in order to avoid spoilers.

Given its many defensible position and useful properties (see Khazan's Spell Drain below), Van Richten's Tower can become a useful safe haven for PCs seeking to evade the wrath of Strahd or Morgantha's coven. Do note, however, that a **vampire spawn's** Spider Climb feature can still allow it to climb the tower's exterior in order to enter through the hole on the third-floor. Additionally, a pack of **werewolves** can easily lay siege to the PCs from the other side of the causeway (see Pack Attack below), while a **vampire spawn** or **Strahd zombie** can easily lie in wait beneath the waves of Lake Baratok (which is still water, rather than running water, and quite dark) without needing to breathe.

Approaching the Tower

Six gryphon-shaped gargoyles are visible atop the tower, distributed amongst six of the eight sides of the structure. The remaining two sides bear evidence of other gargoyles that once rested there, but both appear to have been worn away or otherwise removed.

Khazan's Spell Drain

The rules of Khazan's Spell Drain are as follows:

191 [JamesRPGArt, Patreon](#)

- The antimagic field at Van Richten's Tower nullifies the protective aura around enchanted items, allowing them to be destroyed like mundane artifacts when exposed to it. See [here](#) for more information on destroying objects in 5th Edition.
- Creatures (e.g., Bucephalus or the night hags) cannot enter or reach into the tower from the Border Ethereal.
- Spells cannot be cast while the caster stands within the structure, immediately outside the door, or on the scaffolding around the tower.
- *Scrying* and similar divination spells will be unable to detect any creatures within the radius of the spell drain.

For more information about how to determine whether an effect is magical or not, see “**Is the breath weapon of a dragon magical?**” in [Sage Advice](#).

Areas of the Tower

While Van Richten inhabited the tower at one point, he did not at any point regard it as a true “home” or private residence. Due to his departure several months ago, the tower has since lost any metaphysical strength it may have gained from his presence, leaving it without a spiritual threshold and thereby wholly accessible to vampires that attempt to enter through the front door or through the windows and holes of the upper floors.

V1. Ezmerelda's Magic Wagon

Ezmerelda has carved the following rune ([Link](#))¹⁹² onto the wooden sign hanging from the wagon's door, just below the words “Keep out!”¹⁹³:



The werewolf pack has recently explored the area around the tower, smelling the dangerous trap within Ezmerelda's wagon and wisely choosing to avoid it. When the PCs arrive, they can find large wolf tracks in the sand and soil around the wagon, but can clearly see that none have approached the wagon proper.¹⁹⁴ A successful DC 20 Wisdom (Survival) check can allow the PCs to follow the wolf tracks to the entrance of the Werewolf Den on the opposite side of Lake Baratok.

¹⁹² /u/LivingRacoon, [SCP MTF Field Codes, found on /x/](#).

¹⁹³ Butlerlog, CoS Discord

¹⁹⁴ BigPapaTn, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 9/9](#)

A successful DC 20 Intelligence (History) check reveals that the rune is a Vistani *tralak*, or roadsign, that means “Danger On Other Side.” A Vistani PC or one that knows Thieves’ Cant automatically succeeds on this check.

Unlike in the module, Ezmerelda has been unable to decipher the puzzle on the front door, and is unable to enter. Originally bringing her cart to Lake Baratok to search for clues regarding Van Richten’s whereabouts, she has recently begun ranging to nearby locations (e.g., Argynvostholt, the Abbey of St. Markovia) while leaving her cart behind in the interest of mobility. As a result, Van Richten’s journal page and map are no longer located in Ezmerelda’s cart, and instead can be found within the stove and upon the desk, respectively.¹⁹⁵

V2. Tower Door

In the middle of the door is a large, embossed red circle that is clean of any marking or engraving. The following runes ([Link](#)) are carved into the lintel above the door, their forms faded and worn with age:



These letters once spelled out the name “Khazan,” but have lost much of their shape and definition over the years. A creature that touches the door triggers the lightning sheath trap, as described in the original module.

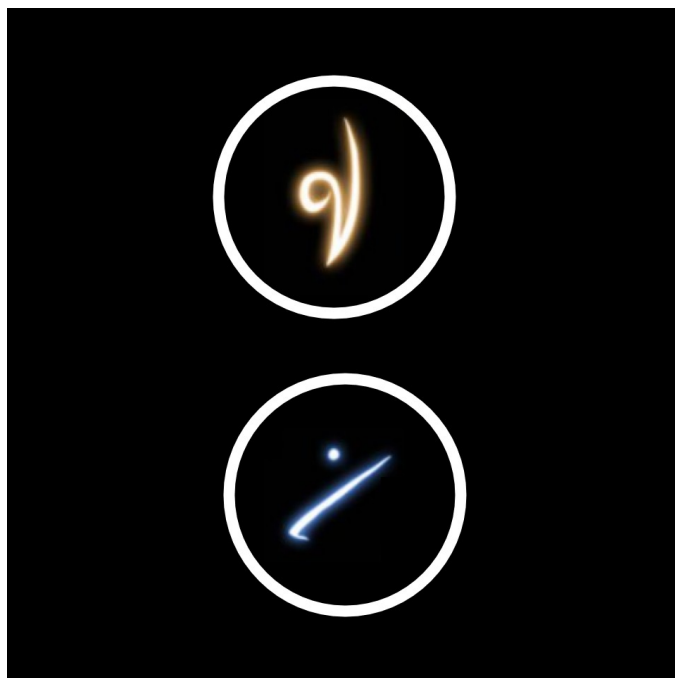
Opening the Door

A creature that speaks Khazan’s name causes the runes above the door - and the area just beneath them where the rest of the letters once stood - to glow with a dim blue light, spelling out “Khazan” in shimmering arcane energy. This light lasts for ten minutes before fading once more; while this light remains, the lightning sheath trap on the door and tower is disabled.

When these letters become illuminated, the red disk at the middle of the door revolves one-hundred and eighty degrees before settling into place with a heavy thud. Two symbols ([Link](#)) then appear on the disk’s surface¹⁹⁶:

¹⁹⁵ /u/paintraina, [What I Have Learned from Running Curse of Strahd Twice: Van Richten's Tower Edition](#)

¹⁹⁶ redheadstock, [Arcane Runes Photoshop and GIMP Brushes](#)



A DC 13 Arcana (Intelligence) check can identify the top symbol as the arcane rune for “heat,” and the bottom symbol as the arcane rune for “cold.” If the top symbol is exposed to a heat source (e.g., a lit torch or candle), it begins to flicker once per round with a deep red glow. Each time the symbol flickers, it dims slightly, darkening completely after ten rounds (1 minute). If the bottom symbol is exposed to a source of cold (e.g., a cold gust of wind, a splash of cold water, or a chunk of ice), it illuminates with a bright blue glow. A large brass handle then materializes on the door, and can be used to open the door normally. The handle and symbols both vanish after ten minutes, or after the door is opened and then closed, whichever comes first.

If the top (heat) symbol becomes completely extinguished before the bottom symbol has been activated, or if the bottom symbol is activated before the top one, both symbols begin to throb with a sickly purple glow. The six gryphon **gargoyles** atop the tower then come to life and attack any creature standing within five feet of the door, returning to their perches once all creatures have retreated at least fifteen feet from the door. While perched atop the tower, the gargoyles are comprised of inanimate stone with an AC of 17, and regain all lost hit points at dawn each day (a gargoyle that is destroyed is not able to return to its perch). All six gargoyles animate and attack if damaged while in stone form, returning to their perches only once all creatures have retreated at least one hundred feet from the door. The symbols’ purple glow vanishes once the gargoyles return to their inanimate form.

□ Know the Monsters - Tower Gargoyles

The **gargoyles** of Van Richten's Tower have two goals: the elimination of any potential intruders to the tower; and the immediate defense of the tower from damage or robbery. To that end, their first priority will be the physical removal of any trespasser from the area immediately in front of the door.

When combat begins, four of the gargoyles will attempt to **grapple** the creature closest to the door while two additional gargoyles move forward and use their **Multiattack** to engage any enemies that might attempt to intervene. Once two gargoyles have successfully grappled a target, they attempt to lift the target into the air at half-speed (30 feet per round). One gargoyle each turn will use the Ready action to move alongside its partner, while the other gargoyle will use its **Multiattack** action to inflict additional damage upon their victim, with both gargoyles re-grappling as needed to ensure that their victim stays within their grasp. Once they have successfully raised a target to 150 feet above ground level (taking a minimum of 5 turns to do so), they release their holds and allow the creature to plummet to the ground, inflicting 15d6 bludgeoning damage upon impact (or Xd6 bludgeoning damage if the creature manages to escape the grapple at an elevation of X * 10 feet).

No more than two gargoyles will engage a grappled creature at any given time, with additional gargoyles attempting to grapple additional creatures before repeating the steps outlined above. If the door is successfully opened, the gargoyles release any grappled targets (without lowering them to the ground first) and return to their perches atop the tower.

For additional fun, the first round that the gargoyles lift a grappled creature into the air, they fly directly adjacent to the scaffolding besides the tower. If any creatures with a combined weight greater than 200 lb attempts to follow onto the scaffolding, it immediately collapses beneath their weight, inflicting 1d6 bludgeoning damage per 10 feet fallen plus an additional 2d6 piercing damage from the debris. A creature underneath the scaffolding must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or take 14 (4d6) bludgeoning damage from falling debris.

Khazan, in his genius, gave this door a magical lock that only he could activate. He enjoyed the sense of powerful arrogance that came with the ability to use a mere pair of cantrips - *fire bolt* and *ray of frost* - to safeguard the sanctum that held his many arcane secrets. In his hubris, however, the idea that a non-spellcaster could create a similarly simple effect - and so open the door - did not even cross his mind.¹⁹⁷

Ezmerelda was able to complete the first half of this puzzle (Khazan's name) with relative ease, but managed to convince herself that Van Richten had managed some way of subverting the spell drain around the tower in the process of solving the second half. As such, she has no idea how to complete the puzzle, and has been unable to enter the tower. She is well aware of the defensive measures that powerful mages tend to take when defending their sanctums, and has therefore avoided triggering the lightning trap or gargoyles.

197 Matt88, [Van Richten's Tower](#)

V3. Rickety Scaffolding

Due to their weight, adult werewolves are unable to ascend this scaffolding while in hybrid form, and can only ascend one at a time while in human form. Due to prior experience with the tower, they are reluctant to approach the scaffolding unless driven to do so by the PCs or Strahd himself.

V4. Tower, First Floor

As a creature gets within 10 feet of the golems in this chamber, both statues react by tensing their grip on their chains, standing taller at the character's approach.¹⁹⁸

V7. Tower, Fourth Floor

A PC who keeps watch in the night with a sharp eye from Van Richten's Tower (Perception DC 20) can watch the dark shapes of the werewolf pack ascending and descending a winding trail in the northwestern hill.¹⁹⁹

Due to changes made earlier in the chapter, Van Richten's journal page and map are now located in this room. The journal page is caught in the grated door of the iron stove (the reason for its survival), while the map can be found in the top right drawer of the desk.²⁰⁰

Special Events

Pack Attack

Should the PCs set off the lightning sheath trap on the tower, the noise attracts the attention of the werewolf pack, as described RAW. Upon their arrival, the six normal **werewolves** and nine **wolves** conceal themselves in the woods beside Lake Baratok, while Kiril approaches in human form. A successful DC 17 Wisdom (Perception) check can allow a suspicious character to spot the wolves' shapes moving in the eastern woods.

Kiril hails the characters as he approaches; if the party remains within the tower, he hollers to them from a respectful distance outside. He presents himself as a worn and weary Barovian who attempted to travel from Vallaki to Krezk in order to escape the civil unrest that plagued the town. He claims to be travelling with two others: a brother, Emil, who was taken by a vampire during an attack in the night; and a sister, Zuleika, who was wounded when they were attacked by wolves on the road. A DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check is sufficient to show that he is lying; if caught in his lie, he "confesses" that Zuleika was bitten by a werewolf, and that he fears that her fevers signify a turn to lycanthropy. A DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) check is sufficient to show his lie.

198 ElvenTower, [Chapter 11 – Van Richten's Tower](#)

199 Butlerlog, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 11/18](#)

200 /u/paintraina, [What I Have Learned from Running Curse of Strahd Twice: Van Richten's Tower Edition](#)

Kiril confesses to having heard the eruption of magic at the tower while resting with his sister at their camp, and begs the PCs to return to his camp to heal his sister and help track down his brother. He makes every effort to flatter the PCs, impressing upon them the bravery and significance of any creature that would approach and activate the Old Mage's Tower. His ultimate goal is to lure the PCs and their compatriots onto the other side of the causeway, at which point his packmates will attack with surprise.²⁰¹

While clearly reluctant to do so, Kiril will enter the tower if invited, confessing a superstitious fear of such an arcane monument. If the PCs catch both of his lies or otherwise refuse to help him, he leaves, though not before assigning three **werewolves** and four **wolves** to linger in the woods by the causeway, ambushing the PCs soon after they depart the tower.

201 /u/paintraina, [What I Have Learned from Running Curse of Strahd Twice: Van Richten's Tower Edition](#)

□ **Know the Monsters - Kiril's Pack**

The **werewolves** of Kiril's pack prefer to attack from hiding, ambushing prey with advantage before retreating to the shadows. They will prefer to fight in hybrid form, aiming to deal maximum damage through their **Multiattack** action. The werewolves will gang up on the weakest members of the party, preferring to knock-out and drag away unconscious prey one at a time rather than spreading their aggression across several PCs at once.

Due to their immunity to nonmagical weapon damage, werewolves will provoke opportunity attacks with relish, moving freely across the battlefield in order to corner the most vulnerable prey. If struck by magic or silvered/magical ranged weaponry from a distance, a werewolf will aim to close the distance between themselves and the spellcaster/archer in order to maximize their physical advantages.

If an enemy magic user or archer is too far away or otherwise inaccessible, the werewolf will take the Dash action to flee out of sight, shift into a wolf (gaining a +3 bonus to Stealth), and take the Hide action in order to resume stalking their prey, beginning the fight anew with surprise some rounds later. If injured by a magical or silvered melee weapon, the werewolf will flee from battle entirely, preferring to preserve its own hide and hunt another day.²⁰²

The **wolves** of Kiril's pack prefer similar tactics, employing their high Stealth in order to ambush prey amidst the dark trees and underbrush. While fighting alongside their werewolf masters, their first priority is to render prone and "pin" stronger melee combatants while their larger siblings hunt the tastiest, most vulnerable prey. Each wolf will do its best to maximize its proximity to the enemy, thereby allowing its packmates to make use of their **Pack Tactics** feature in order to gain advantage on attacks against their targets.

The wolves will then use their **Bite** action (with advantage) against larger, meatier opponents with the intention of knocking them prone; once a creature has been knocked over, nearby wolves will pile on by taking the **Grapple** action. While the advantage rendered by Pack Tactics does not apply to the wolves' Athletics checks during their Grapple attempts, their sheer numbers will hopefully allow the pack to keep priority targets pinned to the ground while their packmates target easier prey. In order to prevent their targets from easily standing up, the pack attempts to have two wolves grappling prone combatants at all times.

Once the pack has rendered one or more PCs unconscious, they swiftly retreat with their prey, aiming to imprison them at the Werewolf Den as a future sacrifice to Mother Night.

Rahadin's Proposal

Should the PCs find sanctuary in Van Richten's Tower alongside Ireena, Strahd is able to deduce their location by reports from his wolves and bats and his own inability to Scry her or the party. If Strahd is actively pursuing Ireena and/or the party with hostile intent at this time, he deploys Rahadin alongside a platoon of three **vampire spawn** with the intent of laying siege to the Tower.²⁰³

202 The Monsters Know, [Lycanthrope Tactics](#)

203 Matt88, CoS Discord

Upon arriving at the Tower, Rahadin approaches its front door at dusk, openly flanked by his three vampiric compatriots. He hails the PCs politely, and asks that they exit the structure in order to parlay with him and his companions. If he is there to retrieve the Sunsword, the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind, or Ireena, he shares this information freely, and informs the PCs that Strahd is more than happy to negotiate wealth, power, or freedom from Barovia in exchange for their release. A PC who attempts a successful DC 18 Wisdom (Insight) check can tell that Rahadin does not believe that Strahd will offer the PCs wealth or power, but can tell that the offer of freedom is likely genuine.

If the PCs attack and damage Rahadin or his party, he directs his vampire spawn to extract the PCs from their “hiding place,” promising the PCs that he will call off the spawn if they accept his offer to negotiate in good faith. If the PCs refuse to exit the tower, Rahadin orders the spawn to retreat alongside him to the opposite side of the causeway. One hour later, he is joined by six **wolves** that assume positions beside the spawn.

For as long as he lingers there, Rahadin sleeps by entering an elven trance for four hours a day, ending just before dawn. The wolves awaken him if they detect the PCs attempting to attack or escape. The vampires vanish into the woods approximately two hours before dawn; a watchful PC who makes a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check can see them vanish within a gout of black fire on the back of a tall, flaming, jet-black horse. The horse is identifiable as a **Nightmare** with a DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check. The vampires return each dusk if the PCs linger within the tower, departing once more at dawn.

The party will begin to run out of food and water for as long as they remain within the tower. If the PCs have not been tracking rations, they have 1d4 days’ worth of food and drink remaining at the start of Rahadin’s siege.

If the PCs attempt to swim across Lake Baratok to safety, they must make two DC 12 Strength (Athletics) checks to do so swiftly. A PC that fails either one of these checks must make a DC 14 Constitution saving throw for each check failed to resist the cold water of Lake Baratok, gaining one level of exhaustion for each failed Constitution saving throw. Unless the PCs attempt to conceal their departure from the tower by exiting from one of the tower’s rear windows and succeeding on a DC 16 (if Rahadin is in a trance) or DC 21 (if Rahadin is awake) Dexterity (Stealth) check, Rahadin and his wolves quickly notice their movements and move to intercept them on the shore.

□ **Know the Monsters - Rahadin's Siege Party**

If they are directed to attack the PCs within the tower, the three **vampire spawn** employ their Spider Climb feature in order to directly climb the walls and interior ceilings of the tower, employing fourth-floor windows or the hole on the third floor to gain entry. While within the tower, the spawn prioritize Ireena (if she is present and currently targeted by Strahd) and/or the wielders of the Sunsword and Holy Symbol of Ravenkind (if their wielders present and are known to Strahd).

If targeting Ireena, one of the spawn uses its **Multiattack** action, employing two Claw attacks in order to grapple and carry her without dealing damage. This spawn then attempts to retreat through the nearest exit in order to remove Ireena from the tower entirely. Meanwhile, the other two spawn use their own **Multiattack** actions in order to grapple any PCs that approach, using a Shove action if necessary to push a nearby enemy away from Ireena, or to push a vulnerable and grappled target prone.

If Ireena is safely removed from the tower, the nightmare **Bucephalus** uses its Ethereal Stride action to appear in the Material Plane approximately 30 feet from the tower's entrance. If the spawn is able to mount Bucephalus (bringing Ireena alongside it), the nightmare then takes flight toward Castle Ravenloft, moving 180 feet per round and disappearing from sight in three rounds. (Bucephalus is unable to use its Ethereal Stride because Ireena is an unwilling passenger.) Once Bucephalus has successfully escaped, Rahadin and any remaining vampire spawn flee into the woods nearby.

If targeting the wielder(s) of the Sunsword and/or Holy Symbol, the spawn gang up on one of these wielders at a time, attempting to corner, grapple, and shove them prone before reducing each wielder to unconsciousness. While a wielder is unconscious, one vampire spawn can use its action to retrieve their respective magic item from the wielder's person; on its next turn, that vampire spawn uses its action to throw the item down to Rahadin, who is waiting at the foot of the tower.

Once both magic items have been retrieved in this way, or once all of the spawn have been eliminated, the **nightmare** Bucephalus uses its Ethereal Stride action to appear in the Material Plane approximately 30 feet from the tower's entrance. Rahadin (now in possession of any stolen magic items) and up to two of the remaining vampire spawn move adjacent to Bucephalus. Bucephalus then transports its passengers into the Ethereal Plane on its next turn, with any remaining vampire spawn fleeing into the woods nearby.

If **Rahadin** and his six **wolves** engage the PCs in combat outside of Van Richten's Tower, on the opposite side of the causeway, or on the shores of Lake Baratok, the wolves prioritize the strongest of the PCs' combatants, aiming to knock them prone and grapple them on subsequent turns. While the wolves harry the toughest enemy, Rahadin targets Ireena or the wielder(s) of the Sunsword and/or Holy Symbol of Ravenkind, aiming to grapple her onto Bucephalus (who then flies away as described above), or aiming to knock unconscious the wielders before removing their magic items (as described above).

Rahadin begins combat by casting *magic weapon* (Concentration) on his scimitar as a bonus action, increasing his to-hit to +11 and his damage to 1d6+7. He doesn't hesitate to close the distance between himself and his prey, relying on his Deathly Choir feature to discourage any enemies from getting too close. However, Rahadin does not activate his Deathly Choir's

damage when Ireena is within range, as he is unable to exempt her from the attack's effects.

If reduced to one-third (45) of his hit points, Rahadin casts *misty step* as a bonus action to flee combat. If there is mist, fog, rain, or drizzle in the surrounding area, he then employs his Mask of the Wild feature to attempt to conceal himself in the environment as he escapes Lake Baratok; once safely away from the PCs' sight, Rahadin casts *phantom steed* and rides to Castle Ravenloft to tell Strahd of his failure. If there is no natural phenomena that Rahadin can hide behind, Bucephalus instead uses its Ethereal Stride action to move adjacent to him, transporting the dusk elf into the Ethereal Plane on its following turn.

If any of Rahadin's **vampire spawn** are present during this fight, they assist Rahadin employing tactics as described above.

Chapter 10: The Village of Krezk

□ Strands of Fate - Hooks to Krezk

Escorting Ireena: Should Vallaki become inhospitable to Ireena Kolyana, either Father Lucian or Father Donavich may have suggested the Abbey of St. Markovia as an alternate place of sanctuary.

Fleeing Vallaki: Should Vallaki become inhospitable to your PCs due to revolution, the Baron's wrath, or Strahd's intervention, Krezk can serve as a new base of operations.

Sanctifying the Sunsword: Once the PCs recover the fragmented hilt of the Sunsword from their Tarokka reading, they are summoned by the spirit of Sergei von Zarovich to bring it to the sanctified pool in Krezk, where he promises to restore the magic of the blade. For more information on this, see **Sergei's Summons** below.

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies in the Abbey of St. Markovia or beneath the Shrine of the White Sun, the PCs can find it here.

□ Worth a Thousand Words - The Village of Krezk

Consider using [this picture](#) to provide an artist's depiction of Krezk as your party first discovers it.²⁰⁴

When the PCs arrive, the villagers of Krezk are terrified of monstrous incursions. This is in large part due to a recent attack by a werewolf that - against all reason - somehow managed to bypass the village's walls and attack the townsfolk directly. After killing a villager and wounding

204 /u/LawJohnArt, [The Village of Krezk, Barovia](#)

several others, the werewolf savagely mauled the Baron's daughter and spirited his son away into the woods. Suspicion is high, and many of the villagers are terrorized - not least because of reports that the corpse of the Baron's daughter has recently been stolen from its grave.

For more information on recent events in Krezk, see **Baron Dmitri Krezkov & Baroness Krezkova** below.

Areas of Krezk

S2. Gatehouse

The residents of Krezk are wary of outsiders, and now even more so due to the recent events that have rocked the village to its core. No person is allowed entry into Krezk unless they perform some service for the village. As-written, the guards at Krezk's gatehouse ask the PCs to investigate and retrieve three barrels of wine from the Wizard of Wines winery to gain entry to the village. If the PCs are unable to do so (because the winery has been destroyed; all barrels of non-poisoned wine have been delivered; or for any other reason), the guards instead ask them to slay and return the head of Whiteclaw, a known werewolf who haunts the woods north of the Raven River alongside her pack of dire wolves (see **The Hunt for Whiteclaw** below).

Once the PCs have returned with their requested item(s) - wine or Whiteclaw's head - they must pass an additional trial before gaining entry to Krezk. One of the two archers within the gatehouse descends to a reinforced, silver-lined and steel-barred window at the ground level of one of the parapets and tosses a steel dagger to the characters requesting entry. Each of the PCs are then asked to slice their palm with the dagger to prove their humanity (a vampire will quickly regenerate, a ghoul's blood will not be red, and a werewolf will not be wounded). If any single character refuses to do this or does not continue to bleed after doing so, the entire party is denied entry.

□ Plot Hook - The Hunt for Whiteclaw

Whiteclaw is a **werewolf packleader** (see below for full statblock) exiled from the northern pack for the crime of consuming the flesh of another werewolf after a fight for dominance. She is accompanied by four fiercely loyal **dire wolves**, which fell in beside her to devour her packmate after he fell to her claws.

Distinguished by her snow-white fur coat in hybrid or wolf form, Whiteclaw in human form is an elderly, dark-skinned woman bearing a frizzed mane of bright white hair that descends past her waist. A large chunk of her nose is missing in all three forms, having been sliced from her muzzle by Dmitri Krezkov decades past. The guards of Krezk can describe her distinguishing features in wolf or hybrid form, but are ignorant of any details of her human appearance.

For the past several years, ever since her exile from the werewolf pack, Whiteclaw has haunted the woods south of Krezk, near the shore of the Raven River alongside her four loyal dire wolves. She frequently harasses any hunters, trappers, or other woodsmen that dare venture south of the Svalich Road, targeting Krezk's populace with a terrifying precision beyond even the careless ferocity of the northern pack.

In truth, Whiteclaw is Illyria Krezkov, aunt to Dmitri Krezkov and an heir to the family curse. Wild from birth, Illyria questioned her family's devotion to restraint and service, instead advocating subjugation and - eventually - consumption of Krezk's populace. Exiled from her village after messily devouring the village priest forty years ago, Illyria soon found a new home in the northern werewolf pack while Dmitri Krezkov's grandmother, Kala Krezkov, worked to cover up the incident.

Illyria and her pack have laired in a small cave atop an outcropping alongside the Raven River. Any creature that searches for her in the woods nearby can soon locate the rotting corpse of a badly mauled man in the underbrush to the northeast. A DC 14 Wisdom (Medicine) check provides evidence that the man was devoured by a number of canine creatures, and also reveals evidence of a prominent scar across the man's shoulder - an old bite mark made by lupine teeth. The man was a member of Kiril's werewolf pack, and was slaughtered recently by Whiteclaw and her packmates.

A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check made at this corpse can allow a character to track Whiteclaw's pack through the trees to her hideout on the Raven River. A failed check causes the party to waste time, becoming lost in the dark woods until night begins to fall. If the PCs linger in the nearby woods past nightfall, Whiteclaw and her packmates attempt to attack them with surprise soon after. Otherwise, the PCs are forced to camp elsewhere in the Barovian wilderness, or make the long trek toward some other shelter.

If the PCs speak to her of Dmitri Krezkov or Kiril Stoyanovich, Illyria speaks of them with clear disdain, and hints to the PCs the dark nature of the Krezkov family curse. She is not aware of Ilya Krezkov's recent rampage, but does know that the werewolf pack recently picked up a younger "stray." If reduced to one-quarter hitpoints, a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check can convince Illyria to provide accurate directions to the werewolf den; on a failed check, Illyria instead provides inaccurate directions that lead to one of the pack's favored hunting grounds, at which the PCs are met by a hunting band of five **werewolves**.

WEREWOLF PACKLEADER

Medium humanoid (human, shapechanger), chaotic evil

Armor Class 13 in humanoid form, 14 (natural armor) in wolf or hybrid form

Hit Points 76 (9d8 + 36)

Speed 30 ft. (40 ft. in wolf form)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	17 (+3)	18 (+4)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Perception +6

Damage Immunities bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered or made by another lycanthrope's natural weapons

Senses passive Perception 16

Languages Common (can't speak in wolf form)

Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)

Keen Hearing and Smell. The werewolf packleader has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Pack Tactics. The werewolf packleader has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the werewolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Shapechanger. The werewolf packleader can use its action to polymorph into a wolf-humanoid hybrid or into a wolf, or back into its true form, which is humanoid. Its statistics, other than its AC, are the same in each form. Any equipment it is wearing or carrying isn't transformed. It reverts to its true form if it dies.

Actions

Multiattack (Humanoid or Hybrid Form Only). The werewolf makes two attacks: two with its spear (humanoid form) or one with its bite and one with its claws (hybrid form).

Bite (Wolf or Hybrid Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d8 + 3) piercing damage. If the target is a humanoid, it must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw or be cursed with werewolf lycanthropy.

Claws (Hybrid Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 10 (3d4 + 3) slashing damage.

Spear (Humanoid Form Only). *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one creature. Hit: 10 (2d6 + 3) piercing damage, or 12 (2d8 + 3) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Baron Dmitri Krezkov & Baroness Krezkova

Baron Dmitri Krezkov uses the statblock of a **knight**, with resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered, and Keen Hearing and Smell feature of a **werewolf**. Baroness Anna Krezkova has the statistics of a **veteran** (with a silvered battleaxe in place of a longsword). Both own and carry six **wooden stakes** at all times.

The Krezkov line that rules Krezk as Burgomaster and Baron are in secret a clan of werewolves. First infected with lycanthropy two centuries past when a progenitor of the clan, a man named Karkal Krezkov, was bitten, the curse has been passed down from generation to generation ever since. No one among the Krezkian populace is aware of this curse, and the Krezkovs have long honed their abilities to keep it concealed.

Using brews of Wolfsbane to calm their emotions as the full moon approaches, the members of the Krezkov family imprison themselves during the full moon in a cellar beneath their manor using chains, collars, and manacles in order to avoid attacking their fellow citizens. An only child, Dmitri Krezkov married his wife, Anna, and with her sired two children: Ilya and Alana Krezkov. Anna, having married into the family, is free of the curse, while Ilya (14) and Alana (9) were both born werewolves.

Ilya Krezkov, an adolescent preparing to turn with the full moon for the first time, became cocky, and tricked his parents into restraining him incorrectly in an effort to prove his control over his

transformation. When the full moon rose, Ilya transformed - and easily escaped his restraints, breaking out of the Krezkov's cellar and running wild through the village. In the ensuing rampage, Ilya killed his younger sibling, Alana, who had been outside in the garden, and one of the other townsfolk. Maddened by the attacks of the town's militia, he escaped over the wall and fled into the forest.

If the PCs discover the Krezkovs' secret, they beg the party to keep it concealed, and ask them to find and rescue Ilya.²⁰⁵ Neither Dmitri nor Anna knows where Ilya is, but know that Whiteclaw, a solitary werewolf to the south, may have more information on his whereabouts. For more information about Whiteclaw, see **The Hunt for Whiteclaw** above.

In addition to serving as Baron, Dmitri Krezkov is also a skilled blacksmith. If the PCs are looking to have their weapons silvered in order to better combat werewolves and other monsters of Barovia, Dmitri and Anna Krezkov are happy to do so. In exchange, the Krezkovs ask them to investigate the disappearance of their daughter's corpse from her grave in the family garden, fearing necromancy or worse. A number of graves have been robbed over the past year, rousing alarm across the village.

An investigation of the area around Alana Krezkov's grave provides the following clues:

- **Intelligence (Investigation) DC 5:** A preponderance of twigs and pin needles in the area around Alana's grave, despite a lack of non-flowering plants in the area near the garden.
- **Intelligence (Investigation) DC 10:** Deep furrows in the dirt around the grave, as well as an eclectic collection of paw-prints and footprints.
- **Intelligence (Investigation) DC 15:** A few scattered green lizard scales and tufts of soft amber fur.
- **Intelligence (Investigation) DC 20:** A set of meandering, mismatched foot- and paw-prints leading toward the northeastern side of the village, pointed directly toward the Abbey of St. Markovia.

S3. Village of Krezk

Burgomaster's Cottage

An external pair of wooden doors on the south side of the cottage open to a set of stone steps that lead into the burgomaster's wine cellar (which is identical in layout to the cellar of Wachterhaus, save for the staircase leading to the upper floors, which is absent). These wooden doors are badly damaged, having been splintered and bent outward when a transformed Ilya Krezkov forced his way outward on the night of the recent full moon.

The northern wall conceals a secret door, which requires a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check to find. A PC can attempt a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to search the area for clues, locating the remains of a torn dark blue tunic and a path of scratch-marks leading from the northern wall to the cellar doors. The tunic was destroyed and discarded by Ilya

205 https://www.reddit.com/r/CurseofStrahd/comments/9yc9xv/cos_discord_recap_week_of_1118/

in the midst of his transformation, and the scratches were made by his claws scrabbling across the stone floor.

The space beyond the secret door comprises a small chamber containing six sets of steel manacles and collars that are chained to the walls (Strength DC 20 to break). Until the recent full moon, Dmitri Krezkov was the only person chained in this room during his transformations, trusting his wife, Anna, to carefully imprison him for his family's safety. When he came of age, Ilya was chained alongside his father - but, as mentioned above, managed to trick his mother into locking the manacles improperly, and so was able to escape.

Krezk Lore

In addition to the lore listed in the book, the residents of Krezk know the following information:

- A monstrous werewolf recently managed to somehow bypass Krezk's walls, killing a villager and wounding several others, before savagely mauling the Baron's daughter and spiriting his son away into the woods.
- Shortly after Baron Krezkov buried his daughter, Alana, in the aftermath of this attack, her grave was dug up and her corpse stolen in the night. A necromancer is feared to be the culprit, as several other corpses have been dug up from family plots in a similar fashion over the past year.

S4. Pool and Shrine

□ Strands of Fate - Sergei's Summons

When the PCs first find the Sunsword, they see that its blade has been shattered, leaving only its platinum hilt behind, and leaving the sword itself inert. If the PCs keep the fragmented Sunsword in their possession as they travel the lands beyond Krezk and have not previously encountered Sergei at the shrine, he speaks to its wielder in dreams, sending repeated visions of the Shrine of the White Sun and the Sunsword submerged in the pool's waters, fully mended and blazing with divine light.

If the PCs arrive at the Shrine of the White Sun, if they are in the company of either Ireena or the shattered Sun Sword, they are beckoned to the statue of the Morninglord by a single shaft of sunlight that splits through the clouds, piercing through a crack in the roof of the gazebo to illuminate the face of the statue within.

When the PCs approach the statue, read the following:

The lonely shaft of sunlight dances across the statue's mournful face, the light illuminating every inch of its chipped and tarnished wood. And then - its expression moves.

The worn paint upon the statue's surface begins to glow a dim gold, even as its features begin to shift and change. The age vanishes from the old man's face, the statue's beard receding and hair lengthening. Color returns to the statue's surface, the features of a young man's face and body taking shape: dark hair; storm-colored eyes; and a lithe, but well-

muscled form.

His features are strikingly reminiscent of those of Strahd von Zarovich - but the soft warmth in his gaze and quiet smile upon his lips would look alien on the vampire's ancient face.

"I am Sergei von Zarovich," the statue says. "Welcome to the Shrine of the White Sun."

As-written, Sergei's spirit has found sanctuary in the Pool of the White Sun, and is able to manifest itself through the statue of the Morninglord within the gazebo. His spirit cannot pass beyond the boundaries of the pool or shrine, but his awareness is linked to both Tatyana's soul and the Sunsword, and he is able to communicate to her and the sword's wielder through dreams when necessary.

Sergei thanks the PCs for keeping Tatyana safe; if she is present, Ireena hastily reminds him that her name is "Ireena," rather than "Tatyana." If reminded of this, Sergei sheepishly apologizes and addresses her as "Ireena" from that point forward.

Sergei's goal is the removal of his brother's curse and the freedom of the Barovian people - especially Tatyana, now reincarnated as Ireena Kolyana. He hopes to accomplish this by advising the PCs regarding his brother's history and personality, and to guide them to the fragmented Sunsword if they do not already have it in their possession. He has an approximate knowledge of the Sunsword's direction and distance from Krezk, as well as a fuzzy understanding of the sword's immediate surroundings if questioned. Notably, he is largely ignorant of the major events over the past several hundred years since his death, though he knows the names and circumstances of each of Tatyana's reincarnations.

If the PCs are accompanied by Ireena upon meeting Sergei, he offers her spirit (though not her body) sanctuary in the blessed pool—a place where Strahd cannot reach her. If Ireena agrees, Sergei takes her by the hand and guides her soul from her body, leaving her body alive, but nonfunctional on the shores. Sergei promises that, should Ireena wish it, she can return to her body when Strahd is defeated (assuming the PCs protect it)—or, if she chooses, she can leave Barovia for the afterlife with Sergei.

If the PCs have given Ireena reason to stay with them (e.g., treating her kindly, training her to defend herself, including her as a member of the party, relying on her skills and expertise), she Ireena considers Sergei's offer, but firmly declines—it is Strahd, after all, who originally reduced her agency and worth to a woman he loved centuries past. She refuses to run away—a sign of cowardice that would be Strahd's victory. Instead, she vows to fight by the PCs' side until Strahd is destroyed; not because she fears him, but because she wishes to join the PCs on their quest to free all of Barovia, and because she refuses to be defined as "Tatyana." She does not know Sergei, she knows that he loves Tatyana—rather than Ireena—and she will remain—until her dying day—herself, rather than a name or inheritance that others have given her.

If Ireena decides to stay with the PCs, Sergei is clearly crestfallen, but accepts her decision. He then tells Ireena that, if she wishes to fight by the PCs' side, and if she wishes to have answers to her questions of identity, reincarnation, and purpose, she should journey to Marina's Monument in the ruins of Berez and lay her hand upon the epitaph. There, he promises, she will find the answers she is seeking.

If the PCs have the fragmented Sunsword when they meet Sergei, he directs its wielder to submerge its hilt beneath the blessed waters of the Pool of the White Sun. As its wielder withdraws the sword from the water, the hilt is joined by a blade of pure blazing sunlight, and can now be attuned to by its wielder as normal.

The sword consumes the blessing of the pool upon restoring its own magic, rendering its waters dull and nonmagical. Sergei then instructs the PCs to deliver the blade to him, at which point he transfers his spirit into the weapon, providing it with the spark of emotion and consciousness that makes it a sentient weapon. In this form, Sergei cannot speak, but can convey emotions and defend the sword's wielder against Strahd's vampiric charm, as dictated by the following rule for sentient weapons:

Conflict

A sentient item has a will of its own, shaped by its personality and Alignment. If its wielder acts in a manner opposed to the item's Alignment or purpose, conflict can arise. When such a conflict occurs, the item makes a Charisma check contested by the wielder's Charisma check. If the item wins the contest, it makes one or more of the following demands:

- The item insists on being carried or worn at all times.
- The item demands that its wielder dispose of anything the item finds repugnant.
- The item demands that its wielder pursue the item's goals to the exclusion of all other goals.
- The item demands to be given to someone else.

If its wielder refuses to comply with the item's wishes, the item attempts to take control of its wielder. The wielder must make a Charisma Saving Throw, with a DC equal to 12 + the item's Charisma modifier. On a failed save, the wielder is Charmed by the item for 1d12 hours. While Charmed, the wielder must try to follow the item's commands. If the wielder takes damage, it can repeat the Saving Throw, ending the effect on a success. Whether the attempt to control its user succeeds or fails, the item can't use this power again until the next dawn.

Areas of the Abbey

□ Strands of Fate - Introducing a New PC

If you need to introduce a new PC in Krezk, this new PC arrived in Barovia several years back and was swiftly overcome by Strahd's minions, losing their companions and fleeing to Krezk. They have waited for their true companions (as per Eva's prophecy) to arrive in Barovia, and in the meantime enjoy a daily game of chess with the Abbot while inhabiting the Abbey or Krezk itself.²⁰⁶

S13. Main Hall

□ Know the Monsters - The Abbot

Should the PCs attack the Abbot while in the Abbey and persist after he reveals his divine form, he warns his "children" (the mongrelfolk) to hide themselves from the "monsters" (the PCs) before joining battle himself.²⁰⁷ The Abbot prefers to fight outdoors, and attempts to draw the PCs into area S12 (Courtyard) through strategic Disengages and retreats. He is joined by the **flesh golem** in area S15 (Madhouse) one round later.

While in combat, the Abbot takes flight and attacks using his Mace multiattack, flying out of reach of any melee attackers before concluding each of his turns. The flesh golems prioritizes grappling and shoving any ranged combatants, aiming to prevent them from damaging the Abbot before attacking with its **Shove** actions. The Abbot targets any PC that attacks Vasilka, who remains within the dining hall. Vasilka does not fight, but lets loose an unholy scream if harmed; if driven berserk, she fights until the Abbot reasserts control or until she is destroyed.

When reduced to 33 hit points or fewer, if Vasilka is still alive, the Abbot grapples her and attempts to flee through the sky away from the Abbey while trying to calm her if she has been driven berserk. If he successfully escapes, he and Vasilka take up residence in Tsolenka Pass, where he plots his vengeance against the "heretics" that have destroyed his holy mission. If Vasilka has been killed, the Abbot fights to the death.

S17. Loft and Belfry

Beneath the black shroud covering the larger table lies the corpse of the nine-year-old **Alana Krezkov**. While Otto and Zygfrek's find proved wholly unsuitable for the replacement right arm that the Abbot was hoping for, the deva is currently looking to remove portions of Alana's skin from her back and torso in order to cover a number of ruptures on Vasilka's body, presuming that a child's skin will be more supple and last longer. If the PCs request the return of Alana's body, the Abbot will agree to do so if the party retrieves for him a wedding dress for Vasilka's use. To sweeten the deal, he also offers to cast *raise dead* up to three times on their behalf after the dress is obtained, or to give them the benefit of his healing touch if required. If the PCs

206 Grotsnik, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 12/9](#)

207 Mawmaw, MShermanator, & Grotsnik, [CoS Discord Recap: Week of 11/18](#)

decline his offer, he orders them to leave the abbey immediately, attacking them if they refuse while doing his utmost to keep Vasilka safe.

Chapter 11: The Werewolf Den

□ Strands of Fate - Hooks to the Werewolf Den

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies in Mother Night's hoard, the PCs can find it here.

The Stolen Children: If the PCs are hunting for the missing Ilya Krezkov, or if they are trying to rescue the two children that fled from St. Andral's Orphanage, they can find them caged in the cavern guarded by Zuleika.

Captive of Ravenloft. If the PCs have rescued Emil Toranescu from the dungeons beneath Castle Ravenloft and agreed to aid him in vanquishing Kiril Stoyanovich, he can lead them here upon his return.

Following the Trail. If the PCs successfully follow the wolf tracks left near Ezmerelda's wagon at Van Richten's Tower, the trail ends shortly outside of the entrance to the Den.

Werewolves in the Mist. If the PCs take it upon themselves to rid the Barovian valley of the werewolf scourge, or if they have been tasked by Madam Eva or a non-Barovia faction in doing so, they can extract the location of the Den by interrogating members of the werewolf pack after capturing one in a random encounter.

Running the Werewolves

As-written, lycanthropes are immune to nonmagical and non-silvered weapon damage. However, a werewolf's hide isn't immune to injury. Instead, similar to Strahd's Heart of Sorrow, a werewolf rapidly regenerates any wounds that it sustains in an instant. The only exceptions are wounds from magical, silvered, or environmental (e.g., falling or drowning damage) sources, which do not regenerate.

Note that the challenge ratings of lycanthropes heavily depend on their immunity to most kinds of weapon damage. If all or most of your PCs have reliable access to magical or silvered weapon damage, treat werewolves as creatures of CR 1, rather than CR 3.

There are two kinds of lycanthropes:

- **Inherited** lycanthropes were born into their curse. They are either the offspring of an infected lycanthrope or a direct descendant of a creature that first sustained the curse.

Inherited lycanthropes first transform at a young age, and can shift to their hybrid and bestial forms at-will. Inherited lycanthropes remain in control of themselves at all times except on the night of the full moon, when they lose themselves to their animalistic instincts.

- **Infected** lycanthropes were bitten by another lycanthrope, which spread the curse to their body and soul. They do not control their transformations and cannot assume the form of a non-hybrid wolf, except after months of meditation and an acceptance of the bloodlust of the beast within. Like inherited lycanthropes, infected lycanthropes are forcibly transformed into their hybrid state on the night of the full moon; in Barovia, an infected lycanthrope's transformation occurs every night other than the new moon.²⁰⁸

Members of the Pack

Kiril Stoyanovich, Emil and Zuleika Toranescu, Skennis, and Wensencia are natural-born, inherited lycanthropes. Most other members of the pack are infected lycanthropes instead.²⁰⁹

The Krezkov family in Krezk is comprised entirely of inherited lycanthropes (save for Baroness Anna Krezkov, who married into the family and is human).

Spreading the Curse

If a PC is infected by the curse of lycanthropy, they gain the following features and traits when the relevant prerequisites are met:

- **Weapon Immunity.** You gain immunity to slashing, piercing, and bludgeoning damage from nonmagical, nonsilvered weapon attacks.
 - **Prerequisite:** Take slashing, piercing, or bludgeoning damage from a nonmagical, nonsilvered weapon.
- **Increased Strength.** You gain a Strength of 15 if your score isn't already higher.
 - **Prerequisite:** Take a long rest.
- **Keen Senses.** You gain advantage on all Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell or hearing.
 - **Prerequisite:** Make a Perception or Investigation check.
- **Werewolf Attributes.** You use the statistics of a **werewolf** while transformed. Attack and damage rolls for your natural weapons are based on your Strength.
 - **Prerequisite:** Transform into your hybrid form.
- **Shapechanger.** On nights of the full moon (or any night in Barovia except the new moon), you are forcibly polymorphed into a wolf-humanoid hybrid. Any equipment you are wearing or carrying isn't transformed. You revert back to your true form when the moon sets, or if you die.
 - **Prerequisite:** Exist on the Prime Material Plane during moonrise on the night of the full moon (or on any night in Barovia except the new moon).
- **Curse of the Werewolf.** When you assume your hybrid form, you lose control of your mind and body. During this time, you are unaware of your actions, and you lose the

208 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Running Werewolves and Lycanthropes in Game.](#)

209 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Running Werewolves and Lycanthropes in Game.](#)

capacity to create new memories. While transformed in this way, you are driven to hunt, kill, and devour livestock, vulnerable humanoids, and wild game. When you regain consciousness the next morning, unless somehow restrained or obstructed, you find yourself 3d4 miles from your original location. While transformed, you do not gain the benefits of a short or long rest.

- **Prerequisite:** Transform into your hybrid form.

When the PC is first infected, **do not tell them**. Instead, privately tell them to add each feature to their character sheet when the given prerequisite is met.

Ezmerelda d'Avenir and Rudolph van Richten can immediately recognize the danger of lycanthropic infection if they see or are informed of a werewolf bite. Ezmerelda will advise the party to restrain and muzzle the PC before moonrise to ensure their own safety and to test the PC's health. The party may use silk or hempen rope, which has 2 hit points and can be burst with a DC 17 Strength check; or a metal chain, which has 10 hit points and can be burst with a successful DC 20 Strength check.

If the PC is infected, they must make a single Strength check upon transforming in effort to snap their restraints. If at any point a transformed werewolf's muzzle is left free, it will immediately make a Bite attack against any ropes or bonds within reach of its teeth.

A creature that fails to take a long rest in a 24-hour period must make a Constitution saving throw when that period ends. The DC is 10 + 2 for each missed day of rest. On a failed saving throw, a character suffers one level of Exhaustion.

Removing the Curse

An inherited lycanthrope such as Kiril, Zuleika, or the Krezkov family cannot be cured of their condition by *Remove Curse* or similar magic. Only a *Wish* spell can do that.

An infected lycanthrope, however, can be cured of their condition using a simple *Remove Curse* spell. If the target does so willingly, their lycanthropy is removed when the spell resolves.

If the target is unwilling (or if the target is transformed), the caster must make a melee spell attack against the werewolf's AC. On a hit, the werewolf's lycanthropy is cured, removing its damage immunities, keen senses, and natural weapons.

However, should that creature be bitten again, it can and often will choose to fail the Constitution saving throw against the spread of the curse. Once re-infected, the cured creature immediately regains its full infected lycanthropy, including the ability to transform into its hybrid or wolf form at-will (if it has previously been able to do so).

Areas of the Werewolf Den

Z1. Cave Mouth

If the guards in area Z2 become suspicious of nearby activity, Aziana enters area Z1 to survey the area immediately beyond the cave mouth. If she spots or smells a potential enemy nearby, she returns to the guard post and whistles for the wolfpack in area Z3 to join her at the guard post, then lies in wait for anyone to enter. Otherwise, she returns to area Z2, prepared for a potential disturbance.

Z2. Guard Post

If the guards here become aware of intruders nearby, they whistle for the wolfpack in area Z3 to join them at the platform. The wolves divide into two groups, with one at the entrance to Z3 and the other within the eastern entrance to Z4. The guards and werewolves attack any enemies that enter the cave, but do not pursue them beyond area Z1.

The werewolves in areas Z3, Z5, and Z7 trust Aziana and Davanka to kill any intruders, and remain in place even when alerted to combat.

Z3. Wolf Den

If the alarm is raised, Skennis remains here in human form. Should the PCs confront him, Skennis taunts them about fearing “an old, feeble man” before spending an action to transform into his hybrid form.

Z5. Deep Caves

If alerted to activity toward the cave entrance, Bianca and Wensencia hide Kellen in area Z7, and then return and extinguish the torches in this area, hiding behind the central pillar of this cavern. They are joined by three **wolves**, which attempt to grapple and drag away any weaker melee combatants. The werewolves and their companions surprise any PCs whose passive perception is lower than their Dexterity (Stealth) check.

Z7. Shrine of Mother Night

One of the “empty” cages is occupied by Ilya Krezkov, the son of Baron Dmitri Krezkov. An inherited lycanthrope, Ilya was captured by Kiril the night of his recent rampage and taken to the Den to join the pack. Ilya is horrified at his lycanthropic nature, but the strength of his bloodline has left Kiril impressed at his potential worth as a packmate. Ilya has steadfastly refused to cooperate with the pack’s demands, however.

To this end, Kiril has ordered the other werewolves to starve him, leaving three rotting corpses of children just beside his cage. The children abducted from the realms beyond Barovia, and were killed by Kellen in one of Kiril’s regular deathmatches. Kiril believes that if Ilya is driven mad by starvation, he will willingly partake of the childflesh beside his cage, and so allow his mind to be subsumed by the wolf within.

Two of the children in the cages are Lazlo and Franz, two of the three boys who fled St. Andral's Orphanage for fear of Felix's demon. (The third boy was devoured by wolves as he fled through the woods.) If the alarm has been raised elsewhere in the cave, Kellen has been left alone in one of the cages as well. The other children keep away from him, fearful of his true nature.

Zuleika is a **werewolf** with 90 hit points and 16 Wisdom. In addition, she is a 4th-level cleric of Mother Night (+5 to hit, spell save DC 13) with the following spells prepared:

- Cantrips: Toll the Dead, Thaumaturgy, Light, Spare the Dying
- 1st Level (4 Slots): Sanctuary, Inflict Wounds, Command
- 2nd Level (3 Slots): Spiritual Weapon (taking the form of a wolf wrought of moonlight), Enhance Ability, Blindness/Deafness, Prayer of Healing

Dealing with Zuleika

When the PCs arrive at the shrine, Zuleika assumes that they have been sent by Mother Night as an answer to her prayers. If the PCs demand the release of the children in the cages, Zuleika agrees to do so - but only if the party first journeys to Castle Ravenloft and releases her mate, Emil, before returning him safely to her. If the PCs accept her deal, Zuleika promises to use her *light* cantrip on one of the teeth of the cave to signal when Kiril is out hunting. If the PCs refuse her bargain, she casts *Spiritual Weapon*, and threatens to kill the children herself if they do not comply.

If the PCs confirm that Emil is truly dead, either by their hand or Strahd's, Zuleika might still let the prisoners go if they kill Kiril Stoyanovich when he returns from his latest hunt.

If the PCs attack Zuleika or move to free the children from their cages, Zuleika attacks, using her bonus action each turn to attempt to kill one of the human children using her *Spiritual Weapon*. If her concentration is disrupted, Zuleika discards her plan and enters combat in full, casting *Blindness/Deafness* on the most dangerous PC before attacking a more vulnerable target.

In combat, Zuleika begins by casting *Sanctuary*, and then immediately transforms into her hybrid form. In combat, she uses *Command* to prevent the PCs from freeing the children in the cages, and attacks using *Inflict Wounds* at 2nd-level (if any slots are available). Once she has exhausted her supply of spell slots, she continues to attack using her Claw and Bite attacks. Zuleika fights to the death.

If the PCs slay Zuleika, she curses them with her dying breath, condemning them to suffering should they steal from Mother Night. She then spits her gratitude that the monstrous Kiril will kill them when he returns, even as his cruelty has destroyed her.

Treasure

A creature that takes treasure from Mother Night's hoard falls under the Curse of the White Wolf. Should that character fall below half of their maximum hit points in combat, a single white-

furred **wolf** appears in the distance, locking eyes with the cursed character. The wolf is not visible or detectable by any other character, except through the use of *Truesight*. If the character is healed above this threshold, the wolf retreats, and soon vanishes into its surroundings.

As the cursed creature approaches death, the wolf gets even closer. As it approaches, it shows more noticeable signs of hunger. It begins salivating, its eyes becoming wild as it pants even harder. If the cursed creature attempts to attack the wolf, it retreats, maintaining its distance, but without vanishing from sight.

If the cursed creature is reduced to zero hit points, the white wolf becomes visible to all other creatures and rolls initiative. On its turn, it attempts to use its Bite attack action on the victim to tear out their throat, dealing a critical hit and inflicting two automatic failed death saving throws on a hit. If the wolf is killed before its target dies, it returns the next time the cursed creature is reduced to half its hit points.²¹⁰ If the target dies (due to the wolf's attack or a failed saving throw while the wolf is nearby), the wolf spends its action on its next turn devouring the character's corpse, equipment and all. It then vanishes into silver mist.

If the PCs entreat with Zuleika and fulfill one or more bargains with her, she solemnly informs them of the curse upon Mother Night's hoard should they request one of the artifacts foretold by Madam Eva's Tarokka reading. She is incapable of interceding on their behalf, however.

Special Events

Leader of the Pack

The first time the PCs linger in the Werewolf Den for one hour or more, Kiril and his pack return to the cave, fresh from their latest hunt, and proceed to assault the party as-written. Kiril is a **werewolf alpha** with the following statblock:²¹¹

210 /u/RexiconJesse, [Steal My Idea: 3 Curses Your Players Won't Expect](#)

211 Modified from /u/StoneStrix, [\[Homebrew\] Monster a Day BBEG Friday: Werewolf Alpha](#)

KIRIL, WEREWOLF ALPHA

Medium humanoid (human, shapechanger), chaotic evil

Armor Class 14 (armor scraps) in humanoid form, 16 (natural armor) in wolf or hybrid form

Hit Points 119 (14d8 + 56)

Speed 30 ft. (40 ft. in wolf form)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)

Saving Throws Str +9, Con +8, Wis +6

Skills Athletics +9, Perception +6

Damage Immunities bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical weapons that aren't silvered

Senses passive Perception 16

Languages Common (can't speak in wolf form)

Challenge 7 (2,300 XP)

Legendary Resistance (2/Day). If Kiril fails a saving throw, he can choose to succeed instead.

Keen Hearing and Smell. Kiril has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Shapechanger. Kiril can use his bonus action to polymorph into a wolf-humanoid hybrid or into a wolf, or back into his true form, which is humanoid. His statistics, other than his AC, are the same in each form. Any equipment he is wearing or carrying isn't transformed. He reverts to his true form if he dies.

Actions

Multiattack (Hybrid Form Only). Kiril makes three attacks: one with his bite and two with his claws.

Bite (Wolf or Hybrid Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit* 14 (2d8 + 5) piercing damage. If the target is a humanoid, it must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw or be cursed with werewolf lycanthropy.

Claws (Hybrid Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 16 (2d10+5) slashing damage.

Legendary Actions

Kiril can take 2 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one legendary action option can be used at a time, and only at the end of another creature's turn. Kiril regains spent legendary actions at the start of his turn.

Leap. Kiril moves up to his speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Howl. Kiril howls with bloodlust, granting his allies advantage on melee attack rolls against any hostile creature within 5 feet of him until the end of his next turn.

Claws (Costs 2 Actions). Kiril can make one claw attack.

Development

If the PCs successfully rescue Emil Toranescu, another **werewolf alpha**, from Castle Ravenloft, Emil is determined to kill his rival and become the new leader of the pack. The next time Kiril returns to the Den, Emil challenges him to single combat for control of the pack. With the aid of a surreptitious casting of *Enhance Ability* on Zuleika's part, Emil successfully defeats Kiril and drowns him beneath the waters of Area Z4, the underground spring. If Zuleika is not present, and the characters do not intervene on Emil's behalf, Kiril wins a narrow victory, and directs his pack to kill the party shortly thereafter.

Die Kinder

If the PCs defeat Zuleika and get the children away from the den while Kiril is still alive, Kiril reassembles his hunting party and pursues the party relentlessly by tracking their scent and following the cries of the children. As the PCs make their way away from the Den, the sky darkens, and a storm begins to brew overhead.

If the PCs successfully quiet the children as-written, Kiril is unable to track them, and turns to pursue vengeance against the party instead. While Kiril is hunting the PCs, wilderness random

encounters occur on a roll of 15 or above for each 30 minutes that the party spends in the wilderness, and each encounter has a 50% chance of being an encounter with Kiril and his pack of six **werewolves** and nine **wolves**.

If the PCs fail to quiet or calm the rescued children as they travel, the werewolf pack catches up with them as the party approaches the gates of Vallaki or Krezk. All the werewolves arrive in wolf form. When this occurs, run the following skill challenge:

Skill Challenge: Escaping the Werewolf Pack

In this skill challenge, the PCs must evade the werewolves and make it safely to the gates of Vallaki or Krezk without losing any of their wards. See [here](#) for more information on how to run skill challenges.

The PCs must accrue three successes before three failures. If the PCs pass this challenge, they safely enter the gates of civilization and leave the pack behind. The third time the PCs fail a check, the pack surrounds them, and combat begins. In combat, the werewolves work to detain and kill the PCs while the wolves drag the crying children away into the surrounding forest.

During the skill challenge, the PCs face the following obstacles.

Flash Flood. The storm overhead releases a sudden downpour of rain. The road beneath the PCs' boots becomes muddy and slippery as the party is near-blinded by the deluge of rain around them. Each PC must make a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw. The party accrues one failure if at least half of the PCs fail the save.

Lightning Strike. Lightning flashes overhead, hitting and splintering a tall oak tree that threatens to crush the PCs beneath its weight. The PCs must find some way of moving or evading the trunk. Potential skills include Acrobatics to evade the trunk (DC 15 - Medium), Athletics to lift or deflect it (DC 18 - Hard), Perception to spot a safe place to stand (DC 15 - Medium), or Investigation to predict where the tree will fall (DC 12 - Easy).

Branching Path. The PCs arrive at a place where the path splits, with the main road taking a long detour around a wooded hill. A small, but rugged footpath climbs the crags of the hill. If the PCs choose to stay on the main road, they automatically gain one failure. If the PCs take the footpath, one member of the party must make a Survival Check (DC 15 - Medium) to safely climb and navigate the path, gaining one success or failure as appropriate.

Injured Child. A branch thrown into the air by the harsh winds whips past the PCs, injuring one of the children. The child collapses on the ground, sobbing. The PCs might make a Persuasion or Intimidation check to convince the child to continue running (DC 12 - Easy), make a Medicine check to quickly dress the child's wound (DC 15 - Medium), or make an Athletics check to carry the child forward (DC 15 - Medium).

Rocky Gorge. The PCs notice a pair of werewolves peel off from the rest of the pack as they enter a small, rocky gorge, running along the unstable top as the road meanders below. The werewolves clearly intend to entrap the PCs where the road emerges on the other side. The PCs can gauge the werewolves' timing by using Insight (DC 15 - Medium), use Athletics to create a rockslide by toppling one of the large boulders supporting the gorge's walls (DC 18 - Hard), or use Perception or Investigation to find a weak spot in the gorge's walls that an attack can collapse (DC 15 - Medium).

Lupine Aggression. Three wolves leap from the underbrush, attempting to shove several PCs prone. Those three PCs must make a DC 11 Strength saving throw, taking 2d4 + 2 piercing damage from the wolves' bites on a failure. If two or more PCs fail their saves, the party accrues an additional failure.

Hungry Wolves. A werewolf leaps forward, taking hold of a child's arm between its jaws. The child must make a DC 11 Constitution saving throw, or be infected with lycanthropy. The party can tug the child free by prying the werewolf's jaws open using an Athletics check (DC 15 - Medium), locating and attacking a weak point in the werewolf's anatomy using a Nature or Animal Handling check (DC 18 - Hard), or shocking the werewolf with a sudden attack and making an Intimidation or Performance check (DC 15 - Medium).

Chapter 12: Tsolenka Pass

Chapter 12: Tsolenka Pass

□ Strands of Fate - Hooks to Tsolenka Pass

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies in the tower of white knights or within the Amber Temple, the PCs can find it here or beyond the bridge, respectively.

Ascending Mount Ghakis

The journey up Mount Ghakis can be segmented into two parts: the Barovian Highlands, and Mount Ghakis itself.

The "Mount Ghakis" segment begins after Tsolenka Pass, and continues up to the Amber Temple (see below). The Barovian Highlands, conversely, begin where the road branches south from the Old Svalich

Road, and terminate just before Tsolenka Pass.

□ Worth a Thousand Words - Maps & Battlemaps

For a rough visual overview of the locations described in this chapter, click [here](#). User /u/swombat0 has also made several battlemaps for the locations in this chapter, which you can find [here](#).

Climate & Hazards

Weather and environmental conditions in the Barovian Highlands are largely similar to those of the Svalich Woods below. However, due to the greater elevation, the temperature is somewhat colder, often approaching or passing below freezing, and snow is more common than rain.

The weather of the Mountain's Peak is much more severe. The ground is nearly always covered with 1" - 2" of snowfall, and the temperature is far below freezing. As a result, characters who don't have heat sources, cold weather gear, or magic to protect them are subject to the effects of Extreme Cold (DMG 110).

Extreme Cold

Whenever the temperature is at or below 0 degrees Fahrenheit, a creature exposed to the cold must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw at the end of each hour or gain one level of exhaustion. Creatures with resistance or immunity to cold damage automatically succeed on the saving throw, as do creatures wearing cold weather gear (thick coats, gloves, and the like) and creatures naturally adapted to cold climates.

Due to this extreme cold, the following weather and environmental hazards are much more common while ascending the Mountain's Peak, and may be included as part of any encounter with the DM's discretion: Strong Wind (DMG 110), Heavy Precipitation (DMG 110), Frigid Water (DMG 110), Slippery Ice (DMG 110), Thin Ice (DMG 110).

Strong Wind

A strong wind imposes disadvantage on ranged weapon attack rolls and Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing. A strong wind also extinguishes open flames, disperses fog, and makes flying by nonmagical means nearly impossible. A flying creature in a strong wind must land at the end of its turn or fall.

Heavy Precipitation

Everything within an area of heavy rain or heavy snowfall is lightly obscured and creatures in the area have disadvantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight.

Frigid Water

A creature can be immersed in frigid water for a number of minutes equal to its Constitution score before suffering any ill effects. Each additional minute spent in frigid water requires the creature to succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or gain one level of exhaustion. Creatures with resistance or immunity to cold damage automatically succeed on the saving throw, as do creatures that are naturally adapted to living in ice-cold water.

Slippery Ice

Slippery ice is difficult terrain. When a creature moves onto slippery ice for the first time on a turn, it must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check or fall prone.

Thin Ice

Thin ice has a weight tolerance of 165 (3d10 x 10) pounds per 10-foot-square area. Whenever the total weight on an area of thin ice exceeds its tolerance, the ice in that area breaks. All creatures on broken ice fall through.

Flora & Fauna

The hills of the Barovian Highlands are dominated by broad-leaved deciduous trees, including maple, oak, and poplar trees. At upper slopes, these change to needle-leaved, evergreen trees including spruce and pine trees. Beyond the

switchback road above Tsolenka Pass, the treeline stops, with the weather growing too cold to support large vegetation. The only flora beyond this point are sparse grasses and low-growing alpine flowers.

The wild inhabitants of the Barovian Highlands include elk, foxes, goats, wolves, ravens, and rabbits. Ravens and elk do not proceed beyond Tsolenka Pass due to the cold and sparse vegetation, but the other four can be found at all altitudes at any time of year.

The Barovian Highlands

Southern Hills

As the PCs begin their journey through the winding hills that lead to Mount Ghakis, the shadow of an enormous bird briefly blots out the light overhead - the Roc of Mount Ghakis. The Roc flies far overhead the PCs, and pays them no mind, focusing instead on transporting the adult cow that it has clutched in its talons. It soon vanishes from sight beneath the dark clouds that encircle the snowy peak of Mount Ghakis.

Abandoned Campsite

Shortly after bypassing the southern hills and entering the craggy road that winds through the mountains, a PC with a passive Perception of 12 or more can see footprints in the snow leading behind a jagged rock formation off the side of the road.

Investigation reveals an abandoned campsite behind the rocks, including an extinguished campfire, a torn and shredded leather tent, and a trio of fur-lined sleeping bags within the tent.

A DC 15 Survival check reveals that the campfire was lit the previous night, and that

a bloody struggle took place shortly afterward - indicated by the chaotic array of boot prints and monstrous pawprints across the ground. A DC 15 Nature check can reveal that the pawprints are a wolf's prints - similar to a dire wolf, but far larger.

A character that investigates the site and succeeds on a DC 10 Investigation check finds a severed human hand, its veins bloated and tinged black, as well as a pair of discarded spears stained with black blood. A DC 15 Medicine check can reveal that the veins contain a particularly potent poison that likely spread from the rest of the body before it was severed. An investigation of the tent and sleeping bags reveals a trio of waterskins, a pouch full of rations, and a wooden flute inscribed with the Druidic rune for "Air."

This campsite was previously inhabited by Birghild, the wife of the Mountain Folk chieftain, Sigrid; Kaldur, Birghild's ten-year-old son; and Runa, a Mountain Folk scout. The two adults had planned to take Kaldur on his first hunting trip, but were slaughtered by a demon known as **shoosuva** (*Volo's Guide to Monsters*, pg. 137) in the night. Kaldur narrowly escaped, and is currently located at the Frozen Lake.

Frozen Lake

This frozen lake is split by an icy causeway that extends across its middle. Several small islands dot the water's surface, which is frozen over by a thin layer of ice (see **Thin Ice in the Climate & Hazards** box above). Battlemaps for this lake can be found [here](#) (credit to /u/Macharian) or [here](#) (credit to /u/SnooTangerines5710).

A PC with a passive perception of 12 or above that enters the causeway

immediately notices a set of enormous paw prints similar in size and shape to those of a dire wolf. A DC 22 Nature check can identify the prints as belonging to a **winter wolf** (*Monster Manual*, pg. 340). The prints proceed from the south toward the north end of the lake, parallel to the PCs' path.

Halfway across the causeway, each PC must make a DC 10 Perception check; on a success, that PC hears a faint voice calling for help. The source of the voice is a small child struggling to stay afloat after falling through the thin ice - Kaldur, the Mountain Folk boy who fled the abandoned campsite.

Seeking refuge from the shoosuva that attacked his guardians, Kaldur fled toward the northern lake, but was soon set upon by a pack of hungry winter wolves that threatened to eat him. He attempted to flee across the ice toward the opposite end of the lake, but fell through and is now close to drowning.

The round immediately after the PCs make contact with Kaldur (a **commoner** with 2 hit points), they are attacked by four **winter wolves**, who surprise any PC whose passive Perception does not beat their Stealth check. One winter wolf attempts to race the PCs across the lake to reach Kaldur, while the other three attempt to slow any would-be rescuers down. If a wolf reaches Kaldur, it attempts to grapple him before dragging him away from the lake; if it is unable to escape from the PCs due to its slow speed and Kaldur's struggles, it attempts to reduce Kaldur to 0 hit points before fleeing at full speed into the hills.

On turn 3 of combat, assuming he is not removed from the water, Kaldur's strength

gives out and he begins to drown. On turn 4, he falls unconscious; on turn 5, he dies.

The surface of the lake is covered in thin ice, and each island in the lake is covered in slippery ice; the water in the lake counts as frigid water. (see **Climate & Hazards** above for more information).

When the PCs first kill a winter wolf, the nearest wolf begins to speak to them in broken Common, asking the PCs to give them the child in exchange for guidance to a great treasure. The wolf claims that it is working to return Kaldur to his settlement, and that winter wolves serve as "spiritual guardians" to the people of Mount Ghakis. The wolf is lying (Insight DC 9), and will attempt to flee with Kaldur as soon as escape becomes possible.

Developments

If the PCs rescue Kaldur, he can share a fragmented and terrified version of the attack that took his mother's life the previous evening. He doesn't know what the shoosuva is, but can describe it as a "giant wolf with a stinger like a scorpion's." He also asks the PCs to escort him back to Yaedrag. Kaldur doesn't know the exact way home, but knows that the party must travel north through a forest to get there, and that the entrance is hidden behind a frozen waterfall amidst ancient ruins.

If Kaldur makes himself known when the PCs attempt to gain entry to Yaedrag via the tunnel behind the frozen waterfall, the guards automatically allow the entire party in.

Overgrown Woods

As the road progresses northward, it is swallowed up by an ancient, overgrown

forest of snow-covered pine trees and towering oaks, rendering the path forward invisible. Fifty feet beyond the edge of the forest lies the corpse of a dead winter wolf, carved up by Shoosoova's claws and bloated from the poison of the demon's stinger. Just beside the corpse rests an old headstone carved with the following inscription: "Beware the fury of the mountain's daughters. Follow the dragon's gaze and remain on the path." Twenty feet beyond this stone rests a small stone obelisk, five feet high and carved on one side with a sigil of the Order of the Silver Dragon that points in the direction of the next marker.

Once, these obelisks marked a clear path through the woods here, but time has caused them to crumble, allowing the nearby vegetation to swallow up any signs of the roadway that once cut through the forest. Now, only the obelisks remain, halfway-concealed by the underbrush that surrounds them.

Three additional obelisks lie along the old forest road, each pointing the way toward the next marker. The first obelisk lies beneath a thorny bramble, and must be located with a successful DC 15 Survival check. If the PCs fail this check, they must each make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw before attempting it again, taking 3d6 piercing damage from the surrounding thorns on a failure, or half on a success.

The second obelisk lies atop a small mound at the heart of a chill, opaque mist, requiring a successful DC 20 Perception check to locate. On the party's first failure for this check, eight **snow maidens** appear from the mists and attack. A snow maiden uses

the statistics of a **specter**, but with the following modifications:

- The snow maidens have immunity to cold damage.
- The snow maidens' Life Drain attack deals cold damage instead of necrotic damage.

A battlemat of this location created by /u/SnooTangerines5710 can be found [here](#).

The final obelisk, which points toward the exit from the forest, lies in plain sight, but upon a crumbled base of earth that has collapsed from the forest floor onto an outcropping ledge halfway down a rocky chasm one hundred feet deep. A half-ring of small stones around the obelisk matches up with a similar ring toward the top of the cliff, allowing the PCs to easily determine the obelisk's original position. A DC 15 Athletics check is required to reach it, and the carved sigil pointing the way forward is not visible except when adjacent to the obelisk. On a failure, the PC attempting to reach the ledge falls to the bottom of the chasm, taking 8d6 bludgeoning damage, but may attempt a DC 20 Dexterity saving throw to catch themselves on the obelisk's ledge.

Each of these skill checks may be replaced with an alternate skill check or solution (e.g., the *Locate Object*, *Gust of Wind*, or *Fly* spells) at your discretion and/or your PCs' suggestion.

Ancient Ruins

A half-hour's journey along the road past the woods, the landscape is dotted by several dozen ancient stone structures. Close to the path, between a crumbled tower and a ruined shrine that once honored the Morninglord and the Ladies Three, a

frozen waterfall falls from a two-hundred-foot cliff into an icy stream that flows into a shallow cavern beneath the cliff. On the opposite side of this waterfall sits a secret stone door (Perception DC 20 to locate) that opens up into a forty-foot tunnel that enters into the hidden Mountain Folk settlement of Yaedrag. The door can only be opened from the inside or with suitably powerful magic (e.g., the *Telekinesis* spell).

These ruins once comprised a trading post between the Mountain Folk and the knights of the Order of the Silver Dragon. Even before Strahd's arrival, the knights of Argynvostholt relied on the Mountain Folk for guidance through dangerous weather conditions, and honored the indigenous deities alongside their own as a show of respect. Today, however, the ruins have long since fallen into disrepair, and the surrounding area has become a favored haunt of the Shoosuva.

At the north end of the ruins, several icy ledges form a terraced slope up the nearest cliff. Mt. Ghakis' resident **shoosuva** (*Volo's Guide to Monsters*, pg. 137) prowls this area regularly, attacking any creature that breaches the borders of its territory its territory with fang, claw, and stinger. These ruins also lie at the edge of the territory of a **hezrou**.

The shoosuva is a recent arrival to this area, a fact known by the residents of nearby Yaedrag. The bargura has resided here longer, having inhabited the mountains for a generation. The Mountain Folk (correctly) believe both to be the accursed spirits of sinful mortals who sought the power of the Amber Temple and who were damned and twisted for their hubris.

The first time the PCs arrive in this area, they are set upon by the **hezrou**, which attempts to conceal itself amidst the snowy bluffs before attacking the most vulnerable character. The hezrou is motivated solely by bloodshed, and will not depart combat until all non-demon enemies are dead. It immediately engages the most vulnerable character with its **multiattack** and relies on its **magic resistance** and **stench** to defend itself.

At the end of the second round of combat, a great roar announces the arrival of the **shoosuva**, which leaps down to the combatants from atop an icy ledge. It aims to sate its hunger by slaughtering and carrying off the weakest prey present, and attacks by using its **tail stinger** to paralyze its target, followed by a **bite** attack in an attempt to reduce its prey to 0 hit points.

If the shoosuva succeeds in capturing a creature, it carries its prey away to the Shoosuva's Canyon; if bloodied, it immediately retreats from combat.

You can find a reader-contributed map of the ruins by /u/Bumbr [here](#). An alternative version by /u/SnooTangerines5710 can be found [here](#).

Developments

If Kaldur or Kasimir are present with the PCs, they can easily guide the party to the secret door behind the waterfall and persuade the guards to allow the party access to the tunnel beyond. Otherwise, a party that has been directed to Yaedrag by Kavan's spirit or Madam Eva's fortunetelling can gain entry with a successful DC 15 Persuasion check; on a failure, the tunnel guards demand that the PCs track and kill the **shoosuva** in its canyon to the north,

returning the beast's head and stinger to prove their worth. The Mountain Folk won't answer or open the door for anyone else.

Yaedrag

Yaedrag is a small village of no more than one hundred inhabitants, populated entirely by the Mountain Folk of Mount Ghakis. Lying within the crater of a hollow mountainous peak north of Tsolenka Pass, its people enjoy the quiet and safety their isolated location provides.

Long ago, the Mountain Folk comprised the hunter and warrior tribes of the People (what the Mountain and Forest Folk call those who serve the Rozana, also known as the Ladies Three), but when the druidic tribes betrayed the Rozana and schismed from their fellows to serve Strahd, the other tribes retreated to the mountains to escape the wrath and sight of the Shadowsworn, their name for Strahd.

While the vast majority of Yaedrag's inhabitants are human, you may choose to have Yaedrag partially populated by the fading remnants of another species once indigenous to Barovia, such as dragonborn or aarakocra. This is especially recommended if one of your PCs is an isolated member of that species, and is seeking out others of their kind in search of family or a sense of belonging.

You can find a battlemat of Yaedrag drawn by /u/Snootangerins5710 [here](#).

Entry Tunnel

The secret entrance to Yaedrag is guarded at all times by six **berserkers** and one berserker commander with the statistics of a **gladiator**.

Tent Village

Nearly all of Yaedrag's occupants live within large conical tents woven of hides from elks and bears hunted among the snowy forests. Most residents work as hunter-gatherers, though many perform specialized tasks such as tanning, nursing, woodworking, or jewel making. Many members of the tribe also serve as warriors and guards, training in the ancient ways of the berserker to defend the village from outside harm and intrusion.

The tribe trades through barter, rather than currencies, but is glad to accept payments of precious gemstones, high-quality trade goods, and services in place of gold. Should the PCs make their way to Yaedrag without cold weather clothing, they are advised to purchase sets from a local clothes maker.

The tribe is ruled by Chief Sigrid, a boisterous and proud middle-aged woman trained as a berserker, who resides in the largest and most decorated tent to Yaedrag's south side. Her eldest daughter, Helwa, is currently venturing to the Amber Temple for a coming-of-age ceremony to become the next chief. Her younger son, Kaldur, recently left for his first hunt alongside Brynhilde, Sigrid's wife, and Chief Sigrid has grown concerned by their failure to return home.

Developments

If the PCs deliver Kaldur to Yaedrag safely, Chief Sigrid greets them like heroes, permitting them to roam the small settlement as they please. She offers every courtesy with her limited resources, and, if informed of their interest in the Amber Temple, offers to introduce the PCs to Elder Ormir to obtain more information.

When the PCs leave, Chief Sigrid warns them to be wary of avalanches and goat attacks at Sangzor's Ridge, as well as Shoosuva and other corrupted demons that lurk the slopes of Mount Ghakis. She offers the assistance of a Mountain Folk **scout** named Folkvar in escorting the PCs to their ultimate destination. Folkvar does not fight in combat except from afar or in self-defense, but can act once per round to give a PC advantage on their next ability check or saving throw made to traverse or survive the wilderness of Mount Ghakis.

On the next night following the PCs' arrival, if the PCs informed Chief Sigrid of the slaughter at the abandoned campsite, she gathers the tribe to hold a funeral ceremony for the lost Brynhilde and Runa.

Shrine of the Rozana

The Shrine of the Rozana comprises a small cavern at the east end of the village, its entrance enclosed within a tall, red-painted tent painted with the symbols of the Ladies Three: the wolf's head, the tree, and the eye.

The tent serves as the living quarters of Elder Ormir, an old man and religious leader to the Mountain Folk. Elder Ormir is one of the few living experts on the histories, rituals, and worship of the *Rozana*, or Ladies Three, and is willing to share his knowledge only with those he trusts. He also possesses limited knowledge of the Amber Temple, including its location, the means of entering through the collapsed passage, the presence and temperament of the arcanaloth and flameskulls, and legends of the lich that inhabits the deeper chambers.

Elder Ormir is wary of sharing this knowledge for fear that it may encourage others to seek out the Temple in search of the dark power it contains. It is custom for the future chieftain of the tribe to journey to the Amber Temple, accompanied only by their most trusted retainers, and to remain in the temple for six days and six nights, exposed to the corruption within as a means of proving their stalwart courage and resistance to evil.

If the PCs appear interested in overthrowing Strahd, Elder Ormir shares with them the following information:

- Before Strahd von Zarovich - called the "Shadowsworn" by the Mountain Folk - or his predecessors, the Delmoreans, conquered Barovia, it was inhabited by a civilization that called itself the First People. The First People worshipped the *Rozana*, or Ladies Three - a trio of ancient goddesses that ruled over the land - and made sacrifices in their name, seeking omens and fortune in the entrails of beasts and mortals alike.
- The *Rozana* wielded powerful magic, bringing good fortune to those that followed their ways. Only their most devout priests knew the Ladies' names; to all others, they were known as the Weaver, the Huntress, and the Seeker.
- For as long as they ruled the land, known in those days as Cerrunos, the Ladies acted as its sovereigns, making their will known through auguries and omens. Through intermediaries, they wielded powerful magic, drawing power from water, earth, and air. It was said that the Ladies could hear everything that happened in their woods, predict the future, twist the threads of human lives, and bring blessings as well as curses.

- When the men of Delmor first invaded Cerrunos, the druids and berserkers fought bravely in defense of their ancient land. Even so, the technology of iron and steel drove the native warriors back to the mountains and wild places, where they hid from the wrath of the Delmoreans. Worship of the Ladies continued, but with fewer followers and more doubt than before. Many amongst the tribes believed their failure to drive out the invaders to be a punishment sent by the Ladies for their failures and flaws; in their oral histories, the First People's failure to serve the Ladies adequately became known as the Second Betrayal.
- Two hundred years later, a haughty warlord named Strahd von Zarovich conquered the fledgling kingdom of Delmor. Fearful, yet optimistic that Zarovich could yet be their savior, the druids of the forest approached him soon after his coronation. They offered him forbidden secrets - hidden knowledge that would bind his power to the land, if only he would promise them patronage and safety. Strahd, his interest piqued, accepted.
- Thrice did the druids of old Cerrunos guide Strahd von Zarovich, mortal that he was, to the Fanes of the Ladies Three. As he stood in these sanctums and felt their primal, ancient magic, Strahd became determined that these, too, must be conquered. In the Swamp Fane, temple of the reclusive Weaver; in the Forest Fane, home of the wise Huntress; and in the Mountain Fane, home of the mystic Seeker, Strahd re-consecrated each stone altar to his own image, sealing rites of blood and powerful magic that bound his soul to the magic of the Ladies - and so became the Land.
- The druids, desperate for a protector, were silent in the face of this profane desecration; the warrior tribes, however, saw it as blasphemy, and separated from the company of the druids in disgust. This became known as the Third Betrayal.
- Today, the Ladies and their rituals are lost to time and mist, the power of the *Rozana* bound by Strahd's desecrations. Elder Ormir and those that preceded him believe from ancient prophecies that the Fanes can still be cleansed of Strahd's taint, restoring the Ladies to power and greatly weakening Zarovich's defenses and his connection to the land. However, the locations of these Fanes were once guarded fiercely by the druidic tribes, and the Mountain Folk only know the location of the Mountain Fane, which lies beneath the Gulthias Tree on Yester Hill.

If they appear amenable to restoring the power of the *Rozana* and freeing the land of Barovia from Strahd's bindings, Elder Ormir asks the PCs to journey to Yester Hill in order to cleanse the Mountain Fane of the Shadowsworn's taint and to learn how the Forest Fane and Swamp Fane might be restored, wherever they may be found.

Shoosuva's Canyon

North of Yaedrag, a half-hour's walk from Tsolenka Pass, the road passes between two craggy cliffs covered in snow and slick with ice. This is Shoosuva's Canyon, the lair of the corrupted beast Shoosuva, and a necessary pass for any creature aiming to climb Mount Ghakis.

A PC with a passive Perception of 15 or higher can hear soft moans emanating from several crags of the canyon. As the PCs proceed down the path, several mounds of

snow occasionally swirl in the wind, forming eddies that whirl for several seconds before settling back down.

Two hundred feet down the canyon and twenty feet off the ground lies the shoosuva's lair: a large, dark single-roomed cavern containing spoiled straw, old gnawed bones, shredded and rotted fabric, and a reflective surface formed of ice. The icy mirror is gouged with deep claw marks and a battleaxe has been slammed into the wall beside it, the blade embedded into the stone of the cavern wall.

The cave itself is accessible by a wide ledge that winds from the floor of the canyon to the cavern's mouth. The first time that a PC approaches this ledge, they are attacked by a **shoosuva**, which strikes with surprise against any characters whose passive Perception is lower than the shoosuva's Stealth check. The shoosuva fights to the death.

On the second round of combat, six **snow maidens** emerge from the craggy cliffs, attacking any living creature that comes too close.

You can find a battlemat of the canyon created by /u/SnooTangerines5710 [here](#).

Treasure

The shoosuva's cave contains six diamonds worth 100 gold pieces each, as well as a **shard of amber** bound to the vestige of Yog the Invincible.

Tsolenka Pass

The first time that the PCs arrive at the bridge at Tsolenka Pass, if Strahd has discovered their location or knows that they plan to journey to the Amber Temple,

Rahadin is standing in wait for them at the center of the bridge. Four **wights** are concealed in the northern archway of the bridge, awaiting Rahadin's orders to attack with their **longbows**. Concealed beneath the bridge is Beucephalus, Strahd's **nightmare**.

A strong wind blows across the bridge at all times, and the air nearby is always filled with heavy snowfall (see **Climate & Hazards** above for more information on wind and heavy precipitation).

Rahadin has taken it upon himself to prevent the PCs from obtaining access to the Temple, Strahd's greatest secret. He waits for the PCs to step onto the bridge before attacking, but employs his **Mask of the Wild** feature to strike from the shadows if the party strikes from afar.

Rahadin aims to keep the PCs in the open, where he and his wights can easily target them. On each round of combat, the wights move up to their speed toward the PCs, attacking with their **longswords** once they are in melee range.

On the fourth round of combat, the Roc of Mount Ghakis appears, acting on initiative count 20. It uses its first turn to attack one of the wights on the bridge, but immediately discards it with disgust after using its first **bite** attack. On his next turn, Rahadin whistles for Beucephalus and leaps from the bridge onto the nightmare's back, vanishing into the Ethereal Plane on Beucephalus' next turn.

On its subsequent turns, the **roc** attempts to target the largest, meatiest-looking creature on the bridge with its **talons** attack. Once it has captured its prey, it rapidly climbs

through the air, away from the bridge and toward its nest at the peak of Mount Ghakis. It uses its action to dash unless its prey fights back, in which case it attacks with its **bite** until the grappled creature is dead.

If, at the beginning of the Roc's turn, there are no living creatures present atop the bridge, it shrieks in disappointment and returns to its nest.

Mount Ghakis

Sangzor's Ridge

This snowy, mile-long ridge ([see here for battlemat](#); [see here for an alternative](#)) overlooks the fog-shrouded Svalich Woods to the south of Luna Lake. Its tall, rocky bluffs are carved with deep gouges, each half the width of a man's torso - markings left by Sangzor, the giant goat, which has claimed this territory as its own.

According to legend, Sangzor has inhabited this ridge for centuries - and its size and sheer toughness both do little to bely those rumors. Sangzor has the stat block of a **mammoth**, but is Large sized, and has the Sure Footed feature from the **giant goat** stat block. Its thick and ancient hide gives it the Magic Resistance feature, as well as resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from non-magical attacks. Its **gore** attack rams its horns into its target, dealing bludgeoning damage rather than piercing.

As the PCs travel across this path, a thick snow begins to fall. Sangzor makes a Stealth (Dexterity) check to conceal itself among the white snow before attacking. It prioritizes attacking the largest or most physically powerful PC, but will immediately take the Shove action against any PC

standing against the edge of the ridge. Sangzor attempts to flee when bloodied.

This ridge is also a precarious avalanche zone. Sangzor's routine ramming of the cliff face has caused heavy piles of icy snow to build up above - and while the goat's Sure Footed feature allows easy escape from collapses, any nearby adventurers may not be so lucky.

Each time a creature casts a non-cantrip spell that deals fire, lightning, force, thunder, or bludgeoning damage, or any spell that disrupts the nearby environment (e.g., *tidal wave* or *earth tremor*), they must roll 1d10. If the result is equal to or below the level of the spell cast, an avalanche begins.

Running the Avalanche

Once triggered, the **avalanche** can be run as a chase sequence (credit to /u/mysteryHLshopper for developing this idea).²¹²

The PCs begin the sequence 100 feet in front of the avalanche, and can attempt to flee from the avalanche each turn. The avalanche falls from behind and above, preventing PCs with fly speeds from escaping it without issue. The chase ends after five rounds.

Each PC must roll initiative, with the avalanche acting on initiative count 0. Each PC also gains a number of **dash points** equal to 2 plus their Constitution modifier. Each PC's turn then proceeds in the following order:

212

https://www.reddit.com/r/DnDBehindTheScreen/comments/cpvm36/three_ways_to_run_an_avalanche/

- The PC rolls 1d20, and the DM announces the corresponding result on the **Complications Table** (see below). The PC may use a skill or cast a levelled spell in order to overcome that complication, so long as that skill or spell takes no more than one action to complete. A PC that casts a levelled spell or a PC that beats the corresponding DC automatically overcomes the complication; a PC that fails the DC suffers the complication's consequences this turn.
- If the PC has a base speed of 60 feet or higher **without taking the Dash action** (e.g., due to the *Fly* spell) or if the PC uses a bonus action to increase their speed (e.g., by spending 1 ki point to use Step of the Wind, using Cunning Action, etc.), the PC runs 200 feet away from the avalanche. Otherwise, the PC runs 100 feet away from the avalanche. If a consequence causes the PC to move at half speed instead, they move 100 or 50 feet, respectively.
- The PC can choose to expend a **dash point** to move an additional 200 or 100 feet, depending on their speed. If a PC has no more dash points remaining, they can make a DC 10 Constitution saving throw; on a success, they move an additional 200 or 100 feet, depending on their speed; on a failure, they gain one point of exhaustion.

At the end of each round, the avalanche advances 50 feet plus an additional 1d4 x 50 feet. If this movement causes the avalanche to move further than a creature,

that creature takes 4d10 bludgeoning damage and becomes **restrained**.²¹³

At the end of each turn that a creature remains restrained in this way, it must make a DC 15 Strength saving throw or take an additional 2d10 bludgeoning damage. When the encounter ends, the avalanche settles, and any restrained creatures cease taking damage. A creature with a Strength score of 15 or more can dig itself out in 2d6 minutes; otherwise, it takes 2d10 minutes for a creature to dig itself out of the snow and debris.

Creatures that are proficient in Survival can learn how far the avalanche will move at the end of the current round with a successful DC 10 Survival check.

Complications Table

The table below presents a list of ten types of complications that may affect your PCs as they attempt to escape the avalanche. Each complication must be overcome with a corresponding challenge. Though the table offers a brief list of recommended skill checks for overcoming each complication (e.g., a DC 10 Perception check to overcome a Poor Visibility complication), PCs are invited to be creative with their

²¹³ Assuming (1) the avalanche advances an average of 175 ft/round; (2) each PC has a speed of 30 ft and a Constitution modifier of +2 (and therefore 4 dash points); (3) each PC faces a complication 50% of the time and fails that complication 50% of the time; and (4) each complication reduces a PC's speed by 75% in a given round, each PC will move an average of 150 ft/round for the first four rounds and 75 ft/round for the final round. In this situation, the avalanche will catch up to the PCs in the fourth round and overtake them in the fifth round, requiring the average PC to risk exhaustion to outrun it, or forcing an unlucky or low-Constitution PC to expend spell slots or risk exhaustion simply to keep pace.

responses (e.g., casting *Gust of Wind* to automatically clear a Poor Visibility complication, or casting *Fly* to automatically overcome a Balancing complication).

If failed, each complication carries with it a corresponding consequence (see the **Complications** table on the next page)..

1d20	Complication	Skill Check	Consequence	Examples
1	Poor Visibility	DC 10 Perception	The creature moves at half speed for 1 round	thick fog, snow flurry, gale of wind
2	Impediment	DC 10 Athletics or Acrobatics	The creature moves at half speed for 1 round	crashing tree, slippery ice
3	Barrier	DC 15 Athletics or Acrobatics	The creature moves at half speed for 1 round	escarpment or cliff, icy river, fallen tree
4	Uneven Ground	DC 15 Acrobatics or DC 10 Survival	The creature has disadvantage on their next ability check or saving throw.	steep incline or decline, slippery ice
5	Obstacles	DC 15 Acrobatics	The creature moves at half speed for 1 round	field of jagged boulders, chunks of broken ice
6	Entanglement	DC 13 Acrobatics	The creature becomes restrained (can immediately make DC 13 Strength check to end)	deep snow, broken ice over water
7	Cramped Space	DC 15 Acrobatics	The creature moves at half speed for 1 round	canyon, small cave, strong winds
8	Balancing	DC 10 Acrobatics	The creature cannot move this turn.	crumbling ice, ice bridge over ravine, rocky ledge
9	Animal Herd	DC 15 Acrobatics or DC 13 Animal Handling	The creature is pushed back 100 feet and takes 4d10 bludgeoning damage.	giant elk, herd of goats
10	Hunter	N/A	A nearby creature makes an opportunity attack against the creature.	Sangzor, winter wolf, snow maiden (specter stat block)
11-20	No Complication			

Blizzard Fields

This part of the trail is barren, isolated, and largely flat. It is also prone to blizzards.

As the PCs enter this area, the constant snowfall grows steadily heavier. The wind

picks up, soon crescendoing into a gale that sends puffs of powdered snow swirling into the air. Have each character make a DC 15 Survival check; on a success, that PC recognizes this weather as the beginnings of a potential blizzard, giving each member of the party advantage on their first saving throw and their first ability check in the skill challenge below.

When the PCs agree to seek shelter from the blizzard, or when the weather becomes too severe to proceed any further, the **Escape the Blizzard** skill challenge begins (credit to /u/OrkishBlade).²¹⁴

Escape the Blizzard

This skill challenge has three stages. To complete this challenge without any penalties, the PCs must complete all stages before they reach three failures. On the PCs' third failure, and on each failure thereafter, each character must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw, taking 2d6 cold damage on a failure or half damage on a success. A character that is immune or resistant to cold damage takes no damage from this effect.

To complete each stage of the challenge, each PC must make a skill check or cast a spell, as described [here](#). At the beginning of each round, each character must make a DC 10 Constitution saving throw; on a failure, that character makes all ability checks this round with disadvantage.

Any creature that attempts to fly in the blizzard must land at the end of its turn or fall prone.

Stage 1: Stay Together: As the blizzard escalates, the high-velocity winds and icy snow make it difficult to see - and easy to become separated from your allies. The characters swiftly lose sight of their allies and find themselves at risk for becoming lost in the blizzard.

A PC can complete this stage with a successful DC 17 Perception check, a successful DC 12 Sleight of Hand check to tie the party together using a rope, a *Gust of Wind* or similar spell to divert the falling snow, a DC 17 Performance check to shout instructions over the screaming winds, or a DC 15 Survival check to track one's allies through the snow. Other skills or spells may be used at the DM's discretion and player's suggestion.

Stage 2: Find a Shelter: With the party united, it's clear that the PCs must find a shelter to escape the elements. At this stage, the PCs find themselves on the edge of the plains, pressed against a dark and craggy cliff that offers little shelter from the wind and biting cold.

A creature that successfully casts *Leomund's Tiny Hut* automatically passes this and the following two stages if they pass three consecutive DC 10 Constitution saving throws; otherwise, the caster takes 2d6 cold damage and must begin again.

A PC can locate shelter and complete this stage with a successful DC 17 Survival check, a successful DC 15 Athletics check to scale the cliff toward higher ground, a successful DC 17 Nature or Investigation check to identify likely points of shelter within the architecture of the cliff, or other skills or spells at the player's suggestion.

Regardless of which skill or spell a PC uses to complete this stage, the party successfully locates a cavern halfway up a switchback trail that can serve as shelter. This is the **Bodak Cave** (see below).

Stage 3: Stay on Track: As the party attempts to make their way together toward the shelter that they've located, the players must select one character to lead the way toward their destination. That PC must roll 1d20; the result of this roll determines which obstacle the PCs will face on the path toward their destination, given by the table below.

After the obstacle is determined, each member of the party must make a saving throw corresponding to that specific obstacle. Each PC that fails the saving throw suffers the corresponding consequence.

If all members of the party fail the saving throw, the PCs must choose a new leader, who rolls a new obstacle. This counts as one failure for the skill challenge. The process continues until at least one PC succeeds on a saving throw. When at least one PC succeeds on the saving throw, the party successfully reaches the cave.

1d20	Obstacle	Saving Throw	Consequence
1-4	Sudden Chill	DC 17 Constitution saving throw	2d6 ice damage and the creature's speed is halved for the next hour
5-8	Crumbling Earth	DC 17 Strength saving throw	2d6 bludgeoning damage and the creature has disadvantage on ability checks for the next hour
9-12	Slippery Ice	DC 17 Dexterity saving throw	2d6 cold damage plus 2d6 bludgeoning damage
13-16	Snow Maiden	DC 17 Wisdom saving throw	3d6 necrotic damage, and the creature's maximum hit points are reduced by the damage taken
17-20	Blast of Snow	DC 17 Constitution saving throw	2d6 cold damage and the creature is blinded for the next ten minutes

Bodak Cave

When the PCs first arrive in this cave (see battlemat [here](#)), the blizzard outside continues to rage, casting a deep, bone-chilling cold into the interior chambers. For each hour that the party remains in the first or second chamber of the cave without a

fire or similar source of heat, each PC must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, the character suffers 2d6 points of cold damage, and that hour does not contribute to the completion of a long rest.

There is no wood within the cave, but a Create Bonfire spell can be used to repeatedly conjure a campfire for as long as the caster is awake. A PC can also attempt a DC 20 Survival check to range outside of the cave for wet (but burnable) branches and roots, which can be lit with a successful DC 10 Survival check or any 1st-level spell or cantrip that deals fire damage. Other skills, resources, or spells may be used at a player's request and at the DM's discretion.

Alternatively, a PC that ventures forth into the second chamber of the cave can gather enough lichen from the walls to fuel a campfire.

If the PCs take a long rest in this cave, the two **bodaks** in the third chamber emerge to attack.

The blizzard outside ends the next morning, allowing the party to progress.

Entry Chamber

The first chamber of the Bodak Cave holds the cavern entrance and is a spacious but barren and earthy room approximately forty by forty feet across. It is connected to the second chamber by a narrow winding passageway five feet across and ten feet long. Any creature near this passageway can hear a low moan emanating from the chambers beyond, similar to that of a person in pain.

Carved Message

The second chamber is approximately half the size of the first. The lower walls and floor are covered in a thick, grey-green lichen, save for a wide black streak of lichen that cuts across the room from the first chamber's corridor to the entrance to

the third chamber. Its eastern wall bears a rough, carved inscription written in Common: "THE SHADOWS LIE." Below, around, and above it, are carved several dozen repetitions of a single phrase in Abyssal: "Do not accept their gifts."

The black line of lichen is accompanied by a trail of dark crimson that smears across the floor from the entrance toward the rear chamber. A DC 15 Medicine check shows this to be comprised of blood - scarcely a day old.

Toward the rear of the room, a narrow opening scarcely three feet across allows passage to the third chamber. This passageway winds an additional five feet forward before opening into a dark corridor. Any creature within the second chamber can hear a low-pitched, pained moan emanating from the narrow opening.

Bodak Labyrinth

This labyrinthine "chamber" comprises several narrow corridors criss-crossing and encircling one another in a maze. The trail of blood leads toward the center of the area, where a large mound of gnawed bones lies at the intersection of two corridors. See [here](#) for a potential map that may be used to depict this area.

A dead elk calf is lying against the bones, its eyes torn from their sockets and its stomach gouged open. Closer inspection reveals that the calf's flesh has begun to slough from its bones, its hide and muscles rotting and its organs scorched a dark, sickly grey. A DC 15 Medicine check can show that the calf's hide was torn by long, sharp claws; and that its innards appear far more decayed than the freshness of its blood would indicate.

The labyrinth contains two dead ends, one to the east and one to the west, each one containing a “nest” belonging to one of the two resident **bodaks**. Both nests are made of rotted fabric, gnawed bones, and a circle of lumpy stones.

When a character first enters the chamber, one **bodak** is eating the calf beside the bone mound, while the other **bodak** lurks in the western nest. A creature that makes a successful DC 14 Stealth check can sneak up on either bodak without being detected; however, any sign or sound of intrusion immediately places both bodaks on alert, allowing them to immediately activate their **Aura of Annihilation** feature and stealthily move through the cavern.

The **Aura of Annihilation** is not obstructed by cover, allowing a bodak to damage any other creature that ends its turn within a 30-foot radius of its location - whether the bodak and its target are separated by empty air or a ten-foot-thick cavern wall.

In combat, a bodak attempts to stalk its prey, preferring isolated targets that are vulnerable to its **Death Gaze**. On its own turn, the bodak uses its **Withering Gaze** to damage the closest target, and uses its high Stealth skill to hide away in the labyrinthine tunnels in response to sunlight or a **Turn Undead** effect, skulking away to a more advantageous position before attacking once more. Neither bodak will flee the cavern, and both will fight to the death if cornered.

Treasure

The eastern nest contains an old *adventurer's pack* containing 12 blood-stained platinum pieces and 56 gold pieces

alongside an ancient, torn letter that reads: “Cassius - I know I’m breaking my promise, but I can’t ignore these visions any longer. If there is a way to bring Mother back, then I have to take it - no matter the risks.” It is signed: “Deirdre.”

The western nest contains a set of shredded clothes, a crumpled map that shows a path up Mount Ghakis to the Amber Temple, and a purse containing 6 silver pieces.

Each bodak wears a chain necklace bearing a **shard of amber** bound to the vestige of Sykane, the Soul Hungerer.

Rimespire Canyon

The Amber Temple is concealed by the natural crags of the Rimespire Canyon, whose entrance lies at the north end of the Blizzard Fields. An experienced tracker can locate the entrance to the canyon within one hour with a successful DC 15 Survival check; otherwise, a party that is searching for the canyon automatically finds it after 2d4 hours of searching.

The canyon itself is 50 feet wide, 100 feet tall, and half a mile across. Its frozen sides are nearly perfectly sheer and bereft of caverns or outcroppings, and it contains only three structures: a deep chasm that bisects the canyon’s midpoint; the Amber Temple; and the enormous spire of frozen ice that gave the canyon its name.

Deep Chasm

The chasm is 200 feet deep and 60 feet wide, and its bottom is lined with jagged ice spikes ten feet in height. It runs perpendicular to the canyon, intersecting it at the quarter-mile point, and has no

ledges or handholds. (A reader-contributed map for this location can be found [here](#)).

An old and crumbling natural stone bridge five feet across passes over its center, allowing medium-sized creatures to pass over. However, a constant **strong wind** (see **Climate & Hazards** above) makes it difficult to keep upright, requiring a creature to make two DC 14 Athletics checks to pass safely. A creature that crawls across the bridge on its hands and knees automatically succeeds on its Athletics check, but a creature that fails either check must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or fall to the bottom of the chasm, suffering 20d6 bludgeoning damage from the impact plus an additional 4d10 piercing damage from the ice spikes.

Developments

After each PC has made their first Athletics check to cross the bridge, if the **roc of Mount Ghakis** has not already been slain elsewhere, its piercing screech rings through the canyon. An instant later, the great bird's shadow falls over the party, forcing them to make a decision: to run for the Amber Temple or stand and fight.

If the PCs decide to fight, the roc—once the familiar of the Seeker—attempts to seize and kill each of the PCs to prevent them from claiming the profane power contained within the Temple. If encountered here, the roc fights until reduced to 100 hit points, then departs to return to its nest.

If the PCs choose to flee for the Temple, run **Flight from the Roc** below.

The Rimespire

The eponymous “Rimespire” lies approximately halfway into the curving canyon. Standing just over 70 feet in height, this single-helix ice structure has stood within sight of the Amber Temple since the temple was first constructed, shedding mass in warmer months and regaining its volume in the winters.

All of the ground in a 100-foot radius around the Rimespire is **slippery ice** (see **Climate & Hazards** above).

Flight from the Roc

This skill challenge has five stages: (1) crossing the chasm; (2) avoiding the rockslide; (3) withstanding the gale; (4) crossing the ice; and (5) fleeing the spire.

Stage 1: Crossing the Chasm. The PCs must successfully cross the deep chasm to avoid the roc's first swoop. Each PC must make a DC 14 Athletics check to cross the bridge as normal; however, a PC may also use magic or different skills such as Acrobatics or Survival (if possessing a climber's kit or similar equipment) to succeed. A PC that chooses to crawl across the bridge automatically fails this check, taking 4d6 + 9 slashing damage as the roc's talons rake across their back.

Stage 2: Avoiding the Rockslide. The roc flies ahead of the party and perches on the side of the canyon, its great weight and enormous talons scraping loose an avalanche of ice, earth, and stone that threatens to bury the PCs beneath it. Each PC may make a DC 15 skill check of their choice or cast a levelled spell in order to evade this rockslide. Recommended skills include acrobatics, athletics, investigation (to calculate the trajectory of the falling

rocks), and perception (to spot a path forward through the rockslide). A creature that fails this check takes 2d10 points of bludgeoning damage and has disadvantage on any checks made in the third stage.

Stage 3: *Withstanding the Gale.* The roc's mighty wings summon a forceful gale that threatens to bowl the PCs from their feet. Each PC must make a DC 15 Strength saving throw in order to stand their ground against the oncoming winds; a creature that roots themselves to the ground with a piece of equipment (e.g., grappling hook or battleaxe) or that casts a levelled spell to fortify their position has advantage on the save. A creature that fails this saving throw has disadvantage on any checks made in the fourth stage; additionally, each character that failed must make a Dexterity check. The character with the lowest result suffers 8d8 + 18 piercing damage as the roc slashes at their prone form with its talons and tears at them with its beak.

Stage 4: *Crossing the Ice.* Just as the Amber Temple finally comes into sight, the PCs must cross the slippery ice that surrounds the Rimespire. Each PC may make a DC 15 skill check of their choice or cast a levelled spell in order to make their way at full speed across the icy field. Recommended skills include acrobatics, nature (to predict patches where the ice is thinnest), perception (to locate a path covered in snow for greater friction), or survival (to draw on past experiences to avoid slipping). Each creature that fails has disadvantage on any checks or saving throws made in the final stage.

Stage 5: *Fleeing the Spire.* The Roc, maddened by the PCs' ability to evade it, flies blindly toward the party - colliding with and cracking the Rimespire. The enormous ice spire splinters at its base, sending the conical spike tumbling through the canyon toward the fleeing PCs. Each PC may make a DC 15 Athletics check or cast a levelled spell to evade the rolling spire. Any creature that fails to do so must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or be crushed by the rolling spire, taking 4d10 bludgeoning damage plus 2d6 cold damage on a failure or half damage on a success.

When the snow and dust settle, the PCs find themselves safely beneath the outcropping of rock at the end of the canyon that shelters the Amber Temple. If alive, the roc gives a final screech of rage before returning to its nest at the peak of Mount Ghakis.

Chapter 13: The Amber Temple

□ Strands of Fate - Hooks to the Amber Temple

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies within the Amber Temple, the PCs can find it here or beyond the bridge, respectively.

Kasimir's Plea: If the PCs agreed to escort Kasimir to the Amber Temple, he guides them to its location.

Whispers of Shadow: If one of the PCs has been directed to the Amber Temple by a Dark Gift resurrection or a shard of amber, they can find the amber sarcophagus of their patron vestige within the Temple.

Morgantha's Bargain: If the PCs bargain with her, Morgantha the **night hag** can reveal that Strahd gained his knowledge of ancient lore from the Amber Temple, located near the peak of Mount Ghakis.

The Amber Temple is, in many ways, the true climax of *Curse of Strahd*. It may not be the climactic battle, but it is the peak of many PCs' character arcs - especially those that run the risk of corruption. Here, the PCs will come face-to-face with the powers that enabled Strahd's curse, and have the option of embracing those powers as well.

This chapter changes two primary aspects of the original source material: the origin of its inhabitants, and the nature of the Dark Gifts of the vestiges. Both aspects are heavily related to the dark vestiges and the themes of corruption that permeate the temple.

As-written, the Amber Temple is filled with undead, aberrations, and demons. However, the module never explains how four **nothics** or **ghasts** came to reside here, let alone a **death slaad** or an **arcaneloth**. In this rewrite, these monsters didn't come to the Temple simply to lair here - instead, they are victims of the vestiges' corruption. More information on their origins is detailed in the sections below.

The RAW Dark Gifts given by the vestiges, while theoretically interesting, make for severely un-fun gameplay. If run RAW, a PC accepting these Dark Gifts can instantly "die" with a single failed Charisma saving throw, rendering them forevermore as an NPC under the DM's control. Many DMs, rightfully, remove this drawback to allow players to retain control of their PCs after accepting a vestige's Dark Gift.

However, this comes with its own consequences, with power-hungry PCs scooping up every Dark Gift they can get their grimy hands on. This reduces the final battle with Strahd to little more than a farce, with an army of undead, spine-covered, bone-winged, plague-diseased PCs marching into Castle Ravenloft to fling lightning bolts, command fiery hounds, and generally be as unpleasant as possible.

In this revision of the Amber Temple, these Dark Gifts - which, by now, have been heavily foreshadowed by the amber shards found in Tsolenka Pass, Mount Ghakis, and elsewhere in Barovia - are instead a constant corrupting force that the PCs know well to avoid. Any PC that chooses to accept the great power offered by the vestiges is now free to do so at the risk of great corruption - but in a fairer, reasonable manner.

Resting in the Amber Temple

It is difficult, if not impossible for an ordinary person to find rest in the Amber Temple's walls. Any person with a passive Perception of 15 or greater can easily detect that the air of the temple is infused with a miasma of evil and madness, and that prolonged exposure can lead to mental harm or madness.

Any humanoid or beast that attempts to take a long rest in the Temple must succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw or suffer one point of exhaustion and be visited by terrible nightmares. A creature that fails this saving throw is visited by a suitable vestige in their dreams, which tells them how to obtain that vestige's Dark Gift. A character that refuses or falsely accepts a vestige's offer gains a random form of short-term madness when they awake, as dictated by the appropriate table in the *Dungeon Master's Guide*.

Regardless of success or failure on this saving throw, no humanoid or beast can gain the benefits of a long rest (e.g., restoring spell slots, regaining hit points or hit dice, or restoring class features) for as long as they remain in the Amber Temple. However, a creature can still sleep, thereby avoiding the threat of further exhaustion due to sleeplessness.

Note: Additions & Replacements

All content below is an **addition** to the content in the original module, rather than a replacement, unless implied or specifically stated. As such, if a specific magic item has a new description, or if a room contains a new monster encounter, you can assume that this description and encounter have replaced the original description and encounter.

However, if the room did not originally contain a monster encounter, or if the room originally contained a puzzle encounter in addition to a monster encounter, you should assume that the new encounter is an **addition** to the room's original description. Similarly, if a room originally contained a monster encounter, and the revised description of that chamber does not mention that encounter, you should assume that the encounter is still present unless specifically removed in this revision.

X1. Temple Facade

The following inscription has been carved into the frame above the front door into the Amber Temple:

If you seek honor or power, turn back - for these walls hold naught but doom.

In amber tombs below, the darkness shelters a timeless evil.

This temple is infected with a scourge of malevolent divinity.

Our arrogance and folly forged this place into our prison.

Leave now, before our damnation becomes yours.

A character with a passive Perception of 15 or greater notices that the snow to the left side of the temple entrance appears to have been traversed recently. A DC 15 Survival check reveals a set of human footprints alongside a much larger pair of canine paw prints leading to Area X1a (Narrow Fissure). A DC 15 Nature check can identify the paw prints as belonging to a **winter wolf**.

X4. Overlook

The arcanaloth **Neferon** does not attack the PCs on sight. Instead, as soon as the PCs enter area X4 (Overlook), a booming, telepathic voice greets them and demands to know if they have come to steal the secrets of the Amber Temple. If the PCs respond with hostility, Neferon demands that they leave, and attacks immediately if they fail to do so. If the PCs appear willing to negotiate, Neferon demands that **each** character who wishes to enter the Temple offer a separate tribute of knowledge or power. As such, if three PCs and two NPCs wish to enter the Temple together, they must offer a total of five tributes meeting Neferon's demands. Neferon will reject any tribute that does not meet his standards, and will allow its offerer to provide a new tribute.

A tribute of **knowledge** must be a useful and well-hidden secret about some part of Barovia. Neferon is not interested in information that is either widely known, such as the existence of Van Richten's Tower; information regarding current events, such as the death of Burgomaster Kolyan Indirovich; or secrets with little value or impact, such as the nature of Stella Wachter's madness.

Potential tributes include:

- The true lycanthropic nature of the Keepers of the Feather
- The headquarters and leadership of the Keepers of the Feather
- The identity and location of Mordenkainen
- The contents of the Tome of Strahd
- The true identity of the Abbot
- The history and current status of the Fanes of Barovia

A tribute of **power** must be a magic item of rare or greater value. A sacrifice of three or more uncommon magic items will also meet Neferon's approval. Alternatively, a character can offer three **amber shards** to gain passage to the interior of the Amber Temple. These tributes can be placed at the base of Area X5a (God of Secrets) by the character that offers it.

Upon accepting the tributes of all who wish to enter into the Temple, Neferon offers the following promise and warning:

"You shall have safe passage to and from the Temple, so long as you take no treasure that is not freely given. Be warned - I and my guardians are not the only inhabitants of this place, and those that dwell deeper within may greet you with hostility or violence. Your safety is your sole responsibility. And remember - those
--

that break the accords of this Temple shall be condemned to haunt it forevermore.”
--

Once the tributes have been made, if any creature attempts to enter the Temple without Neferon’s permission (e.g., while invisible), or if the PCs attempt to enter the Temple via areas such as X5 (Temple of Lost Secrets), area X6 (Southeast Annex), or area X15 (Southwest Annex) without making a sufficient offering, Neferon and the three **flameskulls** in Area X17 (Upper West Hall) immediately attack.

For as long as the PCs remain in the temple, Neferon will follow invisibly, taking care to keep at least 30 feet from the party and, wherever possible, hovering 20 feet above the ground at all times. He will employ his at-will *invisibility* spell and his **Teleport** action to avoid the PCs while monitoring them closely for any evidence of thievery.

For every 30 minutes that the PCs remain in the temple, Neferon must make a Stealth check; if the passive Perception of the PC or NPC closest to him exceeds his result, that character can hear the sound of whooshing air behind and above the party, as though a strange breeze is moving through the air. If detected directly (e.g., via a character with truesight or *see invisibility*), Neferon uses his **Teleport** to swiftly retreat to area X5a (God of Secrets).

X5a. God of Secrets

□ Know the Monsters - Neferon, Arcanaloth Guardian

Neferon was once the vice-chancellor of the Amber Temple, but became corrupted when he grew jealous of Exethanter's power and accepted several dark gifts from the vestiges below. Today, he remembers little of his life as a mage, but remains fiercely protective of the treasures and secrets that lie within the Temple, believing himself to be their caretaker and sole owner. However, he is willing to share the gifts of the vestiges with others - so long as they assuage his natural greed as an arcanaloth for magical power or valuable secrets.

In combat, Neferon's greatest utility tools are his at-will *invisibility* spell, his 120-ft. truesight (which allows him to see through all magical darkness, illusions, polymorphs, and invisibilities), and his fly speed. Unless he is concentrating on *heat metal*, Neferon should always focus his concentration on *invisibility*, renewing the spell whenever he feels endangered.

If he believes combat to be imminent and he can do so while remaining hidden, Neferon immediately casts *mirror image* on himself.

Neferon will not abandon his position in area X5a (God of Secrets) unless the PCs maneuver to a position beyond his reach such as Area X2 (Entrance), area X15 (Southwest Annex), or area X17 (Upper West Hall). Whenever he is not within area X5a (God of Secrets), Neferon will use his fly speed to skim the ceiling of whichever room or corridor he is in, refusing to allow any floor- or wall-bound enemies to engage him in melee. Neferon will not pursue PCs into tight, enclosed spaces such as X3 (Empty Barracks), X6 (Southeast Annex), or X39 (Plundered Treasury, preferring instead to use his **Teleport** and his *invisibility* to secure a more advantageous position while the PCs take cover.

If he believes the PCs present a threat, Neferon opens combat with an 8th-level *chain lightning*, followed by a 6th-level *chain lightning*; if the PCs are at 6th level or below, he will instead open with a pair of 4th-level *fireballs* as warning shots, escalating his attacks with a 6th- and 8th- level *chain lightning* if the PCs fail to heed his warnings. He will focus on clumped-up groups and "thieves" first, but will cast *finger of death* at 7th-level toward any isolated character who appears close to escaping the Temple, either via area X2 (Entrance) or area X15 (Southwest Annex).

Neferon will automatically reserve spell slots for and cast *counterspell* to block any spell that threatens to incapacitate him, such as *hold monster* or *hypnotic pattern*. If the party does not appear to have any such status-imposing spells, he will instead use his reaction to cast *shield* to defend himself from ranged attacks - but only if he is at half health or lower.

Once his 6th- and greater spell slots are expended, Neferon uses his 5th, 4th, and 3rd spell slots to cast *fireball*, though he reserves a single 4th-level spell slot to cast *dimension door* and escape to area X31a (West Catacombs) in case he is ever reduced to 26 HP or less. Once he has no more 3rd-level slots remaining, or if he is forced to hold his 3rd- and 4th-level slots in reserve to cast *counterspell*, Neferon switches to casting *fire bolt* exclusively.

If Neferon is ever engaged in melee by a flying opponent wearing metal armor or bearing a weapon made of metal and finds it difficult or irritating to escape using his **Teleport**, he will cast *heat metal* to force that enemy to drop their weapon or (in the case of armor) inflict disadvantage on all attack rolls and ability checks.

X6. Southeast Annex

Unlike the flameskulls in area X17 (Upper West Hall), the three **flameskulls** that reside in area X33a (Vault of Shalx) are not under Neferon's command, and immediately attack any intruders that rouse their attention.

X15. Southwest Annex

The four **berserkers** that reside in this chamber are members of the Mountain Folk settlement of Yaedrag, and are led by Helwa, a **gladiator** and the eldest daughter of Chief Sigrid, making her the powerful but impatient heir to Yaedrag's leadership.

These berserkers are Helwa's Bloodspears - her most trusted companions - and will ascend to leadership roles within the tribe when she takes her mother's place. They include:

- Keldei, Helwa's First Spear, a stubborn, and powerfully loyal warrior.
- Astrid, an inquisitive and curious tracker.
- Frida, a timid but fierce hunter
- Harald, a proud, stocky fighter

A fifth **berserker**, Bjorn, was recently killed. His body is watched over by Skald, Helwa's **winter wolf** companion. Skald is capable of basic human speech, though he struggles to speak through his canine muzzle. However, he does not speak when in the presence of strangers.

This group has come to the Amber Temple to undertake a traditional rite of passage for new leaders of the tribe at Yaedrag. To pass, they must survive six days and six nights within this chamber, enduring the madness and darkness of the Temple to prove their strength and steadfast defiance of the temptations of evil.

The Mountain Folk have recently experienced a tragedy: Last night, their friend, Bjorn, was killed during his watch. Astrid, who was assigned the watch after him, was the first to discover the body. A casual inspection of Bjorn's body reveals massive slashes down the length of his back; a DC 14 Medicine check also indicates that large chunks of flesh have been torn from the body's stomach. A DC 16 Medicine check reveals a pair of puncture wounds along Bjorn's shoulder, as well as a distinctive grey-yellow tinge to the skin that indicate that poison was injected by the fangs of some creature.

Skald has thus far been unable to track the killer, as the only scents within the room and on Bjorn's corpse are those belonging to the other Mountain Folk.

Helwa is also upset because her magic spear, *Shatterspike* (TftYP, page 229), has disappeared from her belongings. It vanished on the third night of their stay at the Temple, and has not yet reappeared. As a result of these two incidents, the Mountain Folk are tense and suspicious of outsiders, and will threaten to attack the PCs on sight, believing them to be monsters or illusions

of the Temple, unless convinced that the party has been sent by or previously met with Chief Sigrid.

The true killer and thief is Frida, who located an amber shard of **Drizlash** in a forgotten corner of the chamber during her first night's watch in the Temple. Since then, she has grown terrified of the darkness that lurks within the Temple, and allowed the voice she hears through the amber shard to coax her into accepting its gifts. Offering Shatterspike as tribute to Neferon, she descended into the Amber Temple and accepted Drizlash's dark gift.

As a result, Frida has obtained the **Spider Climb** ability and **Bite** attack of a **dridrider**, as well as a Dexterity score of 16 (+3) and a Stealth modifier of +9. She also has a drider's **Sunlight Sensitivity** feature, and has been infected with a drider's madness, paranoia, and hunger. Her spider's fangs are concealed among the rest of her teeth, but can be detected up with a physical inspection and a DC 15 Medicine check or a visual inspection and a DC 20 Perception check. She conceals the amber shard on a cord of leather that hangs around her neck.

If her true nature is revealed, Frida flies into a rage and attacks her accuser. If Helwa and her companions have not already been convinced that Frida has been corrupted, they fight alongside her, encouraging Frida to avoid revealing her "gifts." If bloodied, Frida flees through Area X1a (Narrow Fissure), hoping to find a hiding place on the slopes of Mount Ghakis where she can complete her transformation.

If Frida is not dealt with, the first night that the PCs rest after first arriving at the Amber Temple, she kills Astrid while Astrid is on watch. The following night, Harald is killed. The final night, Helwa surprises Frida and kills her, though not before Keldei is killed and Skald's left foreleg is heavily wounded.

X17. Upper West Hall

The three **flameskulls** in this chamber will not attack any creature that has made a successful tribute to Neferon, unless that creature has previously stolen a treasure or magic item from within the Temple.

The **staff of frost** on the floor is cursed, and becoming attuned to it extends the curse to you. As long as you remain cursed, you are unwilling to part with the staff, keeping it on your person at all times. All nonmagical flames within 30 feet of you automatically extinguish, and fire damage dealt by you is halved. Additionally, any creature that takes a short or long rest within thirty feet of you suffers the effects of **extreme cold**. This curse replaces the flaw described in the original module.

X27. Lich's Lair

Formerly the head chancellor of the mages guarding the Amber Temple, Exethanter swiftly moved to accept the dark gift of Tenebrous as the Temple fell into darkness and temptation.

However, in the many centuries of isolation and corruption that followed, his mind has decayed greatly, leaving him in his current pitiable state.

Unlike in the module, Exethanter cannot be found in his lair; instead, he is in area X30 (Preserved Library) when the PCs first meet him. However, his spellbook remains inside this chamber, as well as an additional **arcane laboratory** comprising a cabinet full of two dozen unmarked chemical and magical ingredients, a thick and weighty book titled *The Alchemist's Almanac*, and a potion-brewing set that includes a small cauldron, a balance scale, and all other appropriate tools.

Exethanter's spellbook is currently opened to a scribbled recipe for a *Potion of Greater Restoration*. The following note has been jotted hastily in the margins.

The weight of the centuries presses upon these old bones like quicksand, devouring every other thought. Though my skull may be physically whole, I can feel the rot of my mind progressing like the decay of crawler maggots.

I must locate the final ingredient of the potion. Its creation is beyond my capabilities - a cruel joke for one capable of commanding the very fabric of reality. It is ironic, perhaps, that divinity lays beyond the reach of one who has transgressed the laws of Death itself.

I must wait. I have never known faith, save for the sacrifices made to the nameless god below. Yet now, I can only wait - and pray that there is yet enough time.

The recipe is as follows:

Potion of Greater Restoration

- 1. Brew a one-quart base of third-degree reagents (1 activator : 2 declinator).*
- 2. Add a pinch of nightfern leaves (NOT blackwort leaves - highly toxic!).*
- 3. Mix in ounce of rimesap for potency (check the hidden compartment)*
- 4. Simmer for five minutes; add wyvern mucus (extra samples in cabinet if needed; taste first to confirm it's not pale tincture).*
- 5. Add holy water and stir.*

The phrase “holy water” is circled and underlined twice.

In his final years of lucidity, Exethanter sought to do the impossible: to replicate the power of a divine spell - *greater restoration* - through purely arcane means. Through much trial and error, he was able to develop a specific recipe capable of doing so, but with one problem: to instill the necessary divine energy, it required an infusion of *holy water*, an ingredient that Exethanter is wholly incapable of producing.

In the event that the PCs are unable to cast *greater restoration* to restore Exethanter's memories, the party can instead attempt to brew the recipe listed in the lich's spellbook. If brewed successfully, this *Potion of Greater Restoration* has the same effects of the spell *greater*

restoration; however, Exethanter's laboratory has only enough spare ingredients to brew this potion twice.

If cured of his amnesia, Exethentar thanks the PCs deeply and offers to guide them through the Temple as described in the original chapter.

The PCs can successfully complete each step as follows:

Step 1. A DC 15 Arcana check can identify the correct potion ingredients in Exethantor's cupboard to serve third-degree reagents, including an activator and a declinator, which must be added in the appropriate proportions. Alternatively, the PCs can locate the proper ingredients by searching through *The Alchemist's Almanac*.

Step 2. Within Exethanter's ingredients cupboard lies a pair of glass bottles that appear to contain the leaves of distinct plants. The bottles are unmarked. One contains a number of thick, curled leaves with an indigo coloration; the other contains a half-dozen needle-thin leaves with a razor-sharp edge. A successful DC 17 Nature check can identify that the curled leaves are poisonous blackwort and the needle leaves are nightfern leaves.

If the bottle containing the poisonous blackwort is opened, it immediately emits a cloud of toxic gas, forcing each creature within a ten-foot radius to make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or take 4d6 points of poison damage, or half on a success.

Step 3. In the northwest corner of Exethanter's lair, within the wall close to the ceiling, rests a hidden compartment no larger than a fist. It can be located with a successful DC 15 Investigation check or one hour of careful searching; if the check result was 20 or higher, the PCs also locate a poisonous needle trap concealed within the compartment's door mechanism.

The needle trap can be disarmed with a successful DC 20 Thieves' Tools check. If the compartment is opened without first disarming the trap, the opener must make a DC 18 Constitution saving throw, suffering 10d6 poison damage on a failure or half on a success. This compartment contains a small glass vial containing a brilliant cerulean blue liquid marked "RIMESAP."

Step 4. Beside the cauldron rests a glass vial labelled "WYVERN MUCUS." Though its contents are empty, a thick film of dried-up grey-colored flakes cling to the sides. A successful DC 16 Medicine check can match the dried-up remnants of this ingredient with a trio of other vials of grey-white liquid within Exethanter's component cupboard.

A trio of vials containing a similar liquid are mixed in with the others; these contain concentrated Pale Tincture. A creature that ingests even a small amount of Pale Tincture must succeed on a DC 18 Constitution saving throw or take 3d6 poison damage and become **poisoned**. The poisoned creature must repeat the saving throw every hour, taking 3d6 poison damage on a failed save. This damage cannot be healed by any means, though the poison can be removed

from the creature's system by means of *lay on hands* or similar magic. After seven successful Saving Throws, the effect ends and the creature can heal normally.

Step 5. The potion can only be completed if holy water is added. The PCs may obtain holy water from Ezmerelda (if she is travelling with the party and still has some available), from the *Ceremony* spell, or by some other means.

X30. Preserved Library

Upon entering this chamber, the PCs can find Exethanter standing on the carpet in the center of the room, looking lost. After greeting them, if the PCs seem friendly, the lich asks if any of the characters have seen his "book." If asked, he describes the book as "heavy," "wrapped in a smooth, tough material" (leather), and written in ink "the same color as those short, skinny plants" (green grass). He also recalls that it has the word "Incants" in the title, and that he left it open on a desk somewhere. He doesn't know where the desk is, but knows that it isn't downstairs.

If the PCs are still being invisibly tailed by Neferon, the **arcanaloth**, after making the tribute at the Temple entrance, Exethanter notices its presence using his **truesight** several minutes after first encountering the PCs. Though he doesn't recognize Neferon due to his memory loss, Exethanter points out the appearance of a strange, fox-faced creature in the air toward the top of the chamber, and asks the PCs if it's a friend of theirs. Upon hearing this, Neferon swiftly retreats from sight.

X33. Amber Vaults

Each time a creature uses a dark gift received from one of the vestiges of the Amber Temple, it must make a DC 10 Charisma saving throw; on a failure, one of the following consequences occurs, based on the creature's level (or twice the creature's Challenge Rating, if it doesn't have a level):

- **Level 1 or Lower:** The creature is overwhelmed by the malevolent power and is immediately transformed into a **ghoul**.
- **Level 2 or 3:** The creature is overwhelmed by the malevolent power and is immediately transformed into a **nothic**.
- **Level 4 or Above:** The creature gains an additional stage of corruption, depending on the dark gift it accepted and dictated by the **Corruption Table** below. Creatures accrue corruption from different dark gifts separately. (For example, if a creature has two levels of corruption from Fekre's dark gift and one level of corruption from Drizlash's dark gift, and that creature fails a saving throw while using Drizlash's dark gift, the creature now has two levels of corruption from Fekre and two levels of corruption from Drizlash.)

Each time the creature succeeds on this saving throw, the DC for the next saving throw increases by 5. The third time the creature makes a successful saving throw, its new abilities, attributes, and flaws become permanent and it does not need to make any more saving throws.

When a creature accepts a new dark gift, it begins with zero stages of corruption in that specific dark gift. However, it also instantly gains a stage of corruption in every other dark gift it had already accepted.²¹⁵ For example, assume that a creature has previously accepted a dark gift from Fekre. If that creature then accepts a dark gift from Drizlash, that creature begins with zero levels of Drizlash's corruption, but automatically gains one level of Fekre's corruption. (You might present this as the creature becoming increasingly vulnerable to the vestiges' dark power, or as a jealous vestige asserting its claim over the creature).

Corruption Table

Wherever a corruption stage lists a specific feature or attack (e.g., the **Rotting Presence** feature in the second stage of Fekre's corruption), assume that it uses the same description and statistics as the corresponding feature or attack on the stat block of the creature listed in the third stage of that vestige's corruption (e.g., the **bulezau**).

If a creature gains a new attack, but doesn't have the anatomy necessary to use it (e.g., the **Barbed Tail** attack in the second stage of Fekre's corruption), the creature also gains the anatomical features needed to use the attack (e.g., a long barbed tail).

Vestige	Stage One	Stage Two	Stage Three
Fekre, Queen of Poxes	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Constitution score and the flaw: "I crave violence." Its flesh is covered by maggot-infested open sores.	The creature gains the Rotting Presence feature, the Barbed Tail attack, and the flaws "I live for the kill," and "Death holds no fear for me."	The creature transforms into a bulezau under the DM's control.
Zrin-Hala, the Howling Storm	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "I long to carve the flesh of my foes." Its feet fuse into cloven hooves.	The creature gains the Serrated Tail attack, the Magic Weapons feature, and the flaw: "Every creature - friend or foe - is an opportunity to prove my strength."	The creature transforms into an armanite under the DM's control.
Sykane, the Soul Hungerer	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Constitution score and the flaws: "I must devour a pound of earthworms each day, or become incapacitated," and "I enjoy killing helpless things." Its skin becomes pallid and gray.	The creature gains the Regeneration feature, the Burrowing Worm attack, and the flaw: "I am incapable of speech, but giggle at odd intervals."	The creature transforms into a spawn of Kyuss under the DM's control.
Savnok, the Inscrutable	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "I am prone to bouts of madness." It gains six inches in height and its flesh becomes transparent, allowing the veins and muscle below to become visible.	The creature gains the Psychic Mirror feature, the Slam attack, and the flaw: "I am apathetic to all things, and obey all orders given to me."	The creature transforms into a star spawn hulk under the DM's control.

Tarakemedes, the Grave Wyrn	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "I am envious of my betters and cruel to my inferiors." Its nails become long, bony, and white with crimson-tips, and small, vestigial wings of bone emerge from its back.	The creature gains a pair of vestigial wings that reduce fall damage to zero and allow it to glide five feet horizontally per five feet fallen, the Sting attack, and the flaw: "I hate what I cannot have, and lust for all that is valuable or powerful."	The creature transforms into a bone devil under the DM's control.
Shami-Amourae, the Lady of Delights	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Charisma score and the flaw: "I can't get enough pleasure. I desire others to create beauty for me at all times." Its hair turns red and grows past its waist, its feet fusing into cloven hooves.	The creature gains the ability to communicate via telepathy, the Telepathic Bond feature, the Charm action, the Draining Kiss attack, and the flaw: "I demand worship and loyalty from all that I meet."	The creature transforms into an incubus or succubus under the DM's control.
Drizlash, the Nine-Eyed Spider	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Constitution score and the flaw: "Only raw flesh can satiate my hunger, and I am always hungry." Its skin becomes a pale black, and fangs grow in its mouth.	The creature gains the Web Walker ability, the Bite attack, the Sunlight Sensitivity feature, and the flaw: "I suffer from extreme paranoia, and am quick to anger."	The creature transforms into a driider under the DM's control.
Dahlver-Nar, He of the Many Teeth	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Dexterity score and the flaw: "I have little sense of self - it's hard to remember who I am or where I'm going." Its teeth become long, sharp, and pointed, and its eyes glow a pale yellow.	The creature gains the Assume Form feature, the Claws attack, and the flaw, "I constantly hunger for humanoids' flesh, and can never sate my urges."	The creature transforms into a maurezhi under the DM's control.
Zantras, the Kingmaker	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Charisma score and the flaw: "I expect my orders to be obeyed, and am easily enraged by disobedience." Its skin turns red, its hands each gain a sixth finger, and it grows a pair of small	The creature gains the Fiendish Charm ability, the Fiendish Blessing feature, and the flaw: "I exult in every opportunity for wickedness and perversion."	The creature transforms into a cambion under the DM's control.

	horns on its brow.		
Delban, the Star of Ice and Hate	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "Expressions of emotion disgust me." Its face and back grow dozens of grotesque blue boils.	The creature gains the Cold Aura feature, the Greatsword attack (which manifests as a blade of never-melting ice grown from one of the creature's limbs), and the flaw "Fire terrifies me."	The creature transforms into a drowned master under the DM's control.
Khirad, the Star of Secrets	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Intelligence score and the flaw: "I am obedient to all who would command me." Its eyes become a milky-white color, its hair falls out, and its scalp grows several pinkish-red tentacles.	The creature gains the ability to communicate via telepathy from 600 feet and loses the capacity to understand all other speech. It gains the Tentacles attack and the flaw: "I pay no heed to the concerns of creatures incapable of the psionic arts."	The creature transforms into a mindwitness under the DM's control.
Yrrga, the Eye of Shadows	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Constitution score and the flaw: "I enjoy tormenting others." Patches of ash-grey scales sprout across its skin, and its teeth become sharp and pointed.	The creature gains the Magic Weapons and Magic Resistance features, the Bite attack, and the flaw: "I believe that all life is pointless, and look forward to death when it finally comes."	The creature transforms into a death slaad under the DM's control.
Great Taar Haak, the Five-Headed Destroyer	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "I'm always hungry for a fight, and I love taking gruesome trophies from my victims." Its muscles swell to a larger size, and short, orange fur covers its body.	The creature gains the Reckless ability, a 40-foot climb speed, the Bite attack, and the flaw: "I'd tear someone limb from limb with barely the slightest provocation."	The creature transforms into a barlgura under the DM's control.
Yog the Invincible	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "Once I've entered battle, I can't distinguish between friend and foe." A line of jagged black spikes grows along its spine, and its eyes	The creature gains the Rampage ability, the Tail Stinger attack, and the flaw: "I'm always hungry for flesh - but my hunger can never be sated."	The creature transforms into a shoosuva under the DM's control.

	grow a dark, scarlet red.		
Norganas, the Finger of Oblivion	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Dexterity score and the flaw: "Expressions of life and joy disgust me." Its eyes become black voids, and its jaw unhinges, drooping uselessly past its neck.	The creature gains the Aura of Annihilation and Sunlight Hypersensitivity features, the Withering Gaze attack, and the flaw: "I seek out undead, and avoid the living."	The creature transforms into a bodak under the DM's control.
Vaund the Evasive	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Dexterity score and the flaw: "I do not feel joy, sorrow, or love - only hate, rage, and apathy." Its form becomes ethereal and clouded in shadow, and its eyes glow yellow.	The creature gains the Incorporeal Movement feature, Life Drain attack, and the flaw: "I despise reminders of what I once was, and what I have become."	The creature transforms into a wraith under the DM's control.
Seriach, the Hell Hound Whisperer	The creature gains a +3 bonus to its Strength score and the flaw: "I must regularly indulge my hunger for killing." A cloud of smoke and embers constantly emits from the creature's mouth.	The creature gains the Keen Hearing and Smell feature, a 50 foot movement speed, the Bite attack, and the flaw: "A weakened ally is little better than prey."	The creature transforms into a hell hound under the DM's control.

X33. Amber Vaults²¹⁶

The dark gifts and accompanying flaws listed in the original module have been replaced by a new set of dark gifts (listed below) and the risk of progressing through the **Corruption Table** for each particular dark gift (see above).

X33A. Vault of Shalx.

West Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a vast, dark stone chamber lined with twisted pillars and sculptures of snakes. At the opposite end of the chamber, upon a dais, rests a dark stone altar that bears a porcelain bowl decorated with simple swirling patterns. The bowl is filled with a bubbling purple liquid.

Behind the altar stands **Fekre, Queen of Poxes**, a tall woman with pallid, purple-grey skin and a dress of deep violet. Her hair resembles a grey-green fungus that extends on either side of her head, and her eyes are covered with a purple fungus that mimics the shape of a masquerade mask. She offers the creature her dark gift: the power of spreading disease. To

²¹⁶ All credit for the visual descriptions of several of the vestiges in this section goes to /u/fedex777 for their post "[Dark Powers in Barovia.](#)"

accept, the creature must drink the potion from the ceramic bowl. The dark gift allows its beneficiary to cast the *contagion* spell as an action without components three times per day.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to an infinite, flat plain of dead vegetation and dry, cracked soil. Overhead, torrential black storm clouds swirl as immense lances of lightning flash across the sky, followed shortly by pounding eruptions of thunder. No rain falls.

Amidst the clouds, at the eye of the storm, hovers **Zrin-Hala, the Howling Storm**, a massive humanoid apparition formed of dark storm clouds that constantly crackle and hum with lightning. Its lower body is a black tornado that descends to the ground below, carving deep gouges into the landscape. Its hands are long, crackling bolts of lightning, and its mouth is a gaping, dark maw. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power to create lightning. To accept, the creature must be speared in the chest with one of Zrin-Hala's lightning bolts. The dark gift allows its beneficiary to cast the *lightning bolt* spell as an action without components three times per day.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a vast, dark graveyard of twisted, decaying vegetation and sunken, crumbling headstones. The sky is covered with flat, grey clouds, and the cemetery is interspersed with tall, cast-iron fences that have rusted and bent with age.

At the center of the graveyard, before an enormous mass grave filled with humanoid corpses, rests **Sykane, the Soul Hungerer**, an enormous worm with the mouth of a lamprey. Drifting clouds of dim golden mist occasionally drift past its cavernous maw, which it greedily devours whole. Its flesh is not skin, but a writhing mass of millions of tiny earthworms that weave together like fabric. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power to raise the recently deceased. To accept, the PC must devour an earthworm from Sykane's flesh. This dark gift allows its beneficiary to cast the *raise dead* spell once per day without components as an action.

X33B. Vault of Maverus

North Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a circular chamber filled with shelves that groan beneath the weight of arcane components, potions, and devices. The floor, which is forged of glittering lapis-lazuli, is carved in the design of a pentagram. Each of the pentagram's points bears the sigil of one of the five elements of fire, earth, wind, water, and will. At the center of the room, upon a white marble pedestal, rests an orb carved from an amethyst gem.

Beside the pedestal stands **Savnok, the Inscrutable**, a figure whose features and limbs are entirely concealed by the long, cowed violet robe that it wears. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power to shield the mind. To accept, the PC must place its hand upon the orb upon the pedestal. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to cast the *mind blank* spell once per day without components.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a vast ossuary built to resemble a throne room forged entirely with bones. Lightless grey flames burn in countless sconces carved from skulls and mounted upon the walls, which themselves are built of interlocking femurs and decorated with rib cages organized in sickening patterns.

At the center of the chamber, behind a throne forged of skulls, ribs, clavicles, and femurs, towers **Tarakamedes, the Grave Wurm**, a serpentine worm with a body formed of jagged grey spikes, its head terminating in a massive, tooth-filled maw that extends beyond the edges of its body, without eyes or other facial features. Twin skeletal wings extend from its back, its vast wingspan brushing the edges of the chamber. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power of flight. To accept, the PC must seat itself upon the throne. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to cast the *fly* spell three times per day without components, manifesting as a pair of skeletal wings.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a lush windowless parlor lit by flickering candlelight and filled with soft pillows, divans, love seats, and futons colored pink, pastel green, and scarlet red.

Upon a futon at the center of the room lies **Shami-Amourae, the Lady of Delights**. Her beautiful face is painted white, and her lips are a deep, crimson red. Her eyes are jade-green, and her hair is pulled into a simple, yet neat bun atop her head, kept in place by a pair of ivory needles. She offers the creature her dark gift: the power of persuasion. To accept, the creature must accept a kiss from Shami-Amourae. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to cast the *suggestion* spell three times per day without components.

X33C. Ghastly Vault

North Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a decrepit stone hall cloaked in thick webbing. The webs are covered in small, silk-woven sacs that range in volume from the size of a fist to that of a humanoid's head; if broken, they release 3d4 **swarms of spiders** that escape into the surrounding webbing. The walls and floor are lined with ancient bones marked with the prints of many teeth, and rusted weapons and armor are trapped haphazardly among the webbing.

At the center of the hall looms **Drizlash, the Nine-Eyed Spider**, an enormous creature with the upper body of an ancient, wizened crone and the lower body of a bloated, spine-covered arachnid. Her pale face has eight visible eyes; when offering her gift, a ninth, blind eye opens atop her forehead. She offers the creature her dark gift: the power to walk on walls and ceilings. To accept, the creature must swallow a fist-sized egg sac teeming with infant spiders offered by one of Drizlash's eight legs. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to cast the *spider climb* spell three times per day without components.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a circular chamber whose walls, floor, and ceiling are forged entirely of concentric rings of human teeth. Nine alcoves line the walls, each containing the unconscious and floating body of an

unconscious **human, elf, half-elf, half-orc, dwarf, halfling, tiefling, dragonborn, or gnome.** The bodies cannot be woken. At the center of the chamber stands a stone dais upon which rests a tall stone basin. Within the basin swirls an ever-shifting liquid of wispy strands of grays, whites, and blues. Visions of dozens of shifting, ever-morphing faces are visible in the liquid's surface.

Behind the basin lurks **Dahlver-Nar, He of the Many Teeth.** Each limb or body part of this monstrous, ten-foot humanoid splits into a separate mouth - or, in some places, many separate mouths. Each mouth is filled entirely with molars, fangs, canines, or tusks, and they constantly drool a thick, viscous saliva onto the floor. Dahlver-Nar offers the creature his dark gift: the power to live many lives. To accept, the creature must bathe its head in the liquid within the basin. This dark gift allows the body to reincarnate upon death once per day, as if it was the target of a *reincarnate* spell. Any stages of corruption received from this or any other dark gift are preserved each time the creature reincarnates.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a kingly throne room carved of pure marble and decorated by ornate wall hangings and tapestries of gold and purple. A tall and proud throne sits upon a raised dais at the room's end, carved of gold and gilded with platinum. Upon the throne's seat, resting on a soft violet pillow, rests a golden crown inset with many beautiful and priceless gems.

Upon the steps of the dais sits **Zantras, the Kingmaker**, a slender and handsome young man. He wears fine robes of deep blues and blacks, and bears a simple dagger at his side. Zantras offers the creature his dark gift: the power of great presence and force of personality. To accept, the creature must allow Zantras to place the crown upon its head. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to reroll any Persuasion, Intimidation, or Deception check up to three times per day.

X33D. Breached Vault

West Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a vast, frozen wasteland. Strange, twisted monuments of ice arc unnaturally in leaping spirals and immense, impossible architectures. Shards of ice swirl on the wind, cutting into any exposed flesh. Several hundred yards away rests a near-bottomless pit, its sides covered in snow and frost, its base glowing a faint, weak orange-red several dozen miles below. A constant column of red-hot magma rises in great, shifting blobs from the base of the pit, swirling in a column of air into the skies above.

The column of magma rises far into the atmosphere. As it rises, the magma can be seen darkening, the heat vanishing as it turns black with cold. Above, the magma is devoured by a dark, gaping crater of **Delban, the Star of Ice and Hate**, an icy, planetary moon that hangs overhead. The crater is lined with enormous, miles-long spikes of ice that rim its edges like teeth. Delban offers the creature its dark gift: the power to unleash deadly cold. To accept, the creature must step into the column of magma and allow itself to be devoured by Delban's crater. This dark gift allows the beneficiary to cast *cone of cold* without components three times per day.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a stone platform floating in an endless black ocean. The water is rough, but yards-wide pockets of stillness occasionally bubble up from below, existing for mere seconds before the currents and waves swallow them up once more. The sky is filled with dark clouds, and the sun is eclipsed by a dark moon that devours the light around it.

Floating in the air before the platform, haloed by the eclipse above, is the avatar of **Khiraad, the Star of Secrets**, a tall, cowed figure wearing a long, rippling yellow cloak that conceals all features. Though the moon overhead is the true vestige, this figure projects its sonorous, yet whispered voice for the creature to hear. Khiraad offers the creature its dark gift: the power of divination. To accept, the creature must step off of the platform and dive into the ocean. This gift allows its beneficiary to cast the *scrying* spell three times per day without components as an action.

X33E. Vault of Harkotha

North Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a circular glass platform floating in an endless, starry void. At the center of the platform, upon a raised glass pillar, rests a spherical object covered in a simple red cloth.

The creature is soon met by **Yrrga, the Eye of Shadows**, a woman's silhouette formed by the stars and planets of the surrounding void, her eyes a pair of swirling spiral galaxies. She offers the creature her dark gift: the power of true seeing. To accept, the creature must remove the red cloth and gaze into the glass orb that lies beneath it. This dark gift grants its beneficiary the ability to cast the *true seeing* spell three times per day.

West Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a desolate wasteland of mountainous canyons, ridges, and chasms that bubble with streams and geysers of lava. A great river of lava cuts through the earth nearby, its surface churning with melting black stone and spouts of hot magma. The river flows into a large lake of lava, framed by a semicircle of five great mountains that tower above the rest.

Rising from the lake of lava is **Great Taar Haak, the Five-Headed Destroyer** - an immense, five-headed hydra of dark platinum scales, each maw wide enough to devour an entire village. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power of great physical strength. To accept, the creature must wade into the lake of lava and be baptised beneath the hydra's monstrous claw. This dark gift grants its beneficiary the ability to increase its Strength score to 26 as an action for one hour up to three times per day.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to the floor of a dark cavern whose arched ceiling rises hundreds of feet overhead. A stone ridge extends from the floor and extends in dozens of spirals around the edge of the chamber toward the ceiling. The ridges are dotted with enormous boulders, some of which rival entire houses in size, while the smashed remains of many stones of similar size lie pulverized on the ground.

The lowest floor of the cavern sinks to a circular, flat depression; at its center, formed by several converging cracks in the earth, rests a deep, dark hole filled with a thick, bubbling tar.

Perched atop the highest ridge overhead, and slowly descending toward the creature, is **Yog the Invincible**, a house-sized wolf whose black fur is like a shell of dark, steel quills. A thick, oozing tar constantly drips from Yog's coat, its yellow eyes gleaming in the darkness of the cave. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power of physical resilience. To accept, the creature must bathe itself in the pool of tar at the center of the cavern. This dark gift grants its beneficiary the ability to grant itself 30 temporary hit points three times per day.

X33F. Vault of Thangob.

West Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a decrepit chapel carved of black marble. Stone coffins carved with pentagrams fill the sanctuary in long, perfect rows, their covers removed to reveal the ancient undead that lie within. Atop a dais at the opposite end of the chapel lies an additional open stone coffin.

Clad in twisted darkness behind the elevated coffin is **Norganas, the Finger of Oblivion**, a writhing mass of shadows shaped like grasping hands and long, reaching tendrils. Just above the darkness' center floats an elaborate helm carved of bone, its visor revealing nothing but a pair of crimson red eyes. Norganas offers the creature its dark gift: the power to turn life into undeath. To accept, the creature must crawl into the coffin atop the dais and allow Norganas' many hands to pull the cover shut above it. This dark gift grants its beneficiary the power to cast the *finger of death* spell as an action once per day.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to an impenetrable void of perfect blackness. The floor is wet, as though covered by a thin layer of liquid water. In the distance, a standing silver mirror, taller than the creature, can be seen.

A creature that approaches the mirror, instead of their own reflection, can see a golden mask fashioned into a smiling human face hovering in the air where another creature's head might be. The rest of the mirror is filled with blackness. This mask hides the features of **Vaund the Evasive**. It offers the creature its dark gift: the power of evasion. To accept, the PC must step through the surface of the mirror. The beneficiary can use this dark gift up to three times per day to either cast the spell *nondetection* without components or to use their reaction to succeed on a failed Dexterity saving throw.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to an arid hellscape forged of black volcanic rock. A crimson sky of impossible heat blazes down from above, and the ground is split in many places by deep fissures and cracks that allow great gouts of lava to burst and ooze from beneath the surface. A pair of **hell hounds** linger beneath a twisted arch of black earth, smoke and embers steaming from their nostrils as magma drips from their maws like saliva.

Between and behind the hell hounds stands **Seriach, the Hell Hound Whisperer**, a figure clad entirely in black steel armor inlaid with crimson markings and sigils. The armor upon its shoulders are rimmed with spikes, and its helmet bears a pair of metal horns that thrust into the air a full foot above the helmet's top. In its hands, Seriach holds a pair of whips that crackle with swirling flames. He offers the creature the power to summon and control the beasts of the Nine Hells. To accept, the PC must allow itself to be devoured by the two hell hounds. The beneficiary can use this dark gift to summon and control two **hell hounds** for one hour once per day.

X38. Haunted Room

Should the PCs encounter the **poltergeist** that haunts this chamber, rather than forcing the players to roll initiative, treat the spirit as an active trap or hazard, allowing it to move and attack the PCs whenever you feel that six seconds (one round) have passed in-game.

X42. Amber Vault

West Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a dark field of dead grasses and twisted, dying trees. Littering the ground are thousands of pale, shriveled corpses, their bodies torn, pierced, and drained of all blood. Tens of thousands of enormous black bats, each one the size of a small dog, hang from the branches of the trees, their eyes fixated upon the creature.

Beneath an enormous black **guthias tree** that looms far above the rest crouches **Vampyr**, a monstrous humanoid with two long, bat-like wings that extend beyond its arms, a pair of bat-like ears, and a gaping maw of teeth that culminate in a pair of enormous fangs. It crouches upon the ground rather than standing, its flesh a pale, blue-tinged gray, and its mouth and face dripping with blood. Crimson stains mark the flesh of its chest, and its arms end in long, wicked claws from which blood oozes without end. Vampyr offers the creature its dark gift: the immortality of undeath, as described in the original module. To accept, the creature must allow itself to be exsanguinated by Vampyr and its thousands of bats, its flesh torn and mutilated by the vestige's great claws.

South Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to a dark tomb, the walls lined with twisted engravings of undeath and sacrilegious, profane arcane rites. A pair of pedestals carved from enormous, powder-white bones hold a pair of objects: one, an ancient grimoire bound in human skin; the other, a small metal box inscribed with hundreds of intertwining, concentric arcane symbols.

Between the pedestals stands **Tenebrous**, a towering undead figure whose flesh has decayed and shriveled, leaving its features sunken, twisted, and sagging. Six red circles have been carved into the flesh of its bare scalp, and its eyes glow a dim, distant crimson. On a loop of platinum chain links around its neck, it wears a simple amulet forged of platinum and bearing a purple gem at its center. Tenebrous offers the creature its dark gift: the secret of lichdom, as

described in the original module. To accept, the creature must open the grimoire upon the pedestal and read its contents.

East Sarcophagus. A creature that touches this sarcophagus is mentally transported to the crest of a tall, mountainous hill that overlooks a rugged and desolate landscape. Cold, raised lines of pale blue curl between each mountain, splitting and rejoining like veins. The sky overhead is an inky black, filled only with thirteen distant stars whose blue light flickers coldly across the void.

As the creature obtains its bearings, the hill splits apart at its peak, revealing its true nature: one of the many, miles-long eyes of **Zhudun, the Corpse Star** - an aberrant moon-sized planetary body covered in eyes. Dozens, then hundreds of mounds, mountains, and hills across the horizon, as far as the eye can see, do the same, revealing hundreds of purple-irised eyes, each one larger than a city. Zhudun offers the creature its dark gift: the power to raise the ancient dead, as described in the original module. To accept, the creature must allow itself to fall into the great dark hole of Zhudun's pupil.

Special Events

Neferon's Judgement

The first time that the PCs enter area X17 (Upper West Hall) or area X4 (Overlook), or approach the southern staircases in area X5 (Temple of Lost Secrets) after taking a treasure or magic item from within the Amber Temple, Neferon teleports to area X5a (God of Secrets), condemns the party for stealing, and attacks - with surprise, if the darkness around the god's statue remains in place. The three **flameskulls** in Area X17 (Upper West Hall) also immediately join his attack. The only item that the PCs can retrieve without incurring Neferon's wrath is the *wand of secrets* in area X2b (Guard Room), which Neferon does not consider to be a part of the Temple proper.

However, if the PCs have previously found, cured, and befriended Exethanter, Neferon instead appears before the PCs as a hovering cloud of darkness before delivering its condemnation. If Exethanter is not already with the party, he swiftly appears and commands Neferon to cease his foolish actions. With a snap of Exethanter's bony fingers, Neferon's darkness vanishes, revealing his demonic form to the party. Exethanter scorns Neferon for his opposition, scoffing, "You made your choice - as I made mine. Now begone, and trouble us no more." Neferon hisses at Exethanter in displeasure, vowing that Exethanter's protection will not shield the PCs forever, but soon teleports away to hide in area X5a (God of Secrets). Exethanter promises the PCs that Neferon's threats are hollow outside of the Temple, and offers to escort them outside. He refuses to elaborate on his words to Neferon, but will disclose that he and Neferon were once colleagues if asked

Chapter 14: The Ruins of Berez

□ Strands of Fate—Hooks to Berez

Treasures of the Tarokka: If Madam Eva's Tarokka reading suggested that one of the fated treasures lies within Berez, the PCs can find it beneath Marina's Monument or in Baba Lysaga's hut.

Davian's Quest. If the PCs have rescued the Wizard of Wines from the threat of the Forest Folk, Davian Martikov asks them to retrieve the second enchanted gemstone from Baba Lysaga's possession in Berez.

Ireena's Answers. If the PCs [brought Ireena to Sergei's spirit at the blessed pool in Krezk](#) and Ireena refused Sergei's offer of sanctuary, he tells her that she can find the answers she seeks at Marina's Monument in Berez.

The Swamp Fane. Following the PCs' visitation to the mountain village of Yaedrag, they can learn that the Swamp Fane, shrine to the Weaver, is located at the standing stones at Berez.

Introduction

In the original module, the Ruins of Berez are an infrequent, out-of-the-way destination for most *Curse of Strahd* parties, ranked above only the Werewolf Den for player interest. Unless the Tarokka reading places one or more items in this dreary swamp or the PCs forge a strong connection with the Keepers of the Feather at the Wizard of Wines, it is unlikely that a party will journey here in most campaigns. It's easy to see why—barring Baba Lysaga herself, there is little of note here.

Some guides have sought to expand Berez by creating a more expansive hexcrawl, adding additional random encounters or points of interest throughout the swamp. While these additions can make Berez feel bigger, they can run the risk of consuming the players' valuable OOC time while adding little of value beside additional complications and HP taxes.

I strongly recommend against the common practice of replacing Baba Lysaga's flying giant's skull with the skull of Argynvost, which removes the dragon's skull from Castle Ravenloft entirely. While this may serve as another hook to Berez, it does raise the question of why Vladimir Horngaard and/or his revenants have not previously attempted to recover the dragon's bones and how Baba Lysaga recovered the bones from Castle Ravenloft in the first place. Additionally, many DMs have found their plans upended when their players—entirely reasonably—have destroyed the dragon's skull to prevent Lysaga from flying in it.

More importantly, however, the heist of Argynvost's skull presents a prime opportunity to force your PCs to enter Castle Ravenloft before they are ready to face Strahd, allowing them to explore the layout of the castle's peaks and depths before the final battle. This heist also provides an excellent pre-finale climax (especially if paired with a rescue of Ireena and/or the recovery of a Tarokka artifact), and can make for a notable turning point in Strahd's relationship

with the players. See [Guide to Castle Ravenloft: The Heist](#) for more information on running this scenario.

In this guide, Berez exists as a culmination of several disparate plot hooks: the finale of Ireena's quest for safety and self-discovery; the reveal of Tatyana's nature and history; the exposition of the lost lore of the Ladies of the Fanes; the consecration of the Weaver's holy shrine (and the severance of Strahd's associated boon); the recovery of the second lost Martikov gemstone; and a fateful encounter with the woman who helped plant the seed of Strahd's evil.

Running Baba Lysaga

Baba Lysaga is the deepest enigma of the RAW module. Despite the presence of a full page devoted to her backstory and statblock, we know precious little about her personality. However, what we do know is informative.

First, Lysaga is a solitary, ancient hermit with an obsessive devotion to Strahd von Zarovich. She is exceptionally intelligent, easily matching Strahd in cunning and arcane lore and exceeding him in wisdom. While she is not especially charismatic, she does appear to have a forceful personality and the capacity to gain (or create) allies, as shown by her relationship to the coven in Castle Ravenloft. Her captivity of ravens suggests a sadistic streak—she could easily kill them and deprive the Keepers of valuable spies, but prefers to let them live, as their squawking is “music to her ears.” She is a fierce and amoral zealot, eager to destroy her enemies with cold, calculating efficiency.

As a follower of Mother Night, Lysaga is capable of ruses and deception, though her dismissal from Castle Ravenloft suggests that she is not overtly comfortable with them. Her affinity for illusory magic and divination suggests a cerebral approach to tactics and spellwork, rather than the blunt-force necromancy and evocation styles favored by Strahd himself (though she is certainly capable of brute arcane strength if needed). Finally, her refusal to march on the Wizard of Wines herself—instead dispatching her scarecrows and empowering the druids to fight for her—suggests a tactician's distance from conflict and an interest in self-preservation, rather than a brawler's love of the fight.

Accordingly, Lysaga prefers proxy fights to personal fights, solitude to company, and (unsurprisingly) vengeance to forgiveness—though mercy is always an option if it somehow advances her interests. If she engages in hostilities, she will have a reason to do so—whether it is pride, obsession, or power—and she is wise enough to keep herself out of danger when she does choose to fight. In combat, she prefers to delegate the “brute force” of fighting to her **creeping hut**, choosing instead to remain out-of-reach in her flying giant's skull while striking down any creature that dares venture close to the enchanted gem at the hut's heart.

A creature who is the first to strike Lysaga in an encounter temporarily breaks her composure and draws her ire, as the ancient witch sears in fury at any who would dare lay a finger upon the mother of royal blood. After casting *finger of death* at her assailant, however, Lysaga's sharp

mind soon overcomes her hot rage, and her better senses reassert themselves. A PC who belittles Strahd or his accomplishments soon stokes Lysaga's rage, though; the witch will not flee combat while such a character survives.

In combat, Lysaga prefers to use *cloudkill* to keep meddlesome PCs out of her hut (which is, luckily, immune to poison damage). If her hut is present, she prefers to wield *polymorph (worm)* or *Evard's black tentacles* to incapacitate her enemies and ease the hut's attacks; otherwise, she wields *blight*, *fireball*, and *lightning bolt* with devastating efficiency. In either case, she will gladly cast *dispel magic* to remove opposing magical effects, *misty step* to avoid danger, or *power word stun* to incapacitate any enemy that seems capable of destroying her flying skull. If possible, she will use her creeping hut as cover to shield her flying skull from enemy spells and attacks, and will direct her hut to prioritize spellcasters over melee fighters.

If her flying skull is destroyed, Lysaga polymorphs into a **swarm of insects (flies)**. If her hut is still animated, she attempts to take cover inside and continue her attack. If not, she flees to the skies, vanishing into the fog once she reaches a distance of 120 feet from the PCs.

If your PCs TPK to Lysaga, don't fret. Instead, assume that she has (or soon brews) a dose of *potion of cloven curse* (see below) for each of them. The PCs subsequently awaken as **goats** imprisoned in Lysaga's goat pen. If present, an imprisoned adventurer or Barovian (see "Goat Pen" below) can suggest that the cure to their affliction may be found in Lysaga's potions cabinet. (In this case, assume that there is a *null tincture* available for each cursed PC).

Approaching the Ruins

The original module notes that, whenever the PCs take a short or long rest in the marsh, they are troubled by several swarms of hungry flies (unless the PCs are in Lysaga's Hut or near Marina's Monument).

According to the 5e SRD, a short rest "is a period of downtime, at least 1 hour long, during which a character does nothing more strenuous than eating, drinking, reading, and tending to wounds." As such, **it is impossible to take a short rest in Berez outside of the two safe locations.**

A long rest, by contrast, is only interrupted by at least 1 hour of "a period of strenuous activity"; as such, a party can successfully take a long rest in greater Berez. The encounter with the 1d4 swarms of flies is, in this case, the cost of doing business.

Marsh Scarecrows

As-written, Berez contains seven **scarecrows** that attack if attacked, commanded, or summoned by Lysaga's howling skulls. However, the module gives little guidance on how to run them.

Though the scarecrows are scattered at varying distances throughout the marsh, it might feel a bit silly for them to trickle toward your players one-by-one if activated. As such, I'd recommend having all seven (or six, if triggered by the PCs attacking one of their own) lurch through the fog simultaneously in $1d4 + 1$ rounds.

The chapter's introduction specifies that Lysaga spends "most of her time crafting and animating scarecrows." Given that there are only seven scarecrows in Berez and that the average scarecrow random encounter included four scarecrows, we can estimate that there are anywhere from 12 to 32 scarecrows roaming around outside of Berez at any given time.

According to the text, Lysaga's primary goal in making scarecrows is to kill the ravens and wereravens of Barovia—enemies who she didn't learn of until recently. As such, while she has likely been making security scarecrows for decades, it's probable that she didn't ramp up production until recently. Lycanthropes can't be wounded by nonmagical weapon damage, but the paralysis from a scarecrow's **Terrifying Glare** ability *does* make it easier to kill them via falling damage or drowning.

With that said, why hasn't Barovia been overrun by scarecrows yet, given that Lysaga has few other hobbies? We must assume that building and enchanting a scarecrow takes time and resources—two limiting factors on Lysaga's production line. After all, if the winery is destroyed, Lysaga sends all seven of her existing security scarecrows to guard it, rather than sending new ones.

Let's estimate that it's been around a year since Lysaga learned of the wereravens. Let's also say that she's suffered around a 20% attrition rate (losing scarecrows to successful wereraven defenses, annoyed werewolves, random natural disasters, etc). If she's spent almost every day building a new scarecrow, we can calculate (based on the average estimate from above) that she's built around 22 scarecrows in the past twelve months. Assuming each month has approximately 30 days (according to the Barovian calendar in Chapter 2), that's around 16 days per scarecrow.

As a result? If your PCs kill several scarecrows and leave before killing Lysaga, you can make one of the following assumptions:

- 1d4 scarecrows return to Berez at dusk each day, until there are seven scarecrows once more
- Baba Lysaga's forces remain depleted, forcing her to spend 4d6 days crafting a replacement for each scarecrow destroyed

Choose the first option if you want the scarecrows to remain a threat in any combat with Lysaga; choose the latter if you want to let your players "lay siege" to Berez and slowly whittle down the crone's resources.

Recall also that, according to the *Monster Manual*, scarecrows are animated by bound evil spirits. Fortunately, there's one other creature in Barovia who has access to evil spirits: Morgantha (and her coven of night hags). Accordingly, it might be reasonable to assume that Morgantha routinely supplies Lysaga with the souls of evil Barovians in exchange for components, arcane lore, or simple information. (This might also provide Morgantha or any surviving night hags with a motivation to flee for Berez if the Bonegrinder is destroyed—they already have a working relationship with Lysaga herself).

Areas of Berez

Note that, according to the module (pg. 161), thick fog within the village blocks line-of-sight, preventing any creature from seeing further than 120 ft. away. Baba Lysaga is familiar with this feature, and will gladly abuse it to take down any intruders. See below for more information on her combat tactics.

U2. Ulrich Mansion

If Ireena is present when Lazlo appears to the PCs, he greets her as if she were Marina, apologizing profusely for his crimes against her and insisting that his actions were “necessary” to protect her from the Devil’s clutches.

If the PCs ask for the location of Marina’s Monument or (after learning of Marina’s sad tale) additional details of Marina’s fate, or if Lazlo has reason to believe that sharing the existence of the Monument will in some way improve his standing in the PCs’ eyes, he shares the following:

“Travel west. Two hundred paces from the mansion lies a monument to my folly—and a testament to Marina’s memory.”

Goat Pen

As-written, Baba Lysaga’s goat pen contains nine **goats** trapped behind its fence. However, if you would like to incorporate a missing character (e.g., from a PC’s backstory) or introduce a new PC, you can introduce that character as a true polymorphed tenth **goat** trapped in Lysaga’s goat pen. Baba Lysaga caught this character intruding upon her goat pen or hut several days or weeks ago and transformed them into a goat using a *potion of cloven curse*. She intends to use this goat in her blood ritual under the light of the next new moon.

As the PCs approach the pen, they can hear the sound of repeated collisions and cracking wood. When the pen comes into view, they can see this polymorphed character repeatedly ramming the side of the fence with its horns. Unlike its fellow goats, this goat bears odd or additional markers or coloration fitting its true appearance. (For example, a red tiefling could become a red-furred goat with devil-like eyes).

Upon encountering the PCs, the goat acts in any way possible to communicate its past identity and goal of escape to the party. While the goat has the intelligence of an ordinary goat, the PCs

should be able to tell that its behavior is far more purposeful and eccentric than its fellows. The goat doesn't know how to undo its condition, but does think that Baba Lysaga's potions cabinet might hold the secret to reversing her spell. PCs who are *polymorphed* into goats or otherwise able to speak with animals can converse with the polymorphed adventurer normally.

Combat with Baba Lysaga

If the PCs trigger an encounter with Baba Lysaga by triggering the skulls, she arrives on her flying skull on initiative count 20 in two rounds. Her **scarecrows** arrive soon after, with two arriving every other round until all seven have arrived.

On her first turn of combat, Lysaga emerges from Berez's fog and commands the PCs to depart from Berez at once, or be lost in its swamps forevermore. (PCs with sharp passive Perception may notice the silhouettes of distant **scarecrows** shambling closer through the fog). If questioned, she introduces herself as "the Witch-Mother, the begetter of power," but makes no allowances to further justify her demands; if challenged, she opens hostilities and strikes the most defiant PC with *blight*.

If the PCs seem happy to flee, Lysaga follows by casting *cloudkill* (taking care not to kill any of her goats as the poison gas flows across the earth) to ensure that they don't have any second thoughts.

If, however, the PCs still appear ready to do battle and Baba Lysaga is not confident in her victory (e.g., if the PCs are at least 7th level, the *blighted* PC was not bloodied from her spell, or otherwise), she cackles and informs the PCs that "they were warned." She then vanishes into the mist above in her flying skull. If any creature attempts to follow her through the air, such as by a *fly* spell, she has no compunctions about causing her pursuer to fall to the ground by casting *power word stun* once that creature is sufficiently far above the ground. As a mad witch, Baba Lysaga cares far more for style than efficiency.

Baba Lysaga then returns to **Baba Lysaga's creeping hut** and activates it, returning to the PCs' last known location in an attempt to hunt them down.

U3. Baba Lysaga's Hut

Hut Interior

The wicker cabinet containing Baba Lysaga's wicker cabinet contains one *potion of cloven curse* and two *null tinctures*. A creature that drinks a *potion of cloven curse* must succeed on a DC 17 Charisma saving throw or be turned into a **goat**. Shapechangers are immune to this effect. The potion can be reversed only by a creature casting *dispel magic* at 6th level (or by casting *dispel magic* and beating a DC of 16), casting *remove curse*, or by feeding the victim a *null tincture*. A *null tincture*, if imbibed, ends all spells and magical effects of 3rd level or lower currently affecting its drinker.

If Baba Lysaga has taken one or more wereravens prisoner (see *The Wizard of Wines* guide for more information), they have been held captive in a rusted iron cage sitting on her desk. The cage is held shut by one of Lysaga's *arcane lock* spells and opening it requires a *knock* spell, a successful DC 20 Strength check, or a successful DC 20 Dexterity check using thieves' tools.

The wooden chest in Lysaga's hut contains, in addition to its other contents, the *spindle of the Weaver*, which Lysaga uses as a focus when casting rituals, animating scarecrows, or creating potions. This ancient, stone-carved weaving spindle is wrought with intricate spirals and inset at its top with a carving of a three-petalled flower with two seed clusters sprouting from its stem. A DC 14 Nature (Intelligence) check reveals this to be the flower of the sanzienne plant (a native Barovian makes the check with advantage). See Area U6 for more information about the *spindle of the Weaver*.

Encounters with Lysaga

If she has not been drawn forth by activity elsewhere, the PCs can find Baba Lysaga here. As-written, she cannot hear anyone approaching due to the squawks of her imprisoned **swarms of ravens**. Her hut has no windows, but because her hut's entrance has no front door, a PC whose Stealth roll exceeds her passive Perception (13) can peer through the empty doorway to spy on the crone's activities without detection.

Your PCs may also attempt to ambush Lysaga or attack with surprise. One of the most common issues that DMs face when running Baba Lysaga in combat, however, is her "glass cannon" nature. Specifically, she can deal immense damage to the PCs—but if she is surprised or cornered by high-level characters, she can easily be demolished in a round or two. Still, there are a few things to remember when running such an encounter to avoid an unsatisfying and undignified end.

First, if your PCs attempt to surprise Lysaga, you must first determine if she is actually surprised. If three PCs snuck up to Lysaga's hut and two of the three PCs succeeded on a DC 14 Stealth roll (see above), the three PCs succeeded on a group stealth check and may attack Lysaga with surprise.

Second, there are no "surprise rounds" in 5th edition. Instead, "surprised" is a condition like "prone" or "frightened." "Surprised" simply means that the creature cannot move or take actions on its first turn and cannot take a reaction until that turn ends. As such, once Baba Lysaga's first turn has ended, she loses the "surprised" condition and can telepathically command her **creeping hut** to attack the PCs and/or protect her. The hut will then roll initiative and join the battle on the second round of combat.

Once it does so, it can use its **roots** to KO any creature threatening Lysaga from within it; alternatively, it can attempt to grapple and remove a single creature within it. In both cases, the hut will likely also use its 30-foot move speed to move away from any other combatants and face its open doorway away from any ranged attackers, assuming Lysaga knows that other

attackers are present). Remember that as long as Lysaga is inside of the hut, she functionally has full cover from any creature that cannot see through the open doorway.

When encountered in her hut, Lysaga is likely to be:

- stuffing and weaving a new (inanimate) scarecrow,
- repairing a damaged (animate) scarecrow with needle and thread,
- sorting through the spell components in her wicker cabinet,
- restraining a sacrificial goat,
- cooing over the illusory infant Strahd,
- using her swamp water-filled tub to scry on (and receive a regular, pre-scheduled one-way report regarding goings-ons at the castle from) a **Barovian witch** in Castle Ravenloft, or
- taunting the ravens imprisoned in the cage on her desk (if she has wereraven prisoners).

If the PCs approach Lysaga openly and politely, Lysaga is likely to insist that they leave her swamp, though she may be willing to briefly humor PCs who flatter her ego (though she has no intention of dealing fairly and honestly with anyone who trespasses into her swamp). If the PCs overstay their welcome, Lysaga uses her action to polymorph into a **swarm of insects (flies)**, reappearing in her giant's skull. She then telepathically commands her **creeping hut** to animate and attack any PCs remaining inside, while casting *cloudkill* (which her hut is immune to) to force the PCs to evacuate.

However, if the PCs' appearance suggests a threat to Strahd (e.g., one or more of them are wearing plate armor, Strahd's animated armor, a visible holy symbol, or either the Sunsword or Holy Symbol of Ravenkind), she greets them kindly and briefly attempts to uncover their business and/or loyalties. If she comes to believe that the PCs pose a threat to Strahd (her "darling boy"), she attempts to lure them out of the hut before entering her giant's skull, casting *Evard's black tentacles* to restrain the group, and commanding her hut to attack any restrained PCs.

If the PCs attack Lysaga openly, she immediately wills her hut to animate, at which point it attacks all other creatures inside using its **root** multiattack. She then casts *misty step* to escape into her giant's skull and casts *cloudkill* centered within the hut.

If Lysaga catches a lone PC snooping in her hut, she uses her **summon swarms of insects** action to fill the door with thick swarms of large, black flies. She then interrogates the PC, aiming to find who and what they are. She may cast *sleep* to incapacitate that PC, followed by giving them a dose of her *potion of cloven curse*, turning them into a **goat** (which she swiftly deposits into her pen with the others).

Diplomacy with Baba Lysaga is likely doomed to failure. Aside from the extinction of the Keepers of the Feather, there are few things that she truly desires, and she is more likely to

destroy potential “rivals” to Strahd’s power than to entertain an alliance with powerful adventurers.

U4. Churchyard

If you have placed an imprisoned adventurer in the Goat Pen (see above), this abandoned church and/or the cemetery behind it are a perfect place to leave their forgotten belongings. Perhaps the prisoner and their friends (if any) made a last stand here amidst the ruined church, and Lysaga missed one or more of their belongings in collecting their unconscious bodies.

If the PCs have not previously encountered Lysaga, her hut, or her skull, you can show them an eerie sight when they emerge from the church after exploring it: a large, hovering silhouette that ghosts silently through the mist from the opposite side of the ruined mansion and vanishing into the eastern fog. (This is Baba Lysaga returning to her hut atop her flying skull after checking in on or retrieving one of her goats.)

U5. Marina’s Monument

If Ireena lays her hand upon Marina’s epitaph after receiving Sergei’s instructions, her past five lives manifest before her:

There’s a moment of silence, the croaking of frogs and distant buzzing of flies vanishing into a whisper. For a heartbeat, you are alone in the swamp, the fog swirling lazily about you, as the brackish muck glistens in the grey light. Ireena, kneeling beneath the monument, looks almost like a pilgrim offering a gesture of supplication.

And then, the swamp is gone.

The PCs and any other allied creatures present are magically transported to a demiplane within Ireena’s soul. Here, the PCs encounter each of Ireena’s past lives in reverse order, and must save them from their ultimate fate. (You can find a battlemat of this sequence [here](#)).

U5a. Marina’s Cottage

You find yourselves in a small one-room cottage, its single cramped chamber lit by the flickering lights of several candles. A pair of old, dusty windows look out over a dark, mist-shrouded village, and a lonely wooden bookshelf groans beneath the weight of the many books upon its shelves.

You hear a startled gasp from a well-lit corner. There, sitting upon a hay-stuffed mattress, wearing a simple, worn dressing gown, peering at you from behind a pair of cracked eyeglasses, sits a woman with a striking resemblance to Ireena Kolyana.

The woman is Marina (NG female human **commoner**), Ireena’s fifth and most recent life. She is reading a book by candlelight when the PCs arrive (a work of fiction about adventures in far-off lands), but quickly sets it aside when they appear.

She is surprised and somewhat startled by the PCs' appearance, but treats them as old friends, welcoming them to her small home. If asked about her familiarity, she looks momentarily confused, but insists that she feels like she's known them for a long time. She has no knowledge of the name "Ireena" or the PCs' mission against Strahd.

After introductions, Marina asks the PCs if they can stay the night and guard her door against a former friend who has taken to visiting her in the night—a man named Vasili von Holtz. She shares that she has become uncomfortable with Vasili's overtures, but (for reasons she's unsure of) feels that she would be unable to turn him away without the PCs' help. If the PCs agree, she thanks them and turns into bed.

Marina's cottage stands alone on the western edge of Berez's northern perimeter, quite close to the village church. The village is quiet this night, but some time after Marina falls asleep, a PC with passive Perception 10 or more can see a silhouette moving around the outside of the house (Burgomaster Lazlo Ulrich, LN male **commoner**), followed shortly by a second (Brother Grigori, LN male **acolyte**). If the PCs do not intervene, Lazlo fiddles at the door (unlocking it with his key), then pauses. With a successful DC 14 passive Perception check, a PC can overhear Brother Grigori reassure him in low tones: "It must be done to save the girl's soul—it is too late to save her life."

When the door is opened, the PCs see two dark silhouettes: Lazlo and Grigori, both carrying long, sharpened wooden stakes.

Lazlo and Grigori ignore the PCs unless attacked or obstructed, seemingly ignorant to the characters' presence until they make themselves known. If the PCs do not intervene, they make their way to Marina's bed and plunge wooden stakes through her heart as she sleeps.

The PCs can awaken Marina, block or confront Lazlo's efforts, conceal Marina from sight, or take any other action likely to protect her. If confronted, Lazlo and Brother Grigori attempt to justify their actions, claiming that their efforts are necessary to protect Marina's soul from Strahd's corruption. If the PCs successfully defend Marina from attack, she awakens (if still asleep), expresses quiet horror at Lazlo's scheme, and thanks the PCs.

Whether the PCs protect Marina or allow her to die, the environment of Marina's cottage then fades as the PCs are transported to Area U5b.

U5b. The In-Between

The PCs find themselves standing in a blank white space (the "In-Between") surrounded by five tall windows. This space is an environment created by and within Ireena's soul; through it, the PCs can encounter and "save" each of Ireena's past lives in turn, allowing her to connect with their memories and experiences. Each time the PCs return to this space, they gain the benefits of a short rest.

The first time the PCs enter the In-Between, and each time thereafter, they are joined by Ireena Kolyana. If the PCs successfully protected Marina, Ireena now possesses some of Marina's memories, and is astounded and somewhat overcome by the experience of recalling memories from a life she never lived. She can recall Vasili's face and mannerisms, and quickly realizes that Strahd and Vasili are associates or (more likely) the same person. She is venomous toward Strahd for his pursuit of Marina, and determined never to allow her life to be the plaything of powerful men again. She believes that Marina deserved better than to have her story come to an end as a result of Strahd's predations.

The five windows are made of stained-glass. When the PCs first encounter them, the first four are rendered in muted grey tones, with each figure rendered in silhouette. Ireena believes that each of the windows depicts one of her past lives, and is determined to know more. If the PCs pass a window's trial (i.e., by rescuing that window's past life), the figure is rendered in full color and detail. The fifth window ("The Noble") is blank until the PCs pass the trials of the other four windows. The windows are as follows:

- **The Scholar.** If Ireena touches this window, the PCs are transported to Area U5a unless they have already passed its trial. Once the PCs do so, the window is fully illuminated, depicting a woman resembling Ireena Kolyana wearing threadbare peasant's clothes, a patched traveller's cloak, and cracked reading glasses. She carries a book under one arm. This is **Marina**.
- **The Warrior.** If Ireena touches this window, the PCs are transported to Area U5c unless they have already passed its trial. Once the PCs do so, the window is fully illuminated, depicting a woman resembling Ireena Kolyana wearing leather armor, a shield, a spear, and a longbow. This is **Sorina**.
- **The Mage.** If Ireena touches this window, the PCs are transported to Area U5d unless they have already passed its trial. Once the PCs do so, the window is fully illuminated, depicting a woman wearing a beautiful maroon dress and a noble's garb. She holds a spellbook open in one palm and carries a pale-wood wand in the other. This is **Victoria**.
- **The Acolyte.** If Ireena touches this window, the PCs are transported to Area U5e unless they have already passed its trial. Once the PCs do so, the window is fully illuminated, depicting a woman resembling Ireena Kolyana wearing coarse brown priest's robes and bearing a wooden symbol of the Morninglord on a leather cord around her neck. This is **Isabella**.
- **The Noble.** If Ireena touches this window after the PCs have passed the other four trials, the PCs are transported to Area U5f. A PC who touches this window transports the party to Area U5a unless Marina has already been rescued. Once the PCs do so, the window is fully illuminated, depicting a woman resembling Ireena Kolyana wearing a torn and bloodied wedding dress. This is **Tatyana**.

U5c. Wolfrun

A light dusting of snow crunches beneath your feet, the tall pines and rotting trees around you casting long, dark shadows across the loamy earth of the Svalich Wood. You hear a familiar voice calling from the woods

and the sound of boots stepping through the icy mulch.

The voice belongs to **Sorina** (NG female human **scout**), Ireena's fourth life. She wears hide armor warmed with furs and bears a spear, with a bow and quiver slung across her back.

Like Marina, Sorina neither knows the PCs personally nor recalls her existence as Ireena. She does, however, greet the PCs as friendly strangers, introducing herself as a guardswoman and scout from Krezk. Sorina is in the Svalich Woods north of Krezk to search for a young girl named Vasha, Sorina's adoptive sister, who vanished on the mountain ridge adjacent to the Svalich Wood. (Sorina's life pre-dates the arrival of the Abbot, and searches have turned up no sign of Vasha in the Abbey or elsewhere in Krezk).

Sorina asks the PCs for help in finding her missing sister. If the PCs assist her, a PC can make a DC 14 Survival check with advantage. On a success, the PCs locate the girl's scarf hooked around a dead log in the woods; on a failure, the PCs find nothing.

In either case, several minutes after beginning their search, the PCs and Sorina are confronted by Gorek (CE male human **werewolf**), alongside six **wolves** and two **dire wolves**. Gorek, among Strahd's other minions, was instructed by his "master" (Strahd) to escort Sorina to Castle Ravenloft, and is pleased that his lucky find of Vasha on the slopes of Mount Baratok has successfully drawn Sorina out past Krezk's walls. Gorek has already handed Vasha off to the other members of the pack, and commands Sorina to accompany him.

If Sorina or the PCs refuse, Gorek sends his companions to knock her unconscious. If the wolves fail, Gorek attacks in hybrid form with clear bloodlust in his eyes, adding, "The Master wanted you brought to Ravenloft—but I'm sure he wouldn't mind if there were a few pieces missing, would he?"

Whether the PCs protect Sorina or allow her to die, the environment of Marina's cottage then fades as the PCs are transported to Area U5b. If the PCs were successful, Sorina first retrieves Vasha's scarf and holds it close before thanking the PCs, a resolute steel to her voice.

U5d. Slopes of Mount Ghakis

The howling wind muffles all sound, and the biting cold leaves your skin numb. A frozen wasteland of eerie white surrounds you, a craggy mountain peak rising far above the snowy ridge on which you stand. Overhead, the pale moon looms above a dark night sky. Several yards away, huddled beside a cliff and wearing a soaked and half-frozen cloak, is a female figure holding a pale-wood wand in one hand and a soaked book in the other. She bites out several syllables through chattering teeth, and a small wisp of flame curls from the tip of the wand before dissipating in the arctic air.

The figure is **Victoria Voltanescu** (NG female **mage**), Ireena's third life and a former noblewoman of Vallaki. The book is a spellbook containing her prepared spells strapped to the

inside of her cloak, and the wand (carved of pine wood) is her arcane focus. She has 1 hitpoint remaining and three levels of exhaustion.

Victoria is a well-read mage and the third daughter of a minor Vallakian noble family. Distressed by Strahd's visitations, she turned to magic for a means of escape and protection. After fleeing Vallaki, she found herself turned away from Krezk and found no protection in Berez (a small, defenseless village that could barely muster enough force to defend itself). Fearing an inability to hide from the vampire beneath the castle's shadow in Barovia Village, Victoria fled to Mount Ghakis in an attempt to last-ditch, desperate attempt to evade him.

Victoria is grateful for any aid the PCs may provide, but is at risk of death from exposure without aid. The PCs can help her survive the night by locating shelter (e.g., finding a nearby crag or cave with a successful DC 13 Survival check after one hour of searching, or within thirty minutes of searching with a successful DC 17 Survival check), providing healing and/or warm, dry clothes, and providing a warm heat source until morning. Both Victoria and any PC without cold weather clothing or access to a sufficient heat source suffer the effects of extreme cold (see the *Dungeon Master's Guide*).

If Victoria survives until morning, she thanks them and bids them well in their travels. Whether Victoria lives or dies, the PCs are returned to Area U5b.

U5e. The Burning Church

A slouching church steeple, just beginning to fall to the ravages of age, burns with a torrent of crimson flames. A splintering support beam sends sparking embers leaping into the black, smoke-filled sky as rain pours from storm clouds overhead, thunder rumbling and lightning crackling in the distance. A man wearing a brown monk's robe watches the sight with silent horror and haunted eyes; beside him a pale, gaunt woman with dark hair catches your gaze. "My daughter!" she sobs—"Please, she's inside!"

The man is Father Marek (neutral good male human **priest**). The woman is Lavinia Swilova (lawful good female human **commoner**) and the mother of Isabella (neutral good female human **acolyte**), Ireena's second life and an acolyte to the Morninglord. Any PC who has previously visited the village of Barovia recognizes the church as a younger version of Father Donavich's dwelling.

The PCs can learn that the church was set aflame when a bolt of lightning struck the steeple, the fire spreading unnaturally fast despite the rain.

To rescue Isabella, the PCs must succeed on the following three-round skill challenge. The general rules for skill challenges can be found [here](#). To complete a given round, the PCs must make two DC 10 skill checks in attempt to overcome the obstacles therein. Each time a PC fails a skill check, that PC and Isabella take 1d4 fire damage plus 1d4 poison damage from the smoke, representing the time that the PCs have lost by their failure. (Unlike an ordinary NPC, Isabella falls unconscious when she reaches zero hit points, and proceeds to make death saving throws as a PC would).

- **Round One—The Burning Doors.** The PCs must make their way through or circumvent the burning doors of Barovia’s church. Potential skills include Athletics, Acrobatics, Perception (to find places where the burning walls have left openings to dash through), Investigation (to follow and predict the fire’s movement), or spells to move, bypass, or extinguish the doors.
- **Round Two—The Smoky Room.** The PCs must rescue Isabella (who resembles Ireena Kolyana, save for the soot-stained white acolyte’s robe and the wooden symbol of the Morninglord she wears) from the bedroom in which she is trapped. If conscious, Isabella is kneeling in her room and praying while quietly crying. The flames have blocked access to her room, and the interior of the church is filled with toxic black smoke. Potential skills include Athletics, Perception (to find openings in the flames), or spells to extract Isabella or extinguish the flames.
- **Round Three—The Crashing Roof.** The PCs must escape with Isabella before the burning roof, weakened by the flames, comes crashing down on their heads. Potential skills include Athletics, Acrobatics, or spells to expedite the PCs’ escape.

If rescued from the church, Isabella thanks the PCs before sharing, somewhat deliriously, that she had only prayed for an escape—a way to keep “Him” from finding her. Whether Isabella lives or dies, the PCs are returned to Area U5b.

U5f. The Bloody Wedding

(Note: If using the **Interactive Tome of Strahd** by /u/Aciduous, please note that this sequence conflicts with the portrayal of events in that resource. Some adjustment may be required.)

You find yourselves atop a stone-paved overlook, with a low stone wall adorned with outward-facing gargoyle carvings. A flash of lightning illuminates a quiet village lying far below. Overhead, dark clouds rain from a black sky, the silhouette of Castle Ravenloft towering ominously above you. A woman in a torn and red-stained bridal gown stands backed up against the edge of the overlook, mere inches away from a thousand-foot fall into the swirling mists beneath. She clutches a crystalline sword with a platinum handle, and her features are the spitting image of Ireena Kolyana.

Corpses of men and women in livery lie across a flagstone avenue that connects the overlook to the castle, discarded swords and spears lying beside them in pools of crimson blood. At the center of the avenue stands a tall, gaunt man wearing a noble’s finery that has been torn and ripped by dozens of arrows that still protrude from his flesh. His gaze snaps to the woman’s, his crimson eyes gleaming in the darkness. He hisses: “Tatyana—please. I did this for you. All of this, for you. My brother is dead, and you are mine. With the pact I have made, power and eternal life are within my grasp. You can deny my love no longer.”

The woman takes a half-step back, glancing uncertainly over the ledge. Her hands tremble around the hilt of the sword, and you see a flash of fear and hesitation in her eyes.

The woman is, of course, Tatyana (NG female human **noble**); the man is Strahd von Zarovich (retaining his modern statblock, but without lair actions or the Spellcasting feature). The blade Tatyana holds is Sergei’s enchanted crystal blade and the progenitor of the *Sunsword*. With its

pieces joined together, it has none of the properties of a *sun blade*; instead, it has the properties of a *sentient crystal blade (longsword)* (see *Fizban's Treasury of Dragons*, pg. 22) or a +3 *sentient longsword of striking* (see *staff of striking*, DMG pg. 203).

Strahd ignores the PCs entirely. If the PCs do nothing, Tatyana drops the sword, insists that she will never love Strahd, and leaps to her death from the overlook.

If the PCs intervene, Strahd informs them that nothing will stop him from claiming his love, and attacks. Tatyana's resolve is strengthened by the PCs' support, and she joins the fight alongside the PCs.

If Strahd is slain, Tatyana thanks them. If the PCs are slain by Strahd, the final thing the PCs see is a figure holding up the crystal sword—now blazing with sunlight—to defend them before all goes dark. In either case, the PCs—and Tatyana—rejoin Ireena in Area U5b. The PCs can only fail this trial if they refuse to fight on Tatyana's behalf.

There, Tatyana greets the PCs kindly and thanks the party for fighting for her and her other incarnations. She warns them that Strahd will be no easy foe, having grown only stronger and more wicked over the centuries. She tells Ireena that she has a chance that none of her past lives had: an opportunity to make a stand and take the fight to Strahd alongside her friends—but warns her that doing so has dangers, including an eternity of undeath.

Tatyana then asks Ireena if she truly desires to fight Strahd, despite the risks and his power. Ireena accepts, and insists that she's tired of running. Tatyana thanks the PCs once more, and informs Ireena that wherever she goes, she will carry all of her past lives' experiences with her. "We will all be fighting alongside you," Tatyana shares, before vanishing.

The PCs reawaken at Marina's Monument in Berez. Ireena awakens beside five items: a bow, a longsword, a book, a wooden wand, and a vial of holy water. She also gains the **Ireena, Reborn** statblock.

IREENA, REBORN

Medium humanoid (human), neutral good

Armor Class 16 (breastplate)

Hit Points 52 (8d8 + 16)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)

Skills Arcana +4, Deception +5, History +6, Insight +4, Medicine +4, Perception +4, Persuasion +5, Religion +4

Senses passive Perception 14

Languages Common

Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)

Divine Eminence. As a bonus action, Ireena can expend a spell slot to cause her melee weapon attacks to magically deal an extra 10 (3d6) radiant damage to a target on a hit. This benefit lasts until the end of the turn. If Ireena expends a spell slot of 2nd level or higher, the extra damage increases by 1d6 for each level above 1st.

Spellcasting. Ireena is a 5th-level spellcaster. Her spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks). Ireena has the following sorcerer spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): dancing lights, mending, fire bolt
1st level (4 slots): guiding bolt, cure wounds, protection from evil and good
2nd level (3 slots): misty step, scorching ray, lesser restoration
3rd level (2 slots): spirit guardians, mass healing word

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Ireena makes two attacks with her **Longsword**.

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack.* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit.* 7 (1d8 + 2) slashing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 2) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Longbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack.* +5 to hit, reach 150/600 ft., one target. *Hit.* 1d8 + 3 piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Parry. Ireena adds 2 to her AC against one melee attack that would hit her. To do so, she must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

When this occurs, thirteen **zombies**, attracted by the spiritual energy, rise from the mire around the monument and attack all living creatures nearby. When killed, a zombie's corpse splits open, disgorging a hostile **swarm of poisonous snakes**. See [here](#) for a battlemat of Marina's Monument.

U6. The Swamp Fane

The Swamp Fane is an area of tiled stone that lies within the circle of standing stones at Berez (area U6). It is devoted to the Weaver, one of the Ladies Three, but has become corrupted by Strahd von Zarovich. Today, it forms one of the three anchors tying him to the land of Barovia and protecting him from harm.

Long ago, Strahd desecrated the Swamp Fane, perverting its power for his own ends through the use of blood magic and fell rituals carried out beneath the light of the new moon. In doing so, he channelled its energy to provide himself with resistance to fire, cold, lightning, thunder, and acid damage. So long as he remains bound to the Swamp Fane, Strahd cannot be truly slain; instead, he revives by the will of the Dark Powers in his coffin at Castle Ravenloft 24d6 days after his destruction.

To break this connection and deprive Strahd of the Fane's boon, the PCs must carry out a ritual once performed by the worshippers and priests of the Weaver. They can learn of this ritual from Elder Ormir, a Mountain Folk priest residing at [Yaedrag in Tsolenka Pass](#). To complete this ritual, the PCs must first obtain the [spindle of the Weaver](#) from Baba Lysaga, who has

commandeered it as an arcane focus; and the *shuttle of the weaver* from the Weaver's reliquary, which is buried at the center of the circle.

Areas of the Swamp Fane

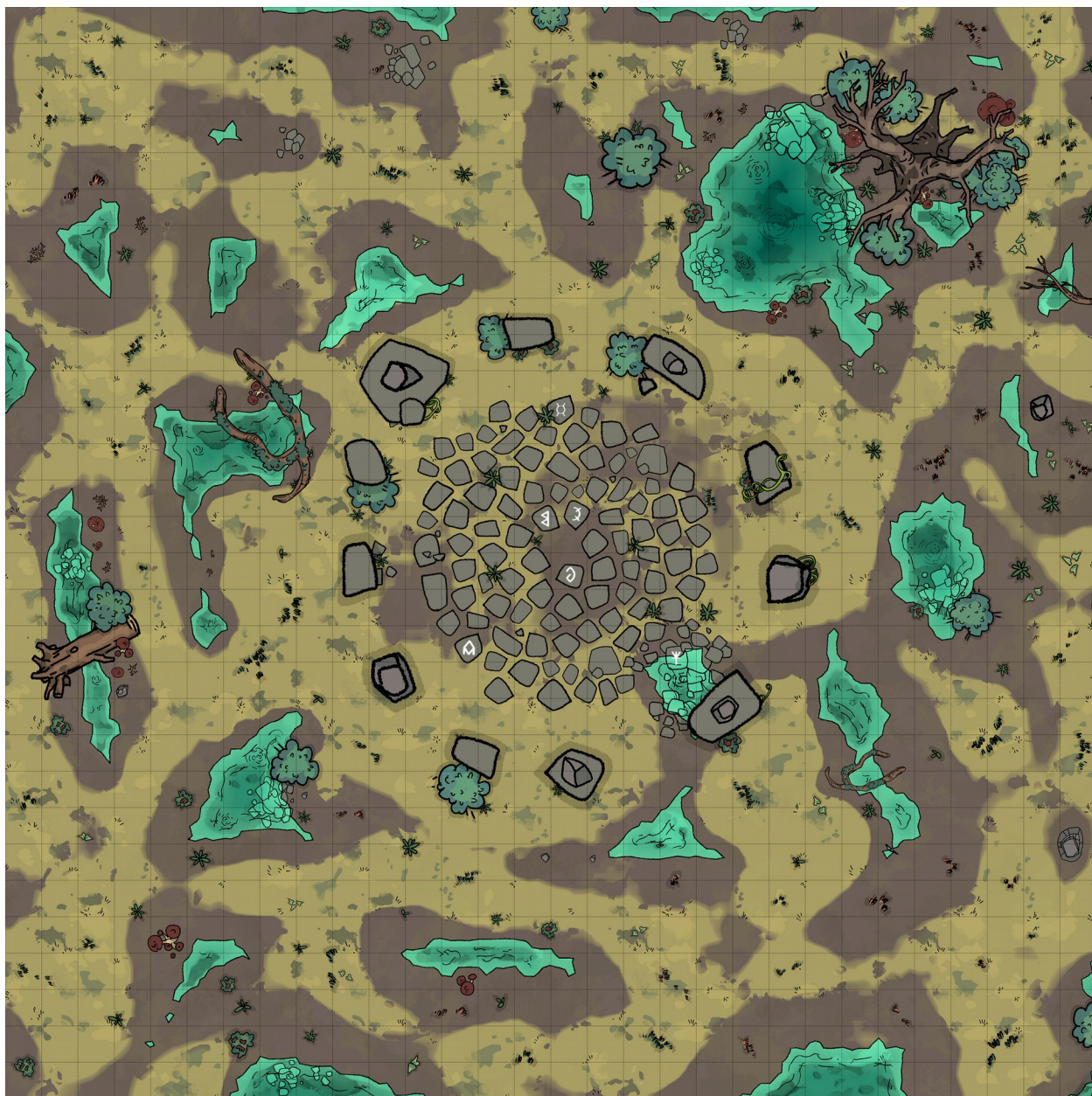
A dozen moss-covered menhirs form a near-perfect circle in the spongy earth. These weathered stones range in height from 15 to 18 feet, and the northernmost stone appears to bear ancient carvings. The ground within the menhirs is filled with a similar circle of flat, unmarked stones, tiled across the soil like a featureless gray mosaic. A three-foot-wide patch of earth lies at the center of the circle of tiles. Clusters of frond-bearing flowers with triads of angular white petals sprout from around each menhir's base.

The flowers are *sanziene plants*. The PCs can mash or grind them (e.g., using an herbalist's kit, an alchemist's kit, or simply the flat end of a dagger) into a paste, which can then be applied around one's eyes to reveal hidden features of the area. (See areas U6b and U6c below). One flower provides sufficient paste for a single creature's use.

If the PCs have not previously encountered Muriel Vinshaw elsewhere, they can find her here, as described in the book. You can find more information about Muriel in [the guide to the Village of Barovia](#). If Muriel is present, add:

A wary-looking peasant woman lurks behind the tallest stone, a streak of blue bangs falling across the right side of her face. She clutches a rusty lantern in one hand and a dagger in the other.

A creature that steps onto the soil within the menhirs feels an uncomfortable prickling on the back of their neck. The space within the circle of standing stones is **desecrated ground**, providing all undead standing within it advantage on their saving throws.



A battle map of the Swamp Fane, including the six rune-marked stones (see below). Click [here](#) to download. You can find an alternative battle map by /u/SnooTangerines5710 [here](#), and an alternative battlemat by @AonbarrCartog [here](#).

U6a. Reliquary

Buried two feet beneath the patch of earth at the center of the circle is the Weaver's reliquary: an ancient stone box fitted with a weighty stone lid that seals it shut. The lid is carved with the sigil of the Weaver: a spider. The reliquary contains the stone [shuttle](#) of the Weaver. If the shuttle or reliquary are removed from the circle, both items vanish and reappear in their original position beneath the earth.

U6b. Carving of the Weaver

A creature who inspects the northernmost menhir finds the following image carved into its stone surface:

Carved into the stone surface of this moss-covered menhir is the graven image of a cross-legged woman with six arms, three on either side. Six ancient runes are carved into the stone above her head, each rune forming a vertex of a three-pointed star.

On the left side, the woman's lowest arm holds a carving of a mortar holding a flower with three triangular petals and a pair of leafy fronds on either side. The middle arm holds a pestle, appearing to mash the mortar's contents. The fingers of the upper arm are pressed against the woman's face, just beneath her eyes.

On the right side, the woman's lowest arm clasps a thread between two fingers, a spider hanging from the end. The middle arm holds a weaver's spindle, wound with thread. A carved line of thread connects the spindle to a weaver's shuttle, which the woman holds aloft with her upper arm, nearly touching one of the runes overhead. The carved line of thread continues from the shuttle to the end of the nearest rune.

The flower depicted perfectly resembles the tri-petaled flowers (the *sanziene plant*) within and around the Fane.

U6c. Stone Tiles

If a character who has not previously received the boons of the Forest or Mountain Fane holds both the *spindle of the Weaver* and the *shuttle of the Weaver* while standing in the circle of menhirs, read:

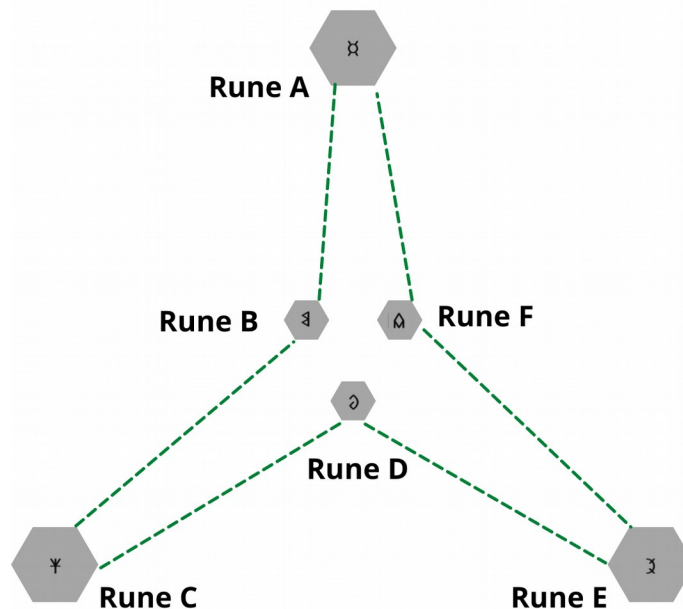
The stone spindle begins to glow with a faint ethereal light, glimmers of fae radiance beginning to gather about it. Wisps of misty light are pulled from each glimmer, collecting around the spindle's central spike until it glows with strands of luminescent thread. As quickly as it is created, the thread is spun through the air into the central cavity of the stone shuttle, vibrating with energy.

[To the character holding the artifacts]: As soon as the shuttle is full of radiant thread, a strand of light weaves deftly from its center and wraps tightly around your arm. It hums audibly, and feels strangely and pleasantly warm. The strand continues weaving around your forearm like a snake, terminating at the top of your finger where it hangs, patiently, for your response. As your finger traces through the air, it leaves a trail of shimmering green light in its wake.

If this character takes either artifact beyond the radius of the circle or relinquishes either artifact to another creature takes either artifact, these threads begin to fade; once they vanish, any activated runes are extinguished, forcing the ritual (see "Consecrating the Fane") to start anew. (Quick-thinking and perceptive creatures can immediately return to the circle or return the artifacts to their original bearer, preventing the threads from vanishing completely). Stowing or dropping either artifact does not cause the threads to vanish.

If a character grinds the flowers of the *sanziene plant* and smears the resulting paste around or beneath their eyes, two unseen things become visible:

- The following phrase appears beneath the carving of the Weaver, written in smeared, jagged crimson letters: *BEWARE THE WATCHERS*.
- Six carved, chalk-white runes become visible atop certain stones in the circle, as depicted in the image below.



If a creature carrying the shuttle and spindle stands atop one of these stones and uses an action to trace the shape of its respective rune in the air, the tile is activated and shines with viridian light. (The tile is extinguished if the consecration ritual fails or succeeds, if the bearer exits the circle, or if the bearer relinquishes the shuttle or spindle to another creature).

Once a tile is activated, its traced rune is connected to any also-activated neighbors by a strand of ethereal green light, as given by the dotted lines in the diagram above.

Special Events

Consecrating the Fane

To carry out the ritual of the Weaver, the bearer of the *spindle* and *shuttle of the Weaver* must stand atop each of the six rune-marked tiles (in no particular order) and use an action to trace that tile's rune into the air using the ethereal viridian thread stored in the *shuttle of the Weaver*.

The fey energy created in activating a tile generates additional threads of light that the bearer of the *spindle* and *shuttle* can use to defend itself. Immediately after using the ritualist uses their

action to activate a tile, the newly activated rune shines with fae energy, erupting with radiant strands of light in a five-foot radius.

Each hostile undead creature in that area must make a DC 17 Dexterity saving throw (with advantage, due to the desecrated ground). On a failed save, the target takes 1d6 radiant damage. The radius increases by five feet and the damage increases by 1d6 for each additional activated rune (e.g., if three runes are activated at the time that the ability triggers, the light deals 3d6 radiant damage in a 15-foot radius).

Once all six runes are activated, the strands of light connecting them form the three-pointed star of the Ladies Three, consecrating the Fane and severing its connection to Strahd (see “The Ritual Succeeds” below). However, to do so, the characters must first combat several attacks launched by Strahd’s undead guardians (see “Defending the Fane” below).

Defending the Fane

When he claimed the Swamp Fane as his own, Strahd redirected its power to create many malevolent spirits and bind them to his will. These spirits serve as his faithful guardians of the Fane, and are reborn and conjured whenever a new creature attempts to carry out the ritual of the Weaver.

Immediately after a character uses the Weaver’s artifacts to activate a rune within the circle, if no other runes are activated, these malevolent spirits begin to climb forth from the muck and mire nearby, assuming the forms of malignant undead as they shamble forward. Each undead guardian is surrounded by a shimmering aura of necrotic energy.

These undead seek to destroy or drive away the creature performing the ritual, or to hinder the ritual’s ultimate completion. Each undead guardian gains the following action:

Extinguish Rune. This creature visibly channels the negative energy it carries toward an activated tile of the Weaver. At the start of this creature’s next turn, if it is standing atop the activated tile, the tile is extinguished and must be reactivated for the ritual to continue. If this occurs, this creature is immediately reduced to 0 hitpoints and is destroyed. Destroying this creature or moving it off of the targeted tile before the start of its next turn interrupts this action.

Weaker undead guardians prioritize the extinguishing of active tiles (if any), but will attack any creature that obstructs their path. Stronger undead guardians prioritize the destruction of the character performing the ritual, or, if intelligent enough, may take tactical action to harm the ritualist’s allies.

Strahd’s undead guardians begin combat ten feet from the outside of the circle of menhirs. Recall that the area within the circle of menhirs is desecrated ground, giving any undead creature within that circle advantage on saving throws. The natures of these undead guardians (and the rounds in which they emerge) are as follows:

Round	Undead Guardians
1	6 zombies
2	6 ghouls
3	3 ghasts
4	3 will-'o-wisps and 7 skeletons
5	3 wights
6	1 wraith and 4 specters
7	1 flameskull and 3 wights
8	2 wraiths and 2 will-'o-wisps
9	2 flameskulls and 4 ghasts
10	3 wraiths and 3 skeletons

If the PCs seem to be struggling, feel free to decrease the size or difficulty of future waves (and vice-versa if the encounter seems to be too easy). However, all waves from the 6th round onward should feel notably more difficult than the preceding six waves, and the PCs should feel a building sense of tension and danger throughout.

Additionally, if the PCs appear to be completing the encounter without much difficulty, you can have a *stinking cloud* appear at the center of the stone circle on Round 4 (lasting for two rounds) and a motionless *cloudkill* appear at the center of the stone circle on Round 7 (lasting for three rounds).

The Ritual Succeeds

If all six rune-marked tiles are activated, the ritual succeeds and the Swamp Fane is reconsecrated.

The six runes and connecting threads of light thrum with energy. Each rune grows brighter, glowing stronger and more vibrant until everything within the circle of menhirs is illuminated in an eerie, viridian fey light. The undead cringe away from his light, their faces and forms contorting in unfamiliar agony.

[To the character performing the ritual]: In that moment, you can suddenly perceive a pair of viridian veins running from the palms of your hand into the loamy soil at the center of the circle. Beside them, however, you can now also perceive a dark, crimson vein, as wide as a tree's trunk and crackling with malignant black sparks, running from the center of the circle into the grey sky overhead. This bloated, throbbing vein arcs to the east and vanishes out of sight.

As it pulses with malevolent intent, you feel from its opposite end the unmistakable touch of a dark and

ancient consciousness. There is a flash of black light from its depths, and for an instant, you perceive the burning scarlet eyes of Count Strahd von Zarovich, their hatred and rage boring into your very soul.

The six points of light and six connecting threads shine ever-brighter, until their intensity consumes your vision. Threads of viridian light stretch from the emerald veins bonded to your palms, burning with life, and wrap across the throbbing vein's surface. These burning fey threads spiral like snakes, constricting and binding the crimson vein—and then, with a thunderous snap, sever it completely.

The sense of Strahd's enraged consciousness vanishes—replaced with a burning warmth that runs from the palm of your hands deep into the very core of your being.

You hear a voice—a woman's, distant at first—speak softly: *What once was stolen, I now give freely. Accept my boon, champion of the Swamp Fane.*

As you watch, small black tattoos in the shape of spiders appear in the palms of your hands, directly where the veins of life meet your skin.

[To everyone]: The undead shriek in pain, powerless to resist as the brilliant light burns through them. Each fell creature in turn collapses to the ground, its flesh and essence sloughing into a thick, grey sludge.

As you watch, a shimmering green liquid begins to condense around the strands of pulsing light, flowing forth to the swampy soil below. Wherever the liquid touches the earth, it devours the grey undead sludge. In its place, the grass grows lush and green, red and brown-speckled toadstools sprouting in small, well-rooted colonies across the spongy, moss-covered soil.

When the liquid reaches the outer menhirs, it flows not out, but *up*, covering each standing stone until the circle glimmers with ethereal fey light. As the shimmering liquid slowly evaporates, each menhir is left covered in lush, green vines that stretch from stone to stone, covering the air above the circle with a canopy of life. Dozens of small, beautiful spiders begin to emerge from the spaces between the vines, spinning silvery-grey threads until the circle glistens with dew that clings to the newborn webs.

The prickling, squeamish feeling that you've felt since entering the stone circle has gone, replaced by a soft, gentle sensation of warmth and peace.

With the Swamp Fane reconsecrated, Strahd loses his resistance to fire, cold, lightning, thunder, and acid damage. The creature who carried out the ritual gains these benefits instead.

To desecrate the Fane once more, Strahd must first slay the creature who completed the consecration ritual before performing a new corruption ritual. The corruption ritual takes three days and nights, and must begin on the night of the new moon.

Chapter 15: Castle Ravenloft

WELCOME TO CASTLE RAVENLOFT

Welcome to Castle Ravenloft—the only location in *Curse of Strahd* more terrifying for a DM to run than Vallaki. Strahd’s castle is the core of the *Curse of Strahd* campaign. It is the heart from which his power extends, the symbol of your players’ fears, and the inevitable site of the adventure’s final battle.

Castle Ravenloft is one of the largest and most complex structures in Barovia. It is also one of the most lived-in, with more inhabitants than any location other than Krezk, Vallaki, or the village of Barovia. It has numerous entrances, exits, and a maze of twists and turns that can leave a player’s head spinning—let alone a DM’s.

It is extremely likely that your players will visit Castle Ravenloft at least once, if not multiple times throughout their adventure. However, fear not—for Strahd’s castle is not impossible to run. It might be tough to piece together all of the information in the original 46-page chapter. However, with the right mindset, proper organization, and a helpful guide, this massive fortress can soon become quite manageable.

To give proper context for Castle Ravenloft, we’ll start with a brief **history of Castle Ravenloft**, followed by its **significance to**

major NPCs. We’ll explore **why your players are here**, and **what you (the DM) should expect**.

We’ll go over sections such as the **mechanics of running Castle Ravenloft**, the **guide to navigating the castle’s chambers**, and a **list of castle residents**. We’ll walk through the **major quest objectives** located in the castle, a **list of loot**, and take inventory of the **traps, monsters, and hazards** that lurk within.

We’ll walk through the **tools that Strahd can use** while within his castle, explore the **three reasons your players are likely to visit** the castle, Strahd’s **disposition and tactics** while in the castle, and a full compendium of **tactics for every monster and NPC**.

Finally, we’ll explore a quick list of **audio tracks, artwork, and battlemaps** that might come in handy while your players are exploring this towering, haunted fortress—and with any luck, we’ll finish it all in time to be home for dinner.

Sounds like a lot? Don’t worry—it is. But you’re not alone, and thousands of DMs have ruled this castle’s halls before you. With their guidance—and a little bit of preparation—you’ll do just fine.

HISTORY OF THE CASTLE

Castle Ravenloft was not built until after Strahd conquered Barovia, following his conquest and near-total genocide of the Forest Folk and Mountain Folk who had once occupied the land. After summoning settlers of every race and ethnicity from the diverse lands he'd conquered, Strahd commissioned a small army of wizards to construct the seat of his power: Castle Ravenloft. It was named in honor of his beloved mother, Queen Ravenovia.

Under the direction of the architect, Artimus, the mages wrought Castle Ravenloft from the Pillarstone of Ravenloft itself, carving the castle in whole from earth and enchanted stone. The foreboding and formidable fortress was guarded on all sides by steep cliffs, connected to the road by a simple drawbridge, and shielded from external threats by the eastern mountains of Barovia.

One of these mages, the archmage Khazan, chose to settle in Barovia, and would later build the tower at Lake Baratok. His body, and his *staff of power*, lie in the crypts of Castle Ravenloft to this day.

The castle completed, Strahd summoned his surviving family—his mother, Ravenovia, and his younger brother, Sergei—to join him at the new seat of the von Zarovich line. Queen Ravenovia, who was old, and in poor health—perhaps due to the whispered curses and dark prayers of Baba Lysaga—passed away during the journey. Sergei arrived alone, and joined his brother at Ravenloft.

Rahadin, Strahd's most trusted general and adoptive brother, came to reside at the castle as Strahd's chamberlain. At some

point, the Duchess Dorfinya Dilisnya journeyed to Barovia alongside her beloved fool, Pidlwick, hoping to win the hand of Count Strahd von Zarovich. In an effort to earn Strahd's favor, she commissioned the legendary toymaker, Fritz von Weerg, to build Pidlwick II, a clockwork effigy of Pidlwick. The Duchess, however, soon succumbed to illness after a harsh winter trapped her in the castle for several months. Pidlwick perished as well after falling victim to the murderous envy of his clockwork counterpart.

In time, a new suitress came to Strahd's door: the dusk elf archmage Patrina Velikovna. Strahd was taken by her passion for the secrets of immortality, and voyaged with her to the Amber Temple to forge a pact with the dark gods that lay within. When he returned, however, he learned that his brother, Sergei, had found a new romance with a Barovian peasant girl named Tatyana—and Strahd's heart was set aflame with jealousy and lust.

Patrina was swiftly set aside, and Strahd became consumed with envy for his brother's impending marriage. On the day of the wedding, Strahd lured Sergei to the royal chambers, slit his throat, and drank his blood. This sealed his pact with Vampyr, one of the vestiges of the Amber Temple. The guards of the castle fell upon Strahd, killing him—but Strahd was resurrected as a vampire. Newly immortal and fueled by the power of undeath, Strahd rampaged through the castle, killing his own guards and subjects. Many of those slain still linger in the castle today, whether as wights, skeletons, or zombies. Tatyana fled from him—and leapt from the Pillarstone of Ravenloft into the abyss below to escape. Her body was never found.

Rahadin, eager to distract his master from Tatyana's death, helped Strahd lure more women to the castle, lavishing them with jewels and fine clothes before Strahd drained their lives and turned them into vampire spawn. When Patrina heard of Tatyana's death and Strahd's rebirth as a vampire, she returned to Castle Ravenloft. However, this time Strahd saw that she craved only his power, and Patrina came to understand that he would never love her. Soon after, Patrina was stoned to death by the Dusk Elves at the direction of her brother, Kasimir, and her body was laid to rest in the crypts below the castle.

Over the five centuries since Strahd's death, many adventurers have traveled to Barovia, most unintentionally, lured there by the mists and Strahd's own desire for entertainment. In that time, all have fallen. Their spirits live on as ghosts, rising each night from the earth of the cemetery in the Village of Barovia and marching along the Svalich Road toward the castle. Once there, they fling themselves from the top of the highest tower, plummeting to the catacombs below as their spirits relive their deaths, surrounded by the vampiric husks of those they once called "friend."

So too, shall it be, for all others who challenge Castle Ravenloft—unless and until Strahd is slain.

WHY YOU'RE HERE

There are six main reasons why the PCs might find themselves in Ravenloft: Invitation, Exploration, Infiltration, Negotiation, Assault, and Imprisonment.

Invitation. Strahd may invite the PCs to Castle Ravenloft: either because he seeks to meet with them over dinner, because he

wants to gloat while getting married to Ireena, or because he seeks to lure them to their deaths.

Exploration. The PCs may choose to venture into Castle Ravenloft unbidden simply because they are curious about the secrets and treasures the castle holds, or because they are curious about Strahd and wish to meet him. This happens infrequently, but is most likely to be done at low levels and by individual PCs, rather than an entire party.

Infiltration. The PCs seek to raid Castle Ravenloft to obtain an item, such as a Tarokka treasure, the skull of Argynvost, or Tasha Petrovna's holy symbol; to rescue a kidnapped Ireena Kolyana or an imprisoned ally, such as Ezmerelda or another PC; or to make their way to Strahd's foretold location and slay the vampire, once and for all.

Negotiation. The PCs journey to Castle Ravenloft to cut a deal with Strahd—likely for the release of hostages or the freedom of an imprisoned ally.

Assault. The PCs have declared all-out war on Strahd (or vice-versa), and are seeking to attack the castle with a team of allies against the army of undead within.

WHAT TO EXPECT

RISKS & DANGERS

Castle Ravenloft is the deadliest location in Barovia. Compared to the Amber Temple, the castle has few high-intensity, win-or-die combats, save for the ultimate battle with Strahd himself. Compared to Berez, the castle has no face-offs with powerful spellcasters or invulnerable brawlers, save

for the iron golem trap in area K78 (Brazier Room).

Rather, the danger of Castle Ravenloft is twofold:

- First, once your players enter, the maze-like nature of the castle and its abundance of traps make it unlikely that they will escape again, unless Strahd wishes them to.
- Second, the constant trickle of combat encounters and hazards will wear down your players' resources, forcing them into a slow battle of attrition.

These aspects, combined with Strahd's own power and mastery of the castle, make Castle Ravenloft dangerous for even a high-level party—deadly if those characters have drawn Strahd's wrath.

THE MAZE

Between the twelve different staircases linking seven enormous floors and a multitude of secret doors scattered throughout almost ninety separate rooms, Castle Ravenloft can be challenging for even experienced DMs to navigate. On top of this, the book presents the castle in isometric form by default rather than supplying a standard two-dimensional map. For your convenience, [here is a link](#) to my preferred two-dimensional version of the Castle Ravenloft maps to help you follow along as we walk through Ravenloft's full architectural plan.

THE SEAT OF STRAHD'S POWER

Castle Ravenloft is the seat of Strahd's power. It is the base of his operations and

the headquarters from which he projects power across Barovia.

At its core, Castle Ravenloft is where Strahd keeps his coffin and tomb—the one place which he must always return to each morning. It is where he stores his legions of undead wights, specters, and vampire spawn.

It is where his most trusted confidants make their home, from his brides—Ludmilla, Anastrasya, Volenta, and Escher—to his trusted chamberlain, Rahadin.

It is where the arcane secrets and ancient treasures of the von Zarovich family lay undisturbed, from the teleportation brazier of area K78 (Brazier Room) to the *Daern's instant fortress* that defends Strahd's treasury in area K41 (Treasury).

Finally, it is Strahd's lair. It is the epicenter of the rot and corruption that suffuses Barovia, the source of Strahd's powerful and combat-ready Lair Actions, and the home of his hordes of bats, rats, and other creatures of the night.

Outside of Castle Ravenloft, Strahd is a challenging and worthy opponent. Inside of his castle, Strahd is an indomitable—and deadly—foe.

KEEPING IT ORGANIZED

Organization is one of the most common challenges that DMs face when running Castle Ravenloft. It can be taxing and confusing to constantly flip between different parts of the chapter as your players traverse different areas and floors, especially if you're routinely referring back to maps of the castle or campaign guides such as this one.

Depending on which medium you're using to run your *Curse of Strahd* campaign, here are a few suggestions for keeping orderly, organized, and understandable notes while running Castle Ravenloft.

Roll20. Create a one-document file using Google Docs or OneNote. For each section of the castle, create a new section header; for each room of the castle, create a new section sub-header. In each room's section, paste or type the description text that your players see when entering that room, as well as a brief bullet-pointed list of the important features of the room. Then, create a brief list of exits from the room, with each exit hyperlinked to the section sub-header of the room that it leads to (if using Google Docs, place a bookmark next to each room's section sub-header to allow hyperlinking). Whenever your players leave a room, click the hyperlink for the exit they used to automatically scroll to their destination.

Foundry VTT. Create a new folder in the Journal titled "Castle Ravenloft," then create a separate subfolder for each floor of the castle. In each floor's subfolder, create a new journal entry for each room. Paste or type the description text that your players see when entering that room, as well as a brief bullet-pointed list of the important features of the room. Drag and drop each journal entry onto the map into the center of the room it refers to. When your players enter a new room, double-click that room's journal entry to pull up its information.

Pen and Paper. Using post-it notes or adhesive dividers, mark off and label the first page of each floor of Castle Ravenloft in your *Curse of Strahd* book. If desired, do the same with each "transition room": rooms

that connect directly to a room on a different floor (e.g., K20, the Heart of Sorrow), to easily allow you to flip back and forth when your players are ascending or descending staircases. Finally, paste or type up all monster stat blocks that you might need in Castle Ravenloft, then organize them by floor and room. Use post-it notes or dividers to mark off and label the first page of each floor of Castle Ravenloft in these printed "monster" notes.

RUNNING CASTLE RAVENLOFT

LIGHTING & SOUND

Nearly all of the inhabitants of Castle Ravenloft possess darkvision. As such, each room of the castle is naturally dark, save for those where the book's description naturally indicates otherwise—e.g., K8 (Great Entry, illuminated by torches), K15 (Chapel, illuminated by moonlight), K37 (Study, illuminated by the fireplace), or K78 (Brazier Room, illuminated by the brazier)—or where the room's inhabitants would require illumination to function—e.g., K30 (King's Accountant, occupied by Lief Lipsiege).

As such, any PCs without darkvision will need to bear a source of light, such as the *light* spell or a torch, in order to see. However, these light sources will make them far easier to spot. A character who attempts to hide from a monster or enemy within Castle Ravenloft while bearing a source of light should automatically fail in almost all situations.

Your PCs should then face a dilemma: Do they explore the castle in darkness, risking ambush by the many denizens who can easily see in the dark? Or do they march

brazenly through well-illuminated halls, risking the attention of unwanted eyes?

RESTING & RESOURCES

Just as Pidlwick found himself smothered in his sleep by his clockwork clone, only a fool would think to rest in Castle Ravenloft. If the PCs are unwelcome, then even in the best of cases short rests are potentially dangerous within the castle walls, and long rests near-impossible. If Strahd is within the castle, aware of the PCs' presence, and actively pursuing their deaths, the PCs shall find no rest for as long as they remain within the castle.

An adventuring party must check for a random encounter every 10 minutes they spend resting in the castle. Over the course of a single 60-minute short rest, the average party must check for a random encounter six times, giving them a measly 38% chance of taking their rest undisturbed. On the bright side, not all encounters are hostile, and the PCs have only a 32% chance of encountering an enemy or monster during this rest.

A long rest is far more challenging. Over the course of a single two-hour period, there is only a 14% chance that the PCs will go without an encounter, and a 47% chance that the PCs will face a hostile enemy. Moreover, if the PCs are unwelcome, there is little chance that they can hide themselves from Strahd—and even less chance that Strahd will allow his uninvited guests to enjoy their sleep.

A short rest is “a period of downtime, at least 1 hour long, during which a character does nothing more strenuous than eating, drinking, reading, and tending to wounds.” A character that attacks—or is attacked—

must therefore end their short rest prematurely and re-start from scratch, regaining no hit dice or class features. As such, if a short rest is interrupted by a hostile random encounter, it is null and void, and must be restarted. Strahd understands this, and will gladly create his own hostile encounters if he is aware of the PCs' presence.

Long rests are slightly more forgiving of interruptions—but far more difficult to survive. Not only will a long rest risk far more random encounters, wearing the party's resources down over time, but Strahd's exceptional +14 Stealth score allows him to easily surprise any PC assigned to stand watch. After all, the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind can project sunlight for only so long, and even the Sunsword's wielder must sleep eventually.

Using his mist form, Strahd can easily slip through any door or open window and swiftly charm the PC on watch. Due to the wording of this ability, Strahd can use his charm ability while in bat and wolf form as well, allowing him to repeatedly attempt to charm his target while in clear view. If Strahd is discovered, he can simply dissolve to mist form, exit the room, and come back later. After all, the PCs must sleep to heal. Strahd—with his vampiric regeneration—has no such restrictions.

Unlike Berez or the Amber Temple, Castle Ravenloft is first and foremost a battlefield of attrition. In this sense, it is the purest application of the “5-8 encounter adventuring day” proposed by the designers of 5e *Dungeons & Dragons*. However, by a cruel, intentional joke, taking short rests to regain resources are and should remain nearly impossible within the castle's walls,

condemning any party of unprepared adventurers to a slow, painful death.

In short: **Under no circumstances should a hostile Strahd permit *any* invader to take a short or long rest within his castle. He is watchful, well-informed, well-hidden, and highly mobile, and far too cunning and brutal to allow it.**

AREAS OF THE CASTLE

ENTRANCES AND EXITS

There are several ways to enter Castle Ravenloft, each with their own challenges and dangers.

Main Entry. The main first-floor entrance of Castle Ravenloft (area K7). Leads into a foyer with adjoining corridors to the chapel (K15) and the Dining Hall (K10), plus a staircase to the Audience Hall (K25) on the second floor. Guarded by eight **gargoyles** in the foyer who attack any unwelcome PC that returns after leaving, and four statues of **red dragon wyrmlings** that attack any PC that attempts to leave the castle without Strahd's permission.

Servants' Entrance. An auxiliary first-floor door located in the back courtyard of the castle leads to the servants' entrance (K23), which has an adjoining staircase that descends to the servants' hall (K62). It also connects to the servants' quarters (K24), which contain a staircase that climbs to the servants' upper floor (K34), which contain a secret door providing access to the Heart of Sorrow (K20).

Overlook Window. A trio of stained-glass windows overlooking the village of Barovia from the tomb of King Barov and Queen Ravenovia (K88). Located 900 feet above

the church in the village of Barovia, and 110 feet below the Overlook (K6). Only accessible by PCs with climber's kits or magical flight. Known outside the castle only by the Keepers of the Feather. Leads into the catacombs (K84).

Tower Rooftop. The rooftop of Castle Ravenloft's third-highest tower (K57). Connects to the tower of the Heart of Sorrow (K20) via a windy bridge (K58). Descends via a staircase to the Familiar Room (K54), where the familiars of the Barovian witches lurk. Accessible only by flight or long-distance teleportation.

High Tower Peak. The tallest spire of Castle Ravenloft (K59) and the top of the high tower shaft (K18a), which runs all the way down to the catacombs (K84). Connects to the top of the high tower staircase (K18), which descends directly to the chapel on the first floor. The roof has crumbled, creating a hole that allows the castle's bats and Strahd's **nightmare**, Beucephalus, to easily enter and exit the castle. Accessible only by flight.

Parapets. The inner walls of Castle Ravenloft's keep (K46), adjoined to the third floor of the castle. An open doorway leads into the Heart of Sorrow tower (K20) on the north side, while the Guards' Stair (K64) on the south side leads down to the South Archers' Posts (K11) on the first and second floors—including secret doors that provide access to the Dining Hall (K10) and Audience Hall (K25), respectively—and the Guards' Quarters (K69) in the basement. Accessible only by flight.

Chapel. While the chapel has no doors, its stained-glass windows make for an extremely suitable place for [dramatic](#)

[entrances](#), especially if Strahd's wedding is currently underway.

Brazier Room. The castle also has a one-way exit: the teleportation brazier in the brazier room (K78). Using this artifact, Strahd (and his minions) can travel almost anywhere in Barovia, including the coffin maker's shop in Vallaki, the Amber Temple, the Abbey of Saint Markovia, and Tsolenka Pass.

The brazier can also provide an instant one-way trip to several other locations in the castle including Strahd's study (K37), which is near the treasury (K41) and the king's bedchamber (K42); the north tower peak (K60), which contains Strahd's crown and sits atop the Heart of Sorrow (K20); and Strahd's tomb (K86).

PUBLIC & PRIVATE AREAS

The interior of Castle Ravenloft can be divided into two main sections: The "public" areas accessible by the South Tower Stair (K21), and the "private" areas accessible from the Heart of Sorrow's tower (K20).

The "public" area includes notable locations like:

- the Dining Hall (K10) and Chapel (K15) on the first floor,
- the Audience Hall (K25) on the second floor,
- the Study (K37) and King's Bedchamber (K42) on the third floor,
- the Lounge (K49) and Cauldron (K56) in the towers,
- the Elevator Trap (K61) and Hall of Bones (K67) in the Larders of Ill Omen, and
- the North and South Dungeons (K74 and K75) in the dungeons.

These areas are meant to be easily accessible by visitors to the castle.

The "private" area includes:

- the Servants' Quarters (K24) on the first floor,
- the Maid in Hell (K32) on the second floor,
- the Hall of Heroes (K45) on the third floor,
- the North Tower Peak (K60) in the towers,
- the Chamberlain's Office (K72) in the Larders of Ill Omen, and
- the Catacombs (K84) in the Dungeons.

These tucked-away, interconnected areas were once largely meant to be accessed only by servants of the castle, or the von Zarovich family themselves.

A creature in the "public" area can easily climb or descend the South Tower Stair (K21) to reach any other public chamber.

A creature in the "private" area can easily ascend or descend the stairs of the Heart of Sorrow (K20) and Tower Hall Stair (K20A) to reach any other private chamber.

To enter the "public area" from outside, a creature can enter through the Entry (K8) on the first floor.

To enter the "private area" from outside, a creature can enter through the Servants' Entrance on the first floor, proceed to the Servants' Upper Floor (K34) on the second floor, and pass through the secret door into the Heart of Sorrow (K20).

The “public” and “private” areas connect at four points:

- **1st Floor:** The High Tower Stair (K18) that descends from the Chapel (K15) to the catacombs (K84). Currently obstructed by a solid stone wall.
- **2nd Floor:** The secret doors that connect the Guards’ Post (K26) to the second-floor Turret Post Access Hall (K13) through the King’s Apartment Stair (K33)
- **3rd Floor:** The door that connects the Study (K37) to the Hall of Heroes (K45) and Heart of Sorrow (K20).
- **Towers:** The Bridge (K58) that connects the Tower Roof (K57) to the Heart of Sorrow (K20)
- **Ladders:** The Kingsmen Hall (K70), which connects the Kingsmen Quarters (K71) to the Hall of Bones (K67)

TERRITORIES OF THE CASTLE

Strahd’s three most honored brides are not simply mindless spawn—they are devoted and powerful executors of his will, each with their own strengths and portfolios. As such, each bride oversees a separate section of the castle, with the two remaining sections reserved for Rahadin and Strahd himself.

Strahd’s brides are as territorial as they are fierce. While they do occasionally allow their neighbors to complete projects in their domains (e.g., Ludmilla’s **flying halberds** in Volenta’s Heart of Sorrow, or Volenta’s suit-of-armor trap in Anastrasya’s Grand Landing), an uninvited intrusion into a bride’s territory by another bride is met with hostility, if not violence. As such, neither the brides nor any creatures encountered in their territory will willingly follow the PCs

past the borders of their own territory. Rahadin and Strahd, however, are not limited by the territories of the brides, and pursue prey wherever they please.

ANASTRASYA

As the envoy and hostess of Castle Ravenloft, Anastrasya oversees the entryway, public spaces, and royal quarters of the castle, which include the following locations:

- K7. Entry
- K8. Great Entry
- K9. Guests’ Hall
- K10. Dining Hall
- K14. Hall of Faith
- K15. Chapel
- K16. North Chapel Access
- K17. South Chapel Access
- K19. Grand Landing
- K20. Heart of Sorrow
- K21. South Tower Stair
- K25. Audience Hall
- K30. King’s Accountant
- K35. Guardian Vermin
- K36. Dining Hall of the Count
- K37. Study
- K38. False Treasury
- K39. Hall of Webs
- K40. Belfry
- K41. Treasury
- K42. King’s Bedchamber
- K43. Bath Chamber
- K44. Closet

While travelling through Anastrasya’s territory, the PCs are likely to meet the following random encounters:

- 1d4 **wights**, which serve as Anastrasya’s personal guard

- A giant spider cocoon, left behind by the **giant spiders** that Anastrasya favors
- A trinket
- An unseen servant, carrying a silver goblet filled to the brim with wine or a purple silk handkerchief with white ruffled edges

VOLENTA

The mistress of Ravenloft's secret places, Volenta lurks in the dark, shadowed chambers of the castle. Her domain includes the following rooms:

- K20. Heart of Sorrow
- K20A. Tower Hall Stair
- K23. Servants' Entrance
- K24. Servants' Quarters
- K26. Guards' Post
- K27. King's Hall
- K28. King's Balcony
- K31. Trapworks
- K31A. Elevator Shaft
- K31B. Shaft Access
- K32. Maid in Hell
- K33. King's Apartment Stair
- K34. Servants' Upper Floor
- K45. Hall of Heroes
- K59. 60 North Tower Peak
- K60A. North Tower Rooftop
- K61. Elevator Trap

While travelling through Volenta's territory, the PCs are likely to meet the following random encounters:

- 2d6 **crawling claws**
- A crawling **Strahd zombie**, the desecrated remains of an uninvited houseguest
- A Blinsky toy

- An unseen servant, carrying a crystal dinner bell that attracts 1d4 hungry **vampire spawn**
- 1d4 + 1 **vampire spawn**

LUDMILLA

An arcane researcher and alchemist at heart, Ludmilla keeps to herself, preferring the isolation and altitude of the castle spires to the chambers of the keep below. Her territory includes the following rooms:

- K47. Portrait of Strahd
- K48. Offstair
- K49. Lounge
- K50. Guest Room
- K51. Closet
- K52. Smokestack
- K53. Rooftop
- K54. Familiar Room
- K55. Element Room
- K56. Cauldron
- K57. Tower Roof
- K58. Bridge

While travelling through Ludmilla's territory, the PCs are likely to meet the following encounters:

- 1d4 + 1 **flying swords**, enchanted by Ludmilla
- An unseen servant, carrying a gold candelabra with three branches
- A trinket
- 1 black **cat**
- 1 **Barovian witch**

RAHADIN

As Strahd's chamberlain, Rahadin is responsible for the upkeep, oversight, and defense of the castle and its inhabitants. As such, his territory extends through the lower portions of the castle, the areas reserved for its staff, and the defensive posts throughout

the keep. Rahadin's domain therefore includes the following rooms:

- K11. South Archers' Post
- K12. Turret Post
- K13. Turret Post Access Hall
- K22. North Archers' Post
- K62. Servants' Hall
- K63. Wine Cellar
- K64. Guards' Stair
- K65. Kitchen
- K66. Butler's Quarters
- K67. Hall of Bones
- K68. Guards' Run
- K69. Guards' Quarters
- K70. Kingsmen Hall
- K71. Kingsmen Quarters
- K72. Chamberlain's Office
- K73. Dungeon Hall
- K74. North Dungeon
- K75. South Dungeon
- K76. Torture Chamber
- K77. Observation Balcony
- K78. Brazier Room
- K79. Western Stair
- K83. Spiral Stair
- K83A. Spiral Stair Landing

While travelling through Rahadin's territory, the PCs are likely to meet the following encounters:

- Rahadin
- An unseen servant, carrying a covered silver platter of moldy scones
- 1 **broom of animated attack**, recently escaped from Cyrus Belview
- 1d4 **wights**
- 1d6 **shadows**
- A trinket

STRAHD

As master of Castle Ravenloft, all chambers within the keep are under Strahd's domain. However, his presence is most strongly felt in the following rooms of the castle:

- K80. Center Stair
- K81. Tunnel
- K82. Marble Slide
- K84. Catacombs
- K85. Sergei's Tomb
- K86. Strahd's Tomb
- K87. Guardians
- K88. Tomb of King Barov and Queen Ravenovia

While travelling through Strahd's territory, the PCs are likely to meet the following encounters:

- An unseen servant, carrying a spellbook
- 1d6 **swarms of bats**
- A trinket
- Strahd von Zarovich

RESIDENTS OF THE CASTLE

After the three Barovian settlements, Castle Ravenloft is the most well-populated location in Barovia. Before running it, make sure to familiarize yourself with those who reside here.

STRAHD & SPAWN

Strahd von Zarovich. The titular villain of the module, and the lord of Castle Ravenloft himself. Strahd can be encountered in several locations throughout the castle, regardless of time of day. However, if he is not aware of intruders in the castle, he is most likely to be found in his tomb (K86), unless the PCs' Tarokka reading indicates otherwise.

Ludmilla Vilisevic. As Strahd's protege in magic, Ludmilla is the spellmistress of Castle Ravenloft and the master of the coven of **Barovian witches** that dwell in its highest towers. She has the characteristics of a **vampire spawn** with 105 hit points and an Intelligence of 18. Additionally, Ludmilla possesses a familiar named Heshka, which most commonly takes the form of a horned viper **snake**. Heshka has the characteristics of a familiar as defined in the *find familiar* spell.

Ludmilla is an 8th-level spellcaster. Her spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 15, +7 to hit with spell attacks). She has the following Wizard spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): *ray of frost, mage hand, prestidigitation, light*

1st Level (4 slots): *ray of sickness, sleep, shield, fog cloud*

2nd Level (3 slots): *misty step, blindness/deafness, levitate*

3rd Level (3 slots): *counterspell, lightning bolt*

4th Level (3 slots): *greater invisibility, evard's black tentacles*

At nearly 200 years old, Ludmilla is Strahd's oldest bride.²¹⁷ Where other consorts have been cast aside as Strahd grew tired of them, Ludmilla has survived by keeping to herself while tending to matters he deems important. She serves as the unofficial leader of his harem, and reins the others in when necessary.

Ludmilla first came to Barovia as a little girl, stowing away in a Vistani caravan that passed through her homeland of Amn. When she arrived in Barovia, she made a living by stealing and hiding in the shadows.

It was only as a young woman that a kindly family in Vallaki found and adopted her.

Life with a family was better than life on the streets, but the dark color of Ludmilla's skin marked her as an outsider—and, in some ways, an outcast—to the other citizens of Vallaki. At the age of eighteen, Ludmilla fled Vallaki, following an ancient map that provided directions to the Amber Temple. There, she believed, she would find the answers and belonging she sought.

It was on the snow-covered slopes of Mount Ghakis that Ludmilla met the dusk elf, Rahadin, for the first time. Ludmilla was entranced by him; Rahadin saw her as a pleasurable and exotic distraction for his master. He offered to guide her to Castle Ravenloft, where he promised her a partner, a teacher, and a home.

For the next three years, Strahd taught her the secrets of the arcane arts alongside the minutiae of courtly etiquette. He fed upon her regularly, and was impressed by her stoic, yet thoughtful response to his hunger. Her intelligence and charisma were apparent, and Strahd soon offered her a position as his bride. She gladly accepted.

As a vampire, Ludmilla quickly learned from Rahadin that Strahd would inevitably tire of her—unless, that is, she proved herself useful. She set about serving him in the advancement of his arcane studies, and personally took on the task of recruiting and training his next bride, Anastraya. She now carefully stays out of Strahd's way unless he requests her presence directly, and has formed close ties to Rahadin.

When not needed elsewhere by Strahd or resting in her coffin in Strahd's tomb,

Lumilla can most often be found in area K55 (Element Room).

Anastrasya Karellova. The diplomat of Castle Ravenloft and a former Vallakian noble,²¹⁸ Anastrasya is as skilled with a sword as she is with her tongue—but is sure never to get her hands dirty. Anastrasya has the characteristics of a **vampire spawn** with 105 hit points and a Charisma of 18, as well as expertise in Deception (+7 modifier).

Of Strahd's brides, Anastrasya is most adept with the vampiric arts. As an action, she can use a **vampire's Charm** action with a DC of 15. If the target successfully saves against the effect, or if the effect on it ends, the target is immune to Anastrasya's Charm for the next 24 hours. Anastrasya can have only one target charmed at a time. If she charms another, the effect on the previous target ends.

As an action, Anastrasya can also use the **vampire's Shapechange** action to transform into a **wolf**, a **bat**, or a cloud of mist. However, she lacks the vampire's **Misty Escape** ability. Once per day, she can use the **vampire's Children of the Night** ability.

Using powerful magic, Anastrasya telekinetically wields a longsword that gains the properties of a **flying sword** that acts on her initiative. While wielded in this way by Anastrasya and within 50 feet of her, the sword has a Strength of 16 and cannot be targeted or damaged by attacks or spells, as though it were a held item. While wielding it, Anastrasya can use her bonus action to allow it to perform two **Longsword** attacks against a target she can see using its modified Strength score. Anastrasya also

telekinetically wields a shield that acts as if it were an *animated shield* while under her control.

Anastrasya is Strahd's second-eldest bride, and the foremost executor of his will among the Barovian populace. In life, she was a Vallakian noblewoman who hosted great celebrations in Strahd's honor and ruthlessly punished any who displayed traitorous intent. Enamored with the prospect of becoming his bride, she believed that if he could only see her unearthly beauty in person, he would deem her worthy of his hand in marriage.

It was at one of her events that she met Ludmilla Vilisevic, who claimed to be an agent of the count and offered an invitation to dine at Castle Ravenloft with Strahd himself. Anastrasya eagerly accepted.

Upon arriving at the castle, Ludmilla gave Anastrasya a tour of the decrepit keep, pleased with the prospect of unnerving the noblewoman with the macabre sights of Castle Ravenloft. Much to her surprise—and Strahd's satisfaction—Anastrasya was immediately taken with the displays of Strahd's power and darkness.

Strahd took to her immediately, and though it meant his waning interest in Ludmilla faded faster, he appreciated his elder bride's foresight in locating this new consort.

When not needed elsewhere by Strahd or resting in her coffin in Strahd's tomb, Anastrasya can most often be found in area K37 (Study).

Volenta Popofsky. The trapmistress and self-proclaimed artist of Castle Ravenloft, Volenta delights in hidden passages, lethal

mechanisms, and morbid curiosities. She has the characteristics of a **vampire spawn** with 105 hit points and a Dexterity of 18.

Volenta has the **Assassinate**, **Evasion**, and **Sneak Attack** features of an **assassin**. Additionally, Volenta has the **Blood Frenzy** feature, granting her advantage on melee attack rolls against any creature that doesn't have all its hit points.

In life, Volenta dwelled in the village of Barovia as a prostitute.²¹⁹ She revelled in the pain and suffering of others, and captured several of her customers in the cellar of her home, tormenting and torturing them for weeks before they expired. When her morbid activities were discovered, a mob drove her from the village, forcing her to seek shelter at Castle Ravenloft.

Despite Strahd's power and intimidating reputation, Volenta showed no fear upon meeting him, and gladly offered herself to him. Strahd, impressed by the depths of her sadistic streak, made her his bride.

Volenta is the most willful of the three brides, gleefully pushing the boundaries of Strahd and Ludmilla's patience. Her carefree, childlike personality can swiftly descend into a berserker's aggression when provoked, but her love of secrets drives her to lurk and spy on all visitors to the castle.

She has continued her passion for torment through the traps she has installed across Ravenloft, including the trapped chest in the False Treasury (K38), the trapped suits of armor on the Grand Landing (K19), and the enchanted trapdoors in the Dungeon Hall (K73)—a collaborative project with Ludmilla. She has also indulged her love for the

macabre on several aesthetics, and gleefully joined Cyrus Belview in the construction of the Hall of Bones, which she considers her masterwork.

When not needed elsewhere by Strahd or resting in her coffin in Strahd's tomb, Volenta can most often be found in area K60 (North Tower Peak).

Escher. One of Strahd's newest consorts, Escher is a dashing **vampire spawn** with a Charisma of 16 to whom Strahd has shown favor in the past.

Escher has the **Taunt** ability of a **bard**, and is a 4th-level spellcaster. His spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks). He wields a silver lyre as his arcane focus, and has the following bard spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): *friends*, *prestidigitation*, *vicious mockery*

1st level (4 slots): *charm person*, *heroism*, *sleep*, *dissonant whispers*, *faerie fire*

2nd level (3 slots): *invisibility*, *crown of madness*

A traveling minstrel with exceptional social graces and adept in manipulation, Escher impressed Strahd with his wit, intellect, and remarkable musical talents. Despite this, however, Escher has little ambition, and is content to enjoy the quiet, hedonistic lifestyle that Strahd provides him with.

Recently, Escher has begun to feel neglected, and has retreated from his position in the castle until Strahd's mood improves. He dreads the prospect of losing Strahd's interest, especially if Strahd's boredom leads to his imprisonment in the crypts below Castle Ravenloft.

Escher strongly (and correctly) suspects the cause of Strahd's disinterest to be the Count's growing obsession with Ireena Kolyana. Jealous of Ireena's presence in Strahd's attentions, Escher is determined to ensure that the happy couple is never wed,²²⁰ though he justifies his treasonous thoughts through the assumption that a talentless peasant such as Ireena could never be worth Strahd's affections.

To this end, Escher has forged a reluctant relationship with Sasha Ivlskova, one of Strahd's former brides, and a prisoner in the crypts below the castle. Should Sasha be released to serve Strahd's will once more, the pair have agreed to work together to keep Ireena from the castle. This goal may lead Escher to assist the PCs in certain endeavors—so long as his contributions cannot be traced back to him by Strahd or one of his spies.

Escher can be found in area K49 (Lounge).

Helga Ruvak. One of Strahd's minor consorts, Helga is a **vampire spawn** who lurks in area K32 (Maid in Hell). Upon encountering the PCs, she claims to be the daughter of the village bootmaker, kidnapped and forced into service by Strahd. Helga plays the part of the innocent damsel in distress to the last, revealing her vampiric nature and ferocity only when she betrays the party and attacks. She is, in fact, the bootmaker's daughter she claims to be, but she chose a life of evil with Strahd.

Heart of Sorrow. While not a "character" in the traditional sense, the Heart of Sorrow is a notable presence in Castle Ravenloft. While it's never explained in RAW how it

came to be, we can make some decent inferences about what it is and how it was made.

According to the book, "The Heart of Sorrow is held aloft by the will of Strahd. Casting dispel magic on it has no effect." We can connect this to the other instances of "the will of Strahd" throughout the module, plus this description of Strahd's curse in Chapter 9: ". . . Strahd saw the faces of his father and mother in the thunderclouds, looking down upon him and judging him. He had destroyed the family bloodline and doomed all of Barovia . . . For Strahd and his people, there would be no escape."

From this, we can reasonably guess that the Heart of Sorrow isn't a magical artifact at all; rather, it's an external manifestation of Strahd's sorrow and self-loathing, empowered by the Dark Powers and mists of the Demiplanes of Dread.

In other words, it wasn't built or forged. Instead, it sprang into being when the mists tore Barovia away and Strahd realized the extent of his curse

It's also possible that Strahd uses the Heart of Sorrow as a vessel for the grief and sorrow he feels due to this curse, externalizing his most human emotions to keep them from consuming him.²²¹ When the Heart is destroyed, as glass and blood rains down the hollow shaft of the tower, all of the rage, sadness, guilt, and pain that Strahd has suppressed for centuries comes rushing back to him. As Strahd struggles to process the emotions flooding his mind, he is **stunned** for one round as his scream of agony and rage echoes through the castle.

220 /u/violetgrubs, [Let's Flesh Out Escher](#)

221 Twi, /r/CurseOfStrahd Discord

Until Strahd is able to reconstruct the Heart of Sorrow (a process which takes thirty days and nights), he is riveted by pain and driven by rage—specifically, rage toward those who dared destroy his Heart. He may not be as tactful or subtle as he was before, but Strahd will still bring every ounce of his cunning, bloodlust, and power to bear upon his unfortunate victims. With the Heart destroyed, any idea of mercy that Strahd may have once entertained toward the PCs is gone for good.

CASTLE SERVANTS

Rahadin. The chamberlain of Castle Ravenloft and Strahd's right-hand man, Rahadin is a dusk elf who betrayed his people and served Strahd faithfully for years as a general of his armies. Today, he oversees the day-to-day operations of Castle Ravenloft, and serves as Strahd's enforcer in the lands beyond the castle. Rahadin is a fearsome fighter and an adopted son of the von Zarovich line. Only Strahd outranks him within the walls of Castle Ravenloft. He can most often be found in the Chamberlain's Office (K72), but can occasionally be encountered as a random encounter throughout the castle.

Lief Lipsiege. Lief Lipsiege was pressed into service as Strahd's accountant many years ago. He records all of Strahd's riches and conquests, and has inhabited Castle Ravenloft longer than he can remember. He can be found in K30 (King's Accountant).

Cyrus Belview. Cyrus is the butler of Castle Ravenloft and a bestial **mongrelfolk**: a member of the Belview family that was twisted into monstrous insanity by the Abbot in Krezk decades ago. He holds a key that can unlock the iron chest containing

Strahd's crown in K60 (North Tower Peak), and unwittingly wears a pendant containing the *hag eye* of the coven in Old Bonegrinder. He is quite insane, and previously collaborated with Strahd's bride Volenta Popofsky on the Hall of Bones (K67), an unholy work of art. He is totally devoted to Strahd, and will do his best to usher the PCs to "their rooms" in K50 (Guest Room), using the Elevator Trap (K61) to transport them there. He can be encountered in the Servants' Hall (K62), and regularly lurks in the Kitchen (K65) or the Butler's Quarters (K66).

GHOSTS & LURKERS

Pidlwick. The ghost of Pidlwick, the former fool of Duchess Dorfinya Dilisnya, lurks in the Dining Hall of the Count (K36), and can be summoned by a character who plays his harp and succeeds on a DC 15 Performance check. If encountered, he commends the character for their playing, and directs them to his crypt (Crypt 9) in the Catacombs (K84), where the PCs can find a *deck of illusions*. He dislikes Pidlwick II, who killed him by pushing him down a staircase in Castle Ravenloft.

Pidlwick II. Constructed by the legendary toymaker Fritz von Weerg at the request of Duchess Dorfinya Dilisnya, Pidlwick II, a clockwork effigy of Pidlwick the fool, was constructed with a touch of his creator's madness. Isolated after the Duchess succumbed to illness during a harsh winter at Castle Ravenloft, and jealous of Pickwick's role in Strahd's court, Pidlwick II pushed Pidlwick down a long flight of stairs, killing him. Its presence was upsetting to Tatyana for the time that she stayed at the castle, and as a result it was shut away in the guest bedrooms of Castle Ravenloft. From time to time, Pidlwick II snuck out to

smother a sleeping guest with a pillow, amusing Strahd with its murderous nature. It now lurks in the rafters of the High Tower Peak (K59), and will try to be helpful if shown kindness—or murderous, if treated meanly.

Patrina Velikovna. In life, before Strahd first met Tatyana, Patrina Velikovna sought Strahd's hand in marriage, enamouring him with her deep knowledge of the dark arts. Patrina was responsible for showing Strahd the secrets of the Amber Temple, and an enchanted Strahd nearly consented to wed her—before stumbling upon Tatyana Federovna instead. Later, after Strahd became a vampire, Patrina returned to win Strahd's affections, but he no longer cared for her, now fully realizing that she craved only his power. Kasimir, Patrina's brother, however, became convinced that she had become a consort of Strahd's, and directed his people to stone Patrina to death. Strahd demanded—and received—Patrina's body. Now, her soul is eternally trapped in the Catacombs (K84) below Castle Ravenloft as a **banshee** that haunts the crypt where her body was laid to rest (Crypt 21).

Sir Klutz Tripalotsky. A clumsy **phantom warrior** who died by falling on his own sword, the spirit of Sir Klutz Tripalotsky dwells in the Catacombs (K84) of Castle Ravenloft within his crypt (Crypt 33). If the PCs remove the sword that killed him from his suit of armor, Sir Klutz's ghost appears and offers to fight alongside them for seven days.

Varushka. Varushka was a maid of Castle Ravenloft who took her own life when Strahd began feeding on her, denying him the chance to turn her into a vampire spawn. Her spirit resides in K43 (Bath

Chamber), manifesting as a pool of blood that, if disturbed, releases a terrifying (but harmless) apparition.

Strahd's Animated Armor. The armor that Strahd wore into battle when he was alive lives on today as a headless, animated suit of plate armor. It is imbued with a sliver of Strahd's malevolent being, and fortified with arcane wards and spells. If the PCs linger on the Parapets (K46), they can encounter the Animated Armor making its patrol. Alternatively, Strahd may have previously gifted the Armor to an unwitting PC, removing it from the Castle entirely.

GUESTS & PRISONERS

Any creatures that Strahd takes prisoner are stored in the North Dungeon (K74) or South Dungeon (K75). He may also store bound and guarded noncombatant prisoners on the second floor of the Treasury (K41) if the waterlogged conditions of the Dungeon prevents him from doing so.

If Strahd captures Ireena, he keeps her in the King's Bedchamber (K42)—with one exception. If the PCs have previously rescued Ireena, Strahd immediately kills her and turns her into a **vampire spawn**, then seals her into the crypt marked "Ireena Kolyana" (Crypt 18) in the Catacombs (K84).

Gertruda. A naive teenage girl and the daughter of Mad Mary from the village of Barovia, Gertruda escaped her mother's overbearing grasp and fled to Castle Ravenloft, her mind aflutter with dreams of honorable princes in beautiful castles. Strahd was amused by her naiveté, and keeps her as his guest in the King's Bedchamber (K42). Gertruda is oblivious to any danger to herself—especially from

Strahd, who has charmed her. Strahd will gladly bite and turn her if he can do so while the PCs look on helplessly. If he captures Ireena, Strahd will relocate Gertruda to the Guest Room (K50).

Emil Toranescu. A **werewolf** from the Werewolf Den, Emil duelled with Kiril Stoyanovich for leadership of Barovia's werewolf pack. Kiril advocated forcing the children captured by the pack to fight to the death, thereby allowing only the strongest to live. Emil favored turning all of the children into werewolves, thereby swelling the pack's ranks. Emil's actions caused a schism in the pack, and Strahd locked him in the South Dungeon (K75) as punishment. If encountered by the PCs, Emil claims to be a resident of Vallaki who was chased by dire wolves to the castle. If freed, he betrays the PCs as soon as an opportunity arises in order to prove his worth to Strahd. However, if the PCs have previously met his wife, Zuleika, in the Werewolf Den, Emil doesn't betray the party, and instead works with them to reunite with her.

OBJECTIVES IN THE CASTLE

There are several reasons why your PCs might visit Castle Ravenloft. Each of these scenarios will be explored in more depth in the sections "The Dinner," "The Heist," and "The Finale" later in this chapter. See below for a brief description of the different objectives your PCs might have when entering the castle.

Attending the Dinner. Your PCs may visit Castle Ravenloft to attend dinner with Strahd. This "dinner" can take two forms. In the original module, Strahd sends an invitation to dine when the PCs anger or impress him in some way. When the PCs arrive, they find that the Strahd in the dining

hall is an illusion, and the dinner itself was a trap. In the community revisions, the "dinner" is an opportunity for a low/mid-level party to safely socialize with Strahd while observing Castle Ravenloft as guests, before any significant animosity has developed. More information about this "dinner" can be found in the "Visits to the Castle" section below.

Recovering an Artifact. Your PCs may infiltrate Castle Ravenloft to recover the Sunsword, Holy Symbol of Ravenkind, or Tome of Strahd, as foretold by Madam Eva or Ezmerelda's Tarokka reading. They may also venture into Ravenloft to meet their destined ally, if that ally is Pidwick II or Sir Klutz.

Locating Tasha Petrovna's Holy Symbol.

The PCs may enter Castle Ravenloft in effort to recover Tasha Petrovna's holy symbol, which must be returned to the priestess' grave in Krezk. The symbol possesses no power of its own, but reveals a *ring of regeneration* if taken to its proper place. This is most often included as part of a PC's personal quest if you used this guide's revised Adventure Hook chapter. Tasha Petrovna's holy symbol can be found in Crypt 11 of the Catacombs (K84).

Retrieving Argynvost's Skull. If your PCs have previously visited Argynvostholt and heard Argynvost's request, they may venture to Castle Ravenloft to recover the dragon's skull and return it to its rightful place in his mausoleum. Argynvost's skull is mounted in the Hall of Bones (K67).

Exploring & Looting Ravenloft. Certain daring and intrepid—not to mention suicidal—adventurers may venture into Castle Ravenloft to explore its shadowed

passageways and loot its priceless treasures. They will likely be most interested in the Treasury (K41) and the contents of the Catacombs (K84)—but beware. Strahd does not easily endure the company of thieves.

Rescuing Emil. If the PCs have previously met Zuleika in the Werewolf Den, they may have agreed to rescue her husband, Emil, from his place in Strahd's dungeons. Emil can be found imprisoned in the South Dungeon (K75), and will gladly join the PCs if they mention his wife.

Rescuing Ireena or Ally. If Strahd has successfully kidnapped Ireena or one of the PCs' other allies, such as Ezmerelda, Ismark, or a member of the Keepers of the Feather, the PCs may attempt to rescue them from the castle. To do so, the PCs must first learn where their friend is being hidden, and must then find a way to free them from Strahd's clutches.

Killing Strahd. Nearly all campaigns will culminate in a final battle against Strahd in the dark corridors of Ravenloft. Can your PCs defeat Strahd within the seat of his power? Or will they fall to his dark machinations—another band of misguided souls now lost to the ages?

DANGERS OF THE CASTLE

Castle Ravenloft is full of dangers and threats, from traps to hostile creatures, environmental hazards, and more. Here's a full list of what you should expect (and what your players should fear) while running Castle Ravenloft.²²²

MECHANICAL & MAGICAL THREATS

Castle Ravenloft is full of mechanical and magical threats—traps, devices, spells, and contraptions that trigger when the PCs misstep, often to the party's horror and surprise.

MAIN FLOOR

K10. Dining Hall. An illusion of Strahd greets the PCs. After three rounds, the illusion vanishes, extinguishing all open flames and torches and causing the castle drawbridge to lift, sealing the PCs inside the keep.

K15. Chapel. The *Icon of Ravenloft* upon the altar, if touched by an evil character, deals 16d10 radiant damage.

K19. Grand Landing. Both suits of armor lining the staircases to the Audience Hall (K25) are mechanical traps; a creature that steps on a pressure plate in front of a suit of armor causes it to spring forward and attack with its mace.

COURT OF THE COUNT

K27. King's Hall. Upon reaching the halfway point of this corridor, the PCs encounter a flying vampiric mannequin disguised to resemble Strahd, which may startle them into wasting spell slots or other resources to attack it.

ROOMS OF WEEPING

K38. False Treasury. The empty chest in this chamber, when opened, releases a cloud of sleeping gas that fills the room, causing a paralysis that lasts for four hours.

²²² /u/RealLifeWaterfowl, [Encounter Roster—Castle Ravenloft](#)

LARDERS OF ILL OMEN

K61. Elevator Trap. When an unwary party places at least 400 pounds of pressure on a 10-foot pressure plate in this hallway facade (e.g., three ordinary Medium creatures or two tanky Medium creatures), they trigger an elevator that rockets them up four floors to K47 (Portrait of Strahd), while also filling the interior with sleeping gas. The elevator is audible throughout the castle, and swiftly attracts Strahd's attention. Cyrus Belview, if he is with the PCs, will attempt to intentionally trigger this trap.

DUNGEONS & CATACOMBS

K73. Dungeon Hall. Hidden under the surface of the water lurk five submerged trapdoors. For every 10 pounds of weight on a trapdoor, there is a five percent chance that it will open—a Medium character that weighs 150 pounds has a 75 percent chance of triggering a given trapdoor. Each trapdoor, when opened, is linked to a magical teleport trap that teleports its victim to one of the cells in the North Dungeon (K74) or South Dungeon (K75).

K79. Western Stair. The midpoint landing of this staircase contains a hidden *glyph of warding*. If activated, it conjures an aggressive illusion of Strahd, which may startle the PCs into wasting spell slots or other resources to attack it.

K81. Tunnel. The midpoint of this tunnel bears a trapdoor that opens when 100 pounds of weight or more are placed upon it. When it opens, everyone standing on it slides into the marble chute below (K82), which deposits them into a flooded dungeon cell (K74e).

K84. Catacombs. The three corridors that lead to Strahd's Tomb (K86) are defended by invisible teleport traps 10 feet across. Any creature that steps inside of a trap is teleported into a coffin beneath Crypt 15, trading places with a **wight** that attacks anyone who remains near Strahd's tomb.

Crypt 28. A creature that rings the bell of Bascal Ofenheiss causes magic fire to sweep through the crypt, scorching the chef's bones—and anyone in the crypt.

Crypt 31. The floor of the crypt is actually the cover of a 30-foot-deep spiked pit. The cover opens if 100 pounds of weight or more are placed on it. It splits down the middle, east to west, and its doors are spring-loaded. After a victim or victims fall into the pit, its doors snap shut.

Crypt 32. Creatures that enter the eastern alcove of this crypt are teleported to the eastern alcove of Strahd's tomb (area K86).

Crypt 35. The floor here is an illusion that hides a 20-foot-deep pit. The sides of the pit are polished smooth; a creature without a climbing speed can't move along them without the aid of magic or a climber's kit. At the bottom of the pit are six starving ghouls. A permanent silence spell suppresses sound in the pit.

Crypt 37. If the brass-knobbed end of Gralmore Nimblenobs' staff is placed in the recess in the marble slab, the holder of the staff takes 22 (4d10) lightning damage.

GUARDIANS & DEFENSIVE

ENCOUNTERS

Several dangerous encounters within Castle Ravenloft are entirely optional—so long as your PCs don't stray from the path.

However, if your PCs insist on unwisely poking the bear, they may activate one of these guardian monsters or defensive combat encounters.

MAIN FLOOR

K20. Heart of Sorrow. If a creature damages the Heart of Sorrow, Strahd telepathically summons four **vampire spawn** to attack. The tower also animates 10 **animated halberds** to attack.

COURT OF THE COUNT

K30. King's Accountant. If Lieg Lipsiege, Strahd's accountant, feels threatened, he instantly pulls the rope near his desk, summoning one of the following encounters to protect him, which arrive in 1d6 rounds: 1d6 **shadows**, 1d4 **vampire spawn**, 1d4 **wights**, or 1 **wraith** and 1d4 + 1 **specters**.

ROOMS OF WEEPING

K40. Belfry. If a creature pulls the rope and rings the bell, or attempts to climb the rope, it causes five **giant spiders** to drop from their webs and attack.

K43. Bath Chamber. If a creature disturbs the blood in the tub, they are surprised by a terrifying (though harmless) apparition of Varushka, the tormented spirit of a former maid of Ravenloft.

K46. Parapets. If the PCs linger on the parapets for more than five minutes, they encounter **Strahd's animated armor** making its rounds around the keep (unless the armor has previously been provided to one of the PCs as a gift).

SPIRES OF RAVENLOFT

K60a. North Tower Rooftop. Characters who remain on the roof for more than three rounds are accosted by 10 **swarms of bats**.

LARDERS OF ILL OMEN

K63. Wine Cellar. A character that breaks the middle southern cask frees a **black pudding** that bursts forth and attacks.

K65. Kitchen. A character that looks into the pot angers three **zombies** that rise up from its bubbling depths and attack.

DUNGEON AND CATACOMBS

K74a. North Dungeon. A character that enters this otherwise-empty cell is attacked by an effectively invisible **gray ooze**.

K78. Brazier Room. If the brazier, hourglass, or either golem is attacked, the doors of the room magically slam shut and lock, and the two **iron golems** in this room animate and attack.

Crypt 4. A creature that opens this crypt risks possession by the **ghost** of Prince Ariel du Plumette, who attempts to hurl a possessed PC down the High Tower Shaft (K18a).

Crypt 7. If the bones on the slab are disturbed, one of the **gargoyles** in the crypt animates and attacks. If it is destroyed, the second gargoyle animates and attacks.

Crypt 14. If a creature lifts the lid of one of the occupied coffins in the vault below this crypt, the wight within attacks.

Crypt 20. Once the **vampire spawn** in this crypt realizes that the characters aren't Strahd, she attacks.

Crypt 21. Patrina Velikovna, the **banshee** inside this crypt, attacks as soon as the door is opened. If her brother, Kasimir, is with the party, she may be persuaded to cease her attack. Once awakened, she is free to roam Castle Ravenloft.

Crypt 38. A character that opens this crypt frees three **hell hounds** and a **wraith** that attack on sight.

Crypt 39. A character that opens this crypt is attacked by Beucephalus, Strahd's **nightmare**.

SURPRISE ATTACKS & AMBUSHES

Castle Ravenloft is a dangerous place, full of predatory creatures lying in wait for prey to wander past. Here's a list of the surprise attacks and hidden ambushes that your PCs might face as they explore Castle Ravenloft.

MAIN FLOOR

K7. Entry. Any creature that attempts to leave the castle via this entrance causes the four statues of **red dragon wyrmlings** to animate and attack.

K8. Great Entry. The first time the PCs enter this room after leaving it, the eight **gargoyles** animate and attack.

COURT OF THE COUNT

K32. Maid in Hell. If the PCs allow Helga Ruvak to join their party, the **vampire spawn** attacks as soon as she is able to isolate one of the PCs.

ROOMS OF WEEPING

K35. Guardian Vermin. Anyone that tries to move through this area is attacked by four **swarms of rats** piled atop one another to form manlike shapes.

SPIRES OF RAVENLOFT

K47. Portrait of Strahd. Any person that moves across or disturbs the **rug of smothering** activates it. If the PCs attack or attempt to remove the rug or disturb the portrait of Strahd on the wall, the portrait (a **guardian portrait**) attacks.

K54. Familiar Room. If the three familiars in this room see the characters, the witches in area K56 (Cauldron) are notified of their presence and cast *invisibility*, hoping to surprise any intruders.

LARDERS OF ILL OMEN

K62. Servants' Hall. If the characters follow Cyrus, he will attempt to intentionally activate the Elevator Trap (K61).

K69. Guards' Quarters. When one or more characters reach the midpoint of this hall, 10 human **skeletons** leap from the alcoves and attack.

K72. Chamberlain's Office. If he has not been defeated elsewhere, **Rahadin** is here, waiting for the PCs to arrive so he can kill them. He is swiftly joined by a **shadow demon**.

DUNGEON AND CATACOMBS

K75a. South Dungeon. If the PCs free Emil Toranescu from his cell, the **werewolf** attacks them as soon as a good opportunity arises.

K76. As soon as a character moves more than 10 feet into this room, six **Strahd zombies** rise from the water and attack.

HAZARDS & ENVIRONMENTAL

DANGERS

Castle Ravenloft is not meant for human habitation—a fact your players will soon discover. Strahd, however, knows every twist and turn of his castle, and won't hesitate to use these dangers to his advantage. See below for a list of dangerous hazards and environmental risks that can complicate any combat (or peaceful) encounter.

MAIN FLOOR

K20. Heart of Sorrow. The awakened tower shakes and pitches on the Heart of Sorrow's initiative count. Any creature on the stairs or hanging on a tower wall must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or fall to the base of the tower, falling:

- 50 feet (5d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the second floor
- 90 feet (9d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the third floor (e.g., the landing adjacent to the Hall of Heroes)
- 130 feet (13d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the fourth floor (e.g., the stairs at the same level as the Lounge and Guest Room)
- 150 feet (15d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the fifth floor (e.g., the stairs at the same level as the Element Room and Cauldron)
- 170 feet (17d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the sixth floor (the landing closest to the Heart of Sorrow)
- 220 feet (20d6 bludgeoning damage) if on the seventh floor (the

stairs leading up to the North Tower Peak)²²³

Characters who are crawling on the staircase or who lie prone on the stairs succeed automatically.

COURT OF THE COUNT

K29. Creaky Landing. The creatures in area K28 (King's Balcony) can't be surprised by anyone climbing these creaky steps.

ROOMS OF WEEPING

K39. Hall of Webs. Most of this hall is full of giant spider webs. Characters who stray from the unobstructed path through the webs risk becoming stuck.

HAZARD: WEBS

These web-filled areas are difficult terrain. Moreover, a creature entering a webbed area for the first time on a turn or starting its turn there must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or become restrained by the webs. A restrained creature can use its action to try to escape, doing so with a successful DC 12 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check. Each 10-foot cube of giant webs has AC 10, 15 hit points, vulnerability to fire, and immunity to bludgeoning, piercing, and psychic damage.

K40. Belfry. Most of the belfry is filled with giant spider webs. Characters who blunder into them risk becoming stuck.

K46. Parapets. A creature that falls or is dropped off of the walls of the keep falls 90 feet to the castle courtyard below.

223 /u/Riizu, [Curse of Strahd Map Analysis & Possible Height Discrepancy \(Castle Ravenloft\)](#)

SPIRES OF RAVENLOFT

K53. Rooftop. A character must succeed on a DC 15 Acrobatics check to traverse the roof. The check succeeds automatically if the character crawls. If the check fails by 5 or more, the character slides off the edge of the room and falls 40 feet to the Parapets (K46).

K58. Bridge. A creature that takes damage while standing on this bridge must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or fall 60 feet onto the roof of the keep.

DUNGEON AND CATACOMBS

Crypt 29. This room is filled with **brown mold**.

HAZARD: BROWN MOLD

When a creature moves to within 5 feet of the mold for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there, it must make a DC 12 Constitution saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) cold damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Brown mold is immune to fire, and any source of fire brought within 5 feet of a patch causes it to instantly expand outward in the direction of the fire, covering a 10-foot-square area (with the source of the fire at the center of that area). A patch of brown mold exposed to an effect that deals cold damage is instantly destroyed.

K87. Guardians. A creature of lawful good alignment can pass through the magical curtain of light into the tomb without difficulty, but creatures of other alignments that do so are teleported back to the top of the stairs behind them. A Small creature can squeeze behind and around one of the bronze statues to circumvent the light curtain.

STRAHD'S RESOURCES

No good villain acts alone, and Strahd is no different. A five-hundred-year-old vampire, a former general, and an experienced mage, Strahd can draw upon a wealth of minions, monsters, and resources within Castle Ravenloft to supplement his own formidable skills.

THE BRIDES

Strahd's three most favored brides—Ludmilla, Anastrasya, and Volenta—have proved their worth and loyalty to Strahd many times over. Whether Strahd needs a lieutenant to command his minions in a certain part of the castle, a guardian to protect a valuable treasure or important prisoner, or an envoy to another part of Barovia, his brides are always an excellent option.

Ludmilla. As a mage, Ludmilla is most adept in situations that require cunning, skill, and unique abilities. Whenever Strahd requires a servant to oversee a complex scheme or trap, Ludmilla is his most reliable companion.

Anastrasya. A diplomat and warrior both, Anastrasya is well-equipped to hold her own on the battlefield and in the ballroom. When Strahd requires a diplomatic emissary to the PCs, Anastrasya is his first choice—especially if a betrayal is in the cards.

Volenta. Volenta is blunt, violent, and sadistic above all else. Strahd does not care to use her for fine, detail-oriented tasks, but he is glad to make use of her bloodlust for any battle or objective that can be summarized with the words: "Kill it 'til it's dead."

When necessary, Strahd can also call upon the services of two additional brides: Escher and Sasha Ivlskova.

Escher. A skilled musician and fanciful conversationalist, Escher is adept at luring Strahd's guests into a false sense of security, even when among the dark spires of Castle Ravenloft. Though he will do his best to avoid Strahd's attention in times of strife, he can also be commanded to wield his musical talents to bind and incapacitate Strahd's enemies in battle.

Sasha. Though currently imprisoned beneath Castle Ravenloft, Sasha is useful to Strahd in other ways—specifically, as a triple-agent meant to gain the PCs' trust. Desperate to prove her worth (and win her freedom) for Strahd, Sasha will gladly do her best to persuade the PCs that she stands with them against Strahd—only to betray them at the worst possible moment.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Castle Ravenloft is full of dark and deadly creatures, from **vampire spawn** to **wights**, **Barovian witches**, **shadows**, **swarms of bats**, and much more. You should assume that Strahd is always aware of the location of all random encounters throughout Ravenloft, and that—if given sufficient time (i.e., at least one hour), he can organize and assign all potential random encounters to specific posts or tasks throughout the castle.

BEUCEPHALUS

Beucephalus, Strahd's **nightmare**, is one of his most lethal weapons. Using his **Ethereal Jaunt** ability, this demonic horse can lurk in the Ethereal Plane close to Strahd's side, constantly prepared to enter the Material Plane and whisk Strahd away

to safety. If Strahd has the ability, foresight, and time to do so (i.e., at least one hour), he will always rouse Beucephalus from his place in the crypts below the castle to assist him in combat.

THE BRAZIER ROOM

Using this teleportation device, not only can Strahd instantly transport himself and/or his servants (e.g., Beucephalus, Rahadin, one of his brides, or any number of minions) to one of several locations throughout Barovia. Additionally, the magical brazier can provide access to several locations around the castle, including the Study (K37), Strahd's Tomb (K86), and the North Tower Peak (K60).

TREASURY

The plundered riches of Strahd's secret hoard in the Treasury (K41) form a priceless collection. Only teleportation or the *Polymorph* spell can allow another creature entry; otherwise, only Strahd and any creature that knows the command word ("Mordite") can open the sealed adamantine door at its base or the adamantine trapdoor on the roof. As such, this magic tower can serve as a prime location to store the PCs' stolen weapons and magic items (e.g., the *Sunsword* or *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind*), as well as a high-security prison in the event that the North and South Dungeon (K74 and K75) are suboptimal or undesirable.

However, under no circumstances does Strahd make use of the magic items within this hoard. The +2 *shield* of the Order of the Silver Dragon bears the emblem of an order he despises; the *helm of brilliance* deals damage to him and his undead minions; and the +1 *rod of the pact keeper*, *potions of greater healing*, and *alchemy jug* are functionally useless to him. He may,

however, use the gold and jewels within as rewards for loyal adventurers.

DUNGEONS

In the event that Strahd captures a PC or an allied NPC, he can manacle and imprison them in one of the empty cells of the North Dungeon (K74) or South Dungeon (K75). If he does so, he confiscates all of their weapons, holy symbols, arcane focuses, and other equipment, and stores it in the Treasury (K41).

ARCHERS' POSTS

Castle Ravenloft is a classic medieval keep, and keeps were built for the explicit purpose of defense. As such, any ranged attackers—such as wights, Barovian witches, or charmed **Barovian scouts** that Strahd has kidnapped from Vallaki or Barovia—are free to use the South and North Archers' Posts (K11 and K22) on the first, second, and third levels to fire at any unwanted intruders. That especially includes anyone that might attempt to enter the castle by air.

CATACOMB INHABITANTS

Several of the inhabitants of the Catacombs (K84) are deadly when unleashed, and can make excellent obstacles to a party of PCs invading the castle through its lower floors. The **giant wolf spiders** (Crypt 27) and the **hell hounds and wraith** (Crypt 38) can prove useful shock troops, as can the hundreds of **swarms of bats** (2d4 swarms per 10-foot square), which attack when provoked or on Strahd's command.

Additionally, Strahd will make full use of the many traps and hazards throughout the Catacombs, especially the invisible teleport traps, the brown mold (Crypt 29), the spiked pit (Crypt 31), and the **ghoul** pit (Crypt 35).

CRACKED WALLS

Two cracked walls exist in Castle Ravenloft, each one wide enough to allow Strahd's mist form to pass through: one between the Wine Cellar (K63) and the High Tower Stair (K18); and one in the High Tower Stair (K18) between the Chapel (K15) and the Catacombs (K84). Should you choose to remove Strahd's Lair Action that allows him to pass through walls, floors, and ceilings (see **Strahd's Tactics** below for more information on modifying and using Strahd's stat block), these two passages can prove invaluable for allowing Strahd to move quickly through the castle.

VISITS TO THE CASTLE

There are several occasions on which your PCs may visit Castle Ravenloft. These visits may be voluntary, born from desperation, or by Strahd's will alone.

Here's what to expect in some of the more frequent types of visits to Strahd's keep.

1. THE DINNER

In the original module, "Dinner at Ravenloft" is a trap laid by Strahd. When the PCs do something sufficiently impressive or aggravating, Strahd sends them a letter inviting them to dinner at Castle Ravenloft. They are peacefully escorted to the castle by the Count's black carriage, greeted by Rahadin, and directed to the Dining Hall where they encounter an illusion of Strahd. The illusion summarily vanishes, the castle drawbridge lifts, and the PCs are left trapped in a castle of nightmares.

The dinner didn't become a "true" dinner (in which the PCs actually dined with Strahd) until the earliest community guides. In these versions, the dinner was either an opportunity for Strahd to sow seeds of

division in the party, or it was the starting point of the final battle, where Strahd delivered his ultimatum to a party that had become too powerful or bothersome to contain.

Today, however, most DMs use the dinner with Strahd as an opportunity for a low-level party (anywhere between 4th and 6th level) to encounter Strahd in-person—potentially for the first time. Not only does this let the PCs socialize with him in a low-stakes, low-conflict context, it also familiarizes them with the villain of the campaign and his lair while giving Strahd additional insight into their histories, secrets, and motivations.

STRAHD'S INVITATION

Strahd invites the PCs to dine at Castle Ravenloft the first time that the PCs complete any of the following objectives:

- Restore the bones of Saint Andral to the church in Vallaki
- Fend off the attacking vampire spawn during the Feast of Saint Andral special event
- Overthrow Baron Vargas Vallakovich and reinstall a new Vallakian burgomaster
- Defeat the Forest Folk at Yester Hill
- Clear the werewolf pack from the Werewolf Den
- Neutralize the night hag coven at Old Bonegrinder

His goal in extending this invitation is as follows:

- To take measure of the PCs as people and as heroes
- To flaunt his power over these newcomers to his land

- To scope out potential successors or new consorts

When the PCs draw Strahd's attention by completing one of the listed objectives, he sends Rahadin, his chamberlain, to hand-deliver his invitation to dinner. (If, for some reason, Rahadin is indisposed or is poorly disposed toward the PCs, Anastrasya delivers the message instead.)

Rahadin arrives in Strahd's black carriage, and informs the party that their presence is expected at Castle Ravenloft. He does not depart when the invitation is delivered; rather, he waits for the PCs to accept or refuse the invitation in person.

If the PCs accept the invitation, Rahadin bows, and notes that his Lord awaits their presence eagerly. If the PCs reject the invitation, Rahadin activates his Deathly Choir ability as a warning sign, and reminds them that Count von Zarovich does not take kindly to those who refuse his hospitality. (If the PCs again reject the invitation, Rahadin nods and departs, but warns the PCs that they may come to regret their rudeness).

If the PCs ask Rahadin for more time to decide, he curtly informs them that the date of the occasion is marked on the invitation, and warns them not to offend his Lord by rejecting his hospitality. He then departs.

No matter what, Rahadin assures the PCs that their travel to the castle will be a peaceful one; that they shall be free to come and go as they please during the dinner; that no harm shall come to them by Strahd's hand or that of any creature that serves him during the dinner; and that, should they accept, their transportation to

dinner will meet them beyond the Barovian Gates to the east of Vallaki.

The invitation is as follows:

My friends,

I am honored to have hosted you in this land, my home, and look forward to meeting you in person. I have heard tell of your activities in my domain, and wish to know those who have arrived in my beloved land of Barovia. As such, I bid you dine at my castle in three nights' time so that we may meet in civilized surroundings.

Your passage here will be a safe one, and you shall have full privileges of hospitality and guest right for as long as you remain at Castle Ravenloft.

I await your arrival.

*Your host,
Count Strahd von Zarovich*

STRAHD'S REMINDER

If the PCs refuse or defer Rahadin's invitation, Strahd visits them in person within the next forty-eight hours. He may appear without pomp or circumstance, but is more likely to arrive while the PCs are preoccupied with or have recently completed another major task (e.g., battling the Forest Folk at Yester Hill).

When he does, he appears atop Beucephalus, and may be accompanied by Anastrasya, if he feels that her diplomatic skills may be useful.

He greets the PCs warmly, inquiring after them by name even if he's not met them personally before. He congratulates them on their most recent accomplishments, praising the specific achievements of

individual PCs (especially those who he sees as potential consorts or successors), and shares his experiences with their current tasks or recent objectives.

For example, Strahd may reflect on the mythology of the Wall of Fog and the history of the Forest Folk if the PCs have just cleared Yester Hill, or he may discuss the history of the Vallakovich family if the PCs have recently overthrown Vargas' rule. He then asks how the PCs are enjoying their time in Barovia, and gently reminds them of his invitation. He then asks to confirm their attendance.

If the PCs accept Strahd's invitation, he bows, notes that he looks forward to seeing them and getting to know them better, and leaves.

If the PCs reject Strahd's invitation, his mood darkens, and he asks them—politely—if they mean to offend him. If necessary, he will (truthfully) reassure the PCs that no harm will come to them for the duration of their visit, aiming to proactively dismiss any fears they might have regarding his honesty.

If the PCs continue to reject his invitation, Strahd shares his regrets that his hospitality was not to their taste, and states simply that he shall not make the mistake of offering the party his friendship again. He then leaves.

From then on, Strahd will actively seek to torment the PCs, both personally and through proxies, while working to forcibly remove Ireena (if present) from their party. After all, it would be unbecoming of him to entrust his bride's safety to the hands of uncivilized brutes.

THE BLACK CARRIAGE

When the PCs arrive at the western Barovian Gate, they are met by Strahd's black carriage, which opens its door at their approach. On the carriage seat, Strahd has left a parchment-wrapped parcel and a small note sealed in crimson wax.

The note reads simply: "A gift for your arrival.—S.v.Z."

The parcel contains multiple black, velvet-lined traveller's cloaks with silver trim, accompanied by pairs of gloves of similar make, with one set included for each visitor that Strahd is expecting.

WELCOME TO RAVENLOFT

When the PCs arrive at Ravenloft, they are greeted by Rahadin in the Great Entry (K8). He welcomes them to the castle, and notes that the lord of the castle, Strahd, is currently occupied, but will be with them shortly.

The group is swiftly joined by Escher and Sasha Ivlskova. Escher jovially greets the PCs, and shamelessly flirts with any attractive male party members (while making equally shameless vampire puns). Sasha, who has been freed from her crypt for the duration of the evening, keeps to herself and greets the PCs with quiet, monosyllabic responses.

If the PCs have not otherwise prepared for the occasion by cleaning themselves and purchasing formal wear, Rahadin notes his mild disgust for the PCs' dirt-stained, blood-marked clothing, and informs the PCs that they must make a good first impression if they are to be allowed to dine with the lord of Ravenloft. He then directs the PCs to

follow Sasha and Escher to the guest room and lounge upstairs, where they will be cleaned and suitably dressed for the occasion.

If the PCs refuse to change, Rahadin does not force them to do so, but makes his displeasure clear. He does, however, request that they wait in the lounge with Escher and Sasha until Strahd is ready to receive them.

GETTING DRESSED

If the PCs agree to dress for the occasion, Escher and Sasha lead them to the lounge (K49), where Ludmilla is waiting for them. If the PCs have previously encountered Ludmilla at the Feast of Saint Andral, she apologizes for her actions, and notes that Count von Zarovich has disciplined her for her errors.

Each PC is asked to enter the Guest Room, strip to their smallclothes, and allow Ludmilla to use the *prestidigitation* cantrip to slowly and carefully remove any grime, blood, and sweat from the PCs' skin. The PC is then directed to dress in a set of fine clothing chosen by Strahd himself, and returned to the lounge, where Escher happily and chattily brushes their hair using a tarnished silver hairbrush.

Any creature that exits the lounge is swiftly met by Rahadin, who instructs them to return to their companions.

When the PCs leave the castle after dinner (see "Gifts from the Count" below), Sasha returns them their clothes, now neatly cleaned and folded. When the PCs go to change, they will each notice that a small garment of theirs—e.g., a stocking, a sock, or a belt—is now missing.

Escher carefully cleans the hairbrush between brushings, and provides Strahd with the hairs (and the stolen garments) for use in scrying.

THE DINNER

When the PCs are fully dressed, or at a suitable moment after they've waited in the lounge, they are summoned downstairs by Rahadin to enter the dining hall.

There, Strahd is waiting for them, playing a mournful melody on the pipe organ as described in the original module. When the song concludes, he turns and greets them warmly, by name.

Strahd welcomes the PCs to Ravenloft, and inquires after their health, their enjoyment of their journey to Ravenloft, and their time in the valley of Barovia. He asks how they have enjoyed their time in his land, and asks their opinion on Castle Ravenloft. During this time, Escher and Sasha, assisted by a pair of **unseen servants** bearing trays of wine glasses and bottles of Red Dragon Crush wine, serve drinks and small refreshments to the party.

When Strahd feels that introductions have come to an end, he invites the PCs to take a seat at the table. Once they have, Escher and Sasha, once more assisted by the unseen servants, swiftly bring forth an assortment of delicious foods and drinks, as described in the original module. Strahd himself takes a glass of wine alongside a plate of roast pig and root vegetables, but a player with a passive perception greater than 15 notices that Strahd never touches his food, and that the liquid in his wineglass is a deeper, fuller red than that in the players' glasses.

While eating, Strahd engages the PCs in a lively conversation, exploring their histories, interests, goals, passions, and experiences. If needed, he shares information from his own past, such as his conquest of Barovia, his tales of previous guests of the castle, or his relationship with King Barov and Queen Ravenovia. He is instantly intrigued by any PC that studies magic or deals with dark powers, and enjoys theological discussions and debates with clerics, paladins, and druids. He may ask PCs where they studied, how they gained their experience, or what drew them to their field of interest. While he may share information about himself as-needed, he prefers listening to speaking, and will always turn an anecdote about himself into a question regarding a PC's history or interests. He displays genuine interest at all times, and is glad to be vulnerable, even to the point of discussing the nature of the curse of vampirism—with three exceptions:

- He never mentions his brother, Sergei, or acknowledges the nature of his death
- He never mentions or acknowledges the nature of Tatyana's death, or the events of her wedding day
- He never shares or discusses the source of his vampiric curse (the Amber Temple), or his reasons for obtaining it

Halfway through the conversation, Escher informs the party that they've run out of wine, and asks for help in bringing up a fresh barrel, claiming that it's too heavy for him to carry alone. If a PC accepts, he guides them downstairs via the South Tower Stair (K21), over the Elevator Trap (K61), and through the Servants' Hall into

the Wine Cellar (K63). The Elevator Trap has been deactivated, leaving a noticeable divot in the stone floor.

The door to the Kitchen (K65) is open; as they pass, the PC clearly notices a dead Barovian—a young man or woman—hung upside-down from the ceiling, their blood slowly draining into a large basin below. Escher notices their glance, and, shrugging, asks: “You didn’t forget that you were having dinner with monsters, did you?” He flashes a fanged smile and continues forward, retrieving a fresh barrel of Red Dragon Crush before returning upstairs.

While Escher is downstairs, Strahd occupied himself in conversation with one of the other PCs specifically. Sasha, taking advantage of the distraction, slips a note into one of the PCs’ laps while refilling their drink. The note, if unfurled, reads: “Not everyone here is an enemy.”

This note is a lie. Strahd directed Sasha to deliver it to the PCs as payment for being permitted to leave her crypt for the evening. However, if confronted, Sasha insists that the note was genuine, and will willingly assist the PCs with any schemes they may have in Castle Ravenloft—even while keeping Strahd informed as to their plans and secretly working to trap or sabotage them.

TOUR OF THE CASTLE

After dinner, Strahd offers the PCs a tour of Castle Ravenloft. If the PCs accept, he leads them on the following route:

- Guests’ Hall (K9)
- Great Entry (K8)
- Hall of Faith (K14)
- Chapel (K15)

- North Chapel Access (K16)
- Creaky Landing (K29)
- King’s Balcony (K28)
- King’s Hall (K27)
- Guards’ Post (K26)
- Audience Hall (K25)

The PCs face no random encounters as they explore. Additionally, the **Strahd zombies** have been removed from Area K28, and the Flight of the Vampire trap has been disabled in Area K27. The “floating” skeletons from Area K26 have been similarly removed. Strahd and Ludmilla have also placed a glamor over these public areas of the castle, covering up the cobwebs, dust, and other signs of desecration or disrepair. A *detect magic* spell, however, or a character inspecting their surroundings too closely reveals the illusion.

During the tour, Strahd shares the history of the castle, including notable guests (e.g., Duchess Dilisnya, Pidlwick, or Patrina Velikovna), its major architects (Khazan and Artimus), and the religious symbolism of the Morninglord and Mother Night. If asked about the fate of the castle’s guests or builders, he shares solemnly that their bodies rest in the catacombs beneath the castle.

If asked for a tour of other parts of the castle, Strahd apologizes, noting that several areas of the keep are devoted to private quarters or are under reconstruction, and may be too dangerous to host visitors.

Strahd does not move to stop any PC who attempts to sneak away during this tour. However, all doors are locked (using Strahd’s lair action), and any PC whose Stealth check fails to exceed Strahd’s

passive Perception is swiftly met by Rahadin, who confronts them with catlike grace and insists that they return to their companions, lest they fall into danger while exploring somewhere they shouldn't. A PC that goes undetected by Strahd has 2d4 minutes to explore the castle alone, after which Rahadin finds them and attempts to return them to the party.

DANCING WITH THE BRIDES

When the tour concludes in the Audience Hall, Strahd and the PCs are met by Ludmilla, Anastrasya, and Volenta, as well as a number of magically animated instruments. As the music plays, Strahd invites the PCs to dance with each other or any of his brides, and personally dances or converses with any PC who may make a suitable successor or consort. During this time, Strahd pries deeper into his dance partner's history and goals, and attempts to gauge their worthiness for his throne or companionship.

During this time, Anastrasya looks to dance with the PC who appears most easy to manipulate, and looks to extract any secrets or hidden information that she can.

Ludmilla dances if she must, but is tight-lipped and unfriendly.

Volenta happily latches onto whichever PC appears most visually striking, and serenades them with joyful babbles and questions regarding her morbid interests (e.g., "Did you know how much blood is in a churchmouse?"). After she's regaled the PC with her childlike, but disturbing hobbies, she asks the PC if they're interested in seeing her artistic "masterpiece." Regardless of their answer, she attempts to drag them downstairs to the Hall of Bones

(K67) via the King's Accountant (K30) and the South Tower Stair (K21), where she gleefully presents the ossuary she's constructed alongside Cyrus Belview—including the enormous dragon's skull she found mounted in the castle courtyard.

At some point, either before or after Volenta has departed, Escher enters the hall alongside Lief Lipsiege, Strahd's accountant. Lief does not dance, but will sip a glass of wine while glowering from across the room.

GIFTS FROM THE COUNT

When the dancing has concluded, Strahd escorts the PCs to the Great Entry, where Rahadin awaits. If the PCs have impressed Strahd during the dinner, Rahadin is accompanied by three **unseen servants**, each one bearing a silver tray that holds one or more parcels.

Each parcel contains a small, personalized gift for one of the PCs (excluding any that insulted or failed to impress Strahd during the visit). These gifts are nonmagical, non-valuable trinkets, but are tailored to the PCs' individual interests. They may be a book of hymns to the Morninglord, a well-crafted instrument, a platinum dagger, or a notebook of alchemical theorems.

Before they depart, Strahd then offers the PCs a job. He informs them that an infamous assassin named Rudolph van Richten with a genocidal hatred for the Vistani has come to Barovia, and that van Richten seeks to slay Strahd for his role as the Vistani's protector. He warns the PCs that van Richten may appear to be an old man, but that he is a dangerous, wiley, paranoid individual with a lifetime's experience in death and a vast collection of

lies and cover stories at his disposal. If the PCs apprehend him—alive—and return him to Castle Ravenloft, Strahd truthfully promises them each a treasure from his vault.

Whether the PCs accept his job or not, Strahd bids them farewell, and provides them safe return passage to their choice of Vallaki or Barovia via his black carriage.

2. THE HEIST

There are several objectives within Castle Ravenloft that the PCs may want to complete before entering their final battle with Strahd. They may seek to fulfill a personal quest by returning Tasha Petrovna's holy symbol to the Abbey of Saint Markovia, put the revenants to rest by restoring the skull of Argynvost to its crypt at Argynvostholt, locate a foretold Tarokka treasure from the castle's depths, or rescue a kidnapped ally (or Ireena) from Strahd's clutches.

GETTING INSIDE

These castle infiltrations—or “heists”—will most likely take place while the PCs are between level 6 and level 8. As such, the PCs may not even have the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind* or *Sunsword* when they undertake this dangerous mission. Therefore, the PCs' first priority upon entering the castle is the same: Evade Strahd's attention, and avoid his wrath at all costs.

Strahd is not omniscient. While he has many spies and servants throughout Barovia and the castle, he does not have eyes and ears everywhere—including within Castle Ravenloft. As such, we can assume that there are four ways for Strahd to learn of the PCs' presence:

1. The activation of the drawbridge trap following the PCs' conversation with the illusion of Strahd in the Dining Hall (K9)
2. The activation of the Elevator Trap (K61)
3. A random encounter with Strahd himself within Castle Ravenloft
4. A foretold encounter with Strahd in the location predicted by the Tarokka reading

Only the third and fourth possibility bring Strahd directly to the PCs; in the first and second case, Strahd hears the trap from his coffin and arrives at the PCs' location in 4d4 rounds.

Strahd's brides are jealous, territorial, and prideful beings, and are under strict orders by Strahd to guard the grounds of Castle Ravenloft with their lives; if bested by the PCs, they will sooner die than flee. Rahadin is similarly dedicated, and will fight to the death if encountered.

However, if Strahd is notified of the PCs' intentions ahead of time (e.g., through his disguise as Vasili von Holtz, through a timely *scrying* spell, or through a report from his bestial or human spies that the PCs are heading toward the castle), he will track the PCs from the moment they enter the castle.

If Strahd has previously been suitably impressed by the PCs on a previous occasion, he may even allow them to carry out their mission unmolested. After all, the symbol of a dead saint holds little interest to him, the skull of a dead dragon is hardly more than a sentimental object, and he can always retrieve Ireena later.

The only exception is if the PCs retrieve one of the three foretold Tarokka items from Castle Ravenloft (the Holy Symbol, Sunsword, or Tome of Strahd). If he is aware of the PCs' presence and learns that they have obtained one such treasure within Castle Ravenloft's walls, Strahd will not allow the PCs to depart until that item is retrieved.

There are, however, two possible occasions when the PCs can visit Castle Ravenloft while Strahd is not present:

- **Red Moon.** Once per fortnight, halfway between the New Moon and Full Moon, a red moon rises over Barovia. On this night, Strahd visits the Wall of Fog on Yester Hill atop Beucephalus, where he gazes into the vision of his ancestral homeland beyond the mists. The PCs can learn of this from the Forest Folk, Mordenkainen, Rudolph van Richten, Ezmerelda, or Strahd himself (who may mention it to the PCs during the dinner at Castle Ravenloft or following the ritual at Yester Hill).
- **Blood Tax.** Should Fiona Wachter become Baron of Vallaki, she soon implements an old custom: the Blood Tax. Once per month, on a night chosen by Strahd, the vampire rides to Vallaki in his black carriage at midnight. There, he selects one Vallakian—always one with a soul—as tribute. The chosen townsfolk vanish with Strahd into the black carriage, and are never seen or heard from again.

A sufficiently ingenious party may also attempt to lure Strahd out of Castle

Ravenloft through other (difficult, and likely complex) means.

THE TARGETS

There are several objectives that the PCs may target while infiltrating Castle Ravenloft. Their purposes, locations, and means of access are as follows:

Tasha Petrovna's Holy Symbol. If one of your PCs has been given a personal Tarokka reading by Madam Eva that instructs them to recover Tasha Petrovna's holy symbol and restore it to the saint's grave at the Abbey of Saint Markovia, they can find the symbol in Tasha Petrovna's crypt (Crypt 11) in the Catacombs (K84). Once obtained, the symbol can be returned to the Sun's Grave in the Graveyard (S7) of the Abbey of Saint Markovia, where the PCs will receive a *ring of regeneration* as a reward.

Skull of Argynvost. If the PCs have previously undertaken Argynvost's quest at Argynvostholt, they can locate the dragon's skull in the Hall of Bones (K67). If they have previously attended dinner with Strahd, they may have recently seen the skull when shown Volenta's "masterpiece." The skull is heavy—250 pounds—and must be properly and carefully transported to the Dragon's Mausoleum (Q16) in Argynvostholt. Once placed there, the spirit of Argynvost will illuminate the beacon at the top of the highest tower, laying the revenants' spirits to rest and providing a +1 bonus to AC and saving throws for all creatures who oppose Strahd von Zarovich.

Tarokka Treasure. There are several locations within Castle Ravenloft where Madam Eva's Tarokka reading can place one of the Tarokka artifacts:

- The chapel (K15).
- The audience hall (K25)
- The study (K37)
- The treasury (K41)
- The north tower peak (K60)
- The wine cellar (K63)
- The Hall of Bones (K67)
- The crypt of Artank Swilovich (K84, Crypt 5)
- The crypt of Endorovich (K84, Crypt 7)
- The unnamed crypt in the catacombs (K84, Crypt 31)
- The crypt of Gralmore Nimblenobs (K84, Crypt 37)
- The crypt of General Kroval “Mad Dog” Grislek (K84, Crypt 38)
- Sergei’s tomb (K85)
- Strahd’s tomb (K86)
- The tomb of King Barov and Queen Ravenovia (K88)

Strahd is either unaware of the treasure’s location there (in the case of the Sunsword), has forgotten its presence (in the case of the Holy Symbol), or has spared little thought to it (in the case of the Tome of Strahd).

Kidnapped Ally. If Strahd has kidnapped one of the PCs’ allies (e.g., their foretold ally, one of the Martikovs, or another friendly NPC), they have been shackled, gagged (if capable of spellcasting), and imprisoned in the empty cells of either the North (K74) or South (K75) Dungeons.

If Strahd has kidnapped Ireena, or if Ireena has ventured willingly to Castle Ravenloft, she can be found in the King’s Bedchamber (K42), charmed by Strahd. For the duration of Ireena’s stay, Gertruda has been relocated to the Guest Room (K50).

However, if Strahd has already wed Ireena, she can be found in her crypt in the Catacombs (K84, Crypt 18) as a **vampire spawn**.

3. THE FINALE

All *Curse of Strahd* campaigns must end, and yours is no different. Unless the party has gained Strahd’s favor and therefore their freedom from the Barovian mists, their only escape from this cursed land is through Strahd’s death. As such, once they feel sufficiently prepared—most likely after reaching level 10, obtaining all three Tarokka items and their foretold ally, and potentially reconsecrating the Fanes of the Ladies Three, the PCs may choose of their own volition to storm Castle Ravenloft and slay the vampire at the location foretold by Madam Eva.

Throughout the campaign, Strahd will likely appear to the PCs time and time again, both in casual conversation and in open, hostile conflict. However, once the PCs grow sufficiently powerful (e.g., possessing both the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind* and the *Sunsword* while at level 8 or above), Strahd will not dare face them in open combat. As such, he may choose to initiate the final battle by forcing the PCs into a position where they must enter Castle Ravenloft—his lair and the seat of his power—and so fall by his hand.

INFILTRATING THE CASTLE

If the PCs aim to kill Strahd in accordance with Madam Eva’s fortune telling, they can enter the castle via any of the entrances listed above before making their way to the foretold location. If Strahd locates the PCs via random encounter or because of the Elevator Trap or drawbridge trap, he

retreats once wounded. If Strahd is encountered in the foretold location, he fights to the death to defend his lair (see “Strahd’s Tactics” below).

INVITED TO DINNER

If Strahd believes that the PCs may be tempted to leave Barovia rather than killing him (and if he believes that none of the PCs are capable of flight), he sends the following invitation via bat, Vistani, or (if he still lives) Rahadin:

My friends,

It would appear that we are at an impasse. While I have enjoyed this game that we have played, I am not without mercy—or without a sense of practicality.

It is my understanding that you seek to depart my lands for greener pastures. It has been a pleasure to host you in my domain, but it may yet be that your time in my lands is growing short.

Know that it was by my will that you entered Barovia, and by my will alone that you may yet leave it. I entreat you to join me at Castle Ravenloft to dine at your earliest convenience, where we may discuss the terms of your departure face-to-face.

I look forward to your arrival.

*Your gracious host,
Count Strahd von Zarovich*

This invitation is, of course, a trap. When the PCs arrive at the castle, they are directed by Rahadin (or another of Strahd’s surviving trusted servants) into the Dining Hall (K9). There, they are greeted by the illusion of Strahd described in the original module, which soon causes the lights to extinguish, the doors to slam shut, and the drawbridge to raise—trapping the PCs

within Castle Ravenloft. From then on, Strahd pursues the PCs throughout the castle, aiming to hunt them down one-by-one.

If this invitation goes ignored, and if the PCs continue to pose a threat to Strahd or his interests, he triggers the “Declaration of War” finale (see below) instead.

CRASHING THE WEDDING

If Strahd has previously kidnapped Ireena, or if the Ireena has made her way to Castle Ravenloft of her own volition, Strahd soon issues the following invitation to the PCs (which arrive via bat, or are delivered to their most common place of residence, such as the Blue Water Inn in Vallaki):

Count Strahd von Zarovich
son of the late King Barov and the late Queen Ravenovia, Conqueror of the Delmoreans, and Lord of Barovia

and

the Lady Ireena Kolyana
daughter of the late Burgomaster Kolyan Indirovich and the late Ira Mironova

*request the honor of your presence
at their wedding*

*upon the First Eve
of the Feast of the Moon
at sundown*

*The Chapel of the Sun
Castle Ravenloft*

Should your PCs decide to attend and attempt to disrupt the wedding, run the (paid) [“Wedding At Ravenloft” expansion](#) by Wyatt Trull.

DECLARATION OF WAR

If Strahd has exhausted all other means of stealing the Tarokka artifacts, ambushing the PCs in greater Barovia, or luring the PCs to Castle Ravenloft, he instead selects a more nuclear option: an outright (though veiled) declaration of war.

Once Strahd begins to believe that the PCs pose a true threat to him, he begins to gather charmed **Barovian scouts** from Vallaki and Barovia, until a total of 24 scouts are housed at Castle Ravenloft. The scouts are split into two groups of 12, which are stationed behind the arrow slits in the north archer's post and south archer's post on the third-floor Parapets (K46). The scouts are staggered in three shifts, with eight scouts sleeping on the stone floor of the archer's posts at any one time. These sharp-eyed and sharp-eared archers are joined by a pair of **wights**, who employ their darkvision to constantly scan the night sky and drawbridge for approaching PCs.

If he believes the PCs may approach by air (and so gain entry via the Servants' Entrance or Tomb of King Barov and Queen Ravenovia), Strahd also directs six **wights** and eight **swarms of bats** to defend the Overlook (K6). Additionally, Ludmilla instructs the coven of **Barovian witches** (if alive) to set their black **cat** familiars to guard the Servants' Entrance (K23) and the staircase beneath the Tower Roof (K57), alerting the coven to the presence of any intruders.

While the PCs are next away on a quest or mission, Strahd and his minions kidnap the children and other NPCs that the PCs have grown most attached to throughout the module. This may include:

- Brom & Bray Martikov
- Alana Krezkova
- Felix (from Saint Andral's Orphanage)
- Milivoj and Yeska
- Stella Wachter (if cured)
- Kaldur (of Yaedrag)
- Doru

Employing Beucephalus, his black carriage, and the assistance of Rahadin, his brides, and any Vistani or Vallakian spies, Strahd oversees a mass kidnapping effort and one or more nights of terror throughout Barovia:

- A charmed Vallakian invites Strahd's forces into the living chambers of the Blue Water Inn, where Urwin and Danika are nearly killed and Brom and Bray are locked in silver manacles (which burn their skin and prevent them from transforming)
- Dmitri Krezkov's house is burned to the ground (forcing the family and their children into the unprotected village grounds)
- Felix is forcefully removed from the Orphanage (by a charmed Ernst Larnak or other Vallakian spy)
- Milivoj and Yeska are forced into the black carriage (if the Church of Saint Andral is unconsecrated or destroyed)
- Strahd requests dinner at Wachterhaus, and charms Fiona and Stella, forcing the girl to return with him to Castle Ravenloft
- Chief Sigrid's tent is burned to the ground (forcing her family and her children into the unprotected and icy grounds of Yaedrag's crater)
- Doru is forcefully removed from the church in Barovia, and Donavich slain if he resists

The children are manacled, blindfolded, and gagged, and placed on the second floor of the *Daern's instant fortress* within Strahd's treasury (K41). Strahd also kidnaps and charms Parriwimple, who he sets alongside a charmed Doru (if present) to guard the children from attack.

STRAHD'S ULTIMATUM

Immediately after the hostages are taken, Strahd instructs one of his Vistani spies (or, failing that, a charmed Vallakian or Barovian) to deliver the following message to the PCs:

My dearest friends and subjects,

It has been too long since I have enjoyed the pleasure of your company. As such, I bid you join me for dinner tomorrow evening at sundown at Castle Ravenloft.

I understand that a two-party dinner is a lonesome affair. As such, I have taken the liberty of inviting several of our mutual acquaintances to join us for this momentous occasion. I am delighted to share that they are currently enjoying the hospitality of Castle Ravenloft, and look forward to your imminent arrival.

For the safety of my retainers and our guests, I must insist that you come alone and unarmed, save for the holy relic and blessed blade you now carry. Should these requests prove overly burdensome to you, I fear that I may be unable to offer my hospitality to you, or to continue offering it to our treasured guests.

I am sure you have grown weary of this game we play. Fear not—it shall end soon.

Sincerely,

*Your Lord and Master,
Strahd von Zarovich*

If the PCs travel to Castle Ravenloft at the predetermined time, they face no random encounters along the way and are met by the black carriage near the western Barovian gate, which transports them to the front gates of Castle Ravenloft. Once inside, the PCs are directed by Rahadin (or another of Strahd's surviving trusted servants) into the Dining Hall (K9).

There, they are greeted by Strahd, the charmed **Barovian scouts**, and Gertruda. Strahd greets the PCs warmly, and describes the terms of the hostages' release: the unconditional surrender of the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind*, the *Tome of Strahd*, and the *Sunsword*, and the immediate exit of the PCs from his lands. Strahd (falsely) promises that the PCs will be allowed to depart Barovia unharmed and unmolested, and that the hostages will be safely released to their families once the transaction is complete. If the PCs refuse Strahd's offer, he promises in veiled terms that the hostages may not survive to the following sunrise.

In truth, Strahd has no intention of upholding his end of the bargain (a fact he will shamelessly and repeatedly deny). Once the PCs hand over the items they hold, Strahd causes the lights to extinguish, the doors to slam shut, and the drawbridge to raise—trapping the PCs within Castle Ravenloft. Strahd then immediately attacks.

RESCUING THE HOSTAGES

The password to the *instant fortress* is set to the name: "Ravenovia." Without the password, the fortress can only be entered via teleportation (e.g., *misty step*) or transformation into a Tiny creature or smaller (e.g., *polymorph* or *gaseous form*).

If the PCs have restored the Sunsword at the blessed pool of Krezk and instilled it with Sergei's spirit, Sergei can share the names of the royal family and any other potential passwords if asked. Sergei can also suggest potential places that the hostages may have been stored: the dungeons, the catacombs, the high tower peak, or the third-floor treasury (though Strahd has walled off the former entrance via the parapets and Sergei does not know how to gain entry via the study).

If contacted via *Sending* or similar magic, the hostages can share the approximate elevation of their imprisonment (an upper floor of the castle), but not their exact location or means of entry. Parriwimple and Doru both know the password to open the *instant fortress* (having overheard Strahd saying it), and will provide it to the PCs if Strahd's charm is broken or suppressed (and, in Doru's case, if he is sufficiently intimidated or wounded).

If Strahd becomes aware of the PCs' presence in the castle before the hostages are rescued, and if the PCs delay their arrival by ten minutes or more (e.g., by casting *Prayer of Healing*, taking a short rest, or wandering the castle for a long period of time), he retrieves the PCs' most beloved hostage from the treasury and brings them to the foretold Tarokka location, where he waits for the PCs to arrive. Parriwimple, Doru, or any of the other hostages can inform the PCs that Strahd removed the chosen hostage shortly before their arrival.

When the PCs arrive at the foretold location, if Beucephalus is still alive, Strahd commands him to escort the charmed hostage to a secure place (likely the North

Tower Peak or Strahd's Tomb, whichever is further). He then taunts the PCs before engaging them in battle.

If the PCs choose to take a short rest after saving the hostages (e.g., within the *instant fortress*, whose protection shields the PCs from any hostile encounters for the duration of their rest), Strahd brings any surviving **Barovian scouts** from the third-floor parapets to the foretold location, where they stand guard at his side.

STRAHD'S TACTICS

STRAHD'S STAT BLOCK

Strahd's as-written statblock, while directly templated from the **vampire** entry in the *Monster Manual*, can be severely underwhelming for a party of 10th-level PCs in *Curse of Strahd*. The reason for this is twofold: the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind* and the *Sunsword*.

As-written, Strahd actually has a CR of 19 (which can be determined using a standard online CR calculator). However, this CR assumes that Strahd is fighting in a vacuum; in other words, it assumes that he is fighting in his preferred territory (e.g., darkness).

If Strahd's Sunlight Hypersensitivity feature is taken into account, we can make the following adjustments to his statblock while he is in direct sunlight or within range of the *Holy Symbol*:

- The average attack bonus for Strahd's **Claws** attack is reduced from +9 to +6 (due to disadvantage from Sunlight Hypersensitivity)
- Strahd's regeneration is negated
- Strahd has two fewer Legendary Resistances (as he is forced to use it

each time he is affected by the **Hold Vampires** ability from the *Holy Symbol of Ravenkind*, which he has only a 65% chance of making his saving throw against. This assumes an average combat encounter length of four rounds)

- Strahd has approximately 80 fewer hitpoints (due to damage from Sunlight Sensitivity, assuming an average combat encounter length of four rounds)

Under these circumstances, Strahd has a CR of 12—barely more than Baba Lysaga or her Creeping Hut. When placed against five 10th-level PCs and Ezmerelda (the equivalent of an 8th-level PC), Strahd alone barely registers as an Easy encounter using the DMG's rules for encounter building.

Averaged together, these best- and worst-case CRs give Strahd's given RAW Challenge Rating of 15. However, we can assume that most parties can defeat an Easy encounter in 1-2 rounds—which means that if Strahd allows himself to enter the range of the *Sunsword* and *Holy Symbol* for even a single round, he risks defeat. In other words, if Strahd ever faces the PCs in a head-on combat after they obtain the Tarokka artifacts, he will be utterly demolished.

While you may choose to supplement Strahd's forces with other monsters from Castle Ravenloft (e.g., the brides, wights, shadows, etc.), aside from Rahadin, the vast majority of Strahd's potential allies are either far too weak to make a difference (in the case of the werewolves or Barovian witches) or equally vulnerable to sunlight (in the case of most undead). As such, buffing Strahd's encounter level with the addition of

other monsters and NPCs is a difficult and suboptimal task.

Under these circumstances, Strahd's strategy is simple: Do everything he can to whittle down the PCs from afar while forcing them to waste their resources. This "guerilla warfare" strategy is detailed in-depth in my article, "[The Genre-Savvy Strahd: A Guide to Running Combat for D&D's Most Dangerous Villain.](#)"

However, it is my firm belief and experience that this strategy is unfulfilling for both the DM (who must oversee a boring game of cat-and-mouse for several hours), and the PCs (who, without the use of *Telekinesis* or *Wall of Force* and an exceptional amount of luck, are physically unable to win). A final battle using Strahd's RAW statblock is binary: either Strahd is destroyed in short order, or the players are destroyed over the course of a long, hopeless slog.

Therefore, I've designed a customized Strahd statblock to meet the following goals:

- Tough enough to last the length of a full high-level combat encounter (5-8 rounds)
- Powerful enough to match the PCs in action economy
- Resourceful enough to address or escape most compromising situations
- Flavorful enough to provide an engaging, exciting, and in-character combat experience to the PCs

To this end, I have made the following changes to Strahd's statblock:

- Increased his Hit Dice to 30, increasing his hitpoints to 255

- Added +1 to his Proficiency modifier
- Increased his spellcaster level to 10
- Replaced his spell list with more standard, useful, and interesting spells

- Replaced his lair actions with a new suite of flavorful, powerful, and diverse lair actions

See below or [click here](#) to view the full statblock:

STRAHD VON ZAROVICH

Medium undead (shapechanger), lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (natural armor)

Hit Points 255 (30d8 + 120)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	18 (+4)	18 (+4)	20 (+5)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws Dex +10, Wis +8, Cha +10

Skills Arcana +17, Perception +14, Religion +17, Stealth +16

Damage Resistances necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical weapons

Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 24

Languages Abyssal, Common, Draconic, Elvish, Giant, Infernal
Challenge 17 (18,000 XP)

Shapechanger. If Strahd isn't in sunlight or running water, he can use his action to polymorph into a Tiny bat or a Medium cloud of mist, or back into his true form.

While in bat form, Strahd can't speak, his walking speed is 5 feet, and he has a flying speed of 30 feet. His statistics, other than his size and speed, are unchanged. Anything he is wearing transforms with him, but nothing he is carrying does. He reverts to his true form if he dies.

While in mist form, Strahd can't take any actions, speak, or manipulate objects. He is weightless, has a flying speed of 20 feet, can hover, and can enter a hostile creature's space and stop there. In addition, if air can pass through a space, the mist can do so without squeezing, and he can't pass through water. He has advantage on Strength, Dexterity, and Constitution saving throws, and he is immune to all nonmagical damage, except the damage he takes from sunlight.

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If Strahd fails a saving throw, he can choose to succeed instead.

Misty Escape. When he drops to 0 hit points outside his resting place, Strahd transforms into a cloud of mist (as in the Shapechanger trait) instead of falling unconscious, provided that he isn't in sunlight or running water. If he can't transform, he is destroyed.

While he has 0 hit points in mist form, he can't revert to his vampire form, and he must reach his resting place within 2 hours or be destroyed. Once in his resting place, he reverts to his vampire form. He is then paralyzed until he regains at least 1 hit point. After spending 1 hour in his resting place with 0 hit points, he regains 1 hit point.

Regeneration. Strahd regains 20 hit points at the start of his turn if he has at least 1 hit point and isn't in sunlight or running water. If Strahd takes radiant damage or damage from holy water, this trait doesn't function at the start of Strahd's next turn.

Spider Climb. Strahd can climb difficult surfaces, including upside down on ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.

Vampire Weaknesses. Strahd has the following flaws:

Forbiddance. Strahd can't enter a residence without an invitation from one of the occupants.

Spellcasting. Strahd is a 10th-level spellcaster. His spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 19, +11 to hit with spell attacks). He has the following wizard spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): mage hand, prestidigitation, ray of frost

1st level (4 slots): shield, absorb elements, fog cloud

2nd level (3 slots): detect thoughts, blindness/deafness, misty step

3rd level (3 slots): fireball, counterspell, dispel magic, fly

4th level (3 slots): greater invisibility, blight

5th level (2 slots): animate objects, scrying

ACTIONS

Multiattack (Vampire Form Only). Strahd makes two attacks, only one of which can be a bite attack.

Unarmed Strike (Vampire Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +10 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage, plus 14 (4d6) necrotic damage. If the target is a creature, Strahd can grapple it (escape DC 18) instead of dealing the bludgeoning damage.

Bite (Bat or Vampire Form Only). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +10 to hit, reach 5 ft., one willing creature, or a creature that is grappled by Strahd, incapacitated, or restrained. *Hit:* 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage plus 10 (3d6) necrotic damage. The target's hit point maximum is reduced by an amount equal to the necrotic damage taken, and Strahd regains hit points equal to that amount. The reduction lasts until the target finishes a long rest. The target dies if this effect reduces its hit point maximum to 0. A humanoid slain in this way and then buried in the ground rises the following night as a vampire spawn under Strahd's control.

Charm. Strahd targets one humanoid he can see within 30 ft. of it. If the target can see Strahd, the target must succeed on a DC 18 saving throw against this magic or be charmed by Strahd. The charmed target regards Strahd as a trusted friend to be heeded and protected. Although the target isn't under Strahd's control, it takes Strahd's requests or actions in the most favorable way it can, and it is a willing target for Strahd's bite attack.

Each time Strahd or Strahd's companions do anything harmful to the target, it can repeat the saving throw, ending the effect on itself on a success. Otherwise, the effect lasts 24 hours or until Strahd is destroyed, is on a different plane of existence than the target, or takes a bonus action to end the effect.

Children of the Night (1/Day). Strahd magically calls 2d4 swarms of bats or rats, provided that the sun isn't up. While outdoors, Strahd can call 3d6 wolves instead. The called creatures arrive in 1d4 rounds, acting as allies of Strahd and obeying his spoken commands. The beasts remain for 1 hour, until Strahd dies, or until Strahd dismisses them as a bonus action.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Strahd can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one legendary action option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. Strahd regains spent legendary actions at the start of his turn.

Move. Strahd moves up to his speed without provoking

Strahd also gains the following Lair Actions while in Castle Ravenloft:

- Strahd targets any number of doors and windows that he can see, causing each one to either open or close as he wishes. Closed doors can be magically locked (needing a successful DC 20 Strength check to force open) until Strahd chooses to end the effect, or until Strahd uses this lair action again.
- A 40-foot radius sphere of fog appears centered on a point within 120 feet of Strahd that he can see. The sphere spreads around corners, and its area is heavily obscured. It lasts until Strahd uses another Lair Action or until a wind of moderate or greater speed (at least 10 miles per hour) disperses it.
- Grasping ghostly hands sprout from the ground and walls in a 10-foot cube starting from a point within 90 feet of Strahd that he can see. For the duration, these hands turn the ground in the area into difficult terrain. A creature in this area must immediately make a Strength saving throw or be restrained by the grasping hands until this effect ends. A creature restrained by these hands can use an action to make a DC 18 Strength saving throw; on a success, it frees itself.
- A 10-foot diameter sphere of fire appears in an unoccupied space of Strahd's choice within 60 feet that he can see. Any creature that starts its turn within 5 feet of the sphere must make a DC 18 Dexterity saving throw. The creature takes 3d6 fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

The sphere ignites flammable objects not being worn or carried, and it sheds bright light in a 20-foot radius and dim light for an additional 20 feet. It lasts until Strahd uses another Lair Action or until dispelled.

- Strahd magically calls four **swarms of bats** or **swarms of rats**. Each swarm appears next to a hostile creature that Strahd can see, makes an attack against that creature, and then exits the area.

At full strength, this revised Strahd is CR21—comparable to Acererak of *Tomb of Annihilation*. While within sunlight, Strahd's revised CR is 14. Assuming Strahd spends half of the final battle in sunlight (as his RAW statblock does), this results in an average CR of 17, or a Medium encounter for a party of five 10th-level PCs plus Ezmerelda.

COMBAT TACTICS

This revised Strahd is a far tougher and capable opponent than the RAW version. Even so, he is still, first and foremost, a skirmisher. While fighting in Castle Ravenloft, he sets up an ambush, strikes hard, and retreats when moderately wounded (179 HP) if Ireena is not present, or severely wounded (102 HP) if she is.

Strahd places the greatest value on his 5th-level spell slots; he uses these slots only to cast *Animate Objects*. He always reserves one 4th-level spell slot to cast *greater invisibility* in case he needs to escape, and uses *counterspell* and *dispel magic* as-needed to block spells of 3rd level or lower that would empower his enemies (e.g., *haste* or *fly*).

He uses his Legendary Resistances only to avoid any incapacitating effects (e.g., *hold monster* or the **Hold Vampires** ability of the Holy Symbol); otherwise, he relies on *absorb elements* and his regeneration to protect him from direct damage.

Strahd's tactics can be divided into four phases: ambush, attack, harass, and retreat.

AMBUSH

During the **Ambush** phase, Strahd seeks to establish surprise when he attacks the PCs—both to avoid the sunlight of the Sunsword for as long as possible and to gain the upper hand on his first attacks.

During this phase, he uses his **Spider Climb** ability to relocate to hard-to-reach places (such as the ceiling), and uses his high Stealth to conceal himself from sight. He relies on his high Perception to detect the PCs as they approach. If the PCs leave for another part of the castle, he follows them in the form of mist (if they're in the main castle) or the form of a bat (if they're in the catacombs or moving quickly), always taking care to avoid the radius of sunlight.

Strahd will then aim to isolate and distract the PCs, either by:

- Using his **Lair Action** to summon swarms of bats to harry a concentrating spellcaster
- Casting **Blindness/Deafness** to weaken his prey or incapacitate a spellcaster, or
- Casting **Animate Objects** or using his door-locking **Lair Action** to separate his target from their companions

If the PCs are outdoors, Strahd may also cast *fly* on himself to keep out-of-reach of any melee attackers.

When the conditions are right, Strahd strikes, using his Legendary Actions to approach his target as quickly as possible.

ATTACK

During the **Attack** phase, Strahd hits hard and fast, focusing almost entirely on his chosen prey. He uses all three legendary actions, plus his multiattack, to take his target's health down as quickly as possible. If he can hit four or more targets without hitting Ireena, he'll cast *Fireball* first. He'll use his **Lair Action** to imprison his target with ghostly hands, and cast *Absorb Elements* to protect himself from any elemental damaging spell of 3rd-level or higher while enhancing his **Unarmed Strikes**.

HARASS

If Strahd is moderately wounded (179 HP) and Ireena is not present, it's at this point that he'll move to the **Retreat** stage. However, if Ireena is present, he'll instead move to the **Harass** stage.

Here, his goal is to weaken his prey for future encounters, taxing their resources and health. He will aim to use his movement, plus his legendary actions, to stay out of the reach of the Sunsword, while attacking his target with multiattack **Unarmed Strike** attacks or *Fireball* (with the same restrictions as before). If any PC is at or below 30 hit points, Strahd casts *blight* from afar, aiming to take them down to zero.

Strahd will spend his reaction on **Shield**, but only against attacks with magical weapons

by rogues or paladins or melee attacks from monks. He'll use his **Lair Action** to summon the flaming sphere, focusing on blocking or harassing enemy interlopers while he focuses his damage on his target.

RETREAT

When Strahd is severely wounded (102 HP), he will **Disengage** and move to retreat. If he has enough spell slots, he'll cast **Misty Step** instead of Disengaging. He uses his **Lair Action** to summon a fog cloud, and uses **Shapechange** to shift to bat form (though he prefers mist form if he can escape through a door, or **Greater Invisibility** if he's within sunlight).

He'll use his **Legendary Actions** to get out of sight, then **Hide** to conceal himself. He'll lick his wounds for a few rounds, letting his regeneration go to work, and follow back around when he's fully healed, returning to Stage 1 (Ambush) once again.

CRAFTING A STRATEGY

Strahd is a tactical genius. As such, Strahd never enters combat without a plan, a backup plan, and an escape route. Moreover, these plans are never complicated, and never rely on more than one moving part. He also never enters combat without first gauging his enemies' strengths, weaknesses, and tactics.

If you've been using Strahd's spies and Scrying spell correctly, Strahd should swiftly learn what spells the PCs are able to cast, what magic items they have in their possession, and what benefits their class features offer. He should know what strategies they favor (e.g., Does the sorcerer routinely polymorph the monk into a Giant Ape? Does the paladin wait for the wizard to cast Telekinesis before rushing in

with a Divine Smite? What animal forms does the druid favor, and how adept is the rogue at picking locks?), and prepare accordingly.

He's seen the Sunsword in action before, and his +10 to Religion means that he almost certainly knows what the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind is capable of.

When running Strahd in combat, preparation is king. Review your PCs' character sheets and magic item lists in-depth, and jot down any special abilities or spells that they reveal to Strahd or his spies.

Whenever possible, Strahd prioritizes killing spellcasters first, followed by skirmishers and strikers (such as rogues or monks), and finally tanks and melee combatants.

Strahd's favored strategy prefers an area with plenty of entrances and exits. He favors larger spaces, through not wide-open areas where the PCs can spread out-of-range of *Fireball*. If possible, Strahd prefers to avoid risking damage to his possessions (e.g., the collection of books in the Study). Additional hazards are a bonus, but not necessary. As such, he prefers to fight in the following spaces:

- Entry (K7), Great Entry (K8), or Heart of Sorrow (K20) on the first floor
- Audience Hall (K25) or King's Hall (K27) on the second floor
- Tower Roof (K57) and Bridge (K58) in the spires of Ravenloft
- Elevator Trap (K61), Servants' Hall (K62), and Hall of Bones (K67) in the Larders of Ill Omen.
- Dungeon Hall (K73), Brazier Room (K78), and Catacombs (K84)

In the Entry (K7) or Great Entry (K8), Strahd lures the PCs into the chamber, activating the **gargoyles** or **red dragon wyrmlings**.

In the Heart of Sorrow (K20), Strahd casts *fly* on himself and attempts to lure the PCs to a higher floor. He then grapples them using his **Unarmed Strike** and drops them down the center of the shaft. A PC must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw and a grapple check to grab hold of Strahd before being dropped.

Near the Elevator Trap (K61), Strahd uses his **Unarmed Strike** to grapple two PCs who together weigh 250 or more pounds, then pulls them onto the pressure plate that activates the trap, using a Legendary Resistance to resist the magic sleep gas if necessary.

In the Dungeon Hall (K73), Strahd uses **Spider Climb** to cling to the walls, luring the PCs into crossing over the hidden teleportation traps.

In the Brazier Room (K78), Strahd lures the PCs into the center of the chamber, then moves just outside one of the doors. He casts *Ray of Frost* to attack one of the **iron golems** within, causing the golems to animate and attack and the doors to magically slam shut and lock.

Finally, in the Catacombs (K84), Strahd uses his door-opening Lair Action to release the **wraith** and **hell hound** inhabitants of Crypt 38 (General Kroval “Mad Dog” Grislek), and his **nightmare**, Beucephalus, from Crypt 39. He lures the PCs past Crypt 27 (containing three **giant wolf spiders**) and across the teleportation traps outside of his tomb (K86). If he has grappled a PC, he

will also use **Spider Climb** to drop them into the shaft in Crypt 14 (Stahbal Indi-Bak) or the **ghoul**-filled pit in Crypt 35 (Sir Jarnwald the Trickster).

MONSTER & NPC ENCOUNTERS

There are dozens of potential encounters in Ravenloft, and many of them have the potential to turn hostile for your players. Here’s a full list of monsters and hostile NPCs your PCs might face, how you might choose to approach them, and a collection of tactics they’ll prefer in battle.²²⁴

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

RAHADIN

If encountered as a random encounter within Castle Ravenloft, Rahadin attacks only if the PCs attack him first. As such, we can assume that his response depends largely on the strength of the PCs that attacked him.

If Rahadin takes moderate damage before his first or second turn (41 damage or more), he immediately uses his full movement to Dash away from the PCs (Disengaging if he doesn’t have enough space or spell slots to cast *misty step* first), and then takes the Hide action on his next available turn. From this point onward, he stalks the PCs through the castle using the tactics described in the **Larders of Ill Omen** section below.

Given his high Insight and Intimidation modifiers, we can assume that Rahadin prefers a “shock-and-awe” approach if he believes he has little to fear from his opponents. If Rahadin takes only light

²²⁴ Full or partial credit for many of the adapted tactics in this section goes to *The Monsters Know What They’re Doing: Combat Tactics for Dungeon Masters*, by Keith Amman.

damage before his first turn (14 damage or less), he focuses his attacks on the PC that attacked first (or opened hostilities, if that PC rolled low on initiative). He attacks three times with his scimitar and attempts to maximize the number of targets caught by his Deathly Choir ability. If he believes the PCs too weak to easily kill him (e.g., if the PCs are of 7th level or below), he commands the PCs to lay down their weapons and immediately cease their attack.

If the PCs obey, Rahadin sheathes his weapons and commands the PCs to depart Castle Ravenloft immediately. If the PCs defy him, Rahadin continues to attack, focusing his efforts on the PC that most actively defied him.

Rahadin is a cruel and ruthless killer. If one of the PCs is a cleric, a paladin, a druid, or a bard, he assumes that the party is capable of magical healing, and continues attacking any unconscious PCs with his scimitars (dealing an automatic critical hit and inflicting two failed death saving throws on a hit) until they are dead.

BROOM OF ANIMATED ATTACK

A **broom of animated attack** is a simple dumb construct with no special tactics or features—save for one: its Animated Attack reaction, which allows it to immediately attempt an attack against a creature that grabs it.

When spotted by the PCs, the broom continues sweeping for a moment, then gently sets itself against a nearby wall. If the PCs ignore it and continue past, it sweeps into the air and attacks from behind.

However, if a PC grabs hold of it, the broom immediately uses its Animated Attack reaction to make a Dexterity check contested by its opponent's Strength check, flying out of the creature's grasp and making an immediate melee attack with advantage before combat starts.

The broom has a +3 Dexterity modifier, giving it a slight statistical advantage on this feature (as most Strength is one of the most common PC dump stats). However, if it fails and the PC continues to grapple it, the broom doesn't mind—it's not tough or intelligent enough to confidently make flyby attacks against melee opponents, and it's perfectly happy to remain adjacent to the nearest target available.

Once it's made its first attack, the broom continues attacking with its multiattack until destroyed.

CRAWLING CLAWS

Given their low CR (CR 0), **crawling claws** are pretty much only good for a jumpscare. Notably, however, they have a climbing speed of 20 feet and a decent Dexterity modifier, suggesting a preference for Stealth. As such, the mob of severed hands doesn't skitter toward the PCs so much as drop on them from above, surprising any PCs whose passive Perception failed to exceed the claws' Stealth check.

It shouldn't be obvious to the PCs upfront that they're being attacked by severed hands upfront, though. To play up the creep factor, let the PCs notice the *hands* part before they notice the *severed* part. One hand wraps around a PC's mouth and clamps it shut while a second hand latches around another PC's throat and starts to squeeze. Another PC finds something cold,

clammy, and foul holding their hands in a tight embrace, even as another pair of hands forces a final PC to play “peekaboo.”

As-written, at least one of the hands may attempt to scurry into a PC’s backpack to hide. However, time in and out of Ravenloft is short. If your PCs are in Ravenloft for the final confrontation, rather than an earlier visit, consider having a hidden hand pop out the next time they take a short rest, instead.

SHADOWS

As-written, the shadows in Castle Ravenloft are non-hostile unless attacked or directed to attack by Strahd—perhaps they’re the shadows that Strahd has previously stolen from other adventurers?

In this case, if attacked in dim or bright light, a shadow doesn’t strike back; instead it Dodges and moves as far away from its attacker as it can. There it waits, ever-curious about these newcomers and desperate to be in the company of a living creature once more. If the PCs leave the shadows behind, they follow from a distance of 30 feet, fleeing if attacked again and separating from the party if the PCs enter a chamber occupied with other NPCs or monsters.

If ordered to attack by Strahd, a **shadow** immediately latches onto the nearest PC, draining their strength until dealt radiant damage, struck with a magic weapon, or turned by a cleric or paladin’s Turn Undead. In this case, a shadow Disengages, moves out of view, uses a bonus action to Hide, and waits for a new victim to come within striking distance.

SWARMS OF BATS

A **swarm of bats** has high Dexterity, average Constitution, and exceptionally low Strength, making it a shock fighter. A swarm’s natural resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage (magical damage included), plus its 30-foot fly speed, means that a swarm has no compunctions against making flyby attacks against melee or ranged creatures.

If the swarm is accompanying Strahd in battle and Strahd needs assistance with an ability check (e.g., hiding from a perceptive party or escaping a grapple), or if it’s been reduced to 11 hitpoints or fewer (reducing the damage of its Bites attack by half), the swarm will take the Help action to assist Strahd or any of his allies who are present. Otherwise, it makes a Bites attack.

CRAWLING STRAHD ZOMBIE

A normal **Strahd zombie** is only CR 1, leaving this bisected zombie little more than a jumpscare for even the lowest-leveled parties. Lean into that. Use the RAW description text of “the deathly groans of something vile” to encourage the PCs to hide from whatever horrific thing might be coming, then reveal its true nature as the zombie pathetically crawls past. If any PCs try to engage it, don’t worry about rolling initiative. Just let them deal with it (or ignore it) as they’d like.

It might not risk killing them, but it’ll do an admirable job of ramping up tension and instantly defusing it—giving your players a flash of humor and relief while ramping up their anxiety before the final fight with Strahd.

WIGHTS

Wights are tough fighters, but their Perception and Stealth proficiencies (plus their average Intelligence and decent Wisdom) suggest more intelligence than their undead nature might indicate. They hate the living and hunger for destruction, but there's no reason they have to do so barbarically.

When the PCs first hear the sound of the wights' approaching footsteps, if they fail to hide from the wights' passive Perception (13) or if they're carrying a light source, the footsteps instantly stop as the wights attempt their own Stealth checks to conceal themselves from possible intruders. The wights take full advantage of their darkvision as they creep forward, then attack with their Longbow multiattack as soon as the PCs are in their sights.

Once combat has begun, the wights move their full movement every turn to approach while making more Longbow multiattacks, switching to their Longsword multiattack once they've closed the distance to melee range.

Once an opponent is reduced to 18 hitpoints or fewer, a wight uses Life Drain as its second melee attack. When its target is knocked unconscious, it continues to attack, using Life Drain as its first melee attack, rather than the second, aiming to revive the PC as a **zombie** under its control 24 hours later.

Wights are capable of speech, and these particular wights once served as guards of Castle Ravenloft. They remember nothing of their lives—only the undying rage they harbor and the bitterness they feel toward those who still live.

BAROVIAN WITCH

Barovian witches as a group are poor foes for PCs of any level; a single **Barovian witch** is barely even a speed bump.

Witches are, however, decently intelligent. If encountered solo, a witch will quickly tally the number of foes she's facing. If she's only up against one PC, she'll inspect the PC for any holy symbols or cleric's robes; if she sees any indication that she's up against a cleric, paladin, or druid, she'll cast *ray of sickness* to attack. Otherwise, she opens with *Tasha's Hideous Laughter* and attacks on subsequent turns with *ray of sickness*.

If the witch finds herself up against a group of enemies, rather than a single foe, she'll cast *invisibility* before turning tail and running. Even witches can do math.

Witches are evil, but they have a strong sense of self-preservation. If cornered or moderately wounded (reduced to 10 hitpoints or fewer), a solo **Barovian witch** immediately surrenders.

VAMPIRE SPAWN

Though the module suggests that the **vampire spawn** fight until destroyed, vampires are opportunistic predators, preferring the weakest or sickest prey when possible, and prioritizing feeding over all else. As such, when the PCs encounter a pack of vampire spawn in Castle Ravenloft, the vampires prioritize any PC that's moderately wounded (60 percent of its hitpoints or fewer), any creature that isn't wearing heavy or medium armor, and any creature that's surprised.

A vampire spawn uses its first Multiattack to attempt to grapple its prey; once it's succeeded in doing so, it Dashes away, dragging the grappled victim to a dark, isolated corner where it can feed. Its regeneration is strong enough that it doesn't fear triggering attacks of opportunity or drawing PC fire—but it does prioritize pulling its victim as far away from sunlight as possible. As such, a pack of vampire spawn drags its prey in *opposite* directions, forcing any un-grappled PCs to split up and reducing the chance that any single vampire spawn is stuck in sunlight.

Ultimately, however, these vampire spawn are under the control of Strahd von Zarovich and have been commanded to defend the castle against intruders. If cornered in sunlight or moderately wounded (reduced to 50 hitpoints or fewer), a vampire spawn stops dragging its victim and immediately lashes out with a Claws/Claws attack. All vampire spawn continue to fight until destroyed.

STRAHD VON ZAROVICH

If the PCs do not pose a threat to Strahd (e.g., they're level 7 or below, and they're missing one or both of the Sunsword and Holy Symbol), instead of attacking immediately, he disguises himself in mist form and follows them through the castle, keeping his distance to avoid any sunlight or unpleasant area-of-effect damage. If he thinks he can get away with it, he'll transform into a bat and attempt to draw the attention of a PC with low Wisdom, using his action to charm them without giving away his identity.

If the PCs do pose a threat to Strahd, he immediately enters combat, attacking the most vulnerable PC with a Claws/Claws

multiattack. However, he doesn't stay for long, warning the PCs that unwelcome visitors will not last long in his castle before sinking into the shadows using his Legendary Action movement, his dark laughter echoing through the castle as he regenerates any damage dealt to him.

From this point on, Strahd stalks the PCs through the castle, aiming to see them driven from the keep—or better yet, dead. For more information on Strahd's combat tactics, see the "Strahd's Tactics" section above.

MAIN FLOOR

RED DRAGON WYRMLINGS

Most dragons—wyrmlings included—will do their best to take full advantage of their natural fly speed. But the statues of **red dragon wyrmlings** in the Entry (K7) aren't here to stay alive—instead, their instructions are to make sure no uninvited guest leaves Ravenloft alive.

Notably, the dragons don't wait until every PC has entered the room—just the first. If the PCs are already engaged in combat when they enter this room from the Great Entry (K8), you'll probably have to wait until the dragons' initiative to let them attack (though waiting for their initiative to let them animate could be a nasty surprise for your players—to keep things as fair as possible, I'd have them animate and drop down to the floor as a reaction as soon as a PC takes the first step into their chamber).

The dragons don't want to kill guests—just keep them from reaching the exit. On their first turn after animating, they take wing, flying five feet off the ground, and form a line down the center of the corridor to prevent any PCs from passing through.

The dragons' Fire Breath ability is a recharge, which means that it's always their preferred attack when available—on one condition. According to the DMG, a 15-foot cone should hit at least two opponents; as such, a dragon only uses its Fire Breath if it can hit two or more enemies. Otherwise, it defaults to Bite.

If any creature gets past the dragons and makes a break for the door, the dragons immediately attack with Fire Breath (or Bite, if Fire Breath isn't available) if that creature is heavily wounded (i.e., reduced to 30% of its health or less). Otherwise, the dragons use their +4 Strength modifier to attempt to grapple the intruder before they escape; if successful, the dragon flies its captive back to the entrance of the Great Hall and returns to its place in the line.

A note about Fire Breath: For a PC with a +3 to Dexterity saving throws, this attack will deal an average of 17 fire damage per dragon. If a PC is unlucky enough to be caught in the center of all *four* dragons' fire breaths, it'll take an average of 69 fire damage—enough to outright KO any non-martial class with a +2 Constitution modifier or less. Ouch!

GARGOYLES

Unlike the dragons in the Entry (K7), the **gargoyles** of the Great Entry (K8) are free to roam wherever they like once animated. Their goal isn't to block the players from advancing, but to simply cause as much damage and destruction as possible.

Also unlike the dragon wyrmlings, the gargoyles have the False Appearance feature, which makes them indistinguishable from a normal statue while motionless. So

long as the PCs don't regard the unmoving gargoyles as potential threats, the gargoyles can and should surprise every PC once combat begins.

For bonus points, don't describe what the gargoyles look like until *after* the lights go out—and even then, only describe their appearance to PCs with darkvision or magical light sources. For characters who have been suddenly plummeted into the dark, the gargoyles' attack should feel like a sudden, terrifying assault by a flurry of unseen assailants.

Due to their damage resistances to (most) nonmagical weapon attacks, gargoyles don't fear attacks of opportunity. As such, gargoyles prefer flyby attacks whenever possible, abusing their 60-foot fly speeds to duck down, slash at their prey with a Bite/Claw multiattack, and then immediately fly back up to the ceiling to ready itself for another attack.

No matter where the characters flee in Castle Ravenloft, the gargoyles will follow—unless the PCs block themselves in a room or corridor by closing (and reinforcing) the door. Any surviving gargoyles will happily spend a full round making Shove attacks against the door to force it open (contested by the PC holding it shut, who makes their check with advantage if they're able to lock it or otherwise reinforce their position). After one round of unsuccessful Shoves, the low-Intelligence gargoyles abandon their quarries and return to their posts.

ANIMATED HALBERDS

The ten **animated halberds** around the Heart of Sorrow are simple constructs: Once they spot a target, they attack it until it's dead. Like gargoyles, their False

Appearance feature grants them surprise against any PC who doesn't already suspect their true nature. After that, though, they keep attacking until destroyed.

(Note: Normal halberds have a reach of 10 feet, but these animated ones don't. If you think that's an oversight by Wizards, feel free to upgrade the reach of their attack to 10 feet instead of 5, forcing your players to get more creative in how they combat these hovering, speedy weapons)

VAMPIRE SPAWN (HEART OF SORROW)

If encountered on the lower levels of the Heart of Sorrow's tower (e.g., on the second floor or below), the **vampire spawn** sent to defend it behave similarly to the vampire spawn described in the "Random Encounters" section above: They grapple a vulnerable PC (attacking with surprise if possible), and attempt to drag their victim off to a dark, shadowy corner to feed.

The vampires behave similarly if encountered at upper floors of the tower, *unless* the PCs are wielding sunlight from the Holy Symbol or Sunsword. In this case, the vampires—with few other places to go—use their Claw/Claw multiattack to grapple their chosen prey (using their Spider Climb feature to maneuver along the walls if needed), then *leap* from the staircase to the distant ground below, pulling the PCs with them.

(To make this fairer, you can let the grappled PC make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw to catch onto the edge of the staircase, followed by a DC 10 Athletics check to hold the combined weight of themselves *and* the vampire spawn now dangling from their ankle.)

A vampire spawn starts with 82 hitpoints, which means that it only uses this grapple-and-leap maneuver if it's fairly confident that it'll survive the fall, *or* if it's sure that it's about to die no matter what. In the former case, it first uses its Spider Climb ability to pull its prey down to the sixth floor (the landing closest to the Heart of Sorrow), or the third floor (if it's been reduced to 50 hitpoints or less); in the latter case, it jumps from the highest point possible out of spite.

As it descends, a vampire spawn relies on its natural regeneration to restore its health (clinging to the undersides of staircases to block sunlight wherever possible), while also biting its grappled victim to restore its own health. Once it reaches the bottom, the vampire drags its prey downstairs through the Tower Hall Stair (K20A) or toward the front of the keep through the Turret Post Access Hall (K13), eager to enjoy its meal in private.

VOLENTA POPOFSKY

For a link to Volenta's revised statblock, [click here](#).

With her Assassinate and Sneak Attack features, Volenta always prefers to strike from hiding wherever possible. With her childlike personality and the additional insurance provided by her Evasion trait, she plays combat like a game. She strikes her chosen target with incredible force before Dashing away the next turn, laughing as she regenerates any damage she's suffered and vanishes into the shadows. Of the three brides, Volenta is most likely to rely on her Spider Climb feature, tucking herself away on ceilings or ascending to inaccessible areas as she skitters along the darkened stone of Ravenloft.

If cornered, however, she is no less deadly. Volenta always prioritizes the weakest or most injured PC first, relying on her Blood Frenzy feature to grant her advantage on her attacks (or to nullify the disadvantage granted by sunlight). Once her playful attitude has turned to mindless bloodthirst, Volenta fights like a maniacal berserker, and never disengages from combat until her thirst is fully sated, or she's been destroyed.

COURT OF THE COUNT

STRAHD ZOMBIES

The two **Strahd zombies** on the King's Balcony (K28) remain motionless until one of them is disturbed, or another creature comes within their reach. A zombie initiates combat by grabbing the target's wrist, hand, or leg, then slowly looking up to meet the target's eyes as the zombie's tongue lolls from its shattered jaw and the skin across its face sloughs down, revealing the bone-white skull beneath.

SHADOWS

If summoned to defend Lief Lipsiege, these 1d6 **shadows** slip into the room through the crack beneath the door leading to K21 (South Tower Stair). If any of the characters are standing in dim light or darkness, the shadows each make a bonus action to take the Hide action, attacking with surprise if successful. If the room is well-lit, the shadows instead surround the characters from the walls, with each one attacking a separate PC.

VAMPIRE SPAWN

If summoned to defend Lief Lipsiege, these 1d4 **vampire spawn** are, like their peers throughout Castle Ravenloft, more interested in finding a meal than in

protecting an old man. The spawn enter K30 on the ceilings, skittering through the doorway and dropping down to assault the closest prey. See the "Random Encounters" section above for more information about running this encounter.

WIGHTS

If summoned to defend Lief Lipsiege, these 1d4 **wights** attack in an immediate show of force, arriving from the Audience Hall (K25) after entering through the secret door from the southern Turret Post Access Hall (K13). See the "Random Encounters" section above for more information about running this encounter.

WRAITH AND SPECTERS

If summoned to defend Lief Lipsiege, a **wraith** arrives through the wall separating K30 (King's Accountant) from the Elevator Shaft (K31A). Rather than prioritizing the most antagonistic foe, it immediately attacks the most Good character present, driven by its malevolent compulsion to kill the greatest paragon of goodness in the party with its Life Drain. If injured by radiant damage or silvered or magic weapons, the wraith turns to attack less dangerous prey—but immediately returns to the most Good-aligned PC once its safer prey is dead (and turned into a **specter** using the wraith's Create Specter feature).

The 1d4+1 **specters** that accompany it arrive by passing through the northern wall, and quickly latch onto the nearest living victim. However, a specter will only reluctantly follow a wraith into sunlight, and once the wraith dies, the specters will quickly flee for darker pastures. Otherwise, if a specter takes radiant or magical weapon damage, it Disengages and moves to a new

place of safety 50 feet away, then swoops in and attacks a new target in the next round. If a specter suffers 7 or more points of any damage from one opponent in a single round, it flies to a new target and attacks immediately without worrying about opportunity attacks, relying on its damage resistances to protect it. If hit by a ranged attack, the specter immediately dive-bombs the ranged attacker and engages them in melee.

HELGA RUVAK

Helga's strategy is simple: Attack any isolated PCs, or when commanded to do so by Strahd. When she strikes, she acts as any other vampire spawn would (see the "Random Encounters" section above), with two exceptions: if the PCs enter her room with sunlight and obstruct the exit, Helga shies toward the back wall, hissing in pain as the light burns her vampiric flesh, before lurching forward to strike whichever PC is currently blocking her escape. Otherwise, if Helga is already accompanying the party when the sunlight of the Sunsword or Holy Symbol is activated, she hisses and quickly scuttles away into the darkness, clinging to the walls and ceilings as she beats a hasty getaway.

ROOMS OF WEeping

SWARMS OF RATS

When the PCs approach or attack these rats, the two "manlike shapes" they form slowly turn to face the PCs. The swarms are covered only by threadbare black cloaks, which reveal beneath them two standing mounds of writhing, furred flesh, with faces covered in wormlike tails, flashing white teeth, and dozens of glinting black eyes. Once their anger is aroused, the rats begin

to rush down the figures' sides, the manlike shapes slowly melting away as their "body" dissolves into hundreds of chittering, wriggling rats.

INVISIBLE STALKER

It's unlikely that your PCs will trigger this encounter. However, if they do, the **invisible stalker** should prove a memorable—if horrifying—encounter. With its high Strength and Dexterity (but only decent Constitution), plus its exceptional 50-foot fly speed, this monster is a shock attacker, lunging to strike its prey before retreating into the air once more.

The stalker makes good use of its invisibility and fly speed, and doesn't hesitate to trigger opportunity attacks via flyby attacks, relying on its resistance to nonmagical attacks. However, because of its invisibility, an invisible stalker will almost always have advantage on its attacks against its quarry (who effectively suffers from the **blinded** condition relative to the stalker's presence). As such, it doesn't bother taking advantage of its sky-high Stealth modifier, except to gain surprise at the start of combat.

Whenever possible, an invisible stalker always begins and ends its turn out of any opponent's melee reach. When it reduces its quarry—the character that stole the cake's groom figurine—to 0 hitpoints, it doesn't stop fighting. Instead, it keeps attacking until that creature is dead.

GIANT SPIDERS

The **giant spiders** in the Belfry (K40) only attack if attacked first or if the bell is sounded. In both cases, we can safely assume that they're attacking defensively, rather than for food.

Giant spiders are reasonably speedy, with a high Dexterity, decent Strength and average Constitution. They prefer to first attack from range using their Web attack, repeating it whenever it's recharged. Since these five spiders are living together in such a tight space, we can assume that they form a social nest—which means that they'll focus-fire their Web attacks on one target at a time, to ensure that each enemy is **restrained** before moving into melee.

Once an enemy is **restrained** by webbing, one or more spiders moves in to retrieve them, first by grappling the target (rolling with advantage, while the target rolls with disadvantage), followed by pulling the target up into the spiderwebs above, further restraining the target. Once it's done so, each spider dives in, using their Bite attacks to inject as much venom as possible. Once a victim is reduced to 0 hitpoints, one spider uses its Web attack to wrap it inside of a cocoon, and ties it off in the web to be consumed later.

The belfry is far too small and constrained, leaving the spiders with nowhere to go. If heavily wounded (reduced to 8 hitpoints or less), a spider will beat a hasty retreat to the top of the Belfry, where it clicks its mandibles toward the PCs threateningly. If cornered, it will fight to the death.

STRAHD'S ANIMATED ARMOR

Unlike its other animated peers, **Strahd's animated armor** is almost as intelligent as an average human, allowing it to use some basic tactics. Its Armor Class is exceptionally high, and its Strength and Constitution are high as well, making it a trueborn tank.

In combat, the armor opens with Shocking Bolt (favoring attacks against opponents wearing metal armor), followed by a series of Greatsword attacks as soon as it closes within melee range. Against a spellcaster with an AC of 15, it can deal an average 8 damage per Greatsword attack. Once in melee range, it will always prioritize more vulnerable opponents first (using its multiattack to grapple an unarmored or lightly armored opponent before attacking that same turn), and will instantly focus its attacks on a caster that attempts to cast *dispel magic* on it and fails.

Shocking Bolt has a lower to-hit bonus and deals less damage, making it an inferior choice to Greatsword in all close-ranged scenarios. Even with advantage on its Shocking Bolt attack against an enemy wearing armor, it still deals slightly less than 8 damage per attack on average, making its Greatsword a safer (and more powerful) choice.

ANASTRASYA KARELOVA

For a link to Anastrasya's revised statblock, [click here](#).

When encountered in Castle Ravenloft, Anastrasya is never far from the sword or shield she wields with telekinetic grace. However, she prefers civility to open violence, relying on her high Deception modifier and Charm ability to keep her enemies talking while she wraps them around her fingers.

While speaking with the PCs, Anastrasya will use each round to target a PC with her Charm ability, preferring to prioritize classes without proficiency in Wisdom saving throws. When Anastrasya uses her Charm, have each PC make a Perception or Insight

check, but secretly modify the result of her victim to use their Wisdom saving throw modifier, rather than the appropriate skill modifier. If the victim fails to beat Anastrasya's Charm DC (15), secretly let them know that they are now charmed by her and what that entails.

When this happens, have Anastrasya make a Stealth check. If any PC makes a Perception or Insight roll that beats Anastrasya's Stealth result, secretly inform them that they noticed Anastrasya's eyes flash crimson-red, followed by her victim's gaze growing slack and distant a heartbeat later.

If possible, Anastrasya will prioritize the strongest or most charismatic PCs for her Charm first, relying on the goodwill of those she's already bewitched to suppress any notion of violence. If she has any indication that things are about to go south, however, she quietly uses her Children of the Night ability, summoning 2d4 **swarms of rats** or **swarms of bats** to assist her should combat erupt.

In battle, Anastrasya uses her bonus action to attack with her modified **flying sword** while taking the Dodge action, relying on the additional AC provided by her *animated shield* to protect herself. Elegant and graceful to the last, Anastrasya only attacks with her Claw/Claw multiattack if cornered, and only drains a victim's health with her Bite if she is moderately wounded (reduced to 60 hitpoints or fewer) and a weak, vulnerable victim is easily available to her.

Otherwise, Anastrasya immediately flees battle if she is exposed to sunlight or heavily wounded (reduced to 30 hitpoints or fewer), transforming into a bat (if indoors), a wolf (if

outdoors), or a cloud of mist (if nearby to one of the cracks in the wall that lead to the High Tower Stair). Once out of sight, if she isn't already in mist form, Anastrasya transforms into mist and conceals herself amid the decay of the rest of Castle Ravenloft. If commanded to do so by Strahd, however, she will (reluctantly) remain and fight to the death, unable to defy her master's will.

Anastrasya never travels alone. In Castle Ravenloft, she is always defended by an honor guard of four **wights** that stand guard at each entrance to her current chamber, and who violently attack any creature that threatens her.

SPIRES OF RAVENLOFT

RUG OF SMOTHERING

Due to its False Appearance feature, the **rug of smothering** always attacks with surprise—but because it can't attack while restraining a target, that's likely the only attack it will ever get. It will, however, use the Dodge action on all subsequent turns to avoid taking damage, and will attack the nearest target with its Smother if its original prey somehow frees itself. It fights to the death.

GUARDIAN PORTRAIT

Like the Rug of Smothering, the **guardian portrait's** False Appearance feature allows it to always attack with surprise (though, given the fact that it only attacks if the rug is attacked or either item is moved, this is only relevant in the latter case).

The portrait can't move, however, and has no damage-dealing attacks, meaning it has to rely on one of its three combat-ready spells: *crown of madness*, *hypnotic pattern*,

or *telekinesis* (though it automatically casts *counterspell* any time an enemy casts a spell of 3rd level or lower). Each of these three spells uses concentration and two of them require an action each round to maintain, which means that once the portrait casts one of them, it won't cast another spell until it sees a reason to switch.

Given the portrait's low AC and hitpoints, it will likely only have the chance to cast one of these spells, which means it has to make it count. Let's take a look at these options:

- *Crown of Madness* charms one humanoid of the portrait's choice within 120 feet. While the target is charmed, it must use its action before moving on each turn to make a melee attack against a creature chosen by the portrait. The most likely use of this is to force one of the PCs to attack their fellows while reducing the number of combatants attacking the rug.
- *Hypnotic Pattern* has the potential to affect every creature in the room (aside from the rug, which operates on blindsight alone). This includes the portrait, however, as the room is too small to exclude it. However, because the entire party is likely to be crammed into the room, this means that the portrait has a decent chance to charm approximately half of the party (assuming an average Wisdom saving throw of +2).
- *Telekinesis* is the portrait's highest-levelled spell, allowing it to restrain a creature in its arcane grip. It'll prioritize a low-Strength enemy, like a rogue, wizard, sorcerer, warlock, or druid, and fling them against the ceiling twenty feet overhead, forcing

its target to take 2d6 falling damage when the spell ends.

Generally speaking, *hypnotic pattern* is most effective against a larger group, while *telekinesis* is best against a small group. *Crown of madness*, which removes approximately one-and-a-half PCs from combat, is somewhere in between.

According to the DMG, a spell with a 30-foot-cube area of effect like *hypnotic pattern* should generally affect at least six creatures. As such, the portrait won't bother casting this unless it has at least that many enemies (counting both PCs, NPCs, and beast companions/familiars) in range.

Telekinesis, on the opposite side of the spectrum, the portrait keeps tucked away for encounters with two or fewer enemies—one for the rug to handle, and one for the portrait to keep pushed away. Finally, the portrait casts *crown of madness* if it finds itself in the sweet spot of facing three to five enemies, prioritizing obvious melee attackers first (preferably a low-Wisdom combatant like a fighter, rogue, or barbarian).

Interestingly enough, the guardian portrait can speak Common, plus up to two other languages; its average Charisma modifier also implies that it may be interested in speaking with the PCs (though it's unlikely that it'll do so before it attacks, in order to preserve the surprise from its False Appearance feature). While it's not actually Strahd, it's likely the portrait retains some of his mannerisms, and will taunt and insult the PCs in his voice while battling them.

To keep this encounter interesting, make sure to include these two nuggets of detail

from the portrait's information section, as well:

- “When a guardian portrait attacks, the figure in the painting animates and moves as though alive (albeit in two dimensions)”
- “When it casts a spell, the figure painted on the canvas makes all the appropriate somatic gestures and verbal incantations for the spell”

ESCHER

As described in the original module, Escher prefers conversation to conflict and fleeing to fighting. However, if cornered—or ordered to do so by Strahd, Ludmilla, or Anastrasya—Escher reluctantly enters the fray.

In combat, Escher prefers the following options:

- *Heroism*, which he uses only if Ludmilla orders him to cast it on himself
- *Dissonant whispers*, which he casts to move a Sunsword-wielding attacker away from Strahd (while providing Strahd with an opportunity attack), or which he uses to clear an exit route after *charm person* has already failed
- *Faerie fire*, which he casts to nullify Strahd's disadvantage on attacks while in sunlight, or to empower any other undead allies that may join him
- *Invisibility*, to conceal his escape after clearing a path to safety

Otherwise, he either attacks with a Claws/Claws multiattack (if there's no sunlight present) or casts *vicious mockery*, insulting everything he can find—whether

that's the target's fashion sense, their physical appearance, or their mother's resemblance to a particularly ugly species of warthog.

VAMPIRE SPAWN

Should they wander in through a window, the **vampire spawn** in these towers behave identically to the spawn described in the “Random Encounters” section. If possible, they drag their victim out of the window they came through, using their Spider Climb feature to cling to the stone and forcing their victims to stay in their grasp—or fall to the cold, hard ground 170 feet (17d6 bludgeoning damage) below.

BAROVIAN WITCHES

A **barovian witch** has low Strength, average Dexterity, and barely above-average Constitution. She has decent Intelligence, but otherwise average mental stats.

Her attacks are both lackluster: Claws requires a 2nd-level spell slot and concentration, and her Dagger attack deals an average of 2 piercing damage with a +2 bonus to hit. Neither is worth using—leaving the spells.

- *Ray of sickness* is always a good go-to, though it doesn't really mesh well with *Tasha's hideous laughter* (which drops its victim prone, imposing disadvantage and dropping the average damage by more than half).
- *Sleep* is not worth using against any PC of 4th level or higher.
- *Tasha's hideous laughter* imposes an excellent condition (prone and incapacitated), but the witch has no

easy ways of following up on it. As such, the witch will only cast this if joined by a melee attacker.

- *Invisibility* doesn't allow the witch to attack, which means that it's only good for escaping and attacking surprised enemies. The witch has only +0 to Stealth checks, meaning that any opponent with even a passable Perception modifier is pretty likely to detect her before she attacks.
- *Ray of frost* is a usable cantrip, but not worth casting unless there are no spell slots to cast *ray of sickness* with.

In general, spellcasters prefer to preserve scarcer spell slots for spells at that level. However, *alter self* is almost never worth casting, which means that a given witch will always reserve one 2nd-level spell slot for *invisibility* (in case she needs to make a quick getaway) and one 2nd-level spell slot for an upcasted *ray of sickness* (if she hasn't already spent it on another *invisibility* spell to attack with surprise).

If notified in advance by Ludmilla or Strahd to expect company, however, a Barovian witch can swap out her spells for new (and more useful) ones using the spellbook in area K56 (Cauldron). Potential choices include:

- *Burning hands*—an auto-include anytime the witch expects open combat
- *Charm person*—worth including if the witches expect to encounter only three or fewer enemies (allowing them to focus their casts)
- *Mage armor*—same as *burning hands* above

- *Misty step*—same as *burning hands* and *mage armor* above.

Using this swapped-out spell list (assuming they had time to prepare it that morning), the witches prepare for combat by casting *mage armor* and *invisibility* as soon as they're alerted to expect company by one of their feline familiars. The witches immediately open combat with *burning hands*.

In this case, a Barovian witch will prefer *misty step* to *invisibility* for getaways if and only if she is lightly wounded (reduced to 14 hitpoints or less) and immediately adjacent to a melee opponent. In this case, she'll *misty step* out of her attacker's reach and immediately move to a safer position—or Dash away to safety if she's decided to flee.

No matter what their spell lists are, Barovian witches, to quote the module, "have no scruples. They will deal with anyone in return for power. They will also betray anyone for the same reason." While they fear Strahd and would never willingly betray him, they will happily surrender to the PCs as soon as they feel endangered—say, if they're cornered (e.g., if they have no spell slots remaining for *misty step* or *invisibility*) and reduced to 5 hitpoints or fewer, or if they're cornered and at least half of their compatriots have already been killed.

LUDMILA VILISEVIC

For a link to Ludmilla's revised statblock, [click here](#).

In combat, Ludmilla focuses first on immobilizing and incapacitating her enemies. Against lower-level enemies, she will incapacitate melee fighters by casting *levitate*; against higher-level foes, she will

begin by casting *evard's black tentacles* if she can catch at least four enemies in its radius. Otherwise, she begins by casting *blindness/deafness* to blind any spellcaster that she deems a large enough threat, followed by *misty step* to avoid the reach of any melee attacker.

If Ludmilla is alerted to the PCs' presence beforehand, she will begin by casting *greater invisibility*, and will stalk the PCs until they are sufficiently close together for her to cast *evard's black tentacles*.

Once the PCs are restrained by *evard's black tentacles*, Ludmilla takes advantage of their **restrained** condition to attack with *lightning bolt*, taking care (if possible) to hit at least three PCs with the spell whenever possible.

Ludmilla has three options for her reaction: *counterspell*, *shield*, and her recharge ability Misty Escape. If she is facing an enemy spellcaster with the ability to incapacitate her (e.g., via *hypnotic pattern*), or if she is heavily wounded (reduced to 32 hitpoints or less) and attempting to escape, she holds *counterspell* in reserve. She uses *misty escape* to block attacks by rogues, paladins, or monks, though she switches to *shield* if caught within sunlight.

Ludmilla always keeps one 2nd-level, one 3rd-level, and one 4th-level in reserve to cast *misty step*, *counterspell*, and *greater invisibility*, in case she needs to escape. Ludmilla places a high value upon her own life, and will flee as soon as she is heavily wounded (reduced to 32 hitpoints or less).

Whenever possible, Ludmilla is joined by 1d6 **Barovian witches** or 1d4 + 1 **flying swords**, which she personally enchanted.

LARDERS OF ILL OMEN

BLACK PUDDING

The **black pudding** in the Wine Cellar (K63) has the ability to corrode weapons and armor, hang from the ceiling, and Split when struck by slashing or lightning damage. A Large black pudding retreats when reduced to 34 hitpoints or fewer by non-slashing, non-lightning damage; a Medium pudding must be reduced to 16 hitpoints or fewer; and a Small pudding must be reduced to 8 hitpoints or fewer.

SKELETONS

By the time they reach these skeletons in the Guards' Quarters (K69), your PCs should be long-since used to their presence in Castle Ravenloft (following their run-ins with Cyrus

Belview's skeletal "guards" elsewhere in the keep). In combat, eight of these ten **skeletons** immediately attack the PCs with their shortbows while two remaining skeletons closest to the door block the exit, attacking the PCs from behind with their shortsword. A skeleton switches to its shortsword as soon as any PC engages it in melee.

RAHADIN

There are two circumstances under which the PCs may fight Rahadin here: Either the party has entered his office after breaking into Castle Ravenloft, or the party is working to steal the skull of Argynvost from the Hall of Bones (K67) nearby, and they've made enough noise to attract him to their location.

Rahadin has a high AC of 18, a high Constitution, and a godlike Dexterity (+6). His mental stats are all well above average (with a notably high Charisma) and his other

physical stat (Strength) is fairly good as well.

Rahadin also has darkvision, a move speed of 35 feet, and proficiency in two of the big three saving throws (Constitution and Wisdom); given his exceptionally high Dexterity, he's unlikely to fail many of those saving throws either.

While Rahadin's Mask of the Wild feature is exceptionally useful in the wilderness, it is near-useless in Castle Ravenloft unless the PCs encounter him outdoors (e.g., on the Tower Roof or in the castle grounds). As such, we can safely ignore it here.

Rahadin's actions are simple: He attacks three times with his scimitar, dealing an average 27 damage; or he attacks twice with his poisoned darts, dealing an average 26 damage. These attacks have the same to-hit modifier, leaving them roughly equivalent in value—especially when we consider that the normal maximum range of Rahadin's poisoned darts (20 feet), plus his natural speed of 35 feet, doesn't allow him to escape a PC who dashes after him as he retreats.

Rahadin has three features that allow him to enhance his action economy through bonus actions: the *misty step* spell (which he can cast three times per day), the *magic weapon* spell (which he can cast once per day), and his Deathly Choir ability

Misty step increases Rahadin's mobility even further, allowing him to teleport up to 30 feet away to a place he can see. However, Castle Ravenloft is full of enclosed corridors and chambers—and a closed door blocks the line of sight that Rahadin needs to cast it. As such, *misty*

step is probably less of an escape feature and more of a means of avoiding opportunity attacks when Rahadin needs to withdraw from melee.

Against an enemy with AC 15, *Magic weapon* increases the average damage of Rahadin's scimitar by 1.4 per strike, increasing his average melee damage output by 4 slashing damage per round. However, he can only cast it once per day; if the PCs are of sufficiently low level (5th level or lower), or if he doesn't plan to engage the PCs in melee (as he can't cast *magic weapon* on more than one poisoned dart) Rahadin won't bother casting it. Otherwise, he uses a bonus action to cast it on his scimitar on the first round of combat.

Deathly Choir deals an average of 13 psychic damage to any creature caught in it (assuming his targets have a Wisdom modifier of +3). For a target with a higher Wisdom saving throw modifier, such as a cleric or druid, that average damage decreases to 11, which is still comparable.

Because Rahadin's two attacks are roughly equal, his decision to engage in melee or ranged combat comes down to the positioning of potential targets. According to the "Areas of Effect" table in the DMG, Rahadin's Deathly Choir ability should target at least two enemies most of the time; as such, if Rahadin can guarantee that he'll be able to damage at least two enemies with his ability while attacking with his scimitars, he'll enter melee combat immediately, relying on *misty step* to escape to an exit if he gets in over his head..

Otherwise, Rahadin's Constitution, while high, isn't quite high enough to allow him to enter a lengthy combat alone against a

team of coordinated and powerful opponents. As such, if he can't guarantee at least two targets for his Deathly Choir, he'll take potshots from 20 feet away with his poisoned darts before retreating his full move speed, tempting the PCs to waste their action by Dashing. Whenever possible, Rahadin ends his movement behind full cover (e.g., a wall or closed door), forcing the PCs to relocate to hit him.

Rahadin knows Castle Ravenloft like the back of his hand, and his exceptionally high Stealth modifier (+14) means that few, if any enemies, will be able to track him. While the book says Rahadin fights to the death, he knows his value to Strahd, and has no plans to allow his master's enemies to roam the castle freely. As such, when Rahadin is moderately wounded (reduced to 70 percent of his maximum health, or 95 hitpoints), he uses his full movement to Dash away from the PCs (Disengaging if he doesn't have enough space or spell slots to cast *misty step* first), and then Hides in a dark, tucked-away space.

From then on, Rahadin, like the Alien of *Alien: Isolation*, takes full advantage of the narrow, twisting, dark corridors of Castle Ravenloft to tail his prey through the shadows with his +11 Perception modifier, striking from a distance before immediately withdrawing once more. According to the PHB, we can expect Rahadin to carry no more than 2d4 poisoned darts (average 5), leaving him to rely solely on his scimitar after all darts have been thrown.

Once he's latched onto a group of invading adventurers, he doesn't stop his pursuit until all of them are dead—with one exception. If the PCs ever take a short rest while Rahadin is stalking them, he departs to

report their location to Strahd, who appears to confront the PCs within 6d10 minutes.

Rahadin is a cruel and ruthless killer. If one of the PCs is a cleric, a paladin, a druid, or a bard, he assumes that the party is capable of magical healing, and continues attacking any unconscious PCs with his scimitars (dealing an automatic critical hit and inflicting two failed death saving throws on a hit) and Deathly Choir (automatically inflicting a failed death saving throw) until his target is dead.

SHADOW DEMON

For a **shadow demon**, staying out of light is a must. It'll do its best to avoid bright light, and will do whatever it can to avoid an enemy capable of inflicting radiant damage.

In combat, the demon Hides in dim light or darkness, giving it advantage on its first attack from hiding and boosting its damage. Using its Incorporeal Movement feature, the demon will dodge in and out of the Spiral Stair Landing (K83a) to avoid PC attacks, and to re-conceal itself before attacking again. It will prioritize the weakest and most vulnerable targets first, but will retreat to reposition itself if its first blow either doesn't deal at least severe damage (60 percent of the opponent's maximum hitpoints) or if the second doesn't finish them off.

If the PCs move away from the walls of the room and illuminate the chamber's corners, the demon is out of luck, and will skulk away, tailing the PCs from afar until a suitable time comes to strike again.

DUNGEON AND CATACOMBS

GRAY OOZE

When the **gray ooze** in the North Dungeon (K74) detects a PC, it waits for them to step

close enough before attacking with surprise through its False Appearance feature. Once it's engulfed a victim, it slowly moves away from other living beings at its full movement speed and keeps attacking—corroding any metal its target is wearing—until the ooze is reduced to 8 hitpoints or fewer or the PC is completely digested (i.e., dead).

STRAHD ZOMBIES

As before, I highly recommend removing the Loathsome Limbs feature of the six **Strahd zombies** in the Torture Chamber (K76) while keeping their statistics otherwise unchanged. Otherwise, this is a fun, spooky encounter that will set the stage for the rest of this area while letting your players feel powerful.

If any of your PCs are capable of flight, or if they wind up climbing on top of the balcony to escape the zombies, let the zombies climb on top of each other—at half speed—to reach the higher elevation. Whenever a zombie at the bottom of the stack takes damage, any zombie on top must make a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or fall back into the water.

IRON GOLEMS

These two **iron golems** are Strahd's secret weapon. If he is able to lure the PCs into the Brazier Room (K78), your party is in serious danger.

As mentioned in the "Strahd's Tactics" section above, if Strahd finds himself adjacent to this room while the PCs are inside, he'll attack one of the golems with a weak ranged attack, causing the doors to slam shut and letting the golems immediately animate and attack. Because the PCs are already aware of the danger

Strahd poses, they won't be surprised (unless Strahd is hidden and doesn't trigger anyone's passive Perception).

Once they animate, the golems fight as described in the original module.

SWARMS OF BATS

There are a few lines of text that are easily overlooked in the Catacombs (K84):

- The bats in the catacombs **fly out in the evening** to hunt at night; in other words, if your PCs arrive in the catacombs after dark, the ceiling will be empty of bats (which means Strahd can't command them, as described below).
- The bats will attack intruders if **provoked or specifically commanded** by Strahd. How many bats is that? Well...
- If any bats within a 10-foot square on the map are attacked or harmed by a spell, 2d4 **swarms of bats** form in that area and attack. There are roughly 90 squares in the catacombs that fit that description, resulting in 225 swarms of bats. If Strahd commands them *all* to attack... Yeouch. (Don't fight a vampire in a cave full of bats, kids).

In combat, each swarm will attack the PCs as long as its hitpoints remain above half, and will switch to taking the Help action (to assist Strahd or another of his minions) once bloodied.

However, to be fair to your PCs, if Strahd commands his bats to attack, give them a reasonable warning: On the turn that Strahd commands his bats, he must spend his turn verbally directing them to attack—during

which a maelstrom of thousands of bats forms overhead, threatening to eclipse the PCs with their mass.

If the PCs stay in the catacombs after that, that's their own damn fault.

TELEPORT TRAPS

A quick note about the three teleport traps outside of Strahd's Tomb (K85): Once triggered, they make for an *excellent* moment of horror, both for the victim and for their companions.

Remember: The traps are completely invisible, which means that there's no indication *why* the person disappeared. One moment they're there, the next, they're just—not. They might have triggered a trap, they might have turned invisible, or they might have been teleported away by a spellcaster.

Make sure not to reveal the fate or location of the victim until their left-behind companions have decided what to do (including, for example, fighting the angry **wight** that has just teleported to take their friend's place). If they keep walking into the trap, keep yanking them into the trap's destination (the vault beneath Crypt 14). If they decide to look in the wrong place for the victim, let them wander for a bit before turning the camera back.

Once you refocus on the victim, play up the claustrophobia *hard*. Let them know that the dim light of the catacombs has been replaced immediately with pitch-black darkness, that they can barely move their arms or legs, and that the air they're breathing is stale, rotted, and thin—too thin to breathe comfortably. From there, let them

work out on their own what's happened and how they can escape.

I do have to add this disclaimer, though: If you know that the player in question has a real phobia of tight spaces, ignore everything above and instead make it immediately clear how they can escape. Horror is fun; anxiety attacks aren't.

PRINCE ARIEL

It's unlikely the PCs will trigger the encounter with Prince Ariel's **ghost** in Crypt 4, but on the off chance they do, remember that, like all ghosts, Ariel's goal is the resolution of his trauma. In this case, that trauma is his death at the hands of his ill-begotten wish to fly.

However, no ghost wants to be destroyed and risk leaving its trauma unresolved. As such, if wounded by magic weapons or radiant damage, Ariel will swiftly Disengage and retreat at his full speed away from the group. If repelled by Turn Undead, Ariel keeps away as well.

It's unlikely Prince Ariel will have reason to use his Horrifying Visage attack, but on the off-chance that the PCs manage to upset or anger him (perhaps by dismissing his dream of flight), Ariel uses this action immediately and reflexively in response. To encourage them to converse with him (and to make the stakes clear), consider having him rant and rave about how he'll "fly" from the highest peak of the tower before possessing a PC.

On his third failed Athletics or Acrobatics check to escape if the PCs grapple his possessed target, Ariel will relinquish control of his victim and immediately try to possess a different target that *hasn't* already resisted his possession ability. If no

such targets exist, he flees back to his crypt, wailing in insane despair.

WIGHTS & SKELETONS

If summoned by the teleport traps near Strahd's crypt or awoken by a creature that opens its coffin, the **wights** in Crypt 14 immediately engage with the PCs in melee with its longsword and, eventually, with its Life Drain ability. It otherwise behaves as described in the "Random Encounters" section above.

Any animated **skeletons** brought to life when a wight dies in this vault behave identically to the skeletons described in the "Larders of Ill Omen" encounters section above.

SASHA IVLISKOVA

Sasha, a **vampire spawn** (Crypt 20), has been locked in her crypt for decades. As a result, she's blood-starved, and, at her lowest points, very nearly feral—save for the compulsions Strahd has placed on her and her desperate, twisted hope for freedom.

If the PCs open the door to her crypt, she immediately attacks with a Claw/Bite multiattack. If she previously delivered her message to the PCs during the dinner (as described again), she immediately surrenders and apologizes when the PCs raise a hand against her, claiming that she thought they were someone else. If questioned, she hints that this "someone else" may be Strahd (though a DC 14 Insight check reveals that she's lying).

If the PCs ask her to accompany them, she asks if they can protect her from Strahd, attempting to glean information about their

capabilities. Regardless of how they answer, Sasha immediately agrees (so long as the light of the Sunsword or Holy Symbol is kept low enough to avoid harming her). As she travels with the party, she does her best to be "helpful" by providing directions to her companions—until a suitable moment comes to misleadingly direct them to a trap or stab them in the back.

If attacked, Sasha dashes away in panic, moving to the ceiling if needed to escape the reach of the Sunsword. Until Strahd commands her otherwise, she has one wish: freedom (and, once she reaches easier prey, food).

Strahd, of course, soon catches up with her, and eventually makes Sasha's momentary freedom a nightmarish hell.

PATRINA VELIKOVNA

As mentioned RAW, the **banshee** Patrina (Crypt 21) attacks the characters immediately—but immediately after doing so, if Kasimir is with the party and claims to be here to resurrect her, she ceases all hostilities, though asks her "dear brother" why he might wish to revive her now, after murdering her and letting her spirit lie fallow for centuries.

If Kasimir isn't with the party or can't persuade Patrina to stop attacking, she attacks with Horrifying Visage the turn after using her Wail while using her fly speed to stay aloft in the air, away from enemy weapons.

From the third round onward, Patrina strafes her opponents with Corrupting Touch, flying down to attack before flying back up out of reach. She first prioritizes enemy spellcasters, marksmen, and skirmishers,

picking off those at the edge of the group, rather than those at the front or center. Under no circumstances does she willingly end her turn adjacent to an enemy holding a magic weapon—one of the few things capable of gravely wounding her.

GIANT WOLF SPIDERS

The two **giant wolf spiders** of Crypt 27 are little more than a jumpscare. Spook your players with an intimidating physical description as they jump out, threatening a much larger, more deadly arachnid foe—but then reveal their true nature and let your players easily dispatch them.

ALCOVE PORTALS

If the PCs don't have *mage hand* or anyone capable of teleporting past or lifting the portcullis to Strahd's tomb, these teleportation portals are their only access point to the tomb after Strahd has fled to his coffin in mist form to rejuvenate. In the rare occasion that this occurs, let your players wander through the catacombs in search of a hidden trick or secret—it'll be a race against time as they carefully search every crypt for a way to open the door (possibly triggering several dangerous encounters as they do), and they'll be excited to find this area when they finally succeed.

GHOULS

It's unlikely the PCs will venture into the seemingly-empty crypt (Crypt 35) containing the six starving **ghouls**, but on the off chance they do, the ghouls won't be starving for long. This is one of *Curse of Strahd's* classic punishments against traditional dungeon-crawlers: A PC that ignores the warning of the "charnel stench"

within this space and investigates for hidden treasure will have a very unhappy time.

HELL HOUNDS AND WRAITH

The **wraith** of General Grislek (Crypt 38) behaves identically to the wraith described in the "Court of the Count" section described above. Meanwhile his three **hell hounds** will zero in on the most vulnerable enemy and attack with their Pack Tactics feature. If there's a second enemy close enough to the first, the hounds will use their Fire Breath feature (provided it's available) to roast both prey, but if not, they'll just stick with their Bite.

BEUCEPHALUS

Beucephalus, Strahd's **nightmare** steed (Crypt 40), is the Dark Lord's valued transportation service, and smart enough to know that. As a result, while he'll put up a fight against character he hasn't met yet, if heavily wounded (reduced to 62 hitpoints or less) within the first two rounds of combat, he will immediately use his Ethereal Stride to retreat to the Ethereal Plane.

When transporting Strahd in combat, Beucephalus will ready an Ethereal Stride action to occur immediately after he attacks (if the nightmare goes first in initiative), or allow Strahd to ready an attack action to take place immediately after Beucephalus transports them to the Material Plane (if the nightmare goes second). When in the Ethereal Plane, Strahd's regeneration can't be stopped by sunlight, making Beucephalus a treasured tool—and a dangerous enemy—for the PCs.

ADDITIONAL NOTES

A few minor notes of personal opinion:

- Leave the “silly names” in the Catacombs (K84) unchanged. It might feel like you’re ruining the horror mood by having the PCs cross paths with “Isolde Yunk” and “Elsa Fallona von Twitterberg,” but spots of light and humor are essential for making the moments of dark and horror hit harder. Moreover, these evocative names encourage the PCs to explore their crypts—without them, it’s just another array of Generic Fantasy Names for the PCs to skip.
- Strahd is *not* omniscient, and that’s doubly true in Castle Ravenloft. As written in previous sections, he is only alerted to the PCs’ presence in the castle if they trigger a noise-making trap, find him in the predestined location, find him as a random encounter, tip him or one of his spies off ahead of time to their presence, or summon him by letting another encounter (e.g., Rahadin) escape to report their presence. Though your PCs should feel terrified of the possibility of running into him, never be unfair; if they sneak through the castle without being stupid, let them escape.
- Yes, I removed Strahd’s phasing lair action in Castle Ravenloft. It’s incredibly unfair and punishing, and turns fights into a binary “he dies immediately, or we all suffer for six hours while he invincibly picks us off, one-by-one.” Seriously, don’t use it.
- Remember: The castle is a living, breathing system, and its occupants are the same. If the PCs smash a table when they visit the first time, that table should either be cleaned up or still smashed when they return. If the PCs kill or alienate a bride of Strahd, that bride stays dead—or pissed-off—when

they come back. If the PCs tied up Cyrus Belview and intimidated him into spilling Strahd’s secrets, he should be very unhappy to see them again. Track what your PCs do in Castle Ravenloft, and make sure to keep those details in order when they return.

- Don’t feel imprisoned by the random encounter table. Instead, each time the PCs visit Ravenloft, pick out ten interesting encounters and scatter them throughout the castle, using the “Territories of the Castle” section above for additional guidance.
- Don’t use the Vistani **thug** or Barovian **commoner** random encounter if you can avoid it. The former plays up some pretty awful stereotypes about Vistani, and the latter is just unnecessary and immersion-breaking (how does a society *survive* so many angry mobs?)
- It’s okay for the PCs to trash a low-level encounter when they’re travelling through Castle Ravenloft. The castle (minus the brides and Rahadin) isn’t actually that dangerous to most adventuring parties; if a 3rd-level party can somehow evade any **wights** or **vampire spawn** they encounter, they should have a pretty easy time getting to their destination.
- If your characters are in Castle Ravenloft at midnight and are in a good position to view it, don’t forget to run the finale of the March of the Dead encounter from the Village of Barovia! It’s spooky, bizarre, and wonderfully foreboding.

ASSETS & AUDIO

BATTLEMAPS

I strongly prefer the free battlemaps created by /u/pigonthewing, which you can find [here](#)

—they're high-quality, easily scaled to a virtual tabletop, and wonderfully detailed.

If you're looking for another style, however, I recommend the (paid) battlemaps by [Venatus](#) or [G Jensen](#).

LOCATION ARTWORK

JamesRPGArt (also known as /u/brochiefwave) has put out some amazing artwork depicting locations throughout Castle Ravenloft. Check out his renditions of the [Chapel](#) (for weddings), [Dining Hall](#) (for dinners), and [Study](#), and follow his [Patreon](#) for still and animated versions of these locations and others locations throughout Barovia.

MUSIC & AMBIENCE

Swordcoast Soundscapes has published some excellent ambience tracks for Castle Ravenloft, including the [main castle](#) and the [catacombs](#).

However, if you're looking for something a little more instrumental to use in your sessions, my personal playlist for Castle Ravenloft is as follows:

- Graveyard (Midnight Syndicate)
- Opus 186—Eternal Night (Sigmund Krähe)
- An Ominous Place (The Witcher)
- Ominous Ambience (The Witcher 3 —Blood and Wine)

Finally, my playlist for the final battle with Strahd includes the following tracks, which can be easily found on YouTube:

- Ludwig the Accursed Holy Blade (Bloodborne)

- Bloody Tears—Orchestral Version (Castlevania)
- Bloody Tears—Orchestral Cover (Castlevania)
- Sir Alonne, Crown of the Old Iron King (Dark Souls II)
- Slave Knight Gael (Dark Souls III)
- Battle Music (The Witcher 2—Assassins of Kings)
- Archangel (Two Steps from Hell)
- Diabolic Clockwork (Two Steps from Hell)
- Fight the Darkness (Two Steps from Hell)
- One Against All (Two Steps from Hell)
- Sarel (Two Steps from Hell)
- Tyrianis (Two Steps From Hell)
- Unforgiven (Two Steps From Hell)
- Divided We Fall (Two Steps From Hell)

Appendix A: Fortunes of Ravenloft

Appendix A: Fortunes of Ravenloft

Depending on the tone and progression you intend for your campaign, you may prefer to avoid placing any treasures or the destined ally within Castle Ravenloft. As the “final dungeon,” exploration of Ravenloft prior to the final showdown may make your PCs feel more familiar or comfortable with the layout of the Castle than you may want. If any of the treasures do appear in Castle Ravenloft, they will likely be guarded and heavily concealed, rather than out in the open for anyone to remove.²²⁵

In order to encourage your PCs to explore a variety of areas, you may prefer to choose to place the treasures within a trio of distant, lesser-travelled regions of Barovia. It is also a wise choice to direct each card’s reading to a separate PC, which should encourage that player to focus on it as though it were a personal quest.

The Tome of Strahd

As a lore-centered item, the Tome of Strahd lacks the late-game power of the Sun Sword and Holy Symbol of Ravenkind. If found at an opportune time, the Tome can provide vital insight into Strahd’s history and character that invests the characters in his story, rather than leaving them focused on their own day-to-day struggles. For this reason, you may choose to place the Tome in one of the more populated areas of Barovia, in order to ensure that your PCs locate it earlier, rather than later.²²⁶

Here are the locations that we recommend placing the Tome of Strahd for your players to find:

Card	Location	History
Torturer (9 of Swords)	The treasure is hidden in the attic of the	The Tome was stolen from Castle Ravenloft by an ancestor of Baron

225 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

226 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

	burgomaster's mansion in Vallaki (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N3s).	Vallakovich. However, the injuries that the thief sustained soon killed him, and his family never understood the value of the old book he had stowed in his bag. The Baron's grandfather shelved it away in the attic long ago, and it has lain there forgotten ever since.
Enchanter (3 of Stars)	The treasure lies under Marina's monument in Berez (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 10, Area U5).	Marina was the first of Tatyana's reincarnations, and the second time Strahd's heart was broken. After her death, Strahd hardened his heart, and buried his Tome beneath her monument as a promise that he would not yearn for the Tatyana of his past, but instead hunt her down in his future.
Abjurer (4 of Stars)	The treasure lies in the beacon of Argynvostholt (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 7, Area Q53).	When Argynvost marched on Castle Ravenloft, only one of his soldiers survived. Given this Tome by the Silver Dragon himself, that soldier bore it back to Argynvostholt, hoping that a brave hero might one day use it to uncover the secrets of Strahd's dark past and so defeat him.
Illusionist (7 of Stars)	The treasure lies in Rictavio's carnival wagon (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N5).	When Saint Markovia marched upon Castle Ravenloft, only one of her followers - a coward of little faith - survived. An illiterate peasant, the follower sold the Tome to a band of Vistani, who paid little mind to the plain, unlabelled book. Many years later, Rudolph van Richten purchased the Tome from a wandering merchant, and discovered within its pages a way by which he could travel into Barovia.
Wizard (Master of Stars)	The treasure lies on the top floor of Van Richten's Tower (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 11, Area V7).	When Saint Markovia marched upon Castle Ravenloft, only one of her followers - a coward of little faith - survived. An illiterate peasant, the follower sold the Tome to a band of Vistani, who paid little mind to the plain, unlabelled book. Many years later, Rudolph van Richten purchased the Tome from a wandering merchant, and discovered within its pages a way by which he could travel into Barovia.
Tax Collector (8 of Coins)	The treasure is hidden in the Vistani treasure wagon (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> ,	When the mists rolled into Barovia, sealing it away from the Material Plane, Strahd was distraught. In a fit of despair, he bade a

	Chapter 5, Area N9i).	friend of his among the Vistani to bear his Tome away from his castle, so that he could no longer recall the sweetness of his victories, nor his love for Tatyana. That Vistani passed the Tome down their familial line, swearing each keeper to secrecy. Today, Arrigal is the keeper of the Tome, but his interest in books is so low that he regards it as little more than one more book among many.
Druid (5 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies at the base of the Gulthias tree (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 14, Area Y4).	When the mists rolled into Barovia, sealing it away from the Material Plane, Strahd was distraught. In a fit of despair, he bade a trusted servant among the druids to bear his Tome away from his castle, so that he could no longer recall the sweetness of his victories, nor his love for Tatyana. That druid joined with their Circle to bury the Tome beneath the roots of the Gulthias sapling, whose roots now cover and bind the book beneath.
Anarchist (6 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies in Castle Ravenloft's hall of bones (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K67).	Over the years, Strahd has lost his interest in the trappings of Castle Ravenloft, and has misplaced many treasures. One such treasure is his Tome, which lies at the center of the table within the Hall of Bones, reverently avoided by Cyrus Belview, who recognizes his master's handwriting.
Charlatan (7 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies in the attic of Old Bonegrinder (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 6, Area O4).	When Saint Markovia marched upon Castle Ravenloft, only one of her followers - a coward of little faith - survived. He filled his bag with treasures and fled the fortress - only to be taken in the night by the hags of Old Bonegrinder as he camped by the road. The hags display the Tome reverently, and believe that its presence is a sign of Strahd's favor.
Traitor (9 of Glyphs)	The treasure is hidden in the master bedroom of Wachterhaus (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N4o).	After the soldier Leo Dilisnya betrayed and murdered Strahd, an ancestor of Lady Wachter hunted him down, providing Strahd with his location. As a show of gratitude, Strahd gifted the House of Wachter with his Tome, and asked them to guard his secrets from any that might seek to steal them.

The Holy Symbol of Ravenkind

The Holy Symbol of Ravenkind is a powerful item for your PCs to obtain, but markedly less lethal to Strahd than the Sunsword, whose ambient radiance can badly harm Strahd's chance of escape from a deadly encounter. Because of this, you may prefer to make the Symbol be the second or third artifact found by your PCs. Because of its generic nature (as compared to the Sunsword), it can serve an important role in directing your PCs toward more isolated areas, such as Berez, Argynvostholt, and the Werewolves' Den.²²⁷

Here are the locations that we recommend placing the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind for your players to find:

Card	Location	History
Avenger (1 of Swords)	The treasure is in the possession of Vladimir Horngard in Argynvostholt (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 7, Area Q36).	The Holy Symbol was an ancient holy relic used by the Order of the Silver Dragon in their crusade against the evil things of this land. Vladimir guards it now, knowing that any who might seek it must do so in order to free the Devil from his prison.
Myrmidon (5 of Swords)	The treasure lies in the shrine of Mother Night in the werewolf den (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 15, Area Z7).	The werewolves of Lake Baratok once raided a church near the shores of Lake Zarovich, and recognized the Holy Symbol as an aspect of Mother Night's divine form. They took it to Mother Night's shrine, where they worship it with fell services and sacrifices.
Enchanter (3 of Stars)	The treasure lies under Marina's monument in Berez (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 10, Area U5).	Queen Ravenovia kept the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind as a token of office; when she died, Strahd kept it in the castle's chapel. When Marina was killed, he buried it beneath her monument as a symbol of his love for her.
Conjurer (9 of Stars)	The treasure is in Baba Lysaga's hut (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 10, Area U3).	The Holy Symbol of Ravenkind was a powerful artifact of divine power kept by Saint Markovia. When Markovia's march on Castle Ravenloft was destroyed, the Symbol found itself in the hands of Baba Lysaga, who kept it under her protection to prevent any other creature from using it to harm Strahd again.

227 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

Beggar (6 of Coins)	The treasure is hidden in Kasimir's hovel (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N9a).	Queen Ravenovia kept the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind as a token of office; when she died, Strahd kept it in the castle's chapel. Once, long ago, Kasimir stole away into the castle in an effort to spirit away his sister's corpse. Instead, he found the Symbol, and felt a powerful compulsion to take it away with him, waiting for an ally powerful enough to wield it.
Shepherd (4 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies in the tomb of King Barov and Queen Ravenovia (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K88).	Queen Ravenovia kept the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind as a token of office; when she died, Strahd buried it alongside her.
Bishop (8 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies in the sealed treasury of the Amber Temple (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 13, Area X40).	The Holy Symbol was a holy artifact found long ago by the wizards of the Amber Temple. They kept it in their treasury alongside a host of other treasures and riches.
Miser (9 of Coins)	The treasure lies in Castle Ravenloft's treasury (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K41).	Queen Ravenovia kept the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind as a token of office; when she died, Strahd sealed it away in his treasury from grief, vowing to keep his mother's memory protected from any that might sully it.

The Sunsword

As discussed above, the Sunsword is likely the most powerful magical item that the PCs will find in the entire module. Its discovery can serve as one of the most climactic moments of the module, second only to the defeat of Strahd himself. For this reason, you may prefer to push it toward a difficult-to-reach or high-level area, such as the Amber Temple or Baba Lysaga's hut.²²⁸

When the PCs first discover the Sunsword, it is inert, bearing only a cracked hilt and no obvious magical power. For more information on how the PCs can restore the Sunsword's strength, see *Sergei's Summons* in [Curse of Strahd: Reloaded, Chapter 10: The Village of Krezk](#).

Here are the locations that we recommend placing the Sunsword for your players to find:

Card	Location	History
------	----------	---------

²²⁸ /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

Avenger (1 of Swords)	The treasure is in the possession of Vladimir Horngaard in Argynvostholt (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 7, Area Q36).	When Khazan's apprentice stole the Sunsword's hilt, he fled into the forest. There, he was recognized and slain by a wandering revenant. The undead knight recognized the blade and delivered it to Vladimir, who has kept the blade out of the hands who may use it against the Devil.
Paladin (2 of Swords)	The treasure lies in Sergei's tomb (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K85).	When the Sunsword's hilt was left in the Svalich Wood, Sergei's spirit was able to spirit it away out of Strahd's sight, to the one place where he knew his brother would never dare look: Sergei's own coffin in Castle Ravenloft.
Conjurer (9 of Stars)	The treasure is in Baba Lysaga's hut (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 10, Area U3).	Soon after the Sunsword's hilt was left in the Svalich Wood, a servant of Baba Lysaga found it upon the ground, and brought it to the old witch as a gift. Lysaga recognized the blade, and has kept it under lock and key ever since to ensure that no creature can use it to harm Strahd.
Beggar (6 of Coins)	The treasure is hidden in Kasimir's hovel (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N9a).	When Khazan's apprentice stole the Sunsword's hilt, he was overcome by a platoon of vengeful spirits. Kasimir watched the battle from a hiding place, and recognized the Sunsword's hilt. When the apprentice fell, Kasimir took the treasure back to his camp, and swore to keep it for a hero who would one day overthrow the tyrant Strahd.
Monk (1 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies in the main hall of the Abbey of Saint Markovia (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 8, Area S13).	After the Sunsword's hilt was left in the Svalich Wood, it lay there for centuries - until the Abbot arrived in Barovia. The Abbot was immediately drawn to the strong, holy power possessed by the artifact, and spirited it away to the Abbey of Saint Markovia, where he occasionally uses it as a holy symbol for communion with the Morninglord.
Healer (3 of Glyphs)	The treasure lies beneath the gazebo in the Shrine of the White Sun (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 8, Area S4).	When the Sunsword's hilt was left in the Svalich Wood, Sergei's spirit was able to spirit it away to the one place where his soul could still touch the land of Barovia: the Shrine of the White Sun, near the Blessed Pool of Krezk.
Bishop (8 of	The treasure lies in the	When the Sunsword's hilt was left in the

Glyphs)	sealed treasury of the Amber Temple (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 13, Area X40).	Svalich Wood, Sergei's spirit was able to spirit it away to Saint Markovia, which she took as a sign to march upon Castle Ravenloft. Once the rebellion was destroyed, Strahd seized the hilt. With Khazan dead, Strahd was unable to destroy the hilt himself. He stored it in the Amber Temple, and bade Exethanter to guard it from any who might seek its power.
---------	---	--

Strahd's Enemy

Due to their low hitpoints and the negligible impact of the advantage-providing buff given to the PCs' destined Ally by the module, it is highly recommended that you provide the PCs with an ally of at least CR 3. Several of the potential allies provided by the module have fascinating, compelling storylines of their own, and it is highly recommended that you work to weave those side narratives tightly within the central trunk of your plot.

Here are the enemies that we recommend as best-suited to a mechanically and dramatically satisfying conclusion to your *Curse of Strahd* campaign:

Card	Enemy	Notes
Artifact (Joker 1)	This card refers to Rictavio, who can be found at the Blue Water Inn in Vallaki (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N2).	Rictavio makes for an excellent ally to the PCs, providing healing and support buffs from mid- to late-game. He can easily serve as a mentor or adviser to the PCs, and can play a central role to the story given Strahd's interest in finding him.
Beast (Jack of Diamonds)	This card refers to the werewolf Zuleika Toranescu (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 15, Area Z7).	If you have few hooks to lead your PCs to the Werewolf Den, Zuleika can serve as a strong incentive for them to find it. Her aggressive personality and darker past can serve as an excellent foil to good-aligned PCs. Her personal quest also provides an interesting twist to the final showdown with Strahd, and gives the PCs an insight into the struggles between Strahd's servants.
Broken One (King of Diamonds)	This card refers to the Mad Mage of Mount Baratok (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 2, Area M).	The Mad Mage is a character frequently touched upon in passing by other characters, but never explicitly. If your PCs meet him, he can serve as a piece of living

		history that they are unlikely to meet otherwise; a side quest in his own right (due to his need for a <i>Greater Restoration</i> spell); and a plot hook for adventures beyond Barovia following the end of the module.
Seer (Jack of Clubs)	This card refers to Kasimir Velikov (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 5, Area N9a).	Kasimir is rooted strongly in the history of Barovia, and can provide context to the PCs regarding a number of events, locations, and personages. Moreover, he is a sympathetic example of Strahd's cruelty, and can serve as an adviser to Ireena. His side quest with Patrina is unlikely to be a focus of most non-allied PCs, and Patrina herself can serve as an excellent late-game or post-game opponent or rival.
Ghost (King of Hearts)	This card refers to the revenant Sir Godfrey Gwilym (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 7, Area Q37).	While not well-developed or emotive in the module, Sir Godfrey can provide additional incentive for your PCs to explore Argynvostholt. His past relationship with Vladimir Horngaard is an excellent example of LGBTQ representation, and he can serve as the fuel that drives your PCs to uncover Argynvost's quest and return the dragon's skull to the mansion's tower.
Mists (Queen of Spades)	This card refers to Ezmerelda d'Avenir. She can be found in the Abbey of Saint Markovia (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 8, Area S19), as well as several other locations throughout Barovia.	Like Rictavio, Ezmerelda makes for an excellent supporter in combat, and a potentially fascinating and entertaining ally. She makes for a welcome positive example of the Vistani, and her relationship with Van Richten may deliver her mentor as a two-for-one contact or ally for the PCs. The one drawback: Ezmerelda is likely to join the PCs even if she is not the destined ally, which means her selection could deprive your party of an additional friendly NPC toward the end of the module.

Strahd's Location

A hefty amount of the fun of the final fight with Strahd comes from the dungeon crawl that precedes it, as well as the romp through the castle that follows. If Strahd senses that trespassers have entered his castle uninvited, he will make sure to prepare for them, forcing any

intruders to whittle down their resources before a final confrontation. Because of this, areas of very high or very low elevation may be optimal for Strahd's final location.²²⁹

Here are the areas that we recommend as the most narratively and dramatically satisfying locations to begin the conclusion of your *Curse of Strahd* campaign:

Card	Location	Notes
Beast (Jack of Diamonds)	Strahd faces the characters in the audience hall (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K25).	As seen in this Ravenloft trailer , the Audience Hall can make for a powerful and memorable location for a final encounter. It has easy access to the K64 and K21 staircases, as well as the Heart of Sorrow's tower. It is, however, fairly accessible to PCs that enter through the front door, which may reduce the number of trials your PCs must go through on their way to their final battle.
Broken One (King of Diamonds)	Strahd faces the characters in Sergei's Tomb (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K85).	The story of Strahd and Sergei is a powerful part of the lore of this module. There may be no better way to portray the wretched humanity and monstrous corruption of the Darklord Strahd than to begin his final battle weeping over his brother's tomb. It is a fitting place to mark Strahd's end, just as Sergei's death marked his vampiric beginnings.
Darklord (King of Spades)	Strahd faces the characters in his tomb (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area K86).	There may be no more climactic or traditional place to duel a vampire than the tomb where his coffin rests. Buried deep within the catacombs of Castle Ravenloft, a final showdown in Strahd's tomb ensures that your PCs must battle through hordes of encounters to face off with the master. But beware - the climax of <i>Curse of Strahd</i> should not be the beginning of their fight, but its denouement, when they realize that Strahd's mist form is fleeing for the safety of its tomb. Should they defeat Strahd here, the urgency of that chase is lost.
Marionette (Jack of Hearts)	Strahd faces the characters in the north tower peak (<i>Curse of Strahd</i> , Chapter 4, Area	The North Tower Peak is remote, dreary, and dangerous - all perfect descriptors for a final showdown with Strahd. It may be preferable to move this encounter to K60a,

229 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

	K60).	the North Tower Rooftop, which paints a climactic picture of Strahd standing beneath a thunderstorm, his cloak billowing in the wind as lightning strikes overhead. Due to its proximity to the Heart of Sorrow's staircase, this location can make for an exciting chase through the castle. However, it lacks the thematic resonance that other locations have, and may prove fatiguing for your PCs to find.
--	-------	---

Personal Readings & Quests

In order to invest your PCs more strongly into the narrative of the module, you may choose for Madam Eva to offer personal readings to each of the PCs in addition to her five central predictions. Should you do this, Madam Eva draws two cards for each PC: one to describe the PC's backstory and personal conflict; and one to direct the PC toward a means to achieve a goal or spur personal growth.²³⁰

If you have chosen to use the **Madam Eva's Invitation** adventure hook, the PCs are already in possession of their first card.

As these predictions are tailored to each PC, it is impossible to standardize these readings for any given party. However, you can find below a number of suggested readings for the second card that you may modify to better fit your PCs.

Card	PC's Background/Quest	Madam Eva's Reading
Avenger (1 of Swords)		
Paladin (2 of Swords)	All your life, you have dreamed of becoming a true hero. It is your destiny to free Barovia of darkness.	<i>The shadow over this land has grown as dark as a Devil's heart. It is your hand that will return sunlight to its halls - if the darkness does not swallow you up in its maw.</i>
Soldier (3 of Swords)	You seek a path toward enlightenment. A mystic of the berserker tribes awaits you atop the tower at Tsolenka.	<i>You seek belonging - not merely within the world, but of the world. Go to the mountains. Climb the white tower guarded by the golden knights.</i>
Mercenary (4 of Swords)		

230 /u/MandyMod, [Fleshing Out Curse of Strahd: Tser Pool, the Vistani, and the Ultimate Tarroka Reading](#)

Myrmidon (5 of Swords)	Your village was raided by a pack of marauding werewolves, and a priceless treasure was stolen. Retrieve it from the shrine of Mother Night.	<i>Look for the den of wolves in the hills overlooking a mountain lake. The treasure belongs to Mother Night.</i>
Berserker (6 of Swords)	Your ancestors were separated from their tribe when the mists first shrouded Barovia. Yearning for a connection to your ancestry, you must find the berserker tribes and recreate the bond between your peoples.	<i>The song of blades sings in your heart, and cries out for a chorus. The ice-clad mountains will echo your song with the voices of your ancestors.</i>
Hooded One (7 of Swords)	A demon lurks inside you - a shard of one of a dark vestige. You must journey to the Amber Temple and confront its source to rid yourself of its influence forevermore.	<i>The darkness within you is strong, but all is not lost. Its source awaits your coming, beyond amber gates at the heart of a mountain. Beware the choice! Beware refusing it!</i>
Dictator (8 of Swords)	You seek influence, power, and dominion - either from greed, or from a thirst to prove your worth. It is your destiny to take Strahd's throne, whether by right of conquest or by right of succession.	<i>I see a throne as your seat, and a scepter in your hand. But beware! He that conquers the Devil may himself become the Devil.</i>
Torturer (9 of Swords)		
Warrior (Master of Swords)	You seek to prove your worth as an adult of your clan or tribe. You can do so by claiming the Blood Spear of Kavan, buried beneath the cairns of Yester Hill.	<i>Your blade thirsts for blood, as your soul hungers for recognition. Seek out the mist-clad hill, where the tombs of the ancients hold the instrument of your glory.</i>
Transmuter (1 of Stars)	A close friend or relative of yours vanished into a dark mist, and was turned by Strahd into vampire spawn. Find where Strahd keeps them locked in Castle Ravenloft, and free them from their life of undeath with the gift of a true, good death.	<i>The blood of your blood has gone cold, and only mist yet remains. Find them in the highest peak, and free them of their unholy torment.</i>

Diviner (2 of Stars)		
Enchanter (3 of Stars)		
Abjurer (4 of Stars)	You are a direct descendant of Argynvost. Return the dragon's skull to its crypt, and speak with your ancestor before allowing his spirit to rest.	<i>Your eyes burn with flame, and your blood cries out for blood. I see a fallen house guarded by a great stone dragon. Look to the highest peak.</i>
Elementalist (5 of Stars)	A voice has whispered in your dreams, inviting you to a place of unadulterated power. This dark voice is a vestige of the Amber Temple, and seeks to offer your character that which they desire most.	<i>A shadow's whispers beckon you to the darkest chasm of the highest mountain. There, in tombs of amber, awaits the thing that you desire most. But beware! A honeyed gift can prove a fool's curse.</i>
Evoker (6 of Stars)		
Illusionist (7 of Stars)	You seek the aid of the legendary Dr. Rudolph van Richten. You must find him and assist him in Strahd's destruction. Only then can he return to help you.	<i>Help is often found in the strangest of places. Look for an entertaining man with a monkey. This man is more than he seems.</i>
Necromancer (8 of Stars)	Many years ago, a close friend or relative died from sickness or violence. You seek the power to raise them from the dead - the power of Zhudun, the Corpse Star.	<i>The arrow of time moves ever forward, but the warp of magic can render new life to the souls of the dead through its weave. Follow the light of the Corpse Star, in the place where amber giants sleep.</i>
Conjurer (9 of Stars)		
Wizard (Master of Stars)	You thirst for power, and yearn to prove your might in the arcane arts. Khazan's Staff of Power awaits you, deep within the catacombs of Castle Ravenloft.	<i>A fire burns in your belly, and a star glows in your eye. Find the mage's staff in his resting place beneath the Devil's keep. His name is the power you seek.</i>
Swashbuckler (1 of Coins)	A close friend or relative of yours journeyed into Barovia some time ago. You seek to	<i>Alas! I see swirling snow and frigid ice. The reaper's shadow grows long, and the mountaintops ring with the pleas of</i>

	track them to the place that overcame them - the Amber Temple - and bring them back home.	<i>a lost soul.</i>
Philanthropist (2 of Coins)		
Trader (3 of Coins)	Long ago, you were inflicted with the sickness of lycanthropy, or a similar dark curse. The wizard of Wines can help you find inner peace and control the darkness of your curse.	<i>The beast within you is savage, yet all creatures can be tamed. Find the leader of the feathered ones who live among the vines. Though old, he has wisdom deep within his bones.</i>
Merchant (4 of Coins)		
Guild Member (5 of Coins)		
Beggar (6 of Coins)	You are the descendant of dusk elves - refugees from Strahd's military campaign in Barovia. You seek to find the last of your people and restore their civilization.	<i>A scarred elf has what you seek. He will assist your quest to see his dark dreams fulfilled.</i>
Thief (7 of Coins)		
Tax Collector (8 of Coins)		
Miser (9 of Coins)	You are descended from refugees that fled from Strahd's invasion of Barovia. Those refugees left behind a priceless family heirloom that now rests in the treasury of Castle Ravenloft.	<i>The thing you seek lies amidst glittering gold and countless treasures. Look for a fortress within a fortress, in a place hidden by fire.</i>
Rogue (Master of Coins)		
Monk (1 of Glyphs)	You have been sent to Barovia on the divine command of Lathander or Pelor, the Morninglord. You will come to discover their wish: to destroy the corrupted	<i>The words of the divine fall on deaf ears, muffled by the shadowed mists. Find the damned one in his place of worship, and free his radiant soul of the madness of mortality.</i>

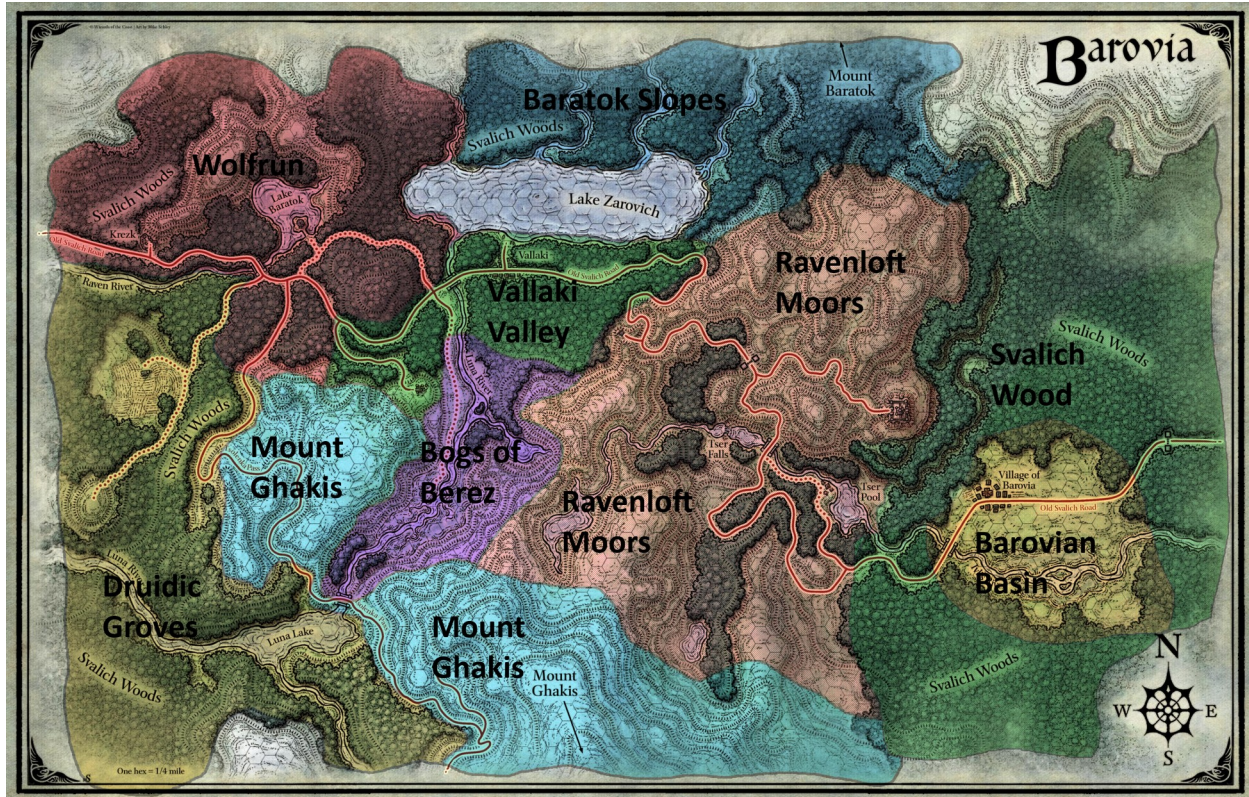
	Abbot, and allow his transcendent soul to return to the Astral Plane, cleansed of the madness of Barovia.	
Missionary (2 of Glyphs)	You have been cast out by your holy order or betrayed your sacred oaths. To regain your deity's favor, you must recover the holy symbol of Tasha Petrovna from her crypt beneath Castle Ravenloft and return it to her grave in Krezk.	<i>The light has fled your blade, and your angel has turned her face away to weep. Her grace will be returned to you, but only if you rescue the saint's sun beneath the devil's tower and restore it to its rightful place.</i>
Healer (3 of Glyphs)		
Shepherd (4 of Glyphs)	The spirits of fae and woodland have begged you to restore the natural order of corrupted Barovia. You must sanctify the megaliths of Barovia, and restore the druidic Fanes to the domain of the Ladies Three.	<i>The Devil is the ancient, and so has become the land. You must restore the holy places of the elder Three, whose whispers are as wind and whose tears are as dew. Look to the misted hill, the drowned spirits, and the lonely mill. Listen to the raven's cry.</i>
Druid (5 of Glyphs)	A shadowed plague of blight and blood has overtaken the forest of your homeland. You must destroy the Gulthias Tree, and craft from its branches a weapon to cleanse your home.	<i>An evil tree grows atop a hill of graves where the ancient dead sleep. The ravens can help you find it. From its roots you shall craft your salvation.</i>
Anarchist (6 of Glyphs)	Your ancestor was a storied general who led the defense against Strahd's invasion of Barovia. Today, his bones rest in Strahd's Hall of Bones, and only you can restore them to their rightful resting place in your family's crypt or burial ground.	<i>Your blood's spirit yet languishes beneath the Devil's watchful eye. I see walls of bones, a chandelier of bones, and a table of bones - all that remains of enemies long forgotten.</i>
Charlatan (7 of Glyphs)		
Bishop (8 of Glyphs)	Legends tell of a powerful, yet lost magical relic. That relic lies forgotten in the vast	<i>What you seek lies in a pile of treasure, beyond a set of amber doors.</i>

	treasury of the Amber Temple.	
Traitor (9 of Glyphs)		
Priest (Master of Glyphs)	You fear death like no other, and dread your own mortality. You seek immortality - and Dahlver-nar, He of the Many Lives, can provide you with the life everlasting that you desire.	<i>Your soul fears the outer darkness, and seeks life everlasting. Should you find He of the Many Lives, no reaper's clock can restrain you. He awaits you in a tomb of amber, in a place of ice and darkness.</i>
Artifact (Joker 1)		
Beast (Jack of Diamonds)	A marauding tribe of werewolves destroyed your home. You seek revenge.	<i>The vengeance you seek is yet within your grasp. Look for the den of wolves in the hills overlooking a mountain lake.</i>
Broken One (Kind of Diamonds)	One year ago, your mentor, the archmage Mordenkainen, vanished on an adventure. You seek to discover his fate.	<i>I see a great chasm, and a body swallowed up by wind and water. This man's mind is broken, but his spells are strong.</i>
Darklord (King of Spades)	You seek greatness - power, dominion, and influence - at any cost. Zantras, the Kingmaker, can provide you the tools you need to achieve this.	<i>I see a throne as your seat, and a scepter within your hand. Seek the Kingmaker in his amber prison, but beware his silver tongue.</i>
Donjon (King of Clubs)	A close friend or relative of yours journeyed into Barovia some time ago. You seek to track them to the place of their imprisonment - Baba Lysaga's hut - and bring them back home.	<i>The one you seek yet lives, but suffers in a den of cruelty and despair. I see a dead village, drowned by a river, ruled by one who has brought great evil into the world.</i>
Seer (Jack of Clubs)		
Ghost (King of Hearts)	Your ancestor was a knight of the Order of the Silver Dragon who betrayed his vows and fled when Strahd's forces overtook the land. You seek to restore your family's honor,	<i>Only blood can pay for honor. I see a fallen house guarded by a great stone dragon. Look to the highest peak.</i>

	and can do so by restoring the bones of Argynvost to their rightful resting place.	
Executioner (Jack of Spades)	You are an orphan or adopted by your parents. You crave knowledge of your family and the comfort of a household. Izek is your brother, and his twisted form matches your own tiefling's appearance or demonic spirit.	<i>A beast has marked your soul, and its twin lurks in the heart of a man shrouded in flame. Marked as a devil, this twisted creature can show you the way to your spirit's cleansing. But, beware! He is no hero</i>
Horseman (Joker 2)		
Innocent (Queen of Hearts)		
Marionette (Jack of Hearts)		
Mists (Queen of Spades)	You and Ezmerelda d'Avenir learned together under the tutelage of Dr. Rudolph van Richten. Soon after Van Richten vanished on a secret mission, Ezmerelda departed to find and assist him. You hope to find Ezmerelda and fight by her side.	<i>A Vistana wanders this land alone, searching for her mentor. She does not stay in one place for long. Seek her out in the sun's holy place, where its rays once shone from the peak above the mists.</i>
Raven (Queen of Clubs)		
Tempter (Queen of Diamonds)	More than anything, you yearn to fly - to soar the skies and defy the power of gravity. The Dark Power Tarakamedes can deliver unto you gift of flight - but at a price.	<i>Neither dragon nor djinn holds sway in these mists, but the Grave Wyrms gift can set you free. His price is steep, but his offering is true. Seek him in the place where ice and amber meet.</i>

Appendix D: Regions of Barovia & Random Encounters

Regional Map of Barovia



Svalich Wood

NPC Encounters

A team of Barovian **commoners** searching for a missing person abducted by

- a pack of **werewolves**
- a vengeful **ghost**
- a horde of hungry **ghouls**
- a pair of cannibalistic **druids**

A pair of Barovian **scouts** searching for a missing person abducted by

- a pack of **werewolves**
- a vengeful **ghost**
- a horde of hungry **ghouls**
- a pair of cannibalistic **druids**

A travelling Vistani family of **commoners** in a barrel-top wagon heading toward

- the Tser Pool encampment
- the Vallaki encampment
- the outside town of Daggerford

the outside city of Neverwinter

A lonely **werewolf** hermit

A cautious **archer** tracking an elk

A babbling **ghost** that asks travellers to lead it to its home

A pair of Barovian **scouts** offering a sacrifice to the Ladies Three

Combat Encounters

A pack of 2d6+1 hungry **wolves** (Levels 1-4)

A thirsty colony of 2d4+1 **swarms of bats** (Levels 1-4)

A giant boar fending off 4d4 **twig blights** (Levels 1-4)

A pack of 1d4+1 hungry **direwolves** (Levels 2-5)

A host of 1d4 **ghosts** haunting their unmarked graves (Levels 3-10)

A nest of 1d8 **giant spiders** awaiting a meal (Levels 1-8)

A hostile **dryad** defending her grove alongside 1d4 **thornies** (Levels 3-5)

Interesting Phenomena

A forgotten hunting trap

A mutilated corpse

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A forgotten trinket lying in the mud

Several watchful swarms of ravens

A carved stone figurine of a maiden tucked into the hollow of an old tree

A skeletal rider

Notable Landmarks

A crumbling chapel maintained by a kindly **ghost**

This old structure once held a shrine visited by travellers on the road. The ghost is the spirit of an old monk who once tended its chapel. The spirit is lonely, and has seen the building fall into disrepair as the woods grew up around its walls.

An old or excavated grave

This ancient headstone marks the remains of a Barovian soldier, who died of sickness during Strahd's campaign to conquer the land.

Barovian Basin

NPC Encounters

A team of Barovian **commoners** tending to their fields

A travelling Vistani family of **commoners** in a barrel-top wagon heading toward

- the Tser Pool encampment
- the Vallaki encampment
- the outside town of Daggerford
- the outside city of Neverwinter

A shepherd's **ghost** watching over the spirit of a lamb

Combat Encounters

None

Interesting Phenomena

A skeletal rider

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A forgotten trinket lying in the mud

A watchful swarm of ravens perched atop a dead tree

Notable Landmarks

A crumbling chapel maintained by a kindly spirit

This old structure once held a shrine visited by travellers on the road. The ghost is the spirit of an old monk who once tended its chapel. The spirit is lonely, and has seen the building fall into disrepair as the woods grew up around its walls.

An old gravesite near an old ruin

This small collection of graves mark a Barovian farming family that died of a supernatural plague in the night. Their residence, thought cursed by the locals, lies crumbling nearby.

Ravenloft Moors

NPC Encounters

A wandering **revenant** hunting zombies

A trader's caravan led by a watchful **scout** travelling to
the village of Barovia
the village of Vallaki

An eccentric **apprentice wizard** communing with a lost soul

A babbling **ghost** that asks travellers to lead it to its home

A **vampire spawn** swordsman searching for a worthy opponent

A faceless **wraith** that stalks travellers atop a dark horse

A travelling Vistani family of **commoners** in a barrel-top wagon heading toward
the Tser Pool encampment
the Vallaki encampment
the outside town of Daggerford
the outside city of Neverwinter

A **wereraven** monitoring the road in raven form

The **green hag** Jenny Greenteeth and her rattling wagon of wares

Combat Encounters

A group of 1d4 **vampire spawn** feeding on the corpse of an ill-fated traveller (Levels 4-10)

A cloud of 1d4 blood-starved **vampiric mists** (Levels 3-9)

A pack of 2d4 **ghouls** picking through the remains of fallen travelers (Levels 2-7)

Interesting Phenomena

A mutilated corpse

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A skeletal rider

A watchful **swarm of ravens** perched atop a dead tree

Notable Landmarks

A burnt ruin haunted by a fiery **poltergeist**

A pair of vampire spawn invaded this house years ago. Its owner fled the structure and set it aflame, burning the spawn alive - but leaving her spouse and child to die in fire as she fled for Vallaki. The poltergeist is the spirit of the owner's spouse, and acts to protect its child's unburied bones. The poltergeist is put to rest if the bones are buried.

A crumbling tower above a bone-strewn courtyard

*This ancient watchtower is all that remains of a ruined fort used by the forces of Delmor during Strahd's invasion. It stands above a flat, grassy yard scattered with rusted armor and old bones. The tower was stormed by Strahd's forces long ago, and contains at its peak a brass **spyglass**. A person that looks through the spyglass sees the world suffering beneath a terrible storm, and sees only ghostly images when viewing characters non-native to Barovia. A character that dies and is resurrected in Barovia appears solid to the spyglass thereafter. A character that lingers in this tower can hear the whistling of wind and the far-away sound of marching troops, both of which soon fade.*

A forgotten chapel ruined by age

This old shrine bears two altars: one to the Morninglord, and one to Mother Night. The Morninglord's fine wooden altar has decayed over time, leaving its carved sunburst barely visible. Mother Night's stone altar still bears the mark of her crescent moon, but moss and fungi have overgrown her side of the sanctum, cracking and crumbling the floor.

An underground crypt housing a colony of **swarms of bats**

The stone slab that covered the entrance to this crypt was pushed aside long ago, revealing crumbling stone steps leading down. The crypt contains three simple stone coffins of Delmorean nobility, the coffins' carved text faded beyond legibility. The crypt has been looted of everything but the skeletons; however, a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) reveals a silver, crescent moon-shaped pendant forgotten behind a crypt. The chamber now serves as a home to a colony of bats, who rest here in the day and attack any creature that wakes them, fleeing once reduced to half hitpoints.

A mossy standing stone slab bearing a carving of a wolf

This slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It was constructed as a monument to the Huntress of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived.

Vallaki Valley

NPC Encounters

- A wandering **revenant** hunting wolves
- A team of Vallakian **commoners** searching for a missing person
- A pair of Vallakian **scouts** searching for a missing person
- A travelling Vistani family of **commoners** in a barrel-top wagon heading toward
 - the Tser Pool encampment
 - the Vallaki encampment
 - the outside town of Daggerford
 - the outside city of Neverwinter
- A trader's caravan led by a watchful **scout**
- A Vallakian **archer** tracking an elk
- A Vallakian **guard** pursuing a murderer
- A deranged **homunculus** gathering ingredients for its master
- A pair of Vallakian **scouts** offering a sacrifice to the Ladies Three
- A demented herbalist **druid** picking mushrooms in the forest
- The **green hag** Jenny Greenteeth and her rattling wagon of wares
- A **wereraven** monitoring the woods in raven form
- A coven of Vallakian **cultists** preparing an animal sacrifice

Combat Encounters

- A pack of 1d4+1 hungry **direwolves** (Levels 2-5)
- A pack of 2d6+1 hungry **wolves** (Levels 1-4)
- A thirsty colony of 2d4+1 **swarms of bats** (Levels 1-4)

Interesting Phenomena

- A forgotten hunting trap
- A mutilated corpse
- A forgotten trinket lying in the mud
- A skeletal rider
- Several **swarms of ravens**
- A carved stone figurine of a maiden tucked into the hollow of an old tree

Notable Landmarks

- An old or excavated grave
- This grave contains the remnants of a pair of Vallakian farmers.*

An overgrown fenced-in cemetery populated by wandering **zombies**
This overgrown, fenced-in cemetery once housed the dead of a small hamlet beyond Vallaki's walls. Its twelve zombies are now overgrown with moss and mushrooms, and do not pursue intruders beyond its rusted fence. The three homes and well that once comprised the hamlet lie just over a hundred yards away.

A maddened **ghost** that attacks any that enter its grove

This spirit is the final remnant of a hunter who was slain by a pack of wolves. It haunts the site of its death, and cannot be calmed so long as its bones remain unburied. Its bones can be found in a small hollow beneath the roots of a nearby tree, wound within the chain of an old pewter locket.

A forgotten chapel defaced and desecrated by **cultists**

Lady Wachter's most devout followers travel here on the night of each new moon, repeating profane rituals as they mark the walls and altar with diabolic symbols.

A crumbling sanctuary maintained by a kindly **ghost**

This old structure once held a shrine visited by travellers on the road. The ghost is the spirit of an old monk who once tended its chapel. The spirit is lonely, and has seen the building fall into disrepair as the woods grew up around its walls.

A trio of **giant spiders** lurking beneath a footbridge

This old stone bridge crosses a wide ditch fifteen feet across and twelve feet deep, with steep sides and few handholds. Each spider has constructed a web-woven lair beneath a separate side of the bridge. The spiders attack any creature that passes over the footbridge alone.

Passers-by can see a well-worn trail that winds toward the south on the Barovian and Vallakian ends of the bridge. Any traveller that follows the trail through the trees eventually comes to a newer wooden bridge that provides safe passage across the ravine.

A mossy standing stone slab bearing a carving of a tree or wolf

This slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It was constructed as a monument to the Weaver (tree) or Huntress (wolf) of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived.

Bogs of Berez

NPC Encounters

A wandering **revenant** hunting scarecrows

An eccentric **apprentice wizard** communing with a lost soul

A deranged **homunculus** gathering ingredients for its master

An outcast **commoner** cursed by a witch to bring pestilence upon their surroundings

A solitary herbalist **druid** picking mushrooms in the bog

Combat Encounters

A pack of 2d4 scavenging **shadow mastiffs** (Levels 3-10)

1d2 maddened **wraiths** that attack any that enter their grove (Levels 4-9)

A bubbling marsh filled by 4d4 **ash zombies** bloated with poison gas (Levels 2-7)

1d4 undead **giant constrictor snakes** mindlessly searching for flesh (Levels 2-8)

A pack of 2d4 **ghouls** picking through the remains of fallen travelers (Levels 2-7)

A **will-o-wisp** leading unwary travellers to a ruin infested by 2d6 **zombies** (Levels 3-7)
1d2 maddened **banshees** wandering a mossy fen (Levels 3-7)
A nest of 1d4 **phase spiders** awaiting a meal (Levels 2-9)
A wandering **corpse flower** (Levels 5-8)

Interesting Phenomena

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears
A forgotten trinket lying in the mud
A skeletal rider

Notable Locations

A sunken farm guarded by watchful **scarecrows**

The farm was abandoned years ago when a pack of rabid werewolves killed its inhabitants. A rotting wooden barn is the only remaining structure on this old field. Tall grasses and cattails border the several swampy streams that trickle through the loamy soil. The barn contains a half-decayed loft and a set of stalls once used for oxen, but is otherwise empty. The scarecrow are spies for Baba Lysaga, and attack any PCs that approach the barn while one scarecrow returns to Berez to inform its master.

A mad alchemist's lonely cottage

The alchemist and his homunculus can be found gathering ingredients elsewhere in Barovia. This cottage holds his living quarters, study, and laboratory. He is trying to create a potion of immortality.

An overgrown fenced-in cemetery populated by wandering **zombies**

This cemetery once housed the dead of Berez. Its zombies are swollen with bog-water and do not pursue intruders beyond its rusted iron fences.

A forgotten chapel ruined by age

This old shrine bears two altars: one to the Morninglord, and one to Mother Night. The Morninglord's fine wooden altar has rotted away completely. Mother Night's stone altar still bears the mark of her crescent moon, but moss and fungi have overgrown her side of the sanctum, cracking and crumbling the floor. It was swallowed up by the swamps when Berez was destroyed.

A mossy standing stone slab bearing a carving of a single eye

This slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It was constructed as a monument to the Seeker of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived.

Baratok Slopes

NPC Encounters

A solitary herbalist **druid** picking mushrooms in the grasslands

An outcast **commoner** cursed by a witch to bring pestilence upon their surroundings

Combat Encounters

1d4 mutated brown bears with the features and temperaments of **owlbears** (Level 2-9)

Interesting Phenomena

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A watchful **swarm of ravens** perched atop a dead tree

A mutated **giant elk** with multicolored horns

A tree split by a lightning bolt

Notable Locations

A swarm of tormented **ghosts** trapped within a darkened cavern

*An old well at the center of this cavern holds the souls of twelve shrieking ghosts, whose remains have settled at the bottom of the cistern beneath. These wretched spirits were trapped here by a necromancer who sought to devour their life force and so grow powerful enough to defeat Strahd. Any creature that approaches the well finds themselves surrounded by the ghosts, who are bound to the shaft of the well by ethereal chains when manifested. The ghosts attack if the well is damaged. If the spirits are spoken to, one of them requests that their bones be recovered from the waters beneath. 1d4 **shambling mounds** lurk in the cistern, and attack if the bones are disturbed.*

Mount Ghakis

NPC Encounters

A meditating **revenant** guarding the path

A group of **berserkers** hunting a goat

An injured **berserker**, wounded by

a **winter wolf**

the **Roc** of Mt. Ghakis

Sangzor the **giant goat**

Combat Encounters

A pack of 1d4 **winter wolves** prowling their territory (Level 2-9)

A 1d2 hungry **cave bears** hunting for food (Levels 2-4)

1d2 cannibalistic adventurers cursed to become **bodaks** by deals with a vestige (Levels 5-10)

Interesting Phenomena

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A herd of **goats** grazing on sparse grass

A forgotten trinket buried beneath a snowdrift

A frozen **zombie** buried beneath a snowdrift

A skeletal rider

A rockslide that threatens to knock the party down toward the banks of Luna Lake

Notable Locations

A crumbling tower atop a snow-covered peak

This old structure was once employed by the army of Delmor as a watchtower overlooking the southwestern corner of Barovia. The tower was stormed by Strahd's forces long ago, and contains at its base a small, rotted wooden chest. The chest contains a broken pendant of a silver dragon that's always cold to the touch.

A swarm of tormented **ghosts** trapped within a darkened cavern

*An old well at the center of this cavern holds the souls of twelve shrieking ghosts, whose remains have settled at the bottom of the cistern beneath. These wretched spirits were trapped here by a necromancer who sought to devour their life force and so grow powerful enough to defeat Strahd. Any creature that approaches the well finds themselves surrounded by the ghosts, who are bound to the shaft of the well by ethereal chains when manifested. The ghosts attack if the well is damaged. If the spirits are spoken to, one of them requests that their bones be recovered from the waters beneath. 1d4 **shambling mounds** lurk in the cistern, and attack if the bones are disturbed.*

2d4 **swarms of bats** living in a shallow cave

The bats rest in this shallow cave during the day and attack any creature that wakes them, fleeing once reduced to half hitpoints.

Druidic Groves

NPC Encounters

A deranged **homunculus** gathering ingredients for its master

An outcast **commoner** cursed by a witch to bring pestilence upon their surroundings

A **werewolf** forester building a life away from civilization

A pair of Krezkian **scouts** offering a sacrifice to the Ladies Three

A solitary herbalist **druid** picking mushrooms in the forest

A group of **berserkers** hunting an elk

A **wereraven** monitoring the woods in raven form

The **green hag** Jenny Greenteeth and her rattling wagon of wares

Combat Encounters

A pack of 2d6 **worgs** (Levels 1-8)

A cannibalistic **druid** accompanied by a swarm of 2d6 **twig blights** (Levels 3-5)

A pack of 4d4 concealed **needle blights** (Levels 2-7)

Interesting Phenomena

A mutilated corpse

A ghostly fog that brings hallucinations of old regrets and hidden fears

A forgotten trinket lying amidst a patch of yellowed grasses
Several swarms of ravens
A carved stone figurine of a maiden tucked into the hollow of an old tree

Notable Locations

An overgrown field guarded by a single watchful **scarecrow**

A rotting wooden barn is the only remaining structure on this old, overgrown field. The barn contains a half-decayed loft and a set of stalls once used for oxen, but is otherwise empty. The scarecrow is a spy for Baba Lysaga and flees when not under direct observation, returning to Berez to deliver information to its master.

A false trail carved by **druids**

*The road splits in twain at this misted intersection. The eastern path winds through a blighted ridge that borders a rocky hill; the western path cuts through an autumnal grove. The western trail was created by druids, and leads to a spiked pit trap concealed by a thin tarp made of twigs and pine needles. Once the trap is set off, 2d6 **twig blights** emerge from the underbrush and attack any creatures surrounding the pit. The eastern path is safe. A DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check can allow a creature to discern that the western trail has been travelled by far fewer creatures than the eastern one.*

A patch of **mantraps** awaiting unwary visitors

*1d4+1 **mantraps** border the road in a circular shape. As travellers cut through this area, each mantrap releases its **attractive pollen**, attempting to lure its prey toward its own plantlike maw.*

A pack of **thorny** guarding their den

*A small field contains a number of ash-gray wildflowers with razor-sharp thorn-covered stalks. A tree containing a number of succulent-looking fruit sits at the center of the field. Its roots conceal the burrow of 1d6 **thorny**, who attack any creatures that approach. The wildflowers are difficult terrain; however, a creature may move through them at normal speed if that creature chooses to take 1 point of slashing damage for each five-foot square travelled in this way. The fruit tastes bitter, and its skin is as tough as leather.*

A creaking water wheel connected to an abandoned lumberjack's cottage

This creaking water wheel once used the power of the Raven River to drive a saw that split trunks into lumber. The mechanism that drives the saw has long since rotted away, though a rusted lock keeps the wheel in its place. The abandoned lumberjack's cottage connected to it is bereft of any valuables, but contains an old bed and a rotted straw-stuffed mattress. The roof is intact, and can serve as shelter in the case of a storm.

A mossy slab of stone bearing a carving of a tree

This slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It was constructed as a monument to the Weaver of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived.

Wolfrun

NPC Encounters

A **wereraven** monitoring the woods in raven form
The **green hag** Jenny Greenteeth and her rattling wagon
A group of patrolling **werewolves** in human form
A Vallakian **archer** tracking an elk
A deranged **homunculus** gathering ingredients for its master
A werewolf-bitten **commoner** fearfully awaiting their first full moon
A cursed **commoner** possessed by a **shadow demon**
A pair of Krezkian **scouts** offering a sacrifice to the Ladies Three
A team of Krezkian **commoners** searching for a missing person
A travelling Vistani family of **commoners** in a barrel-top wagon heading toward
 the Tser Pool encampment
 the Vallaki encampment
 the outside town of Daggerford
 the outside city of Neverwinter

Combat Encounters

A pack of 2d6+1 hungry **wolves** (Levels 1-4)
A pack of 1d4+1 hungry **direwolves** (Levels 2-5)
A pack of 1d4 **werewolves** hunting in wolf form (Level 2-9)

Interesting Phenomena

A mutilated corpse
A forgotten hunting trap
A forgotten trinket lying in the tall grass
Several **swarms of ravens**

Notable Locations

A burnt ruin haunted by a fiery **poltergeist**
A pair of werewolves invaded this house years ago. Its owner fled the structure and set it aflame, burning the lycanthropes alive - but leaving her spouse and child to die in fire as she fled for Krezk. The poltergeist is the spirit of the owner's spouse, and acts to protect its child's unburied bones. The poltergeist is put to rest if the bones are buried.

A crumbling sanctuary maintained by a kindly **ghost**
This old structure once held a shrine visited by travellers on the road. The ghost is the spirit of an old monk who once tended its chapel. The spirit is lonely, and has seen the building fall into disrepair as the woods grew up around its walls.

A creaking water wheel connected to an abandoned miller's cottage

The water wheel was once used to grind wheat into grain. The mechanism that drives the mill has long since rotted away, though a rusted lock keeps the wheel in its place. The cottage is bereft of any valuables, but contains an old bed and a rotted straw-stuffed mattress. The roof is intact, and can serve as shelter in the case of a storm.

Appendix E: The Svalich Road



Landmark A: Barovian Farms

These six farms spread out across much of the Barovian Basin, growing grains and root vegetables that are then carried in heavily-guarded merchant caravans to Vallaki.

Landmark B: Old Gravesite

This small collection of graves mark a Barovian farming family that died of a supernatural plague in the night. Their residence, thought cursed by the locals, lies crumbling nearby.

[[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark C: Ankheg Nest

This nest houses a pair of mated **ankheg** that recently killed a band of adventurers. For more information, see *Last Week's Meat* [here](#). [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark D: Raven's Roost

A swarm of ravens can always be found nestled in the gnarled branches of this large dead tree. If listened to using the *Speak with Animals* spell, the ravens can be heard gossiping about recent events in Barovia, as well as recent events at the Wizard of Wines. If she is with the PCs, Ireena warns the party that to kill a raven is considered bad luck. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark E: Crumbling Chapel

This old shrine bears two altars: one to the Morninglord, and one to Mother Night. The Morninglord's fine wooden altar has decayed over time, leaving its carved sunburst barely visible. Mother Night's stone altar still bears the mark of her crescent moon, but moss and fungi have overgrown her side of the sanctum, cracking and crumbling the floor.

Landmark F: Ancient Watchtower

This ancient watchtower is all that remains of a ruined fort used by the forces of Delmor during Strahd's invasion. It stands above a flat, grassy yard scattered with rusted armor and old bones. The tower was stormed by Strahd's forces long ago, and contains at its peak a brass spyglass. A person that looks through the spyglass sees the world suffering beneath a terrible storm, and sees only ghostly images when viewing characters non-native to Barovia. A character that dies and is resurrected in Barovia appears solid to the spyglass thereafter. A character that lingers in this tower can hear the whistling of wind and the far-away sound of marching troops, both of which soon fade.

The watchtower is a safe place to take a short rest. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark G: Destroyed Caravan

On the north side of Tser Falls, the PCs find the corpse of a horse, along with hoofmarks and wagon treads leading into the underbrush. If they follow the tracks, they find a wrecked wooden cart, along with the corpses of a second horse and six desiccated humans. The horses have had their throats slit by a set of sharp, elegant claws (Medicine DC 15), and the humans have had all blood drained from their veins (Medicine DC 13).

The wreckage of the cart contains barrels of salted jerky, wool-spun cotton, a number of shattered glass bottles that once held inks and dyes, and a small sack of destroyed wooden Blinsky toys (A vaguely coffin-shaped jack-in-the-box containing a pop-up Strahd puppet; a spring-loaded set of wooden teeth with fangs, all painted white; and a smiling jester marionette with tangled strings and tiny copper bells sewn into its cap).

This trade caravan was attacked by a thirsty and bored vampire spawn of no individual significance. Five of the corpses are armored and carry spears (hired guards); the sixth is dressed in furs and wears a copper chain (the merchant). A DC 12 Investigation check shows that nothing appears to have been stolen from the corpses or cart, while a DC 14 Survival check can show the PCs a single set of tracks leading from the nearby underbrush onto the road. A PC that follows the tracks will find themselves back on the road; from here, a DC 20 Survival check will eventually lead them to Castle Ravenloft.

The humans' corpses are quite spread out, and it is clear that at least one of the guards broke rank and ran. A DC 15 Investigation check can tell the PCs that the attack took place more than a day ago. The guards each carry a moneybag containing 2d6 cp and 1d10 sp. The merchant carries a purse holding 2d6 sp and 2d4 gp. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark H: Huntress' Monument

This mossy stone slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It bears a rough carving of a wolf's head, and was constructed as a monument to the Huntress of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark I: Crypt of Bats

The stone slab that covered the entrance to this crypt was pushed aside long ago, revealing crumbling stone steps leading down. The crypt contains three simple stone coffins of Delmorean nobility, the coffins' carved text faded beyond legibility. The crypt has been looted of everything but the skeletons; however, a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) reveals a silver, crescent moon-shaped pendant forgotten behind a crypt. The chamber now serves as a home to a colony of bats, who rest here in the day and attack any creature that wakes them, fleeing once reduced to half hitpoints. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark J: Crypt of Vampire Spawn

The entrance to this crypt is covered by a heavy stone slab, which requires a DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check to move. The crypt contains twelve unmarked stone coffins. If the PCs arrive during the day, each coffin contains a sleeping **vampire spawn**. If the PCs arrive at night instead, they find that the slab has been moved aside, leaving the entrance to the crypt open; if they descend, the PCs find that each of the coffins has been opened and emptied, leaving 1d4 awake **vampire spawn** lurking in the darkness. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark K: Wolves' Den

Any PC that attempts to circumvent the curve in the Svalich Road north of Old Bonegrinder by cutting across the Svalich Wood soon stumbles into this small glen. The shallow cliffs on either side mark the entrances to three dens of wolves, each containing two **wolves** and one **dire wolf**. The wolves attack as soon as the PCs enter the area. The wolves' caves contain only droppings and bones. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark L: Abandoned Boathouse

This rotted boathouse sits forgotten on the shore of Lake Zarovich, just beside an old wooden dock. The boathouse's small interior contains a single canoe and several lengths of usable hemp rope. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark M: Undead Cemetery

This overgrown, fenced-in cemetery once housed the dead of a small hamlet beyond Vallaki's walls. Its twelve **zombies** sleep in shallow graves during the day, and are overgrown with moss and mushrooms. They do not pursue intruders beyond its rusted fence. The three homes and well that once comprised the hamlet lie just over a hundred yards away. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark N: Weaver's Monument

This mossy stone slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It bears a rough carving of a tree, and was constructed as a monument to the Weaver of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark O: Svalich Footbridge

This old stone bridge crosses a wide ditch fifteen feet across and twelve feet deep, with steep sides and few handholds. Several **giant spiders** have constructed a web-woven lair beneath a separate side of the bridge. The spiders attack any creature that passes over the footbridge alone. Passers-by can see a well-worn trail that winds toward the south on the Krezkian and Vallakian ends of the bridge. Any traveller that follows the trail through the trees eventually comes to a newer wooden bridge that provides safe passage across the ravine. [[Battlemap](#) by /u/Soul-XII]

Landmark P: Mad Mage's Mansion

A closed extraplanar door to Mordenkainen's Magnificent Mansion can be found here. The Mad Mage haunts the woods nearby.

Landmark Q: Drowned Well

The road cuts through a ruined hamlet that was abandoned when the Luna River first flooded its banks. An old well at the center of the hamlet holds the souls of twelve shrieking **ghosts**, whose remains have settled at the bottom of the cistern beneath. These wretched spirits were trapped here by the vampire spawn Ludmilla Vilisevic, who once used their corpses to experiment upon the nature of life force. Any creature that approaches the well finds themselves surrounded by the ghosts, who are bound to the shaft of the well by ethereal chains when manifested. The ghosts attack if the well is damaged. If the spirits are spoken to, one of them requests that their bones be recovered from the waters beneath. 1d4 **shambling mounds** lurk in the cistern, and attack if the bones are disturbed. See [here](#) for a battlemap.

Landmark R: Cliffside Tower

This old structure was once employed by the army of Delmor as a watchtower overlooking the southwestern corner of Barovia. The tower was stormed by Strahd's forces long ago, and contains at its base a small, rotted wooden chest. The chest contains a broken pendant of a silver dragon that's always cold to the touch. See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Landmark S: Bat Colony

The bats rest in this shallow cave during the day and attack any creature that wakes them, fleeing once reduced to half hitpoints. See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Landmark T: Berserker Settlement (Yaedrag)

This small settlement hosts the largest population of Mountain Folk in Barovia. For more information, see [here](#).

Landmark U: Avalanche Corridor

This section of the path up Mount Ghakis is unstable and prone to rockslides. If the PCs are led by Kasimir or a berserker guide from Yaedrag, the party is warned to keep slow and quiet, for fear of triggering an avalanche. Each member of the party must pass a DC 13 Dexterity (Stealth) check. If one or two characters fail the check, their clumsiness triggers the fall of an equal number of large boulders, requiring each member of the party to pass a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw per falling boulder, taking 2d6 bludgeoning damage on a failure. If three or more characters fail the check, a full avalanche is triggered. To escape, the PCs must pass a skill challenge. For more information, see [here](#). See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Landmark V: Roc's Nest

This snowy peak hosts the nest of the Roc of Mount Ghakis. See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Landmark W: Jeny's Hut

Nestled just beyond the treeline of the Old Svalich Road, the hut of the **green hag** Jeny Greenteeth is an odd sight to behold. Perched atop a set of wooden scaffolding resembling rickety stilts, and draped with an array of flickering luminescent mushrooms, bulbs, and insects trapped in jars, this wooden hovel serves as Jeny's home and shop. A poorly-painted sign on the main road directs travellers down the dirt path that leads to the hut, advertising "GREENTEETH ENCHANTMENTS. SOLICITORS WILL BE STEWED." See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Jeny herself has the stat block of a **green hag**, but with a Charisma score of 15 and a Wisdom score of 17. A quirky old hag with a penchant for mischief, Jeny spends her time alone undisguised, but prefers the form of a single-toothed and warty grey-haired matron when

travelling or with company. She owns a single garishly yellow dress and an unpleasantly pink sun-hat.

Jeny is also a long-lived former servant of the Ladies of the Fanes, and so is endowed with a certain amount of spellcasting and enchantment ability. Her spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks), and she has the following spells at her disposal:

- Cantrips (at-will): Spare the Dying, Thaumaturgy, Mending
- 1st level (4 slots): Bane, Cure Wounds, Identify, Purify Food and Drink
- 2nd level (3 slots): Augury, Blindness/Deafness, Gentle Repose, Lesser Restoration
- 3rd level (3 slots): Bestow Curse, Dispel Magic, Remove Curse, Speak with Dead
- 4th Level (3 slots): Divination, Guardian of Faith
- 5th level (1 slot): Raise Dead, Scrying, Greater Restoration

Jeny enjoys selling her services to wayward villagers and travellers, but asks a cost in gold in addition to a “favor” (the favor, more than the gold, serves as Jeny’s component for casting the spell). She is also happy to barter for items of equivalent value (or items of high sentimental value, which she keeps on a shelf beside her bed). A list of spells for purchase is as follows:

Spell	Cost	Favor
Mending	5 gp	Give Jeny a stein full of your still-warm saliva.
Cure Wounds	10 gp	Give Jeny a lingering embrace.
Identify	10 gp	Bring Jeny 13 strands of your hair.
Purify Food and Drink	10 gp	Allow Jeny to dig out one ounce of ear wax from your ear.
Augury	20 gp	Tell Jeny your deepest, darkest fear.
Gentle Repose	20 gp	Give Jeny exactly one ounce of your skin.
Lesser Restoration	20 gp	Allow Jeny to dye your hair a color of her choice.
Dispel Magic	90 gp	Eat 11 of Jeny’s cantaloupe-and-venison cookies
Remove Curse	90 gp	Allow Jeny to trim your toenails with her teeth.
Speak with Dead	90 gp	Describe 3+ generations of your family tree to Jeny
Divination	250 gp	Bring Jeny 3 pounds of the Stinking Rotweed flower, found near the shores of Lake Zarovich.
Raise Dead	880 gp	Allow Jeny to remove one of your fingers for use as a spell component.
Scrying	440 gp	Bring Jeny a small white puppy, a large brown cat, and an aged rooster for use as spell components - alive.

Greater Restoration	440 gp	Allow six of Jeny's leeches to feed from you for a full hour.
---------------------	--------	---

Jeny also has a number of magic items for sale. She also owns a Broom of Flying, but refuses to part with it for anything less than 1,000 gp (or its equivalent).

Item	Cost
Amulet of Proof Against Detection and Location	500 gp
Bag of Holding	125 gp
Eyes of the Eagle	250 gp
Figurine of Wondrous Power, Silver Raven	300 gp
Lantern of Revealing	500 gp
Rope of Climbing	300 gp
Staff of Birdcalls	25 gp
Wand of Entangle	400 gp
Wand of Web	400 gp

Item	Cost
Bag of Tricks, Gray	250 gp
Bottled Breath	250 gp
Cap of Water Breathing	250 gp
Dust of Sneezing and Choking	250 gp
Ring of Jumping	250 gp
Ring of Water Walking	250 gp
Sending Stones	250 gp
Staff of Flowers	25 gp
Wand of Smiles	25 gp

Landmark X: Scout's Outpost

A Passive Perception of 15 or higher is required to notice this well-camouflaged structure. This ten-foot-tall wooden platform is disguised by expertly shaped foliage, with a retractable vine-wrapped ladder leading up from the forest floor. The top of this ten-foot-square platform holds a small lean-to (large enough for two Medium-sized creatures), a spare set of blankets, and a locked chest containing a longbow, a shortbow, 30 arrows, 4 days' worth of rations, a waterskin, and a compass.

The chest can be opened with a successful DC 15 Dexterity (Thieves' Tools) check. Yevgeni and Szoldar, the Vallakian wolf hunters, use this outpost while hunting or foraging in the woods. If approached at night, there is a 20% chance that either Yevgeni or Szoldar has retracted the ladder and is resting in the lean-to on top.

See [here](#) for a battlemap of this location.

Landmark Y: Abandoned Waterwheel

This creaking water wheel once used the power of the Raven River to drive a saw that split trunks into lumber. The mechanism that drives the saw has long since rotted away, though a

rusted lock keeps the wheel in its place. The abandoned lumberjack's cottage connected to it is bereft of any valuables, but contains an old bed and a rotted straw-stuffed mattress. The roof is intact, and can serve as shelter in the case of a storm. See [here](#) for a battlemat of this location.

Landmark Z: Overgrown Orchard

While travelling on the road or in the wilderness, the PCs find that their path runs through an overgrown orchard beside an old, run-down shack. The shack once belonged to a married couple whose adolescent son was bitten by a werewolf while hunting. Hiding his wound in shame and fear, the son transformed on the night of the full moon and slaughtered his parents in his madness.

Today, the only items of worth remaining in the shack are a silver mirror upon a rotted vanity; a full quiver of arrows hanging by the door; and a small, locked chest containing six gp, twenty-eight sp, and forty cp. The key to the chest lies in the top drawer of the vanity.

The chest also contains a small leatherbound journal detailing:

- a disease that fell upon the orchard's crops, shriveling and poisoning the apples
- the son venturing into the forest to hunt for food
- the son returning home with his injury
- the son snapping at his mother in a rage
- the father preparing the shack's locks for the full moon
- the son falling ill with a grave fever on the night of the full moon

A pair of skeletons lie near the door, their flesh long since rotted away. Their clothes are of simple peasant's make, now little more than rags. A number of bones have been cast upon the floor, and bear the teeth-marks of a large canine. The only window of the tiny cabin is broken; a search of the ground outside shows that it was broken from the inside.

The orchard also contains a lone **scarecrow** that appears to resemble an ordinary, unmoving scarecrow tied to a wooden post. A DC 12 Wisdom (Investigation) check shows that the scarecrow is not overgrown by vines and roots as the rest of the orchard is. The scarecrow is in truth a spy for Baba Lysaga, and returns to Berez to inform its master of any interesting events at or near the Winery.

See [here](#) for a battlemat of this location.

Landmark %: Seeker's Monument

This mossy stone slab stands four feet in height, and rests on a stone surface bearing intricately carved curls and spirals. It bears a rough carving of an eye, and was constructed as a monument to the Seeker of the Ladies Three by the druids of old Cerunnos long before Strahd arrived. See [here](#) for a battlemat of this location.

Landmark @: False Trail

The road splits in twain at this misted intersection. The eastern path winds through a blighted ridge that borders a rocky hill; the western path cuts through an autumnal grove. The western trail was created by druids, and leads to a spiked pit trap concealed by a thin tarp made of twigs

and pine needles. Once the trap is set off, 2d6 twig blights emerge from the underbrush and attack any creatures surrounding the pit. The eastern path is safe. A DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check can allow a creature to discern that the western trail has been travelled by far fewer creatures than the eastern one. See [here](#) for a battlemat of this location.

Landmark &: Burgomaster's Messenger

This is the resting place of the corpse of Burgomaster Kolyan Indirovich's messenger, Dalvan Olensky.

Landmark \$: Durst House

See [Chapter 1: Death House](#) for more information.